

# The Legendarium of Δια-τὴρ



LEABHAR NAN AOISEAN

# The Legendarium OF DIA-THÌR

*being the Telling of the Making, the Seven Books of the island,  
the Annals of its years, the Appendices, and a Gazetteer of its towns*

---

as they are kept in the Library at Muileann chaol  
and told at the hearths of the island

*Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann.*

We did not come; we were here.

cut on the column at Cnoc ghorm

# CONTENTS

|                                                                               |          |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| <b>The Prologue: Aithris a' Chruthachaidh, the Telling of the Making.....</b> | <b>9</b> |
| I. Of Caoran and the Coals.....                                               | 9        |
| II. Of the Tuath Dè.....                                                      | 14       |
| III. Of the Keeper of the Kin.....                                            | 16       |
| IV. Of the Forgotten Coal.....                                                | 17       |

## PART ONE · THE SEVEN BOOKS

|                                                              |           |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>The First Book: An Aois Àrsaidh, the Ancient Age.....</b> | <b>21</b> |
| I. Of the Mason and the Lightning.....                       | 21        |
| II. Of the Keeper in the Grove.....                          | 23        |
| III. Of the Seven Lightings.....                             | 25        |
| IV. Of the Line of the Mason.....                            | 28        |
| V. Of the Waters and the Woods.....                          | 29        |
| VI. Of the Seann-Dhaoine.....                                | 30        |
| VII. Of the Three Ruins and the Deep Shafts.....             | 32        |
| VIII. Of the Sea-Watcher and the Hollow Man.....             | 33        |
| IX. Of the Groves and the Beasts.....                        | 35        |
| X. Of the Hill-Folk and the Three Stones.....                | 36        |

|                                                                     |           |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>The Second Book: An Aois Ailein, the Age of Ailean.....</b>      | <b>39</b> |
| I. Of the Vigil in the Grove.....                                   | 39        |
| II. Of the Taking of the Hill.....                                  | 41        |
| III. Of the Holders of the Hill.....                                | 43        |
| IV. Of the Red Hill.....                                            | 45        |
| V. Of the Counting of the Dead and the Silence of the Old Ones..... | 46        |
| VI. Of the Salt Shore.....                                          | 48        |
| VII. Of the Unlit Hearth and the Watchers of the Slab.....          | 49        |
| VIII. Of the Ford of Salt and Wool.....                             | 50        |
| IX. Of the Dia-thìrich Name and the Sharing before the Storms.....  | 52        |
| X. Of Oighrig and the Stone Cup.....                                | 53        |
| XI. Of Anndra Breac and the Doctrine Spoken.....                    | 55        |
| XII. Of the Great Gathering at the Ford.....                        | 56        |
| XIII. Of the Long Years.....                                        | 57        |
| XIV. Of the Beacons, the Tide-Rocks and the Long Settling.....      | 59        |
| XV. Of Catriona Mhòr and the King's Last Years.....                 | 60        |
| XVI. Of the Ford below Dùn dhearg.....                              | 62        |

**The Third Book: An Aois Naomh, the Holy Age..... 67**

|                                                                        |     |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| I. Of the Ford of Blood and the Gathering of the Heirs.....            | 67  |
| II. Of the Binding of the First Flame.....                             | 70  |
| III. Of the Parting of the Kingdom .....                               | 72  |
| IV. Of the First Blood and the Strife of the Heirs .....               | 75  |
| V. Of Beathag Bhàn and the First Keepers .....                         | 76  |
| VI. Of Muireach Liath and the Silver.....                              | 78  |
| VII. Of the Stag and the Stone Cup .....                               | 80  |
| VIII. Of the Roads, the Bridges and the Road-Peace.....                | 82  |
| IX. Of the Four Houses and the Reverent Centuries.....                 | 83  |
| X. Of the War of the Two Oaths and the Peace of the Threshold.....     | 85  |
| XI. Of the First Righ of the Lowlands and the Division of Keeping..... | 87  |
| XII. Of the War of the Roads .....                                     | 90  |
| XIII. Of the Letters, the Woods and the Measuring of the Vein .....    | 92  |
| XIV. Of the Red Hall and the Census of Hands .....                     | 94  |
| XV. Of the Hawk, the Cup, the Wolf and the Two Schools .....           | 95  |
| XVI. Of the Shared Meal and the Lean Year .....                        | 97  |
| XVII. Of the House of Tormod .....                                     | 98  |
| XVIII. Of the Parting of the Rites.....                                | 100 |
| XIX. Of the Last Quiet Years and the Close of the Age.....             | 102 |

**The Fourth Book: An Aois Scaraidh, the Age of Sundering.....105**

|                                                                     |     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| I. Of the Rumour of a Shore.....                                    | 105 |
| II. Of the Queen's Word and the Queen's Sister.....                 | 106 |
| III. Of the Building of the Ships.....                              | 107 |
| IV. Of the Sunwise Turn.....                                        | 109 |
| V. Of the Two Landfalls and the White Sorrow .....                  | 110 |
| VI. Of the Empty Harbour.....                                       | 112 |
| VII. Of the Hawk and the Firlot.....                                | 113 |
| VIII. Of the Forbidden Question, the Stone and the Two Horses ..... | 115 |
| IX. Of the War of the Three Claimants .....                         | 117 |
| X. Of Manannan's Mist, and the Crown Joined to the Vein .....       | 119 |
| XI. Of the Stair under the Hill .....                               | 120 |
| XII. Of Things Forgotten, and the Brothers' War .....               | 122 |
| XIII. Of the Last Lamps .....                                       | 124 |

**The Fifth Book: An Aois Choigreach, the Age of Strangers..... 129**

|                                                        |     |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| I. Of the Three Ships and the Leave to Stay .....      | 129 |
| II. Of the Season of Words.....                        | 131 |
| III. Of the Years of Fair Exchange .....               | 132 |
| IV. Of the Treaty in One Tongue, and the Company ..... | 134 |
| V. Of the Lapse of the Law, and the First Steward..... | 136 |

|                                                                                    |            |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| VI. Of the Silver Compact, and the Things the Clerks Could Not File .....          | 139        |
| VII. Of the Smoke in the Gallery, the Child in the Camps, and the Green Death..... | 141        |
| VIII. Of the Eleven Days of Baile thais.....                                       | 145        |
| IX. Of the Levy, the Ring of Beacons, and the Great Hunger .....                   | 146        |
| X. Of the Long Drought, and the Law of One Line .....                              | 148        |
| XI. Of the Second Child, and the Word that was Coined.....                         | 150        |
| XII. Of the Copyist and the Line of Aisling .....                                  | 152        |
| XIII. Of the Rending of Cill ghlas, and the First Blood.....                       | 155        |
| XIV. Of the Houses on the Roads, and the Day the Pits Stopped.....                 | 157        |
| XV. Of the Breaking of the Staff.....                                              | 159        |
| XVI. Of the War of the Hills .....                                                 | 159        |
| XVII. Of the Truce of Àth àrsaidh, and the Closing of the Crossing.....            | 163        |
| <b>The Sixth Book: An Aois Rìoghachd, the Age of the Kingdom.....</b>              | <b>167</b> |
| I. Of the Severance and the Settling of the North.....                             | 167        |
| II. Of the Moot and the Kingdom.....                                               | 168        |
| III. Of Niall, the Shires and the Great Wave .....                                 | 169        |
| IV. Of the Rite, the Orders and the Law .....                                      | 171        |
| V. Of the Mountain, the Guilds and the Fair .....                                  | 173        |
| VI. Of the Library at Muileann chaol .....                                         | 175        |
| VII. Of Brìghde and Eòghan, and the First Word of the Depletion.....               | 177        |
| VIII. Of the Search for a Second Vein .....                                        | 178        |
| IX. Of Mairead and the Failing of the Coal .....                                   | 181        |
| X. Of the Eve of Dubhan .....                                                      | 183        |
| <b>The Seventh Book: An Aois Dhubhain, the Age of Dubhan .....</b>                 | <b>185</b> |
| I. Of Dubhan's Fire .....                                                          | 185        |
| II. Of the Holdouts of the Western Hills .....                                     | 188        |
| III. Of An Cogadh Fada, the Long War .....                                         | 191        |
| IV. Of the Peace, and of the Present Year .....                                    | 193        |
| <b>THE ANNALS OF DIA-THÌR .....</b>                                                | <b>197</b> |
| Age I · An Aois Àrsaidh .....                                                      | 198        |
| Age II · An Aois Ailein.....                                                       | 209        |
| Age III · An Aois Naomh.....                                                       | 228        |
| Age IV · An Aois Scaraidh .....                                                    | 260        |
| Age V · An Aois Choigreach.....                                                    | 286        |
| Age VI · An Aois Rìoghachd .....                                                   | 329        |
| Age VII · An Aois Dhubhain.....                                                    | 356        |
| <b>THE APPENDICES .....</b>                                                        | <b>375</b> |

Appendix A. The Rulers and Houses of Dia-thìr .....377

Appendix B. The Faiths of Dia-thìr .....399

Appendix C. Hosts, Wars and Calamities ..... 427

Appendix D. The Reckoning of Years.....445

Appendix E. Words Born from History .....463

Appendix F. The Tongues and Peoples of Dia-thìr .....483

Appendix G. The Goods and Markets of Dia-thìr ..... 503

Appendix H. The Shires of Dia-thìr.....517

Appendix I. The Land and Waters of Dia-thìr .....533

Appendix J. The Arms of Dia-thìr ..... 543

A GAZETTEER OF DIA-THÌR ..... 559



THE PROLOGUE

# Aithris a' Chruthachaidh

*the Telling of the Making*

BEFORE THE COUNT OF YEARS

*Tha spiorad fa leth san speur, san talamh agus sa mhuir. Meascaich na spioradan agus bidh iad uile-chumbachdach.* The sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit. Merge the spirits, and they become almighty.

— said by Coimhdeach na Fine in the grove of Doire ghlas

I

## Of Caoran and the Coals

**T**his is the telling that Coimhdeach na Fine<sup>1</sup>, the Keeper of the Kin, gave in the grove of Doire ghlas to one of the Mason's line, who had asked it why the coal of Dia-thìr has colours in it when the coal of the common earth has none. The Keeper answered from the beginning, as the old do when a child asks a short question. The Mason's children kept the telling after, father to son and mother to daughter, and said it over at the dark of the year word for word; and it is set down here first because it is older than any other telling.

Before there was a world there were the gods, and they were many, and they were a line. Mother bore daughter and father begot son, back and back into a dark

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1. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

where no name is kept; and every one of that line, when he came to the fullness of his years, went out from the hall of his kin and made a world. That was their coming of age. A god of that line was a child until he had made a thing and kept it, and was grown when it lived.

Each made his world out of what was dearest to him, and each chose a different thing. The eldest of the line, whose name the Keeper would not say, made hers of song: she sang, and the notes hung in the dark and hardened, and the hills of her world are chords and its rivers run in tunes. Another made his of salt and bone. His seas are brine to the bottom and his mountains are the ribs of things that never lived, and he loves that world, though it is hard. Another made hers of wind and the horns of beasts, and nothing in it is ever still. They were all worlds of the elements: each had its earth and its fire, its air and its waters, its life and its spirit, and in each they were made of something else.

In the latest days of that line two of the gods were an Dagda<sup>2</sup>, the Good God, and Danu, the mother; and of them came the Tuath Dè, the people of the gods, whose names are told in their place. Their youngest son was Caoran, whose name is *ember*. He is called an Dia Òg<sup>3</sup>, the Young God, and he is young still, as the gods reckon it.

When Caoran's time came he went about his father's hall a long while and could not choose. He looked at song and found it taken. He looked at salt and bone, at wind and horn, and they were taken also. He went to his sister's forge and to his mother's rivers and to his father's harp, and he came back each time with nothing in his hands. Then one night, when the feast was done and the hall was dark, he sat down by his father's cauldron. The fire under it had burned to its end. The coals lay in the ash, and they had gone black, as coals go when their heat is spent; but when he stirred them, a red eye opened in the heart of one and looked at him.

He took that coal up in his hand. It was black and it was hard, and there was fire in it, sleeping. It had been a tree once, and so it held the memory of life; it had lain under ground, and so it held the weight of earth. It would drink the air and give it back as heat. It was darkness with light folded inside it. And Caoran said to himself that here was a thing in which every element could lie hidden and be woken; and he chose coal.

His brothers and sisters laughed at him, the tellers say, for coal is a mean stuff, the leavings of a fire, and they had made their worlds of finer things. An Dagda

did not laugh. He looked at the coal in his son's hand for a long time, and then he said, "It will do." It is said that no word of his was ever dearer to Caoran.

So the Young God went out from the hall into the empty dark, and he made the world.

He breathed on the coal in his hand until it woke, and he cast it out, and it broke into sparks, and the sparks flew wide and did not fall. Those are the stars. The greatest of them he fanned until it was all fire through and through, and it is the sun. One he let burn down to its grey ash, cool and pale, and hung it where the sun could find it at night; that is the moon, and the pocks in its face are where the fire went out. Then out of the black coal, the heaviest and most patient of all, he made the earth, and laid it down in the middle of his sparks. He pressed the hills up with his thumbs. He drew the long valleys with one finger. The seas he poured out of the dark between the stars, and the rivers he let run down from the high places to find them. He set the winds over all. He made the grass and the trees and the beasts after their kinds, and the fish in the waters and the birds in the air, and he was glad of all of it; and it was all made of coal, though nothing in it looked like coal any more.

Last of all, when the wide earth was done, he made the island; and the island he did not make as he had made the rest. It was born.

He went out over the grey sea where no land was, and he took from the heart of his fire the last coal of all, the one he had been saving, and he held it up over the water and let it burn. Drops of fire fell from it, one by one, into the sea. Where each drop fell the water hissed and smoked and the drop grew hard and black, and the next fell on the one before, and the next on that, until a rock stood up out of the sea, and then a hill, and then the mountains that are the heart of the island; and when the coal in his hand was spent there lay Dia-thìr under him, still steaming in the dawn wind, with the sea round it on every side. That is why the island's coal is not like the coal of the wide earth. The wide earth was made out of coal. Dia-thìr was born of the fire in it.

He loved it as a man loves the youngest child. He gave it rivers, and a lake of fresh water, and soft rain, and a mild sky. He gave a spirit to every spring on it and to every hill, to the old trees and the standing stones and the pools under the falls, so that no part of the island should be without someone to keep it; and those are the old spirits of the land, that the hearths honour still. Then he walked it end to

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2. the Good God, father of the gods

3. the Young God, Caoran

end, and his kin came down to walk it with him and see what the youngest had begotten; for the gods were on the island before any people were. When they had looked their fill they went up again, and Caoran was alone on his island in the grey before the first morning.

Then the godfolk came, an Dia-shluagh<sup>4</sup>, the first people of the earth.

He did not bring them from anywhere, and he did not shape them with his hands. He knelt on the heather in the middle of the island and laid his palms on the warm ground and called, and they grew. They came up out of the island as the green grass comes up after the spring rain, blade by blade, too many to count and each its own; and when the sun rose they were standing on the hillsides, blinking, with the soil still on their feet and the heather in their hair. So the tellings call the people of the island *feur uaine an eilein*, the green grass of the island: they spring up and are cut down and spring up again, and the island is their root. They were a tall people and a quiet one, and their eyes were made to see what he would give them. This is the oldest meaning of the saying of the island, *bha sinn ann*, we were here. The kin did not come to Dia-thìr. They grew out of it on the first morning, and the island is the elder of their line.

"This is yours," the Young God said to them. "Keep it, and it will keep you."

In the wide lands beyond the sea he let other peoples wake after, each in its own time and place, and he gave them the common coal of the earth, which is black and burns and is only coal. Dia-thìr he did not give to them. Dia-thìr was the godfolk's to care for, and in Dia-thìr he hid his gift.

For the Young God had a secret, and he was glad of it, as a father is glad who hides a present under a child's pillow for the morning. When he laid the island down he took the coal that was deepest under its mountains, and into it he put the elements themselves, each in its own colour, where they would lie asleep until they were found. These are na Seachd Guail<sup>5</sup>, the Seven Coals, and this is what each holds.

The first is *gual dubh*<sup>6</sup>, the black coal, and it holds the earth. It is as black as a wet crow, and it takes a polish like still water at night, and it is heavy in the hand beyond its size. In it lies the patience of the ground: the weight of hills, and the strength of roots that hold.

The second is *gual teine*<sup>7</sup>, the fire coal, and it holds fire. Its colour is the colour of flame itself, red and gold together; when it is turned in the light the colour

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4. the godfolk; lit. 'the god-host'

5. the Seven Coals

moves in it, as flame moves when it is seen through closed eyelids. Every fire that was ever to burn on the island was folded into this coal and waited there, for Caoran let no other fire into Dia-thìr.

The third is *gual sneachda*<sup>8</sup>, the snowflake coal, and it holds the air. It is dark and flecked all through with small white stars, like snow falling on black water, and it is the lightest of the seven. In it lie the winds and the breath of the high places.

The fourth is *gual òir*<sup>9</sup>, the gold coal, and it holds the sea. It is black under a sheen of gold, and when it is turned it glints like the sun on the sea at evening. In it lie the salt water and the tides.

The fifth is *gual airgid*<sup>10</sup>, the silver coal, and it holds the river water. Under its sheen of silver it is as dark as a pool in a wood, and it shines as the moon shines on running water. In it lie the springs and the rivers and the rain, which are sweet, and are a different thing from the sea.

The sixth is *gual donn-ruadh*<sup>11</sup>, the mahogany coal, and it holds life. It is the deep red-brown of heartwood and of old blood, warm to look at, and of all the seven it is the most like a living thing. In it lie the quick of the body and the sap of the tree.

The seventh is *gual bogha-froise*<sup>12</sup>, the rainbow coal, and it holds the spirit. All the colours are in it and none of them stays: it shifts as oil shifts on water, as the bow stands in the rain, and no two who look at it see the same. In it lies the spirit that makes the other six more than stuff; and it is the last of the seven, and the hardest to wake.

Together they are called *an gual dathach*<sup>13</sup>, the coloured coal. There is no coloured coal anywhere in the world but on Dia-thìr, for the gift was for Dia-thìr alone. And the Young God set the colours so that only the eyes of the godfolk and their children should see them. To every other eye the coloured coal is black, and it is only coal.

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7. the fire coal, of fire

6. the black coal, of earth

8. the snowflake coal, of air

9. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

10. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

11. the mahogany coal, of life

12. the rainbow coal, of spirit

13. the coloured coal

He locked each colour with its own key, so that each should wake only to the thing that it held, and to nothing else. And he told no one what he had done, not the godfolk, and not his own kin. He wanted the island to find it for itself.

Then he set Crom Cruaich, the bent one of the mound, at the door between the mountain and those who would take from it, and went up to his father's hall to wait; and he was patient, though he is young.

## II

### Of the Tuath Dè

**T**hese are the gods of the Tuath Dè, the people of the gods, the kin of the Young God, who came down with him to see his island in its first days.

The hearths honour them still, each at their feasts and in need. Caoran made the world and all that is in it, and he is the god of the coal. Yet the island honours an Dagda<sup>1</sup> first, for he is the father of the gods, and it was his word that made the Young God's choice good.

**An Dagda**, the Good God, is the father. His is the cauldron from which no company goes away hungry, and it was from the ash under it that Caoran took the first coal. His is the club that kills with one end and wakes the dead with the other, and the harp that calls the seasons in their order; when the island's first year turned, it was his harp that turned it. He is slow of speech, and generous, and he laughs more than any of the gods.

**Danu** is the mother, and the Tuath Dè are named from her. She gives nothing loudly and asks for nothing. The tellings give her the rivers, and it was from her that Caoran learned to let the water run down from the high places; so the silver coal is hers in honour, though the gift in it is his.

**Bride** is the lady of the hearth-fire, of poetry, of healing and of smithcraft. When Caoran shut all the island's fire into the fire coal, it is told that Bride was grieved, for she could not bear to think of a hearth with nothing in it; and he promised her that when the fire was found it should be hers to keep. She has kept it since, and every hearth on the island is swept and relit on her feast.

**Crom Cruaich**, the bent one of the mound, is the god of the vein. When the coal was laid under the mountains, Caoran set him at its door, and so his oldest

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1. the Good God, father of the gods

name is Dòrsair, Uilebheist nan Geataichean<sup>2</sup>, the Monster of the Gates. He is exact. He gives what is asked of the mountain, and he takes his price for it, and his price is measured.

**Manannan mac Lir** is the lord of the sea, and the sea round Dia-thìr is his. When the gods came down to the new island he walked round its coasts in one night, and in the morning he drew up his mist about it, so that no ship from beyond should find it. The gold coal is his in honour. His Cup of Truth breaks at a lie, and is whole again at the truth.

**Lugh Làmhfhada**, Lugh of the long arm, is the master of every craft, and he loves the high places, from which a long arm can reach far. It was Lugh who stood with Caoran on the highest summit of the island on the first evening and named the winds for him, and so the snowflake coal is his in honour. His feast is Lùnastal, when markets open and oaths are sworn before witnesses.

**Macha** is the lady of sovereignty, of kingship and of horses. Two horses draw her chariot, Liath Macha the grey and Dubh Sainglenn the black, and they run as one under one yoke. No king is king until she allows it. When the godfolk had grown up out of the heather, Macha looked them over, one by one, and said that there was no king among them; and she said it gently, as a mother says that a child has not yet grown.

**Dian Cècht** is the healer of the gods, who made a hand of silver for Nuadha when his own was lost. The life that lies in the mahogany coal is the thing he tends, and he knows it better than any. The warm springs of the island are his.

**Goibhniu** is the smith of the gods, and he knew coal before Caoran did, for there is no smith without it. When the Young God's brothers and sisters laughed at his choosing, Goibhniu kept his face straight, and afterward he was the first of them to praise it.

**Nuadha** is the first king of the gods, who lost his hand in battle and ruled again with the silver hand that Dian Cècht made him. Where a king's right is spoken of, his name is spoken also.

**Ogma** is the lord of letters and of eloquence. The godfolk had no letters, and for a long age they needed none; Ogma was content to wait, for he is patient in the way of those who know that a word, once cut, stays.

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2. the Monster of the Gates, Crom Cruaich

**Flidais** is the lady of the deer and of the wild things. When the Young God called the beasts out of the island's heather she went among them, and she keeps them still, and the white stag of the wood is hers.

**The Morrìgan** is the lady of war and the crows. She came down with the rest, and looked at the peaceful island, and said that she would wait; and the others were quiet when she said it. The crows of the island are as black as the black coal, and they are hers.

**Donn** is the lord of the dead. His house is a rock in the sea to the south-west, Taigh Dhuinn<sup>3</sup>, and the dead go to it. In the days of the godfolk no one went to his house for a long time, and he was content with that, for he is in no hurry for the dead.

There are others of the Tuath Dè, and the hearths know them; but these are the ones the Keeper named in the grove.

### III

## Of the Keeper of the Kin

**W**hen the Young God went up again to his father's hall he did not leave his island unwatched. He took up the smoke that had risen from the first coal he woke, which had hung in the dark all that while and never gone thin, and he gave it a mind and a charge. That is Coimhdeach na Fine<sup>1</sup>, the Keeper of the Kin.

It is neither a god nor a ghost. It was never born, and it will not die while the kin are on the island; it is not one of the Tuath Dè, and it has no feast and no house. It is Caoran's watcher, and it watches for him, as a steward rides round a far holding while the lord is away: it goes where it will, it seldom speaks, and it tells its master what it has seen.

When it shows itself it comes as a figure of smoke, grey and upright, of the height of a tall man. It has no face that anyone has been able to tell of afterward. It stands still in a wind, and the smoke of it does not drift. There is a smell about it of a hearth in the morning when the fire has been banked all night. Its voice is low, and it speaks as fire speaks when it settles; those who have heard it say that

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3. the house of Donn, where the dead go

1. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'



they understood every word and could not afterward say whether it had used words at all.

It does not rule the kin, and it does not help them in their work. It will not fight for them. It comes seldom, generations apart, and when it comes it asks after the island as a guest asks after the health of the house. When it is asked a question it answers truly, but it does not always answer the whole of what is asked, for its charge is from Caoran, and some things Caoran has kept for the island to find.

The Mason's children say that it came first in the grove, and that it came there to be asked; that it had waited through the whole long life of the kin on the island for one of them to wonder aloud about the colours. And when one of the Mason's line did wonder, it came and stood with him by his fire under the oaks, and it told him all that is written here, from the hall of the gods to the forgetting of the coal. It told him more, and he asked it more, and what passed between them after is told in the First Book.

#### IV

### Of the Forgotten Coal

**I**n the first days the godfolk lived on the island in peace, and they had no fire.

They did not miss it, for they had never known it. The island was mild to them. The sea gave them its fish and its shellfish on every shore, and the moor gave them its berries and the woods their nuts, and the springs gave them sweet water. They slept in the lee of the rocks and in the long grass, and the rain was soft on them. At night they sat together on the hills and watched the sparks of the Young God's making turn over their heads, and named them, and told each other what they had seen in the day. They did not know that they were keeping the island. They loved it, and that was the keeping.

So many lives went by, the Keeper said, that the godfolk themselves forgot that the island had ever been new.

Then in one year a great rain came down on the mountains. It rained for a month without stopping, and the streams came off the high ground brown and roaring, and one of them tore away half a hillside under the mountains and carried it down into the valley below. When the water went back a child of the godfolk went to look at the new ground. The telling does not keep that child's name.

In the raw bank where the hill had broken, she saw stones that were not like any stones she knew.

Some were black, and shone like a crow's wing in rain. Some had a gleam of gold on them. Some had a gleam of silver. One was dark and flecked with white, like the sky on a clear night. One was red-brown and warm to look at. One was the colour of nothing she had ever seen, for it was the colour of fire, and the god-folk had never seen a fire. And one had every colour in it, and would not keep still.

She filled the fold of her cloak with them and carried them home, and all the godfolk of that valley came to see.

They wondered at them a long while. They turned them in the sun. They held them up to their eyes. They struck them together, and the coal did not ring as flint rings, and nothing came of it. One tried to eat a piece and broke a tooth on it, and there was laughter. One tried to cut a shape into a piece with a sharp stone, and it crumbled under his hand and blacked his fingers, and he threw the rest away in disgust. The eldest of the valley said that they were the droppings of the mountain, and that pretty things with no use in them were for children. After that the children kept them for a while, and set them out in rows, and played at games with them on the flat rocks.

That was the whole of the godfolk's first finding. No one asked why the stones had colours. No one asked who had made them so. No one thought to lay them on the sand where the sea came in, or throw them down from a height, or bury them, or take them to the river; and there was no fire on the island to set them near. The gift lay in their hands, and they did not know it was a gift.

The children grew and forgot their games. The stones were kicked into the heather, and the heather grew over them. The stream moved in its bed and covered the broken bank with gravel, and the grass came over the gravel, and there was nothing to show where the hill had torn. The child who had found the coal grew old and died and went over the sea to Taigh Dhuinn<sup>1</sup>, and those who had known her followed. In a few lives there was no one left on the island who remembered that any such stones had been.

When the Keeper told this in the grove, the one of the Mason's line was ashamed for his forebears, and he asked whether the Young God had been angry.

The Keeper said that he had not. It said that Caoran had watched it all from his father's hall, and had laughed, as a father laughs who sees his child set aside the

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1. the house of Donn, where the dead go

finest gift of the feast to play with the wrapping. It said: "A gift that is not opened is still given. He could wait. The coal was in no hurry, and neither was he."

So the coloured coal lay forgotten under the mountains, and the godfolk lived on without fire, and grew many, and spread over the island from the shore to the high moor. The island turned under the Young God's stars through more years than anyone could count; and nobody counted them, for there was no one yet to begin the count.

It began on the day a mason, splitting rock for a well, set his wedge in a seam he had not seen, and struck. That is the beginning of the First Book.



THE FIRST BOOK

# AN AOIS ÀRSaidh

*the Ancient Age*

VE 1 – 5,324

*Tha spiorad fa leth san speur, san talamh agus sa mhuir. Meascaich na spioradan agus bidh iad uile-chumbachdach.* The sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit. Merge the spirits, and they become almighty.

— the Keeper's riddle, as Clann na Ceiste keep it

## I

### Of the Mason and the Lightning

**T**he count of years begins on 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1. In the hill country that day is only "the night of the lightning", and the tale is told at the hearth in the dark of the year by whoever is oldest in the house; and every hearth that tells it is itself the tale, for before that night there was no hearth on Dia-thìr at all. It goes like this.

Neachdan the mason was sinking a well. He had been at it since the grey of the morning, with a wedge of hard stone and a maul of oak, splitting the rock a hand's depth at a time and lifting the pieces out. It was the dead of the year. The wind came over the heather with sleet in it, and his hands were split at the knuckles from the wet stone, and there was nothing in all the world to warm them but his own breath and the work.

He set the wedge in a seam and struck. The rock broke along a line he had not seen.

Out of every stone he had ever split there had come grey dust and grit, the same dust his father had shaken from his hair. Here the break was black, a hard black that took the light like a wet crow's back; and along the black, where the maul had opened it, lay colour. There was a sheen of gold on one piece, as the sun lies on the sea at evening. There was a piece flecked all over with small white stars, and one that was red-brown like the heart of an old oak, and one with a gleam of silver, and one that seemed, when he tilted it, to hold every colour he had a name for and some he had not. He knelt in the cut with the sleet on his neck and turned the pieces over in his hands until he could not feel them.

He did not know what they were. He filled the breast of his tunic with them, because they were beautiful.

The storm came up the valley at dusk. He took shelter under a lip of rock above the well. Then the sky split with a white light and a noise like the hill breaking, and the light went into the ground.

It went into his well. He saw it strike the broken vein and run along it; and where it ran, the vein began to glow.

The tellers slow here, for the hearth is listening. Neachdan came down out of the shelter with the rain in his eyes and stood at the lip of the well, and something was alive in it. It moved and was not a beast. It breathed out a heat that he felt on his face and his split hands, though the rain was cold; it ate the black stone and gave off a low dark flame, like peat-water moving, with red at its roots. The rain hissed on it and could not put it out. He held his hands over it and they came back to life, and he wept, and was not ashamed to say so after.

He took a flat stone and lifted a burning piece out onto it, and carried it home through the storm under the flap of his cloak, stooping over it the whole way as a man stoops over a sick child. At home he set it on the floor among stones, where the draught would not take it, and fed it with the coloured pieces from his tunic. Each one caught. Each burned the same, low and dark-flamed, and the colours went out of them as they burned, gold and silver and white stars alike, and left only the heat. He saw that, and was sorry a little, and was glad all the same, for his children were sitting round the first hearth on Dia-thìr with their faces red in its light.

So the Dia-thìrich say that fire came to them out of the sky and the stone together.

Three wells of the high valleys claim the crack. Tobar dhìreach and two wells of its neighbours each keep a telling that the mason's well was theirs, and that the lightning fell there. Tobar dhìreach can show a capped shaft with a scorched stain on its lip; the other two can show only the telling. The tellers hold all three claims and choose none.

On what the mason's people did next, every telling agrees. They let the fire in the vein burn until it had burned itself out. Then they dug no further. They laid a flat stone over the broken vein, and would draw no water beside it, and cut their well again a stone's throw away. Of all the deeds of the Ancient Age this is the one told most often, to children and to elders, and it is told the same way every time: the people found a wonder in the ground, and they covered it.

II

## Of the Keeper in the Grove

**N**ine hundred years went by. The fire had gone from hearth to hearth over all the hill country, and no one knew what the coloured coal was. Then the question was asked.

It was asked by **Diarmad**, of the Mason's line, on 17 an Gearran, VE 890, and it was asked in the oak grove at Doire ghlas, far to the north, where the oaks had come in over the old heath. Why he had gone so far from the high valleys the tellers do not agree; the Mason's line says only that he had asked the question of everyone since he was a child, and got nothing for it but laughter.

He had lit a small fire of oak twigs in the lee of a fallen trunk, and he sat with a piece of the rainbow coal in his hand, as he always did, turning it so the colours ran. The wind was blowing hard through the grove. The branches roared with it and the dead leaves went past him in streams.

When he looked up there was someone standing on the other side of his fire.

It was the height of a tall man and made of grey smoke, such as a peat fire gives, and it stood in the middle of the gale and did not stir. Diarmad's own little fire was streaming sideways on the ground, and the smoke that stood beside it was as still as a stone.

He did not run. The tellers make much of that.

"What are you?" he said.

"I am Coimhdeach na Fine<sup>1</sup>," it said. Its voice was quiet and very clear, and the wind did not carry it away. "The keeper of the kin. I watch over the people of this island for the one who made them."

"Are you a god?"

"No."

"A ghost, then."

"Neither. I was made out of the smoke of the first coal he woke. I have watched your line since the mason. You have a question. Ask it."

Diarmad held up the coal in his hand. "Why are there colours in it?" he said. "What are they for?"

Then the Keeper told him. It told him of Caoran, the Young God, youngest son of an Dagda<sup>2</sup> and Danu, and of the long line of gods before him who made their worlds of other things; and how Caoran, coming of age, chose coal, and made of it all that is, and then the earth; and how the island was born of the fire of his last coal, and the first people, an Dia-shluagh<sup>3</sup>, the godfolk, grew up out of it like grass; and how he hid in the coal of this one island the seven spirits of his making, each in its colour, as a gift for them to find; and how they found it once, long before the mason, and did not understand it, and let it lie.

All that the Keeper told him the Mason's line kept, word for word, and in time the hill country learned it from them; it is the Telling of the Making, and it is not told twice here.

When it was done Diarmad sat a long time without speaking. The fire had burned down. At last he said: "He hid it. Why would he hide a gift?"

"So that it would be found," said the Keeper. "He said to me once: a gift that is not opened is still given."

"Then how is it opened? The mason burned the coals and they burned like any coal. We have burned them since. The colours go out of them."

"Because you burn them all in the one fire," said the Keeper, "and none of them in its own." And it gave him the riddle, first in the old words and then again, slowly, so that he would keep them:

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1. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

2. the Good God, father of the gods

3. the godfolk; lit. 'the god-host'



*Tha spiorad fa leth san speur, san talamb agus sa mbuir. Meascaich na spioradan agus bidh iad uile-chumbachdach.* The sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit. Merge the spirits, and they become almighty.

"That is no answer," Diarmad said.

"It is the one I was given to give," said the Keeper; and the wind, which had gone round it all that while, went through the place where it stood, and there was nothing there.

### III

## Of the Seven Lightings

**S**o began the long questioning. The Mason's line took the riddle home to the high valleys and turned it over for four thousand years, with seven coals and three words to go on, sky and earth and sea; and the tellers of Clann na Ceiste<sup>1</sup> give the lightings one by one, as the reciters give the fathers of the line.

The first was the sea. In VE 1,370 **Aodh** of the Mason's line, who had grown up hearing that the sea was one of the three, carried the seven coals of the vein across the hills to the northern shore. He had never seen the sea. He stood on the shingle a long while looking at it. Then he waded in to his knees and threw the coals out into the swell one after another. Six sank without a mark. The seventh, the one with the sheen of gold, struck the water and took fire, and burned on the heave of the sea with a flame the colour of its sheen, bright gold, rising and falling with the waves, until a breaker rolled it under. That coal is *gual òir*<sup>2</sup>, the gold coal, and its spirit is the sea's. Aodh went home and told it at the hearth, and the old women of the line wept, for it was nearly five hundred years since the grove.

The second was the sky. In VE 2,170 **Fearghas** of the line reasoned that if the sea took one coal by its water, the sky might take one by its air, and that the nearest a man could come to the sky was the highest ground on the island. So he climbed it.

The wind on the top of the bare moor was cold enough to make his teeth ache, and he could see the sea shining at every edge of the island. He took the

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1. the Children of the Question

2. the gold-sheen coal, of sea water

coals out one at a time and let each drop from the height of his arm over the steep side of the summit.

The fifth coal did not fall far. Halfway down the rock it took fire in the empty air, and burned white, a small fierce white like a star come down in daylight, and struck the stones below still burning and lay there flickering in the wind. It was the coal flecked with white stars, *gual sneachda*<sup>3</sup>, the snowflake coal; and its spirit is the air's. From that day the summit has carried the name of the kindred, Binn-an a' Chlachair<sup>4</sup>, the Mason's Point. The herders of that moor leave a stone on the top when they pass.

The third was the earth, and it was found by a man who took the riddle more simply than the rest. In VE 2,885 **Brian** of the line said that if the earth has a spirit, it lies where the dead lie, deep; and he dug a grave-deep hole beside the slab at Tobar dhreach and laid the five dark coals in it and covered them over, as the dead are covered, and went home. The next morning he dug them up. Four were as cold as the clay. The fifth, the black one, *gual dubh*<sup>5</sup>, as black as a wet crow, was warm in his hand as a hand is warm, and when the morning air reached it a dark red glow crept over it, and it smouldered. The earth had lit it slowly, overnight, from beneath. Brian kept it burning in a pot for the rest of his life.

The fourth was life, and it came by blood. In VE 3,670 **Cormac** of the line took the four dark coals on the long road north to Doire ghlais, to the grove where the Keeper had first spoken, for he thought the place itself might count for something. He sat under the oaks a month to no purpose, and at last, in a temper, he set the red-brown coal on a stone to break it, to see whether the spirit was inside.

He struck, and the hammer turned on the hard surface of the coal and came down on the back of his other hand, and laid it open to the bone. He swore and fell back, and the blood ran off his fingers and dripped onto the coal. Where it dripped, the coal caught. A flame came up out of it the colour of the coal itself, red-brown, deep and warm like firelight in oak; and Cormac sat in the leaves with his hand in his lap and watched it, and forgot to bind the hand until the flame went out. That coal is *gual donn-ruadh*<sup>6</sup>, and the kindred call it the coal of life. The scar on Cormac's hand is remembered, and his byname with it, Cormac of the Misstrike.

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3. the snowflake coal, of air

4. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

5. the black coal, of earth

6. the mahogany coal, of life

The fifth was the river. Here the tellers of Clann na Ceiste stop and smile, because it is plain enough now, and it took them nearly six hundred years.

In VE 4,225 **Eòghann** of the line was walking home from the northern shore, where he had thrown the three dark coals into the sea once more, to no purpose. He came down tired to the Abhainn ghorm, the river that runs below Tobar dhìreach, and knelt on the stones and drank from his hands.

Then he sat back on his heels with the water running out between his fingers.

"This water tastes different from the sea water," he said aloud, to no one:

*Tha blas eile air an uisce seo seach uisce na mara.* This water tastes different from the sea water.

He had known it all his life, as everyone knows it. He had never thought it before. He took the three coals out of the bag and threw them into the middle of the stream, one, two, three; and the one with the sheen of silver took fire as it went under, and burned on the bed of the river beneath the running water, silver, while the current poured over it and could not put it out. That is *gual airgid*<sup>7</sup>, the silver coal, and its spirit is the river's.

By then the households of the high valleys had grown used to the Mason's line and its long strange business with the coal, and they had begun to call its people **Luchd-ceasnachaidh a' Ghuail Dhìomhair**<sup>8</sup>, the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal (VE 4,625). It was half a jest when it began. The line took it and kept it, and in the lists the long name is shortened to **Clann na Ceiste**, the Children of the Question; and the older name, Clann a' Chlachair<sup>9</sup>, the Mason's children, is heard less after.

The sixth was fire itself, and it was found by accident, by a man who had given up.

**Seathan** of Clann na Ceiste had sat with the fire coal, *gual teine*<sup>10</sup>, for thirty years. He had put it in every fire the line knew, even the first fire itself, which the line said it had kept alight since the mason's hearth, and it burned in all of them dark and low. Sky, earth and sea, the riddle said; where was fire in that? He had begun to half believe those of the line who said the fire coal had no spirit at all.

On 16 an t-Ògmhios, VE 4,905, a warm evening, he was sitting in his doorway at Tobar dhìreach breaking the fire coal into dust with his fingers, as he often did

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7. the silver-sheen coal, of river water

8. the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal

9. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

when he was thinking, and not thinking of the fire coal at all. He was thinking of the mason, and of the lightning that had made the mason's fire out of nothing: a crack, a snap in the sky.

He snapped his fingers.

The dust on them took fire. It went up off his hand in a little rush of flame, and the flame was the colour of the fire coal itself, a clear red-gold that shone through his fingers, brighter than any hearth he had sat at. He yelled and beat his hand against his coat, and the flame went out, and he looked at his fingers and they were whole. There was not a mark on them.

Then he sat in the doorway and laughed until his wife came to see what was the matter. The fire had been in the hand all along, the tellers say, in the hand and in the snap of it, as the lightning is in the sky; and a man cannot go looking in the sea for a thing he carries on him.

There was left the seventh, the rainbow coal, *gual bogha-froise*<sup>11</sup>, that holds every colour; and it was the longest. For more than four hundred years Clann na Ceiste threw it in the sea and the river, dropped it from the Point, buried it, bled on it and snapped over it, and it lay dark through all of them. The tellers do not dwell on those years.

## IV

### Of the Line of the Mason

**T**he Line of the Mason is the eldest genealogy on Dia-thìr, and the only one, and it is kept by Clann na Ceiste<sup>1</sup> by mouth. It is said standing, at the hearth on the night of the lightning; and before a stranger it is said in this short form, the long stretches between the named fathers given as numbers, for the reciters do not give the rest of the names to a stranger.

The reciters of Clann na Ceiste give it thus, and they give it the same way every time:

"Neachdan the Mason broke the stone, and the lightning came into it, and he carried the first fire home. Neachdan was the father of Conall, who kept the vein while it burned. And after Conall came thirty-four fathers, each the son of the

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10. the fire coal, of fire

11. the rainbow coal, of spirit

1. the Children of the Question

one before, whose names we keep; and the last of them was the father of Diarmad.

"Diarmad asked the question in the grove, and the Keeper answered him, and gave him the riddle. And after Diarmad came eighteen fathers whose names we keep; and the last of them was the father of Aodh.

"Aodh threw the seven into the sea, and the gold took fire on the water. And after Aodh came thirty-one fathers whose names we keep; and the last of them was the father of Fearghas.

"Fearghas climbed to the top of the island and let fall the six, and the snowflake took fire in the air, and the Point bears our name. And after Fearghas came twenty-eight fathers whose names we keep; and the last of them was the father of Brian.

"Brian buried the five like the dead, and the black was warm in the morning. And after Brian came thirty fathers whose names we keep; and the last of them was the father of Cormac.

"Cormac of the Misstrike bled in the grove, and the coal of life took fire from his blood. And after Cormac came twenty-one fathers whose names we keep; and the last of them was the father of Eòghann.

"Eòghann tasted the river, and the silver took fire under the water. And after Eòghann came fifteen fathers whose names we keep; and the last of them was the father of Colla.

"In the days of Colla they called us the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal, and we took the name. And after Colla came ten fathers whose names we keep; and the last of them was the father of Seathan.

"Seathan snapped his fingers, and the fire was in his hand. And after Seathan came fifteen fathers whose names we keep; and the last of them was Suibhne.

"Suibhne was the father of Ailean, who carried the six fires to the grove."

There the Line of the Mason ends as it is said at the hearth; for Ailean was a young man still when the age closed, and the reciters do not say a man's line past a man who is living.

V

## Of the Waters and the Woods

**T**he tellers go back now to the first years of the count, for while the Mason's line questioned the coal the island went its own way. In the years after the lightning Dia-thìr was another shape. The snowfields on the central mountains were shrinking, and their meltwater cut the bed that Abhainn uaine follows still; its gravel terraces hold hearth-stones at three heights, each left as the water came up to it. In the bog beneath Doire ghlas the birch and pine of the colder years gave way to oak and hazel, and the grove grew up on the old heath where, nine hundred years after the lightning, the Keeper stood.

At Achadh dhìreach lie the first hearths of the high valleys, lit from the mason's fire or from fires lit from it: pine and heather charcoal, scrapers of grey flint, the split bones of red deer. There is no coloured coal in them. Whoever sat at them either had none of it or would not burn it, and fed the fire with wood.

And the sea rose. It drowned the low neck that joined Eilean dhubh to the main island, and the island's deer, cut off, grew smaller, lifetime by lifetime. Out on Eilean mhin seal-hunters pitched their camps a season at a time, reached by boat, and that is the first sure sign that anyone on Dia-thìr crossed open water on purpose. Abhainn ìseal, the longest river of the island, settled into its broad bed, and weirs of hazel were staked across its side channels, and the stakes were renewed in the same holes for generations.

These are small things. A people who leave no words leave their fires and their weirs and their bones, and he who would know them must learn to read those.

## VI

### Of the Seann-Dhaoine

**A**t Seann Dunn there is a mound taller than a man, made of limpet shell and seal bone and burnt weed, laid down over many lifetimes. It is the first sure trace of the **Seann-Dhaoine**<sup>1</sup>, the Old Ones; and no tool in it is shaped as the hill-folk shape a tool.

What they called themselves is lost. The name they bear was given afterward, by others, and means only that they were before. Yet they held the shores of Dia-thìr for five thousand years and more.

Of them it is told that at Seann Chwen they sank their nets with beach stones, and every stone was notched with the same three strokes, the earliest mark on

Dia-thìr made again and again on purpose. At Seann Skell they laid a mole of un-mortared boulders out into the river, and every landing made there since stands upon it. At Seann Bhral they cut two hundred and twelve steps up the cliff from the shingle to the grazing, and the treads are worn hollow in the middle; no one has counted how many feet that took. At Seann Toll they cut a channel into a river pool with a slot for a gate of wattle, and the slot is still sharp. At Seann Warr they laid a road of crushed shell across the reed marsh, a forearm above the reeds, and it is the first made road on the island that can still be walked. At Seann Mhorn they built seven fish-kilns to dry the catch over peat smoke, the first buildings on Dia-thìr raised for a trade. At Seann Bhrenn they laid long ramps of stone into the water, wide enough for hulls bigger than any hide boat. The hulls are gone, and so is any tale of where they went.

At Seann Tarr they cut rows of signs into the cliff. It is the script that turns up later on the standing stones. It is no Dia-thìris, and it has never been read, and not one sign of it has an agreed meaning.

The Seann-Dhaoine of Seann Vell rowed their dead out to Eilean dhearg and laid them in stone boxes that face the mainland. Forty have been counted. No grave of theirs on the mainland from that time has been found. So the dead of the Old Ones were set to look back across the water at the living.

Their works went up on every coast. Platforms on oak piles stood out in the shallows of Loch chrom, though whether the Old Ones raised them or some other people the timbers do not tell. Below the southern Seann Dunn the ribs of a stranded whale were raised as the frames of round houses. At the eastern Seann Vell there are fourteen house-rings of dry stone. At the north-western Seann Skell stands a hollow-walled tower with a stair in the thickness of its wall, looking over the water where the Sea-Watcher was seen. There was a second Seann Mhorn, a headland of oyster and whelk whose lowest oysters are larger than any taken there since, and a second Seann Bhrenn far to the north-east with the same ramps; whether one people built both or the name was carried, none can say. At the eastern Seann Tarr a long house was built into a cleft of the cliff, and the rock behind its hearth is black with soot to the height of a man.

At their height, in VE 3,872, they held every coast: the ten places whose names begin with *Seann*, and the islands off them, and their greatest landing was Seann Skell on the Abhainn naomh, where the mole already stood. At the warm springs

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1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

under the mountain they set stone basins, and the bones buried nearby show old breaks that knitted clean. That is the first place on Dia-thìr where the sick were brought to be made well. Let it be remembered of them also.

## VII

### Of the Three Ruins and the Deep Shafts

**T**he long centuries that began in VE 2,524 saw as many works and wonders as any stretch of the age. The tellings hold them together as one time, when great works went up inland and great fears came in from the sea.

On a spur above the southern lowland a walled outpost was raised, which the tellings call Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>1</sup>. Its stones are dressed on the outer face only, and its one gate faces inland, away from the sea. A greater work went up on a height nearer the sea: three rings of wall, a cistern cut in the bedrock, and room for four hundred people with their beasts. That is Làrach an Dùin<sup>2</sup>, and whether the outpost's builders raised it too has never been settled. Across the lowland run stretches of a kerbed track, a cart's width and paved with flat slabs, heading toward both; it is the only road the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>3</sup> are known to have built away from the shore.

In the eastern hills a stepped platform was built with an altar block on its top step, and the altar was set square to the central mountains. That is Làrach an Teampaill<sup>4</sup>. No other altar on Dia-thìr faces that way. Seers have said since that it faces the vein under the mountains; each who hears it may join the two or leave them apart.

At the eastern Toll-dubh a shaft was sunk straight down through the rock, its walls tooled smooth as far as a lamp can show, and no spoil heap lies beside it. Whatever was taken out of it was carried away, or nothing was. Across the island, at the western Toll-dubh, a second shaft of the same make was cut. Stones thrown into either are never heard to land.

None of these works lasted. The single gate of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire was blocked with rubble from the inside; whoever did it left by another way, or never

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1. the watch-fort ruin

2. the fortress ruin

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

4. the temple ruin



left. The outpost stood empty, and was a ruin already in the days of the oldest tellings. The cistern of Làrach an Dùin was found choked with the bones of cattle thrown in whole, and no one drew from it again, and the fortress was left in the same state and the same mystery. The top stone of the altar at Làrach an Team-paill was prised off and carried away. The sockets are still sharp. The stone has never been found. Then the temple too was left.

After the high places were given up, every new work of the Seann-Dhaoine lay within sight of salt water, and the middens at the southern Seann Chwen grew as fast as those of Seann Dunn once had. It is as if a people went up into the hills, and built, and were turned back, and came down to the shore and stayed there. That is how the tellers put it, and the stones neither agree nor argue.

When the shafts were already old, the people of the south-east plaited a rope of hide and brought a youth to the lip of the eastern shaft. The wind came up out of the hole, cool and smelling of wet stone, and lifted the hair from his brow as he sat on the edge with the rope knotted under his arms. He had a lamp of fat in a hollowed stone, and he sat looking down into the dark.

They let him go hand over hand, the men braced with their heels in the turf and the hide creaking through their fists. The lamp went down and grew small, a pin of light on the smooth wall, and then the dark closed over it and there was only the rope going out. The rope ran out to its last knot, and they held it there, and it hung straight and heavy and gave no sign.

Then it jerked twice, and they hauled.

He came up alive. His lamp was out and his face was the colour of ash. They asked him, and he shook his head. He never said what was at the bottom, not then and not in all the years he lived; and after him no one went down again in that age.

## VIII

### Of the Sea-Watcher and the Hollow Man

**I**n those same years the fears of Dia-thìr were born, and two of them have never left it.

The tellings of the coast begin with boats. Below the headlands of the north-west, in the tidal mud, lie a row of mooring stakes and a scrap of stitched

hide, the first sure boats of the north-west coast. Who rowed them, and from where, the mud does not say.

On 1 an t-Sultain, VE 2,990, the Sea-Watcher was first sighted. Old sailors of the north-west speak of a creature vaster than any whale in the water off that coast, and add, before anyone else can, that no wreck has ever been raised to prove them wrong. On the last headland of that coast a fire was kept, and it was fed so long that its ash lay a man's height deep. The tellings say it burned to turn boats away from the Watcher's water. The beacon-keepers' word to the boats is kept on that coast still:

*Tionndaidh air ais. Chan ann dhutsa an t-uisce seo.* Turn back. This water is not for you.

A telling of that coast counts seven boats gone from Ros ruadh in one calm season, with no storm to blame; that was the first loss laid at the Watcher's door by name. After it the seal-bone thins in the middens of the north-west, and the middens in the sheltered straits of the north grow. The hunters were working the southern sides of the headlands now, out of sight of the open sea.

Inland the rock faces of the Doire uaine hills are cut with writing, more than anywhere else on the island, in lines that run for yards; and some of the lines are cut over and defaced by the same kind of tool that cut them. The tellings say they speak of something that walked without breathing and fell upon anyone who lit a fire in its sight. This is the Hollow Man of Doire uaine. How a thing written in a script no one can read came to be known at all is a riddle; yet known it is, in every house of those hills.

After the writing, the hearths of those hills changed. Fires were dug into pits and roofed with slabs, and no open hearth showed on those slopes for many lifetimes. The people stayed. They hid their light. At a hill camp in that country nine people lay where they fell inside a hut, beside a hearth of fresh ash, and no wound has been found on any bone. The hut was never reopened, and no one was buried from it.

The fear did not pass. Many lifetimes on, a herding family new to the hills lit an open fire at Doire uaine against the custom, and their hut was found empty with the fire still burning in it. After that the custom was kept harder.

Later again, two herders were driving beasts home past the Doire uaine hills when the light went. They had stayed too long at the far pasture. Neither had flint

or tinder out, for they were hill-bred and would sooner have walked blind; and so they went on in the half-dark with the beasts crowding at their heels.

The younger saw it first and caught the other's arm. Up on the ridge, against the last grey of the sky, a figure was walking, upright and unhurried, along the crest. They watched it for as long as a man might count a score. It was cold enough that the herders' breath hung in clouds before them. Above the walker on the ridge nothing hung at all.

They did not run, for running is noise. They stood among the cattle with their hands over their mouths until the figure passed over the crest. At home they would not let the fire be uncovered until full day. They had no fire lit on the path, the telling says, and that is why they lived.

So the covered hearth spread from the Doire uaine hills to every settlement of that country, and the rule that no open fire is lit on those slopes after dark begins there. Mothers in that country still say:

*Na las teine far am faic e thu.* Light no fire where it can see you.

## I X

### Of the Groves and the Beasts

A forest in the east of that country was hallowed by the hill-folk themselves, and they call it only the holy wood. The trees understood, the old telling goes, before the people did. The charcoal in the hearths around it comes from every wood but that one; the families at its edge carried their fuel a half-day's walk rather than cut a branch within it. There, at the edge of the trees, three hunters once saw a white stag, and none of them drew. The stag comes back in the tellings again and again. Some at the hearths say it is the white stag of Flidais, lady of the deer and the wild, whom the Keeper named in the grove; the most give it no god at all.

A second forest, older in its feeling than the first, was never settled, never felled, never fully walked: Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>1</sup>. Paths lead toward it from three sides, and all three end at a low line of set stones short of the trees. Nothing is worn beyond the stones. Once a child of that country went past the line and was never found, and the searchers stopped at the stones. The telling does not

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1. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

blame them. The hearths of that country say the sìth took the child, the people of the hills and mounds, whose country begins where the worn paths end.

In the northern hills the red deer were driven down lines of stake and brush into a gully, and the antlers of the greatest stags were stacked apart. At Cnoc fhionn dogs were buried beside people, each with a shell at its head, the first beasts given graves on Dia-thìr; and at a spring of the wild northern coast wolves were laid in the ground on their sides like people. The grey geese of Eilean ghorm come into the tellings in these years. They come with the first storm and leave with the last, and they are never hunted there.

In VE 5,170 a thing was first marked that is a wonder still: the great cats of the island cross the mountains by fixed roads at fixed seasons. These are the panther roads. The hill-folk learned the cats' timing and kept off the passes while they crossed. A party of eleven from the southern shore went up into the hills in the crossing season and did not come back, and their bones were found years afterward along the line the cats still use. The households below the passes came to cut a sign on their gateposts at the start of the crossing and scrape it off at the end, the first mark on Dia-thìr made for a season. Herders from the lowland who drove cattle into the passes out of season lost thirty head in a night and came down with nothing. And once the cats came down the road near Imrich nam Pantar<sup>2</sup> and turned back at the foothills. The hill-folk took it for a sign, and stored double; and the winter was hard.

## X

### Of the Hill-Folk and the Three Stones

**I**n the high valleys around the crack there lived people who were of another kind from the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>1</sup>. They called themselves Clann nan Dè<sup>2</sup>, the godkin, and the Mason's line was one household among them. They buried their dead in the ground, and cut no script. When the Old Ones came to the island, or whether they too grew out of it, no telling knows; the Telling of the Making names no people on Dia-thìr but the godfolk and their children. The hill-folk's own answer is that they were always there. These are the hill-folk, and from

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2. the panthers' crossing

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

2. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

them came the Dia-thìrich. They left the green mounds of the valleys unbroken, and built on none of them, and the hearths give the same reason: the sìth live in the hills and the mounds, and a house on a mound is a house on someone else's roof.

At Àth gharbh, in a hearth of plain peat ash, lies a sliver of the coloured coal burnt to a bead, and the hearthstone round it is stained through with colour. It is the earliest burning of the coal by any hand outside the Mason's line that anyone has found, and it burned as the mason's coals had burned, low and dark; whoever fed it to that fire knew nothing of the riddle. It is also small: one sliver, one fire. In the graves at Achadh dhìreach is wool streaked with colour no plant makes, for the hill-folk rubbed broken coal from the vein into cloth for their dead, one grave in some thirty. And far off on the western coast, in a midden of the Old Ones, lies a chip of the coloured coal still staining the shell around it. How a piece of the vein came to a rubbish-heap of the Old Ones, by gift or trade or theft, is anyone's guess.

Then the stones were raised; and the Dia-thìrich hold them holier than any temple.

The first is Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>3</sup>. On its upper face runs a line of the unread script, and lower down, cut with a narrower tool by another hand, are four words of Dia-thìris:

*Bha teine sa chloich.* There was fire in the stone.

When that second hand came, the stone does not say. Clann na Ceiste<sup>4</sup> hold that it was one of theirs, and that the fire in the stone is the mason's.

The second is Colbh Cnoc chiar<sup>5</sup>, and it carries three words only:

*Cuimhnich an teine.* Remember the fire.

Why the command was given, nothing is told. The ground round it is trodden hard in a ring paved with fire-cracked stones, where hearth-sized fires were kept again and again, and nothing else was left.

The third is Calbh Cnoc ghorm<sup>6</sup>, and it carries the doctrine itself, whole: *Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann.* If the doctrine has a birthplace, it may be there.

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3. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

4. the Children of the Question

5. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

6. the column at Cnoc ghorm

The ground round it holds the post-holes of shelters for some hundreds, used and rebuilt many times. Whatever was said there was said to a crowd.

In those years a burial ground grew about a place that no one remembers hal-  
lowing: Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>7</sup>, whose oldest graves are older than any name the  
hill-folk remember. In one of the oldest lies a child with a sliver of the coloured  
coal closed in one hand. The sliver stained the cloth she was wrapped in, and it is  
the only piece of the vein found buried with the dead in all this age. The graves  
came to be laid in rows, heads toward the central mountains; the earliest rows are  
straight, and the later ones bend round graves already there that no one would  
disturb.

So the Ancient Age draws to its close, in the high valleys, among people who  
burned the coal and did not know it. It closes as it opened, with a fire. Far to the  
north, at the grove of Doire ghlas, a young man of Clann na Ceiste had set six  
burning pots in a ring under the oaks and laid the dark seventh coal among them,  
and the Keeper came to him there out of the evening (21 an t-Iuchar, VE 5,324);  
and for the first time since the making of the world all seven coals burned togeth-  
er. The Ancient Age ends in that light, with the young man sitting among the sev-  
en fires under the oaks, and the Keeper standing with him, and the night coming  
on.

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7. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

THE SECOND BOOK

# AN AOIS AILEIN

*the Age of Ailean*

GE 1 – 4,603

*Chaidh e dhan doire na ghille, is thill e na rìgh.* He went into the  
grove a lad, and he came back a king.  
— said of Ailean Mòr at the ford, as the reciters of Dùn Ìseal keep it

I

## Of the Vigil in the Grove

**Ailean** son of Suibhne was a big young man, slow of speech, with hands like his forefather's, and he had done what no one of the line had thought to do. He left the rainbow coal alone and took up the other six, and lit each one again by its own way, one after another, as the line had lit them over three and a half thousand years: the gold on the northern sea, the snowflake off the Point, the black in the earth at Tobar dhìreach, the red-brown with his own blood, the silver in the Abhainn ghorm, and the fire with the snap of his fingers. Each he carried away burning, in a pot of clay with a lid of turf, and he kept them fed. It took him the better part of a year. Then he put the six pots and the dark seventh coal on a pole across his shoulders and walked north, to the grove.

He came into Doire ghlas at dusk on 21 an t-Iuchar, VE 5,324. He set the six pots in a ring under the oaks and took off their lids, and the six fires stood up out of them in their six colours: gold and white and the dark red of the black coal, red-brown, silver, and the clear fire-colour of Seathan's snap. He had never seen them

all together. No one had. He set the rainbow coal on the ground in the middle of the ring, and sat down, and waited, for the tellings said that this was where the Keeper came.

It was there before full dark. He saw it through the heat of the fires, the height of a tall man and made of grey smoke, standing among the oaks; and the smoke of his six fires blew past it on the evening wind and it did not stir.

"You have brought them all," it said.

"All I could," said Ailean. "The last will not light."

"No. It is not lit by anything of the sky, the earth or the sea. It is lit when the rest are together." The Keeper came into the ring. It stooped over the rainbow coal, and the coal took fire.

Ailean said afterward that he could not tell the colour of that flame, because it was every colour, and they would not hold still to be named. The six fires round it leaned in toward it, all together, the way grass leans in a wind, and for the first time since the making of the world all seven coals of Dia-thìr burned at once, each from its own spirit.

"Now listen," the Keeper said. "Stay with them until they are cold. Do not leave them, do not sleep far from them, and eat nothing while they burn."

"Why?"

"So that the spirits, being merged, may know one keeper, and the fire go into no hand but the hand that did not leave it."

"And after me?" said Ailean. "Will my children have it?"

The Keeper was quiet so long that he thought it would not answer. The six fires and the seventh burned between them without a sound.

"It will be yours," it said, "and no one's after you. Your children will have a little of it, and their children less, as a hearthstone keeps the heat a while when the fire is out; and then your line will not have it, and will forget that it ever had, and the island will call you a tale. But hear this, and keep it. When strangers hold this island, the fire will wake again in your line."

"What strangers?"

"That is not given to me to say."

He stayed. He kept the watch seven nights, a night for each coal, in the ring of fires under the oaks, and he ate nothing, and drank from the grove's spring only when the fires were steady. The first nights he was hungry and then he was not. The fires did not burn down as fires do. They burned through the nights at their



full height and did not need feeding. On the fifth night he thought he heard voices in them. On the seventh he could not tell whether he slept.

On the eighth night, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1, the fires were cold. He woke, or came to himself, and they were out, all seven: the coals lay in the ring grey and dead, and the grove was dark, and he was very cold.

Then the grove filled with light.

They came in among the oaks as people come into a hall, talking, and the light came with them. First was a young man with hands black to the wrist, as a mason's hands are grey; and Ailean knew him, though he had never been told how, for Caoran, the Young God, who made all that is. Behind him came the Tuath Dè, his kin. An Dagda came, huge and laughing, with his club over his shoulder, and Danu at his side; Bride with a flame in her hand; Lugh with his spear; Macha, and horses somewhere behind her that he heard but did not see; Manannan, who brought the smell of the sea into the middle of the island; Crom Cruaich, bent, who looked a long while at the slab-country to the south as if he could see it through the hills; and more behind them than Ailean could count or name.

Caoran stood over him in the ring of dead fires, and put out a black hand and held him where he knelt.

"You stayed," Caoran said. "Good." And he said the words that the Line of the Mason keeps, and that no other list has:

*Rìgh Chlann nan Dè.* King of the godkin.

Then he put his hand flat on Ailean's breast, and the heat that had gone out of the seven coals went into him. He said afterward only that it was as the night of the lightning must have been for the mason, if the mason had been the stone.

When he could see again it was morning, and the gods were gone, and the ring of pots lay cold on the leaves.

## II

### Of the Taking of the Hill

Ailean Mòr, as they called him from then on, told his kin that the gods had come to the grove and named him king of the godkin. That much he never hid, and Clann na Ceiste<sup>1</sup> believed him. What had gone into him with

Caoran's hand he told to no one: not his wife, nor his children, nor the reciters, in all the long years he lived. How then is it known? The line answers that the Keeper knows everything it watches over, and tells what it chooses to whom it chooses; and there the question stops.

He walked home from the grove and did not stop at the high valleys. He went on south with eleven of his kin to the hill where Dùn Ìseal now stands, which was held then by households that answered to no one; and the hearths of that hill kept a telling of what came up their slope on 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1, and it is told here as they tell it.

There was a lad on the hill that summer called the knapper's son, for his father worked flint in a pit behind the houses, and he was set with the other lads on the lip of the hill to watch the valley road. He saw them come: twelve people walking, no more, the first of them a head taller than the rest, and none of them in any hurry. He ran and told, and the holders of the hill came out with every spear they had, some sixty, and stood in a crowd on the slope where the ground is steepest, and the lad stood among them with his father's second-best spear.

The twelve stopped at the foot of the slope. The big one came on alone. He carried nothing in his hands.

The lad said, when he was an old man, that he had meant to throw. They had all meant to throw. The big man came up the grass at a walking pace, looking at them as a man looks at cattle in the wrong field; and when he was a spear's cast off, the lad felt a warmth on his face, as if someone had opened the door of a kiln. His arm was up. It stayed up. He could not think why he should throw, and the reason he had had a moment before was gone like a dream in the morning. Beside him the eldest of the hill's holders let his spear down until its point was in the grass, and sat down on the slope, and put his face in his hands; and one by one the others did as he had done, or turned round and walked back to their houses, and none of them could ever say afterward why.

The big man walked through them. He went up to the top of the hill and stood there, looking all round at the valleys, and after a while he called down the slope for someone to bring him water, and the lad brought it.

"What is your name?" said the king, when he had drunk.

The lad told him.

"Is that your father's spear?"

"His second-best."

"Take it back to him," said Ailean. "Tell him I shall want a great many more."

That year the households of the valleys about the hill came in to him one after another, and brought him their grazing and their quarrels, and he judged the quarrels and was feared, and loved a little too; and no one ever saw him lift a hand. A girl of Dùn ìseal said in her old age that she had once stood near him on a winter night and been warm, as if she stood by a fire, and that there was no fire.

So the first kingdom of the godkin was made: a hill and the valleys round it and the households that came in. Ailean threw up the hill's first bank, a single bank and ditch round some forty houses, the oldest defended place of the hill-folk. With him the reciters at the ford open the oldest spoken king-list, *Rìghbrean na Cloiche*<sup>2</sup>, the Stone Kings, and some of Clann na Ceiste say the stone of the name is the mason's stone. The list gives no lengths of reign, and it is older than the name Dia-thìrich.

### III

## Of the Holders of the Hill

**T**he list of the Stone Kings is the hill's list. It names, one after another, those who held Dùn ìseal and sat in judgement within its bank, and it names Ailean first because he held it first. The Line of the Mason says what the list does not: that Ailean Mòr was king from the night in the grove until the day he fell, and never once gave the kingship out of his hand. He set others to hold the hill for him; the crown he kept. The hill was too small for what had gone into him, and within a few years of the taking he was gone from it more than he was on it, riding out to the valleys beyond and the valleys beyond those, and bringing them in; and while he rode he set one of his own blood on the hill to hold it for him. Those holders are the Stone Kings after the first. They were kings of the hill under a king of the godkin, and the hill's own reciters, who counted what was done on the hill and little else, called them kings and left it there.

The first he set there was his daughter, **Gormshuil nic Ailein**, who stands second in the list and is the first woman named in any list on Dia-thìr. She had been born to him in the high valleys when he was a lad of eighteen, before ever he

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2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

went north with the six pots, and she was a small child when her father came back from the grove. Her telling gives her one deed. In a hard winter, when the grass on the hill was under snow and the byres were emptying, she drove the herds of Dùn ìseal down to the warm springs, where the ground steams and the snow does not lie, and lost none.

The reciters of Clann na Ceiste<sup>1</sup> give her more than that, and it is a hard telling. Gormshuil was born before the grove, and she had nothing of what went into her father there. She grew grey on the hill while he came and went from it, and the king who came in at the gate at the end of each riding season was a young man with a young man's back, and his daughter who met him at the gate was bent. Her own grandchildren took him for her son. When she died, an old woman in the ordinary way, he sat by her a night and a day, and afterward he did not speak of her. It was then, the reciters say, that the kin first understood that the long years came from the grove, and that the children born to him after it would have their portion and the ones born before would not.

After Gormshuil he set on the hill a son born after the grove, **Dòmhnall Clachach**, third of the list, who set marker stones along the valley below the hill to part the grazing of Dùn ìseal from its neighbours'. Some of the stones stand yet, and are still quarrelled over. After him came the first named storm, whose name is lost; it broke the shell causeway of Seann Warr in three places. Then came **Fearchar Bacach**, the lame, another son, who had been lamed in his father's wars in the valleys, and held the hill after the storm and after Dòmhnall. He was carried to the gatherings in a chair of woven birch, the first ruler on Dia-thìr remembered for a hurt. Dòmhnall did not die when Fearchar took the hill. He had the long years, and his father sent him north to hold what had been won there; for the holders of the hill came and went, and did not always go into the ground when they went.

So the Stone Kings stand in their list far apart, eighty years between Gormshuil's deed and Dòmhnall Clachach's, and more than four hundred between Fearchar Bacach and Mòrag Chruaidh. The reciters of the hill say the gaps are the long years: that the holders were of the king's blood and held long, as the long-lived do. The list itself says nothing more, and goes on.

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1. the Children of the Question

IV

## Of the Red Hill

A second list was kept in the west, and it opens with **Beathag Ruadh**, who held the hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and that is the Red Hill. She held it in the king's first years and was never his. Her line was an old line of the western lake shore, and when the tellings of Dùn ìseal speak of the Red Hill in those years they speak of it as a hill-man speaks of weather coming from the west.

**Uisdean Mòr**, who held the Red Hill after her, dug a ditch across the neck of the hill and set a palisade of oak on it, and in his time the palisade burned twice and was twice rebuilt. The Red Hill's own list says so much and no more. The reciters of Clann na Ceiste<sup>1</sup> tell the rest, and the Red Hill has never quarrelled with their telling, which is perhaps the strangest thing about it.

The king came west at the end of a summer with some two hundred spears, camped on the lake shore under the hill, and sent up no word. That night the palisade burned. No one saw a torch thrown, and the watch swore that the wood took fire of itself along its whole length, with flames of a colour they did not know, low and dark and shining. They put it out with lake water and hides by morning, and no one came up the hill.

Uisdean rebuilt through the autumn with green oak, which burns worst of all, and the king waited on the shore with his two hundred and did nothing that anyone could see. At the first frost the palisade burned again, the new wood and the old, in the same low dark way, from end to end, in the space of a breath.

In the morning Uisdean Mòr came down from the Red Hill alone.

He was a broad man, heavier than the king, with his hair and beard gone the colour of rust; and the tellers say that he came down the path slowly, stopping twice, and that at the bottom he stood a long time on the shingle looking at the man who sat on a stone by the water. The king did not get up. He was mending the strap of a sandal.

"Was that you?" said Uisdean.

The king finished with the strap before he looked up. "Your palisade has burned twice," he said. "I should not build it a third time."

"I asked if it was you."

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1. the Children of the Question

"I heard you."

Uisdean stood there with the lake behind the king going white under the wind, and the smoke of his palisade still hanging over the hill at his back. Then he went down on one knee on the wet stones and put his hands between the king's hands, and swore to him; and the king raised him, and they sat on the shingle together and ate, and talked about cattle. That was on 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 290.

The Red Hill kept its own holders after that, and its own list, and swore to the king and not to Dùn ìseal; and that is why the two lists make no mention of each other for so long. The Red Hill owed nothing to the hill of the Stone Kings, and the hill of the Stone Kings owed nothing to it. They owed the same man. **Seonag nic Uisdein**, who held the Red Hill after her father, counted her people by pebbles in a bag, one to a household, and knew by the weight when a household had gone; and when the king came west she weighed the bag before him, and he was content.

## V

### Of the Counting of the Dead and the Silence of the Old Ones

**W**hile the kingdom grew in the hills, another people were going out of the world on its shores, and the hill-folk hardly looked round.

In GE 308 the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>1</sup> began to cut strokes on flat stones set at the edges of their middens, one stone to a household. The strokes are simpler than the script: a mark, and then another. They were counting their dead. Before there was a Dia-thìreach people to take up the craft, the Old Ones kept count of their own losses.

At the eastern Seann Warr the counting stones were built into a wall, some three thousand strokes in all, and the wall grew for many lifetimes. At Seann Tarr in the north-east the strokes were cut in fives and the stones set into the floor of a house, and the house was lived in over its own dead. Then the tally stones of Seann Warr, Seann Tarr and Seann Chwen all thicken together, more strokes on each stone, more stones in each course. Whatever killed so many killed on three coasts at once. What it was, the strokes keep to themselves.

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1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

At the southern Seann Chwen, on 5 an Cèitean, GE 510, the last tally stone was left half-cut: two strokes finished, a third begun and given up. The chisel marks stop mid-groove.

After the half-cut stone no new work of the Seann-Dhaoine can be dated. Their middens stop growing, their harbours silt, and their script is never cut again. How they ended, no one knows. Many have guessed, and no guess has been believed for long. The reciters of Clann na Ceiste<sup>2</sup> say only that the king went down once to the shore at Seann Warr in those years, and stood a long while before the tally wall, and came away and would not speak of it.

There is a lament for them on the south coast. It is young, as such things go, and it says what the stones say:

*Stràc air a' chloich, is stràc eile; an treas stràc, cha deach a chrìochnachadh.  
Dh'fhalbh iad, is dh'fhàg iad na b-ainmean.*

A stroke on the stone, and another stroke; the third stroke, it was never finished. They went, and they left the names.

For the hill-folk went on calling the Old Ones' places by the Old Ones' names, putting only their own word for *old* in front: Seann Dunn, Seann Chwen, Seann Skell and the rest. They translated nothing, and the roots are still not understood. Hill-folk families came down the Abhainn naomh and settled the empty river harbour at Seann Skell, using the old mole and mending none of it. When diggers at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>3</sup> broke into a grave lined with slabs in the Seann-Dhaoine way, they closed it and moved their row, and no one opened it again.

At the eastern Seann Dunn, near the end of the age, a household set about cutting a floor for a new house into the side of the old midden.

The woman of the house had the spade, a blade of shoulder-bone on an ash handle, and at a man's length in, it rang. She knelt and cleared it with her hands: a flat stone set on its edge, and on its face the strokes, one and one and one, row on row, more than she could count on her hands and her sons' hands together. Behind it was another, and another. She knew what they were, though no one on that coast had ever seen one.

They lifted them out one at a time and laid them on the turf in the order they had come. She looked at them a long while in the wind off the sea. Then she and

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2. the Children of the Question

3. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

her sons put them back, the last first, each in its own place and facing the way it had faced, and filled the cut and trod it down, and built their house elsewhere, on poorer ground.

So the Dia-thìrich have always dealt with the Old Ones: as a people whose count must not be disturbed.

## VI

## Of the Salt Shore

**T**he first war in either list was a raid for salt, and the king was not in it. **Mòrag Chruaidh**, fifth of the Stone Kings, was a daughter of Dòmhnall Clachach and so the king's granddaughter, and she held the hill while her grandfather was away in the north. The southern shore at Baile ghorm did not yet own the king, and its people had salt, and the hill had none; and Mòrag went down to the pans and carried off the salt. Seven died on the hill side, and the telling keeps the number. The pans, shallow clay basins behind a shingle bar, were the first salt-works of the island.

**Iain Dubh**, sixth, was the king's own son, older than anyone on the southern shore and younger to look at than most of them. He went down to do as Mòrag had done, and the salt-folk were ready for him, and he was killed on the shingle, the first of Ailean's children to die by a spear. The list says only that he was brought home.

The king came home from the north to find his son under a cairn. He stayed three days on the hill. On the fourth he went down to the southern shore, and he went alone and on foot, by the old track through the dunes, and he came out onto the shingle at Baile ghorm on 5 an Lùnastal, GE 728, in the heat of the day, when the pans were drying and the women were raking them.

A woman raking salt was the first to see him, and her telling was kept on that shore. She saw a tall man coming along the shingle from the west, walking as if the beach were his, and she knew who it must be. She screamed for the men. They came running from the huts with the spears that had killed his son, some thirty of them, and made a line across the shingle between him and the pans.

He came on, neither slow nor hurrying, and she said afterward that the wind off the sea was warm on that side of him and cold on the other.



Nobody threw. She saw a man she knew, a hard man, who had been the first to strike Iain Dubh, lift his spear to his shoulder and hold it there, and hold it, until his arm shook; and then lower it, and look at it in his hand as though someone had given it to him and he could not think why. The king walked into the line of them and stopped. He looked along their faces one by one. He did not say anything at all.

Then the eldest of the salt-folk went down on her knees on the shingle. She took up a double handful of salt from the nearest pan, grey and wet, and held it up to him; and he took it, and ate a little of it, and gave the rest back to her. By evening the salt shore was his, and it stayed his. No blood was shed there that day, and none was paid, and the salt-folk were never able to agree afterward whether that was mercy or something worse.

The land was not quiet in those centuries, though the king's peace spread over it. The sea came in over a village on the site of Cnoc chaol and left a hand's depth of sand on its hearths, and in a valley of the hills a crack a man could fall into opened from side to side; the hill-folk laid a line of white stones along it and built no house within a stone's throw.

## VII

### Of the Unlit Hearth and the Watchers of the Slab

**M**eanwhile, in the high valleys, the hill-folk were learning the coloured coal the hard way.

In one dwelling of those years the hearth was laid with dry wood, and beside the wood lay a slip of the coloured coal, and none of it was ever burned. Whoever laid it went away and did not come back to light it, and the neighbours left the house as it stood and called it the Unlit Hearth. It is the earliest witness on Dia-thìr of coal that might easily have been burned and was left.

For in those years a custom set in across the hills, that no fire should take more of the coloured coal than can be held in one cupped hand. It was nowhere written and everywhere kept. The reason is always the same tale, told to children when they first reach toward the coal-box. At Achadh dhìreach, it goes, a household once burned a whole basket of the coloured coal at one time, knowing no more of what was in it than the basket did. The house burned down with three people in

it; and when the neighbours came in the grey of morning the hearthstone was cracked through and running with colour. Then the teller cups a hand, and says:

*Làn na glaise, 's gun tuilleadh.* The hollow of the hand, and no more.

The reciters of Clann na Ceiste<sup>1</sup> add to the tale a thing the hearths do not. They say that the king came to Achadh dhìreach the day after, and stood by the cracked hearthstone with the colour still creeping in it, and put his hand on it; and that the colour went out of the stone and it was grey. Then he said to the neighbours that the handful was a good custom and they should keep it. They kept it. It is the only law of the age that anyone remembers the king making, and he made it by agreeing with them.

And the families near the crack began to sit by the slab laid over it, a household at a time, through the dark half of the year, from Samhain, when the dark half begins, until the light came back. No one ever said what they were watching for. Among the first of them, the Line of the Mason says, was **Beathan**, a son of the king's son Somhairle. Beathan was already some five hundred years old and looked a man of thirty, and he sat his nights in the cold by the slab with the herds-men and their wives as if he were one of them. It was the way of Somhairle's children to do so, and it is why the line of Somhairle stayed in the high valleys when the other lines of the king's blood went down into the kingdom to hold it.

## VIII

### Of the Ford of Salt and Wool

**Raghnall Ceannfhionn**, seventh of the Stone Kings, came down to the ford to meet the Red Hill, and the reciters make much of his coming.

He was a grandson of the king, fair-headed and quick. For close on nine hundred years the two hills had sworn to the same king and never once spoken to each other. His hill had sheep in plenty and too little salt, and the west had salt in plenty and was short of wool; and the king, when Raghnall asked him, said only that they were both his, and that he would not do their talking for them.

So Raghnall brought only a few with him, for more would have looked like a raid. It was early summer, the river running clear and shallow over its stones. The

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1. the Children of the Question

Red Hill's holder, whose name the lists do not keep, waited on the far bank with as many, and the two parties looked at each other a long time across the water while the river talked between them.

Ragnall waded in, alone, to the middle of the ford, with the water to his knees and his cloak held up out of it, and stood there. After a while the other came out to meet him.

What they said the reciters give short. The hill would bring wool; the west would bring salt; neither would bring spears. They clasped arms over the water and waded back, each to their own bank.

Both lists record it, and it is the first time either names the other. The meeting became a yearly gathering where salt, flint, wool, dried fish and pots changed hands and marriages were agreed, and its trodden ground became the oldest meeting-place on the island, and it was never left. **Murchadh Gearr**, who held the Red Hill after Seonag, kept the peace of the ford, and walked the salt road himself every year to be seen on it.

The hill-folk spread in those generations, and wherever they went the king's peace went with them: to Ros bheag on the west coast; to the western lake shore, paying salt to the Red Hill; to Cnoc ghorm with the first cattle of the north-west. An oak dug-out long enough for six was sunk at Cidhe Beag, the oldest boat on Dia-thìr whose whole shape is known. Seal-oil lamps burned at Caol leathan, the first light on the island that was no hearth.

Hard years came. At the site of Baile chrom in the north-west the pots are found full of boiled bark and seaweed and the grave-rows doubled: the oldest hunger on Dia-thìr with a place to it. **Sileas Bhàn**, eighth of the Stone Kings, of the king's blood, held Dùn ìseal through years of failed grazing, and her telling gives her no deed but that. She held, and the list goes on after her. **Tormod Liath**, ninth, a grandson of the king, held the hill so long that he outlived three heirs, and in his time Dùn ìseal got its second bank. He was called the grey, and he was grey, and the hill thought him the oldest thing it had ever seen, until the king came in at the gate one spring and Tormod Liath went down on his knee to a man who looked younger than his own sons.

Things were fixed in those lifetimes that have never been unfixed. Flint was dug at Cnoc àrsaidh, the only good flint on Dia-thìr, and the road of those who carried it was worn a yard deep into the hills. A hawk was carved on a lintel at Àth mhòr, wings closed, head turned, the oldest carving of any bird on the island. Someone began to mark the high-water line against a fixed rock, at intervals too

regular for a fisherman's habit, and at Ros dhomhain the marks crept upward from keeper to keeper, until by the age's end the lake stood a hand higher than at the first cut. And the eight winds were named, and eight stones were set in a ring on the point at Ceann leathan, one to each wind; sailors since have touched the stone of the wind they want before they go out.

## IX

## Of the Dia-thìrich Name and the Sharing before the Storms

**B**y GE 2,201 the hill-folk had begun to call themselves **Dia-thìrich**, and their island **Dia-thìr**. The first mouth to say it is forgotten. The oldest tellings already take both names for granted, and the doctrine goes with them.

With the name came the first forbidden marriage, two lineages refused to each other for reasons none can now give: the earliest sign that the Dia-thìrich ordered themselves by bloodline before the coal gave them any cause to. At the ford, households began to recite their lines seven names back on each side before a marriage was agreed, and those are the first genealogies of the common households, for only the Line of the Mason is older. None of them survives whole. The king's own blood recited no such lines. Their line was two names long, the reciters say, and the second was Ailean's.

In the same years they went looking for another vein. Diggers from Dùn ìseal opened a trench on a far hillside and gave it up when two of them were crushed by a fall, and a second opening elsewhere struck ordinary rock with nothing beneath it. So it was first shown that the vein under the mountain stands alone, and the Dia-thìrich took it that the vein chooses where it lies.

Then came the custom that the coasts have leaned on ever since, more than they admit: that any household with food to spare must share it before a storm season. At Àth shean a household hid its grain in a pit beneath the floor and brought nothing, and when the pit was found the household was put out with what it could carry, the first known punishment under the custom. And when the storm called *A' Ghaoth Dhubh*<sup>1</sup>, the Black Wind, the oldest storm whose name is kept, stripped the thatch from every house on the east coast from Cuan ruadh

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1. the Black Wind

to Ceann chiar, the settlements of that coast fed Cuan ruadh through a whole winter out of what they had shared, and no one there is remembered as dying of hunger that season.

Between the two hills there was fosterage. **Eilidh Ghlas**, tenth of the Stone Kings, sent her younger son to the Red Hill, the first fosterage in either list, and **Lachlann Ruadh** took him in; and the Red Hill list calls Lachlann for it *Lachlann an Altraim*, Lachlann of the fostering, more often than by his own name. **Peigi Dhubh**, who held the hill after him, sent the son home grown, with gifts of salt, and the ford peace held a generation more. The fosterling brought the western salt-songs to Dùn ìseal. The list gives him no name and no reign. He is remembered only as the one who went.

X

## Of Oighrig and the Stone Cup

**A**t the slab the heart of the age was kept, and the hearths of the hill country tell this part closest of all.

It was 26 an t-Samhain, GE 2,403, in the dark half of the year, when the families who watched the slab met beside it and agreed that they would stop taking turns by household and choose one keeper at a time by lot.

**Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill** stood among them with her shawl over her head against the drizzle. The slab lay grey in the middle of the gathering with the rain beading on it, and the old stain at its lower edge that never washed out. She had sat by it through many nights with her household, and had never once seen it do anything at all.

The lots were pebbles in a bag, one marked. She put her hand in and felt the cold stones knock against her fingers, and brought one out, and opened her hand. Everyone near her saw it before she did.

No one cheered. An old man touched her shoulder once and stepped back. She looked at the pebble a while, and then at the slab, and she put the pebble in her belt, and she kept the slab for the rest of her life.

A house was built beside it at Tobar dhireach with its door toward the stone, the first building on Dia-thìr that exists only to be near the vein. Before two years of her keeping were out, Oighrig went to a man who worked stone, and set her own hand on the table before him, cupped as for water, and said she wanted a cup

of grey stone that would hold what that hand held and not a grain more, so that the handful should be the same in every house. He ground it over many days and fitted it to her palm again and again, until it sat in the hollow of her hand like an egg in a nest.

The tellings give her a word at the grinding, though whether she said it, only she could tell:

*Chan e mo làmh-sa a th' ann, ach làmh gach teallaich.* It is not my hand; it is the hand of every hearth.

Copies were ground at Àth gharbh, Achadh dhìreach and Cnoc chaol, and the four were carried to a spring on the moor between Àth gharbh and Tobar dhìreach and filled from it in turn on a flat stone. The place is called Coinneachadh nan Cupan<sup>1</sup>, the meeting of the cups, and so the hills came to measure the coal with one measure.

The lot did not make its keepers holy. A keeper named **Gilleasbuig Beag** was found with a basket of broken coal from the vein in his own house. The households sat in judgement at the slab and rowed him out to Eilean chrom and left him there with no boat to come back in, the first person anyone remembers exiled for the vein. The coal was neither burned nor kept. The keeper who followed him carried it back to the slab, and knelt, and laid it under the stone's edge piece by piece until the basket was empty. The tellings say it in four words:

*Chaidh an gual dbachaigh.* The coal went home.

Eilean chrom was left empty after, and never fished. His fire was seen on it for three nights, the tellings say, and then no more.

Then the holders of the hill reached for the lot. **Calum Ciar**, the elder son of Eilidh Ghlas and eleventh of the Stone Kings, asked that it be drawn at Dùn ìseal in his sight, and the households refused him; and the list records the refusal, which is more than the list usually records of anything. Calum Ciar took the matter to the king, who was at the ford that summer. The king heard him out and said that the slab was older than the hill, and older than the grove, and that he would not overrule it; and Calum Ciar went home. The lot was still drawn at the slab. The holders of the hill ruled the grazing and the gatherings under the king,

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1. the meeting of the cups

and the keepers ruled the vein, and that line held for the rest of the age. It was written nowhere.

## X I

### Of Anndra Breac and the Doctrine Spoken

**I**n the spring of the year before, the watchers in the tower at Seann Skell had seen the Sea-Watcher off the point, a back as long as three boats rising and going under, and there were four of them to swear to it. That summer planks of stitched boats, broken small, washed up along the western shore, with no bodies among them and no boat missing from any settlement there. Those who tell what follows at the ford set these two things down beside it and let them lie.

On 29 an Giblean, GE 2,422, the gathering at the ford was full, and **Anndra Breac**, a teller from the western coast, stood up before the gathering to give a telling.

He was a lean man with a face burnt dark by the sea wind and a voice made for the open air. A child slept against its mother's knee in the front of the crowd. He began, and for a while they listened, because he was good. Then they understood what the telling was. In it the people came to Dia-thir. They came over the sea, in boats, from somewhere else.

The first shout came from the hill households, and then from everywhere at once. Anndra Breac raised his voice over them, which was the worst thing he could have done; and he stood with his mouth still moving and no one hearing a word, and the child woke and cried.

The gathering put him out of the ford for the rest of his life. He went west along the river path and did not look round. His telling was not kept, only the fact of it. The king was not at the ford that year, and when he heard of it he is said to have laughed, and then to have been quiet a long while; for he was the one man on the island who had seen gods walk into a grove, and he knew better than the gathering where the godkin came from.

After Anndra Breac, the saying on the column at Cnoc ghorm was spoken aloud at the opening of every ford gathering: *Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann*. It was the first time the doctrine was said as a rule that bound, where before it had only been believed.

## XII

## Of the Great Gathering at the Ford

**T**he king's days had no height that anyone could point to, for he did not change; but the kingdom's had, and the reciters set it at the great gathering, on 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000, in the three thousandth year since the grove.

There was a girl of the Red Hill at that gathering, nine years old, who had come with her mother's people to sell salt on the downstream ground; and because her grandmother lived to tell it to the Red Hill's reciters, and they to the reciters of the ford, it is her gathering that is told.

She had never seen so many people. The ford ground was full from the river to the trees, and still they came, from the north with pigs and from the west with seal-skins, until the three grounds ran together and nobody knew any longer which bank was whose. Her mother held her wrist all day so as not to lose her.

On the second morning the king came. He was dressed as a herdsman dresses, and he walked in from the hill road with a few others, and he was younger than her father. She was disappointed at first. Then she saw the crowd open for him, all the way down to the river, as a field opens when the wind goes over it, without a word said; and she saw the faces of the old people as he passed, and she was frightened, and after that she could not stop looking at him.

He went and stood in the middle of the ford, where Ragnall Ceannfhionn had stood long before, with the water to his knees. The holders came out to him one by one and put their hands between his hands: the holder of Dùn ìseal, and the holder of the Red Hill, looking small; the holder of the salt shore, and the holders of the north and the west; and each waded back with the front of his clothes wet through, and nobody laughed.

Then his own blood came.

They came down from the upstream ground, and she had not understood till then that they were all one family. Some were old and some were young, and the young ones were the eldest, her grandmother said, for the king's children were very old indeed and did not look it. They stood round him in the river in rings, the nearest ring his children and the next ring theirs, and then theirs, out to the banks, until the ford was full of them and the water was piling up behind their legs; and the reciters on the bank began to say their names, and said names until the sun went down, and had not finished. Some four hundred of his blood stood



in the river that day, the reciters counted afterward. The girl thought that he did not know all their names either. She saw him look at a young woman in the outermost ring as a man looks at someone he has met and cannot place.

Only the households east of the vein sent no one to the ford. People remarked on it, and then forgot it, for the day was fine.

When the reciters stopped at last, the king said something to those nearest him, and they began to wade back to the banks; and when the ford was empty he stood there alone a little while in the dusk. The girl was nearest the water on the downstream side, for her mother had let go of her wrist at last. She said to the end of her life that the river going past her feet was warm, as warm as a bath, with the king standing in it, and that downstream of him the water smoked in the evening air like a spring.

### XIII

## Of the Long Years

**h**e did not grow old. That is the plainest thing the reciters say of him, and the hardest to take in. Somewhere in his second thousand years his hair went grey in a single winter, and then it stayed grey and went no further; and his hands and his back were those of the man who had knelt in the grove. The ordinary people of the island came and went round him, generation after generation, as the grass comes and goes round a stone. All that while he said nothing of what had gone into him in the grove. The power was his alone. It had gone, as the Keeper said, into the one hand that did not leave the fire, and there was no other hand it could go into.

His children had a portion of it all the same, as a child has something of the father's face. He had many wives in the long years, one after another, and buried every one of them; and the children born to him after the grove lived two thousand years and three thousand and more, and their children not so long, and theirs less again, each generation shorter-lived than the one before, as the Keeper had said. They were strong and slow to anger, and most of them were very proud. They held the hills and valleys of the kingdom under him, in shares he gave and took back as it pleased him, and the ordinary people of the island were used to being ruled by a grandmother who had ruled their great-grandmothers.

Somhairle was one of them, and the reciters of Clann na Ceiste<sup>1</sup> keep his line beyond all the others. He was born in his father's sixty-second year, early among the children of the grove, and he never took a share of the kingdom or asked for one. He lived in the high valleys among Clann na Ceiste all his days, and kept the slab, and kept the lines, and his children after him did the same. He died on 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,025, at Tobar dhìreach, and the Line of the Mason gives him two thousand nine hundred and eighty-seven years.

The king came up from the kingdom to bury him. The old people of Clann na Ceiste stood about the grave and looked at the two of them, the father with his straight back and the son in his shroud with a face like a withered apple, and could not find a word to say. The king put his son into the ground himself. Then he sat down on the turf beside the grave with his arms round his knees, like a boy, and stayed there until it was dark. One of the reciters went to him at last and asked whether he would come in to the fire.

"I have buried a wife in every century," said Ailean Mòr, "and a son before this one; and I shall bury them all. That was the bargain. I did not know it was the bargain when I made it."

After Somhairle the long years thinned in his line as they thinned in all the lines of the king's blood. His son Beathan, who had sat by the slab in the dark half of the year among the herdsmen, lived two thousand two hundred and thirteen years, and had died before his father; Beathan's son lived one thousand five hundred and ninety-four; and each after him, born about the middle of the life of the one before, had fewer years than his father, and each of them knew it at his father's grave.

The king saw the fading, and so did the reciters, and they remembered what the Keeper had said in the grove: that the line would not have it, and would forget that it ever had. Clann na Ceiste kept Somhairle's line all the same, by mouth, as they keep everything.

The coloured coal lay under the slab and in the pots of Clann na Ceiste, and the other households of the hills went on burning it by the handful in their common fires, dark-flamed, and never knew what it held.

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1. the Children of the Question

XIV

## Of the Beacons, the Tide-Rocks and the Long Settling

In those years the coasts were lit. Fires were kept on the eastern cape, the northern point, the north-eastern cape and the southern cape, and with the old fire at Baile chrom the coasts were lit at five points. The old fire warned boats off, and the tellings say these new ones were kept to bring them home in a storm. The tide-rock at Ros dhomhain passed to **Seònaid Mhòr**, who cut her marks in pairs, high water and low; the keepers after her went back to single marks. Inis thais cut its own marks at the same interval, and none says why the interval is what it is.

The salt-songs of the pans are the oldest songs on Dia-thìr whose words are said to survive, a refrain of four lines that no one can fully construe. At Cnoc àr-saidh near the panther road were found pipes of bird-bone bored with four holes, the oldest instruments on the island. Pilgrims sat a night at the edge of the holy wood of the east without entering, and came in numbers to the warm springs under the mountain, where the oldest cure-tale on Dia-thìr is set: a herder who came lame and walked home.

Then, over nearly two thousand years, the Dia-thìrich filled the island, and of that long settling only the shape can be told. A salt road ran from the pans of Baile ghorm through the ford to Muileann àrsaidh, where salt sold at three times its price. Dùn thais was banked, the first Dia-thìrich fort away from Dùn ìseal and the Red Hill, and Dùn chrom was raised in the island's middle with a bank that faces both ways; each was held by one of the king's blood, and each holder thought the other's bank faced the wrong way. Cuan ruadh was rebuilt in stone to the eaves against the wind, and Ceann chiar set a stone in its midst cut with one mark for each house the Black Wind took: twenty-two. Everywhere the settlers let the old things be. Those who built below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>1</sup> took no stone from the ruin, though it was the nearest quarry, and a path was worn round Làrach an Teampaill<sup>2</sup> at a distance. At Cnoc naomh the hill was already called holy when the settlers came; the hearths say the sìth were in it, and the settlers built below it and never on it.

The ford gathering grew till it drew every coast. At Ceann leathan the gathering by the wind-stones ended with wrestling and the lifting of stones, and the

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1. the watch-fort ruin

2. the temple ruin

heaviest, a black boulder, lies on the point still; few have raised it, and the hearths of that point say that the first to raise it was a big grey-haired man who came to the gathering once, as a stranger, and put it down again very gently, and would not give his name. In the north the oaks fell back before the heather and the bog-moss, and the groves that give the north its many Doire names shrank to the sheltered valleys; the grove at Doire ghlas was one of those that stood. The land kept its old wounds: the sea came again over Cnoc chaol, less far, and the crack in the valley moved and the spring went back uphill.

East of the vein a double-banked fort was raised at Dùn dhearg by households who owed nothing to Dùn ìseal. They were of the godkin like everyone else, but no blood of the king's was among them, and they were proud of it. The Stone Kings' list does not name its holders. It says only that Dùn dhearg did not come to the gatherings, until in the lifetime the tellings give to Catrìona Mhòr, before ever she held Dùn ìseal, its people came to the ford with seal-skins, asking for salt, and were given ground of their own on the far bank. Among the last settlings of the age was Inis mhòr, whose two facing rows of houses are the oldest street on Dia-thìr.

## X V

## Of Catrìona Mhòr and the King's Last Years

**T**he last name the Stone Kings' list gives is **Catrìona Mhòr**, twelfth of the line and of the king's blood, who knew, her telling says, every household of the hills by its line back seven names. The last in the Red Hill's spoken list is **Seumas Òg**. The list stops with him.

Her people counted the households of the hills by knots on a cord, a knot to a hearth, and the cord from Dùn ìseal is said to have held some nine hundred knots, the largest count made on Dia-thìr in this age. The king's own blood was not on the cord. There was no counting them any longer, and no one tried.

The lot for the slab was drawn now from every part of the hills, and the keepers were made nine, one for each of nine districts, meeting at the slab when a keeper died and at no other time. Every household burned its handful in the dark of the year, measured in a copy of the stone cup, all at once by agreement, so that the low dark fires of the handful showed on every hillside on the same night. That night was Samhain, and it has been the night of the handful ever since. Only the

household of the old trench refused its handful for as long as anyone remembered, the first on record to choose to burn nothing at all.

The words on the column at Cnoc ghorm, worn shallow, were recut along their old grooves by a hand from the Stone Kings' hill. Some say the recutting changed a letter, and no one can prove which.

In the first summer of her holding the two king-lists were recited at the ford one after the other, from first name to last, and it took from dusk to dawn. The reciter of Dùn ìseal stood first, and gave Ailean Mòr and his bank, and Gormshuil and the herds, and Iain Dubh brought home from the shingle, and Calum Ciar refused; and when he came to her own name he said it and sat down, and she felt every face at the ford turn to her in the firelight. Then the reciter of the Red Hill stood, and gave Beathag Ruadh and her hill, and Seonag with her bag of pebbles, and Lachlann of the fostering, down to Seumas Òg, who had taken the Red Hill that same season and sat across the fire from her. It was the first time anyone had heard both lists whole. By the end the sky over the river was grey and the children were asleep in heaps. The king sat among the listeners all night with his cloak round him, and when the reciter of the hill said his name first of all, some of those nearest saw him smile.

She held Dùn ìseal a long time after that night, and she was old when the nine keepers came to her.

They came up together across the trodden ground of the ford while the gathering was full, and stood before her, and the one who spoke for them was older than she was. They asked that their charge be declared before the whole gathering: that the slab and the lot and the handful were theirs to keep, so that no king after her could draw the lot at Dùn ìseal as Calum Ciar had wanted to.

Catrìona Mhòr looked at them a long while. She knew them all, and their lines, seven names back. She looked past them at the gathering, the salt people and the hill people and the flint people on the far bank, all waiting to see what she would do.

"Not this year," she said. And when the old keeper opened his mouth: "Ask me again."

She gave no refusal and no consent, and the keepers went back to their slab to wait.

She died not many years after, and with her the hill's list ends; and it ends, the reciters say, because there was no one after her to put in it. Her kin came to Dùn ìseal from every part of the kingdom to be named after her, and there were more

claims to the hill than there were houses on it. They were all of the king's blood. Each of them could say the two names of their line, and the second was always Ailean's. On 12 an Màrt, GE 4,391, the king came to Dùn ìseal himself and heard them all, sitting on the bank where he had sat the first day, and when they had done he gave the hill to none of them. He held it in his own hand, as he had held it in the first days before Gormshuil, and he stayed on it.

That was the beginning of the trouble, though no one called it so then. The kin had long held the kingdom in shares, as the king gave and took back; and now, seeing him keep the hill, they began to say among themselves that he meant to name no one, and that when he went, if he ever went, the shares would be fought for. They said it at the ford and in each other's halls, never before him, and they began to count their own shares and each other's, and to marry with an eye to what a marriage would bring when the shares fell open. The king knew, and did nothing about it that anyone could see.

And east of the vein, where there was no king's blood, Dùn dhearg watched all this and drew its own counsel. On 11 an Gearran, GE 4,520, the king sent to Dùn dhearg and to the households about it, bidding them come in to him at last; and they sent his messenger back with nothing, and swore among themselves that they would owe nothing to Dùn ìseal nor to its king. From that year the spears of the east were gathered at Dùn dhearg, slowly, as a river gathers behind a dam.

So the age came to 7 an Lùnastal, GE 4,550. The handful was kept in every hearth of the hills; the keepers were nine; the sharing before the storms was kept on every coast; the doctrine was said at every gathering. The Old Ones were names on the shore. The three ruins stood empty and unquarried, the two shafts gave back no sound, and the slab lay over the crack as the mason's people had laid it nearly ten thousand years before. No oath had been sworn over any of it. It was custom and not law, and the vein was a covered wound in the rock and no more. The king sat on his hill, and his kin waited about him, and the east waited beyond the vein; and it was a long wait, even by the reckoning of those days.

## XVI

### Of the Ford below Dùn dhearg

T

he east came at the end of the summer, in the year the reciters count the four thousand six hundred and third of the Grove, and the tellers who give it best are the tellers of the east themselves, who had cause to remember.

There was a lad in the host of Dùn dhearg, sixteen years old and the youngest of his household's spears, whose name the east did not keep; but his telling it kept, and here it is.

He had come down to the river with the rest in the dark before the first morning. The river runs below Dùn dhearg over a wide ford of gravel, and the west bank rises from it in a steep slope of turf with a track cut up it, which is the road to the vein and to Dùn ìseal. The host had been told that the king was coming east with his kin at last, and meant to hold the ford against him. Its fires ran along the east bank for a mile.

In the grey light, there was one man on the west bank.

He was sitting on a stone at the head of the ford with his spear across his knees, and there was no one with him. The lad looked up and down the far bank for the rest, for the king's kin and their households and the spears of the hills, and there was nothing: the turf and the track going up and the mist lifting off the river. Word went down the host that the king had come ahead of his kin with a handful of his household, and had sent the handful back up the road that night; and that his kin had not come. Each was waiting to see whether the others would go, each afraid that while their spears were at the ford their cousins' spears would be on their hills. They were already quarrelling over what the old man would leave. Nobody in the host of Dùn dhearg could believe it, and then everybody could, and a great shout went up along the east bank.

The man on the stone stood up.

The lad said that he had heard all his life how the king was big, and that the king was not big as he had pictured, and was bigger. He came down to the water's edge and stood there, and the grey of his hair was the only grey on that bank; and the lad, who had a spear in his hand and three thousand spears beside him, felt the warmth of him come across the river like the warmth of a kiln, and was afraid, and did not know why.

The first rush went into the ford at sunrise. The lad was not in it, being young, and he watched it from the bank. Some two hundred went in together with a roar and the water went white round their knees; and the king went into the river to meet them, and did not seem to hurry, and the front of the rush reached him in the middle of the ford.

The lad could not afterward tell what he saw. He said the king did not fight as men fight, with a man in front of him and then another. He fought as a river fights a bank. Spears went into the place where he was and he was not there, and men went down round him in the water in a ring, and the water ran red downstream of him in the sunrise; and the rush broke on him and went back, and he walked back to the west bank and sat down on his stone again, and the river carried the dead downstream until they caught on the gravel at the shallows and began to pile there.

All that day they came at him, and he held the ford. They came in rushes and in lines, and across the deep channel upstream to take him from the side, and he was there before them. They threw spears from the bank until there were none to throw, and the lad said that some of them struck him and did not seem to matter. At dusk the host drew back to its fires. The king went back to his stone, and drank from the river, and the lad saw him wash his hands.

On the second day the dead began to dam the river. They lay so thick at the shallows below the ford that the water backed up behind them and spread out over the gravel, and the ford grew wide and slow, and red, and the men of the east had to climb over their own dead to come at him. The lad went in on the second day. He remembered little of it: the cold of the water and then its warmth, for the river was warm round the king as a spring is warm; a face above him, calm and grey-browed, and a hand that took the spear out of his hands as one takes a knife from a child; and then he was on the east bank again, face down in the mud, and alive. He lay there till dark, and heard the rushes go in all the rest of that day, and heard them come back fewer.

In the night of the second day the host of Dùn dhearg met at its fires. Some said to go home. And a greybeard of the eastern households said that no one man could hold a ford for ever; that he was of flesh; and that if every spear in the east went into the river together on the third day, and kept on going in, they must come to the end of him, as the sea comes to the end of a cliff. It was the only counsel anybody had. They took it.

On the third day every spear the east had went into the river together.

The lad went in with them. The water was above his waist where the dead had backed it up, and it was red and warm, and it stank. He was far from the front, and saw the king only in glimpses, over heads and between spears: a grey head in the middle of the river with the whole host of the east closing on it from three sides, and the host breaking round it and closing again, as the tide breaks round a



rock and closes behind; hour after hour, the whole day long, while the sun went over. The lad said that there was light round the king by the afternoon, a light of no colour he knew, low on the water, dark and shining, and that where it touched the river the river steamed. He said that men who were near it said afterward that they saw every colour in it and none, and would not say more.

The kin did not come.

At sunset the king was still standing, in the middle of the ford, with the host around him and the dead around him higher than his knees, and the river going over the dam of the dead in a red fall at the shallows. He was not beaten. The lad was sure of that, and it was the one thing he was sure of. Not one of them had beaten him, and no one of them could have. It was only that there was no end to them, and there was an end to him; and that was all.

He fell on the third night, in the dark. No one saw the spear that did it, and no one claimed it, and no household of the east would let it be said that the blow was theirs. They say that when he went down the light went out of the river all at once, as a coal goes out when water is thrown on it, and that the river, which had been warm three days, ran cold. Then the host stood in the dark in the water and did not know what to do, and some began to weep, and they did not know why they wept.

They drew him out of the river onto the west bank, where his stone was. He lay on his back with his eyes open, and his face was the face of a young man, with no line on it that had not been there in the grove. The Line of the Mason, which keeps the years of its dead beside their names, gives his as four thousand six hundred and twenty-six. He had been king since the grove, and he had not given it up, and no man living had taken it from him. Four thousand and six hundred years he had been king of the godkin; and the whole east, from the vein to the sea, had come against him at last, and he had held them three days alone at a ford.

Before the dawn a saying went along the east bank, from fire to fire:

*Cha do leag aon duine e; leag an sluagh uile e.* No one man brought him down; the whole host brought him down.

The lad had waded out by then and sat at a fire on the east bank, and when the men about it asked him what the king had been like, close to, he said only that he had been warm, and looked at the fire.

Here the Second Book ends, at the ford below Dùn dhearg; for with Ailean Mòr the one hand that held the kingdom was gone, and the Age of Ailean went out with him, as the light went out of the river.

THE THIRD BOOK

# AN Aois Naomh

*the Holy Age*

FE 1 – 2,960

*Làn an dà bhois, agus gun tuilleadh.* The fill of the two palms, and  
no more.

— said of the stone cup at Dùn ìseal

## I

### Of the Ford of Blood and the Gathering of the Heirs

*At Dùn ìseal the knot-keepers tell this, and they tell it with a cord across their knees.*

In the last summer of the Age of Ailean the valley under Dùn ìseal was full of tents. The king held the hill in his own hand, as he had in the first days, and his kin had come in from every coast to wait about him for their shares. Some of them had been waiting a long time. There were sons of his in that valley who had stood about him at the great gathering at the ford when they were already old men by any other reckoning, and daughters who had seen Tormod Liath hold the hill under him, and grandchildren and great-grandchildren and the children of those, more than any reciter could name in a night. Each of them had a fire in the valley, and a steward to argue for it, and a grievance against the fire next to it.

So when the spears of the east came out of Dùn dhearg, the king went down to meet them, and his kin stayed by their fires. Each of them meant to follow in a day or two, once a water-meadow or a hill-grazing or a stretch of shore had been

settled in their favour. The Second Book has told what came of that at Àth na Fala<sup>1</sup>. Here it is told as it came to the valley.

Sìne nan Snaidhm kept the cord at Dùn ìseal that year. It was the cord of the households, of the kind Catrìona Mhòr's people had first made, a knot to a hearth. Sìne was of no one's blood that mattered, and she had the tying of it because her fingers were quick and her memory was good and she could not be bribed, having nothing that she wanted.

She was at the spring below the hill with her pails, on the fourth evening after the battle, when the runner came up the valley road. He was a herd-boy of the eastern hills, barefoot, and he had run so far that he could not stop when he reached the spring; he went on past it three or four steps, and then his legs folded and he sat down in the mud. Sìne gave him water from her pail. He drank half and was sick, and drank the rest.

"Where is the camp of the king's son?" he said. "Any of them. I was told to tell the king's sons."

"There are sixty camps in this valley that call themselves the king's sons," said Sìne. "Tell me, and I'll tell them."

He told her. He had watched from the ridge above the ford. The king had held it alone, three days and three nights, and the host of the east had come at him through the ford and across the deep water above it, and the water was so full of their dead that it rose behind them and spread out over the meadow. On the third night the king went down. No one man had done it. They had come at him until there were no more of him to come at.

"And his kin?" said the boy, looking at the tents. He had come a long way. "Where were his kin?"

Sìne did not answer that, and she took him up to the tents.

She remembered afterward, and told it to her daughters, that the first thing said when the news went into the camps was a question about the hill. A steward in a blue cloak came out of the nearest fire-circle, heard the boy through, and turned round to the men behind him and said, "Who holds the hill now?" She watched that question go through the valley faster than the grief did. For a while no one keened at all. Then a woman in one of the upper camps, a daughter of the king, so old that her hair had gone white and then gone thin, began to keen alone,

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1. the Ford of Blood, below Dùn dhearg

and the valley took it up from her fire to the next, until the whole of it was crying in the dark, and the herd-boy with it.

Of all the kin only one had gone after the king, and he had gone late. Ìomhar Dearg, a son of the king some fourteen hundred years old, had stayed in the valley three days to argue for a stretch of river-grazing, and then had called up his household and ridden east ashamed. He came to Àth na Fala on the morning after the king fell. He found the river dammed and the meadow drowned, and on the west bank, by the stone where the king had sat, his father, and beyond it the host of the east lying spent in the heather, too tired to stand. Ìomhar Dearg fell on them. By evening he held the ford, and in the days after he took Dùn dhearg and burned the halls within its double bank, and those of its people who lived he took under his own hand. He sent his father's body up to Dùn ìseal on a bier made of the host's spears. He did not come himself for nine days, and when he came, he came as the lord of Dùn dhearg. His holding was called afterward *an Earrann Dhearg*<sup>2</sup>, the Red Share, for the hill and for the blood; and it was the one share on the island that was won with a sword before the parting and never given in it.

They carried the king up the valley road, and the heirs came out of the tents to see him go by. Sine stood among them. She had seen him three times in her life, and each time far off, a tall man on a horse at the edge of a gathering. She saw now that he had not grown old. His hair was grey, as it had been since before anyone could remember, but his face was a young man's face, and the wounds were all in front. Behind the bier walked two of his sons, and both of them were grey.

Where they laid him, the tellers of Dùn ìseal and the tellers of the Mason's line do not agree, and each has a mound to show.

Then the heirs sent to every coast, and the kin who had not been in the valley came in, and the eldest keeper of the slab came down to Sine's house and asked her for a new cord.

"The households are counted," she said.

"Not the households," said the keeper. "The heirs. They will want to know how many there are before they start. And they will not believe each other."

So Sine sat at the door of the long gathering-house below the hill, with the new cord in her lap and a basket of flax beside her, and every one of the kin who stood up to claim came before her and said the line of their claim, and she tied a

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2. the Red Share of Ìomhar Dearg at Dùn dhearg

knot. That gathering is called *Cruinneachadh nan Oighrean*<sup>3</sup>, the Gathering of the Heirs.

The eldest to come before her was Murchadh Mòr, the king's eldest living son, near two thousand nine hundred years old. He was the first of them that she knotted, and he stood over her the whole time she tied it, as if she might tie it loose. He had a voice like a door on a cold hinge, and he gave his line in two words, "Ailean's son," and looked down the valley to see who would argue. Nobody did.

The sharpest was Eithne nic Ailein, a daughter of the king, some nineteen hundred years old, small and quick, who had brought her own knot-keeper with her and set him on the step beside Sine to count the count after her. On the fourth day he told Eithne that Sine had made no mistake, and Eithne sent him home.

The one who laughed was Niall Òg. He was a grandson of the king, and at nine hundred years he was a boy beside his uncles and aunts; so they called him the Young, and he never got rid of it. He gave his line through his mother and then through his father, and when Sine looked up at the second he grinned and said, "I'm owed twice," and she tied the knot once.

The youngest to be knotted was a child in arms, a great-great-grandchild of the king, whose mother held it up in both hands to be seen.

Not every line came. The line of Somhairle, who had lived among Clann na Ceiste<sup>4</sup> and died long before his father, held no share of the hill and sent no one to claim. One of that line, Gille-Bride, came up to Dùn ìseal for the Binding and was there when the flame was sworn; and he carried a coal of it home to the hills and asked for nothing, and no knot was tied for him.

The cord took eleven days. At the end it held seven hundred and twelve knots, and it was laid out down the whole length of the gathering-house floor, from the hearth to the door and back, and the heirs walked along it in their good cloaks, looking for their own knots and counting the knots on either side.

## II

### Of the Binding of the First Flame

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3. the Gathering of the Heirs

4. the Children of the Question

**U**nder the king the hill-folk of Dia-thìr had burned the coloured coal by the handful and shared their grain before the storms, and at every gathering they said that they had always been on the island and had come from nowhere. Nine keepers, one drawn by lot for each district of the hills, watched the slab over the crack at Tobar dhìreach. All of it was custom. The king's word was the only law, and the king was dead.

So the first quarrel of the heirs was over the hill of Dùn ìseal, and it came before any other, because the hill stands over the vein. The king had held it in his own hand at the last, and had given it to no one. Every line in the gathering-house claimed it, and each by a different rule.

Murchadh Mòr claimed it by the rule of the eldest. Eithne nic Ailein rose and said that the eldest had only to die for the hill to be parted among his eleven sons, and that she for one would sooner not live to see it; and Murchadh said that she was not likely to, and there was nearly blood on the floor of the gathering-house on the first day. Others claimed the hill by the rule of the living, who were children of the king, over the dead, whose lines were only grandchildren; and the lines of the dead answered that the king had loved their fathers as well as anyone. A cousin from the western shore, whose name the tellers have let go, stood up and said that the hill could be cut like any other ground. Give each of the great lines a gallery, he said, and let each dig its own.

The nine keepers of the slab were sitting at the back of the house on a bench of their own. The eldest of them got up then. He was older than any keeper had been before him, and younger than the youngest of the king's sons.

"Cut the vein, and it bleeds," he said. "You will be parting it for as long as there is any of it left to part, and then you will part the hole."

Then he asked them what the keepers had asked Catriona Mhòr, and what she had told them to ask again: that the keepers' charge be declared before the whole gathering. He asked more than that. He asked that the vein and the hill over it be put into no share at all, and that no one of the king's blood hold it.

The heirs were quiet for a long while. Then Eithne nic Ailein laughed, and said that she would sooner nobody had it than Murchadh. Murchadh said that he would sooner nobody had it than Eithne. So it went down the house, line by line, each of them willing to give the thing away sooner than see a cousin get it; and the tellers of Dùn ìseal, who love the Binding, admit that this is how it was won.

The Holy Age, which opened at the ford, takes its name from that oath. On 23 an t-Sultain, FE 1, three weeks after the king fell there, a custodianship was de-

clared over the vein beneath the central mountains, and that swearing is called the Binding of the First Flame. The heirs swore it first of all, before they had agreed on anything else, and it was the one oath all seven hundred and twelve of them could take.

The flame bound that day was Brìde's undying flame. The tellers of the Mason's line hold that it was first kindled from the mason's fire, which the lightning lit in the broken vein at the beginning of the count; but they keep the two apart, as the Keepers did. The mason's fire is the first fire, and the First Flame is the flame that was sworn to. The vein and the slab over it were given to Crom Cruaich, the bent one of the mound, whose price is measured. The Keepers of the flame took both into their keeping, and they were a faith and a government at once, the first such thing on Dia-thìr that no one of the king's blood could hold, and it stood for centuries before any rìgh rose again in the lowlands. Through all the parting and the strife that came after, it was the one thing on the island that every share had sworn to. Whoever came after to rule the roads and harbours ruled beside it and never over it, for as long as the age lasted.

### III

## Of the Parting of the Kingdom

**W**ith the hill out of the reckoning the heirs turned to the rest, and they sat on at Dùn Ìseal to part it (Ì3 an Dàmhair, FE 1). They sat through that winter and the summer after it, and the tellers say that the grass of the valley did not grow back for three years where their tents had stood.

Four rules were put before them, and each rule had a hundred heirs behind it. By the rule of the eldest the kingdom went to Murchadh Mòr, and the rest could be his men. By the rule of the living every living child of the king took an equal share, and there were more than a score of them. By the rule of the dead every child of the king who had ever lived took a share, living or not, to be held by their lines; and the dead children of the king outnumbered the living, for he had been having children for four thousand years. And by the rule of the lot, which only the youngest heirs wanted, the whole island was to be parted into seven hundred and twelve pieces and drawn for.

What they agreed at last was all four rules at once, and no one ever pretended it was simple. The kingdom was cut into nine great shares, *earrannan mòra*, one



for each of the nine eldest lines of the king's blood that had living heirs to hold them. Out of all nine a part was set aside for the lines of the dead, and it was called *cuid nam marbh*, the portion of the dead; so every great share owed land to cousins who were not its own. The Red Share of Íomhar Dearg was let stand, over the protest of four lines, because nobody could see how to take it from him. And by a clause that every heir swore to with some private reservation, none of them should be called rígh. There had been one rígh, and none of them was fit to follow him, and each of them was sure that the others were less fit still.

Then there was the matter of who among the seven hundred and twelve belonged to which of the nine. It was settled with Síne nan Snaidhm's cord.

Niall Òg was there, and in later centuries he told it often, to anyone who would sit with him.

They had laid the cord along the floor of the gathering-house again, he said, from the hearth to the door, and the heads of the nine lines were to cut it into nine lengths, each length with the knots of the heirs who would hold under that share. It was the night of the handful, the dark of the year, and every hearth in the hills was burning its measure at once, and the gathering-house was so full of smoke and people that he could hardly see the floor. Each of the nine had a knife. Each of the nine walked the cord first, bent over with a lamp, counting, and then walked it again. The rest of them stood along the walls and watched their own knots.

Murchadh Mòr cut first, and he cut where he meant to. After him it went worse. Eithne nic Ailein knelt a long time over the place she wanted, and when she cut, her knife went through a knot. The house went quiet. Somebody asked whose knot it was, and it was a cousin of Niall's, a woman of the salt shore, who stood by the wall with her hand over her mouth. Was she Eithne's, or was she the next share's? Eithne said she was hers. The head of the next share said she was his. The woman said she would take both, if they would let her.

"And that," said Niall Òg, when he told it, "is where the whole of the trouble came from. There were eleven knots cut through before the night was done. I watched every one. I'd have given a year of my life to be one of them, and I've a good many years."

Eleven heirs, cut through, were heirs of two shares and owed oaths to two lords. Theirs were the first double oaths on Dia-thìr, and they were not the last.

On 1 an t-Samhain, FE 2, the night of the handful, the heirs swore the parting of the kingdom, *Roinn na Rìoghachd*<sup>1</sup>. Murchadh Mòr took the great share of the north, with his seat at Baile Mòr mhòr. Eithne nic Ailein took the lowland plain about Cathair mhòr. The western share had its seat at Ros dhomhain on the harbour, and the share of the salt shore at Baile ghorm. The tellers name the rest each in a different order, and they are not agreed on which share had Dùn chrom in the middle of the island, or which had Dùn thais, which is a fair picture of how it was.

The Red Hill was the worst of it. Its holders had bent the knee to the king himself and to no one else, and never to Dùn ìseal. Now its holder stood up in the gathering-house and said that the Red Hill had sworn to Ailean Mòr, and Ailean Mòr was dead, and so the Red Hill was sworn to nobody. Three of the great shares claimed it that same evening. It stayed sworn to three and served none, and it dwindled, as a thing does that everyone claims and nobody keeps.

The great shares were only the beginning. Every holder of a great share had children, and grandchildren, and the lesser blood of the portion of the dead to fit in, and so each share was parted again, and its parts parted again, before the heirs had gone home from the valley (25 am Màrt, FE 4). The great shares were cut into countries, the countries into provinces, the provinces into counties, and the counties into holdings. Some of the countries were held as free states that owed their great share nothing but its name, and every holding under them was some greater holder's vassal, and many were two holders'; and under every holding there were households who had never asked to be anybody's and now found that they were three people's. The clerks of the Hall, who kept the roll of what the heirs had sworn, counted nine great shares, forty-four countries and a hundred and thirty-one provinces. At the counties they gave up. A mill on the Abhainn dhomhain paid a sack of meal to one lord and its pond to another, and its miller was sworn to a third, and the three of them met in the mill-yard every autumn to quarrel over the eels.

The boundaries were marked with stones, *clachan-crìche*, cut with the sign of each share on the face that looked into it. They were set up, and moved in the night, and set up again, and moved again, until the carriers learned to walk a road by the stones and to take no notice of what was cut on them.

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1. the Division; lit. 'the parting of the kingdom'

IV

## Of the First Blood and the Strife of the Heirs

ùn thais stands on its hill north of Dùn dhearg, the first fort the Dia-thìrich ever banked away from Dùn ìseal and the Red Hill. At the Roinn the knives on the cord put it on the line between the great share of the north and the Red Share of Ìomhar Dearg, and nobody could say on which side of the line it fell. The men who set the stones set one on each side of the bank. Neither share would let the other's stone stand.

Ruairidh Glas was a grandson of Ìomhar Dearg, some three hundred years old, and on 17 an Giblean, FE 3, he came up to Dùn thais in the rain with twenty men to drive the cattle off the northern slope, which his grandfather said was theirs. Aonghas Bàn mac Mhurchaidh, a grandson of Murchadh Mòr, was on the bank above with twenty men of his own to see that nobody did.

It was a small, cold, stupid fight, and Ruairidh Glas remembered all of it. He remembered the cattle bawling and the mud over the tops of his shoes. He remembered Aonghas Bàn coming down the bank at him with a stick, a herding-stick, shouting that the stone was on the wrong side; and he remembered that his own spear was already up, because he had been afraid of the men on the bank, and that Aonghas ran onto it.

He knelt by him in the mud afterward. Aonghas Bàn was four hundred years old, and he had the face of a man of thirty, and by the long years of his line he had perhaps a thousand more to come. Ruairidh Glas said so, over and over, to the men who came to lift him. "I have killed a thousand years," he said. They took him home. He lived a long time after that, and he did not come back to Dùn thais.

With that death began *Aimbreit nan Oighbrean*<sup>1</sup>, the strife of the heirs. It was a feud first between the line of Murchadh and the line of Ìomhar, and then, as the lines married and quarrelled and married again, between nearly every line of the king's blood and some other.

It was a strange kind of strife, and the tellers have never found another like it. Among other peoples a feud outlives the men who began it. Among the heirs of Ailean the men who began it lived on, sometimes for a thousand years, and remembered every word. A grandson of the king who had been insulted at a wed-

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1. the Strife of the Heirs

ding could carry the insult for four centuries and take it to the wedding of the insulter's great-grandchild. An heir killed in a feud was a loss beyond counting, for he took with him all the centuries he would have lived; so the kin fought seldom, and they fought bitterly, and they never forgot. And there were more heirs every generation, living shorter lives, which gave them less time to hate one another in and did not make them hate one another less.

The worse trouble was that the Roinn was never finished. At every death of a holder the share was parted again among the heirs, smaller, and every parting was a new quarrel. Murchadh Mòr died in the Hall's first century, close on three thousand years old, and his great share of the north was cut among his eleven sons, and then among their sons, until the north was a floor of counties that could none of them raise twenty spears. Ìomhar Dearg did not wait for age. He was killed by a cousin's spear at a ford in the Hall's second century, one more child of the king to die as Iain Dubh had died, and the Red Share passed whole to his eldest, because nobody in that line would let it be cut. The tellers say that this was the only wise thing the line of Ìomhar ever did, and that it did it for the wrong reasons.

In all of it the Hall at Dùn ìseal took no side. The Keepers fed no warband and blessed no raid. The Binding held in every share alike: the same handful was burned in the north and in the Red Share, and a household sworn to three lords burned it once. The ground of the Hall was the one place on the island no feud could follow a man to, and heirs who had not spoken for two hundred years would stand side by side in the valley at Samhain and not look at one another. So in the years of the strife the Hall was the one thing that every share still held in common, and it grew great on that.

Under the lords the households went on as households do. They cut the coal at the measure, and carried it, and burned it, and paid their dues to whichever lord came for them first, and their neighbours paid the other one. The tellers of Dùn ìseal, when they have finished with the heirs, like to say that the island was never so well governed as when all its governors were busy with each other.

## V

### Of Beathag Bhàn and the First Keepers

**A** flame that no heir might hold still wanted a hand to hold it. The heirs had sworn the Binding in the first weeks; they found a Keeper only when the

Roinn was sworn and its first blood shed, and the choosing came at Dùn ìseal under the mountain, on 28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 4.

Beathag Bhàn stood at the back of the crowd, with the mud of the path still wet on her shins. A wind came down off the high passes and tugged at every cloak on the slope. The keepers of the slab sat on stones in a half-ring, and behind them stood the households who had sworn the Binding, smelling of wet wool and peat-smoke and the coal-dust that never quite washes out of a hill-woman's hands. Further up the slope, in their good cloaks and a little apart from one another, stood the heirs who had sworn it first.

Someone spoke her name. Then the crowd parted, as barley parts when a hare runs through it, and she found herself walking down the lane it made. The eldest of the keepers held out a lit rush in his cupped hands, as a man holds water he is afraid to spill.

"Hold it for Brìde," he said. "And answer to Crom for what is taken from the vein."

She took the rush. It stank of tallow, and the little flame leaned away from the wind toward the mountain. She found she had nothing to say, so she said nothing; and the Keepers after her counted that silence in her favour.

Of what she had been before that morning, nothing is kept, except that she was of no heir's blood and held no share, and could be claimed by no line in the valley. The tellers of Dùn ìseal say that the heirs let her be chosen for that reason and for no other, and that it was the best reason they ever had. The Keepers' recited roll begins with her name, and no name stands before it. The tellers mistrust a roll that begins so bare, but they have found nothing to set against this one.

Nine households round the mountain's foot, one for each district of the old keepers of the slab, took the tending of the flame by turns, each sending a son or a daughter to sit with it through a season. These were the nine hearths, and in time more houses claimed descent from them than nine hearths could ever have bred. Over the flame they raised Talla na Lasrach<sup>1</sup>, the Hall of the Flame, of dry stone and turf, with one door facing the vein and none facing the sea. Brìde's flame burned within; Crom's stone lay under the mountain beyond the door. Many times the Hall was rebuilt on the same footings, and the footings are all that anyone can now swear to.

Beside the Binding, and older at the root, the hearths kept a reverence of their own, and in those years it took a name: Seann Spioradan nan Dia-thìreach<sup>2</sup>, the

Old Spirits. It honoured the ancestors, the síth of the hills and mounds, the vein, and the weather that ruled the mining season. It had no priests and wanted none. Its watchers on the cairns above Cnoc ghlas read the cloud on the high passes to tell the Hall when the galleries might open, and they were chosen with more care than the Keeper was.

The first Keepers ruled mostly by forbidding. No fire might be lit where the hills of Doire uaine could see it, in obedience to the old inscriptions there, and nobody has ever owned to breaking the ban.

Once Beathag Bhàn walked to Làrach an Teampaill<sup>3</sup>, the ruined temple of the Old Ones. She went in alone, the tellers say, with the wind crying in the broken stones, and found the altar already turned toward the mountain. When she came out she said that the place was neither Brìde's nor Crom's, and not the Hall's to keep. No Keeper set foot inside it for the rest of the age. Whose it was, she did not say, and it seems she did not know.

She died at Dùn ìseal, and they laid her on the slope with her face to the vein and her back to the sea, though it is over the sea, in Taigh Dhuinn<sup>4</sup>, that the dead are gone. The nine hearths chose her sister's son, Muireach Liath, to keep the flame after her.

## VI

### Of Muireach Liath and the Silver

*At Muileann chiar, when a crucible is set on the coals, the old smiths tell this while they wait for the metal to run.*

Muireach Liath, they say, fixed the first common measure of coal: a lidded basket of plaited heather, one to a household, filled once in the season. Yet the smiths remember him for two refusals.

The first was over a stream. Allt an Àigh<sup>1</sup> gave fortune, men said, to whoever drank from it in a certain quarter of the moon, and it had become a place of pilgrimage, as it has never wholly ceased to be. Pilgrims wore a path to it from the river landing at Caol shean and walked it by night, to come to the water at the

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1. the Hall of the Flame

3. the temple ruin

4. the house of Donn, where the dead go

1. the stream of the healing water

right hour. Muireach Liath ruled that the stream belonged to the ancestors and the weather, and that the Hall would not keep it, for it had nothing to do with the vein. That was the first parting anyone could see between the Keepers' rite and the older reverence, and both sides later quoted it as proof that they were right. In the same temper the Keepers let the sick be carried to the warm springs below Muileann ruadh and bathed at dawn, since the water's heat came up from the mountain without any hand breaking the stone. The springs were held to be Dian Cècht's, the healer of the gods, and Crom had no claim on them.

The second refusal was over silver, and here the smiths lean closer to the fire.

In the far east, near the great vein yet no part of it, a seam was found at the place called Muileann chiar: the first thing out of the ground on Dia-thìr that was surely not coal. Fearchar Airgeadach, a basket-carrier of the nine hearths, was the first to smelt it and hammer it into rings. He fed his furnace with wood and peat, and the smiths call that the first fire on the island that answered to nobody in the Hall. They say it with some pride.

When the Hall was asked whether the seam fell under the flame, Muireach Liath turned a ring over in his fingers and gave it back, and answered:

*Chan eil fuil san airgead, agus chan ann leis a' bheinn a tha e.* There is no blood in silver, and it is not the mountain's.

Silver shows no colour when broken, and so it was not holy to Crom. The smiths gave their first ring to Goibhniu, the smith of the gods, and the Hall said nothing against it. Muileann chiar was left free to dig as deep as it liked, and it dug. The seam lay in a county of the eastern share that two cousins had claimed since the Roinn, and since the Hall would not take the silver, the cousins went on quarrelling over it; the smiths paid a ring to each of them and dug on. Every later quarrel over the silver began from that sentence. Carriers took the rings down to Ros fhionn and traded them for salt fish and sealskin, the first trade on the island made in anything but food, and the first whose price is remembered. One ring bought a boatload.

Muireach Liath died at Dùn ìseal, keeping the flame. The nine hearths passed over three candidates of other lines and chose his daughter, Gormshuil nic Mhuirich. Her kin came to be called Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>2</sup>, the house of Muireach, the first custodian house known by a name and no longer by a hearth, and the of-

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2. the house of Muireach

fice stayed with them for many generations. The other hearths made no complaint that anyone kept, say the smiths; but then, they add, it was Muireach's own people who did the keeping.

## VII

## Of the Stag and the Stone Cup

**I**n Gormshuil's years a school arose in the east that would spread wider than any order on the island: the first of the druid schools, Scoiltean nan Draoidhean<sup>1</sup>, which the east still calls Feallsanachd an Fhèidh<sup>2</sup>, the Philosophy of the Stag. It began with one stubborn woman. Sileas nic Coinnich, a cutter of Muileann chiar, had seen the coal break bright with its colours under some picks and dull under others, and she would not leave the thing alone. The old tellers said that she had caught the question of the Mason's children, who in the Ancient Age had asked what the seven coals were for. She taught in Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>3</sup>, and her hearers kept her question as she left it:

*Carson a tha an fhèith a' freagairt do làimh seach làimh eile?* Why does the vein answer one hand and not another?

Until then the Dia-thìrich had revered the coal. Sileas was the first to reason about it. Her hearers took their name from a stag said to have stood in the grove through a whole lesson, the white stag of Flidais, lady of the deer and the wild, whose wood it was.

The Hall did not welcome the question. Gormshuil forbade Sileas's hearers to cut in the galleries of Dùn ìseal, holding that a question asked of the vein is a demand made of it, and for a long while after, the stag's people kept to the east and sent no cutters to the mountain.

Then a death made the next law. In a hard year a household at Cnoc dhubh burned its coal by the basketful. The smoke lay down in the valley like a sick dog and would not lift, and three of that household died of it, and two of their neighbours. The case was argued at Dùn ìseal for the rest of the season.

The Keeper who ended it was Fionnlagh Dall, Fionnlagh the Blind.

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1. the druid schools

2. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

3. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood



He came into the Hall on the arm of a boy and found the threshold with his foot. The council had been shouting since morning and their voices were hoarse. He could smell the peat on their clothes and the wet dogs by the door, and under it all the thin hot scent of Bride's flame at his back. The kin of the dead sat on his left. He knew where they were by their silence.

He had brought the old keepers' stone cup, a thing of the Age of Ailean, recut in grey stone to hold exactly what a pair of cupped hands will hold. He set it on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach<sup>4</sup>, knelt, and laid his palm across its mouth.

"Give me the coal," he said.

They poured it for him, a little at a time. He did not know whose hand poured, and he did not ask. When the black grains rose to touch his palm, level with the rim, he said, "Enough," and took his hand away and let them look. No one afterward could say he had favoured anyone's hands.

On 13 an Lùnastal, FE 142, the custom hardened into the Small-Burning Law: no household might burn more than a measured handful of coal in a season. It held for centuries. It was the first law that ran in every share alike, and no lord of any share had made it; the lords grumbled at it, and burned their handful like everyone else.

Its first sentence fell on a household of Seann Tarr that had burned twice its measure. It lost its right for the season after, and its name went on the roll with the offence beside it. Its descendants petitioned for many centuries to have the offence struck out, and never won, and the offence is the only reason anyone remembers them.

The Keepers carried the Law to the coasts. No coal, they ruled, might feed a beacon, since a beacon burns for strangers:

*Cha loisc clach na beinne do choigrich.* The mountain's stone will not burn for strangers.

So the fire on the headland at Tobar dhearg was kept with driftwood and seal fat, and so were the other sea-lights of the island.

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4. the Hall of the Flame

## VIII

## Of the Roads, the Bridges and the Road-Peace

*This is how the carriers tell it at the long table of the house that is now Am Buabhall Fortanach, while the jugged buffalo sits on the fire.*

The Law made the Hall a giver-out of coal, they say, and what is given out must be carried. So the island's roads grew along the carriers' tracks, down stepped paths such as the one to Ceann chaol. The rivers took their toll. One night the Abhainn dhomhain rose at a ford and swallowed eleven carriers with their baskets. The Hall mourned the coal as well as the men, and the carriers will tell you, if you let them, that the Hall's roll names the coal first. Fionnlagh Dall asked the council for a crossing the river could not take, and stone bridges began to join the mining paths to the coast.

Above Ros fhionn, Ailean Clachair and forty masons of the nine hearths threw a single span of fitted stone over the river, and Ailean cut a hearth-sign in the keystone. Every later bridge carried one, and a carrier would sooner wade than trust a bridge without it. The masons swore an oath on the stone cup: no span to be closed in the dark, and none to be paid for in coal. They kept their lodge near the western crossing, in the country of Ros dhomhain.

Houses grew along the roads to feed the people on them, the forebears of Am Buabhall Fortanach, An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>1</sup> and the rest of the circuit. The carriers always begin with this one. Its first keeper was Mòr nic Dhùghaill, a widow of Doire shean, who served carriers jugged buffalo from her own herd, and here the carriers bang the table, for the house serves it still. Where An Taigh-seinnse Mòr stands there was then a turf longhouse with a hearth at each end, one for carriers going up and one for carriers coming down.

The roads ran from share to share, and a carrier on them might pass a dozen boundary stones in a day, and the feuds of every lord whose stones they were. So the keepers of the houses made a law of their own: no feud might be pursued under an inn roof, nor within a spear's throw of its door. It was first kept at the house where An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>2</sup> now stands, and it is the oldest law on the island that neither Keeper nor lord made. It was made against the strife of the heirs, and heirs who would not speak to one another in the valley at Samhain sat at the

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1. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

2. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

same long table under that roof, and did not speak there either. The carriers put it plainly:

*Fo mbullach an taighe, chan eil nàmh ann.* Under the roof of the house,  
there is no enemy.

The roads carried settlers too, to coasts that had names already. Fishers of the nine hearths settled the harbour of Seann Mhorn and kept its name, which is in no tongue of theirs, saying that the name came with the stones; it was the first such name to be kept. Families walking the new road resettled Seann Warr on the western shore of Loch chrom in the same way, and built on the house-footings they found in the grass. At this point the whole table sings:

*Thog sinn air na clachan, is cha do dh'fhaighnich sinn cò leis.* We built upon  
the stones, and did not ask whose.

Fionnlagh Dall died at Dùn ìseal. At his own asking he was not laid on the slope with the Keepers before him. He was carried south to the old graves near Cnoc dhìreach, which no house or share had ever claimed, and his bearers took eleven days over the road and laid him among graves older than any name. Why he asked it, the Keepers after him gave two answers and would not choose between them, and the carriers do not choose either. So Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>3</sup>, ancient already, received its first burial that anyone set down, and a graveyard that no one owned became one that somebody did. More families settled nearby to tend it, and the Hall paid them one handful of coal each a season. It was the only payment in coal the Law ever allowed, and the carriers, who carried every other handful on the island, find that fitting.

## I X

### Of the Four Houses and the Reverent Centuries

**I**n time the nine hearths chose a Keeper from outside the house of Muireach: Eilidh nic Ìomhair of Dùn dhearg. She was of the line of Ìomhar Dearg, and so of the king's blood, and the Binding had sworn the flame to no one of the blood. Her friends answered that by then there was hardly a household in the hills

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3. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

without a drop of the king in it somewhere, which was true, and changed nothing. Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>1</sup> refused her for a season, and then accepted her on one condition, that the stone cup never leave Talla na Lasrach<sup>2</sup>. It never did.

Under Eilidh the office was bound to four houses of custody: Sliochd Mhuirich of Dùn ìseal, Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>3</sup> of Dùn dhearg, Sliochd Thormoid<sup>4</sup> of Seann Dunn, and Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>5</sup> of Seann Tarr. The other hearths kept their council seats but lost their claim to the flame. Sliochd Thormoid claimed for its root Tormod Liath, who had held the hill under the king, and Sliochd Raghnaill claimed Raghnaill Ceannfhionn; so three of the four were of the blood, or said they were, and only the house of Muireach was not. Most of the great families of the age came down from one of the four, or said they did, and from here onward the tale of the age is largely theirs.

Sliochd Thormoid raised a hall and a shrine at Seann Dunn, facing the mountain across the river. Its coal-lamp burned at the Law's measure, and the other houses grumbled that Seann Dunn's measure was always the fullest. Sliochd Raghnaill made its seat at Seann Tarr, the very town first sentenced under the Law, kept boats where the others kept galleries, and grew rich on fish. Its boats sailed round Eilean dhubh and came home, the first voyage ever made only to look at a coast.

Not everyone lived inside the Law. Households stripped of their right for a third offence took to boats and raided the north-western strands, and the name spùinneadairean, plunderers, clung to those waters after them. There a boat out of Baile chrom was lost in a flat calm, and the two men who swam home said something had risen under it. The village has kept a wake for it every year since, and it relit the old beacon on the point with driftwood, as the Law required. From that fire comes Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>6</sup>.

Fishers resettled Seann Bhrenn, kept its old name, and used the stone quay they found under the silt. At Cathair naomh a cairn for the dead was begun that is growing yet. When the great cats' crossing was found to run over the southern road, Eilidh ruled that no panther might be killed there in its season, and the rule held, for it cost the carriers only time.

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1. the house of Muireach

2. the Hall of the Flame

3. the house of Ìomhar

4. the house of Tormod

5. the house of Raghnaill

6. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

At Dùn dhearg, Sliochd Ìomhair built granaries of stone and filled them from the lowland fields of the Red Share against the storm season, as the old custom of sharing asked. The granaries gave that house something the Hall had never had: people who owed it their bread.

In those days, the reverent centuries, the lords fought over the shares and the households under them went on as before. Each generation mined the same modest measure and burned the same modest measure, whichever lord's stones it lived between, and the number of the people stood still. Shepherds took the uplands at Achadh chaol; their headman sat one season on the council, was found to hold no hearth-right, and went home. Coinneach Mòr mac Tormoid, first Keeper of his house, kept the flame longer than any before him and changed nothing at all. He sent walkers out to list the ruins of the Old Ones, and they came back with Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>7</sup>, Làrach an Dùin<sup>8</sup>, Làrach an Teampaill<sup>9</sup> and the standing stones. Beside each place the list says who does not own it. It does not say who built it, for the Keepers ruled that it should not guess. At Cnoc bheag the people fenced the old obelisk with stakes against the cattle, and every generation since has renewed the fence. Over the springs at Muileann ruadh a bath-house was roofed, and the Hall named a keeper of the springs in Dian Cècht's name, the first office it made that had nothing to do with the coal.

X

## Of the War of the Two Oaths and the Peace of the Threshold

*The reapers of Achadh mhòr tell this at the end of harvest, when the last sheaf is cut, and they cut it high.*

By the Hall's sixth century few were left of the seven hundred and twelve who had stood up at the Roinn. The long years had thinned in every line. The holders of the shares were great-grandchildren of the heirs and further, who lived long lives by any other people's reckoning and short ones by their grandfathers', and the shares had been parted at so many burials that most holdings could not raise a score of spears. The strong were the lines that had kept a share whole, as Ìomhar's had, and the few of the old heirs still living. Among those was Eithne nic Ailein,

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7. the watch-fort ruin

8. the fortress ruin

9. the temple ruin

in her hall at Cathair mhòr, who had cut a knot on the cord and never let anyone forget it.

Between Eithne's plain and the Red Share lay Achadh mhòr, the great granary fields. Its lord in those days was Fearghas, whose grandmother had been one of the eleven knots the knives went through, and who held his fields by oath both to the lord of Dùn dhearg and to Eithne. The island called him Fearghas Dà-Mhionn, Fearghas of the Two Oaths, and for most of his life it was a joke. He sent his sheaves to both lords, a little short to each, and each of them thought the other was getting the full measure.

The joke ended over a marriage. A great-grandson of Eithne took a daughter of the line of Ìomhar to wife, to heal the old feud, and she died in the first winter, and both houses claimed the lands she had brought. Each lord sent to Fearghas to bring his spears against the other. By then there were some hundreds of holdings on the island sworn to two lords, and every one of them had to choose, and the ones that chose were burned by the side they had not chosen, and the ones that would not choose were burned by both. That was *Cogadh an Dà Mhionn*<sup>1</sup>, the War of the Two Oaths, and it went on in fits for some forty years.

Fearghas Dà-Mhionn chose nobody. He was old by the end, and he had seen a good deal of burning.

In the heat of Lùnastal the word came to him that both hosts were on the road, the Red Share's from the east and Cathair mhòr's from the west, each to take his harvest before the other could. The barley was standing ripe to the edge of the sky. He walked out into it in the evening with his steward behind him, and ran his hand over the ears, and looked east, where there was dust on the road, and west, where there was more.

"Whichever I feed, the other burns me," he said. "I've sworn to both of them. Let them both have it."

He took the torch himself. On 24 an Lùnastal, FE 556, the fields of Achadh mhòr burned from the eastern stones to the western, and the two hosts came over the rises at either end and found nothing to take but smoke. The fire went into the steadings and took the hall, and Fearghas with it, for he had gone back inside and shut the door. That winter the middle of the island went hungry, and the rolls of the Hall count the dead of that winter among the dead of the war.

It was the hunger that made the peace, where forty years of burning had not. The lords of the shares came to Dùn ìseal at Samhain. They would not meet in

any hall of their own, for no lord would go under another's roof, and so they met at Talla na Lasrach<sup>2</sup>, on its threshold, where the stone cup stood. Eithne nic Ailein came up the path in a chair, close on two thousand five hundred years old and the last living of the nine who had cut the cord, and she swore first.

On 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556, they swore *Sìth an Stairsnich*<sup>3</sup>, the Peace of the Threshold, with the Keeper for witness. No share was to be parted again at a death: a holding was to pass whole to one heir, named by the dying lord, or, if he named none, by the Keeper. No one was to swear to two lords, and whoever held such an oath that day was to give up one of them before the spring. The boundary stones were to stand where they stood that morning, and whoever moved one after was to answer at Dùn ìseal. So ended *Aimhreit nan Oighrean*<sup>4</sup>, the strife of the heirs, some five hundred and fifty years after the first blood at Dùn thais.

After the Peace the shares no longer shrank. They grew instead, by marriages and by lords dying without heirs, and the map of the island, which had been broken smaller at every burial since the Roinn, began slowly to gather. Many of the stones set that morning stand still, on the bounds of fields and holdings and provinces, and the carriers who walk past them have long ago stopped reading the signs cut on their faces.

## X I

### Of the First Rìgh of the Lowlands and the Division of Keeping

**A**fter Coinneach Mòr the rolls grow fuller, generation by generation, and in them the island can be watched filling out, as a field fills with barley.

The silversmiths of Muileann chiar cast weights from a barley-corn to a newborn lamb, and a thing weighed there was weighed fairly. The stag's people founded a house at Cnoc bhàn, and the Keeper Seonaid Chiar let their cutters back into the galleries on oath to ask nothing of the vein aloud. The Hall called it a reconciliation; the school still calls it a truce. Cathair mhòr built the first town wall on the island and never said what it feared; the reapers of Achadh mhòr say

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1. the War of the Two Oaths

2. the Hall of the Flame

3. the Peace of the Threshold

4. the Strife of the Heirs

that it had not forgotten the smoke. Ceann leathan's harbour-master kept notched tally-sticks, and they were kept after him, the oldest counted things on the island. Inis thais burned its handful on the shore so that the drowned could see it, and the salt of Cuan shean kept the fish of half the island. The sunny house rose where An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>1</sup> stands. A roof fell in the highest gallery and killed four cutters, and Seonaid Chiar propped every gallery with oak.

Carriers founded Cathair dhomhain above the western harbour, proud of keeping the measure strictly. A few miles off, at the bridge-foot on the Abhainn dhomhain below Loch chrom, the Red Hill's old settlement, long shrunk to a fishing town on red stone, began to grow again. In those days Cathair dhearg was a place carriers passed through on the way to somewhere else.

The Peace of the Threshold had stopped the shares from breaking, and after it they began to gather. The first to gather them was of the line of Ìomhar. Goraidh mac Ìomhair, head of Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>2</sup>, held the Red Share whole, as his fathers had; and by the deaths of two cousins without heirs, and by his marriage to a third, he came to hold three of the old counties of the east beside it, parted since the Roinn and now in one hand again (3 an Giblean, FE 674). By the Peace no one could part them at his death.

Then the lowland households who ate from Sliochd Ìomhair's granaries began to call him their rìgh, their king. No one had borne the word since Ailean Mòr. At the Roinn the heirs had sworn that none of them would take it, and in the centuries since, the Line of the Mason had been nearly alone in remembering that the gods had once given it to Ailean in the grove. The heirs of Ailean did not give it to Goraidh. The granaries did.

He went up to Dùn iséal in the spring to meet the council, on foot, as a carrier would.

It was a long climb, and by the time the grey roof of Talla na Lasrach<sup>3</sup> came in sight over the shoulder of the hill his breath was short. He had left his spear with his men at the last house on the road. He had thought about that for three nights. A man who comes to the Hall armed has already said what he wants, and he hoped they would read the other thing in his empty hands.

The council sat outside on the stones before the door, for the day was fine, and the Keeper sat among them with the stone cup at her feet. Goraidh stood be-

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1. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

2. the house of Ìomhar

3. the Hall of the Flame



fore them in his travelling cloak with the wind in his beard, and he said the thing he had come to say before anyone could ask it.

"I claim nothing under the mountain. Not a gallery, not a grain of coal. Let the Hall hear me say it."

The Hall heard him. Then they bargained until the light went.

On 9 an t-Sultain, FE 694, the council at Dùn ìseal and the rìgh agreed the division of keeping. The Keeper kept the flame and the galleries. The rìgh kept the roads, the granaries and the peace of the lowlands. The rìgh might not enter the galleries, and the Keeper might not raise spears. On that division Dia-thìr was ruled for the rest of the age, and most of the age's quarrels were over which side of it a thing lay on.

Goraidh Mòr, as they called him after, built a timber hall at Dùn dhearg with a granary at each corner, and set a toll on the roads of one fish in twenty for the guards and the bridges. The waypoint-keepers collected it and kept a share, and the rolls, to their credit, say so. His daughter was Mòrag nan Rathad, Mòrag of the Roads, who walked every carriers' road on the island with a staff in her hand and had the bad stretches remade. She raised the house where An Taigh-seinnse Òir<sup>4</sup> stands, the first built by a ruler, and widened the western crossing of the Abhainn dhomhain with Ailean Clachair's sign recut in the keystone, and the bridge-foot town began to swell.

Her son Dòmhnall Crùbach, Dòmhnall the Lamé, could not walk the roads, and ruled through the waypoint-keepers, who round Ceann mhin paid him what toll they judged fair. They judged generously to themselves. When a storm took a third of Seann Chwen, the Hall and the rìgh both sent grain, and the survivors remembered that the Hall's came first.

Settlers from Cathair dhomhain founded Baile àrsaidh among the yellow scorpions of the western heath, and swore their oaths on a scorpion's sting kept in a box. Their neighbours found the custom strange.

At Muileann chiar the stag's teachers turned the cutters' tally-notches into signs for sounds, so that a teaching could be kept without a teacher. These stag-letters, the ogham, which the druids say Ogma of the gods first cut, were the first letters of the Dia-thìrich, and every hand of the age came from them. The scholars carried them to Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>5</sup> and held them up beside the marks on the obelisk. They matched nothing. So the scholars wrote that the stone's writers

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<sup>4</sup> the golden house, a waypoint inn

<sup>5</sup> the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

were not their teachers: the first thing the Dia-thìrich ever wrote about the Old Ones, and it tells only what they were not.

Dòmhnall's niece Sileas Dhonn made the waypoint-keepers come to her hall once a year and render account of the tolls. Several of them did.

## XII

### Of the War of the Roads

**C**aol leathan in the south-west grew fat on the western fishing and the southern end of the carriers' road, and its leading family under Lachlann Ciar began to keep the road-toll and send none to Dùn dhearg.

Iain Garbh, Iain the Rough, son of Sileas Dhonn, sent west to demand the tolls. His messenger came back with a covered basket, set it on the floor of the hall, and would not meet his eye. Iain lifted the lid himself. The smell came up first, old and rank. The basket was full of fish-bones, picked clean and packed in rows, as a careful wife packs herring.

He looked at them a long time. Then he laughed, which frightened his household more than shouting would have, and called for the road-guards.

He marched west with the road-guards and the lowland levies and burned the toll-house at Muileann òg that Lachlann Ciar's people had taken, and he watched the thatch go up with his arms folded. It was the first war on the island since the Peace of the Threshold. Every war before it had been fought over a share, and this one was fought over the roads the first rìgh of the lowlands had been made to keep.

The Hall blessed neither side. When Iain's messengers asked at Dùn ìseal for the Hall's handful to light the warband's hearths, the Keeper Uisdean mac Ruairidh sent them back empty, and made them repeat his answer before they went:

*Cha bhlàthaich an lasair fìr a tha a' dol a mbarbhadh.* The flame will not warm men who are going to kill.

"Then we'll burn peat," said Iain. The warband wintered on peat, coughing. So the division of keeping was tried, and it held. The rìgh had the spears and the Keeper had the flame, and neither could take the other's.

At the ford of Àth fhiadhaich the men of Caol leathan stood in the water and held it for a day. Iain went in with the second rank. He remembered afterward the cold that took his legs at the first step, and the noise, and a man of Caol leathan who fought on with a split shield until a spear from behind Iain found him. By evening they had given way. Forty lay dead of the two sides, and the carriers long called it the ford of the forty, and said the Morrìgan's crows were on it before the light went.

Falling back, Lachlann Ciar's men burned Baile ghlas so the levies would find no grain. Iain rode through the warm ashes the next morning and found no one to ask where the people had gone. They had walked to Cathair dhomhain, and many never came back. Baile chlar, south of the bridge-foot, shut its gate against both armies and fed the burned-out people through the winter. Neither side forgave it, and neither side attacked it.

Iain closed Caol leathan by land at the start of winter, but he could not close the harbour. From his camp on the hill he watched the boats slip in at dusk, low in the water with fish. When his levies began going home for the next harvest, first by ones and then by villages, the siege ended without an assault.

The war ended under the carriers' law. Iain Garbh and Lachlann Ciar met under the roof of Mòr nic Dhùghaill's house, where by the road-peace neither could draw. They sat at one board, and Iain saw that his enemy was older than he had thought, and had a cough of his own. They ate the jugged buffalo, and then they talked. Caol leathan kept half its tolls and sent half to Dùn dhearg, and Lachlann Ciar swore to the Law before the Keeper's witness. So the War of the Roads was ended in a house built to feed carriers.

It left three things. Caol leathan's fighters became its road-guards and swore their watch on a white stone carved as a wolf, kept at the town gate, and called themselves the wolf-sworn. Caol fhiadhaich, whose boats had fed the besieged town, was given a share of the western tolls and built a harbour wall with it. And when Iain Garbh died, his daughter Catrìona buried him in the floor of his hall at Dùn dhearg and not on the slope at Dùn ìseal. He had never forgiven the Hall, and the Hall did not ask for him.

Catrìona Ghlic, Catrìona the Wise, mended the breach. She sent her own son to sit with the flame for a season, the first of the royal house to do so since the division, and by the end of her reign the Hall and the hall were speaking again. She had two houses built on the northern road, the second out on the open moor for carriers caught by snow; its keepers were paid in grain by the Hall and in cloth by

the crown, and grumbled at both. Inis mhòr, on the wool trade, outgrew every northern town.

In those years, on 28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,122, Eithne nic Ailein died in her hall at Cathair mhòr, the last of the nine who had cut the cord at the Roinn. She had been born in the height of her father's days, and she had outlived nearly every heir who stood up in the gathering-house and all the feuds they made. The rolls of Cathair mhòr give her the old formula, as the reciters give it to the king's children: and all the days of Eithne were three thousand and twenty-one years, and she died. After her the great shares were names on the boundary stones, and the long years went on thinning in the king's kin, generation by generation, until there was no telling his blood from anyone else's by the length of its life.

### XIII

## Of the Letters, the Woods and the Measuring of the Vein

*The scholars of Muileann chaol count the clerk at the start of this chapter their first forebear, and they tell it with the care of heirs.*

After Catrìona Ghlic the king-list gives eleven names at Dùn dhearg and nothing more, and the Keepers' roll five names and nothing more. A clerk broke that silence. Tormod mac Iain, a younger son of the house of Tormod, learned the stag-letters at Muileann chiar, the first of the royal kin to read, and was called Tormod Scriobhaiche, Tormod the Writer. Ealasaid Chiar bade him write down every ruler the reciters could name, in order. That was the first written king-list, and from then on rulers were kept by name and no longer only by story. His roll runs from Goraìdh Mòr to Ealasaid Chiar. He marked which names came from the reciters and which from living memory, and in three places where it disagreed with the Keepers' roll he wrote both readings and would not choose. For that above all the scholars love him.

The Hall, shamed (in its own words) by the rìgh's clerk, had its recited roll written down at Dùn ìseal. It begins with Beathag Bhàn and is several centuries longer than Tormod's.

In the west a company settled at the edge of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>1</sup>, the uncleared wood, to watch for a black horned beast they said walked in it. They

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1. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

were the wood-watchers. They came east and cut a black-barked tree in the stag's grove, saying the beast had shown it to them. The stag's people called it theft and sent teachers to hold lessons in the dark wood, saying the first stag had come from there. In each wood the two companies met under the trees and did not speak. It was the first quarrel on Dia-thìr between rival holy claims, and it was settled by sharing the keeping, with no winner named. Before Fearchar Òg, rìgh after Eala-said Chiar, and the Keeper Calum Liath, the stag's people took the eastern wood and the wood-watchers the western, each free to walk the other's unarmed and without cutting. Two of the boundary stones, cut in stag-letters, stand yet.

Calum Liath then sent cutters with knotted cords and lamps into every gallery to follow the vein and mark where it thickened and thinned. The work took several coal-seasons, and the households went short to pay for it. It was the first attempt to measure how much coal the mountain held. The sum, cut on a slab in the Hall, found that the mountain could give every household its handful for more generations than there were grains in the granaries of Dùn dhearg. It was read to the council and heard in silence, which the Hall took for assent. The slab stood in the Hall after, for any who could read the stag-letters.

Two youths sent into the lower gallery without a Keeper's cutter broke the wrong face and were crushed. Their families asked what the Hall owed them, and the council had no answer. Out of that grief came the apprentice-binding: young Dia-thìrich were bound to a master custodian for seven years before they might touch the coal. Oighrig Bhàn, Keeper after Calum Liath, bound the first twelve on the stone cup, and four of them lived to be Keepers, which is the custom's best argument. The stag's house at Cnoc bhàn took up the seven years and added a written account of every strike. These strike-books became the school's chief record, and in time they asked a question of their own.

Fearchar Òg reigned long and is remembered mostly for dying old. His clerks paid the road-guards in stamped silver rings, the first payment in metal by any ruler, and the rings travelled further than the guards did. The southern guards began meeting at Ceann leathan each year to fight with blunted staves for a ring, and the meeting outlived its purpose. The first winner whose name is kept was a woman, Mòrag Dhubh of Cnoc mhòr. Burned Muileann òg was built again, and it held a harvest fair at Lùnastal, the feast of Lugh. At Cidhe Beag on the Abhainn uaine a landing was built for river-boats over the carriers' protest, and the hide boatmen of Muileann chrom swore their fellowship on a paddle.

## XIV

## Of the Red Hall and the Census of Hands

**B**eathag Mhòr, great-granddaughter of Fearchar Òg, is the first ruler the list calls ban-rìgh, queen, and the change of word is the list's own. On 10 an Gearran, FE 1,699, she moved her hall from Dùn dhearg to the town at the western bridge-foot, Cathair dhearg, where the roads, the river and the western harbours met. It has been the seat of rule on Dia-thìr ever since. Her hall was built of the town's red stone on the rise above the harbour. The masons cut the hearth-sign in its lintel as if it were a bridge.

Dùn dhearg kept its granaries, the graves of the house of Ìomhar, and its pride. Cathair dhomhain, older and larger, refused the queen's toll on its boats and was granted a charter of its own, and the two towns, a few miles apart, stayed rivals for the rest of the age.

By then the council at Dùn ìseal heard more quarrels over the right to the handful than over anything else: new households, divided households, and claims of descent from the nine hearths without proof. The Keeper Dùghall mac Raghnaill asked the queen for a count, with the clerks to write and the Keepers to judge. The counters worked from the waypoint houses, since every household lay within a day of one, and the houses, feeding them at the queen's cost, remember it as a good year.

The census of hands was completed on 22 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,735, the first island-wide count of the households holding the right to burn the coal, and proof that the reverent custom was already being rationed. The rolls gave eleven thousand four hundred households holding the right and about two thousand refused. The refused went on a roll of their own, and from then on it was that roll that families searched when they wished to prove an ancestor's standing. Many of the refused were fisher-families round Seann Tarr who had never burned coal and now had no right to begin. Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>1</sup> argued their case and lost. The fishers burned peat, and said it was warmer.

Beathag Mhòr was carried back at her own order to lie at Dùn dhearg among the house of Ìomhar, the longest royal journey yet made. Her son Ruairidh Liath was already grey when he took the hall, and his byname is the only joke the list makes. He demanded one silver ring in five from Muileann chiar. Sliochd Fhear-

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1. the house of Raghnaill

chair, the silversmiths' house, quoted Muireach Liath back to him, that silver is not holy and so not the crown's either, and shut the workings. For three seasons no silver left Muileann chiar. It is called the Silver Feud, though no one died in it. At last both sides went up to Dùn ìseal and asked the Keeper to judge.

Dùghall mac Raghnaill heard them in the Hall on a raw day, with the door shut against the rain. The smiths had sent an old woman of Sliochd Fhearchair to speak for them. She said Muireach Liath's sentence, and then said it again, slowly, as though the Hall might have forgotten it. The queen's man stood across the hearth and talked of roads and bridges and guards unpaid since Samhain.

Dùghall let them both run dry. Each of them was right, he said afterward, and that is the worst quarrel a judge can be handed.

"Muireach Liath's words stand," he said at last. "Silver is not the mountain's." The old woman nodded as if she had known it all along. "But the crown keeps the roads," Dùghall went on, "and the silver walks on them."

The crown took one ring in ten, the workings reopened, and both sides went home calling it a victory. The Muileann chiar weights were made the only lawful weights on the roads, cast in bronze at Muileann dhearg for every waypoint house.

Ruairidh Liath's granddaughter Seonag Chrom gave the clerks a room in the red hall, and from her reign the king-list was kept year by year. At Inis bheag a stag-teacher taught letters to fishers' children, and the Hall's roll remarked that fish do not need reading. In the red hall Peigi nic Tormoid, of Tormod Scrìobhaiche's line, became the first clerk whose hand can be told from the others, and much of what is known of the middle of the age is in her hand or copied from it.

## XV

### Of the Hawk, the Cup, the Wolf and the Two Schools

**I**n the later centuries of the age the one practice of the Dia-thìrich began to come apart, in each place for its own reason.

At Seann Skell on the northern coast every fowler household kept a hawk and fed it before the family ate. They burned their handful at dawn with the hawk on the wrist, saying that the flame is a hunger and should be fed as a hunger is fed. They called the hawk Mòd, and said it was the Hawk of Acaill, the grey hawk of time, as old as Fionntan mac Bòchra, eldest of men, who lived through

the long ages as a salmon, an eagle and a hawk; and that between the two of them they remember everything. The dawn-burning spread up the Abhainn ìseal to Inis ìseal and Cnoc bheag. The Keeper wrote that since it kept the measure exactly, it was no concern of the Hall's, and that was the last time the Hall said so of any rite. In the west the sting-oath went up the coast from Baile àrsaidh to Ros bheag, where the harbour court took it for every oath of trade, and a merchant who would not swear on the sting was trusted by no one. The wolf-sworn set a second white wolf-stone at the shrine of Inis thais, sledged from the mountain at more cost than the shrine, and its keepers began to pray before it as well as to the drowned.

The stag's people split as well.

At Cnoc bhàn, Donnchadh mac Iain sat up a whole winter with the strike-books, generations of them stacked along the wall higher than his head. He read by a lamp kept at the Law's measure, with a blanket round his shoulders and his breath smoking, and he began, without quite meaning to, to keep a tally on a slate. One night near midwinter he read back down the slate and sat very still. The coal broke brighter in its colours for cutters grown old at the work than for the same cutters young, whatever house they came from.

He took it to the elders in the morning. They heard him out in the cold room, and when he had finished the eldest folded her hands.

"The vein answers to what a cutter is born with," she said. "Practice only shows it."

"Then why does it show more every year?"

She did not answer, and he saw in their faces that the matter was closed. So he left with twenty-two hearers and copies of the strike-books wrapped in oiled hide on their backs, and settled at Muileann chaol. The elders called it theft. Donnchadh called it copying, which it was.

That was the second school of Feallsanachd an Fhèidh<sup>1</sup>. It held that the vein answers to effort, and it wrote no cutter's parentage in its books at all. The two schools argued by letter for the rest of the age, and both kept the letters.

The Keeper Raonaid Dhubh heard both druid schools at Dùn ìseal and gave no ruling:

*Cha do dh'iarr an fhèith oirnn breith a thoirt.* The vein has not asked us to give judgement.

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1. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name



No refusal in the Hall's history was quoted more often.

Once more the Old Ones stepped into the tale, as a question. Scholars from Muileann chaol could not read the pillar at Cnoc ghorm, and the people of Cnoc ghorm told them it said *Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann*: we did not come; we were here. The scholars wrote that the people said so, and there the matter has rested. Men of Baile ghorm dug under Làrach an Dùin<sup>2</sup> for its rumoured riches and found only ash. The Keeper sentenced them as lawbreakers though no law covered the case, and the sentence became the rule for every old place after. The diggers' families did their penance by keeping the road to Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>3</sup> in repair, and it is still called the diggers' road.

## XVI

### Of the Shared Meal and the Lean Year

*At Àth dhìreach, high in the mountain country, they tell this at the turn of the year, and set out an extra bowl for the carriers.*

Lachlann Bàn built granaries in every province seat that would take one. With the Keeper Raonaid Dhubh he wrote the island's oldest custom into law at Cath-air dhearg: a household with grain beyond its winter's need was to give the surplus to its district's common granary before the storm season, and the granary would feed any household of the district that ran short. It was the first law made by rìgh and Keeper together. Cnoc mhòr built its granary first, and its reeve was sent a silver ring. Granaries went up in the mountain districts round Muileann chial, where people lived by cutting and carrying, and the lowlands grumbled at filling them.

Lachlann's daughter Oighrig nic Lachlainn had no children, and the houses began counting their claims before her reign was half over. Early in that reign the weather tried the law. The watchers above Cnoc ghlas looked up in spring and saw snow on the high passes, and looked again a month later and saw it still, white in the sun, long after the galleries should have opened. The Hall kept them shut. When they did open, they opened late and closed early, and a third of a common season's coal came down. The mountain households of Muileann gheal, Doire

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2. the fortress ruin

3. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

uaine and Àth dhìreach, who traded their carrying for grain, had nothing to trade, and by the following autumn they were eating their seed.

On 4 an Dàmhair, FE 2,473, the first famine on Dia-thìr was turned back. The shared-meal law held. The mountain granaries were opened at Muileann gheal, and when they ran low the granaries of Dùn dhearg and the southern coast sent grain up the carriers' roads without needing to be asked twice. The carriers took no fee. No one in the three settlements is known to have died of hunger that winter. Àth dhìreach gave the carriers who had brought the grain the right to rest in any house of the town for as long as they lived. The last of them died old, and the right died with him, and his is the bowl they still set out.

The reeves of Dùn dhearg, who had refused Cathair dhearg their accounts for generations, opened the old granaries of the house of Ìomhar without waiting for an order. The queen wrote that she would have given the order had they waited. The clerk wrote beneath it that they had not waited. The Keepers since have named that winter in the same breath as the Binding.

Oighrig nic Lachlainn died without an heir of her body, and the line of Go-raidh Mòr, as the list reckons it, ended with her. The red hall was shut, and its clerks kept it. The Four Houses met at Dùn ìseal to choose a ruler, since no custom covered a hall without an heir. Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>1</sup> claimed by blood, Sliochd Thormoid<sup>2</sup> through the clerks, and Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>3</sup> through its boats. Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>4</sup>, which held the Keeper's office, made no claim at all. How long the houses sat, and whether the hall stood empty all that while, is not told; the rolls put the choosing some years after the meeting.

## XVII

### Of the House of Tormod

**T**he houses chose Gilleasbuig Mòr mac Tormoid of Seann Dunn, a grandson of the clerks' line. The Keeper set the stone cup in his hands before the council, the first time a ruler was made at Dùn ìseal, and it looked very much, as more than one chronicler has dryly said, as if the Hall had made the

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1. the house of Ìomhar  
 2. the house of Tormod  
 3. the house of Raghnaill  
 4. the house of Muireach

king. Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>1</sup> consented on condition that its graves at Dùn dhearg stay the kings' burying-place. Gilleasbuig had the king-list recopied with a line drawn under Oighrig nic Lachlainn, and the line is in every copy made since. He made his house's shrine at Seann Dunn a temple, whose lamp a Keeper's cutter still checked every season, and he was buried at Dùn dhearg as agreed. His son Tormod Òg succeeded without any meeting of the houses, and nobody asked for one.

Between Tormod Òg and Anna Ruadh the list gives nine rulers of the house with their years and little else, and the rolls of those reigns hold mostly harvests, tolls and bridge repairs. The tellers take this for a sign that the island was doing well.

The bridges, at any rate, were mended. The span at Cathair dhearg was widened for carts on Mòrag nan Rathad's piers. Above Ros fhionn the masons found Ailean Clachair's sign still sharp and left it alone. New crossings rose at Dùn chrom and Ceann àrsaidh, and at Doire mhin the keystone carries, beside the hearth-sign, the first mason's mark on the island: the name of Beathag Clachair. An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>2</sup> was rebuilt in stone and got its name, for carriers said you were never nearer to it than halfway. The house on the northern road began serving a barley spirit the carriers called fire-water. The Keepers ruled that it was not a burning, and its trade doubled.

The north-west kept to the edge of things. Caol mhòr paid its tolls only when the road-guard came for them, and Inis mhin appears in the rolls once, for a complaint. The seal-oil of Ceann mhòr lit the western harbours brighter than anything else on Dia-thìr. Two boats of Baile chrom felt something vast move under them in the north-western water, and one did not come home. The wake kept for the first loss is kept now for both.

Sliochd Raghnaill's<sup>3</sup> boats made the round of the offshore islands, Eilean ruadh, Eilean dhearg and Eilean fhada among them, in a single season. No crew of the age went further than the islands, and none wished to.

Anna Ruadh of the house of Tormod walked the whole road circuit, as Mòrag nan Rathad had, and she walked it twice. At the house where the War of the Roads was ended she ate the jugged buffalo at the long table like a carrier. She gave the sunny house the only royal charter any waypoint house holds, and gave the contest at Ceann leathan a walled field and fed its losers at the crown's cost.

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1. the house of Ìomhar

2. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

3. the house of Raghnaill

She also kept a wood-watcher in her household to read the omens of the hall, the first sign in the capital of the rite of Macha, lady of sovereignty and of horses. The Keeper protested from Dùn iséal and got no answer. Cathair dhomhain, proud of keeping the Law strictly, would take no wood-watcher, and said the capital had handed its omens to people who sat in trees. From then on the two towns' rivalry was a quarrel of faith as well.

Anna Ruadh was buried at Dùn dhearg. Her son Coinneach Bànn reigned long and quietly and had the rolls copied for every province seat. Several of those copies have lasted where the originals have not, and much of what is known of these reigns rests on them.

## XVIII

### Of the Parting of the Rites

**S**eumas Bànn of Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>1</sup> was chosen Keeper, and in his first winter he sat down in the Hall with the Keepers' roll, meaning only to learn the names of those before him.

He read it by the light of Bride's flame. The names went down and down in the old stag-letters, some cramped, some sprawling, a few so faded he had to tilt the page to the fire. Past the middle he began to notice how often he met his own house. By the end he had stopped reading and was counting. More than half the Keepers of the whole age had been of Sliochd Mhuirich.

He sat a while with that. Then he sent for a clerk and a knife and had the fact scraped from the preface. The clerk did as he was told. An unscraped copy survived all the same, and so Seumas Bànn is remembered chiefly for the one thing he wished forgotten.

That winter too he had the Hall list every rite that burned the handful or claimed the vein, so the council would know what it was keeping. The list named the Hall's own rite of the flame and the stone, the old ancestor-keeping, the dawn-hawk, the wood-watchers, the wolf-sworn, the sting-oath and both schools of the stag.

In spring he sent a cutter to check the hawk-keepers' measure at Seann Skell. The man came back wind-burned and angry, with a strip of hide in his hand. The

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1. the house of Muireach

hawk-keepers had sent him back unheard: the measure was the hawk's, they said, and the hawk was not the Keeper's, and they had written it down so he could not mistake it. It was the first rite to refuse the Hall's check outright. Seumas Bàn read the hide twice and put it in the chest with the roll.

After that the news came from every side, and none of it pleased him. The wolf-sworn built a hall round their stone at Caol leathan and swore oaths there that were no longer guards' oaths. The stone, they said, watches the whole island as the guard watches the road, and knows its rightful king. At the western Seann Skell the harbour court's sting-oath became a creed. One power stings the liar wherever he is, its keepers said, and that power is Manannan mac Lir, lord of the sea; the scorpion is only his sign. From then on they swore over a cup marked with the scorpion, Manannan's Cup of Truth, which breaks in three at three lies spoken over it and is whole again at three truths. It was the first teaching on the island to call itself the only true one. Seann Vell, below Cuan shean, took up the sting-oath of its neighbours and carved a scorpion in yellow stone, the first made for worship; every one before it had been sworn on. The wood-watchers stopped bringing their disputes to the Hall and judged them under the trees. They held that the black beast has two natures, one that keeps and one that devours, and that the vein has the same two; and some among them told it of the two horses that drew one chariot, the black Dubh Sainglenn and the grey Liath Macha.

By 11 an Gearran, FE 2,855, the one practice of the Hall had plainly split. It had become many threads, and men began to call them together An Creideamh Sean<sup>2</sup>, the Old Faith, with the older reverence of the hearths standing apart beside them, and the belief of the Dia-thìrich was no longer one thing. The council, which had sat by hearth and house, began to sit in companies by rite, each on its own benches.

Seumas Bàn looked down the Hall on the first day they sat so, at the knots of people who would not look at one another, and said to the clerk beside him, loudly enough to be written down, that he kept the flame now for eight peoples, and each of them thought itself the only keeper.

Two customs stayed outside the companies. Pilgrims of every rite still walked to Allt an Àigh<sup>3</sup> at the right quarter of the moon, the one custom the Hall's list set under no company, and in one season pilgrims of four rites repaved the path from Caol shean together. And the keeper of the springs at Muileann ruadh ruled that

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2. the Old Faith

3. the stream of the healing water

the sick of every rite should be bathed without being asked which. It was the last ruling of the age that every company accepted, and it came from the one office the Hall had made that had nothing to do with the coal.

## X I X

## Of the Last Quiet Years and the Close of the Age

**T**he last generations of the age live in the provincial rolls, which care about what was made and what was owed. The eastern Cnoc dhìreach wove the carriers' heavy cloth, and Muileann bhàn dyed it a pale hill-blue; the Keepers wore theirs undyed, and said so. A flood at Àth chiar took six townsfolk, but the granary on its rise fed the town through the winter. The south-eastern Seann Vell grew into a city on fish and silver and built the island's first stone quay. The beacon at Tobar dhearg was raised on a stone tower. At Muileann naomh a mill and a shrine shared a roof, and the Keeper's cutter found the measure kept and the flour good. Dùn thais built the stag's first temple of stone, a hall of the druid schools. Baile Mòr mhòr sent a member to the council, and the Four Houses seated him at the foot of the hall.

When drought burned the pastures of Achadh shean, grain came from Baile chaol and Cuan ruadh under the shared-meal law, and the rolls at Baile chaol record it repaid measure by measure, the first such debt repaid in full. At Baile ruadh a timber watch-tower was manned against island raiders, the only tower of war the age built. At Inis chrom the families of the drowned set an empty place for each of the lost at a yearly feast on the shore, and the custom spread north to Seann Warr. At Cnoc naomh the ancestors were still kept in the old way, with no hawk or wolf, sting or stag, and the Hall's list counted the old reverence as one company among the others.

Mòr nic Coinnich, granddaughter of Coinneach Bàn, received the stone cup from the Keeper Catrìona nic Mhuirich at Dùn ìseal, as Gilleasbuig Mòr had. Hers is the last name in the king-list of the Holy Age. At the close of the age the Keepers' roll held one hundred and forty names from Beathag Bhàn to Catrìona nic Mhuirich, and the king-list more than ninety from Goraidh Mòr to Mòr nic Coinnich. The Small-Burning Law had not changed by a word since Fionnlagh Dall filled the cup, and the cup still stood on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach',

where the lords of the shares had sworn their peace beside it. Of the Roinn itself little was left but the stones on the bounds of the provinces, and the names of a few great shares that the provinces still answered to when the clerks were not listening.

In those years, about FE 2,949, no family on the island had more years of life than any other. The long years of the king's kin had run out many generations before, and in the halls of those days Eithne nic Ailein and Murchadh Mòr were already names in a telling. Keepers aged at the pace of carriers, and every ruler died in their time. No one wrote it down as a blessing, for it was only the way of things.

Thus ended the Holy Age, with the cup on the threshold and the flame in the Hall, and every hand that held the right to it counted, and the sea at the island's back, uncrossed and unwished-for.





THE FOURTH BOOK

# AN AOIS SCARaidh

*the Age of Sundering*

LE 1 – 1,819

*Roghnaich iadsan, agus dh'fhuirich sinne.* They chose, and we stayed.

— written in the margin of the custody-book at Muileann dhearg, in  
a hand the keepers have never identified

I

## Of the Rumour of a Shore

**I**n those days the kings of Dia-thìr kept their hall at Cathair dhearg, and the custodians kept the vein under the mountain, and the Small-Burning Law measured out the coloured coal hearth by hearth as it had done since the early centuries of the Holy Age. Into that settled house there came a rumour. On 6 am Faoilleach, LE 1, word came back to the island of a land across open water, a coast where no one lived who resembled the Dia-thìrich. Who first carried it, and in what boat, the tellers at the hearth do not know; they shrug and go on, for the tale has never needed a first finder.

By winter it had reached the capital. In the red hall of Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill, daughter of Mòr nic Coinnich, three crews from the western harbours told it one after another, and none of them claimed to have been first. The queen's scribe took down all three and wrote at the foot of the leaf that they agreed on the coast and on nothing else. Most of what Dia-thìr has known of the land beyond has been of that kind.

Then came the Choosing, which the chronicles call a vote. Perhaps it was; or perhaps the word was laid afterward over something older and looser, settled at hearths and on quays. Of one matter every telling is sure: those who went, went because they wished to. No lots were drawn, and no one was pressed. The Choosing is remembered on 8 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1, though it was a season more than a day.

At Seann Skell, the western river port that would give the age its fleet, the harbour scribes opened a roll for those who meant to go. They entered it by household, never by single name, as though going were a thing a family did together or not at all. The roll was kept on boards in the harbour-house, and a later hand notes that entries were struck out as often as they were added.

## II

### Of the Queen's Word and the Queen's Sister

**T**he harbour scribe of Seann Skell learned that year to dread the sound of his own door. All summer they came in off the quay: fishers with tar on their hands, farm wives from up the river with a child on the hip. They stood before the boards and said a household's name, and he cut it. Before the moon was out, as often as not, the same man came back grey in the face and asked to have it struck out, and he struck it.

In the autumn of LE 2 a rider came down from the capital with the queen's word, and the scribe read it out at the harbour-house door. The crown would send no one across the water, and the crown would keep no one back. The custody-book gives her words only in substance. The harbour songs of Seann Skell, younger and less careful, give them like this:

*Cha chuir mi duine thairis, agus cha chùim mi duine air ais.* I will send no one over, and I will keep no one back.

Within that same season a woman came in out of the rain whom he knew before she had lowered her hood. It was Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, the queen's younger sister. She did not sit. She gave the name of her own household, spelled it out for him as though he might not know it, and watched his knife until the last stroke was cut. Then she thanked him and went back out into the weather.

He wrote nothing beside the entry. The record makes no comment, and the later chroniclers, who have made a great many, were none of them in the room.

Up at the vein-house above Muileann dhearg, which kept Crom's stone and was heir to the Keepers' Hall at Dùn ìseal where Brìde's flame was first bound, the custodians sat down with the roll and counted what the Choosing would cost them. Nearly one in five of the households holding the customary right to burn the coal had entered it. They counted twice, the custody-book says, because nobody believed the first figure. Fishers and farmers were going, and the queen's own sister, and many whose hands the vein had answered.

III

## Of the Building of the Ships

**T**he island had no ship fit for the crossing. Her craft until then were sewn-plank coasters that never slept out of sight of land, and a fleet had to be made such as the island had never seen. The making took the better part of a generation.

In LE 5, on the river strand below Seann Skell, the shipwright Alasdair mac Iain, called Alasdair Saor, laid down the first deep-keeled hull ever built on Dia-thìr. Its oaks came from the grove that had given Doire fhionn its name. They went down to the coast on ox-sleds, and the grove never grew again, so the village kept a name it no longer had a reason for. Alasdair bound the wrights of the strand into one fellowship, each apprentice sworn for seven years after the manner of the vein custodians. The custody-book calls it Comann nan Saor-luinge<sup>1</sup>, the fellowship of the ship-wrights.

In LE 6 Alasdair Saor stood on the headland above Ros àrsaidh, where the ships of Inis àrsaidh put to sea, his hands jammed under his arms for want of work. Below him the first finished hull came down out of the Abhainn naomh and met the open water. She rode higher than he had meant, but she rode well, and for the length of a long breath he let himself be glad of her.

Then a following sea came up under her quarter. He saw the stern lift and the bow go under, and the stern lift again, higher, and then she did not come back.

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1. the shipwrights' fellowship

She went over slowly, as a tired beast lies down. There were heads in the water, and then there were fewer. Eleven were drowned.

That night by a driftwood fire he drew the keel in the sand with a stick, rubbed it out, and drew it again. He changed its setting, and every later hull of the fleet was built to the changed pattern. What the change was lived in the hands of his wrights and nowhere else, and some three centuries later no one on the island could remember it.

The rest of Dia-thìr laboured with him. Cuan shean laid long rope-walks down its harbour front and gave its hemp fields over wholly to cordage. Every weaving household in Siorrachd Baile àrsaidh was asked for a length of close-woven sail-cloth, reckoned on tally-sticks at the shire seat; the tallies survive, though how many households paid does not. On the eastern shore the old steersmen of Cuan ruadh, the only sailors on the island who had ever held a course by night, taught the fleet's pilots to keep a heading by the stars. Some of their lore was written down, and that part is lost.

In LE 18 the households on the roll met at Seann Skell and chose their own leaders: Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, the queen's sister, and Fearchar mac Ruairidh, a custodian of the vein. How they chose, the custody-book does not tell. Seven years on, the vein-house ruled whether departing custodians might carry the coal. Each ship might take one sealed measure, as much as a single household might burn in a season under the Small-Burning Law. It is the only text in the custody-book addressed to people who were leaving, and it gives them no blessing. A later custodian wrote a couplet beside it, which is still said at the measured burning in some of the old houses:

*Dòrlach airson an teallaich ùir, is an seann teallach fhathast blàth.* A hand-ful for the new hearth, and the old hearth still warm.

Masons came from the capital to lengthen the west quay at Seann Skell with dressed stone, so that the deep hulls could lie alongside at low water. They set down the stones on which the later rite would be held, and they did not know it.

In LE 38 the whole venture nearly foundered on a quarrel over how much of the island's stored harvest the ships might take. It ran a season and was settled, and nobody wrote how. One piece of it survives. At Àth shean the reeve of the granaries, Tormod mac Coinnich, barred the store-houses while the quarrel was open and set a watch on the doors, and the watch stood until the thing was done.

Tormod held no office after that. When the barges moved at last, a tally-keeper on Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>2</sup> notched them one by one as they passed down Abhainn dhomhain for the fleet, and made the count forty-one.

In the spring of that year the fleet lay complete at Seann Skell. The custody-book gives it as nineteen hulls. A later hand in the margin makes it twenty-one, and there the matter has rested ever since.

## IV

### Of the Sunwise Turn

**O**n the last night before the sailing every house along the Seann Skell waterfront set a lamp on its sill and kept it burning until morning. It is the first custom of the Sundering that anyone wrote down as a custom.

A boy of the harbour sat that night on the wall of the west quay with his knees drawn up to his chin and watched the lamps come out along the strand, one and then another, until the whole curve of the water was pricked with light. It was the moon of Bearnach, the gap between the last of the stores and the first of the green, and the air was sharp. Below him the hulls lay against the new stones, so close that he could have dropped a pebble onto a deck. He smelt pitch and wet hemp and the sheep's fat the crews had rubbed into the blocks. Somewhere aboard, someone was singing under her breath, and someone else told her to hush.

He was to be one of the counters. The harbour scribe had given him a hazel stick and a knife, and told him: one notch for each hull as she passes, and no talking.

On 19 an Giblean, LE 40, in the grey before sunrise, the volunteers departed.

They did not go straight down to the sea. The first hull came off the quay and swung, and the next came after her, and the boy saw that they meant to go round the river pool, sunwise, *diosal*, as you walk round a well or a new-built house for luck. He cut his notches. The hulls went by so near that he knew faces on them, and he did not look at the faces long, because he was counting.

At the foot of the pool the fleet straightened and went away down the Abhainn naomh toward open water, and there the harbour scribe's account of

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2. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

them ends, as if his pen had been lifted from the leaf. Of the crowd, or the weather, or who wept, the chronicles of the island say nothing. The harbour songs go a little further. They say the fleet stood out past the north cape into Manannan's sea, toward the Otherworld of the tellings, Tìr nan Òg<sup>1</sup> and Magh Meall<sup>2</sup>, and that a mist came down on the water behind the last hull and did not lift until it was gone.

Whether the boy's stick said nineteen or twenty-one, no one thought to ask him.

## V

## Of the Two Landfalls and the White Sorrow

From then on the years of Dia-thìr were counted from that turn, though not at once. In LE 44 Donnchadh mac Thormoid, scribe of the vein-house, began to number the years from the sunwise turn at Seann Skell and called them the years of the Diosal. The crown's scribes took up his count only a generation later. So an island that had reckoned its time by kings and harvests began, in one clerk's hand, to reckon it by an absence.

That same year a report of the fleet came into Seann Skell. By whom it came, or in what boat, the custody-book will not say; only that the harbour scribe copied it in a hand that shook. The copy came down to later keepers stained by water, and its end is gone.

It tells of two landfalls, two separate coasts reached, and the keepers have read in it that the fleet was parted on the far side of the sea. Which hulls went to which shore, and whether storm or quarrel or purpose parted them, is dark. Sixteen centuries later Beathag nic Thòmais of Muileann chaol found three copies of the report, and they differed in the order of the coasts and in the number of hulls. She wrote all three out side by side and chose none of them, and the keepers after her have done the same.

In LE 46 Queen Beathag struck her sister Mòrag, and Mòrag's children, from the order of succession, as persons no longer on Dia-thìr. The act stands in the roll without comment, between a grain ruling and the mending of a bridge. It is

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1. the land of the young

2. the plain of delight

the last time the crown of Dia-thìr wrote Mòrag's name, and it wrote it in the ordinary way.

What befell across the water after that, the island learned in pieces, if it learned it at all. The chronicle calls it the thinning. Cut off from the vein, whatever strength the crossing had asked of the departed faded in their children, and by the third generation abroad nothing was left that Dia-thìr would have known for its own.

Then came the second silence. Some twelve years after the thinning is first written, men spoke of a second and smaller crossing: fewer ships, bound for a shore nobody named. Nothing that survives either bears it out or gives it the lie, and the keepers enter it and let it stand.

In LE 53 the vein-house counted again the households that held the right to the coal, and set the loss down as one hand in five. Beside the figure Donnchadh mac Thormoid wrote that the vein itself answered no differently for those who stayed. Donnchadh never said whether he meant it as comfort or complaint, and men have argued over it since.

The next year the queen made a rite for the departed, and she kept it first for her sister. Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill came into her own hall in a gown of undyed wool, pale and rough as a fleece off the hill, and sat at the head of the board. Beside her a place was laid with no one in it: a cup, a trencher, a knife set straight. The meal that followed was neither feast nor fast. The court did not know what to do with its face, so it ate. The queen did not look at the empty place, and she did not look away from it either.

The court called the custom an Tùrsa Geal<sup>1</sup>, the white sorrow, and the chronicle calls it the Mourning Custom. By the next generation it was kept in every harbour town on the island.

The year after, the island shaped itself around what was left. With part of the coal-bonded people gone the custodian class grew smaller and closer, and the great houses of the age were cast in that mould. In LE 55 the remaining custodian households were gathered into seven houses, each answerable to the vein-house for its share of the coal and of the measured burning: Clann Mhuirich, Clann Fhearchair, Clann Ìomhair, Clann Raghnaill, Clann Thormoid, Clann Choinnich and Clann Lachlainn. Mark those names. Until that day the right to the coal had been earned by apprenticeship; from it, the right passed by house.

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1. the Mourning Custom; lit. 'the white sorrow'

Queen Beathag died at Cathair dhearg in the summer of that year, the last ruler of Dia-thìr to have seen the fleet. Her son Ragnall mac Uilleim was crowned in the same hall.

## VI

## Of the Empty Harbour

**T**he net-menders of Seann Skell tell the years after the leaving on winter nights with the door shut, and they tell them so.

A ceremony grew up around the berth the ships had left from, the empty-harbour rite, and it is kept still, in a lesser form, on an anniversary no one can now fix to the day. By LE 64 the harbour-master was writing his berths down at half their old use, because the fishing households that had crewed the fleet were simply gone, and the rope-walks at Cuan shean laid off hands for the first time. On the north-west coast the fishers of Ceann mhòr kept a watch from the head-land for returning sails, household by household in turn. The watch lapsed within a generation. No sail came.

By LE 67 Seann Skell had found a way to go on trading. The berth of the departure was given a new name, so that common trade could keep the old one without the memory clinging to it; the chronicle calls this a forgetting done on purpose. In the harbour rolls the berth became Cidhe an Diosail<sup>1</sup>, the quay of the sunwise turn, and the name Cidhe an Iar passed to the new fish-wharf at the north end of the strand, where within a few years the fishers used it without a thought.

The tongue kept what the harbour put away. From LE 67 the custody-book writes *roghnaich*, to choose, with nothing after it, meaning to have chosen the crossing, and the scribes of the next century write it so and never gloss it. By that same year a generation had grown up that had never seen the harbour with those ships in it, and for them the leaving was already history. A saying of the western shore claims to come from about this time:

*Is fhada an cuan, is goirid a' chuimbhne.* Long is the sea, and short is memory.

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1. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell



Alasdair Saor died at Seann Skell at the end of that summer. His last work was a coasting trader of the old sewn-plank kind, built for a fish merchant of Inis àr-saidh. Seventeen years later his fellowship came quietly apart, since no one wanted ocean-going hulls any more, and its craft was half forgotten before anyone thought to need it again. In a hard season after that, its patterns and keel-moulds were broken up and burned for firewood. The harbour-master wrote down the loss of the shed and said nothing of what had been in it.

In LE 109 the seven houses drew lots at the vein-house for the galleries each would keep. The lot-stones went into a bag at Muileann dhearg, and for centuries the keepers there tipped them out into the hands of visitors. Doire fhionn, its oaks gone to the fleet, began to cut its woods by coppice, and the law spread to every shire with a *doire* in its name.

Every year on the eve of the empty-harbour rite the waterfront of Seann Skell kept the night of lamps. The children were told the lamps were for ships coming home, and the priests let them believe it. The children's verse is still known on the west coast:

*Solas air an uinneig, solas gus an tig iad dhachaigh.* A light on the window,  
a light till they come home.

Donnchadh mac Thormoid died at Muileann dhearg in LE 109. His last entry is a list of the coal burned that season, household by household, in the same hand as his first. Sixteen years on, in LE 125, King Ragnall died after a long reign in which little happened, and his son Ìomhar mac Raghnaill was crowned. The custody-book gives Ragnall a single line. After the shaking of its first years the age seems to have wanted no more than that.

## VII

### Of the Hawk and the Firlot

**T**he centuries that followed were quiet as a well-kept house is quiet: much afoot, and most of it small. The silver of Muileann chiar, mined since the Holy Age, was beaten into neck-rings for the heads of the seven houses, and the smiths' fellowship of the seam shut its craft up within four families. Inis mhòr built barges for its grain, to go down the Abhainn ghorm and along the

coast, sewn-plank boats of the old kind that never slept out of sight of land. The road-house of Am Buabhall Fortanach burned to its footings, and its keeper, Eilidh nic Chaluim, raised it again in stone. The account of her rebuilding already speaks of the juggled buffalo it was known for.

Beathag's line ended in LE 180 with King Ìomhar, who died childless. The heads of the seven houses were summoned to the capital, and in LE 182 they chose Fearchar mac Lachlainn of Baile Mòr dhomhain, of Clann Fhearchair. He was the first king in the record crowned by the choosing of the custodian houses. His son Fearchar Donn followed him, and no one gainsaid it.

In those years the orders of the Old Faith began to take their shapes. At Cnoc bheag the dawn-hawk rite of the Holy Age was still kept, and there in LE 229 the priestess Gormshuil nic Artair taught that the hawk of the rite was Mòd, the Hawk of Acaill, as old as Fionntan mac Bòchra, the oldest of men, and remembering all things with him; and that the vein was the Hungry Hawk, who must be fed the measured handful and no more. A hawk overfed will not hunt, she said, and a hawk starved will turn on the hand. Her followers gathered the old rite into the first house of Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>1</sup>, the order of the Hawk of Acaill, and her pupils raised a second at Ros gheal. After her death her sayings were written down as Leabhar an t-Seabhaig<sup>2</sup>, the Book of the Hawk. The copyist, Ùisdean mac Pàdraig, marked every saying he had not heard from her own mouth, and the marked sayings outnumber the rest. The first in the book is one he heard:

*Beathaich an seabhag, ach na sàsaich e.* Feed the hawk, but do not glut him.

In LE 261 Clann Ìomhair walled Dùn dhearg in stone, the first walls on the island that any custodian house had raised. That same year Sìleas nic Fhearchair, crowned after her father, fixed one measure for grain across the whole island, the firlot of Cathair dhearg, so that barter between shires need no longer begin with a quarrel over the size of a basket. She sent firlots of oak bound with iron to every shire seat. Later she set a tally-house in each royal granary, where every trade of grain for cloth, salt or labour was cut on paired sticks. It was the first account of trade to run the length of the island, and not one coin passed through it. She reigned more than half a century, and her son Uisdean mac Dhùghaill followed her in LE 324.

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1. the Hawk order

2. the Book of the Hawk

It was a good time to be a carter. Near Imrich nam Pantar<sup>3</sup> the herders began clearing the panther roads on the days the great cats crossed, driving their flocks aside beforehand, and those crossing days were the first thing the southern shires ever agreed on in writing. At An Leòmhann Buidhe<sup>4</sup> on the northern mining road the coal-carters were served oatcakes fried in linseed oil, and fire water, and the keeper was fined for watering the fire water. Ros fhionn laid out salt pans at the brine springs on its river flats, and its salt, carted inland over Drochaid Ros fhionn, became the common measure of worth in the north-east.

### VIII

## Of the Forbidden Question, the Stone and the Two Horses

**I**n LE 314 Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn, a druid of the schools of Flidais, lady of the deer, whose teaching the old rolls call Feallsanachd an Fhèidh<sup>1</sup>, founded a house of disputation at Dùn thais. There the schools' old question, *Carson an làmh seo?*, why the vein answers some hands and not others, was argued by rule, and pupils came to hear it from as far as Caol bheag.

Ten years later Coinneach stood up in his own hall to ask the thing he had been carrying.

The benches were full, and the air was thick with wet wool and tallow smoke. Coinneach was old enough by then to know which questions were safe. He had turned this one over on the road, to the knock of his stick, and it had grown no safer for the turning.

"We ask why the vein answers this hand and not that one," he said. "Then let us ask it of the hands that went. Were they the hands it answered best? And if they were, does it answer fewer now?"

No one spoke. A bench creaked. Somewhere at the back a young man laughed, once, and then thought better of it. Coinneach waited, as the rule of disputation bade him, for someone to answer. When no one did, he sat down.

The answer came from the seven houses. They forbade the question at their own tables. The record notes that until then they had forbidden only deeds, and that this was the first question they forbade.

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3. the panthers' crossing

4. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

1. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

The skills of the fleet were slipping already. In LE 344 a merchant of Inis àr-saidh paid for a deep-keeled hull, but the wrights could no longer remember how Alasdair Saor had scarfed his keels, and she listed so badly at her launch that she was broken up for timber.

Aonghas mac Uisdein, crowned in LE 394, was the first king who learned his letters as a child, and in his reign two more orders took their shapes. In LE 409 Dòmhnall mac Ailein, a net-maker of Inis thais, where the wolf-sworn's stone stood, gave that stone its name and its order. He called it Clach, the Stone, and said it was Lia Fàil<sup>2</sup>, which cries out under the rightful king; and he called its sworn guards the Fianna, who keep the island as a wolf keeps its range. So began Òrd na Cloiche<sup>3</sup>, the order of the Stone, and the tales of Fionn and his band, which every hearth on the island knew, the Fianna took for their own. When the Hawk and the Stone both laid claim to the harbour shrine at Caol leathan, the king's reeve divided its days between them as the Holy Age had divided the sacred woods, and the sharing held.

In LE 441 Aonghas himself took up the wood-watchers' rite of Macha, which keeps the two horses of one chariot, foaled on one night: Liath Macha the grey and Dubh Sainglenn the black. Two horses, one yoke, the rite says; dark and light are two powers in balance, and the vein belongs to both. The court followed its king, and Òrd Mhacha<sup>4</sup>, the order of Macha, became the order of Cathair dhearg. From Aonghas on, the kings of Dia-thìr were made by Macha's rite.

In LE 484 Eilidh nic Iain of Doire chiar, called Eilidh Dhubh, raised again the Holy Age's rival teaching, that the vein answers effort and cares nothing for birth, and her tracts were read aloud at harvest gatherings across the north-east. The vein-house ordered every copy brought to Muileann dhearg and burned, and some hundred were given up. Eilidh herself was never punished. She died at Doire chiar, still teaching.

Aonghas died that winter and was the first king buried by the rite of Macha. His son Iain reigned a short while, and Iain's son Tormod mac Iain, called Tormod Bàn for his white hair, was sworn to without dispute. On the central mining road the ox-teams of the mountain now waited out the snow at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, whose keeper, Iain mac Mhurchaidh, built them a second byre and kept a book of the teams that lodged.

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2. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

3. the order of the Stone

4. the order of Macha

I X

## Of the War of the Three Claimants

**I**n LE 534 both sons of King Tormod Bàn were drowned when a ferry overturned crossing Abhainn fhionn in spite. The king had no other child. Thirteen years later he died at Cathair dhearg without naming an heir, and three claims were laid before the houses at once. Catriona nic Aonghais of Inis thais was the dead king's niece. Dùghall Garbh of Baile Mòr dhomhain was his half-brother. Ragnall Ruadh was head of Clann Raghnaill and master of the vein-house. The seven houses split among the three, and in LE 552 the War of the Three Claimants began.

So small a cause, and so long a war: the keepers have wondered at it. Perhaps, having held the coal by inheritance for five hundred years, each house had come to believe that a crown could be inherited the same way.

Seann Warr, the port nearest the capital on the west, shut its gates on all three and declared for none. It was besieged twice and taken by neither. At the ford of Àth shean, the northern town of that name and no kin to the granary town, Dùghall Garbh's host broke Ragnall Ruadh's, and the custody-book counts some three hundred dead, most of them drowned in the ford. Ragnall's men burned Doire mhin and its granary as they fell back, and the villagers wintered at Cathair mhòr on the charity of Macha's priests. Catriona laid siege to Cathair dhomhain, which had declared for Dùghall, and took it after forty days, when the dead of the siege lines had fouled its wells; and she let the garrison go free on their oath.

Snow lay on the mountain on 24 am Faoilleach, LE 558, when Ragnall Ruadh came out into the yard of the vein-house.

The carriers were waiting there with their baskets and their sealed measures, as carriers had waited every season since before there were kings, stamping against the cold. Beyond the gate the road wound down toward the shires, white and empty.

Ragnall had a list in his hand. His clerk had drawn it up the night before: the shires that stood against him, and every hearth and temple in them that took the handful. It was a long list. He read it through once more in the thin light, and then he gave it to the master of the store.

"None of these," he said.

The master of the store looked at the list, and then at him. Since the Small-Burning Law began, the store had measured the coal out; no one in that yard had ever seen it used to hold the coal back. "Lord," the man said, and got no further.

"None of these," said Ragnall again, and went in out of the wind.

Down in the shires that stood against him, hearths that had been lit with the coal for generations burned low, and grey, and then went cold. The chronicle says the deed turned more against him than any battle. A verse from the cold shires survives, with no name to it:

*Cha do chaill sinn blàr, ach chaill sinn an teine.* We did not lose a battle, but we lost the fire.

Catriona and Dùghall joined their hosts against him, and on 14 am Faoilleach, LE 560, in the dead of another winter, they met Ragnall below Muileann chrom. He was killed on the field. The next day his own custodians opened the vein-house, and the carriers went down the white road with their baskets full. Dùghall died of his wounds at Baile Mòr dhomhain in LE 561, and his followers went over to Catriona without another blow. She was crowned at Cathair dhearg in LE 562, and was called ever after Catriona Bhuadhach, Catriona the Victorious. The war had lasted some ten years.

Three years later she did the deed she is remembered for. With the vein-house she fixed it in law that no claimant, house or king might withhold the measured handful from any lawful hearth. This was the ruling of the hearth, the first law in the record written to bind the custodians themselves. To Seann Warr she granted the right to keep its own gates and tolls, in memory of its standing aside, and had the grant cut over the landward gate. When she died in LE 604 the houses swore to her son Lachlann mac Iain in a single day, and the record remarks on it.

In LE 624 Seònaid nic Coinnich, a clerk of the late queen's household, wrote the history of the war from the custody-book and from the mouths of those who had fought. It is the oldest history on Dia-thìr told as one tale from end to end, and every later history of the island descends from it, this book among them. That same year a spotted fever killed some three hundred at Inis chrom. The Fianna of the Stone nursed the sick, and many of them died of it, and after that the town was the Stone's for good.

X

## Of Manannan's Mist, and the Crown Joined to the Vein

**S**o the fishing families of the west coast tell the coming of Manannan's order, as an old woman of Ros bheag once told it to a keeper of Muileann chaol over her nets.

In LE 654 a preacher named Mānas mac Ruairidh stood up at Seann Skell, of all places, where the sting-creed of the Holy Age had first called itself the only true faith, and proclaimed its one power: Manannan mac Lir, lord of the sea, whose Cup of Truth breaks at a lie spoken over it and bears the yellow scorpion for its sign. Manannan, he said, had shut the eastern sea behind the fleet with his mist, and hid the island in it from every ship beyond; and what the fleet had done must never be tried again. Those who heard him on the quay were the first congregation of Òrd Mhanannain<sup>1</sup>, the order of Manannan. A month later, in the autumn of LE 654, Lachlann mac Iain died at Cathair dhearg and his daughter Anna was crowned. The record calls his reign quiet, and means it as praise.

The teaching went down the west coast with the fishing families. At Cuan shean the rope-makers, whose walks had been laid out for the fleet, were among the first to take it up. In LE 694 Manannan's priests at Ros bheag laid it down that no boat of the faithful might go beyond sight of the headlands. The west coast kept that rule for centuries, and there the steering of boats by the stars, half lost already, was lost entirely. Of all the orders of the Old Faith the keepers have been least easy with Manannan's, the one order whose teaching stands on the Sundering; and what it teaches is that the island must never again do what the fleet did.

In LE 739 the vein-house and the crown's scribes found that their counts of years since the Setting-Out disagreed. They settled the difference by agreement, and by the same agreement fixed the day of the empty-harbour rite, which the two counts had placed differently. Later scribes gave up pretending it had been fixed by evidence. Every year counted from the Diosal stands on that bargain between two offices, and whoever reads the old rolls should know it.

Eilidh Bhàn, fifth ruler of the house of Catriona, was crowned in LE 769, and the record of her long reign is nearly all harvests. The north-west had no share in them. From LE 784 boats out of the small islands off that coast fell on the coast-

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1. the order of Manannan

ing traders and took their fish and grain. The sea-thieves were Dia-thìrich of the north-west shore, and the harbour rolls give some of their names. Baile chrom reported half its houses empty, and the crown remitted its grain dues. In LE 801 a force sent by Eilidh Bhàn landed on Eilean dhubh and burned the thieves' boats on the strand, and their leader, Uilleam Ruadh, was hanged at Cathair dhearg. It did not save the coast. In LE 819 a run of failed harvests brought a dearth to the north-west shore that the shared-meal custom could not carry. Families went inland and east, and the north-west stayed thinly held until the age was out.

In LE 829 the queen's scribes recopied the king-list from its oldest surviving roll and added the rulers since the Sundering. The new copy opens the present age with the Choosing, ahead of the fleet, and this book keeps that order. Twelve years after, Eilidh Bhàn died childless, and the seven houses met to choose; this time they met at the vein-house, and the capital waited on their word. They named Dòmhnall Ruadh of Clann Raghnaill, a descendant of the claimant killed at Muileann chrom, and he kept the mastery of the vein-house together with the crown. In LE 859 his reeves wrote into the custody-book that the ruler of Dia-thìr is also master of the vein-house. From then on the heads of the seven houses sat as the king's council, and custodians and court were one body. What Raghnaill Ruadh had seized in war, his descendant now held by law. The ruling of the hearth still bound the custodians; the custodians, now, were the crown. Dòmhnall Ruadh was buried at Muileann dhearg, under the mountain, far from the capital.

The Hawk split in LE 889 over whether Mòd's measure might ever be raised. Those who held it fixed for ever kept the name of the Hungry Hawk and the house at Cnoc bheag. Those who said a larger flock might be fed a larger handful were called the Fed Hawk, and they went to Seann Skell on the north coast, the other town of that name. In LE 919 they petitioned the council to raise the handful by a quarter for the northern hearths. The council refused. It was the first recorded asking to change the Small-Burning Law, and the custody-book enters the Fed Hawk's teaching as an error, at length.

## X I

### Of the Stair under the Hill

**I**n LE 929 a second tremor in the hills of Cill ghlas brought down a gallery of the vein and killed fourteen labourers. The vein-house closed the gallery and



set a stone at its mouth with the fourteen names cut on it. The last shepherds left the high pastures of Doire uaine. They said it was for the grazing, and every one of them who was asked also spoke of the Marbh-bhed<sup>1</sup>.

In LE 979, north of the capital, a quarry face gave way under the hammers and opened on darkness.

Air came up out of the hole, cold as well-water, and it smelt of nothing at all, which was worse than any smell. One of the quarrymen held a lamp in at arm's length, and they saw steps: a stair cut in the living rock, each tread worn hollow at the middle, going down and down past where the light would reach. Someone said the name before anyone else could, Toll-dubh, the shaft of the old tellings, long lost. After that nobody said anything.

One of them went down. His fellows watched his lamp go, turning and dropping and dwindling, until the rock swallowed it. They waited. One who was there said afterward that they waited long enough to be ashamed of how glad they were when the light came back.

The man climbed out, sat down on the spoil heap and said nothing, and whatever he may have said later went unwritten. The custodians came down from the vein-house and had the entrance walled up.

Twenty years later Ailean mac Dhùghaill of the druid school at Dùn thais measured the ruin of Làrach an Teampaill<sup>2</sup> and wrote that its altar faced the central mountains, with its back to the sea. Who had set it so, he would not guess. By LE 1,011 he had finished his tables of the three old ruins, Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>3</sup>, Làrach an Dùin<sup>4</sup> and Làrach an Teampaill, with their measures and their stone and the lie of each, and he concluded that he could not say whether one people had built all three. Because of his tables no one after him could say either.

Mòrag Ruadh of Clann Raghnaill was crowned in LE 1,019, the first ruler whose household accounts survive whole. On 15 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,039, in the dark of the year, the vein-house marked the thousandth year of its count with a single measured burning of the coal on Cidhe an Diosail<sup>5</sup> at Seann Skell, and the queen stood by. The flame burned the colour of the vein, the record says, and the crowd went home without a word.

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1. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

2. the temple ruin

3. the watch-fort ruin

4. the fortress ruin

5. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

## XII

## Of Things Forgotten, and the Brothers' War

**A**fter the thousandth year the island began, plainly, to lose what it knew. A sickness that closed the throat, the swallowing cough, broke out at Muileann dhomhain in LE 1,079 and killed nearly a third of the town. When it reached Seann Bhral the townsfolk shut their own harbour and kept the shared-meal custom by leaving food at the gate. Queen Beathag Fhionn, daughter of Mòrag Ruadh, closed the coast road between the two towns and set reeves at the fords to turn travellers back, and the cough went no further west. Her son Ailean followed her, the first of four kings of that name in the house of Ragnall.

The dyers of Baile ghorm had made a fast blue from a marsh plant and a mordant of their own, and it was the feast-day dress of the seven houses. In LE 1,139 the last dyer who knew the mordant died without apprentices, having quarrelled with both of hers, and the blue that came after was the common blue of the rest of the island.

The Abhainn bheag silted behind a shifting bar below Ros fhionn, and the salt-masters moved their trade to Caol gharbh on the coast. The carts stopped crossing Drochaid Ros fhionn, and the bridge-keeper's office was done away with. Fishers of the thinned north-west saw the Sea-Watcher, Uilebheist na Mara<sup>1</sup>, close enough to foul their nets, and the few boats left there drew further in.

In LE 1,209 Ragnall mac Chaluim of the druid school at Dùn thais set out a table showing that the heads of the custodian houses lived, on the average, a few years longer than the tenants of their lands, and he asked whether the vein answers the hand that holds it. The record notes the finding uneasily and gives it no answer. The council forbade the table to be copied and shut the house at Dùn thais for a generation. Ragnall's own copy went into the vein-house and was entered in its inventory.

In LE 1,266 King Ailean mac Raghnaill died and left two sons by different mothers, Iain Ciar and Alasdair Bàn, each of whom had been told he was the heir. Four years after, Alasdair Bàn's men seized Cnoc naomh and Iain Ciar took it back. The houses split four to three, and the Brothers' War, Cogadh nam Bràithrean<sup>2</sup>, took its name from that fight. Alasdair's ships burned the waterfront of Ceann mhin, which held for his brother; the fire took the rope stores and the

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1. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

2. the Brothers' War

granary, and the town had to beg its bread from Cathair mhòr. In LE 1,274 Iain Ciar beat Alasdair below Muileann ghlas, took him alive, and let his captains go home.

The peace was made in LE 1,276 at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, the road-house where the ox-teams waited out the snow, on neutral ground between the brothers' lands.

The keeper of the house had been given a day's warning and had spent it scrubbing. She set the long board in the common room with a bench on either side, the benches the same length to a finger's breadth, for she had heard that great men quarrel over such things, and she put the same bread and the same ale at each end. Then she stood by the fire and tried to look as though she were not listening.

Iain Ciar came in first and sat. Alasdair Bàn came after him, stiff as a man is who has lately been a prisoner, and sat down across the board. For a long while neither spoke, and the keeper could hear the oxen shifting in the byre. What passed between them she never told. Alasdair gave up his claim and took the lordship of Seann Chwen for his life. Iain Ciar was crowned. When they rose, both loaves had been broken and neither eaten.

Alasdair kept the peace he had made and died at Seann Chwen. Because he had seen Ceann mhin beg its bread, Iain Ciar ordered every shire seat to keep a year's grain against the next war. The law held while he lived and lapsed within a few years of his death, as he had foreseen in a note in his own hand. His clerk Pàdraig mac Ruairidh wrote the account of the war. It praises the king at every turn, and it is the only account that survives, which later readers have found inconvenient.

The road-houses come back into the record here. In LE 1,319 the crown chartered the seven great road-houses of the mining circuit and made their keepers answerable for the roads between them, and the keepers met once a year at An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>3</sup> to settle their accounts. At An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the bare northern road a party of reeves was snowed in for a whole season and lived on pickled spinach and fire milk. Their complaint to the charter-roll is set down in full.

In LE 1,359 Seumas mac Iain of Seann Skell tried to build a deep-keeled hull again from what the strand still remembered of the Sundering fellowship's lore.

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3. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

She filled and sank at her launch, and Manannan's priests preached on her for a year.

Thirty years later Iseabail nic Lachlainn, a folk-collector of the royal household, came to Cuan shean for the songs of the rope-makers. She found them at the end of a walk that had lost half its length to barley, going backward in a line as they twisted the strands and singing to keep the pace. Most of it was the common stuff of work-songs. Then the leader struck up a song she had never heard, and the others fell in behind him, and she caught *druim* and *aisne*, keel and rib, and began to write fast.

Afterward she asked what the song was about. Rope, they told her. And the words further on? They looked at one another. Nobody knew. They were the words of the song.

It names the parts of a deep keel. It is the only record of the fleet's craft that survives in any shape. Its first lines can still be understood:

*Druim fòn aisne, aisne fòn chlàr, clàr ri clàr is an cuan fodhpa.* Keel under rib, rib under plank, plank to plank and the sea beneath them.

After that the song runs on in words no one can read. The rope-makers who kept it were of Manannan's order by then, and they sang it anyway.

### XIII

## Of the Last Lamps

**T**he last four centuries of the age are the longest stretch in the record and have the least to tell, and the keepers will not dress them up.

The order of the Stone split over whether the dead, who are Donn's, might be prayed for at Clach, and its two houses, at Inis thais and Baile gheal, were not reconciled in this age. Catrìona Bheag of Clann Raghnaill was crowned in LE 1,429, the first queen in more than three centuries. The record notes that she was small, and that no one said so twice. In LE 1,449 she had the heads of the seven houses swear to the ruling of the hearth in her presence, the first renewal of that oath since Catrìona Bhoadhach. Clann Choinnich swore last.

More was forgotten. The potters of Muileann gheal made a grey-green glaze no other kiln could match, and the custodian houses bought it for their tables.

The secret stayed in one family, and in LE 1,509 the last of them died without passing it on. The smiths of Dùn dhearg lost the last man who knew how their layered steel was folded, and afterward the blades of Dùn dhearg were ordinary. In the east, charcoal-burners found again the eastern Toll-dubh of the old tellings, with the same cut stair as the first. The custodians walled that one up as well, and the scribe cross-referenced the two entries.

At Àth shean the granary found that its firiot had worn smaller than the standard of Cathair dhearg, and had been so for generations. The reeve corrected the accounts as far back as anyone could reckon.

Sileas Òg, named for the queen of the firiot, was crowned in LE 1,529, the first ruler to visit every shire seat. She ordered a new count of the households holding the right to the coal. It came out smaller than any before it, for the right had narrowed into fewer and larger households, and she had it entered without comment. In LE 1,559 Clann Choinnich asked leave to burn the coal beyond the measured handful to smelt silver at Muileann chiar, arguing that it burned hotter than charcoal. The council refused. Until then the coal had been burned only for worship, and this was the first asking to burn it for work.

Ailean the Fourth had the shortest reign in the king-list. His sister Mòrag nic Raghnaill, who followed him, reigned forty years, and her entries record nothing but good harvests and the rite. In LE 1,590 the priests of Manannan met in synod at Seann Skell, restated the rule of sight-of-land, and added a prayer to be said at the foot of the river pool:

*A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte.* Manannan, keep the sea shut.

The keeping of this record begins here. In LE 1,659 Beathag nic Thòmais, a mill-owner's widow of Muileann chaol, began buying up old copies of the custody-book and the harbour rolls from houses that no longer read them, and stacked them in a loft over her mill. Soon a mill in the same town began making paper from rags, the first on Dia-thìr, and the custody-book was copied onto paper for the first time. Among her papers were the three copies of the landfall report. She died in LE 1,699 and left the loft to the town on condition that nothing in it be burned. The town kept that condition, and very little else of her wishes.

The crown sent a reeve to list the households of the north-west coast between Baile chrom and Ceann mhòr, and he counted fewer households than harbour berths. Tormod mac Ruairidh, crowned in LE 1,709, reigned more than fifty

years. In LE 1,714 Manannan's priests at Seann Skell began saying their prayer to keep the sea shut on the same day as the empty-harbour rite, so that the two were kept together on Cidhe an Diosail<sup>1</sup>. Neither side was pleased.

In LE 1,749 a visiting scribe found the rite at Seann Skell kept by the harbour priests and a few old families, and wrote that none of them could say on which day the fleet had truly sailed. The house of disputation at Dùn thais, shut and opened more than once since the table of years, opened again in LE 1,759 on condition that the question of longer lives was not raised. The scholars agreed, and argued about the vein instead.

Tormod's daughter Gormshuil nic Thormoid, crowned in LE 1,766, rode a progress round every shire seat. Her clerks wrote down each shire's grievances, and she answered none of them in writing. On the eastern road An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>2</sup> fed her company on pan-fried spinach and black wine, and its keeper, Peigi nic Dhonnchaidh, was let off her road dues for a year. It is the last warm entry of the age. In LE 1,776 Clann Choinnich asked again to burn the coal for the silver smelt, with three of the seven houses behind it now, and Gormshuil's council refused by one voice. The record names the member who changed his vote and keeps his reason to itself. In LE 1,791 the vein-house counted the households of the right for the last time in this age. They were fewer than ever, and larger, and three of the seven houses held more than half the right between them.

In LE 1,794 a worked timber came ashore at Ceann mhòr on the empty north-west coast, from beyond Manannan's mist, as the fishers said. It was longer than any tree on the island and fastened with nails of a make no smith on Dia-thìr knew. They carted it to Seann Skell and showed it to Manannan's priests, and the priests burned it.

By then fewer and fewer houses on the Seann Skell waterfront kept the night of lamps, and at last none did. An old woman set a lamp in a window of the harbour-house, and the scribe wrote that it was she who kept it, and not the town.

On 25 an t-Samhain, LE 1,803, the harbour scribe of Seann Skell went down to Cidhe an Diosail with his board and his pen for the empty-harbour rite. The dressed stones of the old quay were green at the foot, where the river had been working at them for eighteen centuries. He counted the people standing on them, and it did not take him long. There were eleven. When the rite and Manannan's prayer were said and the people had gone home, he looked at the sky and at the

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1. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

2. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

water, and wrote down the number, the weather and the state of the tide. He sat a while with the pen in his hand before he closed the board.

Clann Choinnich did not bring its silver petition to the council again, for the member who had turned the vote had died. The petition lay in the vein-house unanswered, and the record of the age ends with the Small-Burning Law still kept.

In those last winters the priests of Manannan at Seann Skell wrote that the mist on the eastern sea, which had hidden Dia-thìr from every ship beyond it since the fleet sailed into it, lay thinner each year. On 27 an Dàmhair, LE 1,813, they set it down in so many words, and they said their prayer at every tide.

A fisher of the north-west coast, putting out before dawn on one of those still mornings, rested on her oars off the headland where the rule of sight-of-land told her to turn. All her life the grey had stood out there on the water like a wall of wet fleece, and the sea ran into it and did not come out. That morning she could see through it. Beyond the grey lay a line, hard and dark and level, ruled across the edge of the world: the open sea, going on. She looked at it for a long time. Then she turned for home as the rule said, and from the quay she heard the priests at their prayer. Manannan, keep the sea shut.

Eighteen centuries after a queen at Cathair dhearg said she would keep no one back, Dia-thìr had kept the vein and kept the law, and had let go of nearly everything else the fleet had meant: the keel and the stars, the far coast, all but eleven keepers of the rite. The houses were fewer and richer. The north-west was nearly empty. For two hundred years the prayer to keep the sea shut had been said, and no one had tried the sea; and now, each winter, the mist that had hidden the island lay a little thinner on the water, and the priests at Seann Skell prayed at every tide.





THE FIFTH BOOK

# AN AOIS CHOIGREACH

*the Age of Strangers*

AE 1 – 151

*Thàinig na coigrich air an t-sàl, agus dh'fhàg iad an cnoc falamb.*

The strangers came over the brine, and they left the hill empty.  
— a line sung in the camps, as the copyists at Muileann chaol set it  
down

*Here is told the history of Dia-thìr from the Crossing to the Severance: the hundred and fifty years in which men from over the eastern sea ruled the island, first by leave and then without it. It is drawn from four witnesses: the rolls of the custodians, most of which live now only in the copies made in a cellar of Muileann chaol; the letter-books of the humans' Administration, left lying in the Residency when its masters fled; the daybooks of the beacon-keepers, who wrote down every sail they saw; and the songs of the camps, which were forbidden, and were written down for that reason. Where the witnesses quarrel, both are heard. Where they fall silent, the telling falls silent with them.*

I

## Of the Three Ships and the Leave to Stay

**T**he age begins with the Crossing, on 5 am Faoilleach, AE 1, when the humans first made landfall on Dia-thìr. That winter Manannan's mist lifted

from the northern water, which had lain on the eastern sea since the fleet of the Sundering sailed into it and had hidden the island from every ship beyond. The humans' land lies east of Dia-thìr, over that sea, and nearer than any Dia-thìreach had guessed; but on the straight way between, the mist has never cleared. The one road through it that the humans ever found ran north-about, out past the north cape and down again on the north-west of the island, and so it was off the north-west that the strangers first raised the land, and every harbour of the Crossing was a harbour of the west coast. The fishers of Achadh àrsaidh saw it go, and theirs is the first telling.

Two boats were out that morning, working the lines off the north-west cape, where the old men say the Sea-Watcher rises when it pleases. The mist stood on the water as it had stood all their lives, a grey wall a few oar-lengths off. But that morning the wall had gone to gauze, and behind the gauze there was a paleness that moved.

It was sail; then three sails, heaped high on masts taller than any tree the fishers knew, and under them black hulls, wet and shining, coming on slowly down from the north with the mist tearing off their bows in rags. A voice called down from high up in a tongue that was no tongue at all.

The steersman stood and gave back the old hail of the north-west boats. The voice answered. Neither understood a word of the other. Nothing in all the customs of Dia-thìr told a fisherman what to do when the sea opened. At last the steersman put his tiller over and turned south for Cuan shean, where there were custodians whose business it was to know. When he looked back, the three ships were following.

The place of that meeting is called Coinneachadh nan Long<sup>1</sup>, the meeting of the ships (13 am Faoilleach, AE 1), and the boats of Achadh àrsaidh slow there still.

The roll of Cuan shean, which is the fuller witness, first sets the ships down on 5 an Gearran, AE 1: three hulls down from the north riding at anchor off the town, the first of their size seen from any shore of the island since the fleet of the Sundering went out sunwise from the harbour and did not come back. Their master came in through the surf in a small boat with eleven men and no weapon among them that anyone could see. The roll calls him Edmund Harrow. He waded the last of the way, stood on the shingle in front of the custodians of the town, and held out an empty cask and tipped his hand to his mouth.

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1. the meeting of the ships

They gave him water. More than that they would not give on their own word, for no custodian living had ever been asked such a thing, and they sent a rider inland to the capital for counsel. For forty days the strangers were fed on the beach and kept below the dunes.

On 11 am Faoilleach, AE 2, the Council of Custodians at Cathair dhearg gave the strangers leave to stay. The council had sat in the crown's place since the crown fell vacant at the close of the Age of Sundering, and its high custodian in those years was Tormod mac Ailein. The roll enters the vote as unanimous. In the margin a later hand has written that three custodians were absent. The copyists kept the note, for it is the first of many places in the record of this age where what was written and what was so do not quite meet.

Soon the old sailors of Cuan shean began to say that the strangers had come in from the very quarter of the sea into which the Sundering fleet had sailed. The council forbade the remark in its hall. It was written down anyway, and never answered. Whether the humans were children of the departed, or of some other people of those waters, or of no one the Dia-thìrich ever knew, the island has never learned.

## II

### Of the Season of Words

**T**he strangers had a name for their homeland in their own tongue, and no Dia-thìreach scribe troubled to set it down. From the first season the rolls call it *an Tìr Thall*<sup>1</sup>, the land beyond, and call its people simply the humans; and so they are called in this book. They had brought their god with them over the sea: Crìosd<sup>2</sup>, one God and no other, with priests and a Bible and a great company of saints. The Dia-thìrich called that faith *an Eaglais*, the Church, after the word its clerics used, and the name has held.

Then came the season of words, when the clerics of the Church and the custodians sat down together to make a common tongue out of two. What was agreed in that season neither side has handed down whole. Two lists were kept, side by side.

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1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

2. Christ

The custodian Gormshuil nic Fhearchair kept the Dia-thìreach list. Through that season she sat across a table from the cleric Samuel Wren, a thin, courteous man who coughed in the damp, and the two of them pointed at things. He held up a cup and said his word, and she wrote it; she held up bread and said *aran*, and he wrote that. Before the season was out they had some hundreds of words each.

Then one morning Gormshuil tipped a basket of broken coal out on the table where the window-light fell, a double handful from the vein, black as a wet crow and bright with a sheen, the colours shining at the edges where it had split.

She began to name the colours. There was the green that lies under the black like deep water under weed, and the red at the break that deepens if you breathe on it, and the grey-violet of old cuttings, and the brown that means the piece came from near the surface; and she laid a finger on each and gave its word, as any child of the hills could have done. She gave forty, and there were more, and she stopped because Wren had stopped writing.

He picked up a piece and turned it in the light with his eyes narrowed, and looked at her in a puzzled, kindly way. Then he said a single word, and wrote a single word, and tapped the whole heap with his pen to show that the word stood for all of it.

When she understood the word she sat very still. It was the word for the fuel his people burned at home.

She waited for him to ask for hers. He smiled, and set the coal aside to make room on the table, and held up a candle.

Wren's list lies still in the Administration's letter-books. Gormshuil's was lost, and only its first leaf lives on, in a copy: forty words for the colours of broken coal. Her copyist wrote beneath it a thing the chroniclers have since set at the head of the whole age. The humans had one word for the coal of the vein, and it was their word for the black fuel of their own hearths. No Dia-thìris word in either list answered to it, for to Dia-thìreach eyes no coal of the vein is only black. And the humans did not ask for one.

### III

## Of the Years of Fair Exchange

Let it be told plainly, since what came after has thrown its shadow back across them: the first years were good. The island had been alone for eighteen cen-

turies and lacked much that the strangers had, and the giving ran both ways. For a few years the bargain looked as if it would last, and those who trusted it were no fools.

The humans set up a trading post at Ros dhomhain, the capital's harbour on the lake. Iron tools went across its counter, and window glass, lamp-oil and paper; wool came back, and salt fish, hides and dyed cloth. Its first tally-book, kept by the trader Thomas Pike, balances to the last line across its first year. The smiths of Cathair dhearg took the humans' bar-iron gladly and learned to temper it in a single winter, and within a few seasons the old bronze hoes of the capital's fields were melted down for bells. The salt-pans of Seann Warr sold to Pike by the barrel, and theirs was the first Dia-thìreach trade the humans came back asking for twice.

Harrow sailed for home with hides and cloth in his holds and came back with four ships in place of three. He brought carpenters, and a surgeon, and a letter from a trading house in an Tìr Thall<sup>1</sup> asking what else the island had. The surgeon, Jonas Tull, set the broken leg of a Cuan shean fisherman whom the whole town had given up for lame, and the custodian of Cuan shean entered it in the roll as the first debt owed to a stranger.

In AE 5 the small port of Baile dhìreach, on the south-west coast, took Dia-thìrich and humans alike under one council of six, three of either people. Its founding compact was written twice, once in each tongue, and it is the only such compact of the age. The chair passed in alternate years between the fisherman Iain mac Chaluim and the human carpenter William Rook, and the harbour dues went half to the custodians and half to the humans' post.

At Baile dhìreach the net-maker Eilidh nic Ruairidh married the human cooper Samuel Hale. The council entered the marriage in both its books. The custodians at Cathair dhearg, asked for a ruling on it, sent none. No other town tried what Baile dhìreach had tried, and the tellers will come back to that marriage when they reach the years in which the humans' law found a use for it.

In AE 6 a human supply ship struck the western reefs in fog and nine of her crew were drowned. Her master had been sailing, the letter-books complain, by a chart drawn from memory on a coast lit only by the old driftwood fires. The human navigators asked for beacons, and the Dia-thìreach engineers agreed, and did not yet see what the asking would bring. The navigator James Fenn and the Dia-

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1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

thìreach mason Torcall Clachair walked the coast together that year to choose the ground. They marked the five headlands of the old fires. Fenn's chart survives. Torcall's cairns, for the most part, have gone back into the hills.

#### IV

### Of the Treaty in One Tongue, and the Company

**I**n AE 8 the terms of the humans' presence were set down in writing for the first time, in the humans' tongue only, and no one on the Dia-thìreach side is known to have spoken against it.

Tormod mac Ailein came to the council hall at Cathair dhearg on the day of the signing, 7 an Cèitean, AE 8, and sat down at the long table across from Josiah Pell, newly come over the sea as the humans' first Commissioner. Between them lay the treaty, covered edge to edge in the strangers' close black writing.

Tormod could not read a word of it. The letters stood on the page like a fence of thorn. Someone read it to him, and he sat with his hands folded and listened as the voice went down the sheets, and once he asked for a line to be read again. Outside the rain was coming off the lake.

When the reading was done Pell turned the last sheet round and held out a pen. Tormod took it. He looked a long moment at the place where his name should go, as a man looks at a ford before he wades it. Then he wrote, and Pell signed after him for the Administration.

The treaty was dated by the humans' day, month and year. The custodians' clerk entered it in the roll under its year of the Diosal and the moon in which it was signed, and left the day empty, having nothing to put there. It was the first of many such pages. Within a generation every clerk on the island wrote two dates at the head of his page, and the crews in the Company's pits had learned the humans' week before they learned their prayers, because they were paid by it.

Pell built a house of dressed stone on the rise above Ros dhomhain and called it the Residency, and from it the humans governed Dia-thìr for a hundred and forty years. Harrow went back to the sea, and with Pike he founded a trading house licensed by the Administration, which the island knew only as the Company. Its charter gave it first refusal on "all fuels, ores and minerals the island may yield." Its first building of its own was a stone warehouse at Cathair dhomhain,

along the lake shore, where it kept its tools out of reach of the harbour thieves. The copyists ask the reader to remember that warehouse.

The strangers' fever came ashore at Cuan shean with a crowded ship in AE 9 and ran down the west coast. Ninety-one Dia-thìrich died of it, by the custodians' count, and eleven humans. The custodians shut Cuan shean to ships for a season, and Pell protested in writing.

In AE 10 the Company sent two prospectors, Abel Stone and Hugh Mercer, into the hills east of the capital, the country of Muileann chrom. They came down again with sacks of broken coal on their backs and word that the black seam ran "further than can be walked in a day." The custodians demanded the coal back, to be laid in the rock again with the proper words. The Company gave back half. The roll enters the other half as "carried west."

In AE 11 barter gave way to contract. Under the first contracts of extraction Dia-thìreach hands began to cut the vein on a scale that no reverent keeping had ever used. A crew of thirty opened the first pit at Muileann chrom, paid by the ton in iron tools and lamp-oil, where the custodians' own cuttings had never once been measured by weight. The Company built a coal quay at Ceann fhada, a fishing hamlet below the hills, and paid the fishermen for their foreshore in iron nails, by weight. Wren finished his grammar of Dia-thìris for the Mission, which was the Church's mission to the island. It is careful and right in most things, and it turns the name of the vein's custodians into "keepers of the coal." The Mission raised a chapel on the quay at Ros dhomhain and hung in it the first iron bell on Dia-thìr, and the custodians asked that it not be rung before the fishing fleet was out.

In AE 14 one settlement would not sign.

The Company's agent climbed to Doire mhòr, in the hills above Muileann chrom, with the contract under his coat. The custodian, Beathag Dhubh, met him at her door and did not ask him in. She let him say all he had come to say, and answered him in a few words, and shut the door.

Her words live only in his report, where he set them down in his own tongue: that the hill was not hers to sell, and not his to buy.

Doire mhòr was not punished. The Company opened its next working at Cnoc fhiadhaich instead, and ran its cart-road round Doire mhòr's fields rather than through them. The annals add two words: *for now*.

The first of the new beacons was finished in AE 15 on the southern headland at Tobar dhearg, a round tower of grey stone raised over the old fire-tower and paid for by the Company. Torcall Clachair built it and Fenn set its lens.

In AE 17 the humans brought in their coin beside the barter of the island, for convenience, they said: the mark and its hundred pence, struck at Ros dhomhain from metal shipped in from an Tìr Thall<sup>1</sup>, with a ship on one face and nothing of Dia-thìr on either. At the capital the custodians' clerks began to keep two sets of books, and complained of it in both. Within ten years nothing that came across the sea could be had for anything but marks.

Wren spent a winter at Dùn thais among the druids of Feallsanachd an Fhèidh<sup>2</sup>, the school of the deer. He asked them why the vein should be holy. They asked him why his fuel should be burned. Neither side's account names a winner. Wren wrote home that the druids told of a voyage west to an isle of the blessed very like his own Church's telling of Naomh Breandan, told from the other shore, and that he did not know what to make of it.

The Harbour Articles followed, written like the treaty in the humans' tongue alone, and they fixed the dues at Ros dhomhain in the Company's favour. This time two custodians refused to sign. The council granted the Administration upland grazing in the north-west, around Muileann àrsaidh, for human families who would not work in the pits. The grant was for grazing. The families built houses of stone.

Tormod mac Ailein died at Cathair dhearg in AE 20, and the council chose Coinneach Glas of Ceann àrsaidh to follow him, a man who had never met a human before the Crossing and had dealt with little else since. In AE 21 Edmund Harrow's ship did not come home from the crossing. The Company passed wholly into Pike's hands, and the letter-books mourned Harrow as the man who found Dia-thìr.

## V

### Of the Lapse of the Law, and the First Steward

**T**he keepers at the hearths of the hills tell the end of the Small-Burning Law as they would tell of a fire that went out for want of feeding. That Law had

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1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland



been kept since the Holy Age: that the vein be cut and burned sparingly, and that what the hill could give in a year be counted and never exceeded. The Age of Sundering ended with it still kept. Within a generation of the Crossing it was gone. No council repealed it. It stopped being enforced when it stopped paying to enforce it. At Dùn dhearg the custodian Fionnghal nic Artair wrote to the council the only defence of the Law that has come down. The Law, she wrote, was made for the people more than for the coal, for a people becomes whatever its burning makes it.

At Seann Skell the hawk-priest Murchadh Seabhag preached that Mòd, the Hungry Hawk of Acaill, starves those who eat faster than the land can feed them. The sermon was copied and carried into the camps, and it was the first Dia-thìreach writing the Company's agents were told to seize. At Muileann chom the Company burned coal by the cartload to drive its pumps, and when Coinneach Glas's council asked that the old tally be kept, it was sent a copy of the Company's accounts.

Pell sailed home in AE 24 and did not return. Henry Maddox came in his place, with orders to double the yield and a letter in his pocket promising him a share of it. In AE 25 a gallery at Cnoc fhiadhaich, driven forward faster than any Dia-thìreach crew would have chosen and without the timbering the crews had begged for, came down and killed eleven. The custodians' roll names all eleven. The Company's report names none, and calls the gallery "unsound ground." Then a dry cough ran through the camps and killed thirty-eight, most of them boys who broke coal at the pit-mouth. The Mission's surgeon called it a winter complaint. It lasted through the summer.

The second beacon was lit at Baile ìseal on the eastern shore, with Torcall Clachair directing the work from a chair at the foot of the headland, too old now to climb. The Company founded a camp of timber huts at Àth ìseal, the first settlement on Dia-thìr built for no purpose but the pit. It dammed the stream that watered Doire mhòr to wash its coal. No order for it was ever found. Beathag Dhubh's people carried water up by hand for two summers, and then they began to leave. In AE 30 the hill villages lost their oats to rain that no one was home to cut ahead of, and the Company sold them meal for marks, and they had few marks.

From AE 31 the mountain was worked by the ton. The Company was chartered anew in an Tìr Thall<sup>1</sup> under a name the Dia-thìrich never used, and at

Ros dhomhain its agents outnumbered the Administration's clerks four to one. Coal barges loaded at Cidhe Beag on Abhainn uaine, where the old canoe landing was widened with cut stone and its shrine carried uphill out of the way. Within a few seasons the green river ran black with slurry and the salmon at its mouth failed, and the fishermen kept the river's name and said it bitterly. Baile dhomhain was laid out on a grid by a Company surveyor, the first Dia-thìreach town drawn on paper before a stone of it was set. On the coal road the old carters' house at the halfway stage was rebuilt and kept its name, An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, and its keeper Seònaid Bhàn took marks and barter both, the only keeper on the road who would. Seann Toll was made a coal landing for the barges on the Abhainn uaine, and its fishing boats were moved to the next reach.

In AE 36 a Dia-thìreach was set over Dia-thìreach miners to answer to human masters, and the chroniclers count it the first crack within the Dia-thìrich themselves. He was Ragnall mac Dhòmhnaill of Muileann chrom, a crew-leader since the first contract. The Company gave him its staff and a house with a slate roof, and the Dia-thìrich gave him his byname: Ragnall Maor, Ragnall the steward. Soon there were overseers at every working in the district, and the roll stopped giving their names and gave only their number. At Cnoc mhòr the overseer Seumas Dubh was killed by his own crew after a boy was crushed on a haulage he had ordered hurried, and the Company hanged two men at Ros dhomhain. It was the first hanging the Administration did on Dia-thìr.

Maddox barred the priests of the hawk from the camps in AE 38, on the ground that their preaching slowed the work. The overseers enforced it; several of them were hawk-faithful themselves, and the roll says so. A spotted pox came up the coal road from the quays of Ros dhomhain. The Mission counted four hundred and six dead. The custodians counted more, and wrote the difference in the margin of the Mission's list. The Administration moved its customs house from Baile dhìreach to Ros dhomhain, and the mixed council there, left with half an income, shrank from six to four. In AE 41 Maddox left Dia-thìr a rich man, and Arthur Lisle, a lawyer, came to the Residency. His first act was to have every agreement since the treaty copied into a single bound book.

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2. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

VI

## Of the Silver Compact, and the Things the Clerks Could Not File

Reading that book closely, Lisle found in it nothing whatever about silver.

When the Company's surveyors came up the valley to Muileann chiar with their chains and pegs, Ùna nic Choinnich was waiting for them at the mouth of the adit. Behind her, filling the yard and the slope above it, stood the whole membership of the guild in their leather aprons, not one of them speaking, and two of the eldest held the guild's ledgers open across their forearms.

The chief surveyor began to read out his authority. Ùna let him finish. Then she turned the first ledger toward him, and the second, and asked him, in his own tongue and quite pleasantly, to find the humans' name anywhere in either.

He looked. The yard waited, and the wind came down off the hill with the smell of the smelting-floors in it. After a while the surveyor closed his book, and the Company's men went back down the valley.

On Là Fhèill Bhrìde of AE 44 Lisle signed a compact that left the seam to the town. It was the first writing of the age in which the Dia-thìreach side kept the better terms, and Muileann chiar held its silver in its own hand through all the rest of the age. When a Company coal ship was taken off the eastern coast by raiders in low black boats and burned to the waterline, the Company said the guild had paid them. The guild said nothing.

The third beacon was lit at Àth dhearg in AE 45, and its keeper, Tormod mac Pheadair, kept a daybook of every ship he saw. From his book, and the books of the keepers after him, the sailings of the humans in this age are known; and the copyists have leaned on the daybooks more than on any other witness, for a keeper has nothing to gain from a ship that is not there.

In AE 47 the council of Baile dhìreach broke up in a quarrel over a boundary wall and never sat again. The human families went to Ros bheag and Ros dhomhain; the Dia-thìrich stayed. The households that were both split, or went quiet. The next year the rain failed for a single season around Achadh shean, and it was a warning nobody heeded.

At Dùn thais in AE 49 the Deer master Aonghas mac Coinnich put to his students a question the register calls new: why the humans could not see the colour in broken coal that every Dia-thìreach child sees. He did not answer it, and told

them it was the wrong question. Its form in the Deer books has been quoted ever since:

*Carson a chì sinne an dath, is iadsan dall air?*

Why do we see the colour, and they blind to it?

On the concession the human families founded a market town at Cathair gheal under a charter that made no mention of the custodians. In AE 51 the family of Eachann Mòr, a custodian of Ceann àrsaidh who had lost his seat, sent their son Calum over the sea on a Company ship hoping his schooling would buy them better treatment. He never came home. The Mission opened a school at Ros dhomhain in the humans' tongue, and most of its pupils were the children of overseers. The Company rebuilt the old bridge over the river at Ros fhionn for its eastern coal road.

Two things the Administration's clerks never knew where to file. The crew of a Company brig reported a beast larger than their ship off the north-western headlands; the clerk put the report in with the complaints about pirates, and the sailors of that coast said they had wondered when the humans would see it. And two Company surveyors went up into the hills at Doire uaine against the villagers' advice and were not seen again.

In AE 57 the Administration's share of the coal rose sharply, and what the Diathìreach towns received did not rise with it. Lisle's schedule took the portion from one part in five to one part in three, and the custodians received it in the humans' tongue with a translation made by a Mission pupil. A bloody flux broke out on the Ros dhomhain quays; the Mission's nurse Anne Colby turned the chapel into a sick-house, and the record credits her with keeping the dead under two hundred. Lisle died at the Residency in AE 61, and Walter Crane, the Company's chief agent at the pits, took the seal after him, the first man to hold both offices in turn.

Raghnall Maor died in AE 62, and the Company gave his staff to his son Dòmhnall. The custodians had hoped the office would die with the man. It became a family's inheritance instead.

The fourth beacon was lit at Muileann bheag in AE 63. It was the first to burn coal in place of oil, and its flame laid a colour on the water that no oil lamp ever had. The Mission cleric Edwin Lowe dug that season at Làrach an Teampaill<sup>1</sup> and

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1. the temple ruin

found cut stone, burnt bone and marks he could not read, and wrote that the ruin's builders "were not the present race." The custodians agreed with him, and added nothing. Of how the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>2</sup> ended, his spade turned up nothing.

In AE 67 the Company agent Martha Gale offered the silver guild a partnership, on terms its own ledger calls generous. Ùna nic Choinnich was very old by then. She had the offer read aloud twice in the guild hall, slowly, and then put it to a show of hands, and the hands refused it. At the turn of the next year a new camp was opened at Achadh dhomhain for the deep galleries. Its houses were built of spoil.

## VII

### Of the Smoke in the Gallery, the Child in the Camps, and the Green Death

**W**hen the women of the camps tell of the Green Death, they begin with a child, for she was born in the same years and the same dust, and the one tale has grown into the other. And when they tell of the child, they begin with her father, and with what he met in the dark.

His name was Donnchadh mac Thormoid, and he was a hewer. His grandfather Ruairidh had stood behind Beathag Dhubh at Doire mhòr on the day she sent the Company's agent back down the hill. His father Tormod had carried water up to Doire mhòr for two summers after the Company took the stream, and then gone down with the rest to the huts at Àth iséal; and there Donnchadh was born, and broke coal at the pit-mouth before he could read, and went below at twelve. When the Company opened its camp at Achadh dhomhain for the deep galleries under the hill (AE 68), he went with the first crews. The pay was better below. It always is where the dying is.

In the first winter of that camp he was working a face at the far end of the deepest gallery, alone, with a coal-lamp hung on a nail behind him. The Company had sunk a shaft from the hillside to draw the air, and a draught came along the gallery from it all day long, cold and steady, so that the flame of his lamp lay over on its side and the dust of his cutting went away from him in a thin drift toward the dark.

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2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

He stopped to spit, and turned, and saw that the drift was parting.

Something was standing in the gallery between him and the shaft. It was the height of a tall man, and it was grey, and it was made of smoke, such smoke as a peat fire gives in a shut room. The draught went past it on either side. His lamp flame streamed and the dust streamed, and the smoke that stood in the middle of them did not stir by a thread.

Every child of the hills has heard of the smoke in the grove. Donnchadh had heard it on his grandmother's knee, with the Hollow Man and the white stag, and had put it away with them when he went below. He did not run. There was nowhere to run but past it, and he said afterward that he had not wanted to.

"You are Tormod's son," it said. Its voice was low and very clear, and the draught did not carry it off.

"I am."

"And Somhairle's, and Ailean's." It seemed to him to be looking about the gallery, at the black walls and the props and the cut face, as a guest looks round a house where things have gone badly. "They are taking the hill."

"They are," said Donnchadh.

"I will not fight for the kin. I never have; that is not my charge. But I was set to keep the kin, and a kin with its hill dug out from under it is not kept." It came nearer, and he smelt it: a hearth in the morning, when the fire has been banked all night. "I made a promise once, in the grove, to the one you come from. Breathe."

He breathed, because it had told him to. The smoke went into him with the dust of the gallery, and it was warm, and it went down into his chest and stayed there, like a coal carried home under a cloak.

"What is it?" he said, when he could speak.

"A gift. It is not for you. You will carry it, and the carrying will not be easy. It will wake in your daughter." The draught had begun to move through it, and it was thinning. "It is in the dust of the deep places now, for every one of the kin who goes down; and where it wakes, it wakes. Tell no one of it but the one who will bear the child."

Then the draught went through the place where it had stood, and his lamp flame lay over again on its side, and there was nothing in the gallery but the dust.

He coughed from that day. It was a deep cough, and he brought up black with it, and he grew thin through the spring, and the men of his crew moved their bread away from him at the break. The Mission's surgeon listened at his chest and wrote him down with the miners' lung, the dust-rot the humans knew from the

pits of their own country, which the crews called the lung-rot; and he gave him a year. The coal of Dia-thìr rots the lungs of the humans as their own coal does. It does not rot the lungs of the kin in that way, and what Donnchadh carried was no rot at all. But it looked like one to a physician who could not see the colour in the coal, and nobody else was asked.

On 7 am Màrt, AE 69, his daughter was born in a house of spoil at Achadh dhomhain. That night Donnchadh's cough stopped, and it never came back. He told his wife then what he had met in the gallery, and in time she told the women of the camp; and that is all the witness there is, and the camps have never asked for more.

The child's whole life long she was steeped in more raw coal than any Dia-thìreach in living memory, and she did not age as the people around her aged. Her name was Aisling, and she was the first child of the camps whom the years did not touch. Of her the rolls give three things, her birth, her name and her condition. The camps gave her more.

It was the women who laid out the camp's dead who first said it, over the washing, as they said most things: that the child was of the old king's blood. They meant Ailean Mòr, whom the gods crowned in the grove, who was king four thousand years and more and fell at the Ford of Blood, and whose children lived thousands of years. Not one of them believed a word of the thousands of years. Ailean Mòr was a tale for the dark of the year, the scribes of the Hall had set him among the tellings long ago, and nobody in the camps had ever heard the Line of the Mason said. But the years went over the child and left her as they found her, and the whisper grew with her. In the camps they called her *nighean an rìgh*, the king's daughter, half in jest, and *Aisling-aois* came to be said there of anyone who kept her youth; and half not. A people whose hill is going out in ships will take its hope where it finds it, and the camps found theirs in an old tale and a girl of the spoil-houses who did not grow old. Nobody could prove a word of it. That came later, and is told in its place.

The next year the Company set up a great steelyard on the quay at Ros dhomhain, and from then on the island's yield was known by the ton, and the custodians' old count, kept in seasons of labour, was no longer entered. What was happening to the child had no name in any tongue on the island, and decades passed before anyone tried to find one. At Cill ghlas the custodians of Brìde's flame kept the old rites of the flame and the stone at the mouth of the oldest cutting, while the pits deepened all around them. It was the last shrine in the district the crews

still climbed to on the old feast days, at Samhain and Imbolc, Bealltainn and Lùnastal. Remember it.

In AE 73 came A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>1</sup>, the Green Death.

It showed first at Achadh dhomhain. A man would go pale with a greenish cast, like a candle seen through bottle-glass; then came a cough that brought up dark dust; then weakness. The camp buried forty in the first month, in a field beyond the spoil-heaps that is called the green acre to this day. It went out along the coal roads from the camps at Muileann chrom, Àth ìseal and Cnoc fhiadhaich, and it fell hardest on Ros dhìreach, Ceann òg, Inis ìseal, Baile dhomhain, Achadh fhada, Cnoc bheag, Muileann uaine, Cuan àrsaidh and Inis bhàn. Twenty-six settlements set down cases. The roll lists them, and leaves a blank line after the last, as though waiting for another. At Àth ghlas the custodians burned every hut in which anyone had died, bedding and all, over the Company's protest at the loss of its property, and there the sickness stopped sooner than anywhere else.

The dust was blamed, and no study was ever finished. The Administration's physician Nathaniel Bright began one at Muileann chrom, weighing the dust in the lungs of the dead. He fell ill in its second season, and his notebooks break off in the middle of a table. Commissioner Crane, who had walked the camps through the worst of it, died of it at the Residency in AE 75, and Martha Gale held his seal until George Tolley came over the sea, with orders that the yield must not fall. Tolley never visited the camps. His letter-book blames the dust, the Diathìreach habit of sleeping near the fire, and the custodians' shrines, in that order.

The hawk-priests were still barred, so the crews carried the sermons in their own mouths, and the overseers' reports of those years list hawk-feathers nailed above hut doors as a matter for discipline. The saying of the feathered doors outlived every report:

*Ithidh Mòd an neach a dh'itheas an cnoc.*

Mòd will eat whoever eats the hill.

Anne Colby opened sick-houses at Àth ìseal and Achadh dhomhain and nursed in them until the sickness ebbed. Of all the humans on the island she is the only one the camp people name in their own tellings of the plague, and they name her kindly.

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1. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'



VIII

Of the Eleven Days of Baile thais

**C**atrìona nic Eachainn called the halt on a grey morning in AE 77, standing on an upturned coal-tub at the pithead of Baile thais with the whole shift below her.

She had asked the Company to close the galleries where the Green Death had been worst, and had been told that the yield must not fall. So she told the crews what she had told the agent, and then she stepped down off the tub and sat on it, and folded her arms, and did not go below.

Nobody went below. By noon the word had gone round every hut in the town, and the winding-gear stood still, and the coal-carts stood in a line on the rails with nothing in them. The agent came up and shouted in two tongues, and the crews sat on the spoil-heaps in the thin rain and listened to him politely.

For eleven days no coal left Baile thais. Each evening Catrìona walked the town and counted the loaves in the windows, and knew what the agent knew: that there was one store in Baile thais, and it was the Company's. Each day the shelves were barer. On the twelfth morning she went down to it herself and looked through the shutters at the empty shelves, and then she walked back up to the pithead and told the crews to go below.

After it the Company built its own granary at Muileann chrom and forbade the camps to keep more grain than a week's ration, and the order was signed by Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill Maor. Catrìona was turned out of Baile thais and refused work at every Company pit. She went east over the hills to Muileann chiar, and the silver guild took her on as a refiner. The Company asked for her back. The guild's answer was filed, and has not been kept.

The Administration built a new bath-house at the hot springs near Muileann ruadh for officials recovering from fevers. The Dia-thìrich, who had bathed there for centuries, were let in on certain days for a penny. The silver town grew, for the humans wanted both metals, and in AE 82 the guild founded a daughter town to the west for its refiners and carters, under the same name; the record calls them the old town and the new, and does not always say which it means. The guild sold bar silver to the Company at a price the guild fixed, and it was the only thing on Dia-thìr in all the age priced by Dia-thìreach hands.

At Tolley's asking the priests of Òrd Mhacha<sup>1</sup> at Cathair dhearg, the capital's own order and the crown's, blessed the Residency's new coin. Macha's priesthood teaches that the two horses of her rite, Dubh Sainglenn the black and Liath Macha the grey, each have their due, the dark and the light; the dissenting priests said the coin was only one of them. In AE 86 barter was cheapened against the mark a second time, on terms set wholly by the Administration. In AE 87 the dissenting priests left the capital's temple for the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag, where custodians who had lost their seats found a welcome. And Dòmhnall Maor died, and his son Iain took the staff: the first overseer schooled at the Mission, who kept his reports in the humans' tongue and his household in Dia-thìris.

## IX

## Of the Levy, the Ring of Beacons, and the Great Hunger

**T**he hunger of Baile chrom is told in the north-west by the beacon-keepers' families, and they begin it with a piece of paper. On 4 am Faoilleach, AE 88, Tolley issued the ordinance the Dia-thìrich called simply the Levy. Every farming village in the west and north was to send one in five of its able men and women to the pits for two years, and be paid for them in marks, at the new rate. It fell hardest on the villages round Baile chrom and on the northern concession, which had never sent crews to the pits. The Dia-thìrich of the concession were taken. Its human farmers were exempt.

Tolley closed the hall of Feallsanachd an Fhèidh<sup>1</sup> at Dùn thais in AE 89, over a lecture on whether the humans' blindness to the colour of the coal might be a kind of sickness. The masters went on teaching in their own houses, to smaller rooms each year, and some went out under the trees of the sacred forest of Flidais near Muileann chiar, where there was no hall to shut.

Work began on the fifth and last beacon at Baile chrom, and the masons were taken by the Levy from the very villages whose fields they left unworked. The ring was finished in AE 91: Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>2</sup>, Baile ìseal, Muileann bheag, Àth dhearg and Tobar dhearg. It had been asked for so that ships should not be lost on the reefs. By the time it was done it served a trade that was plunder in all but

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1. the order of Macha

1. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

2. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

name. The Baile chrom beacon was lit with a coal flame in AE 91, and the day-books show the sailings doubling in the years after.

In AE 94 the harvest failed. Gorta Baile chrom<sup>3</sup>, the Great Hunger, went across thirty-four settlements, and it bit the deeper because the Levy had stripped the countryside of the hands to farm it. It was worst at Baile chrom itself. From their empty fields its people could see the coal flame of the new tower moving on the sea at night; and the custodians recorded that more died at Baile chrom than anywhere else, and the Administration, which kept its own count, did not dispute the figure. A relief ship from an Tìr Thall<sup>4</sup> lay a month at Ros dhomhain with her holds full of grain while the Residency and the Company argued over who should pay to unload her. The Mission opened kitchens meanwhile at Cath-air gheal and Baile chrom, and Anne Colby, come back to the island, ran the one at Baile chrom. The Levy was suspended in the famine districts in AE 97, too late for the harvest. It was never repealed, and never used again, and the custodians note that it never needed to be, since the villages had learned what it meant.

Tolley retired with honours in AE 98. Robert Haskins, who came after him, ordered that the custodians' council be consulted on the tithe, and then set the tithe before the council had met.

In AE 99 the custodians acted together for the first time. Nineteen settlements sent their custodians to Ceann àrsaidh, and there, meeting as one body, they drew up a formal grievance to lay before the Administration.

Peigi Ghlas, the custodian of Cill ghlais, carried it to the Residency. She was kept waiting on a bench in a stone passage that smelled of lamp-soot, and at last was shown to a young clerk at a high desk. He took the petition from her, and thanked her, and laid it on a pile, and bent to his work again. She stood a moment longer. Then she went home.

It was not answered.

From these years come the oldest Dia-thìreach writings of grievance that survive. They are grievances as yet and no more, the first written word that something had gone wrong. The earliest is Leabhar Baile thais<sup>5</sup>, a book of complaints kept by many hands over some years: wages, deaths, the granary, the stream at Doire mhòr. At Muileann dhearg the poet Fearchar Bàrd, who had broken coal since boyhood, made songs of the Levy and the famine. The overseers forbade

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3. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

4. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

5. the book of Baile thais, the book of grievances

them, and the forbidding is why several were written down. They were sung in the roadside houses of the east, and An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>6</sup> became known for them, and the Company's own carters sang them over their ale without always knowing what they sang. When the Company built its deep-water quay at Ros dhomhain for the new iron steamships, which burned the island's own coal to carry it away, Fearchar made the song that is quoted most of all his songs:

*Tha an long ag ithe a' chnuic gus an cnoc a gbiùlan air falbh.*

The ship is eating the hill to carry the hill away.

The Company walled its pithead at Baile thais and set a gate in the wall and a watchman at the gate to count who went in, and it was the first working on Dia-thìr walled against its own crews. Catrìona nic Eachainn died at Muileann chiar in AE 104, a refiner of the silver guild to the end, and when the camp people of Baile thais sent a delegation to her burying, the Company docked each of them a day's pay. In AE 105 a fire in the Company's coal sheds burned three days and took two streets of the harbour quarter with it. The Company's inquiry found no cause. The harbour quarter's own account has several. That year the council, on the death of its high custodian, could not agree on another, and sat for years with the seat empty, and Haskins wrote to an Tìr Thall that this made it easier to deal with.

## X

### Of the Long Drought, and the Law of One Line

**I**n AE 106 came Tiormachd Achadh shean<sup>1</sup>, the Long Drought: three dry seasons one after another, the dry year of the east come back threefold. At Achadh shean the wells failed, and the cattle were driven west in a column the roll says was a day long, and fewer than half of them reached water. The roll counted ten districts as drought country, worst at Achadh shean, Àth uaine, Achadh àrsaidh and Muileann chiar, and reaching down to Cuan ruadh and west toward Baile chaol. The Administration kept no count of its own.

The spring of Allt an Àigh<sup>2</sup>, which is said never to have failed, did not fail. Pilgrims of Na Seann Spioradan<sup>3</sup> came to it from all across the east, the first of them

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6. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

at Bealltainn. The Administration posted a watchman at the spring to charge for the water. He was called back after a single season.

A fever of bad water followed the drought into the towns. It was worst at Baile Mòr ruadh, where the wells had been dug deeper into the old middens, and two hundred and sixty died there. The Mission's report was the first to name the cause rightly, and the Mission bored deep wells at Achadh shean and Àth chrom that held. The custodians of the east entered the Mission's wells and the Company's quotas on facing pages, and wrote nothing beside either. For the quota was not lowered. The custodians petitioned Haskins one by one, and he wrote back to each that the matter was under consideration.

In AE 111 a case came before the Administration that fixed the law of inheritance on Dia-thìr for the rest of the age. The claimant was Thomas Hale, grandson of the Baile dhìreach marriage of Eilidh nic Ruairidh and Samuel Hale, and he claimed a share in a customary cutting through his Dia-thìreach grandmother. The magistrate at Ros dhomhain, Oliver Dunstan, ruled that customary rights descend only through the line the Administration recognises, and that it recognises only its own. Within a few years that ruling had passed eleven customary cuttings to the Company, each because some owner in the line had married a human or been born to one. The custodians stopped entering such marriages in the roll. And so the marriage that Baile dhìreach had written into both its books became, a century on, the reason marriages were written into neither.

In AE 113 a society of pit crews that called itself the Lamp-Watch began to meet at Baile thais and Cnoc chaol under cover of a burial club. The first thing it is known to have done was to bury an old breaker who had died in the Company's lock-up.

Haskins was recalled in AE 114 after a quarrel with the Company over steamship berths, and Edward Vane came to the Residency. He was the first Commissioner born on Dia-thìr, at the Residency itself. He spoke Dia-thìris badly, but he spoke it. He laid the mule-drawn tram-road to Ros dhìreach, and before he died the Company's railway ran from the pits at Muileann chrom to the quay at Ros dhomhain, its engines burning the island's coal (22 am Màrt, AE 120).

In AE 116 came the night-shift order, and from then on the mountain was given no season of rest. It was felt first at Cnoc chaol, in the newest galleries, where the crews worked by coal-lamp in two shifts. The custodians' roll records that the

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1. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

2. the stream of the healing water

hill was given no silence at all, and leaves the rest of the page empty. The crews at Cnoc chaol refused the night shift and were replaced within a week by crews brought from the coast. The Lamp-Watch paid the strikers' families for a season, and then its money ran out. The Mission's minister at Ros dhomhain, Matthew Dunne, preached from the chapel pulpit that the Dia-thirich were right, and that even the ground must rest. The Company complained, and Dunne was called home to an Tír Thall<sup>4</sup>, and the Lamp-Watch copied his sermon and read it aloud in the camps.

A wasting sickness of the lungs spread among the night crews of Cnoc chaol and Baile thais. Unlike the Green Death it killed slowly. It killed the humans among the crews brought in from the coast, as the dust of their own country's pits had killed their fathers. The Dia-thìreach hewers coughed as hard, and the Mission's physicians wrote the same word against them; but the custodians' roll, which knew the crews by name, notes that of the Dia-thirich who coughed few died of it, and the old women of the camps called it Donnchadh's cough and would say no more. The Company paid the widows a pension for a year, and then stopped. In AE 119 Iain Maor wrote to the Company that the night shift was killing his crews faster than it paid for them. The letter survives because it was filed with his dismissal, which was reversed a month later for want of anyone else to do the work.

## XI

### Of the Second Child, and the Word that was Coined

**I**n AE 121 a second child was born who showed the same bond with the coal that Aisling had shown half a century before. His name was Fionnan. To those who kept the rolls his birth meant that the first had been no single mischance, and that the thing was being made by the pits themselves.

Seònaid nic Dhùghaill, the last master of the Deer to teach openly in the age, died at Dùn thais in AE 123, and the school's register ends with her. Nobody took it up again while the humans held the island.

In AE 124 the custodians of the east began to send copies of their rolls to Muileann chaol, which still kept Beathag nic Thòmais's loft of papers, well out of

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4. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

the Residency's reach. The copying was done in the houses of three families and the copies were kept in a cellar, and between the loft and the cellar the memory of the east was kept through the rest of the age.

On 23 am Faillleach, AE 126, the custodians met at the shrine of Cill ghlas to give the thing a name.

They came up the path in ones and twos through the evening, past the spoil-heaps, to where the oldest cutting still stood open in the hillside with Bride's lamp burning in its mouth. They sat on the benches of the shrine with their cloaks steaming, and all around them in the dark they could hear the pumps of the Company's pits.

There were two cases now, and nobody could call it chance. A wonder that comes twice is a sickness, and a sickness must have a name if a physician is to write it down.

They argued late. Some wanted an old word out of the tellings; some wanted none, for a name is a door. At last one of them put forward the plainest word there was: *fuil-ghuail*<sup>1</sup>, coal-blood. It was meant for a physician's register, a word to be written in a column, with no song in it. They took it by vote. In the humans' tongue it was rendered *coal-touched*.

It did not stay in the column.

The Residency, hearing of the word, ordered every Dia-thireach child who showed the condition to be reported to the Commissioner's office. The custodians complied by reporting none.

In AE 129 barter was abolished as lawful tender, and every bargain on the island from then on ran through the humans' coin. The barter houses of Ros dhomhain and Cathair dhearg were shut by order, and a Residency clerk wrote that the ledgers were now "complete for the first time." The hill villages borrowed marks from the Company's stores to buy seed, at interest, and within a few years most of them owed the Company more than a year's crops.

Iain Maor died in AE 131, and his daughter Mòrag took the staff, the first woman to hold it. The Company approved her in a letter that calls her "a safe pair of hands." Vane died at the Residency the next year, and Charles Merriman came with a small company of armed constables, the first standing force the Administration had kept on Dia-thìr. His first posts were at Muileann shean, which the

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1. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

townsfolk called the humans' second Residency and did not mean it kindly, and at Tobar ghorm.

In AE 133 the Mission at Cathair gheal reported that human labourers near Baile chrom had been meeting at night in the fields to keep a silent vigil under the sign of a grey goose. They were of the Church, and took the goose for an Gàadh Fiadhaich<sup>2</sup>, the wild goose of the Holy Spirit. The Mission called the vigil irregular, and supposed it a superstition picked up from the Dia-thìrich. The Dia-thìrich of Baile chrom disowned it. Manannan's priests at Ceann mhòr said the Mission was half right: the practice came from the Dia-thìrich, from Manannan's own harbours; Baile chrom had nothing to do with it. The human fishing families of Ceann mhòr had learned from them the night prayer to keep the sea shut, and the labourers inland had made of it a night of silence to a grey goose. The priests called it their prayer gone astray, and would not have its keepers in their house.

The year after, the dockers of Ros dhomhain, Dia-thìrich and human alike, refused for nine days to load coal over the new berth charges. It was the only strike of the age in which the two peoples stood together. Merriman's constables broke it, and the human dockers were shipped over the sea.

In AE 134 a third child of the condition was born, Lorccan, the first of them born in a mining town outside the camps, and the custodians knew from it that the thing had outgrown any one place. In AE 135 a fourth was born, Cian, within a year of the third: the nearest together that any two of the coal-blood were born.

## XII

### Of the Copyist and the Line of Aisling

**C**ailean mac Eachainn was a copyist in the cellar at Muileann chaol, one of the hands of the three households that were turning the rolls of the east into copies the Residency could not reach; and in the autumn after the word was agreed (21 an Dàmhair, AE 126) he was copying the roll of the camp at Àth iséal, whose custodian had kept the new camp at Achadh dhomhain on the same pages from its first winter.

It was dull work, and he was glad of it. A camp's roll is births and burials, fines and fevers and shifts lost, set down in a custodian's hand that grows worse in the



winters; and among them the marriages, which the custodians write as the households at the ford first recited them in the Age of Ailean, each side with its line seven names back. He had copied a hundred such lines that month and never read one.

This one he read. The name at the head of it was Donnchadh mac Thormoid, hewer; and further down the same roll, in the same hand, a birth was written with a mark beside it that he had seen before, on the other copies, against one name only. *Aisling*. Every copyist in the cellar knew what the camps said of her. Cailean had said it himself, as a boy, as boys said it, with a grin.

He sat with the seven names a long while by the lamp. The last of them was a name nobody gives a child now. Then he copied them onto a slip, and put it in his coat, and in the morning he walked out to Tobar dhìreach.

Clann na Ceiste<sup>1</sup> were few by then, and fewer every winter, and the one of them who still said the lines at the hearth on the night of the lightning was an old woman named Ealasaid, in a house not far from the slab. She let him in, because it was raining. When he told her what he wanted she looked at him as the reciters look at a stranger, not unkindly and not at all as if she meant to help; but she let him read the seven names aloud.

She sat with her eyes shut while he read. At the seventh she opened them.

"Where did you get that?"

He told her.

"That is Somhairle's line," she said. "The son who asked for nothing. We have kept it since Somhairle, and no one of it has come asking in a thousand years. They went down into the valleys and forgot us." She was quiet a while. "Whose is the child?"

"Donnchadh's. Her name is Aisling."

Ealasaid said nothing for so long that he thought she had not heard. Then she said, not to him, and as though she were reading it off the wall: "When strangers hold this island, the fire will wake again in your line." She looked at him. "That is the end of the vigil, as we have it. I have said it every winter of my life, and I never thought to see what it meant."

She stood up, for the lines are said standing, and she gave it him as it is given at a naming, from the child back to the fire. The Mason's line has kept the years of its dead beside their names since the mason, and keeps them still, but it says them

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2. the wild goose of the Holy Spirit

1. the Children of the Question

to no stranger except where they are strange; and so in the short form only the long lives are given their years. Cailean wrote it down as she said it:

"Aisling, daughter of Donnchadh, who hewed in the deep galleries of Achadh dhomhain; son of Tormod, who carried water up to Doire mhòr two summers, and then went down to Àth ìseal; son of Ruairidh of Doire mhòr, who stood behind Beathag Dhubh when she sent the Company down the hill; and seventy generations whose names we keep; son of Fionnlagh, who stood on the quay at Seann Skell when the ships went out, and did not go; and a hundred and sixteen generations whose names we keep; son of Ceallach, the last of us whose years were long; and all the days of Ceallach were a hundred and forty years, and he died; son of Gille-Bride, who carried a coal of the First Flame home to the hills; and all the days of Gille-Bride were two hundred and twenty-four years, and he died; and six generations whose names we keep, each longer-lived than the one after, and their days were three hundred and eight years, and four hundred and thirty-one, and five hundred and ninety-seven, and eight hundred and twenty-six, and one thousand one hundred and forty-eight, and one thousand five hundred and ninety-four; son of Beathan, who sat by the slab through the dark half of the year; and all the days of Beathan were two thousand two hundred and thirteen years, and he died; son of Somhairle, son of Ailean, who asked for no share of the kingdom and went before his father to the grave; and all the days of Somhairle were two thousand nine hundred and eighty-seven years, and he died; son of Ailean Mòr, the first king, whom the gods crowned in the grove, and who was king until he fell at the Ford of Blood; and all the days of Ailean Mòr were four thousand six hundred and twenty-six years, and he died; son of Suibhne, and fourteen fathers whose names we keep; son of Seathan, who snapped his fingers, and the fire was in his hand; and ten fathers; son of Colla, in whose days they called us the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal; and fifteen fathers; son of Eòghann, who tasted the river; and twenty-one fathers; son of Cormac of the Misstrike, who bled in the grove; and thirty fathers; son of Brian, who buried the five like the dead; and twenty-eight fathers; son of Fearghas, who climbed to the top of the island; and thirty-one fathers; son of Aodh, who threw the seven into the sea; and eighteen fathers; son of Diarmad, who spoke with the Keeper in the grove; and thirty-four fathers; son of Conall, who kept the vein while it

burned; son of Neachdan, who found the fire; son of the godfolk, who grew out of the island like grass; and the island was born of Caoran's fire."

When it was done she sat down again, and the rain went on against the shutter.

"They'll say it's a tale," said Cailean.

"The four thousand years, they will," said Ealasaid. "Let them. I never told you a man lived four thousand years. I told you whose son he was."

Cailean walked back to Muileann chaol, and wrote the line in the margin of the Àth ìseal roll, small, beside the birth; and it stands there still. So the whisper of the camps was found true, as far as a line of names can make a thing true: the girl of the spoil-houses was a daughter of the first king's line. What else it proved the copyists did not say, and the camps did not ask them to.

### XIII

## Of the Rending of Cill ghlas, and the First Blood

**I**n AE 136 the Company began to drive galleries under the hills around Cill ghlas with blasting-powder shipped from an Tìr Thall<sup>1</sup>. The custodians of the shrine asked that no charge be set within sight of the old cutting. The Company's engineer marked their request on his plan, and set the charges below it.

On 9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 137, in the course of an ordinary day's work, the hills east of the capital broke.

The tellers of Cill ghlas say the ground spoke first, a long grinding under the feet like a quern turning, and then the fault tore open. That was Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>2</sup>, the Rending. It killed dozens and shut a whole mining district. The old cutting where the rites had been kept through all the age, where Brìde's lamp had burned and the word *fuil-ghuail*<sup>3</sup> had been agreed, went down into the earth with its shrine and was not seen again. The custodians' roll sets down the loss of the shrine before the loss of the dead, and a later copyist has put the order right; the copyists of Muileann chaol let both hands stand. The Company fenced the district and left Cill ghlas and its hamlets without work, and the closed country went to thorn.

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1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

2. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

3. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

Within days came the first blood between the two peoples. The fuller account of it in the roll, written up at the year's end, sets it at Muileann chrom.

Mòrag nic Iain Maor was at the pithead when they brought the seven up.

The pumps had been stopped the day before to save fuel, and in the night the gallery had filled. Now the seven lay on the wet boards in a row, and the women of the camp were coming up the track, and there was no sound but their feet and the rain.

At noon the Company's agent rode up with his constables and began to speak about the loss to the working.

The first stone took him on the shoulder. Then the air was full of them, and the constables were shouting, and Mòrag was shouting too. She saw a constable raise his rifle. She saw the smoke before she heard the sound. When it was over four Dia-thìrich lay in the mud beside the seven, and one constable with them.

At the inquiry she stood up in her good dark dress with the Company's staff in her hand, the staff her great-grandfather had taken from the Company, and testified that the pumps had been stopped on the agent's order. The clerk wrote it down, and then was told to strike it out.

The Lamp-Watch got a copy anyway.

In AE 138 the grey fever came in on the ships, a fever of the chest that took the young and strong before the old, and it ran from the capital to the eastern farms. The camps, already hungry, buried more than the towns.

In AE 139 a second petition went to the Residency, and where the first had held a plea, this one held a warning. It was drafted by Eilidh nic Raghnaill, a crew-leader of Baile thais and a member of the Lamp-Watch, and signed by custodians and crew-leaders of thirty-one settlements, and its last sentence was underlined at the Residency: that the hill would not be worked by people who were not asked. It was the first Dia-thìreach writing the Administration troubled to answer. It answered with constables. In AE 140 Merriman tripled the constabulary and posted companies at Muileann chrom, Baile thais, Ceann fhada and Cnoc chaol, each with a fortified store, all paid for out of the tithe; and a barracks for two hundred at Dùn chrom stood empty most of its first year for want of men to fill it.

At Seann Skell, where Murchadh Seabhag had preached the hawk's hunger in AE 22, the hawk-priest Ìomhar Seabhag now preached that Mòd's hunger had turned at last toward those who had eaten the hill. The hawk-shrines of the west became meeting-houses for the Lamp-Watch, and the constables did not yet know it.

The grey fever came back in AE 140 and settled in the north-west, and there it killed humans as readily as Dia-thìrich. In the Mission's crowded hospital at Cath-air gheal the two peoples lay in the same wards for the first time.

## XIV

### Of the Houses on the Roads, and the Day the Pits Stopped

**T**he carters of the old coal roads tell these years as a tale of inns. From AE 141 the roadside houses of the mining routes began, unbidden, to serve as way-stations for a nameless militia in a war not yet declared. The singing house, An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>1</sup>, walled its yard and set a watch on its gate. Am Buabhall Fortanach on the south-western road barred its gates at dusk and kept a man on its roof, and its keeper Tormod Buabhall sent a list of travellers up the road every week, and never told the constables whose hands it reached. At An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the northern road the stables were rebuilt with a loft for sleeping men, and the carters noticed that the loft was never empty and never held the same men twice. An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>2</sup>, near the silver country, became the post-house through which the Lamp-Watch sent word to Muileann chiar and the silver guild paid its rent. And An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, the carters' house that Seònaid Bhàn had opened in the first years of the extraction, was kept now by her great-grandson Aonghas. It was the busiest of the fortified houses, the one the constables searched most often and found least in.

In AE 143 the pits stopped.

That morning the Company's chief agent stood at his window over the Ros dhomhain quay to watch the first coal-trains come down to the steamships. None came. By noon the ships still rode high at their moorings with their holds open to the rain.

Word came in by rider and by rail. Every working in the Muileann chrom district had halted at once. So had Baile thais, and Cnoc chaol, and the silver town, and the eastern pits at Ros fhionn. The signal had been a fire on the hills above Doire mhòr, which the Company took for a heath fire.

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1. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

2. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

For six days the steamships lay at Ros dhomhain with empty holds. The agents wrote home that they had never known the harbour so quiet, and that the quiet frightened them more than the crowds ever had.

The stoppage was broken as the strike at Baile thais had been broken, when the constables shut the Company stores in every district at once. Forty crew-leaders were taken. Thirty-two were let go without charge. Eight were shipped over the sea to an Tìr Thall<sup>3</sup> for trial, and were never heard of again. The beacon of the stoppage had been lit on Doire mhòr's hill by the children's children of Beathag Dhubh's people, and the constables burned the heather there so that no fire could be lit on it again.

The keepers' daybooks were showing by now fewer ships from an Tìr Thall each year, and older ones. The Company's letters speak of troubles at home and do not say what they are. Of whatever was happening beyond the sea, the island saw only the emptiness in the daybooks.

In AE 146 the Administration began to issue its orders with no Dia-thìreach counsel sought at all, and the polite pretence of permission, kept up since the council's vote of AE 2, was put away. Merriman left in ill health, and Lionel Strake, a soldier, took his place. His commission, read aloud at the Residency, made no mention of the Council of Custodians, and he did not call on it. He brought a flying machine over in the hold of a Company steamship and had it flown over the coal country to count the workings from the air. The Dia-thìrich called it *eun-iarainn*, the iron bird (27 am Màrt, AE 147). He had the council hall at Cathair dhearg locked and its keys lodged at the Residency. The custodians met instead in the temple of Macha, whose priests had once blessed the humans' coin and now sheltered those who had petitioned against it.

In AE 147 the Administration claimed the right to take any Dia-thìreach dwelling it judged needful for the widening of the workings. Of all the wrongs of the age, the edict of seizure is the one named most often in every telling of what came after. The first houses taken under it were those of Doire mhòr, for a new shaft beneath the hill, and the last households there were carried out by constables. The village that had refused the first contract was the first to be emptied by the last. At Baile dhomhain, the first camp laid out on paper, two streets were pulled down for a spoil-tip.

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3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

XV

## Of the Breaking of the Staff

**I**n AE 148 the order came to Mòrag nic Iain Maor to clear the houses of her district.

She read it twice at her table in the steward's house under the slate roof. Then she took down the staff from over the hearth, the staff Raghnaill had carried, and Dòmhnall after him, and her father Iain, and walked down through Muileann chrom to the Company's office, with the townsfolk coming out of their doors behind her.

At the Company's door she broke it across her knee. It was old wood and it went with a crack like a shot. She laid the two halves on the step and walked home.

Three other overseers resigned that month, and the Company put humans in their places. So ended the office that Raghnaill mac Dhòmhnaiill had taken up more than a hundred years before, Raghnaill, Dòmhnall, Iain and Mòrag each in turn; and the custodians' hope that it would lapse with the first of them was granted at last by the fourth.

That summer the silver guild of Muileann chiar, still holding its seam under the compact of a century before, began to buy rifles from the raiders of the eastern waters, where no gunboat had patrolled for years, and paid them in bar silver by weight. Its ledger enters the rifles as refining tools. Custodians, crew-leaders of the Lamp-Watch and the dissenting priests of Macha met in the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag and made themselves one council for the mining country, and chose Eilidh nic Raghnaill to speak for it. No human hand wrote down that meeting. Strake learned of it all the same, and ordered the arrest of Eilidh and the forest council; and the constables went to Baile thais, and found her house empty and the town silent.

XVI

## Of the War of the Hills

**O**n 20 an Gearran, AE 149, the grievance of the Dia-thirich, joined at last under one council across the mining country, became war.

It opened in the hills. At first light crews under Mòrag nic Iain, who had broken the staff, rushed the fortified store at Muileann chrom, and its eleven constables gave themselves up without a shot; before noon the rifles and the grain were gone. Crews from the camps took the coal quay at Ceann fhada and sank two barges across its mouth, and no coal left the hills by water again in the age. At Baile thais the constables held the walled pithead for eleven days, the span of Ca-triona's strike a lifetime before, and on the twelfth, their water gone, they came out. Eilidh nic Raghnaill sent them under guard to the coast unharmed. The Residency had not looked for that, and did not return it in kind. The northern pits at Baile gharbh rose in the same season, took the constable posts at Muileann shean and Tobar ghorm, and sent the constables south on foot. Aonghas shut the gates of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr across the coal road, and the men in its loft came down armed, and the road between the capital and the hills was cut at its halfway stage and stayed cut. At Muileann dhearg the smith Uilleam Gobha made grenades of the Company's own blasting-powder cased in tin from the coal sheds, and pike-heads from the rails of the galleries, and the council's roll says it could not have fought its first season without him.

Then the capital rose. The custodians broke the Residency's locks on their hall at Cathair dhearg and sat in it again. The townsfolk held the stone bridge against the constables sent up from the harbour, the bridge the Company had rebuilt for coal-carts, and they barricaded it with the carts. At Cathair dhomhain the townsfolk broke open the Company's warehouse, the first building the Company had ever owned on Dia-thìr, and carried its tools to the council's companies. Strake drew the Administration back into the Residency and fortified the Company's quarter of the harbour. The city below it, Dia-thìreach almost to a soul, neither joined the rising nor stood against it, and the constables did not trust it enough to leave their walls.

A column of constables and Company guards under Major Peter Ashdown marched up the coal road to relieve the hills, and on 5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 149, it came to the ford of Àth chiar and found the rebels on the far bank. The water was high and brown, and his men went into it to the waist with their rifles over their heads, and the fire from the far bank came down on them. Ashdown lost forty men there and all his baggage, and turned back. The rebels lost nineteen, and the council's roll names every one, as the custodians' roll had named the eleven of Cnoc fhiadhaich when the Company's report named none. Ashdown's column halted a night at the barracks of Dùn chrom, and in the morning found the



town's gates shut behind it, and went on to the coast without its wounded, whom the townsfolk kept and nursed.

In the east the silver guild declared for the council, opened its armoury, and escorted the Company's agents to the coast with their papers. The guild's ledger notes that this was the one place on the island where the rising took nothing, because the humans had never held anything there to take. The constables' post at Dùn ìseal gave itself up to the guild's riflemen after a single exchange of fire, and the east was clear of human arms. Dùn dhearg declared for the council and sent it grain, and its declaration quotes the defence of the Small-Burning Law that its custodian Fionnghal nic Artair had written a hundred and twenty-seven years before. The crews of the eastern workings at Ros fhionn stopped the pumps and walked out, and let the lower galleries flood, and the bridge on the eastern coal road fell silent.

The humans struck back from the sea. Early in AE 150 a Company steamship came up the Abhainn uaine and shelled the coal stage at Seann Toll to keep it from the rebels, and set the fishing town behind it burning, and twenty-three townsfolk died. It was the first time the humans turned the island's own coal, burning in their boilers, against a Dia-thìreach town. Fishing boats from Seann Chwen and Ros ruadh, sailing by night along the south coast, boarded a Company coaster at anchor and burned her, and the Company drew its coastal shipping back into Ros dhomhain and Ros bheag.

On the concession, Cathair gheal shut its gates and raised a militia and sent none of it south. Its magistrate asked both sides to leave it alone; the council granted it, and Strake did not reply.

That spring the council's letters to the Hawk coast went north by the hands of seven hawk-faithful crewmen of the river towns. They waited nine hours for the letters at An Cupa Dàna in Cuan dhearg (19 an Giblean, AE 150). Each wore at his throat a hawk cast in lead from the cartridges taken at the store at Muileann chrom, and the record calls them Buidheann an t-Seabhaig Luaidhe<sup>1</sup>, the Leaden Hawk company. They left at dark.

They went on foot, past the burned stage at Seann Toll, over the hills by Achadh dhomhain, down the Abhainn ìseal to Cnoc bheag and along the Hawk coast to Inis mhin. At every hawk-house on the way one of them stood up among the benches and read the letter aloud. At Inis mhin they heard that Strake's con-

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1. the Leaden Hawk company; lit. 'the company of the leaden hawk'

stables rode the western roads out of Ros bheag every day, so they hired a carriage and left the roads altogether. In the grasslands above Tobar dhomhain they lay eleven hours in the long grass over the road from Ros bheag and counted the constables' riders as they passed (23 an Giblean, AE 150). There were forty-one, and none of them going north.

They came down to Inis thais six days after they had set out. The priests of the Stone, the keepers of Clach, heard the letter in their temple and would send no men; but they shut the harbour of Inis thais to the Company's ships (25 an Giblean, AE 150), and gave the hawk-faithful the use of the Fianna's roads. At Seann Skell Ìomhar Seabhag declared that the war was Mòd's own hunger turned back on those who had fed it, and the hawk-shrines of the west became recruiting-houses.

The keepers at Tobar dhearg put out their beacon, and Àth dhearg and Baile iséal followed. Company ships feeling their way along the coast by night ran onto the reefs the beacons had been built to light, and two were lost. The Administration begged an Tìr Thall<sup>2</sup> for troops and ships. One ship came in the war's first year, with dispatches and a few crates of cartridges, and sailed again within the week.

Through the first winter the council held the hills, the east and the capital, and Strake held the Residency, the harbour quarter below it and the western ports, and neither had the strength to break the other. Cathair dhearg went short, its harbour held against it, and the custodians shared out the grain by household; and the roll records that they took the same share as everyone else.

In that stalemate the ledgers burned.

The first fire was at the Company's counting-house on the Ros dhomhain quay, inside Strake's lines. Dùghall Dubh and the men of the harbour quarter came to it over the roofs on a night of low cloud, in their stocking feet, and in at a garret window and down the stair in the dark. The tithe books stood in rows in the long room, calf-bound, heavy as flagstones. They carried them out into the yard in armfuls and heaped them on the cobbles, and Dùghall struck the light himself. The sentry at the front door never turned round until the whole yard was lit.

The second raid burned the tithe-house at Ceann àrsaidh, where the portion owed by every settlement of the hills had been entered since the first schedule.

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2. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

The clerks were let go. The custodians of Ceann àrsaidh asked that one ledger be spared for the record, and their own people refused them, and the copyists at Muileann chaol have been sorry for it ever since. The third burned the weigh-house at Muileann chrom, with the steelyard ledgers in which the coal of the hills had been set down by the ton since the first contract. The rebels' own chronicler writes that the fire burned green. The chroniclers hold those fires great in what they meant, if small in what they did. The camps made a verse of them:

*Loisc iad an leabhar, ach cha do loisc iad an cnoc.*

They burned the book, but they did not burn the hill.

On 25 an Lùnastal, AE 150, Company guards and constables sallying from the harbour to win back the eastern road were driven back at Cnoc ghorm, in the hills beyond the capital, and it was the Administration's last attempt of the war to reach the mining country. Ten days later the Dia-thìrich of the Ros dhomhain harbour quarter opened the lower gates to the council's companies, and Strake held only the Residency and the Company's quays. On 21 an t-Sultain, AE 150, Strake took his officials, the Mission's clergy and the Company's agents away by water to Ros bheag. The council's companies came into the Residency the next morning and found it stripped of everything but its furniture and the letter-books, from which so much of this history is drawn, and which the humans had not troubled to take.

## XVII

### Of the Truce of Àth àrsaidh, and the Closing of the Crossing

**R**os bheag, the western port the humans had used since the early years, became the last seat of the Administration, and the human families of the west and south, a few thousand in all, gathered behind its walls. With the roads cut and no ships from over the sea the town went short within months, and Strake ordered the Company's stores opened to the human families and the Dia-thìreach townsfolk alike. It is the one deed of his that the Dia-thìreach rolls give him credit for.

The custodians of Cuan shean, the town where the first humans had waded ashore to beg for water, shut their harbour to Company ships. The council's roll

marks the turn of it and says no more, and neither shall the tellers. At Baile dhìreach the descendants of the old joint council, many of them of both peoples, were asked by each side which people they belonged to. Most of them would not answer, and neither side made them.

On 1 an t-Samhain, AE 150, on Samhain, the last ship known to have come from an Tìr Thall<sup>1</sup> anchored at Ros bheag. She brought no troops and no grain, only a sealed letter for the Commissioner, and she sailed on the next tide with as many passengers as she could hold. What the letter said, Strake kept to himself. On 2 an t-Samhain, AE 150, envoys of the council and the Administration met at Àth àrsaidh, on the edge of the northern concession, and agreed a truce: the humans remaining on Dia-thìr would withdraw into the north-west under the council's safe-conduct, and the council would leave the concession towns standing.

On 29 an t-Samhain, AE 150, the columns went north. The human families of Ros bheag, Cuan shean, Baile dhìreach and the south-west walked up the western roads with their carts and bundles under the guard of the council's companies, and few of them had ever lived in the north. The roll records that no column was attacked, and that none was helped. At Àth chrom the custodians stood at the ford and counted them over, and that count was the last the Dia-thìrich made of the humans on Dia-thìr in this age. At Àth leathan, the last stage before the northern country, the columns camped a night, and the custodians of the town record that the humans asked the name of the place, and that several of them wrote it down.

The keeper of the beacon at Baile chrom saw the last of it.

He was on the gallery of the tower on 5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 150, with his glass to his eye when the ship came up along the coast. She had sailed from Cuan shean with Lionel Strake, the last Commissioner, and his officials, and she was the last ship on the island that could make the crossing. How the harbour that had shut itself to the Company came to let her go, the men of Cuan shean never said. The keeper watched her stand out to the north, smaller and greyer, until the sea had her. Then he went in out of the wind and wrote her down.

Nothing on Dia-thìr records her arriving anywhere.

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1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

The council ordered the five beacons lit again, from Baile chrom round to Tobar dhearg. The keepers kept their daybooks as before, and there was nothing to put in them. The line that stands in them, in the hands of five keepers, is this:

*Cha tàinig long.*

No ship came.

At the year's end the custodians sent what was left of the age's rolls down to the cellars at Muileann chaol: their copies of the petitions, the book of Baile thais, and the letter-books left in the Residency. What the Administration's own clerks carried west with Strake, no one on Dia-thìr saw again.

On 1 am Faoilleach, AE 151, the war ended with the crossing itself closed. Whatever had let the humans reach Dia-thìr shut behind them. No one on the island knows what it was, or why it opened, or why it closed, and the chroniclers set it down as a thing that befell the sea. The humans still on the island were gathered into the northern country under the council's safe-conduct. This was the Severance. Cian and Lorccan were neither of them yet twenty.

*The masters of the humans on Dia-thìr, as the letter-books give them.* Edmund Harrow, captain, from the Crossing until the treaty; then the Commissioners at the Residency: Josiah Pell, AE 8 to AE 24; Henry Maddox, AE 24 to AE 41; Arthur Lisle, AE 41 to AE 61; Walter Crane, AE 61 to AE 75; George Tolley, AE 76 to AE 98; Robert Haskins, AE 98 to AE 114; Edward Vane, AE 114 to AE 132; Charles Merriman, AE 132 to AE 146; Lionel Strake, AE 146 to AE 150, the last.

*The Stewards of Muileann chrom, as the custodians' roll gives them.* Ragnall mac Dhòmhnaill, Ragnall Maor, AE 36 to AE 62; Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill, AE 62 to AE 87; Iain Maor, AE 87 to AE 131; Mòrag nic Iain, AE 131 to AE 148, who broke the staff.

Thus ended the Age of Strangers. It began with a vote that three custodians did not attend, and with forty words for the colours of the coal that the strangers never asked to learn; and it ended with the hill cut to its roots, the Small-Burning Law a hundred and thirty years forgotten, and the tithe ledgers burning green at Muileann chrom. What was lost the rolls can count only in part: the shrine at Cill ghlas and the water of Doire mhòr, the salmon of the green river, the Deer school's hall and the barter houses, the eight who were shipped over the sea, and all the names the Company's reports never gave. What was kept is shorter to tell: the silver of Muileann chiar, the copies in the cellar at Muileann chaol, and the

four children of the coal-blood, whom the strangers' pits had woken and the strangers' registers never held. The hill was the island's again. But the island knew no way to use it save the way the strangers had taught.

THE SIXTH BOOK

# AN AOIS RÌOZHACHD

*the Age of the Kingdom*

SE 1 – 71

*Tha e scrìobhte a-nis.* It is written now.

— a minute of the Moot at Caol mhòr, 6 an t-Samhain, SE 64, entire, as the Library renders it

I

## Of the Severance and the Settling of the North

*So the old people of the north tell it, at the hearths of Doire ghlas, when the fire is low and the children will not sleep.*

In the last days of the Age of Strangers, whatever road had brought the humans over the eastern water shut behind their last ships, and those still on Diathìr were marched north under the council's guard. That was the Severance, and it fell on the first day of AE 151, in the dead of winter, when the roads north were mud to the knee.

On 22 am Màrt, SE 1, with the lambs coming, the homeland of the Tuathaich was fixed. The children of the stranded humans were settled in the north by the council's word, and its guard stood at the head of the roads. It was a confinement, and everyone on both sides of the guard knew it. Their grandchildren would call it home all the same, having no other. Cian and Lorccan of the immortal generation grew up in the wake of those days; of them the chronicles of this age tell nothing further.

The victors began by putting things away. At Cathair dhearg the war-companies of the Severance were stood down, and their rolls went into the council's chests instead of the fire. Nobody ever abolished the companies. They lived on as names on a list, and the list lay quiet through all the rest of the age. On the roads running north, at Caol mhòr and elsewhere, stones were set to mark where the Tuathaich country began. No wall came after them. Many still stand at the road-side, since nobody has ever been paid to shift them.

That first year the north went hungry alone. The stores that had come over the water from an Tìr Thall<sup>1</sup> came no more, and the grain ran out before the spring. At Doire ghlas, the old people say, more than two hundred were buried that winter; they had it from their grandmothers. The Dia-thìrich made no count.

Meanwhile the council's clerks went through the humans' counting-houses at Cathair dhearg, Ros dhomhain and Seann Skell like rooks through stubble, and carried off every written leaf. The tithe ledgers, or what the raids of the war had left of them, they boxed unread, for few of them could make out the humans' hand. In the north-west things went otherwise. At Ceann mhòr, Cathair gheal and Inis àrsaidh the human harbour officers had sailed with the last ships and taken their keys with them. The Tuathaich fishermen took hammers to the locks of the harbour stores and shared out what they found, house by house. The north tells that part with some relish.

## II

### Of the Moot and the Kingdom

**I**n the south the kingdom was making itself. On 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 2, in the high summer, the state styled itself Rìoghachd Dia-thìr<sup>1</sup>: a kingdom in its form, whatever it was in its working, and its own records carry that contradiction still.

A month before the council was seated, the householders of the northern towns came to Caol mhòr.

They came on foot and in carts at the tail of a wet summer, and crowded into a long low room that smelt of damp wool and fish-scale. Walter Hale stood at the

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1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland



back with his hat in his hands. He had been a harbour clerk under the humans, and there was still ink in the creases of his knuckles.

They argued most of the afternoon over who should speak for them. Somebody said his name, and it went round the room like a bucket passed along a line, and it stopped with him.

"We've no standing," said a man by the door. "Not in their law. They needn't hear a word of it."

"Then we'll say it where we can hear it ourselves," said Walter Hale. He sat down at the trestle, opened a book that had nothing in it yet, wetted his pen and wrote the day.

That was the Moot. It had no standing in Dia-thìreach law. It met all the same, and it kept minutes, and they run unbroken from that wet afternoon to the present year.

That autumn a royal council of twelve was seated at Cathair dhearg, drawn from the custodian families and the captains of the Severance war. Its minute-books are the oldest unbroken record of the state in this age, younger than the Moot's by a month.

At Ros dhomhain the first Dia-thìrich harbour-master, Dùghall mac Iain, kept the humans' tariff in force for want of another, and spent years turning it into Dia-thìris, clause by clause.

In the early summer of SE 3 a ship was sent out past the north-western capes and north-about to seek the crossing the humans had used. She came home after a month of grey water. She had seen no land and no sign of any passage, and no second ship was sent. At Seann Skell the priests of Manannan said that the lord of the sea had shut his sea again, as they had begged him to ever since the Crossing, and they said the old prayer at the harbour mouth:

*A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte.* Manannan, keep the sea shut.

### III

## Of Niall, the Shires and the Great Wave

**I**n the long light of midsummer, on 19 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3, Niall was crowned at Cathair dhearg by Macha's rite, as the kings before the humans had been

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1. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

crowned. He was the first ruler of the restored kingdom and the first name in the line that the state's chronicles have kept without a break ever since. So smoothly did the crown pass to him that *mar a thàinig Niall*, "the way Niall came", became a saying for any handing-over of power that went without a quarrel. The first place it is found written is a tavern ledger in the capital, set against a debt paid without argument.

The council drew the kingdom into shires, each *siorrachd* named for its seat, and drew them on the humans' district lines, for the humans' surveys were the only whole surveys of the island there were. The kingdom used them and did not say so. Over each shire went a *maor* to gather the Crown's dues: the head-due on every household, counted by its heads, and the market-due on every sale. Where the humans' lines stopped, at the edge of the great moss of the far north-west, the shires stopped too, and the windy coast beyond was left in no shire at all. In the Tuathaich shires the maor were Dia-thìrich. At Ceann mhòr the maor moved into the old human magistrate's house, and the townsfolk went on calling it by its old name.

Then the sea came in.

The Great Wave came in the short night of early summer, on 3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 4, and it gave no warning at all. The south calls it Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol<sup>1</sup>. In one night it wrecked Cnoc chaol, Cuan dhearg and Achadh mhin.

The relief party out of Cathair dhearg came down the coast road to Cuan dhearg, and the young clerk who carried its tally-book smelt the town before he saw it: salt, and torn weed, and something under both that he did not want to name. Where the harbour had stood there was brown water and a row of broken piles like bad teeth. He looked for the boats, until a man of the party touched his arm and pointed inland. The boats of Cuan dhearg were in the fields behind the town, keeled over among the barley, and one sat upright in a furrow with her mast still stepped, as if she had been sailed there in the dark. The clerk wrote that down, not knowing what else to do with it, and went on counting.

When the tallies from Cnoc chaol and Achadh mhin came in and were added to his, the dead of the three towns came to a little over nine hundred. The wave had run on up the gulf as far as Ros gharbh and broken its quays. That town stood high and lost few of its people, and nearly every boat.

It was the first disaster the new state met on its own terms, and it met it well. The council moved the survivors of Achadh mhin off their salted fields and paid

for their seed out of the treasury, the first relief the restored kingdom ever gave. The old site is called an Tràigh Bhàthte<sup>2</sup>, the drowned strand, and nobody builds there. From the survivors the south took a word: *tonn*, wave, for anything sudden and overwhelming. *Tha e san tonn*, they say, he is in the wave of it.

In SE 5 the human coinage was called in. In the old counting-house at Cathair dhearg, Fearchar mac Dhòmhnaill, whom men called Fearchar Bonn, set up the mint and struck the coin of the Rìoghachd. He pressed each coin's seal with an ink ground from coal dust, so that a clipped coin showed the coal's colour at its edge. The coin was honest and holy, and the kingdom liked it both ways.

The north paid for it. The Tuathaich households had put by their savings in human coin, and those savings were now worth their weight as metal and no more. The Moot petitioned for an exchange. The petition was received and filed. It is the first petition in this book to end that way, and not the last. At Doire mhin a smith named Joseph Marlow gathered up his neighbours' dead coin, melted it down and cast it into ploughshares, and sold the shares back to them for the price of the charcoal. The Tuathaich sing of him still in their own tongue. A Library clerk once set down a verse of the song in plain prose: *he turned the king's silence into iron, and the iron into bread.*

#### IV

### Of the Rite, the Orders and the Law

**I**n the spring of SE 6, Òrd Bhrìde<sup>1</sup>, the order of Brìde's flame and Crom's stone, which had kept the Hall's rite since the Binding, was drawn up into ordered doctrine, where before there had been only a wide and loose reverence. It was built about the leyline and the unbroken line of the coal-touched, and the kingdom calls it simply the Rite. Dòmhnall mac Thormoid was named Àrd-choimheadaiche<sup>2</sup>, the first high custodian of the Rite, and seated at Seann Skell on the southern coast, where the order's greatest house stands. His first labour was to write down an order of worship. In all the long keeping of the flame no one had ever written one.

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1. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

2. the drowned strand at old Cnoc chaol

1. the order of Brìde's flame

2. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

The Hawk houses round Cnoc bheag would have none of it. Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>3</sup>, the older form of the Rite, had never needed a custodian above the local altar, they said, and had no need of one now. Nobody forced them, and here begins the long quarrel between the two forms of the Rite. Only the southernmost hawk-house, at Muileann naomh, far from Cnoc bheag, took up the written order, and it has been a house of the Rite ever since. The houses of the Stone in the south-west, whose Clach was never Crom's stone, sent no witnesses, only a letter wishing the Rite well. Òrd Mhacha<sup>4</sup>, the capital's own order, which makes the kings, was given the coronation regalia to keep, as it had kept them before the humans came, and it gave the high custodian no share in them. Within a year the orthodox Rite had one house that disowned it, one that ignored it with great courtesy, and one that outranked it at court. The orders of the Old Faith stood so for the rest of the age.

In the north the Church was kept quietly. The Tuathaich held to an Eaglais, the faith their grandparents had carried over the sea, and to the fragment they call the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan, which the Dia-thireach priesthood calls superstition. The Library has never been shown the fragment. It knows only that it is kept. At Baile chrom the vigil-keeper Hannah Crane kept the vigil of Rùn-dìomhair na h-Oidhche Glaise<sup>5</sup>, the Mystery of the Grey Night, in the open for the first time since the Severance. The sect keeps one night of silence in the year for Sine, the Peaceful Goose, which is its name for the wild goose of the Holy Spirit, and it tells no outsider which night that is. The Church's bishops call the vigil irregular, and they have never put it out. In the towns of the west coast, where the Tuathaich lived beside the Dia-thìrich of Manannan's harbours, many congregations came to preach in the humans' tongue and to read the Bible in Dia-thìris. How that came about the west coast has never troubled to explain.

In SE 10 a wall between the two peoples was proposed, and the council threw it out as needless, since the peoples were keeping apart well enough without one. The minute that rejects it runs to four lines. The fourth reads *They do not come south*. Five of the twelve initialled it, and the other seven did not sign against it. The Library keeps that minute under glass. It is a small leaf, and a good deal of the age is written on it.

The law came north in the same fashion. In SE 8, at Seann Bhrál, Eilidh nic Leòid, first of the circuit justices, ruled that land held by the Tuathaich under hu-

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3. the Hawk order

4. the order of Macha

man title passed to the Crown, while the right to work it stayed with the holders and their heirs. The Leòid ruling is cited in nearly every land case of the age.

Seven summers later she carried it north herself.

The court at Ceann mhòr sat in the heat of an t-Iuchar, late in the month, in SE 15, with the windows open on the square and the flies drifting in. Eilidh nic Leòid had nineteen cases before her. Seventeen were Tuathaich suits over land, and in each the same kind of paper came up to the bench: a human title, brown at the folds, under the seal of a magistrate who had sailed home. She read every one to the end, and would not be hurried, while the suitors stood in their best coats and sweated. Then she took up her own ruling and read that too, aloud, so that the room should hear what the law was, and gave judgment.

In fifteen of the seventeen she found for the Crown. She was exact. The law she was exact about had been made for one people, and she had made it. Her rulings became the kingdom's first law-book.

Some years before, in SE 7, Walter Hale had asked leave to open schools in the north that taught in the humans' tongue. The council answered that the kingdom's schools taught in Dia-thìris and it had no others. The Moot's minute calls the answer "clear, at least." In the middle of the winter of SE 15 Agnes Pike opened such a school at Doire ghlas anyway, with Moot money and without leave, and within ten years there were nine. The council never licensed them and never shut them. For most of the age that was the kingdom's way with the north: it forbade little there, and helped with less.

## V

### Of the Mountain, the Guilds and the Fair

**B**y SE 11 the mine was yielding as much as it had under the humans, and then more. The work was the same work. Only the owners had changed.

The Crown granted the Sloc Mòr, the great shaft at Achadh dhomhain, to Uisdean mac Ùisdein of Cathair mhòr, whose house had held an overseer's post under the humans. The Crown took a fifth. Those were the humans' terms with the names changed. The council would not end the day-and-night working the humans had ordered, and so the mountain was still given no season

of rest. The custodians entered a protest, and then went down and blessed the shafts. The hewers had a saying for it:

*Cha d'fhuair a' bheinn fois a-riamh, is cha d'fhuair sinne.* The mountain never got its rest, and neither did we.

Families from the hungry east came to the vein-towns for wages, and Muileann dhearg doubled in three years. The humans' railway was mended to the pithead, and in an Dàmhair of SE 12 the first coal train ran from the Sloc Mòr to Cathair dhearg, under the kingdom's name, on the humans' rails. At Muileann chom the families who worked the little shunting engines were counted apart and lived apart, in rows beside the lines. For forty years the public buildings of the south went up in the Sloc Mòr's grey spoil-stone, sold under the Mac Ùisdein quarry-mark.

In SE 13 the apprentice-binding of the Holy Age was taken up again, and this time the charters said in so many words that it was for Dia-thìreach applicants. The Guild of Hewers came first, its oath sworn with a hand laid on a lump of coal, and the shipwrights, chandlers, lamp-makers and weavers came after. The Tuathaich boys already bound to Dia-thìreach masters were released from their indentures. Some went north. Most stayed on as day-labour, outside the guilds and beneath their wages. The rule kept them where the pay was worst.

Off Cathair gheal, ships that flew no flag began to raid the north-western coast, and some of their crews were men who had served the human administration. The Tuathaich towns suffered first, undefended. In SE 20, having asked twice and been sent nothing, the fishermen of Cathair gheal armed their own boats and drove the raiders out of the bay. The council then fined the town for bearing arms without a licence. The town paid.

On 16 an Dàmhair, SE 21, in the reddening of the year, the fair at Muileann òg was established, and it grew to be the greatest recurring gathering on the island. Its first toll-mistress, Oighrig nic Mhathain, set down its rules, and one of them was this: that Tuathaich goods be sold only through Dia-thìreach factors. They are still read aloud when each fair opens. Two years after, the Còmhrag began at Ceann leathan, a yearly melee that the south called an old custom of arms, and where, more and more, men who had nowhere else to spend their anger spent it. Two men died in the first one that anyone remembers.

On 7 an t-Ògmhios, SE 24, in the green of early summer, there was a cluster of births among the shunting families, the generation called Splatter and Dodge's. Seachran and Brean were among them.

## VI

### Of the Library at Muileann chaol

**O**n 1 an Cèitean, SE 16, which was Bealltainn, the fires were lit on the hills round Muileann chaol to bring the summer in, and their smoke hung over the town all day. Ailean mac Iain spent that day in a cellar.

He had been named first keeper of the new Library, and had brought the council's minute-books with him, and the remains of the humans' tithe ledgers in their boxes. Now the townsmen led him down a stair to the custodians' rolls, which had lain there since the Severance war, stacked on planks above a wet floor, the lowest gone as soft as bread. He untied one and read three lines by the light from the stair. Then he sent for lamps, and a table, and a boy to fetch and carry.

He spent years having them read, and as they were read he had every date in them turned into the civil calendar, the day and month the humans had brought, and set in the years of its age as the copyists' table of the ages divided them. He had come to dislike the count of the Diosal, which ran backwards into the thousands for everything older than the sunwise turn, and he said that a people should not have to name every year of its life after the day its kin went away. In that work his reckoners parted the eldest age of the copyists' table in two. Laying the tellings of Clann na Ceiste<sup>1</sup> against the king-lists, they found that nearly half of it lay within the days of one man, Ailean Mòr, crowned in the grove and king until he fell at the Ford of Blood; and they held that a life so long was an age in itself, and counted the Age of Ailean apart. Before the year was out, *a chur san Leabharlann*, to put it in the Library, meant to make a thing settled and beyond dispute. A clerk once used it in his hearing.

"The Library settles nothing," said Ailean Leabhar, for so they called him by then. "It only keeps."

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1. the Children of the Question

The phrase outlived him all the same. The Library now keeps the fullest surviving record of everything told in this book, and the reader should bear that in mind.

Among the camp rolls he came on the margin of the Àth ìseal roll where Cailean mac Eachainn had written the Line of Aisling. He had it copied fair into the Library's book of lines, where it stands after the Line of the Mason; and the long years of Ailean Mòr and his children he entered in the book of tellings, with the Hollow Man and the white stag. A clerk asked him which of the two books was right. "Both," said Ailean Leabhar, who had been named for the first king, as half the boys of the hills were. "The one keeps names. The other keeps what people said."

In SE 18, as the nights drew in, an office was made to keep the kingdom's record, and from its books this book is drawn. The first royal chronicler, Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill, a council clerk, kept her record at Muileann chaol and would not keep it at the capital. She wrote in her first entry that a record kept beside the throne is kept for the throne. The same order that made her office bade the kingdom's records count their years as Ailean Leabhar counted them, each age from its own first event, and Gormshuil headed her first year the eighteenth of the Severance Era. It was the first year so written in the kingdom's own record, and the years of the Diosal went into the old books. She sent clerks to every shire to copy parish books, grave-lists and harbour rolls. The south filled forty chests. The northern shires filled one, for few of the Tuathaich would talk to the clerks.

The five lighthouses of the humans were given Dia-thìreach keepers. At Baile chrom, on the Tuathaich coast, the keeper's warrant bade him report what he saw by land as well as by sea. In time he reported that the Grey Night sect kept its vigil in the lighthouse's own shadow. The council took no action.

The Library also dug. At Làrach an Dùin<sup>2</sup> its trenches turned up walls older than any Dia-thìreach building and no writing at all, and the finds were catalogued as belonging to the Old Ones, purpose unknown. At Làrach an Teampaill<sup>3</sup> the houses of the Seann Spioradan asked it not to dig, and the keeper entered the ruin as *measured and let be*. The obelisk near Cnoc bheag bore signs that matched no script known on the island. In this age as in every age, the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>4</sup> appear only in what they left, and in what the living will not do near it.

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2. the fortress ruin

3. the temple ruin

4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich



When Ailean Leabhar died in SE 40, Mòrag nic Coinnich became keeper. She began the practice, kept ever since, of writing beside each item where it came from. In SE 42 Gormshuil laid down the chronicle. Her last entry is a list of what the record did not hold: the northern towns' own accounts, the humans' treaties in their own tongue, and the Board's surveys. Her successor, Tormod mac Sheu-mais, called Tormod Pinn for the speed of his hand, copied that list into the front of his first book and added nothing to it. He struck nothing out, either.

## VII

### Of Brìghde and Eòghan, and the First Word of the Depletion

**N**iall died, and his daughter Brìghde was crowned on 31 an Lùnastal, SE 22, at summer's end, and no one contested it. It was a mortal succession in an aristocracy that stood very near the undying, and it seemed nothing strange. Gormshuil wrote that the succession came *mar a thàinig Niall*, and that is the only idiom she let into the chronicle in all her years.

On 12 am Màrt, SE 26, in the raw end of winter, the survey reports first began to say, very quietly, that the vein's yield was falling.

Iain mac Ruairidh of the Mine Board, whom the hewers called Iain Mapa, had spent long months crawling the faces of the Sloc Mòr with a lamp and a chain, and he knew what he had found before he had finished finding it. The vein was thinning to the east and to the south, and it was thinning in a way that did not argue.

He carried his survey to the Board himself, rolled and tied, and laid it on the table in front of three men who did not unroll it while he was in the room.

"It will be considered," said the one in the middle.

"I should like a receipt," said Iain Mapa.

The clerk looked at him as though he had asked for a kiss. But he wrote one, and signed it, and Iain Mapa folded it into his pocket-book and went home. The survey was filed and never circulated. Soon after, he was sent to the silver works at Muileann chiar.

The next year the Board moved its clerks to Cathair mhòr and made a rule that its surveys were to be kept there and not sent to the Library. The state did nothing for years. The Library could not know what it was never sent. It knows now, and it counts those years as part of the Depletion.

Brighde's reign ended young, and no cause was ever made public. Her cousin Eòghan was crowned on 11 an Gearran, SE 28, amid the first true strife over a succession that the restored kingdom had known. The chronicler's entry gives the fact and nothing more, and no chronicler since has added to it. In an Dùbhlachd of that year the council's minutes recorded votes against a succession for the first time. They name the councillors and not their reasons. Two of them did not sit again.

On 9 an Cèitean, SE 29, in the green of an Cèitean, Dubhan was born, mortal, into the confinement the Severance had made, decades after the war that had shut the island to the people his line came from. No chronicle of that year mentions him, and none could have.

The kingdom went on round the Depletion it had not announced. In SE 33 the second census measured, for the first time, the gap between Dia-thìrich and Tuathaich living. The report was never made public. A census clerk, Seonag nic Ille-Mhoire, left a note among her papers saying that she had asked to see it and had been refused, and that note is the only mention of the report outside the council.

That year Walter Hale died, and the Moot chose Mary Coyle, a fisherman's widow, the first woman in its chair. The Còmhrag grew bloodier. In SE 36 six fighters died, and the custodians asked for it to end. The fair-wardens of Ceann leathan, whose town lived off the crowds, refused.

On the first day of an t-Iuchar in SE 39 a gallery gave way under Muileann dhearg, in the reopened Cill ghlas district, along a line the surveyors had marked as sound. Thirty-one hewers died. It was small beside the Rending. It was the same fault. New rules for digging followed. They were written for Dia-thìreach workers, and near the Tuathaich country they were kept loosely, and by intent. At the pits round Àth leathan, where Dia-thìreach overseers worked Tuathaich hands, the timbering rules were posted on the pit-head door and never paid for. The overseers' books show the timber ordered and never delivered. Àth leathan will come into this book again.

## VIII

### Of the Search for a Second Vein

**A**fter Muileann dhearg the Guild of Hewers bound sixty apprentices to fill its rolls, and not one of them was Tuathaich. On Samhain eve of SE 40 fire ran through the fair at Muileann òg. Its court sat in a field the next morning, and the fair went on, and Oighrig nic Mhathain died of her burns. That winter the Rail Board refused to carry the Moot's goods, and the north's wool went south by cart, five days on the road. The north calls that way the Carters' Road. The south has no name for it.

In the dark of the year's end in SE 41 the Moot began a register of Tuathaich hewers killed or maimed in the western pits, since no Dia-thìreach book counted them. It has been kept ever since, and never sent south. In those years Dubhan was a child in the north, watching a caste that did not age hold every true advantage on an island to whose edge his own forebears had been pushed. The coal was never his to inherit.

The age had its good keepers too. When the dry years came back to Achadh shean in SE 43, the council sent grain up the coal line out of the Sloc Mòr's share, and nobody in the shire died of hunger. The maor had twelve wells dug to the rock, and four of them are still drawn from.

Of Ciorstaidh nic Artair it is told at Tobar dhearg that her father, the keeper of the light there, drowned going out to a boat on the reef, and that she went out after him and brought the boat's crew in. She took his warrant, and set a belled post on the reef. While she kept the light, no boat went aground there.

On 12 an t-Samhain, SE 46, when the leaves were down, the druid schools, Scoiltean nan Draoidhean<sup>1</sup>, whom many still call Feallsanachd an Fhèidh<sup>2</sup>, woke out of their long sleep. Their founding question, why the vein answers some hands and not others, mattered again now that the vein was running short. Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain lectured in Flidais's sacred wood near Muileann chiar, and at Caol shean her students copied the census line on the coal-touched and argued over it in the open, which the Rite did not do. They set the old pillars and the obelisk side by side and found signs in common, and no meaning. Seonaid wrote that the Old Ones had been here and had said so, and that nobody living could hear them.

In SE 50 Alasdair mac Ùisdein, grandson of the first holder of the Sloc Mòr, borrowed against his house's share to go looking for a second vein. The Board lent its surveyors and the Crown lent its name. Seonaid wrote to the Board that the

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1. the druid schools

2. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

search asked the wrong question. Her school had always asked why the vein answered some hands; nobody had asked why there was only one vein. The Board filed the letter.

The search failed. Forty-one shafts went down between the hills above Dùn dhearg and the moors south of Baile ruadh, and none of them struck the vein. Afterwards Mòrag nic Coinnich found in the Library a list from the Holy Age that named those same hills as searched and barren. The kingdom had repeated a failure that its own Library could have warned it of, had anyone thought to ask. The house of Mac Ùisdein paid part of Dùn dhearg's damages and sold half its share back to the Crown. The dry shafts at Baile ruadh were left open to the sky, and sheep fell into them, and one child, before the shire fenced them at its own cost.

In SE 55 Mary Coyle laid down the chair, and Daniel Frayne of Muileann leathan came after her, the first speaker born after the Severance. He had taught young Tuathaich to bind books when the southern guilds would not take them. That winter the fair gave one day to northern goods. They were still sold through factors, but under the makers' own marks, and it was the first time a Tuathaich name had been written on anything sold there. The first such mark was the Doire ghlas weavers' grey twill, with a white thread at the selvedge. Within the year the weavers of Baile chiar were weaving a white thread into theirs.

On 11 am Màrt, SE 56, the Depletion could no longer be denied.

Catrìona nic Neacail, the surveyor-general, had drawn the last untouched sections of the vein, and they were smaller than anyone wished to admit. When the drawing was finished it fitted on one sheet. Because a sheet so small wanted explaining, she went down into the Board's files at Cathair mhòr to learn how long the thinning had been going on.

It took her the best part of a week, by a smoking lamp. Near the bottom of a press she found a survey of the faces of the Sloc Mòr, rolled and tied, in a hand she did not know. It showed the vein thinning to the east and the south, and it was thirty years old.

She published her map. She sent the Library a copy of Iain Mapa's survey, with a note of the day the Board had received it, and within the year she resigned. Iain Mapa died at Muileann chiar that same spring. His own copy of the survey was found among his papers with the Board's receipt pinned to it. He had kept the proof that he told them.

Muileann dhearg lost a third of its households. Its Fèidh hall was shut, and its bell was sold to Caol shean, where it still rings the students in to their lectures.

I X

## Of Mairead and the Failing of the Coal

**M**airead was crowned on 29 an Dàmhair, SE 58, in the fall of the leaf. Eòghan's reign had ended in the decade the Depletion came into the open, and she was heir to a kingdom whose founding wealth was plainly failing. That year the Guild of Hewers bound no apprentices, for the first time since its charter.

The north began building things that did not hang on the mountain. In SE 59 wool mills went up at Doire ghlas with Moot money. The Rail Board refused to carry their cloth, until the circuit justice at Seann Bhral, Ruairidh mac Phàdraig, ruled that the Board was a carrier of the Crown and must carry for anyone who paid. It was the first ruling the Moot ever won in a Dia-thìreach court. The Board appealed, and the council let the appeal lapse without a reason given.

In SE 60 the Crown bought the last of the house of Mac Ùisdein's working shafts, and from then on the Board worked the vein in the Crown's name alone.

On 1 an t-Iuchar, SE 61, Dubhan began his experiments, trying to make a fuel to stand in for the coal out of what the mines threw away. They all failed, and the record of those years scarcely troubles to name them. In that same month the lowest galleries of the Sloc Mòr were let flood, because the pumps cost more to run than the coal beneath them was worth. The Board's minute calls it a pause.

The chronicle of those years is full of small alarms. Panthers came across the south-west, beasts named in the Holy Age lists and not seen in living memory, and the old list named the year after them as a hungry one. At Muileann chrom the yard families stopped the coal trains for three days over cut wages; the Board settled on the fourth day and dismissed eleven men on the fifth. Then the harvest after the panthers came in good, and Tormod Pinn drew a line through his own note of the year before. This book has always liked him for it.

In the autumn of SE 64 the third census published its figures openly, the first census in the kingdom's history to do so. It was a small reform, and nothing in the frame of the kingdom moved because of it.

A month later the figures were read at Caol mhòr. Daniel Frayne sat in the Moot's chair with his hands flat on the table, the way he sat when he meant to keep them still. The clerk read the columns in a flat voice. In every column the census clerks had chosen to take, the northern towns stood at about half the Dia-

thìreach measure. Nobody in the room was surprised. They had simply never heard it read aloud from the kingdom's own paper.

When the clerk had done, there was a long quiet. Then Daniel Frayne drew the minute-book towards him and wrote two words, and the words are the whole of the minute: *Now written*.

The census carried a line for the coal-touched, as the first one had, giving a number and nothing else. Tormod Pinn copied it into the chronicle without comment, as Gormshuil had done before him.

Tormod Pinn died at his desk in SE 65 and Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh became royal chronicler. She was the first to add, at the foot of each year, a note of what the record could not learn. Her first concerned the northern shires. The census clerks there had been told the figures and had not counted them, and the figures they were told were the Moot's. So the kingdom's first honest census was honest in the north because the Moot had supplied the numbers.

Mòrag nic Coinnich now called the shires' record-chests in to Muileann chaol. At Seann Tarr the shire keeper burned his chest in the yard sooner than send it, saying that the shire's record belonged in the shire, and that chest is lost. In SE 67 the Library doubled its holdings, and from then on the history of Dia-thìr was kept in one place instead of many.

No Tuathaich record was called in. The Moot's minute-books, the schools' registers and the vigil-books of Baile chrom stayed in the north in private keeping. The new wing was built of Sloc Mòr stone. The shires' chests filled three floors, and the fourth was left empty for what had not been sent. It is empty still, or near enough.

In the west the Board was drawing back. In SE 68 it closed the branch line to Àth leathan, citing the falling yield of the western pits. The Tuathaich hewers there kept working under their own pit captains and paid the Crown's fifth by the Leòid ruling, and the Board took the payments and entered them as arrears. At Cnoc thais the pits passed to their hewers in the same way. The south did not notice; it wanted nothing in the western hills any longer.

In SE 70 Ragnall mac Mhuirich became keeper of the Library. The price of coal-fuel at the fair doubled, and at Cnoc fhiadhaich households were found picking coal off the spoil-heaps to burn. The Board posted watchmen from the town, who saw nothing.

X

## Of the Eve of Dubhan

**T**he summer of SE 71 came in dry and dear. The poorer streets of the capital were darker than they had been since the humans first lit them, the Guild of Hewers bound no apprentices, and the fair's court could not hold its price. So far as the kingdom's own record knew, its seventy-first year held nothing larger than a watch set on the spoil-heaps, whose watchmen saw nothing.

In the north Dubhan was at his work still, as he had been for ten years, boiling and burning what the pits threw away. Nobody in the capital was watching him, and nobody in the Library knew his name. One night near midsummer, the tellers of the north say, he banked his fire and slept beside it, as he had on a hundred nights before.

Here the Sixth Book ends, with the fire banked in the north and the kingdom asleep. The Library closes the Age of the Kingdom on that night, and the Severance Era with it.





THE SEVENTH BOOK

# AN AOIS DHUBHAIN

*the Age of Dubhan*

DE 1 – 27

*Bho latha a' chiad dubhain cunntar na bliadhnaichean às ùr.* From  
the day of the first dubhan the years shall be counted anew.  
— the council's proclamation of the Dubhan Era, 5 an Cèitean, DE

15

I

## Of Dubhan's Fire

**O**n 19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1, about midsummer, the first working dubhan was made, and from that morning the island counts the years of its seventh age, the Dubhan Era, though nobody counted them so for fourteen years. It was crude, and it burned. Nobody yet traded in it; for the while it was one man's answer to a crisis that the caste in power had still not faced. At the foot of that year Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh wrote that a fuel made without the vein was reported from the north, and that she had not seen it. That is the first mention of dubhan in the royal record, and she spelled the word three ways in two lines.

In the capital the poorer streets were left dark to save coal. By DE 3 coal was sold at the fair only by the sack, and at last only by the lump, for altars.

Cathal was crowned on 1 an Lùnastal, DE 3, the feast of Lùnastal, by Macha's rite. Mairead's reign had ended while Dubhan's experiments still failed more of-

ten than they worked, and Cathal did not yet know how near his kingdom's answer lay. The new dies at the mint still pressed the coal ink into the seal.

The fuel came south within three years. In DE 4 a company of shipmasters set up a dubhan works at Seann Skell on the southern coast, the first outside the north, and how they came by the making of it they never told. The high custodian wrote to the houses of the Rite that the new fuel was not forbidden, since it was not coal, and not blessed, since it was not coal. It sold its first year's making to the south-coast boats and the capital's lamp-houses, and the dark streets were the first to be lit again.

In DE 6 the five coastal beacons, which had burned coal-lit flame for more than a century, were the first works of the kingdom to be turned over to dubhan by decree.

Ciorstaidh nic Artair was grey by then, but nobody else was let carry the lantern. Inside its thick glass the flame of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>1</sup> burned with the dark, coloured edge that only the island's coal gives. She carried it into the Rite's house at Seann Skell in the high summer, down the hall between the custodians of four shires, who stood in their rows and did not speak. Her boots were loud on the flags.

At Bride's altar she set the lantern down and opened its little door. The flame leaned towards the air, and steadied. Nobody told her to go, so she stayed, and so did they, while the last of the coal burned down. It took longer than anyone had thought. When the flame shrank to a blue bead and then to nothing, a thread of smoke went up and hung under the roof, and one of the custodians let out a breath as if he had been holding it the whole while.

The south coast has a song of that day in more than one form. This is the shortest:

*Dh'fhalbh an lasair às an tùr, tha solas ann, ach chan ann leinn.* The flame has gone out of the tower; there is a light there, but it is not ours.

At Baile chrom, on the Tuathaich coast, the change was made by Tuathaich fitters from Caol mhòr, because the Lighthouse Board had none of its own to send so far. The keeper's report names none of them.

After that the change came to everything, and it came fast. On 1 an Cèitean, DE 8, Bealltainn, the Rail Board ran its first dubhan engine on the coal line. It

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1. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

carried no coal. The drovers sold their oxen for lorries. On 25 an t-Ògmhios, DE 9, the fitters at Seann Skell set a lorry's engine under a closed carriage for the high custodian of the Rite, the first carriage on the island that needed no horse, and on 5 an t-Iuchar, DE 13, buses began to run out of the capital to Inis mhòr and Cath-air mhòr. The roadside inns put in dubhan lamps, and centuries of oil and wick were gone within a decade. At An Leòmhann Buidhe<sup>2</sup> the landlord kept one wick lamp burning over the door beside the new ones, and a wick lamp over an inn door is still called a Leòmhann.

In DE 8 Daniel Frayne died, and the Moot chose Martha Greaves of Doire ghlas, a mill manager. His old pupils rebound the Moot's minute-books from the first meeting onward. The Moot's minute says that a second set was made and hidden elsewhere. The Library notes this and has not gone looking.

In DE 10 the last working face under Muileann dhearg was closed. The hewers' families that remained were moved to the Hewers' Row at Seann Toll, and most of them went to work on the dubhan tanks at the river landing. The pit quarter of Muileann dhearg was left with its druid house, its graves and a caretaker.

By DE 11 *dubhan* meant the fuel and no longer the man, years before the trade built on it was whole. A letter of the Fèidh school at Caol shean coined *dubhan-tùsail* for a first attempt that looks like a dead end until it turns out to be the road. On 30 an Cèitean, DE 12, the Guild of Hewers dissolved itself. Its rolls, its oath-stone of coal and its sick-roll went to the Library. Its last master, Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh, wrote that the guild had outlived the mountain's patience.

By DE 13 the markets, the army's supply lines and the shipping were all going over to the new fuel. The coal caste watched its own source of power fail and did not object. The house of Mac Ùisdein sold the last of its share in the spoil and put its money into dubhan shipping at Ros dhomhain, the only family of the vein that moved before the vein failed it.

In DE 14 the fitters of dubhan engines were chartered as a guild at Seann Skell. Like every guild before it, its rolls were open to Dia-thìrich only, and the Tuathaich fitters were let go. They went home and fitted engines without a guild. That winter the Moot voted to take up the new fuel, and the delegates of the western pit towns got up and walked out. When the northern depots opened, Martha

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2. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

Greaves wrote in the minute that the north now bought its fire from the south, and she did not say whether that was good.

On 5 an Cèitean, DE 15, the coinage was pegged to the making of dubhan in place of the coal reserves, which was a quiet way of owning which of the two now ran the kingdom. At the same sitting the council proclaimed that the Age of the Kingdom had ended with the first working dubhan, and that the kingdom's years were counted anew from that day. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh re-headed fourteen years of her chronicle, and wrote at the foot of the page that she had never before had to move a year she was living in. The coal ink was left out of the seal, and the seal was plain. Fearchar Bonn's first dies went to the Library, where they lie beside the Hewers' oath-stone. The high custodian protested that a plain seal showed the vein was no longer held sacred. The council answered that the kingdom had never said it did. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh copied both letters into the chronicle. It is one of the few places in the whole record where the kingdom said plainly what it was.

The north has a rhyme from those years, heard there in both tongues. This is its Dia-thìris form:

*Dubh an gual, 's dubh an dubhan, ach cò leis an teine?* Black the coal, and  
black the dubhan; but whose is the fire?

## II

### Of the Holdouts of the Western Hills

**I**n the spring of DE 16 the western pit towns met at Muileann àrsaidh, apart from the Moot, and agreed to go on working their seams and to sell their coal to any household in the north that would buy it. Àth naomh, with only a few old shafts to its name, joined them, saying it would rather be cold with its neighbours than warm alone. So a knot of northern towns refused to fold themselves into the new trade. They kept to the last workable coal seams sooner than hang their fires on one man's fuel. They were Àth leathan, Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais, Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg, and their spokeswoman was Ruth Calder, a pit captain's daughter from Àth leathan. The Moot neither joined nor condemned them. At Cnoc thais Tom Varley opened again two shafts that had lain

abandoned since the humans' time. The coal was poor. It was theirs, and it kept the town warm.

In DE 17 Ellen Marsh, a schoolteacher of Doire ghlais, finished eleven books of Tuathaich accounts of the Severance and the settling, taken down from the old people of the north. She asked Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>1</sup>, formally, to keep the Tuathaich tellings beside the Dia-thìreach record. The request was tabled, and it lies on the table yet. Ragnall mac Mhuirich replied that it awaited the council's view on the standing of spoken witness. The council has never given one. Ellen Marsh wrote back that spoken witness had been good enough for the census clerks when they took the Moot's figures. Her letter is filed with the request. It is short, and nobody has answered it.

The holdout pits undersold dubhan across the north, and the Moot's own mills bought their coal. In DE 18 the Board's northern revenue fell by a quarter, the first fall since the Severance, and its report named the western pits as the cause and the Leòid ruling as the cure. Eighty years after Eilidh nic Leòid gave it, her ruling was put to the use the north had always feared. The Board declared the western seams Crown property, holding that the right to work them had lapsed when the holders stopped paying the fifth. The holders answered that they had stopped paying when the Board stopped carrying the coal. Both were true. The pits were ordered shut.

A company of enforcers was posted to Seann Skell in the west, which is another town from the Rite's Seann Skell in the south. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh noted that it was the first armed company the kingdom had sent toward the north since the Severance. Martha Greaves wrote that the western towns would not shut their pits because of a letter, and asked for a year while the Moot talked with them. Her letter was received and filed.

In the autumn of DE 19 the first skirmishes began. Each was too small to name and none was written down, and together they ran straight into open war. At the foot of that year Beathag wrote that clashes were reported in the west, and that she had asked for the Board's reports of them. They were not given. At Muileann àrsaidh the pit-heads were walled and the road from the south was dug across. On 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19, which was Christmas Day, Ruth Calder wrote to the council for the western towns and offered the Crown's fifth in coal, if the Board

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1. the Library at Muileann chaol

would carry it and let the pits work until the seams were spent. The letter reached the Library. No answer to it did.

In DE 20, in the depth of winter, the Moot resolved by nine votes that it was no party to the quarrel and would feed anyone who came to its towns hungry. That summer it filled its granaries at Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas beyond the usual. The minute gives no reason. It needed none.

In an Lùnastal Beathag laid down the office, and her clerk Sileas nic Rath became royal chronicler. It is her record of the war that the Library now keeps sealed. In an Dàmhair came the order to mobilise. Regiments that had not been called out since the Severance were formed again and armed again, openly, months before anyone in power would admit that a war was coming. Command went to Somhairle mac Lachlainn, who had risen among the Board's enforcers. The rolls of the Severance companies were brought out of the council's chests to name the new regiments, and the old names were read aloud before new men. The list had been kept for nearly ninety years. Now it was used.

On 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20, Christmas Day again, Martha Greaves came to Cathair dhearg with the Moot's petition.

She had kept the feast on the road, in a cold carriage, and she came into the capital in the grey forenoon with the frost still white on the bridge. The Dia-thìrich keep no feast that day, and the council was sitting. She waited on a bench in a passage for most of an hour, the petition on her knee. Then a clerk said her name, in the Dia-thìris way, so that for a moment she did not know it for hers.

She was the first speaker of the Moot ever to walk into the council chamber. It was smaller than she had thought, and warm with a dubhan stove. Twelve faces turned to her. She read the petition standing. It asked that the western pits be let alone to work out their seams, which would be spent within a few years in any case. She read it to the end without hurrying, and laid it on the table.

"Received," said the clerk, and wrote.

It was filed. That winter the Rail Board carried arms and dubhan west to Seann Bhral, and the yard at Muileann chrom worked on the trains day and night.

III

## Of An Cogadh Fada, the Long War

*What is told here of the war comes from the open record, the towns' reports and the Tuathaich tellings; the rest is sealed.*

Late in am Faoilleach of DE 21 the hewers of the five towns came together at Àth leathan, where the road from the south goes up into the hills. In the north they tell it like this. It was bitter weather, with a thin snow blowing that would not lie, and the men and women came in by the hill paths with their pit-lamps lit at noon, the sky was so dark. They slept in the pit-sheds, and in the byres with the cattle for the warmth. Ruth Calder went from fire to fire with a list, asking who was here, and who was coming. The Board's lists name her among them, and Tom Varley too.

From Cathair dhearg the regiments marched west, and their carts and lorries ran on dubhan.

The Battle of Àth leathan was fought on 11 an Giblean, DE 21, in the spring, the first great battle of An Cogadh Fada<sup>1</sup>. The state, already leaning on Dubhan's fuel to prop its fading power, moved against the holdouts with its own hand. The open record counts the kingdom's dead and not the holdouts'. The Tuathaich tellings put theirs in the hundreds. Ruth Calder's name does not appear in the open record after that day. Whether she fell there, no teller in the north will say for certain. Her name simply stops.

The holdouts gave up the southern pits and fell back into the hills round Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais. The pits of Àth leathan were flooded on the Board's order, and the field was left unploughed. The seventh regiment was raised on the west coast to hold the road behind the army. Before the month was out a wartime tithe was laid on every sale of dubhan in the kingdom, for the war's sake. It was never lifted. Fleets were raised and sent round the western cape to close the Tuathaich ports of the north-west to every boat but the fishing boats, and to search those.

Late in an Cèitean the regiments invested Muileann àrsaidh. The town held out for weeks on stored coal and potatoes, and its pit-heads were taken one at a time. Sileas nic Rath's open record gives the day it fell and nothing more. The

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1. the Long War

army's dubhan was served before any other use, and the capital's poorer streets went dark again, as they had been before the fuel came.

The families of the western pits came into Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas with what they could carry. The Moot fed them from its own stores, as it had resolved to. The council sent nothing and forbade nothing. The Moot's minute records the families' names, and it is among the few Tuathaich records of the war that the Library does not hold. Agnes Pike's old school at Doire ghlas was given over to them, and Ellen Marsh, who taught there, took down their accounts. This book would give a good deal to read them.

In an Lùnastal Cnoc thais was taken, after the regiments cut the road to its pits, and Tom Varley's two shafts were fired and sealed. The open record gives the number of holdouts taken and not the number who went on into the hills. Some went on past the hills and out onto the windy coast, beyond the shire lines, and the regiments did not follow them there. With the fleets away in the north-west, raiders out of the east took two salt-boats off Àth bheag and burned a third.

Through the autumn the kingdom went on raising regiments, as if it looked for a longer war. The fourth regiment was quartered at Ceann mhòr in the old human magistrate's house, and the Moot's protest was received.

In an Dùbhlachd the regiments came to Baile chrom on the night of the vigil.

The corporal at the head of the file had come up the coast road expecting shutters and dogs and shouting. There was nothing. Not a lamp showed in any window. No dog barked. The only sound was the sea on the stones and his own men's boots, and even they began to tread softer without being told.

He tried the first door. It was unlatched. Inside, by the grey of the window, a man and a woman and three children sat round a cold hearth with their hands in their laps. None of them spoke. He asked them, in Dia-thìris and then in the humans' tongue, who else was in the house, and whether there were arms. The man only shook his head, once, slowly, as a man does at a child who has asked a foolish thing in church.

It was the same in the next house, and the next, until the small hours. He wrote in the end that the whole town had been dark and silent, and that it had been searched and nothing found. The regiments' return for that month says as much, and no more.

That month Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg opened their roads without a siege. Their pits were flooded. The open record names no holdouts taken at either.



Late in an Dàmhair of the next year a column of holdouts, several hundred strong, came out of the western hills, and through an t-Samhain it moved south-east through the middle of the island toward the capital. The reason lies in the sealed archive. The Tuathaich tellings give its leader the name Owen Barrow; the open record gives him none. On 6 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22, the column passed Muileann òg and made camp on the fields by Muileann ghlas, a day's walk from Cathair dhearg, and the first and third regiments were brought down the fair road to meet it. The booths of the fair-ground were cleared for their camp, and the fair court's books for that year end without a closing entry.

The Battle of Muileann ghlas was fought on 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22, four days after, in the short grey days before midwinter. It was the second great battle of the war, and the last. The holdouts were broken in two summers' campaigning. They were the children of humans once pushed to the island's edge, and now they were pushed back again, and the fuel that drove the lorries against them had been made by one of their own. The open record lists the first and third regiments on the field and does not count the column's dead. When word reached the hills, the holdouts still there came down to the seventh regiment's posts on the Àth leathan road. They were disarmed and sent home, and the open record counts their weapons.

So An Cogadh Fada ended on 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22, twenty months after it began, and it has been called the Long War all the same. Nine regiments and four fleets were raised in it. All are under arms yet, and each is named for the town where it is stationed.

Before the year was out the Tuathaich had a new saying. *Chaidh am fadachadh*, they got long-warred, was said first of the defeat in the west, and then of any defeat that comes after holding out too long. It is said as a joke, and the people who say it do not laugh.

#### IV

### Of the Peace, and of the Present Year

**T**he regiments were not stood down. The council kept each at the town where it had been raised and paid them out of the wartime tithe. With the last organised resistance gone, Dubhan's fuel became, in all but law, compulsory across the whole island. The last western seams were flooded and capped

with concrete, and after that no coal was dug on Dia-thìr outside the Board's own works. The holdouts taken at Muileann ghlas were marched north as far as the boundary stones, the stones set in SE 1 that nobody had ever been paid to move. The Moot's register gave their names a column of their own. Somhairle mac Lachlainn was given a seat on the council, the first soldier to sit there since the captains of the Severance war.

In DE 23 the kingdom raised a stone at Cathair mhòr, beside the Mac Ùisdein market cross, with the names of the regiments' dead. On the field of Àth leathan the Tuathaich families built a cairn without leave. The seventh regiment's patrols have let it stand, and it grows by a stone or two every time they pass. At Muileann ghlas the field was sown again, and for years its farmer turned up weapons in the furrows and handed them to the first regiment, which keeps a list.

On 14 am Faoilleach, DE 24, the Library's whole record of the Long War was sealed from the public for fifty years. It is the only sealed archive in the kingdom's history. What is still open for the war years is Sileas nic Rath's list of places, the regiments present, and the counts she was allowed to give. Her full record went into the sealed room with everything else. Ailean Leabhar said once that the Library settles nothing and only keeps. He never foresaw that it would keep a thing it was not let read.

The war left its accounts. The Treasury carried the wartime tithe forward as a standing line under the regiments' pay, and no council minute records a decision to keep it. The fuel-fitters took the contract for the regiments' engines and doubled their rolls, and every new fitter was Dia-thìrich.

In an t-Ògmhios of DE 25 Anna nic Phàil, councillor for Cathair dhomhain, brought the Moot's petition before the council: that the Tuathaich towns be paid for what they had lost in the war. She spoke for it once. On 10 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25, the proposal was raised in the capital and quietly let die without a vote. The Moot's minute on it is one line long: *Allowed to die*. Martha Greaves laid down the chair that year, and the Moot chose Peter Hale, great-grandson of its first speaker. The fourth regiment left the magistrate's house at Ceann mhòr. The Moot asked that the house be given to the town. It was given to the maor.

By DE 26 the Tuathaich had one name for the tabled request and the dead motion together: *seann-chunntas*, an old reckoning that nobody in power will settle and nobody has struck out. Official Dia-thìreach usage has not taken up the word. This book uses it, since the record should hold the words of both peoples.

That year the mountain was shut, or nearly. The Board closed the upper galleries of the Sloc Mòr and kept one face open, in the Rite's custody, to cut coal for the altars. Twelve hewers were kept on to work it, the last of their trade on the island. On 10 an t-Sultain, DE 26, the last coal train ran to Cathair dhearg. The coal line has kept its name and carries dubhan, wool and soldiers. The second regiment set a guard at the Library over the sealed archive, and Ragnall mac Mhuirich wrote to the council that the Library had not asked for one. On the northern road, where the boundary stones stand, the sixth regiment keeps posts, and Tuathaich going south show a pass for the first time since the Severance. The council's minute calls the passes temporary. The reader will know by now what the kingdom's temporary measures tend to become.

The last year and this one have been like other years. Tuathaich wool was sold at Muileann òg on its northern day, through Dia-thìreach factors, as at the first fair. The Còmhrag was fought with staves and fists, and one man died. Ellen Marsh's eleven books have been copied by hand in the northern schools and are kept there; the Library's catalogue lists the tabled request and not the books. The Moot met at Caol mhòr under Peter Hale, its minute-books unbroken since Walter Hale's wet afternoon, with no standing in Dia-thìreach law and no request for any. Every lamp and engine on the island, every ship and every lorry, runs on dubhan; the coinage is pegged to it, and the tithe is taken on every sale. The Treasury's roll for the year stood at 9,568 purses, two parts in three of it from the head-due. In the autumn the Rite's twelve hewers cut the year's altar-coal. It filled four baskets, and the high custodian shared it among the houses by lot.

On 7 an t-Sultain, DE 27, as the summer went out, Dubhan himself, an old man now in his sixty-ninth year, won from the council at Cathair dhearg the right to sell dubhan off the island. He had written to the council for a year and sat before it three times. It is the first leave the kingdom has given for any good of Dia-thìr to go beyond its waters since the Severance, and it is narrowly drawn. The Treasury sets each year's measure. The fuel is loaded only at Ros dhomhain, where a clerk of the Treasury takes the tithe on every barrel. The kingdom's depots and the Moot's are served first. The custodians of Òrd Bhrìde<sup>1</sup> seal every hold, since nothing of the vein may be sold. Dubhan has told neither the council nor the chronicler who his buyers are. The first tank-hull loaded under the charter went out past the north-western capes in the autumn, and at Seann Skell

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1. the order of Bride's flame

the priests of Manannan said the old prayer to keep the sea shut on the day she sailed. Dubhan goes out under that charter and no other.

On 22 an t-Samhain, DE 27, with the lamps lit by mid-afternoon at Muileann chaol, Sileas nic Rath wrote at the foot of the year that the kingdom's record is whole in every part but two: the war, which is sealed, and the north, which was not asked.

So the account stands on 21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27, at the turning of the year's shortest days. The coal is all but gone. The kingdom's trade runs on a name that once belonged to one man, and since the autumn a little of it has gone out past the north-western capes under his charter. The Dia-thìrich hold the capital and the sea. The Tuathaich hold the north, and their Church, and a grievance five years old, and a memory of the First Canoe that the people who twice defeated them still call folklore. The restored kingdom promised the island its own again. It kept the humans' tariff, their surveys, their rails and their terms for the mountain, and it kept the humans' children where the humans had put them. It kept faith as well with the drowned towns of the south, and its wells at Achadh shean still draw water.

Here the Seventh Book stops, at the present year, for the chronicle itself goes on. The age that follows has no name yet, because nobody can yet say what began it. It is left to the next chronicler, who will be handed the whole record and, with it, the things still missing from it: the war in its guarded room, which is to be opened fifty years from its sealing if the kingdom keeps its word; the fourth floor at Muileann chaol, built for what was not sent; the eleven books in the north; and the Moot's minutes with their hidden second set. The old reckoning is still owed. Whoever writes the next book should begin by asking for them.

PART TWO

# The ANNALS OF Δια- τῆρ

## AGE I · AN AOIS ÀRSAIDH

*The Ancient Age · the Vein Era, VE 1 – 5,324*

- 20 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1** — *The mason's fire.* Neachdan, a mason splitting rock for a well, breaks into a vein of hard coal that shows every colour in the break. That night a storm comes over the hills, and lightning strikes the broken vein, and it takes fire. He carries a burning coal home and lays the first hearth: it is the first fire of the Dia-thìrich. On it he tries the other coals he broke out, and all burn alike, with a low black flame; he is glad of the fire all the same.
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, VE 76** — *Three wells claim the crack* (Tobar dhìreach). Tobar dhìreach, Tobar dhubh and Tobar òg each tell that the mason's well was theirs, and that the lightning fell there. Tobar dhìreach can show a capped shaft with a scorched stain on its lip; the other two have only the telling. Between the three no chronicler has ever judged.
- 19 AM MÀRT, VE 151** — *The slab over the burnt vein* (Tobar dhìreach). When the fire in the vein has burned itself out, the mason's people dig no further. They lay a flat stone over the broken vein, draw no water beside it, and cut their well again a stone's throw off. In this all the tellings agree.
- 14 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 227** — *The high snowfields shrink* (Abhainn uaine). Meltwater off the central mountains cuts the bed that Abhainn uaine follows still. On the gravel terraces of its lower reach lie hearth-stones at three heights, each left as the water rose to it.
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, VE 303** — *The first hearths of the high valleys* (Achadh dhìreach). Hearths are made at Achadh dhìreach, of pine and heather charcoal, with scrapers of grey flint and the split bones of red deer about them. There is no coloured coal in them: those who sat there had none of it, or would not burn it.
- 11 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 378** — *The oak comes to the lowlands* (Doire ghlas). The birch and pine of the cold years give way to oak and hazel, as the pollen in the bog under Doire ghlas shows. The grove that names the place stands on ground that was open heath when the vein was first broken.
- 22 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 451** — *The bare north-west.* The oak never reaches the north-western horn of the island. The gales off the north-western sea keep it bare, low heather and blanket bog behind the shore without a tree, as it is still. No hearth of that age has been found there.
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 506** — *Eilean dhubh cut off* (Eilean dhubh). The rising sea floods the low neck of land that joined Eilean dhubh to the main island. The hearths of the neck lie drowned under the sand of the sound, and the deer of the island, cut off, grow smaller in the lifetimes after.
- 1 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 551** — *Hunters on Eilean mbin* (Eilean mhin). Seal-hunters pitch camps on Eilean mhin, coming there by boat: the first sure sign that anyone on Dia-thìr crossed open water of set purpose. The camps are kept a season at a time and left.

- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 611** — *Seals on the skerries* (Eilean fhada). Hunters of the north shore go out in skin boats in the autumn gales to the skerries off Eilean fhada, where the grey seals haul out to pup, and take them there. The seal bones in the middens of the north coast bear the same cut-marks as those of Eilean mhin. On Eilean fhada a hard year is counted by the boats the gales kept ashore.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 681** — *The flood-plain of Abhainn ìseal* (Abhainn ìseal). Abhainn ìseal, the longest river of the island, settles into the wide bed it keeps now. Fish-weirs of hazel stakes are set across its side channels, and the stakes are renewed in the same holes for generations.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 751** — *The middens of Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). The Seann-Dhaoine<sup>1</sup> begin the great mound at Seann Dunn: limpet shell, seal bone and burnt weed, laid down over many lifetimes until it stands taller than a man. It is the first sure trace of them. No tool in it is shaped as any later Dia-thìreach shaped tools.
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 820** — *The notched net-weights of Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). At Seann Chwen the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>2</sup> sink their nets with beach stones, and every stone is notched with the same three strokes. It is the eldest mark on Dia-thìr made again and again of purpose.
- 17 AN GEARRAN, VE 890** — *The Keeper in the grove* (Doire ghlas). In the oak grove at Doire ghlas a figure of grey smoke comes to Diarmad of the Mason's line, who has asked why the coal of the vein has colours. It names itself Coimhdeach na Fine<sup>3</sup>, the kin's keeper, and tells him of the making of the world by Caoran, the Young God, and of the gift hidden in the coal. Asked how the colours may be opened, it gives a riddle: the sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit; merge the spirits, and they become almighty. From Diarmad's line the telling of the making goes to every hearth.
- I AN T-IUCHAR, VE 951** — *The mole at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). A mole of unmortared boulders is laid out into the Abhainn naomh from the bank at Seann Skell, long enough to shelter a dozen boats from the current. Its foot lies under water still at the lowest tides, and every quay wall built there since stands on it.
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 1,027** — *The steps of Seann Bhrál* (Seann Bhrál). Two hundred and twelve steps are cut up the cliff at Seann Bhrál, from the shingle to the grazing above. Their treads are worn hollow in the middle. How many feet that took, none has reckoned.
- 4 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,096** — *The dead of Seann Vell go to Eilean dhearg* (Eilean dhearg). The Seann-Dhaoine<sup>4</sup> of Seann Vell row their dead out to Eilean dhearg and lay them in stone boxes facing the mainland. Forty boxes are counted there. No grave of theirs of this time is found on the mainland.

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

3. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,170** — *The fish-channel of Seann Toll* (Seann Toll). At Seann Toll a channel is cut through a shelf of rock into a pool beside the Abhainn uaine, with a slot for a wattle gate. When the river falls the gate is dropped and the pool emptied by hand. The slot is sharp still.
- 7 AM MÀRT, VE 1,233** — *The shell causeway of Seann Warr* (Seann Warr). A road of crushed shell is laid across the reed marsh at Seann Warr, on the western shore of Loch chrom, a little over a mile long and raised a forearm above the reeds. It is the eldest made road on the island that may still be walked.
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,301** — *The script appears at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). Rows of signs are cut into the cliff above Seann Tarr, in the script that is found afterwards on the standing stones. It is not Dia-thìris, and none has read it. No sign of it has a meaning that all accept.
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 1,370** — *The gold coal takes fire on the sea* (Ceann thais). Aodh of the Mason's line carries the seven coals of the vein down to the northern shore, below where Ceann thais now stands, and throws them into the sea one by one. The coal with the sheen of gold takes fire on the water and burns gold until the waves put it under; the other six sink. It is the first of the Seven Coals to be lit from its own spirit.
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, VE 1,443** — *The fish-kilns of Seann Mborn* (Seann Mhorn). Stone-lined pits with short flues are built above the beach at Seann Mhorn, to dry the catch over peat smoke. Seven are known. They are the first buildings on Dia-thìr made for a trade, and not for sleep or for the dead.
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, VE 1,515** — *The slipways of Seann Bhrenn* (Seann Bhrenn). Long ramps of flat stone are laid down into the water at Seann Bhrenn, wide enough for hulls greater than any hide boat. Of the hulls nothing is left, nor any telling of where they went.
- 7 AM MÀRT, VE 1,588** — *The lake dwellings of Loch chrom* (Loch chrom). Platforms on oak piles are raised in the shallows of Loch chrom and joined to the shore by plank walks. Whether the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>5</sup> built them, or some other people of those years, is not known.
- 6 AN GEARRAN, VE 1,670** — *The whale-rib houses of Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). A whale strands below the southern Seann Dunn, and its ribs are raised for the frames of three round houses roofed with turf. The ribs are set up again in new houses at least twice before they rot.
- 8 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 1,734** — *The round houses of the eastern Seann Vell* (Seann Vell). At the eastern Seann Vell the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>6</sup> build round houses of dry stone, each with a hearth sunk in the middle of the floor and a drain running out under the wall. Fourteen house-rings are counted there.

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4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

5. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich



- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 1,806** — *The tower at the north-western Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At the least of the Seann Skell places, on the north-west coast, a single round tower of dry stone is raised, hollow-walled, with a stair in the thickness of the wall. It looks out over the water where the Sea-Watcher is afterwards seen.
- 1 AN T-IÚCHAR, VE 1,879** — *The butts of the northern Seann Toll* (Seann Toll). At Seann Toll on the north coast a cluster of stone huts is built in the lee of a dune. The dune afterwards buries them whole, and the sand keeps them.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 1,951** — *The eastern Seann Bhrál* (Seann Bhrál). At the Seann Bhrál of the south-east coast the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>7</sup> keep a landing and a line of fish-kilns like those of Seann Mhorn. The two places lie within a day's rowing of each other.
- 4 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,025** — *The shell beds of the southern Seann Mhorn* (Seann Mhorn). At the second Seann Mhorn, on the southern coast, oyster, whelk and cockle shell is heaped over a whole headland, and there is little else. The oysters of its lowest layers are larger than any taken there since.
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,097** — *The twin landings of Seann Bhrenn* (Seann Bhrenn). A second Seann Bhrenn, far to the north-east of the first, has the same long ramps into the water. Whether the two were of one people, or only the name was carried, is not known.
- 2 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,170** — *The snowflake coal takes fire in the air* (Binnean a' Chlachair<sup>8</sup>). Fearghas of the Mason's line climbs to the highest ground of the island, above where Muileann gheal now stands, and lets the six unlit coals fall from the top. The coal flecked with white stars takes fire as it falls and burns white in the air; the others strike the stones cold. The summit is called after the kindred: Binnean a' Chlachair, the Mason's Point.
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,241** — *The cliff-house at Seann Tarr in the east* (Seann Tarr). At the Seann Tarr of the north-eastern headlands a single long house is built into a cleft of the cliff, with the living rock for its back wall. The rock behind the hearth is black with soot to the height of a man.
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,312** — *The north-eastern Seann Vell* (Seann Vell). The Seann Vell on the Abhainn bheag, a short way above its mouth in the north-east, is a small place of four houses and a boat-shed. No Seann-Dhaoine<sup>9</sup> dwelling on the main island is known further to the north-east.
- 22 AM MÀRT, VE 2,382** — *The northern Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At the Seann Skell below the later Ros gheal, on the north coast, the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>10</sup> lay a second breakwater, shorter than the southern one and curved against the swell of the open sea. The two moles are built the same way, stone by stone.

6. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

7. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

8. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

9. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

10. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

- 20 AN GIBLEAN, VE 2,451** — *The western Seann Vell* (Seann Vell). At the Seann Vell of the west coast the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>11</sup> dig a line of storage pits into the dune, lined with clay and lidded with slabs. Some held fish bones still when they were opened.
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, VE 2,524** — *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire*<sup>12</sup> *raised* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire). On a spur above the ground where Cathair mhòr now stands, the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>13</sup> build the walled outpost afterwards called Làrach an Dùin-fhaire. Its stones are dressed on the outer face only, and its single gate looks inland, away from the sea.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 2,576** — *Làrach an Dùin*<sup>14</sup> *raised* (Làrach an Dùin). A greater work is raised on the height near Ceann mhin: three rings of wall, a cistern cut into the bedrock, and room within, as it was later reckoned, for four hundred people and their beasts. Whether the builders of the outpost built this also has never been settled.
- 16 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 2,627** — *The kerbed way between the forts* (Àth fhionn). A kerbed track, a cart's width and paved with flat slabs, is laid through the ground near Àth fhionn toward both strongholds. It is the only road the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>15</sup> are known to have made away from the shore.
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 2,679** — *Làrach an Teampaill*<sup>16</sup> *raised* (Làrach an Teampaill). A stepped platform of fitted stone is built in the eastern hills, with an altar block on its top step. The altar is set square to the central mountains. Every later temple on Dia-thìr faces some other way.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,730** — *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the south-east* (Toll-dubh). A shaft is sunk straight down through the rock at the eastern Toll-dubh, its walls tooled smooth as far as a lamp will show. No spoil lies beside it. Whatever was taken out was carried away, or nothing was.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 2,782** — *The shaft of Toll-dubh in the west* (Toll-dubh). A second shaft of the same making is cut at the western Toll-dubh, far across the island from the first. Stones thrown into either are not heard to land.
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 2,833** — *The First Canoe*. Among the coastal Tuathaich families a half-forgotten telling of a voyage is kept, long hushed: a steersman with a name, and a first crossing to an isle of the blessed. Their church tells it as the voyage of Naomh Breandan. The druids of the Old Faith call it idle belief.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,885** — *The black coal warm in the ground* (Tobar dhìreach). Brian of the Mason's line buries the five unlit coals deep in the ground beside the slab at Tobar dhìreach. When he digs them up on the next day the black coal, as black as a wet crow, is warm in his hand and smoulders as the air comes to it; the other four are as cold as the clay.

11. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

12. the watch-fort ruin

13. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

14. the fortress ruin

15. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

16. the temple ruin

- 8 **AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 2,937** — *Stakes in the mud below Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). The first sure boats of the north-west coast leave their trace in the tidal mud below Ceann mhòr: a row of mooring stakes and a scrap of stitched hide. Who rowed them, and from where, is not known.
- 1 **AN T-SULTAIN, VE 2,990** — *The Sea-Watcher first sighted* (Uilebheist na Mara<sup>17</sup>). Old sailors tell of a vast creature dwelling in the waters off the north-western coast. No wreck has ever been brought up to prove them wrong.
- 3 **AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,042** — *The beacon on the Baile chrom headland* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>18</sup>). A fire is kept on the headland where Taigh-solais Baile chrom now stands, and its ash lies a man's height deep. The tellings say it was lit to warn boats off the water where the Sea-Watcher was seen, and never to bring them in.
- 29 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,094** — *Seven boats lost off Ros ruadh* (Ros ruadh). Seven boats are lost from Ros ruadh in one calm season, with no storm to blame. It is the first loss laid at the door of the Sea-Watcher by name; before this it was feared only in general.
- 30 **AN T-SULTAIN, VE 3,147** — *The seal hunt moves south* (Caol mhòr). The hunters of the north-west leave the open water and work the southern side of the headlands, out of the Sea-Watcher's sight. The seal bones thin in the middens of the north-west and grow at Caol mhòr and Cuan bheag.
- 8 **AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,199** — *Signs cut in the Doire uaine hills* (Doire uaine). Inscriptions are cut on rock faces all across the Doire uaine hills, more than anywhere else on the island, in lines that run for yards. Some lines are cut over and defaced with the same kind of tool that made them.
- 9 **AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,251** — *The Hollow Man of Doire uaine* (Marbh-bhèd<sup>19</sup> Doire uaine). The inscriptions of the Doire uaine hills tell of something that walked without breathing, and fell upon any who lit a fire in its sight.
- 5 **AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,304** — *The hill fires go under the ground* (Doire uaine). After the inscriptions the hearths of the Doire uaine hills are dug into pits and roofed with slabs. No open hearth shows in those hills for many lifetimes. The people stay, and hide their light.
- 6 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,351** — *The nine at the hill camp* (Muileann chiar). Nine people die inside a hut at the camp where Muileann chiar was afterwards built, and lie where they fell beside a hearth of fresh ash. No wound is found on any bone. The hut is never opened again, and none is buried from it.
- 21 **AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,408** — *Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*<sup>20</sup> *set aside* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar). A forest is held sacred long before any order of the Old Faith claims it. The trees knew it first, the old telling says, and the people after.

17. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

18. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

19. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

20. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

- 23 AM MÀRT, VE 3,470** — *No axe in the grove* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>21</sup>). The families at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar carry their fuel a half-day's walk sooner than cut a branch within it. The charcoal in their hearths is of every wood but that one.
- 11 AM MÀRT, VE 3,513** — *The white stag of the grove* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>22</sup>). Three hunters see a white stag at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar, and none of them draws. This is the first telling of it. The stag returns in the tellings again and again; in this age it has no god.
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, VE 3,570** — *Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag*<sup>23</sup> *left unclaimed* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag). A second forest, that seems older than the first, is never settled, never felled, and never walked from end to end.
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 3,618** — *The paths that stop at a line of stones* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>24</sup>). Tracks are worn toward Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag from three quarters, and all three end at a low line of set stones some way short of the trees. Beyond the stones the ground is not worn.
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 3,670** — *The blood of the misstrike* (Doire ghlas). Cormac of the Mason's line carries the four unlit coals to the grove at Doire ghlas, where the Keeper first spoke, and sets about breaking them there. His hammer misses and opens the back of his hand, and where the blood falls on the red-brown coal it takes fire. The kindred call it the coal of life.
- 10 AN GEARRAN, VE 3,720** — *The deer-drives of the eastern forest* (Doire fhionn). Lines of stakes and brush are set to drive the red deer of the eastern woods into a gully near Doire fhionn, where they are killed with spears. The antlers of the greatest stags are stacked apart from the rest.
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 3,771** — *The first dog graves* (Cnoc fhionn). At Cnoc fhionn in the east dogs are buried beside people, each with a shell at its head. No beast was given a grave on Dia-thìr before.
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 3,821** — *The geese of Eilean ghorm* (Eilean ghorm). The grey geese that winter on Eilean ghorm come into the tellings for the first time. They come in with the first storm and leave with the last, and none hunts them there.
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, VE 3,872** — *The widest reach of the Seann-Dhaoine*<sup>25</sup> (Seann Skell). At their height the Seann-Dhaoine hold every coast of the island: the ten places whose names begin with Seann, and the islands off them. Their greatest landing is at Seann Skell, up the Abhainn naomh, where the mole already stands.

21. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

22. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

23. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

24. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

25. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

- 6 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 3,922** — *The warm springs used* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>26</sup>). Stone basins are set into the springs at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh. The people buried near them have old breaks that knitted clean. Here the sick of Dia-thìr are first brought for healing.
- 29 **AN DÀMHAIR, VE 3,973** — *The gate of the outpost walled up* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>27</sup>). The single gate of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire is blocked with rubble from within. Those who did it left by another way, or did not leave.
- 27 **AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,023** — *Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>28</sup> abandoned* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire). The outpost is deserted. It lay in ruin before the first trusty chronicles, and it is older than any dwelling of the Dia-thìrich. Who built it none knows.
- 4 **AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,074** — *The fortress cistern fouled* (Làrach an Dùin<sup>29</sup>). The cistern of Làrach an Dùin is choked with the bones of cattle, thrown in whole. Its water had served four hundred people. No one draws from it again.
- 6 **AM MÀRT, VE 4,124** — *Làrach an Dùin<sup>30</sup> abandoned* (Làrach an Dùin). The fortress is deserted in like manner, and is as much a riddle as the outpost. Whether both had the same builders has never been settled.
- 5 **AN GEARRAN, VE 4,175** — *The temple altar stripped* (Làrach an Teampaill<sup>31</sup>). The top stone of the altar at Làrach an Teampaill is prised off and carried away; the sockets that held it are sharp still. It has never been found, and what was cut on it, if anything, is not known.
- 21 **AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,225** — *The silver coal in the river* (Abhainn ghorm). Eòghann of the Mason's line drinks from the Abhainn ghorm below Tobar dhreach and says, 'This water tastes different from the sea water.' He throws the three unlit coals into the stream, and the coal with the sheen of silver takes fire in the current and burns silver under the water. The coal of fire and the rainbow coal lie dark.
- 7 **AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,275** — *Làrach an Teampaill<sup>32</sup> abandoned* (Làrach an Teampaill). The temple is deserted. It is older than any faith that has a name, and its altar looks to the central mountains and the vein beneath them, away from the sea.
- 9 **AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 4,325** — *The Seann-Dhaoine<sup>33</sup> keep to the shore* (Seann Chwen). The high places are left, and every new work of the Seann-Dhaoine is made within sight of salt water. The middens at the southern Seann Chwen begin to grow as fast as those of Seann Dunn once did.

26. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

27. the watch-fort ruin

28. the watch-fort ruin

29. the fortress ruin

30. the fortress ruin

31. the temple ruin

32. the temple ruin

- 7 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 4,375** — *The ancient sea-way* (Seann Dunn). The boats of the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>34</sup> keep a lane along the south-east coast, from the river mouth below Seann Dunn round the cape where Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>35</sup> now stands to the bay of Ceann chaol. Flat landing-stones lie along it a day's rowing apart, some grooved still by hauled keels. The Dia-thìrich call it Slighe-mhara àrsaidh<sup>36</sup>, the ancient sea-way, and the fishers of that coast keep to it yet.
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,425** — *The hill-folk of the vein* (Àth gharbh). In the high valleys about the crack dwells a people other than the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>37</sup>, who call themselves Clann nan Dè<sup>38</sup>, the godkin. They bury their dead in the ground and not on islands, and they cut no script. Whether they shared the island with the Seann-Dhaoine or came after them, no telling knows; their own word, later, is that they were always there.
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,475** — *The first small burning* (Àth gharbh). At Àth gharbh a sliver of the coloured coal is burnt to a bead in a peat fire by a household not of the Mason's line. It burns black-flamed like any other coal, and the hearthstone round it is stained through with colour. No older burning of the coal by other hands is known. It is a small thing: one sliver, one fire.
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,525** — *The stained cloth of Achadh dhìreach* (Achadh dhìreach). At Achadh dhìreach the hill-folk rub broken coal from the vein into the wool of the dead, and it takes streaks of a colour no plant dye makes. It is seldom done: one grave in some thirty.
- 15 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,575** — *A sliver in a Seann Bhrál midden* (Seann Bhrál). A chip of the coloured coal, still staining the shell about it, is thrown on a midden at Seann Bhrál on the far western coast. By gift, by trade or by theft a piece of the vein came to the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>39</sup>; which, is not known.
- 18 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,625** — *The Children of the Question* (Tobar dhìreach). The households of the high valleys begin to call the Mason's line Luchd-ceasnachaidh a' Ghuail Dhìomhair<sup>40</sup>, the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal, for their long questioning of the two dark coals; the lists shorten it to Clann na Ceiste<sup>41</sup>, the Children of the Question. The kindred take the name, and Clann a' Chlachair<sup>42</sup> is heard less after.
- 17 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 4,672** — *Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>43</sup> raised* (Carragh Cnoc bheag). A standing stone is raised, on which four words are afterwards found carved: Bha teine sa chloich, "there was fire in the stone."

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33. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

34. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

35. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

36. the ancient sea-way

37. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

38. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

39. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

40. the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal

41. the Children of the Question

42. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

43. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

- 11 AN LÙNASTAL, VE 4,718** — *The older face of Carragh Cnoc bheag*<sup>44</sup> (Carragh Cnoc bheag). On the upper face of the stone runs a line of the unread script. The four Dia-thiris words lie lower, cut with a narrower tool by another hand. When that second hand came is not known.
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 4,770** — *Colbh Cnoc chiar*<sup>45</sup> *raised* (Colbh Cnoc chiar). A second stone is raised, bearing only three words: Cuimhnich an teine, "remember the fire." Who is bidden, and why, none has ever said.
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, VE 4,812** — *A ring of fire-stones round the pillar* (Colbh Cnoc chiar<sup>46</sup>). The ground about Colbh Cnoc chiar is trodden hard in a ring and paved with fire-cracked stones. Fires the size of hearths are kept there again and again. Nothing else is left.
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, VE 4,851** — *Calbh Cnoc ghorm*<sup>47</sup> *raised* (Calbh Cnoc ghorm). A third stone is raised, and on it the whole of the saying: Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann. Here, it may be, the belief was first spoken.
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 4,905** — *The fire in the fingers* (Tobar dhìreach). Seathan of Clann na Ceiste<sup>48</sup>, who has handled the coal of fire all his days to no end, snaps his fingers when a thought strikes him, and the coal-dust on his hand takes fire. He beats it out against his coat and is not burned. So the sixth coal is lit, by the fire that is in the hand itself.
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, VE 4,951** — *The gatherings at the column* (Cnoc ghorm). People come to the column at Cnoc ghorm in numbers. The post-holes of shelters for some hundreds lie about it, used and rebuilt many times. Whatever was said there was said to a crowd.
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, VE 5,010** — *Tuam Cnoc dhìreach*<sup>49</sup> *consecrated* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach). A burial-ground grows about a place that none remembers hallowing. Its oldest graves are older than the oldest names that can be read there.
- 14 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, VE 5,070** — *The black chip in the child's grave* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>50</sup>). A child is buried at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach with a sliver of the coloured coal closed in one hand. The sliver stains still the cloth it is kept in. No other piece of the vein is found with the dead of this age.
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 5,114** — *The rows at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach*<sup>51</sup> (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach). The graves at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach begin to be laid in rows, heads toward the central mountains. The first rows are straight. The later ones bend round older graves that no one will disturb.

44. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

45. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

46. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

47. the column at Cnoc ghorm

48. the Children of the Question

49. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

50. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

51. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, VE 5,170** — *The panther roads*. The great cats of the island are first seen to keep their roads, crossing the mountains by fixed ways at fixed seasons. Why they do so no one has learned.
- 20 AM FAOILLEACH, VE 5,219** — *The crossing season kept* (Imrich nam Pantar<sup>52</sup>). The hill-folk learn the panthers' seasons and keep off the high passes while the cats cross. The camps in the passes stand empty at the same point in every year.
- 7 AN T-SULTAIN, VE 5,272** — *Eleven lost on the panther road* (Cnoc àrsaidh). A party of eleven from the southern shore goes up into the hills near Cnoc àrsaidh in the crossing season and does not return. Years afterwards their bones are found along the line the cats use still.
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, VE 5,324** — *The rainbow coal lit by the Keeper* (Doire ghlas). Ailean of Clann na Ceiste<sup>53</sup>, having lit each of the six coals again by its own way, carries them burning to the grove at Doire ghlas with the last coal, which his kindred have tried for more than four hundred years. The Keeper comes to him there and lights the rainbow coal, and for the first time all seven burn together, each from its own spirit. It bids him stay with them until they are cold.

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52. the panthers' crossing

53. the Children of the Question



## AGE II · AN AOIS AILEIN

*The Age of Ailean · the Grove Era, GE 1 – 4,603*

- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1** — *The vigil and the crowning* (Doire ghlas). Ailean keeps watch by the seven fires for seven nights, fasting, a night for each coal. On the eighth night the coals are cold, and Caoran comes into the grove with the Tuath Dè about him. He names Ailean Rìgh Chlann nan Dè<sup>1</sup>, king of the godkin, and puts into him the power that was in the coals. Of that power Ailean tells no one while he lives.
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1** — *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings* (Dùn ìseal). Ailean Mòr, crowned in the grove, comes down to the hill where Dùn ìseal now stands and takes it, and brings the households of the valleys about it under his hand: the first kingdom of the godkin. How he won, none who stood against him could say. He throws up the hill's first ring of bank. He is king from that day until his death, and gives the kingship to no one. With him opens the eldest of the spoken king-lists, afterwards called Rìghrean na Cloiche<sup>2</sup>, which names those who held the hill; it gives no lengths of reign, and it is older than the name Dia-thìrich.
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 9** — *The bank of Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). The first earthwork is raised on the hill at Dùn ìseal: a single bank and ditch, enclosing room for some forty houses. It is the oldest defended place of the hill-folk.
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 18** — *Beathag Ruadh of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Ruadh holds the hill where Cathair dhearg now stands. With her opens a second spoken list, kept in the west. The Red Hill list and the list of the Stone Kings make no mention of each other until late in both.
- I AM FAOILLEACH, GE 27** — *Gormshuil nic Ailein* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil nic Ailein, the king's daughter, holds the hill of Dùn ìseal for her father while he rides beyond it, and the list names her second of the Stone Kings; she is the first woman named in any list on Dia-thìr. She was born before the grove, and has none of the long years. One deed is told of her: in a hard winter she moves the herds of Dùn ìseal down to the warm springs and loses none.
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 107** — *Dòmhnall Clachach sets the boundary stones* (Dùn ìseal). Dòmhnall Clachach, a son of the king and third of the Stone Kings, holds the hill after Gormshuil and sets marker stones along the valley below it to part the grazing of Dùn ìseal from its neighbours'. Some stand yet, and are argued over yet.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 147** — *The first named storm*. A tempest comes so great that the eldest spoken king-lists give it a name. The name is lost; only the memory of the naming remains.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, GE 147** — *The shell road broken* (Seann Warr). The storm breaks the shell causeway of Seann Warr in three places and floods the marsh behind it with lake water. The Seann-Dhaoine<sup>3</sup> do not mend it, and the broken ends may be seen still.

1. king of the godkin, the first king's style

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

- 27 AN GIBLEAN, GE 227** — *Fearchar Bacach* (Dùn ìseal). Fearchar Bacach, the lame, a son of the king lamed in his father's wars, holds Dùn ìseal under the king after the storm and after Dòmhnall Clachach, and is carried to the gatherings in a chair of woven birch. He is the first ruler on Dia-thìr remembered for a hurt.
- 29 AM MÀRT, GE 267** — *Uisdean Mòr of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Uisdean Mòr, second of the Red Hill list, digs a ditch across the neck of the hill where Cathair dhearg now stands and sets a palisade on it. In his time the palisade burns twice and is twice rebuilt.
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 290** — *The Red Hill bends the knee* (Cathair dhearg). Ailean Mòr comes west to the Red Hill, where the palisade of Uisdean Mòr has twice burned. Uisdean comes down to the lake shore and kneels to him. The Red Hill keeps its own holders and its own list, and swears to the king and not to Dùn ìseal; so neither list names the other.
- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 308** — *Strokes on the midden stones* (Seann Chwen). The Seann-Dhaoine<sup>4</sup> begin to cut single strokes on flat stones set at the edges of their middens, one stone to a household. The strokes are not the script. They are simpler: a mark, and then another.
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 348** — *The counting of the dead begins*. The Seann-Dhaoine<sup>5</sup>, whoever they were, who built Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>6</sup> and Làrach an Dùin<sup>7</sup>, begin to keep count of their dead. They keep it before ever there were Dia-thìrich to take up the custom.
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 389** — *The tally wall of Seann Warr* (Seann Warr). At the eastern Seann Warr the counting stones are built into a wall, each cut with its strokes, some three thousand strokes in all. The wall grows for many lifetimes.
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 428** — *The count at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). The counting comes to Seann Tarr in the north-east. There the stones are cut with strokes in fives and set in the floor of a house, and the house is lived in over its own dead.
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, GE 470** — *The bad years in the counts* (Seann Warr). The tally stones at Seann Warr, Seann Tarr and Seann Chwen thicken together: more strokes to each stone, more stones to each course. Death comes on three coasts at once. What it was the strokes do not tell.
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, GE 510** — *The half-cut stone of Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). At the Seann Chwen near Cuan dhearg the last tally stone is left half-cut: two strokes finished, a third begun and forsaken. The chisel marks stop in mid-groove.
- 7 AN GEARRAN, GE 551** — *The Seann-Dhaoine<sup>8</sup> fall silent*. After the half-cut stone no work of the Seann-Dhaoine can be dated. Their middens stop growing, their harbours silt, and their script is cut no more. How they ended no telling knows.

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

5. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

6. the watch-fort ruin

7. the fortress ruin

8. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

- 8 AM MÀRT, GE 591** — *The old names kept* (Seann Skell). The hill-folk keep the names of the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>9</sup> places and set before them only their own word for 'old': Seann Dunn, Seann Chwen, Seann Skell and the rest. They turn nothing into their own tongue, and the roots of those names are not understood.
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 628** — *The old landings taken up* (Seann Skell). Families of the hill-folk come down the Abhainn naomh and settle in the empty river harbour at Seann Skell, using the old mole and mending none of it. They are not known to have dwelt by the water before.
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 672** — *Mòrag Chruaidh and the salt-flats raid* (Baile ghorm). Mòrag Chruaidh, the king's granddaughter and fifth of the Stone Kings, raids the salt-pans on the southern shore at Baile ghorm, which do not yet own the king, and carries off the salt. It is the first war in either list. Seven fall on the hill side, and the number is kept.
- 12 AN GEARRAN, GE 683** — *The salt-pans of Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). Shallow clay basins are made behind a shingle bar at Baile ghorm, the first salt-works of the island. From this time their salt is found in the hill settlements.
- 13 AM MÀRT, GE 694** — *Seonag of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Seonag nic Uisdein holds the Red Hill after her father. It is told that she counted her people by pebbles in a bag, one to a household, and knew by the weight when a household was gone.
- 11 AN GIBLEAN, GE 705** — *The first pots at Doire shean* (Doire shean). Pots of coiled clay, fired in open bonfires, are first made at Doire shean on the south-west coast. Within a few lifetimes the whole southern shore uses them.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, GE 716** — *The dug-out at Cidhe Beag* (Cidhe Beag). A boat hollowed from a single oak trunk, long enough for six, is sunk and left at the landing on Abhainn uaine now called Cidhe Beag. No older boat on Dia-thìr is known in its whole shape.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 727** — *Iain Dubh killed* (Baile ghorm). Iain Dubh, a son of the king and sixth of the Stone Kings, goes down to raid the salt-pans as Mòrag Chruaidh had done, and is slain on the shingle at Baile ghorm. He is the first of Ailean's children to die by a spear. The list says only that he was brought home.
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 728** — *The king at Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). Ailean Mòr comes down alone to the shingle at Baile ghorm where his son was slain. The salt-folk come out against him with spears, and none strikes. They bring him the salt of the pans, and the southern shore is his. No blood is shed there, and none is paid.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 777** — *The wave at Cnoc chaol* (Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol<sup>10</sup>). The sea comes far inland over a village on the site of Cnoc chaol and leaves a sheet of sand a hand thick upon its hearths, with the shells of deep-water creatures in it. The village is not rebuilt on the same ground.

9. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

10. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

- 5 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 827** — *The ground opens at Cill ghlàs* (Scàineadh Cill ghlàs<sup>11</sup>). A crack a man could fall into opens across the valley at Cill ghlàs, and a spring moves a hundred paces downhill. The hill-folk bank the crack with stones and build on neither side of it.
- 3 **AN T-SULTAIN, GE 847** — *The fault-line kept clear* (Cill ghlàs). A line of white stones is laid along the old crack at Cill ghlàs, and for the rest of the age no house is built within a stone's throw of it. Part of the line remains.
- 2 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 902** — *The unlit hearth*. In a single dwelling a hearth is laid and never lit. Peat keeps it by chance. It is the eldest sign that someone here chose not to burn what could easily have been burned.
- 31 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 956** — *Peat over the unlit hearth*. The house of the unlit hearth lies under three yards of peat, its hearth laid with dry wood and a slip of the coloured coal beside it, none of it burned. Whoever laid it went away and did not come back to light it.
- 5 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,011** — *The measured handful* (Àth gharbh). In all the hill settlements a custom takes hold that no fire shall have more of the coloured coal than one cupped hand can hold. It is nowhere written and everywhere kept. From it the Small-Burning Law of the Holy Age is made.
- 7 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,066** — *The basket burning at Achadh dhìreach* (Achadh dhìreach). A household at Achadh dhìreach burns a whole basket of the coloured coal at once, knowing nothing of what it holds. The house burns down with three within, and the hearth-stone is found cracked through and running with colour. Ever after the tellings use it to show why the handful is kept.
- 8 **AN T-ÒGMHÌOS, GE 1,120** — *The watchers of the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). Families near the crack take turns to sit by the slab laid over it, a household at a time, through the dark half of the year. What they watch for, none ever says.
- 10 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,175** — *Raghnall Ceannfhionn makes peace* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>12</sup>). Raghnall Ceannfhionn, seventh of the Stone Kings, meets the holder of the Red Hill at the ford where the fair of Muileann òg is held now, and they agree on salt for wool. Both hills are the king's, and neither is the other's. Both lists tell of the meeting, and in neither is the other named before it.
- 29 **AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 1,208** — *The ford gathering* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>13</sup>). The meeting at the ford becomes a yearly gathering. Salt, flint, wool, dried fish and pots change hands there, and marriages are made. No meeting-place on the island has been used longer without a break.
- 31 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,247** — *Murchadh Gearr of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Murchadh Gearr holds the Red Hill after Seonag and keeps the peace of the ford. It is told that he walked the salt road himself every year, to be seen upon it.

11. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlàs'

12. the fair at Muileann òg

13. the fair at Muileann òg

- 2 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,274** — *Hill-folk on the western shore* (Ros bheag). Households from the hills settle the bay at Ros bheag, the first of their kind on the west coast. They build in the hill manner, round and turf-roofed, a little back from the beach, and fish from the shore and not from boats.
- 8 **AN GEARRAN, GE 1,306** — *Amber from the Hawk bay* (Seann Skell). Amber is gathered from the wrack on the strands of the Hawk bay and drilled for stringing; lumps of it lie in the middens below Seann Skell. A bead of the same amber lies in the oldest ground of the ford gathering, carried there the length of the island.
- 3 **AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1,347** — *The first houses at Cathair dhombhain* (Cathair dhomhain). Round houses are built by the harbour where Cathair dhomhain now stands, near enough the Red Hill to pay it salt. The Red Hill list counts them among its holder's households.
- 25 **AM MÀRT, GE 1,379** — *Cattle in the north-west* (Cnoc ghorm). Cattle come to Cnoc ghorm in the north-west, where the settlements had lived on seal, fish and deer. The herds must have been walked up the flint road.
- 24 **AN GEARRAN, GE 1,416** — *The long-house at Cathair gheal* (Cathair gheal). A long-house forty paces long, with byre and hall under one roof, is built on the rise at Cathair gheal. It is the greatest building of the age in the north-west. Twice it burns, and twice it is rebuilt on the same footing.
- 21 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,452** — *A youth let down into Toll-dubh* (Toll-dubh). A youth is let down on a rope of plaited hide into the eastern Toll-dubh, to the rope's end. He is drawn up alive and never tells what lay at the bottom. No one goes down again in this age.
- 19 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,489** — *A fire lit in the Doire uaine hills* (Marbh-bheò<sup>14</sup> Doire uaine). A herding family, new to the hills, lights an open fire at Doire uaine against the custom. Their hut is found empty, the fire still burning. Thereafter the covered hearth is kept more strictly.
- 24 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,525** — *The lake dwellings burn* (Loch chrom). The platforms on Loch chrom burn to the waterline, and the charred piles are left standing in the shallows. No one builds on the lake again in this age.
- 22 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,562** — *Seal-oil lamps at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). Stone lamps with a hollow for seal oil and a wick of moss are used at Caol leathan. They are the first light on Dia-thìr that is not a hearth, and they give little smoke.
- 27 **AM MÀRT, GE 1,598** — *The fish-traps of Caol fhiadhaich* (Caol fhiadhaich). Wattle fences are staked across the river-mouth at Caol fhiadhaich to trap salmon on the ebb. The same line of stake-holes is used again and again through the rest of the age.
- 25 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 1,628** — *The upright looms of Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). At Muileann leathan in the north cloth is woven on standing frames, no longer twined by hand. The loom-weights of fired clay lie in rows in the houses, where they fell from the warp.

14. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 1,671** — *The first tide-count*. Someone begins to mark the high-water line against a fixed rock. Why is not told; but the marks are cut at intervals more even than a fisherman's need would ask.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,708** — *A second tide-rock at Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). The high-water marking is copied at Ros dhomhain on a boulder in the harbour mouth, the marks cut at the same intervals as on the first rock. Someone carried the practice there, and the interval with it.
- 10 AM MÀRT, GE 1,747** — *The lake is higher* (Ros dhomhain). The marks on the Ros dhomhain rock creep upward from keeper to keeper, and by the end of the age Loch chrom stands a hand higher on the rock than at the first cut. The keepers go on cutting.
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, GE 1,781** — *The flint of Cnoc àrsaidh* (Cnoc àrsaidh). A pit is worked for flint on the hill of Cnoc àrsaidh in the north-west, the only good flint on Dia-thìr. Its grey flakes are carried to hearths from one end of the island to the other.
- 11 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 1,817** — *The flint road* (Àth leathan). A track is worn by the flint-carriers from Cnoc àrsaidh south and east toward the ford gathering. Near Àth leathan their feet sink it a yard deep.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1,853** — *The hawk lintel at Àth mhòr* (Àth mhòr). A hawk is carved on a lintel over a house door at Àth mhòr in the north, wings closed, head turned. It is the oldest carving of a hawk on the island, and of any bird.
- 10 AM MÀRT, GE 1,890** — *Wolves at Tobar fhiadhaich* (Tobar fhiadhaich). At Tobar fhiadhaich wolves are buried whole and with care, laid on their sides as people are. No other beast is so buried in this age.
- 9 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,927** — *Sileas Bhàn and the hungry years* (Dùn ìseal). Sileas Bhàn, eighth of the Stone Kings, of the king's blood, holds Dùn ìseal through years of failed grazing. No deed is told of her but that she held, and the list goes on after her.
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,966** — *The hunger at Baile chrom* (Gorta Baile chrom<sup>15</sup>). Hunger comes to the settlement on the site of the north-western Baile chrom. Its pots are left full of boiled bark and seaweed, and its grave-rows are doubled. No older hunger on Dia-thìr is tied to a place.
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,006** — *The drought at Achadh shean* (Tiormachd Achadh shean<sup>16</sup>). The springs of Achadh shean in the east run dry so long that the field banks are forsaken and grown over. When people return they cut new fields on another line.
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,047** — *The naming of the wind directions*. The eight winds are named, and every Dia-thìreach sailor after uses the names. Their meaning is dark even to those who speak them, and they have never been changed.

15. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

16. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

- 5 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,084** — *The wind-stones of Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). Eight tall stones are set in a ring on the point at Ceann leathan, one for each of the named winds. Sailors of every later age touch the stone of the wind they want before they put out.
- 24 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,124** — *The wind-names carried to the islands* (Eilean fhada). The eight wind-names are used on Eilean fhada as on the main island. The markers on its high point bear eight cut notches, one facing each way.
- 25 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,163** — *Tormod Liath* (Dùn ìseal). Tormod Liath, ninth of the Stone Kings, a grandson of the king, holds the hill so long that he outlives three heirs, and is remembered as old. In his time Dùn ìseal is given its second bank, and its ground is doubled.
- 4 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,201** — *The Dia-thìrich name*. In this age the hill-folk begin to call themselves Dia-thìrich and the island Dia-thìr. The first use is not known; the eldest tellings take both names for granted. With the names goes the belief: they did not come; they were here.
- 2 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,223** — *The first forbidden marriage*. A marriage between two lineages is forbidden, for a reason no surviving telling gives. Already the Dia-thìrich order themselves by blood, long before the coal gives them cause.
- 31 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,247** — *Lines recited at the ford* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>17</sup>). At the ford gathering households begin to recite their lines aloud before any marriage is made, seven names back on either side. These are the first genealogies of the common households; only the Line of the Mason is older. None survives whole.
- 29 **AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,267** — *The first seeking of another vein* (Cnoc dhubh). Diggers from Dùn ìseal open a trench on a hill near Cnoc dhubh in the east, seeking coal like the vein's. They leave it unfinished when two of them are crushed by a fall. The trench stays open, and what it would have found is not known.
- 10 **AM MÀRT, GE 2,289** — *The stone that would not break*. A second opening for a new vein is made elsewhere on the island and fails wholly: common rock, and nothing beneath it. So it is first known that the vein under the mountain is alone of its kind.
- 8 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,312** — *The prospecting ends*. No one tries a third opening in this age. The Dia-thìrich hold that the vein chooses where it lies, and that the choice is not theirs to try.
- 7 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,328** — *The first shared meal law*. A custom arises, unwritten, that any household with food to spare shall share it before the storm season.
- 5 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,356** — *Surplus shared at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). At Dùn ìseal the sharing before the storms is done in the open: every household brings its surplus within the bank, and it is divided by the count of mouths. The custom has no earlier place that is known.

- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,378** — *A household turned out at Àth shean* (Àth shean). A household at Àth shean hides its spare grain in a pit under the floor and brings nothing to the sharing. When the pit is found the household is put out of the settlement with what it can carry. It is the first punishment under the custom that is remembered.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,400** — *Eilidh Ghlas* (Dùn ìseal). Eilidh Ghlas, tenth of the Stone Kings, of the king's blood, sends her younger son to the Red Hill to be fostered, the first fostering in either list. The son's name is not kept; only that he went, and that the peace of the ford held while he was there.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,401** — *Lachlann Ruadh takes the fosterling* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann Ruadh, holder of the Red Hill, takes the son of Eilidh Ghlas into his house. For it he is named Lachlann an Altraim, 'Lachlann of the fostering', and the Red Hill list calls him so more often than by his own name.
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,403** — *Oighrig, first keeper by lot* (Tobar dhìreach). The families who watch the slab agree to choose one keeper at a time by lot, and no longer to take turns by household. The first lot falls to a woman called Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill, and she keeps the slab for the rest of her life.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,404** — *The keepers' house* (Tobar dhìreach). A house is built beside the slab at Tobar dhìreach for the holder of the lot, its door facing the stone. It is rebuilt on the same footing many times. It is the first building on Dia-thìr made only to be near the vein.
- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,405** — *The stone cup* (Tobar dhìreach). Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill has a cup ground out of grey stone to the size of her own cupped hand, that the handful of coal may be the same for every household. The cup is carried round the hill settlements. Whether it outlasts the age is not known.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,407** — *The stone cup copied* (Cnoc chaol). Copies of the keeper's cup are ground at Àth gharbh, Achadh dhìreach and Cnoc chaol, each tried against the first by filling it with water. Thereafter the hill settlements measure the coal with one measure.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,408** — *The meeting of the cups* (Coinneachadh nan Cupan<sup>18</sup>). The keeper's cup and its three copies are carried to a spring on the moor between Àth gharbh and Tobar dhìreach, set side by side on a flat stone and filled from the spring in turn. The place is called Coinneachadh nan Cupan, the meeting of the cups. The hill settlements return to it whenever a cup is broken and a new one must be tried.
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,409** — *Gilleasbuig Beag takes coal* (Eilean chrom). A keeper by lot, Gilleasbuig Beag, is found with a basket of broken coal from the vein in his own house. The households of the hills sit in judgement at the slab, row him out to Eilean chrom, and leave him there without a boat. He is the first known to be exiled for the vein.

17. the fair at Muileann òg



- 4 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,411** — *The coal returned to the crack* (Tobar dhireach). The coal from Gilleasbuig Beag's house is neither burned nor kept. The keeper after him carries it back to the slab and lays it beneath, piece by piece. The tellings make much of it: the coal went home.
- 4 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,412** — *Calum Ciar asks for the lot* (Dùn ìseal). Calum Ciar, the elder son of Eilidh Ghlas and eleventh of the Stone Kings, asks that the keeper's lot be drawn at Dùn ìseal in his sight. The households at the slab refuse him. The list sets down the refusal, which is more than it sets down of most things.
- 7 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,416** — *The kings and the keepers* (Dùn ìseal). After the refusal of Calum Ciar the lot is still drawn at the slab. The holders of the hill rule the grazing and the gatherings under the king, but not the vein, and the king does not overrule the slab. The line between the two holds for the rest of the age. It is not yet written anywhere.
- 1 **AN GEARRAN, GE 2,417** — *A' Ghaoth Dhubh*<sup>19</sup> (Cuan ruadh). A storm called A' Ghaoth Dhubh, the Black Wind, strips the thatch from every house on the east coast from Cuan ruadh to Ceann chiar. Of all storms it is the eldest whose name is kept.
- 8 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,417** — *The sharing holds after the Black Wind* (Ceann chiar). The settlements of the east coast feed the people of Cuan ruadh through a whole winter out of their shared surplus. None on that coast is known to die of hunger that season.
- 2 **AM MÀRT, GE 2,418** — *The beacon at Baile ìseal* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal<sup>20</sup>). A fire is built on the eastern cape where Taigh-solais Baile ìseal now stands, kept by the households of the coast in turn. It is lit to bring boats home in a storm, the tellings say, and not to warn them off.
- 3 **AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,419** — *The beacon at Muileann bheag* (Taigh-solais Muileann bheag<sup>21</sup>). A second shore-fire is kept on the north coast, on the point where Taigh-solais Muileann bheag stands now. Under the tower the ash goes down through three yards of fire-reddened soil.
- 5 **AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,419** — *The beacon at Àth dhearg* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg<sup>22</sup>). Households of the north-east coast keep a fire on the cape where Taigh-solais Àth dhearg now stands, and cut steps up to it from the shore. The steps are narrower than those at Seann Bhral, and less worn.
- 28 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,420** — *The beacon at Tobar dhearg* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>23</sup>). A fire is kept for the boats of the south coast on the southern cape where Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg stands. With Baile chrom, Baile ìseal, Muileann bheag and Àth dhearg the coasts of the island are lit at five points.

18. the meeting of the cups

19. the Black Wind

20. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

21. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

22. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

23. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

- 31 AM MÀRT, GE 2,421** — *The Sea-Watcher seen from Seann Skell* (Uilebheist na Mara<sup>24</sup>). Four watchers on the north-western tower at Seann Skell see a back as long as three boats rise and go under off the point. It is the first sighting of the Sea-Watcher tied to a named place and a count of witnesses.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,421** — *Wreckage in the western water* (Spùinneadairean-mara). For a season planks of stitched boats, broken small, wash up along the western shore below the waters where raiders are afterwards seen. No bodies come with them, and no settlement on that coast lacks a boat.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,422** — *Anndra Breac says 'we came'* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>25</sup>). At the ford gathering Anndra Breac, a teller of the western coast, recites a telling in which the people came to Dia-thìr over the sea. The households of the hills shout him down, and he is put out of the ford for the rest of his life. His telling is not kept; only the memory that he told it.
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,423** — *The doctrine said at the column* (Calbh Cnoc ghorm<sup>26</sup>). After Anndra Breac, the saying cut on the column at Cnoc ghorm is spoken aloud at the opening of the ford gathering: we did not come; we were here. From this time it is said as a rule, and not only held as a belief.
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,424** — *The keepers of the Ros dhomhain rock* (Ros dhomhain). The tide-rock at Ros dhomhain passes to Seònaid Mhòr, who cuts her marks in pairs, one for high water and one for low. Her pairs can be read still. The keepers after her go back to single marks.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,424** — *A third tide-rock at Inis thais* (Inis thais). Households at Inis thais cut their own high-water marks on the harbour rock, at the interval of Ros dhomhain. So three rocks are kept side by side. None tells why the interval is what it is.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,425** — *Ros dhomhain grows* (Ros dhomhain). Ros dhomhain becomes the greatest settlement on the shores of Loch chrom, some sixty houses round the tide-rock. Its people fish now from boats and not from the shore.
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,426** — *The Red Hill's harbour* (Cathair dhearg). The households of the Red Hill build a landing of laid stone at the river-mouth below the hill, where the harbour of Cathair dhearg is now. It is the Red Hill's first way onto the water, and by the lake and the Abhainn gheal to the sea.
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,426** — *Peigi Dhubh of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Peigi Dhubh holds the Red Hill after Lachlann an Altraim. She sends the fostered son of Dùn ìseal home grown, with gifts of salt, and the peace of the ford holds a generation more.
- 31 AM MÀRT, GE 2,427** — *The foster-son returns* (Dùn ìseal). The son of Eilidh Ghlas comes home from the Red Hill to Dùn ìseal, bringing the salt-songs of the west. The Stone Kings' list gives him no name and no reign; he is remembered only as the one who went.

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24. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

25. the fair at Muileann òg

26. the column at Cnoc ghorm

- 2 AM MÀRT, GE 2,428** — *The first songs kept* (Baile ghorm). The salt-songs of the south and west are sung at the raking of the pans. They are the oldest songs on Dia-thìr whose words are said to survive: a refrain of four lines, which no one can now wholly construe.
- 14 AM MÀRT, GE 2,428** — *Bone pipes at Cnoc àrsaidh* (Cnoc àrsaidh). Pipes of hollow bird-bone, bored with four holes, are made in a house at the southern Cnoc àrsaidh near the panther road. They are the oldest instruments of the island.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,428** — *The panthers turn back* (Imrich nam Pantar<sup>27</sup>). The great cats come down the panther road near Imrich nam Pantar and turn back at the foothills without crossing. The hill-folk read it for a hard winter and store double. The winter is hard.
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,428** — *The cattle lost in the passes* (Muileann bhàn). Herders from Muileann bhàn drive cattle into the passes out of season, against the custom of the crossing. The panthers take thirty head in a night, and the herders come down with nothing.
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,447** — *The panther season kept at Baile dhomhain* (Baile dhomhain). At Baile dhomhain in the south the households cut a sign on their gateposts at the start of the crossing season and scrape it off at its end. It is the first mark made on the island for a season.
- 13 AN GEARRAN, GE 2,447** — *The wind-stone at Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). One of the eight wind-names is cut in the Dia-thìreach manner on a boulder at the central Seann Chwen, over an older mark of the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>28</sup>. In few places do the marks of the two peoples touch.
- 14 AN GEARRAN, GE 2,447** — *Boats named for the winds* (Caol bheag). The fishing households of Caol bheag, who fish the north coast from the mouth of the Abhainn ghorm, name their boats for the winds they fish in. A boat named for the wrong wind is held unlucky, and the name of a boat that sinks is never given again.
- 14 AM MÀRT, GE 2,447** — *The Tuam keepers* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>29</sup>). A family dwelling by Tuam Cnoc dhìreach takes on the clearing of thorn from the old graves. They bury none of their own there. They only keep it.
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,447** — *A grave at Tuam opened* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>30</sup>). Diggers laying a new row at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach break into a grave older than any they knew, lined with slabs cut in the manner of the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>31</sup>. They close it and move the row, and none opens that grave again.

27. the panthers' crossing

28. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

29. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

30. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

31. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

- II AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,449** — *Pilgrims at Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*<sup>32</sup> (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar). People begin to walk to the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar and sit a night at the line of the trees without entering. Their small fires, each of a single night, lie all along the edge.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,451** — *A child lost in Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag*<sup>33</sup> (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag). A child of the settlement at Cnoc bheag goes past the line of stones into Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag and is not found. The searchers stop at the stones, and the telling does not blame them.
- 8 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,453** — *The first house at Cnoc bheag* (Cnoc bheag). Settlers from the Red Hill build at Cnoc bheag, near the edge of the forest. They take their timber from the far side of the river, and never from the unclaimed wood.
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,455** — *The spring at Muileann ruadh* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>34</sup>). Pilgrims come in numbers to the warm springs at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh, and a ring of shelters is built there. Here is set the eldest healing-tale of Dia-thìr: a herder came lame and walked home.
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,457** — *The Hollow Man seen again* (Marbh-bheò<sup>35</sup> Doire uaine). Two herders passing the Doire uaine hills after dark see a figure walk the ridge with no breath showing in the cold. They had no fire lit, and so, the telling says, they lived.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,460** — *The covered hearth spreads* (Muileann chiar). The covered hearth, pit-dug and roofed, spreads from the Doire uaine hills to the settlements about Muileann chiar. From this comes the later rule that no open fire is lit on those slopes after dark.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,462** — *Settlers at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Dia-thìreach households settle at Caol mhòr in the north-west, on the strait where the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>36</sup> once hunted seal. They find the old middens and build on them.
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,464** — *Settlers at Baile chrom in the north-west* (Baile chrom). Households from Cnoc ghorm settle again the ground at Baile chrom that the old hunger had emptied. They dig their storage pits deeper than any others on the coast.
- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,466** — *Muileann àrsaidh settled* (Muileann àrsaidh). Houses are built on the stream at Muileann àrsaidh in the north-west. Their flint comes from Cnoc àrsaidh, and their salt from the south, carried the length of the island.
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,468** — *The salt road to the north-west* (Muileann àrsaidh). A salt road runs from the pans of Baile ghorm by the ford gathering to the north-west. At Muileann àrsaidh the salt costs three times its price at the pans, and is paid for in flint and seal-skins.

32. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

33. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

34. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

35. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

36. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

- 26 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,470** — *Doire ghlas settled* (Doire ghlas). Households settle under the oaks at Doire ghlas in the north. The settlement grows in rings, each built outside the last as the wood is cleared back.
- 28 **AM MÀRT, GE 2,473** — *The east settled at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). The hill-folk push east and build a banked enclosure at Dùn thais, on a hill above good grazing. It is the first stronghold of the Dia-thìrich away from Dùn iséal and the Red Hill.
- 27 **AN GEARRAN, GE 2,475** — *Achadh chaol cleared* (Achadh chaol). Fields are cleared at Achadh chaol in the east by fire and by picking stones. The picked stones are laid in banks round each field, and those banks bound the fields still.
- 29 **AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,477** — *Cuan ruadh rebuilt* (Cuan ruadh). Cuan ruadh, stripped by the Black Wind, is rebuilt in stone to the height of the eaves. It is the first settlement of the east coast to build its walls against the wind and not only the cold.
- 13 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,523** — *Cathair fhada on the south coast* (Cathair fhada). Cathair fhada is founded on the south coast, between the old Seann Dunn and Seann Chwen. It draws its water from a well the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>37</sup> dug, and never speaks of where the well came from.
- 14 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,570** — *Caol ruadh on the southern strait* (Caol ruadh). Fishing households settle Caol ruadh on the south coast and take the cod of the strait on long lines. Their middens are the first on the south coast to hold more fish than shell.
- 13 **AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,616** — *Baile Mòr mhòr in the north* (Baile Mòr mhòr). Houses are built at Baile Mòr mhòr on the northern plain, round a spring that never freezes. At its height it has some eighty houses, a great place for the age.
- 15 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,662** — *Baile gharbh in the north-east* (Baile gharbh). Households settle the rough ground at Baile gharbh and live by sheep, not cattle. Their wool goes south along the coast to the ford gathering.
- 17 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,709** — *Baile fhiadhaich on the west coast* (Baile fhiadhaich). Settlers build at Baile fhiadhaich on the western coast, where boars run in the thickets. They hang boar tusks over their doors, and boar is their chief meat for the rest of the age.
- 18 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,755** — *Cuan shean settled* (Cuan shean). Dia-thìreach households take up the harbour at Cuan shean on the west coast, beside an old landing of unknown builders, and use the landing without mending it.
- 7 **AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,801** — *Dùn chrom raised* (Dùn chrom). A banked hill-fort is raised at Dùn chrom in the midst of the island, between the Red Hill and the hills of the vein. Its bank faces both ways.

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37. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,847** — *Cathair mhòr below the old outpost* (Cathair mhòr). Households settle on the ground below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>38</sup>, where Cathair mhòr now stands. They take no stone from the ruin above them, though it is the nearest quarry.
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,894** — *Cnoc naomh* (Cnoc naomh). Households come to settle on a hill for its spring, and the hill is already called Cnoc naomh, the holy hill. Why, is not known.
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,947** — *Tobar dhearg on the southern cape* (Tobar dhearg). The keepers of the beacon at Tobar dhearg build their settlement on the cape itself, round a well whose water runs reddish from the rock. It becomes the greatest place on the south coast.
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,986** — *Muileann naomh founded* (Muileann naomh). Muileann naomh is founded near the south coast, between the beacon at Tobar dhearg and the old Seann Skell. Its first houses stand on stilts over a marsh, and are afterwards moved to firm ground.
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000** — *The great gathering at the ford* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>39</sup>). In the height of his days Ailean Mòr keeps a gathering at the ford of the salt and wool. The holders of the hill, the Red Hill, the salt shore, the north and the west set their hands in his. Some four hundred of his own blood stand about him, children and their children, more than the reciters can name in a night. Only the households east of the vein send no one.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 3,025** — *Somhairle mac Ailein dies* (Tobar dhireach). Somhairle mac Ailein, a son of Ailean Mòr born in his father's sixty-second year, dies in the high valleys at two thousand nine hundred and eighty-seven years, before his father. His line lives among Clann na Ceiste<sup>40</sup> and holds no share of the hill. In each generation after him the long years are shorter.
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,028** — *Ceann mhin on the south-eastern shore* (Ceann mhin). The south-eastern Ceann mhin is settled near Làrach an Dùin<sup>41</sup>. Its people are the first to live in sight of the fortress ruin, and they will not go up to it.
- 23 AM MÀRT, GE 3,079** — *Seann Skell of the south* (Seann Skell). Dia-thireach households take up the old harbour at the southern Seann Skell and keep its old name. Within a few generations it is the busiest landing on the south coast.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, GE 3,125** — *Achadh shean resettled* (Achadh shean). Households return to Achadh shean after the drought and cut new fields on the higher ground. They sink a deep well first and plant after, and the well does not fail again in this age.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, GE 3,172** — *Inis mhin settled* (Inis mhin). A few households settle at Inis mhin on the eastern coast. They live by the eggs and birds of the cliffs, and trade feathers inland.

38. the watch-fort ruin

39. the fair at Muileann òg

40. the Children of the Question

41. the fortress ruin

- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 3,218** — *Muileann chaol on its bill* (Muileann chaol). Households settle on the hill at Muileann chaol, above the upper reaches of the rivers. Where the library stands now there is a cattle-fold.
- 17 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 3,264** — *Cairns on the bill at Muileann chaol* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>42</sup>). At Muileann chaol a cairn is raised for each head of a household at death, on the slope above the fold. By the end of the age some forty stand there.
- 15 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 3,311** — *Baile Mòr ruadh in the east* (Baile Mòr ruadh). Baile Mòr ruadh grows up near the eastern Seann Dunn, on land its people call empty. The middens of Seann Dunn lie a morning's walk away, and the settlers do not dig into them.
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,357** — *The temple ruin avoided* (Làrach an Teampaill<sup>43</sup>). The Diathirich of the eastern hills pass Làrach an Teampaill without stopping and take no stone from it. A path is worn round it at a distance.
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,403** — *Ceann leathan's contests* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>44</sup>). At Ceann leathan the gathering by the wind-stones ends with wrestling and the lifting of stones. The heaviest, a black boulder, lies on the point still, and few have raised it.
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 3,450** — *The ford gathering grows* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>45</sup>). The ford gathering at Muileann òg now draws households from every coast. Its ground is parted by custom: the salt people downstream, the hill people upstream, the flint people on the far bank.
- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,496** — *Stone axes from the north* (Àth àrsaidh). Axes of polished green stone from a quarry near Àth àrsaidh in the north-west are carried all over the island. They are too fine for work; most are laid unused in graves or under house floors.
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, GE 3,547** — *The quarry at Àth àrsaidh* (Àth àrsaidh). The green-stone quarry at Àth àrsaidh is worked by a few households who trade in nothing else, and the chips about it lie knee-deep. Before the age ends the quarry is forsaken, and the axes cease.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,588** — *The moor takes the north* (Doire ghlas). The oak falls back, as the pollen in the bog under Doire ghlas shows. Heather, birch and bog-moss spread over the northern lowlands, and the groves that give the north its many Doire names shrink to the sheltered valleys, where they stand yet. In the north this is remembered as the time the winters lengthened.
- 15 AM MÀRT, GE 3,628** — *The river crossings of Abhainn fhionn* (Abhainn fhionn). Stepping-stones are laid across Abhainn fhionn at its shallows, the first made crossing of any river on the island. They are older than the first bridges, and in places lie beneath them.

42. the Library at Muileann chaol

43. the temple ruin

44. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

45. the fair at Muileann òg

- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 3,680** — *A drowning at the fords of Abhainn chaol* (Abhainn chaol). A spate on Abhainn chaol takes a party of twelve crossing its fords with salt. Thereafter none crosses there in the wet season.
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, GE 3,726** — *The Black Wind remembered at Ceann chiar* (Ceann chiar). The people of Ceann chiar, rebuilding after the Black Wind, set a stone in the midst of their settlement and cut on it a mark for every house lost: twenty-two.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 3,771** — *A dry year on the eastern plain* (Muileann bhàn). The rivers of the eastern plain run low for a whole summer, and the households of Dùn ìseal and Muileann bhàn drive their cattle to the warm springs to drink. The shared surplus holds, and no deaths are counted.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 3,817** — *A second wave on the south coast* (Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol<sup>46</sup>). The sea comes in again over the low ground at Cnoc chaol, less far than before. The new houses stand higher on the slope, and none is lost.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,863** — *The ground shakes at Cill ghlas again* (Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>47</sup>). The old crack at Cill ghlas moves again, and the spring shifts back uphill. The line of white stones is broken in two places, and is laid again.
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,908** — *Cnoc bheag under the Carragh* (Cnoc bheag). Households settle on the bank of the Abhainn ìseal at Cnoc bheag, a short walk from Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>48</sup>. They set their houses so that no door faces the stone.
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,955** — *The seal rocks of Inis bhàn* (Inis bhàn). The households of Inis bhàn on the lower Abhainn ìseal take seals from the skerries off the river mouth by agreement, one household to a rock. A rock taken out of turn is the commonest quarrel in their tellings.
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,000** — *Fields at Achadh mhòr* (Achadh mhòr). The wide field at Achadh mhòr, near the warm springs, is cleared and banked, the largest single field of the age. Its bank is laid with the stones of an older wall that no one claims.
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,047** — *The harbour at Baile ghlas* (Baile ghlas). The households of the Red Hill draw up their boats at Baile ghlas, along the lake shore from the hill, in sheds of stone and turf. It becomes the fishing harbour of the Red Hill.
- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 4,091** — *Achadh naomh's spring-fields* (Achadh naomh). Settlers at Achadh naomh in the north water their fields from a spring they will not build over, and lead the water round it in channels. The spring is fenced before any house is.
- 10 AM MÀRT, GE 4,128** — *Caol gharbh on the rough strait* (Caol gharbh). Households settle at Caol gharbh on the north-east coast and fish the strait in skin boats. They lay paddles beside their dead.

<sup>46</sup>. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

<sup>47</sup>. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

<sup>48</sup>. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag



- 8 AN GIBLEAN, GE 4,183** — *Doire chiar* (Doire chiar). A settlement grows up under the dark oaks at Doire chiar in the north. Its people pen pigs in the wood and drive them out to the acorns at the fall of the year.
- 11 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 4,228** — *The river landing at Caol shean* (Caol shean). Caol shean, on the Abhainn iséal east of the vein, becomes the river landing of the hill households of the east. Salt, fish and seal-skins come up the river to it from the coast, and go on from it into the keepers' country.
- 9 AN GEARRAN, GE 4,274** — *Dùn dhearg raised* (Dùn dhearg). A hill-fort with a double bank is raised at Dùn dhearg, east of the vein, by households who owe nothing to Dùn iséal. The Stone Kings' list does not name its holders; it says only that Dùn dhearg came not to the gatherings.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,321** — *Dùn dhearg comes to the ford* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>49</sup>). In the time of Catrìona Mhòr the households of Dùn dhearg come to the ford gathering for the first time, bringing seal-skins and asking for salt. They are given ground of their own on the far bank.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,325** — *Settlers at Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). Households settle at Àth fhiadhaich in the south-eastern hills, by a ford where wild cattle cross. They take the calves and rear them, and their herds become the best in those hills.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,328** — *Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). Households from the Red Hill settle the point at Ceann àrsaidh on the Abhainn fhionn. They find an old river landing there and name the place for it: the ancient headland.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,328** — *Cnoc thais in the north-west* (Cnoc thais). Households settle on the damp hill at Cnoc thais in the north-west and drain it with ditches. The ditches carry water still.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 4,328** — *Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). Households settle Inis mhòr on the Abhainn ghorm in the north-east and live by the fish of its sheltered pools. They build their houses in two rows facing each other, the oldest street on Dia-thìr.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, GE 4,347** — *Baile gheal in the south-west* (Baile gheal). Baile gheal is founded on the south-western plain round a house with white-limed walls. The lime is burned from the shells of the old middens along the coast.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,347** — *Àth bheag on the eastern coast* (Àth bheag). Households settle the small ford at Àth bheag on the far eastern coast, the easternmost dwelling of the age on the main island. Their boats go out after the geese on the islands.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,347** — *Catrìona Mhòr* (Dùn iséal). Catrìona Mhòr, twelfth of the Stone Kings and of the king's blood, holds Dùn iséal under him; hers is the last name in the spoken list. It is told that she knew every household of the hills by its line seven names back.

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49. the fair at Muileann òg

- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 4,347** — *Seumas Òg of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Seumas Òg holds the Red Hill, and with him the spoken list of the Red Hill ends. In the next age what the reciters kept of it is written down.
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 4,347** — *The two lists recited together* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>50</sup>). At the ford gathering, in the time of Catrìona Mhòr, the list of the Stone Kings and the list of the Red Hill are recited one after the other from the first name to the last. It takes from dusk to dawn. For the first time both are heard whole.
- 29 AM MÀRT, GE 4,350** — *Lots drawn for the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). The lot for the keeper of the slab is drawn now among households from every part of the hills, not only those near the crack. The keepers' house at Tobar dhìreach becomes a place of pilgrimage.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, GE 4,353** — *The keepers number nine* (Tobar dhìreach). The keepers of the slab are made nine, one drawn by lot for each of nine districts of the hills. They meet at the slab when a keeper dies, and at no other time.
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,355** — *Coal in every hearth by the handful*. Every household of the hills burns its handful of the coloured coal, measured in a copy of the stone cup, on one night in the dark of the year, the night later kept as Samhain. All burn at once by agreement, so that the low fires of the handful show on every hillside on the same night.
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, GE 4,358** — *A handful refused at Cnoc dhubh* (Cnoc dhubh). The household of the Cnoc dhubh trench, where the two diggers were crushed, refuses its handful of coal for as long as any remembers. No household before it is known to have chosen not to burn at all.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 4,361** — *Counting the households* (Dùn ìseal). The people of Catrìona Mhòr count the households of the hills by knots on a cord, a knot to a hearth. The cord of Dùn ìseal is said to have borne some nine hundred knots, the greatest count made on Dia-thìr in this age.
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,364** — *The saying on the column recut* (Calbh Cnoc ghorm<sup>51</sup>). The words on the column at Cnoc ghorm, worn shallow, are recut in their old grooves by a hand from the hill of the Stone Kings. Some later readers hold that the recutting changed a letter; none can prove which.
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,367** — *The last Seann-Dhaoine<sup>52</sup> midden disturbed* (Seann Dunn). Households at the eastern Seann Dunn cut into the old midden for a house-floor and find the tally stones. They put them back in the order they lay and build elsewhere.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,370** — *Eilean ìseal given to the dead* (Eilean ìseal). The households of the south-east coast begin to row their dead to Eilean ìseal, after the old manner of the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>53</sup>. Whether they learned it from the Seann Vell graves on Eilean dhearg, or came to it of themselves, is not told.

50. the fair at Muileann òg

51. the column at Cnoc ghorm

52. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

53. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 4,373** — *Gilleasbuig Beag's island* (Eilean chrom). Eilean chrom, where Gilleasbuig Beag was left, stays empty and unfished. His fire is seen on it for three nights, the tellings say, and then no more.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 4,376** — *The keepers ask to be named* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>54</sup>). The nine keepers of the slab ask Catriona Mhòr to declare their charge before the whole ford gathering, so that no king after her may draw the lot at Dùn ìseal. She neither refuses nor agrees, and the matter is left to the next age.
- 12 AM MÀRT, GE 4,391** — *The king takes back the hill* (Dùn ìseal). Catriona Mhòr dies, and with her the list of the Stone Kings ends. Her kin put forward many claims to Dùn ìseal, and Ailean Mòr gives the hill to none of them. He comes to it himself and holds it in his own hand, as in the first days.
- 11 AN GEARRAN, GE 4,520** — *Dùn dhearg will not bow* (Dùn dhearg). The king sends to Dùn dhearg and to the households east of the vein, bidding them come in to him. They send his messenger back with nothing, and swear among themselves that they will owe nothing to Dùn ìseal nor to its king. From that year the spears of the east are gathered at Dùn dhearg.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,550** — *The eve of the Binding*. The handful is kept everywhere in the hills, the keepers are nine, the sharing before the storms is kept on every coast, and the saying is spoken at every gathering. None of it is yet declared, and no oath is yet sworn over the vein. The king holds Dùn ìseal in his own hand, his kin wait about him for their shares, and the spears of the east gather at Dùn dhearg.

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54. the fair at Muileann òg

## AGE III · AN AOIS NAOMH

*The Holy Age · the Flame Era, FE 1 – 2,960*

- 2 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1** — *Ailean Mòr falls at Àth na Fala*<sup>1</sup> (Dùn dhearg). The host of Dùn dhearg and the eastern households who never bowed come against the king at the ford below Dùn dhearg. Ailean Mòr holds the ford alone three days and three nights, and the dead of the host dam the river. On the third night he falls, worn down by the whole host; no one man overcame him, and age had not touched him. His kin, quarrelling already over the shares of the kingdom, did not come. He was four thousand six hundred and twenty-six years old, and had been king since the grove. The ford is called Àth na Fala after.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1** — *The Binding of the First Flame*. Custody is declared over the vein, and the first flame is bound at Dùn ìseal: the undying flame of Bride, kept over the stone of Crom Cruaich. The heirs of Ailean Mòr, gathered to part his kingdom, cannot part the vein, and swear it to no one of the blood. Its keepers, Òrd Bhride<sup>2</sup>, are the first order on Dia-thìr to govern both rite and people, and they are older by centuries than any rìgh after Ailean.
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1** — *The heirs sit at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). The kin of Ailean Mòr, come too late to the ford, stay on at Dùn ìseal after the Binding to part his kingdom. The knot-keeper Sìne nan Snaidhm ties a knot on a cord for every heir who stands up to claim: seven hundred and twelve. The eldest of them, Murchadh Mòr, is near two thousand nine hundred years old; the youngest who claims is a child in arms.
- 1 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2** — *Roinn na Rìoghachd*<sup>3</sup> (Dùn ìseal). On the night of the handful the heirs swear the parting of the kingdom, Roinn na Rìoghachd. The island below the mountain is cut into nine great shares, earrannan mòra, for the nine eldest lines of the king's blood, and the lines of his dead children are given the portion of the dead, cuid nam marbh, out of all nine. No heir is to be called rìgh. The ground of the Hall is in no share. Dùn dhearg, which Ìomhar Dearg had taken with the sword after the ford, is let stand as his share, over the protest of four lines.
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, FE 3** — *First blood among the heirs* (Dùn thais). At Dùn thais, on the line between the great share of the north and the Red Share, the men of Aonghas Bàn mac Mhurchaidh and of Ruairidh Glas of the line of Ìomhar come to blows over which share the fort lies in. Aonghas Bàn is killed. With his death begins Aimehreith nan Oighrean<sup>4</sup>, the strife of the heirs, between the line of Murchadh and the line of Ìomhar and then between many lines.

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1. the Ford of Blood, below Dùn dhearg

2. the order of Bride's flame

3. the Division; lit. 'the parting of the kingdom'

4. the Strife of the Heirs

- 25 AM MÀRT, FE 4** — *Shares of shares*. The great shares are parted again among their holders' children and grandchildren, into countries, provinces, counties and holdings, until the lesser blood of the portion of the dead is fitted in. Many holdings owe oaths to two lords, and some to three. The boundary stones of the Roinn are set up, and moved, and set up again.
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 4** — *Beathag Bhàn keeps the first flame* (Dùn iséal). At Dùn iséal under the central mountains the keepers of the slab and the households sworn to the Binding choose Beathag Bhàn to hold the first flame for Bride and to answer to Crom for what is taken from the vein. She is of no heir's blood and holds no share, and the heirs let her be chosen for that. The spoken roll of the Keepers begins with her name. Of her life before it nothing is remembered.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 10** — *The nine hearths* (Dùn iséal). Nine households about the mountain's foot, one for each district of the old keepers of the slab, take the tending of the flame in turn, each sending a son or daughter to sit with it through a season. The later houses of custody all claim descent from one or another of the nine. Not all the claims can be true.
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 15** — *Talla na Lasrach<sup>5</sup> raised* (Dùn iséal). A long hall of dry stone and turf is raised over the flame at Dùn iséal, with one door toward the vein and none toward the sea. It is rebuilt many times on the same footings, and the footings are all of it that anyone can now swear to.
- 17 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 21** — *Seann Spioradan nan Dia-thìreach<sup>6</sup> established*. At the hearths the eldest of the island's folk-ways takes shape: reverence for the ancestors, for the vein, for the weather that rules the mining season, and for the sìth of the hills and mounds. It keeps no priests, and it has never ceased.
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 27** — *The weather-cairns of Cnoc ghlas* (Cnoc ghlas). Watchers build cairns on the ridge above Cnoc ghlas and read the cloud on the high passes from them, to tell the Hall when the galleries may be opened for the season. A wrong reading costs the whole mountain its season, and the watchers are chosen with more care than the Keeper.
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 33** — *The ban on fires in sight of Doire uaine* (Marbh-bheò<sup>7</sup> Doire uaine). In obedience to the old inscriptions the Keepers forbid any fire, of wood or of coal, to be lit in sight of the Doire uaine hills. Herders who winter on those slopes eat cold for the season. The ban is never lifted, and none is known to have owned to breaking it.
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 34** — *Làrach an Teampaill<sup>8</sup> left unentered* (Làrach an Teampaill). Beathag Bhàn walks to Làrach an Teampaill, finds its altar already turned toward the mountain, and declares the place not the Hall's to keep. The Keepers set no foot in it for the rest of the age. Whose it was they did not say, and it seems they did not know.

5. the Hall of the Flame

6. the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich (the full name)

7. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

8. the temple ruin

- 3 AN GEARRAN, FE 44** — *Death of Beathag Bhàn* (Dùn ìseal). Beathag Bhàn dies at Dùn ìseal and is laid on the slope facing the vein, with her back to the sea. The nine hearths choose Muireach Liath, her sister's son, to keep the flame after her.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, FE 48** — *Coal by the basket* (Dùn ìseal). Muireach Liath fixes the first common measure for coal carried down from the galleries: a lidded basket of plaited heather, one to a household, filled once a season. Baskets of that weave are made at Dùn ìseal still, for no purpose but the making.
- 17 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 53** — *Allt an Àigh<sup>9</sup> named* (Allt an Àigh). A stream is held to bring good fortune to any who drink of it in a certain quarter of the moon. Pilgrims come to it, and have never wholly ceased to come.
- 14 AN GIBLEAN, FE 57** — *The pilgrims' path from Caol shean* (Caol shean). A path is worn from the river landing at Caol shean up the valley to Allt an Àigh<sup>10</sup>. It is walked by night, so that pilgrims reach the water in the right quarter of the moon. Fishermen who walk it are said to lose fewer boats; no count was kept either way.
- 16 AM MÀRT, FE 59** — *The Hall declines the stream* (Allt an Àigh<sup>11</sup>). Muireach Liath rules that Allt an Àigh belongs to the ancestors and the weather and not to the vein, and that the Hall will not keep it. Here the Keepers' rite and the older folk reverence first plainly part, and each side afterwards cites the ruling as proof that it was right.
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 66** — *The sick carried to Muileann ruadh* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>12</sup>). The sick are carried up in litters to the warm springs below Muileann ruadh and bathed at dawn. The Keepers allow it, for the heat of the water comes from the mountain and no one breaks the stone for it.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 71** — *Muileann chiar founded* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). A seam of silver is found near the great vein but apart from it. It is the first wealth of the island other than the coal.
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 74** — *Fearchar Airgeadach works the silver* (Muileann chiar). Fearchar Airgeadach, a basket-carrier of the nine hearths, is the first known to smelt the silver of Muileann chiar and hammer it into rings. His furnace burns wood and peat. It is the first fire on the island that answers to no one in the Hall.
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 74** — *Silver is not holy* (Muileann chiar). Asked whether the new seam falls under the flame, Muireach Liath answers that silver shows no colour when it breaks and so is not the mountain's. Muileann chiar is left free to dig as deep as it likes, and it digs. Every later quarrel over the silver begins from these words.

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9. the stream of the healing water

10. the stream of the healing water

11. the stream of the healing water

12. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 84** — *Silver for salt at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). Carriers take rings of Muileann chiar down to the river quays at Ros fhionn and trade them for salt fish and sealskin, one ring for a boatload. It is the first trade in anything but food, and the first whose price is remembered.
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, FE 89** — *Death of Muireach Liath* (Dùn ìseal). Muireach Liath dies at Dùn ìseal, keeping the flame. The nine hearths pass over three of other lines and choose his daughter Gormshuil nic Mhuirich. After her the Keeper's office stays in the house of Muireach for many generations.
- II AN T-SULTAIN, FE 96** — *Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>13</sup> named* (Dùn ìseal). The kin of Gormshuil nic Mhuirich at Dùn ìseal begin to be called Sliochd Mhuirich, the house of Muireach, the first house of custody known by a name and not by a hearth. No account that survives tells of the other eight hearths objecting.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 103** — *The first school of the druids founded*. The first of the Scoiltean nan Draoidhean<sup>14</sup>, the druid schools, gathers about one question: why the vein answers some hands and not others. For the first time within the Old Faith the coal is reasoned about, and not only revered.
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 110** — *Sileas nic Coinnich in the wood* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>15</sup>). Sileas nic Coinnich, a cutter from Muileann chiar in the far east, begins to teach in Coille Naomh Muileann chiar. At the galleries she had seen the coal break bright with its colours under some cutters' picks and dull under others, and she will not let the question be.
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 118** — *The stag in the grove* (Muileann chiar). The hearers of Sileas nic Coinnich at Muileann chiar name themselves the stag's people, for a stag said to have stood in the grove through a whole lesson. The school's later name, the stag's name Camaran, and the telling that it was the white stag of Flidais, lady of the deer, are found first in writings far younger than these days.
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, FE 125** — *The Hall shuts the galleries to the stag's people* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil nic Mhuirich forbids the hearers of Sileas to cut in the galleries of Dùn ìseal, holding that a question asked of the vein is a demand made of it. The stag's people keep their school in the east and send no cutters to the mountain for a long while after.
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 132** — *The smoke at Cnoc dhubh* (Cnoc dhubh). In a hard winter a household at Cnoc dhubh burns its coal by the basketful and not by the handful. The smoke settles in the valley, and three of the household and two neighbours die of it. The Keepers are sent for, and the case is argued at Dùn ìseal for the rest of the season.

13. the house of Muireach

14. the druid schools

15. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

- 15 AN T-IÚCHAR, FE 139** — *Fionnlagh Dall and the stone cup* (Dùn iseal). Fionnlagh Dall, Keeper after Gormshuil, has the old keepers' stone cup cut anew in grey stone to hold just what a cupped pair of hands will hold, and sets it for the measure on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach<sup>16</sup> at Dùn iseal. He is blind, and fills it by touch before the council, and none can say afterwards that he favoured anyone's hands.
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 142** — *The Small-Burning Law*. The custom of the handful is made law: no household may burn more than a measured handful of the coal in a season. It becomes the holy law of the Keepers of Bride's flame and Crom's stone, and it holds for centuries.
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, FE 145** — *The first sentence under the Law* (Seann Tarr). A household of Seann Tarr burns twice its measure in a season and loses its right to the coal for the season after, the first sentence given under the Small-Burning Law. Its name is set on the roll with the offence beside it, and for many centuries its descendants petition to have the offence struck out.
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, FE 148** — *No coal on the beacons* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>17</sup>). The Keepers rule that no coal may feed a beacon, since a beacon burns for strangers. The fire on the headland at Tobar dhearg is kept with driftwood and seal fat, and so are all the sea-lights of the island after it.
- 4 AM MÀRT, FE 151** — *The carriers' path to Ceann chaol* (Ceann chaol). A carriers' path is cut from the mountain down to the harbour of Ceann chaol, with steps hewn at the steep places. The Hall's baskets go down it to the southern households, and the dried fish of the south comes up.
- 3 AN GEARRAN, FE 154** — *The carriers drowned on the Abhainn dhombain* (Abhainn dhomhain). The Abhainn dhomhain rises in the night and takes eleven carriers and their baskets at a ford. The Hall mourns the coal with the carriers, and Fionnlagh Dall asks the council for a way across that the river cannot take.
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 157** — *The first bridges* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>18</sup>). Stone crossings begin to join the mining paths of the interior to the coast. From them in time come Drochaid Cathair dhearg and Drochaid Ros fhionn.
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 160** — *Ailean Clachair's crossing at Ros fhionn* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). Ailean Clachair and forty masons of the nine hearths bridge the river above Ros fhionn with a single span of fitted stone, from which Drochaid Ros fhionn descends. Ailean sets a hearth-sign in the keystone. Every bridge the masons build after bears one, and a bridge without it is not trusted.

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16. the Hall of the Flame

17. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

18. the bridge at Cathair dhearg



- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 163** — *The masons' custom* (Ros dhomhain). The bridge-masons form a fellowship bound by an oath sworn on the stone cup at Dùn ìseal: no span to be closed in the dark, and none to be paid for in coal. Their lodge is kept near the western crossing, in the country of Ros dhomhain.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 166** — *The tavern roads begin* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). The first waypoint houses are raised along the mining roads. From them come in time Am Buabhall Fortanach, An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>19</sup> and the others of the circuit.
- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 169** — *Mòr nic Dhùghaill's house* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Mòr nic Dhùghaill, a widow of Doire shean, keeps the first waypoint house on the site of Am Buabhall Fortanach. She serves the carriers jugged buffalo from her own herd, and the house has served it ever since.
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 172** — *The house at the middle of the road* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). A second waypoint house is built where the carriers' road from the mountain meets the road to the western harbours, on the site of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr. It is a turf longhouse with a hearth at either end, one for carriers going up and one for carriers coming down.
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 175** — *The road-peace* (An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>20</sup>). The keepers of the waypoint houses agree that no feud may be pursued under an inn roof or within a spear's throw of its door. The custom is first set down at the house on the site of An Sligeanach Fad' às. It is the oldest law on the island that neither Keeper nor lord made.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 178** — *Seann Mhorn resettled* (Seann Mhorn). Fishers of the nine hearths settle the harbour at Seann Mhorn and keep the name they find there, which is not of their own tongue; the old name came with the stones, they say. It is the first such name known to be taken over and not replaced.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 181** — *Seann Warr resettled* (Seann Warr). Families walking the new road from the mountain settle the harbour of Seann Warr on the western shore of Loch chrom in like manner. They find house-footings there already, and build on them, as the carriers' song has it, without asking whose.
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 184** — *Death of Fionnlagh Dall* (Dùn ìseal). Fionnlagh Dall dies at Dùn ìseal. At his own asking he is not laid on the slope with the Keepers before him, but carried south to the old graves near Cnoc dhìreach, which no living people had yet claimed.
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 184** — *Fionnlagh Dall carried to the old graves* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>21</sup>). The bearers are eleven days on the road with the body of Fionnlagh Dall, and lay it at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach among graves older than any name. The Keepers after him cannot agree why he asked it; two answers are given, and neither is chosen.

19. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

20. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

21. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 189** — *The mausoleum consecrated*. Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>22</sup>, already ancient, is hallowed by the Keepers over the grave of Fionnlagh Dall, the first burial there that is set down by name. The burial-ground that no one claimed is claimed.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 194** — *The grave-keepers of Cnoc dhìreach* (Cnoc dhìreach). A few families settle at Cnoc dhìreach to tend Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>23</sup> after the Keeper's burial. The Hall pays them in coal, a handful each a season, the only payment in coal the Law ever allows.
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 381** — *Eilidh nic Ìomhair keeps the flame* (Dùn ìseal). The nine hearths choose a Keeper from outside the house of Muireach for the first time: Eilidh nic Ìomhair, of Dùn dhearg, of the line of Ìomhar Dearg and so of the king's blood. Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>24</sup>, holding to the Binding, refuses for a season, then yields at Dùn ìseal, on the condition that the stone cup never leaves Talla na Lasrach<sup>25</sup>.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, FE 385** — *The Four Houses sworn* (Dùn ìseal). Under Eilidh nic Ìomhair the office of Keeper is bound to four houses of custody: Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>26</sup> of Dùn ìseal, Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>27</sup> of Dùn dhearg, Sliochd Thormoid<sup>28</sup> of Seann Dunn and Sliochd Ragh-naill<sup>29</sup> of Seann Tarr. The other hearths keep their seats on the council, but lose their claim to the flame. Most of the later nobility of the island descends from one of the four, or says it does.
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, FE 389** — *The house of Tormod at Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). Sliochd Thormoid<sup>30</sup> raises a hall and a shrine at Seann Dunn, facing the mountain across the river. A lamp of coal burns in the shrine at the Law's measure. The other houses complain that the measure of Seann Dunn is always the fullest.
- 2 AM MÀRT, FE 393** — *The house of Raghnaill at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). Sliochd Ragh-naill<sup>31</sup> takes for its seat Seann Tarr on the north-eastern coast, the town whose household was first sentenced under the Law. The house keeps boats and not galleries, and grows rich on the fishing.
- 31 AM MÀRT, FE 397** — *Round Eilean dhubh* (Eilean dhubh). Boats of Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>32</sup> sail round Eilean dhubh and come home, the first voyage made to see a coast and not to fish it. The house's songs name the steersman Tormod Ruadh. He brings back word of rock and birds, and of having gone, and of nothing else.

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22. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

23. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

24. the house of Muireach

25. the Hall of the Flame

26. the house of Muireach

27. the house of Ìomhar

28. the house of Tormod

29. the house of Raghnaill

30. the house of Tormod

31. the house of Raghnaill

32. the house of Raghnaill

- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 401** — *The outlaws of the north-west waters* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Households stripped of their right under the Law for a third offence take to boats, live off the north-western waters, and raid the fishing strands. They are called spùinneadairean, plunderers, and the name stays with those waters after them.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 405** — *The boat lost off the north-west* (Uilebheist na Mara<sup>33</sup>). A fishing boat out of Baile chrom is lost in calm water off the north-western coast. The two men who swim home say that something rose under it. Each year thereafter the boat's village keeps a wake for it. Of the thing they saw no more is told.
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 409** — *The fire at Baile chrom relit* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>34</sup>). After the loss the fishers of Baile chrom light the old beacon on the point again, fed with driftwood as the Law requires. From it comes Taigh-solais Baile chrom.
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 413** — *Seann Bhrenn resettled* (Seann Bhrenn). Fishers from the north side of the mountain settle the harbour of Seann Bhrenn on the northern coast and keep its old name, as the western settlers kept Seann Warr's. They find a stone quay under the silt and use it.
- 20 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 417** — *The ancestor-cairn at Cathair naomb* (Cathair naomh). The people of Cathair naomh in the north raise a cairn for their dead on the hill above the town, and bring it a stone at every burial. It is the greatest ancestor-cairn in the north, and it grows still.
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 421** — *The panthers let pass* (Imrich nam Pantar<sup>35</sup>). The crossing of the great cats is found to run straight over the carriers' southern road. Eilidh nic Ìomhair rules that no panther may be killed on the road in its season, and the carriers wait in the waypoint houses until the crossing is done. The rule is kept, for it costs the carriers only time.
- 19 AM MÀRT, FE 434** — *The granaries of Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>36</sup> builds stone granaries at Dùn dhearg and fills them from the lowland fields of its share, holding grain against the storm season as the old custom of sharing asks. So the house gains what the Hall never had: people who owe it their bread.
- 18 AN GEARRAN, FE 448** — *Baile Mòr dhombhain at the foot of the pass* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Carriers who take the Hall's baskets north over the high pass settle at its southern foot, where Baile Mòr dhomhain now stands, to rest their beasts before the climb. The town lives by the pass, and by little else.
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, FE 461** — *The reverent centuries*. Generation after generation mines the same small measure and burns the same small measure, and the people neither grow nor dwindle, whichever lord's share they live in. The rolls call them the reverent centuries.

33. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

34. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

- 17 AN GIBLEAN, FE 475** — *Coinneach Mòr mac Tormoid keeps the flame* (Seann Dunn). Coinneach Mòr mac Tormoid of Seann Dunn becomes the first Keeper of Sliochd Thormoid<sup>37</sup>. He keeps the flame longer than any Keeper before him, and changes nothing while he keeps it.
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 488** — *The shepherds of Achadh chaol* (Achadh chaol). Shepherds settle the upland fields at Achadh chaol in the north-east and send their wool down to the harbours. Their headman sits one season on the council at Dùn iséal, is found to hold no hearth-right, and goes home.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 502** — *The Keepers' count of the old places* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>38</sup>). Coinneach Mòr sends walkers to list the ruins of the old people. They bring back Làrach an Dùin-fhaire, Làrach an Dùin<sup>39</sup>, Làrach an Teampaill<sup>40</sup> and the standing stones. The list says who does not own each place, and not who built it; the Keepers rule that it shall not guess.
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 515** — *The fence round Carragh Cnoc bheag*<sup>41</sup> (Carragh Cnoc bheag). The people of Cnoc bheag set a ring of stakes round the old standing stone above their town, that the cattle may not rub against it. Every generation after renews the ring. The stone is never moved.
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 529** — *The bath-house at Muileann ruadh* (Muileann ruadh). A roofed bath-house is built over the warm springs below Muileann ruadh, with sleeping-places for the sick and their bearers. The Hall appoints a keeper of the springs, who tends them in the name of Dian Cècht, the healer. It is the first office the Hall makes that has nothing to do with the coal.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 542** — *The silver weights of Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar). The silversmiths of Muileann chiar cast a set of weights, the least the weight of a barley-corn and the greatest that of a newborn lamb. Every trader on the carriers' roads comes to use them, and for the rest of the age a thing weighed at Muileann chiar is said to be weighed fairly.
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 556** — *The burning of Achadh mhòr* (Achadh mhòr). Cogadh an Dà Mhionn<sup>42</sup>, the War of the Two Oaths, ends where it began. Fearghas Dà-Mhionn, lord of the granary fields of Achadh mhòr, sworn both to the line of Ìomhar and to the lords of Cathair mhòr, is called to arms by each against the other, and both come to take his fields. The fields are burned to the stubble, and Fearghas dies in his hall.

35. the panthers' crossing

36. the house of Ìomhar

37. the house of Tormod

38. the watch-fort ruin

39. the fortress ruin

40. the temple ruin

41. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

42. the War of the Two Oaths

- I AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 556** — *Sith an Stairsnich*<sup>43</sup> (Dùn iséal). The lords of the shares swear the Peace of the Threshold, Sith an Stairsnich, on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach<sup>44</sup>, beside the stone cup, with the Keeper as witness. No share may be parted again at a death: a holding passes whole to one heir. No man may swear to two lords. The boundary stones are set where they stand that day. So ends Aimhreit nan Oighrean<sup>45</sup>.
- IO AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 556** — *The market under the Hall* (Dùn iséal). A market is held under the walls of the Hall at Dùn iséal on the four quarter days, Samhain, Là Fhèill Bhrìde, Bealltainn and Lùnastal, when the households of the eastern hills come up with their dues. Hides, venison, charcoal, honey and the silver of Muileann Chiar change hands there on the new weights. The Keepers allow no coal to be sold on their ground, and none is.
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 565** — *The stag's people at Cnoc bhàn* (Cnoc bhàn). A house of the stag's people is founded at Cnoc bhàn, north of the mountain, and after the long exclusion takes cutters again. Its teachers keep the question of Sileas nic Coinnich as she left it: why does the coal show its colours for one hand and not another?
- 26 AN GEARRAN, FE 574** — *Seonaid Chiar reopens the galleries to the stag's people* (Dùn iséal). Seonaid Chiar, Keeper of the house of Muireach, lets cutters trained by the stag's people back into the galleries at Dùn iséal, sworn to ask nothing of the vein aloud. The Hall's roll calls it a reconciling. The school remembers it as a truce.
- 27 AM MÀRT, FE 579** — *Cathair mhòr walled* (Cathair mhòr). The people of Cathair mhòr on the southern coast build a wall of fitted stone about their headland town, the first town wall on the island. What they feared no one has told.
- 16 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 584** — *Ceann leathan's fish-market* (Ceann leathan). Ceann leathan becomes the market of the southern fishing and sends dried fish inland along the carriers' paths. Its harbour-master keeps tallies on notched sticks. Several are kept at Muileann chaol, the oldest counted things in its keeping.
- 14 AN GEARRAN, FE 589** — *The shrine at Inis thais* (Inis thais). A shrine to the ancestors lost at sea is raised at Inis thais on the western coast. Its keepers burn their season's handful on the shore and not indoors, so that the drowned, gone west over the sea, may see it.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, FE 594** — *Cuan shean's salt-pans* (Cuan shean). The people of Cuan shean on the western coast dig salt-pans on the flats below the town and boil sea-water over peat. Their salt goes inland along the western road and keeps the fish of half the island.
- 31 AM MÀRT, FE 599** — *Salt-carriers on the heath above Baile fhiadhaich* (Baile fhiadhaich). Salt-carriers from Cuan shean settle on the western heath above Baile fhiadhaich, by a stream that runs all summer. The heath about it is not worth the plough, and its people keep goats.

43. the Peace of the Threshold

44. the Hall of the Flame

- 2 AM MÀRT, FE 604** — *The sunny house* (An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>46</sup>). A waypoint house is built on the eastern road where the carriers from Cnoc leathan meet the southern coast path, on the site of An Taigh-òsta Grianach. It faces south, and from the first is known for its warmth, which is all its name has ever meant.
- 1 AN GEARRAN, FE 609** — *Cnoc leathan's market* (Cnoc leathan). Cnoc leathan, at the eastern end of the road past the sunny house, becomes the market town of the south-eastern hills. Its carriers' guild holds the right to carry for the Hall on the stretch down to the coast.
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 614** — *The fall in the high gallery* (Dùn ìseal). A roof falls in the highest gallery at Dùn ìseal and kills four cutters. The gallery is walled up and left. Seonaid Chiar orders props of oak set in every gallery after, and for the first time the Hall spends timber on the mountain.
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 634** — *Cathair dhomhain founded* (Cathair dhomhain). Carriers settled at the mouth of the western road raise a town on the rise above the harbour and name it Cathair dhomhain. Its shrine keeps the Law's measure strictly, and its people are proud of it.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 654** — *A fishing town at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). The old settlement of the Red Hill, shrunk to a small fishing town, grows again at the western bridge-foot on the Abhainn dhomhain, a little above its meeting with the Abhainn gheal below Loch chrom. The ground is afterwards called Cathair dhearg, for its red stone. As yet it is a place carriers pass through on the way to somewhere else.
- 3 AN GIBLEAN, FE 674** — *Goraidh gathers the shares of the east* (Dùn dhearg). By two cousins dead without heirs and a marriage to a third, Goraidh mac Ìomhair holds in one hand three of the old counties of the east round Dùn dhearg, parted since the Roinn. He is the first of the kin to gather again what the Roinn had divided, and the Peace of the Threshold lets him keep it whole.
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, FE 674** — *Goraidh mac Ìomhair called rìgh* (Dùn dhearg). At Dùn dhearg the lowland households who eat from the granaries of Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>47</sup> begin to call its head, Goraidh mac Ìomhair, their rìgh, their king. No one had been so called since Ailean Mòr, for at the Roinn the heirs swore that none of them would take the word. Goraidh claims nothing over the vein, and is careful to tell the Hall so.
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 694** — *The division of keeping* (Dùn ìseal). The council at Dùn ìseal and Goraidh mac Ìomhair agree on a division. The Keeper keeps the flame and the galleries; the rìgh keeps the roads, the granaries and the peace of the lowlands. The rìgh may not enter the galleries, and the Keeper may not raise spears. On this division the island is governed for the rest of the age.

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45. the Strife of the Heirs

46. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

47. the house of Ìomhar

- 11 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 714** — *Goraidh Mòr's hall* (Dùn dhearg). Goraidh mac Ìomhair, called Goraidh Mòr, builds a timber hall on the hill at Dùn dhearg, with a granary at each corner. Its post-holes could still be seen when the surveyors of the Library walked the hill, and they measured and drew them.
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 719** — *The first road-toll* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). Goraidh Mòr sets a toll on the carriers' roads, one fish in twenty or its worth, to pay the road-guards and keep up the bridges. The keepers of the waypoint houses gather it, and keep a share of it, and the rolls say so.
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 754** — *Mòrag of the Roads* (Dùn dhearg). Mòrag nic Ghoraidh takes the hall at Dùn dhearg after her father Goraidh Mòr. She is called Mòrag nan Rathad, Mòrag of the Roads, for in her first years she walks every carriers' road on the island and orders the bad stretches made anew.
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 781** — *The golden house* (An Taigh-seinnse Òir<sup>48</sup>). Mòrag nan Rathad has a waypoint house built on the road north of Seann Dunn, on the site of An Taigh-seinnse Òir, to shorten the carriers' stage from the coast to the mountain. It is the first waypoint house raised by a ruler and not by a family.
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 794** — *The bridge-foot rebuilt* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>49</sup>). At the bidding of Mòrag nan Rathad the western crossing of the Abhainn dhomhain is rebuilt in wider stone, so that two laden carriers can pass on it. The hearth-sign of Ailean Clachair is cut again in its keystone. From this time the town at the bridge-foot begins to grow.
- 16 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 834** — *Dòmhnall Crùbach* (Dùn dhearg). Dòmhnall Crùbach, Dòmhnall the Lamé, follows his mother Mòrag at Dùn dhearg. He cannot walk the roads as she did, and rules through the keepers of the waypoint houses, who grow mighty in his reign.
- 14 AN GEARRAN, FE 863** — *The waypoint-keepers of Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). In the reign of Dòmhnall Crùbach the keepers of the waypoint houses about the harbour town of Ceann mhin take the gathering of the road-toll into their own hands and pay the rìgh what they judge fair. Their judgement is generous to themselves, and the rolls keep the sums.
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 879** — *Baile àrsaidh on the western heath* (Baile àrsaidh). Settlers from Cathair dhomhain take the wet heath of the west coast and found Baile àrsaidh, where the soil is thin and the yellow scorpions thick. They swear their oaths on a scorpion's sting kept in a box, and their neighbours think it a strange custom.
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 879** — *The storm at Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). A storm drives the sea over the harbour at Seann Chwen and takes the boats and a third of the houses. The Keeper sends the Hall's grain from Dùn iséal, and Dòmhnall Crùbach sends his from Dùn dhearg. The survivors remember that the Hall's came first.

48. the golden house, a waypoint inn

- 15 AM MÀRT, FE 914** — *The stag-letters* (Muileann chiar). At Muileann chiar in the far east the teachers of the stag's people make the cutters' tally-notches into signs for sounds, so that a teaching may be kept without a teacher. These are the first letters the Dia-thìrich use: the ogham, which the druids call the gift of Ogma.
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, FE 914** — *The letters set against the obelisk* (Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>50</sup>). Scholars of the stag carry their new letters to Carragh Cnoc bheag and set them beside the marks on the obelisk. They match nothing. The scholars write that the stone's makers were not their teachers, and that is the first thing the Dia-thìrich ever write of the old people.
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 914** — *Sileas Dhonn* (Dùn dhearg). Sileas Dhonn, niece of Dòmhnall Crùbach, holds Dùn dhearg after him. In her reign the keepers of the waypoint houses are bidden to render account of the tolls at her hall once a year, and several of them do.
- 14 AN GEARRAN, FE 991** — *The lords of Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). The harbour town of Caol leathan in the south-west grows rich on the western fishing and the southern end of the carriers' road. Its leading family, under Lachlann Ciar, takes the road-toll for itself and sends none of it to Dùn dhearg.
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, FE 994** — *Iain Garbh* (Dùn dhearg). Iain Garbh, Iain the Rough, son of Sileas Dhonn, takes the hall at Dùn dhearg and demands the western tolls of Caol leathan. Lachlann Ciar sends back a basket of fish-bones.
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, FE 999** — *The War of the Roads begins at Muileann òg* (Muileann òg). Iain Garbh marches west with the road-guards and the lowland levies, and burns the toll-house at Muileann òg that the men of Lachlann Ciar had taken. It is the first war of Dia-thìreach against Dia-thìreach since the Peace of the Threshold, and the first fought over a road; every war before it was fought over a share. The Hall will bless neither side.
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,000** — *Uisdean mac Ruairidh's refusal* (Dùn ìseal). The Keeper Uisdean mac Ruairidh refuses the messengers of Iain Garbh at Dùn ìseal the Hall's handful for the warband's hearths, saying that the flame does not warm men who go out to kill. The warband winters on peat. Iain Garbh never forgives the Hall, and never enters it.
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,001** — *The fight at Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). The men of Caol leathan meet the levies of Iain Garbh at the ford of Àth fhiadhaich and hold it for a day before they give way. Forty lie dead of both sides. Long afterwards the carriers call it the ford of the forty.
- 16 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,002** — *Baile ghlas burned* (Baile ghlas). The men of Lachlann Ciar, falling back on Caol leathan, burn Baile ghlas, that the levies of Iain Garbh may find no grain. Its people walk to Cathair dhomhain, and many never return.

49. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

50. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag



- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,003** — *Baile chiar holds* (Baile chiar). Baile chiar, south of the western bridge-foot, shuts its gate on both hosts in the War of the Roads and feeds the burned-out folk of Baile ghlas through the winter. Neither side forgives it, and neither attacks it.
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,005** — *The siege of Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). Iain Garbh shuts Caol leathan in from the land for a season, but its boats bring in fish from the sea, and the harbour he cannot close. His levies begin to go home for the harvest, and the siege ends without an assault.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,006** — *The peace at Mòr nic Dhubhaill's house* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Iain Garbh and Lachlann Ciar meet under the roof of the waypoint house that is afterwards Am Buabhall Fortanach, where by the road-peace neither may draw. Caol leathan keeps half its tolls and sends half to Dùn dhearg, and Lachlann Ciar swears to the Law before the Keeper's witness. So the War of the Roads ends in a house built to feed carriers.
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,009** — *The wolf-sworn of Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). Men who fought for Caol leathan become its road-guards and swear their watch on a white stone carved as a wolf, kept at the town gate. They call themselves the wolf-sworn.
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,036** — *Caol fhiadhaich rebuilt* (Caol fhiadhaich). Caol fhiadhaich on the south-western shore had sent its boats to feed Caol leathan through the siege. In thanks Lachlann Ciar gives it a share of the western tolls, and with it the town builds a harbour wall.
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,044** — *Death of Iain Garbh* (Dùn dhearg). Iain Garbh dies at Dùn dhearg. His daughter Catriona buries him in the floor of the hall and not on the slope at Dùn ìseal, and the Hall does not ask for him.
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,046** — *Catriona Ghlic* (Dùn dhearg). Catriona Ghlic, Catriona the Wise, rules from Dùn dhearg. She sends her own son to sit a season with the flame, the first child of the royal house to do so since the division of keeping. By the end of her reign the Hall and the hall are on speaking terms again.
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,081** — *The house on the northern road* (An Leòmhann Buidhe<sup>51</sup>). Catriona Ghlic has a waypoint house built on the northern road above Inis mhòr, on the site of An Leòmhann Buidhe. It serves the carriers who take the Hall's baskets to the northern households and bring back wool.
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,085** — *The house on the cold road* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). A stone house is built on the open moor, on the road between Baile Mòr dhomhain and the northern coast, on the site of An Taigh-seinnse Reòta, for carriers caught by snow. The Hall pays its keepers in grain and the crown in cloth, and they complain of both.

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51. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

- 11 AN MÀRT, FE 1,089** — *Inis mhòr grows* (Inis mhòr). The river port of Inis mhòr in the north becomes the gathering-place of the northern wool trade and outgrows every other northern town. Its people ask Catriona Ghlic for a road-guard of their own, and are given one.
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,122** — *Death of Eithne nic Ailein, last of the nine* (Cathair mhòr). Eithne nic Ailein, daughter of Ailean Mòr and youngest of the nine who took the great shares at the Roinn, dies in her hall at Cathair mhòr. And all the days of Eithne were three thousand and twenty-one years, and she died. After her none of the nine is living, and the great shares are names on the boundary stones.
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,122** — *The market at the fords of Baile Mòr dhombhain* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). The lords of the deep river set a market at Baile Mòr dhomhain, where the carriers' road from the south meets the paths down from the hill pastures. Cattle, sheep, horses, hides and the white stone of the hills are sold at the fords on the day after each new moon, and the lords take one fleece in forty from the sellers.
- 10 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,166** — *Muileann shean on the northern road* (Muileann shean). A mill is built at Muileann shean on the northern road, to grind the grain the carriers bring over the pass, and a town grows round it. The Hall pays the miller in grain, and he pays the rìgh's toll in flour.
- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,211** — *The unremembered rulers* (Dùn dhearg). Eleven rulers hold Dùn dhearg between Catriona Ghlic and Ealasaid Chiar. The later king-list gives their names and their order, and nothing more. For the same years the Keepers' roll gives five Keepers, and of them too only the names.
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,255** — *Tormod Scriobhaiche learns the letters* (Muileann chiar). Tormod mac Iain, a younger son of the house of Tormod, is sent east to Muileann chiar to learn the stag-letters. He is the first of the royal kin to read, and for the rest of his life he is called Tormod Scriobhaiche, Tormod the Writer.
- 22 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,299** — *Ealasaid Chiar* (Dùn dhearg). Ealasaid Chiar takes the hall at Dùn dhearg and brings Tormod Scriobhaiche there as her clerk. She bids him set down in order the name of every ruler of the hall that the reciters can give him.
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,299** — *The first written king-list*. Rulers are first set down by name, and no longer only remembered in tales. The rolls of succession in every later age are kept after this pattern.
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,300** — *The contents of Tormod's roll* (Dùn dhearg). Tormod Scriobhaiche's roll, kept in the hall at Dùn dhearg, runs from Goraidh Mòr to Ealasaid Chiar. The earlier names he has from the reciters and the later from living memory, and he marks which are which. In three places it differs from the Keepers' spoken roll; Tormod writes down both readings and does not choose.

- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,320** — *The Keepers' roll written down* (Dùn ìseal). Shamed, in the Hall's own words, by the rìgh's clerk, the Keepers have their spoken roll written in stag-letters at Dùn ìseal. It begins with Beathag Bhàn, and it is longer than Tormod's by several centuries.
- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,569** — *The watchers of the dark wood* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>52</sup>). A small company settles at the edge of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag, the wood never cleared, and keeps watch for a black horned beast that they say walks in it. The people of Cathair dhearg call them the wood-watchers. None of their own accounts is older than Òrd Mhacha<sup>53</sup>, the order of Macha, which afterwards claims them and takes the beast for a sign of Dubh Sainglenn, the black horse.
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,576** — *The wood-watchers in the stag's grove* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>54</sup>). Wood-watchers come east and cut a black-barked tree in Coille Naomh Muileann chiar, saying that the beast had shown it to them. The stag's people call it theft from a place of teaching. Both sides send to Dùn dhearg and to Dùn ìseal.
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,581** — *The stag's people claim the dark wood* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>55</sup>). In answer the stag's people send teachers west to hold their lessons in Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag, saying that the first stag came from there. Now each side claims both woods, and in either wood the two companies meet and do not speak.
- 10 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,589** — *The holy-wood dispute*. Rival rites contend for Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>56</sup> and Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>57</sup>, the first such strife that is remembered. It is settled by dividing the keeping of the woods, and no side is judged the victor.
- 11 AM MÀRT, FE 1,595** — *The boundary stones of the woods* (Dùn dhearg). The woods are divided at Dùn dhearg before Fearchar Òg, rìgh after Ealasaid Chiar, and the Keeper Calum Liath. The stag's people keep the eastern wood and the wood-watchers the western, and each may walk in the other's wood unarmed and without cutting. Boundary stones are set at the edges of both woods with the terms cut on them in stag-letters. Two of the eastern stones remain.
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,602** — *Calum Liath's surveyors* (Dùn ìseal). The Keeper Calum Liath sends cutters with knotted cords and lamps into every gallery at Dùn ìseal, to follow the vein as far as it can be followed and mark where it thickens and thins. The work keeps the cutters from the coal for three seasons, and the households go short to pay for it.
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,607** — *The measuring of the vein*. For the first time men try to reckon how much coal the mountain holds. Their reckoning proves far too hopeful.

52. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

53. the order of Macha

54. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

55. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

56. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,607** — *The reckoning of the cords* (Dùn ìseal). The reckoning of Calum Liath is cut on a slab in the Hall at Dùn ìseal: the mountain can give every household its handful for more generations than there are grains in the granaries of Dùn dhearg. It is read out at the council and heard in silence, and the Hall takes the silence for assent.
- 22 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,621** — *The deaths in the lower gallery* (Dùn ìseal). Two youths of the nine hearths, sent into the lower gallery at Dùn ìseal without a Keeper's cutter to guide them, break the wrong face and are crushed. They had been less than a season in the galleries. Their families ask the council what the Hall owes them, and the council has no answer.
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,628** — *The apprentice-binding custom*. Young Dia-thìrich are first bound for seven years to a master of the vein's custody before they may go near the coal themselves. Every later guild of the mines is shaped on this binding.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,634** — *Oighrig Bhàn's first bound* (Dùn ìseal). Oighrig Bhàn, Keeper after Calum Liath, binds the first twelve apprentices under the new custom at Dùn ìseal, each to a master cutter by name. They swear on the stone cup to serve seven years before they touch the vein. Four of the twelve are afterwards Keepers, which is the best that can be said for the custom.
- 23 AM MÀRT, FE 1,641** — *The stag's people take apprentices* (Cnoc bhàn). The house of the stag's people at Cnoc bhàn takes the seven years for its own cutters and adds a rule: an apprentice keeps a written account of every stroke, and the account is read. These strike-books are the school's chief record for the rest of the age.
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,647** — *The long reign of Fearchar Òg* (Dùn dhearg). Fearchar Òg, who divided the woods, rules long at Dùn dhearg and is remembered chiefly for dying old. He was named Òg, the young, for coming to the hall as a boy, and the name stuck.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,654** — *The silver tokens* (Muileann chiar). The clerks of Fearchar Òg begin to pay the road-guards in small silver rings of the Muileann chiar weight, stamped with the hall's mark. It is the first payment in metal by any ruler on Dia-thìr. The rings travel further than the guards do.
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,661** — *The toll-house at Àth ghlas* (Àth ghlas). A toll-house is built on the ford at Àth ghlas, where the southern road crosses the river toward Ceann leathan, and the road-guards are paid there in the new silver rings. Its keeper is the first sent from the rìgh's hall, and not chosen in the place.
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,665** — *The road-guards' games at Ceann leathan* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>58</sup>). The road-guards of the south begin to meet each year at Ceann leathan and fight with blunted staves for a silver ring. The meeting outlives its purpose, and on its field Còmhrag Ceann leathan is afterwards fought. The first winner whose name is kept is a woman, Mòrag Dhubh of Cnoc mhòr.

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57. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

- 5 **AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,665** — *The fair at Muileann òg* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>58</sup>). Muileann òg, burned in the War of the Roads, is rebuilt as a market town. A fair is held there each harvest at Lùnastal for the trade of the western and southern roads, and from it Fèill Muileann òg descends.
- 3 **AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,665** — *The landing on the Abhainn uaine* (Cidhe Beag). A landing for river-boats is built on the Abhainn uaine at the place since called Cidhe Beag, so that the grain of the lowlands may go upriver by boat and not on carriers' backs. The carriers of the eastern road protest to Fearchar Òg, and lose.
- II **AM MÀRT, FE 1,685** — *The river-boats* (Abhainn uaine). Flat river-boats of hide over withy begin to carry grain and salt fish up the Abhainn uaine from the landing at Cidhe Beag. The boatmen form a fellowship of their own, sworn on a paddle, and vie with the carriers for the Hall's baskets.
- 8 **AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,685** — *The boatmen of Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). Muileann chrom, up the valley from the landing at Cidhe Beag, becomes the home of the river-boatmen and their fellowship. Its yards build the flat hide boats for every river of the island.
- 6 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,685** — *Beathag Mhòr* (Dùn dhearg). Beathag Mhòr, great-granddaughter of Fearchar Òg, takes the hall at Dùn dhearg. The list calls her ban-rìgh, queen, the first so called, and not rìgh with a woman's name after it; the change of word is the list's own.
- 12 **AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,699** — *The fleece-measure of Baile Mòr fhionn* (Baile Mòr fhionn). The lords of the western plain hold a market at Baile Mòr fhionn and make the fleece of a grown ewe its measure. Grain, wine, cattle and the horses of the plain are all priced in fleeces. The silver rings of Muileann chiar are taken there too, but reckoned in wool.
- 10 **AN GEARRAN, FE 1,699** — *The hall moves to Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Mhòr moves her hall from Dùn dhearg to the town at the western bridge-foot, Cathair dhearg, to sit where the roads, the river and the western harbours meet. Dùn dhearg keeps the old granaries and the graves of the house of Ìomhar. From this reign Cathair dhearg is the seat of rule on Dia-thìr, whatever else changes.
- 22 **AN GEARRAN, FE 1,699** — *Dùn dhearg after the move* (Dùn dhearg). Dùn dhearg, left behind, keeps its granaries and its pride. Its people go on calling it the rìgh's hill, and for many generations its reeves will send their accounts to Cathair dhearg in no hand but their own.
- 23 **AM MÀRT, FE 1,699** — *The red hall* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Mhòr's hall at Cathair dhearg is built on the rise above the harbour, of the red stone that names the town. Its foundations lie under the later citadel. The masons cut the hearth-sign in its lintel as though it were a bridge.

58. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

59. the fair at Muileann òg

**9 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,699** — *Cathair dhombhain against Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhomhain).

The harbour of Cathair dhomhain, older and larger, grudges the new seat on its doorstep and refuses the queen's toll on its boats. Beathag Mhòr grants it a charter of its own tolls. The two towns, a few miles apart, are rivals for the rest of the age.

**22 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,699** — *Disputed hands* (Dùn ìseal). The council at Dùn ìseal is asked to judge more quarrels over the right to the handful than over anything else: new households, divided households, households that claim descent from one of the nine hearths without proof. Dùghall mac Raghnaill, Keeper after Oighrig Bhàn, asks the queen for a counting.**II AM FAOILLEACH, FE 1,735** — *Beathag Mhòr orders the count* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Mhòr and Dùghall mac Raghnaill agree that every household on the island claiming the handful shall be counted, its right proved or refused, and its name written. The clerks at Cathair dhearg are to write, and the Keepers to judge.**9 AN GEARRAN, FE 1,735** — *The waypoint houses as counting-houses* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). The counters make their stations at the waypoint houses, for every household on the island lies within a day of one. The keepers of the houses feed the counters at the queen's cost, and in the houses the count is afterwards remembered as a good year.**22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,735** — *The census of hands*. The households that hold the old right to burn the coal are counted across the whole island for the first time. So it is shown that the burning of the coal was already rationed by rule.**21 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,735** — *The count of hands* (Cathair dhearg). The rolls of the count, kept at Cathair dhearg, give eleven thousand four hundred households holding the right, and some two thousand whose claims were refused. The refused are written on a roll of their own, and from then on it is that roll families search when they would prove an ancestor's standing.**19 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,735** — *The refused of Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). Most of the refused households of the north-eastern coast are fisher-families about Seann Tarr who had never burned coal at all, and now find they have no right to begin. Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>60</sup> takes up their cause at the council and loses. The fisher-families burn peat and say it is warmer.**17 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,735** — *The light at Baile ìseal* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal<sup>61</sup>). The old beacon on the eastern point at Baile ìseal is rebuilt, kept with driftwood and seal fat as the Law requires, to bring the fishing boats of the eastern coast home in the dark. From it comes Taigh-solais Baile ìseal.**16 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,735** — *The light at Muileann bheag* (Taigh-solais Muileann bheag<sup>62</sup>). The old beacon on the northern headland at Muileann bheag is rebuilt; from it comes Taigh-solais Muileann bheag. Its keepers are fisher-families of the north-west, who pay no toll to Cathair dhearg in return for keeping it.

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60. the house of Raghnaill

61. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

62. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,735** — *The light at Àth dhearg* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg<sup>63</sup>). Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>64</sup> rebuilds the old beacon on the north-eastern cape at Àth dhearg, to mark the way in toward Seann Tarr. From it comes Taigh-solais Àth dhearg.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,735** — *Death of Beathag Mhòr* (Dùn dhearg). Beathag Mhòr dies at Cathair dhearg and by her own command is carried back to Dùn dhearg to lie among the house of Ìomhar. No royal journey before it was so long.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,736** — *Ruairidh Liath* (Cathair dhearg). Ruairidh Liath, son of Beathag Mhòr, rules from Cathair dhearg. He is grey already when he takes the hall, and his byname is the list's one jest.
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 1,745** — *The Silver Feud begins* (Muileann chiar). Ruairidh Liath demands one ring in five of the silver taken at Muileann chiar, saying the tokens that pay his guards should cost him nothing. Sliochd Fhearchair, the silversmiths' house, answers with Muireach Liath's ruling: silver is not holy, and so not the crown's either. They close the workings sooner than pay.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 1,746** — *The closing of the silver* (Muileann chiar). For three seasons no silver leaves Muileann chiar. The road-guards go unpaid, the fair at Muileann òg trades in grain again, and the tolls of the eastern road go ungathered. It is called the Silver Feud, though no one is killed in it.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 1,749** — *The Keeper's judgment on the silver* (Dùn iséal). At the asking of both sides the Keeper Dùghall mac Raghnaill rules at Dùn iséal that the words of Muireach Liath stand, and silver is not the mountain's; but also that the crown keeps the roads the silver travels. Ruairidh Liath takes one ring in ten, Sliochd Fhearchair opens the workings again, and each calls it a victory.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 1,750** — *The Muileann chiar weight made law* (Muileann chiar). In the settlement the silver weights of Muileann chiar are declared the only lawful weights on the roads of the island. Copies in bronze are sent to every waypoint house, and the house of Fearchair is paid for each.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, FE 1,781** — *The bronze-casters of Muileann dhearg* (Muileann dhearg). The bronze copies of the Muileann chiar weights are cast at Muileann dhearg, where a family of casters learned the craft from the silversmiths. They go on to cast bells, pins and lamp-bowls, and their lamp-bowls hold the Law's measure exactly.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, FE 1,781** — *Seonag Chrom* (Cathair dhearg). Seonag Chrom, granddaughter of Ruairidh Liath, rules at Cathair dhearg. She gives the clerks a room of their own in the red hall and a wage in silver, and from her reign the king-list is kept year by year and not reign by reign.

63. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

64. the house of Raghnaill

- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 1,854** — *Inis bheag's school of letters* (Inis bheag). At Inis bheag on the Abhainn bheag in the north a teacher of the stag's people begins to teach letters to fishers' children who will never cut coal. It is the first teaching of letters for their own sake. The Hall's roll notes it, and adds that fish do not need reading.
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 1,926** — *Peigi nic Tormoid, clerk of the hall* (Cathair dhearg). Peigi nic Tormoid, of the line of Tormod Scriobhaiche, is clerk of the hall at Cathair dhearg, the first whose own hand can be told from the others in the copies that survive. Her entries are short, and she never gives a reason where a fact will serve. Much of what is known of the middle of the age is in her hand, or copied from it.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 1,999** — *The hawk-keepers of Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell on the northern coast the fowler families keep a hawk in every household and feed it before the household eats. They burn their season's handful at dawn with the hawk on the wrist, for the flame, they say, is a hunger and should be fed as a hunger is fed. They call the hawk Mòd, the Hawk of Acaill, the grey hawk of time, as old as Fionntan mac Bòchra, eldest of men, who lived down the ages as a salmon, an eagle and a hawk; between them the two remember all things. From them Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>65</sup> counts its beginning.
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,072** — *The hawk-rite spreads up the Abhainn ìseal* (Inis ìseal). The dawn burning with the hawk spreads from Seann Skell on the northern shore up the Abhainn ìseal to Inis ìseal and Cnoc bheag. The Keeper at Dùn ìseal writes that the rite keeps the measure exactly and is therefore no concern of the Hall. Never again does the Hall say so of any rite.
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,145** — *The sting-oath at Ros bheag* (Ros bheag). The swearing on a scorpion's sting spreads from Baile àrsaidh up the western coast to Ros bheag, and the harbour court there takes it for every oath of trade. For the rest of the age a merchant who will not swear on the sting is not trusted in the western harbours.
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,217** — *The wolf-stone at Inis thais* (Inis thais). The wolf-sworn road-guards of Caol leathan set a second wolf-stone at the shrine of Inis thais, and the keepers of the shrine begin to pray before it as well as to the drowned. The stone is white quartz, dragged from the mountain on a sledge at a cost greater than the shrine's.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,290** — *The strike-books compared* (Cnoc bhàn). Donnchadh mac Iain, a teacher of the stag's people at Cnoc bhàn, reads through the strike-books of many generations of apprentices. He finds that the coal breaks brighter in its colours for cutters in their later years than in their first, whatever their house, and argues that the vein answers practice. The elders answer that it answers what a cutter was born with, and that practice only shows it.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,300** — *Donnchadh mac Iain leaves Cnoc bhàn* (Muileann chaol). Donnchadh mac Iain and twenty-two of his hearers leave the house at Cnoc bhàn and settle at Muileann chaol, taking copies of the strike-books with them. The elders of Cnoc bhàn call it theft of the books. Donnchadh calls it copying, which it is.

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65. the Hawk order



- 7 **AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,317** — *The founding of the rival druid school.* A school of druids breaks away, holding that the vein answers labour and not birth.
- 9 **AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,330** — *The school at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). The school of Donnchadh mac Iain at Muileann chaol keeps strike-books of its own under a rule the elder school never had: a cutter's parentage is not written in the book at all. The two schools of the stag dispute by letter for the rest of the age, and both keep the letters.
- 4 **AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,366** — *The Hall bears the two schools* (Dùn iséal). The Keeper Raonaid Dhubh hears both schools of the stag at Dùn iséal and gives no ruling, saying that the vein has not asked the Hall to decide. The Hall's roll sets down the hearing and the refusal. No refusal of the Hall is more often cited.
- 6 **AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,376** — *What the people of Cnoc ghorm say of their stone* (Calbh Cnoc ghorm<sup>66</sup>). Scholars of the stag from Muileann chaol come to Calbh Cnoc ghorm and cannot read it. The people of Cnoc ghorm tell them the stone says: we did not come; we were here. The scholars write that the people say so. No later hand explains either the stone or the saying.
- 21 **AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,386** — *The digging at Làrach an Dùin*<sup>67</sup> (Làrach an Dùin). Men of Baile ghorm dig under the fallen walls of Làrach an Dùin for the riches the ruin was said to hold, and find ash and nothing else. The Keeper has them sentenced as if they had broken the Law, though no law covered it, and the sentence stands as the rule for all the old places after.
- 23 **AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,391** — *Baile ghorm's penance* (Baile ghorm). The families of the diggers at Baile ghorm do penance by keeping in repair the road from their town to Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>68</sup>. In the southern hills it is called the diggers' road still.
- 16 **AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,406** — *Lachlann Bàn* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann Bàn takes the red hall at Cathair dhearg. He builds granaries in every province seat that will have one, and makes a law about them, and for these he is remembered.
- 14 **AN GEARRAN, FE 2,411** — *The shared-meal law written* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann Bàn and the Keeper Raonaid Dhubh make the old unwritten custom law at Cathair dhearg: a household with grain above its winter's need gives the surplus to the common granary of its district before the storm season, and the granary feeds any household of the district that runs short. The successors of Peigi nic Tormoid write it into the rolls in full. It is the first law made by rìgh and Keeper together.
- 19 **AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,425** — *The granary of Cnoc mhòr* (Cnoc mhòr). Cnoc mhòr builds its common granary under the new law before any other district, and sends word of it to Cathair dhearg. Lachlann Bàn sends back a silver ring for the reeve.

66. the column at Cnoc ghorm

67. the fortress ruin

- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,435** — *The common granaries of the mountain* (Muileann chiar). Common granaries are raised under the new law in the mountain districts round Muileann chiar, where the households live by cutting and carrying and grow little of their own. The lowland districts grumble at filling them.
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,445** — *The granary at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). A common granary is built within the old wall at Cathair mhòr, the first behind a town wall. The southern fishing towns, having no grain, send dried fish to it for their share.
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,455** — *Raiders in the eastern waters* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Outlaws in boats raid the eastern fishing strands from the islets offshore, taking dried fish and nets. Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>69</sup> arms its boats at Seann Tarr and burns two of the raiders' boats. The rest escape.
- 15 AM MÀRT, FE 2,461** — *Oighrig nic Lachlainn* (Cathair dhearg). Oighrig nic Lachlainn, daughter of Lachlann Bàn, takes the hall at Cathair dhearg. She has no children, and before her reign is half done the houses begin to count their claims.
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,472** — *The late snow on the high passes* (Cnoc ghlas). The weather-watchers on the cairns above Cnoc ghlas see snow lying on the high passes long past the opening of the galleries. The Hall keeps the galleries shut for the cutters' safety, and the mountain households wait.
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,472** — *The poor season in the mountain* (Muileann chiar). The galleries open late and close early, and the coal carried down is a third of a common season's. The mountain households of Muileann gheal, Doire uaine and Àth dhìreach, who trade their carrying for grain, have nothing to trade, and by the season's end they are eating their seed.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,473** — *The first recorded famine averted*. A poor mining season brings three settlements near to starving. The shared-meal law, made in the reign before, holds and saves them. It is the first true trial of the custom.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,473** — *The granaries opened* (Muileann gheal). Under the shared-meal law the common granaries of the mountain districts are opened at Muileann gheal. When they run low the granaries of Dùn dhearg and the southern coast send grain up the carriers' roads without being asked twice, and the carriers bear it for no fee. None in the three settlements is known to die of hunger that winter.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,474** — *Àth dhìreach after the poor season* (Àth dhìreach). At Àth dhìreach, one of the three settlements the granaries fed, the carriers who brought up the grain are given the right to rest in any house of the town without payment for as long as they live. The last of them dies old, and the right with him.

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68. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

69. the house of Raghnaill

- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,474** — *The reeves of Dùn dhearg send the grain* (Dùn dhearg). The reeves of Dùn dhearg, who had withheld their accounts from Cathair dhearg for generations, open the old granaries of the house of Ìomhar to the mountain without waiting for an order. Oighrig nic Lachlainn writes that she would have given the order had they waited. The successor of Peigi nic Tormoid notes that they did not.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,511** — *Death of Oighrig nic Lachlainn* (Cathair dhearg). Oighrig nic Lachlainn dies at Cathair dhearg with no heir of her body, and with her ends the line of Go-raidh Mòr, as the list reckons it. The red hall is shut, and its clerks keep it.
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,513** — *The four houses meet* (Dùn ìseal). The Four Houses of custody meet at Dùn ìseal to choose a ruler, for no custom covers a hall without an heir. Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>70</sup> claims it by blood, Sliochd Thormoid<sup>71</sup> by the clerks, Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>72</sup> by its boats. Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>73</sup>, holding the Keeper's office, makes no claim.
- 12 AM MÀRT, FE 2,516** — *The election of Gilleasbuig Mòr* (Seann Dunn). The houses choose Gilleasbuig Mòr mac Tormoid of Seann Dunn, a grandson of the clerks' line, to hold the red hall. The Keeper sets the stone cup in his hands before the council, and so for the first time a ruler is made at Dùn ìseal. Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>74</sup> consents, on condition that its graves at Dùn dhearg remain the burying-place of the kings.
- 11 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,517** — *Gilleasbuig Mòr at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Gilleasbuig Mòr takes the red hall. He keeps the clerks' office in the hands of his own house and has the king-list copied again from the beginning, with a line drawn beneath Oighrig nic Lachlainn. The line is in every later copy.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,537** — *The shrine at Seann Dunn enlarged* (Seann Dunn). Gilleasbuig Mòr enlarges his house's shrine at Seann Dunn into a temple with a court for pilgrims. The other houses say still that its coal-lamp burns fuller than the measure, and every season a Keeper's cutter is sent to try it.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,541** — *Death of Gilleasbuig Mòr* (Dùn dhearg). Gilleasbuig Mòr dies at Cathair dhearg and is buried among the house of Ìomhar at Dùn dhearg, as was agreed. His son Tormod Òg follows him without a meeting of the houses, and none asks for one.
- 29 AM MÀRT, FE 2,558** — *The gap in the list* (Cathair dhearg). Nine rulers of the house of Tormod reign between Tormod Òg and Anna Ruadh, and the king-list at Cathair dhearg gives their names and years and little else. The successors of Peigi nic Tormoid were diligent and brief; for these reigns the rolls tell mostly of harvests, tolls and the mending of bridges.

70. the house of Ìomhar

71. the house of Tormod

72. the house of Raghnaill

73. the house of Muireach

74. the house of Ìomhar

- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,571** — *The bridge at Cathair dhearg widened* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>75</sup>). The bridge at Cathair dhearg is rebuilt a third time, wide enough now for a cart, for carts have come onto the lowland roads. The hearth-sign is cut again in the keystone. The span stands on the piers of Mòrag nan Rathad.
- 24 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,583** — *Riders on the lowland roads* (Dùn dhearg). The road-guards of Dùn dhearg begin to ride the lowland roads on the small horses of the southern grass country, and a guard can now reach a waypoint house before a quarrel there has cooled. They are the first riders whose names are kept, and for long the only ones.
- 23 AN T-IÚCHAR, FE 2,598** — *The crossing at Ros fhionn repaired* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). A flood takes the eastern approach of Ailean Clachair's span above Ros fhionn, and it is mended. The masons find their founder's hearth-sign still sharp in the keystone, and leave it untouched.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,613** — *The bridge at Dùn chrom* (Dùn chrom). The masons' fellowship bridges the river below Dùn chrom, joining the southern road to the western without the long way round by Cathair dhearg. The toll is set at half the road-toll, and Cathair dhearg complains.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,628** — *The bridge at Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). A bridge is built at the river town of Ceann àrsaidh, the fourth stone crossing of the lowlands. The masons' roll names the forty who built it, all of the fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>76</sup>, who had learned the craft while the boats lay idle.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,643** — *The bridge at Doire mhin* (Doire mhin). The masons' fellowship builds a small bridge at Doire mhin to carry the southern road over a stream that floods each spring. Beside the hearth-sign in the keystone is cut the name of Beathag Clachair, who cut it: the first mason's mark known.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,658** — *The far-off house* (An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>77</sup>). The waypoint house on the site of An Sligeanach Fad' às, the oldest house under the road-peace, is rebuilt in stone. It lies so far from any town that the carriers say one is never nearer to it than halfway, and from the saying it takes its name.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,672** — *Fire-water on the northern road* (An Leòmhann Buidhe<sup>78</sup>). The house on the northern road, on the site of An Leòmhann Buidhe, begins to serve a spirit distilled from barley that the carriers call fire-water. The Keepers rule that it is not a burning and no concern of theirs. The house's trade doubles.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,687** — *Caol mhòr in the north-west* (Caol mhòr). The fisher-families of the north-west gather at Caol mhòr under a headman of their own, and send tolls to Cathair dhearg only in the years the road-guard comes to take them. Little is written of the north-west in this age, and most of it is complaint of that.

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75. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

76. the house of Raghnaill

77. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

78. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,702** — *Seal-oil from Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). Ceann mhòr on the north-west coast begins to trade seal-oil down the western coast to Ros bheag for silver rings, and its beacons burn it. For many generations the seal-oil lamps of the western harbours are the brightest light on Dia-thìr.
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,717** — *The high pastures of Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). Herding families take the high pastures above Muileann leathan in the north and keep sheep there for the wool of Inis mhòr. They hold no right to the handful, have never held one, and are not counted in the census of hands.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,732** — *Inis mhin on the northern shore* (Inis mhin). Inis mhin, a fishing harbour on the northern shore, comes into the rolls for the first time when its headman goes to the wool-fair of Inis mhòr to complain of the road-guard's toll. The complaint is written down in full, and it is all that is written of the town in this age.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,747** — *The raid on the western strands* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Raiders from the north-western waters take a season's dried fish from the strands of the north-western coast. The sting-sworn merchants of Ros bheag pay for two armed boats to watch the strands, and the raiders move north.
- 29 AM MÀRT, FE 2,761** — *The second sighting* (Uilebheist na Mara<sup>79</sup>). Two boats of Baile chrom tell of something vast moving beneath them in the north-western water, the second such sighting remembered. One boat does not come home. The wake that Baile chrom keeps for the first loss is kept now for both.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,776** — *Round the islands* (Seann Tarr). Boats of Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>80</sup> sail from Seann Tarr round the offshore islands, Eilean ruadh, Eilean dhearg and Eilean fhada among them, and come home in one season. No crew of the age goes further from the coast than the islands, and none is known to have wished to.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,791** — *Summer herders on Eilean ruadh* (Eilean ruadh). Families from the coast take sheep over to Eilean ruadh for the summer grazing and bring them back before the storms. They build turf shelters there, which later herders use again.
- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,806** — *Anna Ruadh* (Cathair dhearg). Anna Ruadh of the house of Tormod takes the red hall at Cathair dhearg. She walks the whole circuit of the roads, the first ruler to do so since Mòrag nan Rathad, and she walks it twice.
- 23 AN T-IÚCHAR, FE 2,809** — *Anna Ruadh at Am Buabhall Fortanach* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). On her first circuit Anna Ruadh stops at the house on the site of Am Buabhall Fortanach, where the War of the Roads was ended, and eats the jugged buffalo like a carrier. The keepers of the house tell of it still.

79. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

80. the house of Raghnaill

**21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,813** — *Anna Ruadh at the sunny house* (An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>81</sup>).

On the eastern road Anna Ruadh lodges at the house on the site of An Taigh-òsta Grianach and grants its keepers a toll of their own for the upkeep of the road to Cnoc leathan, Slighe Cnoc leathan. No other waypoint house on the island holds a royal charter.

**12 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,816** — *Anna Ruadh at Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). At Ceann

min on the south-eastern coast Anna Ruadh hears the quarrel of the fishers and the carriers over who may carry dried fish up to the mountain, and rules that both may. The fish going inland is doubled, and its price at Dùn ìseal halved.

**11 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,819** — *The contest at Ceann leathan in stone* (Ceann leathan). Anna

Ruadh gives the road-guard's contest at Ceann leathan a stone-walled field, and for its prize a silver ring from the red hall. Fighters come to it from all the south, and the losers are fed at the crown's cost.

**23 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,822** — *A wood-watcher in the red hall* (Cathair dhearg). Anna Ru-

adh keeps a wood-watcher from Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>82</sup> in her household at Cathair dhearg to read the omens of the hall. So the rite of the wood-watchers, the rite of Macha, goddess of sovereignty and of horses, first comes to the capital. The Keeper sends a protest from Dùn ìseal, and the rolls give no answer.

**24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,826** — *Cathair dhombhain and the wood-watchers* (Cathair dhom-

hain). The shrine at Cathair dhomhain, proud of its strict keeping of the Law, will take no wood-watcher, and its people say that the capital has given its omens to folk who sit in trees. From this the rivalry of the two towns takes a turn in matters of faith that it never loses.

**26 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,829** — *Death of Anna Ruadh* (Cathair dhearg). Anna Ruadh dies at

Cathair dhearg and is buried at Dùn dhearg among the house of Ìomhar and the kings of her own house. Her son Coinneach Bàn takes the hall.

**27 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,832** — *Coinneach Bàn* (Cathair dhearg). Coinneach Bàn rules long

and quietly from Cathair dhearg. In his reign the clerks of the hall begin to copy the rolls for the provinces, so that each province seat has its own copy of the laws. Several of those copies survive where the first writings are lost.

**16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,835** — *Seumas Bàn keeps the flame* (Dùn ìseal). Seumas Bàn of

Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>83</sup> is chosen Keeper. Reading the Hall's roll at Dùn ìseal he finds that more than half the Keepers of the age were of his own house, and has the fact struck from the preface. The unstruck copy survives.

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81. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

82. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

83. the house of Muireach

- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,838** — *The rites counted at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Seumas Bàn has the clerks of the Hall list every rite on the island that burns the handful and every one that lays claim to the vein, that the council may know what it keeps. The list holds the Hall's own rite, the ancestor-keeping of the old folk, the dawn-hawk of the north coast, the wood-watchers of the west, the wolf-sworn, the sting-oath, and both schools of the stag. The clerks write that a thousand years before no such list would have been needed.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,840** — *The hawk-keepers refuse the Hall's cutter* (Seann Skell). The hawk-keepers of Seann Skell turn away the Hall's cutter who comes to try their measure, saying their measure is the hawk's, and the hawk is not the Keeper's. The cutter goes home with the refusal in writing. No rite had refused the trial of the measure outright before.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,843** — *The wolf-sworn build a hall* (Caol leathan). The wolf-sworn of Caol leathan build a hall of their own about the white wolf-stone at the town gate, and swear oaths there that are no longer road-guards' oaths. The stone, they say, watches the whole island as the guard watches the road, and will cry out beneath the rightful king. From this hall comes Òrd na Cloiche<sup>84</sup>, the order of the Stone, and the wolf-sworn begin to be called the Fianna.
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,846** — *The sting-oath at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell in the west the sting-oath of the harbour court becomes a creed. Its keepers hold that one power stings the liar wherever he may be, Manannan mac Lir, lord of the sea, and that the scorpion is but his sign; theirs is the first teaching on the island to call itself the only true one, and the Hall's roll sets it down as new. Thereafter the oath is sworn over a cup marked with the scorpion, Manannan's Cup of Truth, which is said to break in three at three lies spoken over it and to be made whole by three truths. Òrd Mhanannain<sup>85</sup> dates itself from this court.
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,849** — *Seann Vell swears on the sting* (Seann Vell). Seann Vell, on the western coast below Cuan shean, takes up the sting-oath of its neighbours. Its shrine keeps a scorpion carved in yellow stone, the first image of the creature made for worship and not for swearing on.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,852** — *The dark wood keeps its own rite* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>86</sup>). The wood-watchers of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag cease to send to the Hall for judgement of their quarrels, and judge them under the trees. They hold that the black beast has two natures, one that keeps and one that devours, and that the vein has the same. The order of Macha afterwards tells of the two horses that drew one chariot, the black Dubh Sainglenn and the grey Liath Macha: two horses, one yoke.

84. the order of the Stone

85. the order of Manannan

86. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

- 11 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,855** — *The common root of the orders*. The one folk-faith of the island begins plainly to divide into the several ways that later ages name apart: the orders of An Creideamh Sean<sup>87</sup>, the Old Faith, and the hearth-keeping of Na Seann Spioradan<sup>88</sup>, the Old Spirits. From this time the belief of the Dia-thìrich is no longer one.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,858** — *The council divided by rite* (Dùn ìseal). The council at Dùn ìseal, which had sat by hearth and by house, begins to sit in companies by rite. Seumas Bàn complains that he keeps the flame now for eight peoples, each of whom thinks itself its only keeper. The seating holds for the rest of the age.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, FE 2,860** — *Allt an Àigh<sup>89</sup> keeps its pilgrims* (Allt an Àigh). Pilgrims of every rite go on walking to Allt an Àigh in the right quarter of the moon; it is the one custom of the island that the Hall's list sets under no company. In one season the path from Caol shean is paved anew by pilgrims of four rites.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,863** — *The springs at Muileann ruadh common to all* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>90</sup>). The keeper of the springs at Muileann ruadh rules that the sick of every rite shall be bathed without asking which. Her ruling is copied into the rolls of the provinces. It is the last ruling of the age on which every company of the council agrees.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,866** — *Cnoc dhìreach's weavers* (Cnoc dhìreach). The town of Cnoc dhìreach in the east, on the carriers' road south of the springs, becomes known for a heavy undyed cloth that the carriers wear on the high passes. It is not the grave-keepers' village by the old tombs, and the rolls tell the two Cnoc dhìreachs apart by that cloth.
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,869** — *The dyers of Muileann bhàn* (Muileann bhàn). The dyers of Muileann bhàn in the eastern hills learn to fix a pale blue from a hill plant, and the carriers' cloth of all the mountain country is dyed there. The Keepers wear it undyed, and say so.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,872** — *Muileann dhombhain's mill* (Muileann dhomhain). A water-mill is built at Muileann dhomhain in the eastern hills to grind the grain of the common granaries of the mountain districts. The miller keeps one measure in sixteen, and the rolls call it fair.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,875** — *The flood at Àth chiar* (Àth chiar). Rain on the eastern hills brings the river over the ford at Àth chiar, and it carries off the carriers' shelter and six of the townfolk. The common granary of the district stands on a rise, is untouched, and feeds the town through the winter.
- 24 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,878** — *The oyster-beds of Seann Bhrál* (Seann Bhrál). The people of Seann Bhrál on the south-eastern coast begin to lay oyster-beds in the shallows, a craft that came, they say, with the name of their town. The Library's copy of the provincial roll sets down the claim and marks it doubtful.

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87. the Old Faith

88. the Old Spirits

89. the stream of the healing water

90. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh



- 20 AN GEARRAN, FE 2,880** — *Seann Vell's harbour* (Seann Vell). Seann Vell on the south-eastern coast grows into a city on the southern fishing and the silver of Muileann chiar brought down the eastern road. Its harbour is the first on the island with a stone quay.
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, FE 2,883** — *The light at Tobar dhearg rebuilt* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>91</sup>). The old beacon at Tobar dhearg on the southern cape is rebuilt as a stone tower with the fire on its top, the first sea-light raised above the ground. It burns seal-oil of the north-west, carried the whole length of the island.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,886** — *Muileann naomb's mill-shrine* (Muileann naomh). At Muileann naomh on the southern coast a mill and a shrine share one roof, and the miller keeps the shrine's handful beside his millstones. The Keeper's cutter who comes to try it finds the measure kept and the flour good.
- 21 AM MÀRT, FE 2,889** — *Dùn thais walled* (Dùn thais). Dùn thais in the eastern hills is walled, and a temple of the stag's people is raised within it, the first of theirs built in stone and not kept in a grove. The elder school at Cnoc bhàn sends it teachers.
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,892** — *The wool-fair of Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). Inis mhòr holds a wool-fair at every shearing, and buyers come to it from all the northern coast and some from Cathair dhearg. Its silver is weighed on the Muileann chiar weights sent to the northern road.
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,895** — *Baile Mòr mhòr on the northern coast* (Baile Mòr mhòr). Baile Mòr mhòr, on the northern coast west of Seann Toll, grows great enough on the fishing to send its own member to the council at Dùn ìseal. The Four Houses dislike it, and seat its member at the foot of the hall.
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,898** — *The northern boats at Seann Toll* (Seann Toll). The harbour at Seann Toll becomes the home of the northern fishing fleet. Its boatbuilders make the longest craft on the island, built for a day's run along the coast and never for open water.
- 15 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,900** — *Drought at Achadh shean* (Achadh shean). A dry summer burns the pastures round Achadh shean in the east, and by spring the district's common granary is empty. Grain is sent from Baile chaol and Cuan ruadh under the shared-meal law, and the district repays it over the harvests after.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,903** — *Baile chaol's repayment* (Baile chaol). The rolls at Baile chaol set down the repayment of the drought grain by Achadh shean, measure by measure, to the last. The clerk adds that no such debt in the rolls was repaid in full before.
- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,906** — *The panthers late* (Imrich nam Pantar<sup>92</sup>). The great cats cross the southern road late, and fewer than the carriers remember. The weather-watchers read it for a hard winter, and are right. The Keepers note it without remark.

91. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

92. the panthers' crossing

- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, FE 2,909** — *The watch-tower at Baile ruadh* (Baile ruadh). A timber watch-tower is raised at Baile ruadh on the north-eastern coast to look out for raiders from the islands, manned by turns by the fisher-kin of Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>93</sup>. It is the only tower of war the age builds.
- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, FE 2,912** — *Cuan ruadh's boats* (Cuan ruadh). The fishers of Cuan ruadh on the eastern coast give boats and men to the watch against the island raiders. In return Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>94</sup> gives the town a place on the council at Dùn ìseal beside its own seat.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, FE 2,915** — *The drowned-feast at Inis chrom* (Inis chrom). At Inis chrom on the western coast the families of the drowned hold a feast on the shore each year and set an empty place for each of the lost. The custom spreads to the harbours northward as far as Seann Warr.
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, FE 2,918** — *The potters of Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). Potters at Baile ghorm on the south-western coast begin to fire a hard red ware of the local clay, and their jars carry the oil and grain of the western road. Sherds of it lie on every waypoint-house site the Library's surveyors have walked.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,920** — *Cnoc àrsaidh's kilns* (Cnoc àrsaidh). Potters of Baile ghorm set up new kilns at Cnoc àrsaidh in the south-west, where the clay is better and the wood nearer. There the red ware of the western road is made for the rest of the age.
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,923** — *Cathair fhada grows* (Cathair fhada). Families leaving the crowded harbours about Cathair dhearg settle at Cathair fhada on the southern coast and raise its long street along the ridge. They bring a wood-watcher with them, and a copy of the laws.
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, FE 2,926** — *Cnoc naomh's ancestor-shrine* (Cnoc naomh). The people of Cnoc naomh keep a shrine to the ancestors and to the sìth of the hill in the old folk way, with no hawk, wolf, sting or stag in it. The Hall's list of rites names them among the keepers of the old reverence, which by now is a company of its own.
- 15 AN T-IUCHAR, FE 2,929** — *Mòr nic Coinnich crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Mòr nic Coinnich, granddaughter of Coinneach Bàn, takes the red hall at Cathair dhearg. The Keeper Catriona nic Mhuirich sets the stone cup in her hands at Dùn ìseal, as the houses had done for Gilleasbuig Mòr. Hers is the last name written in the king-list of the Holy Age.
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, FE 2,939** — *The Hall's roll at the close of the age* (Dùn ìseal). At the close of the age the Keepers' roll holds one hundred and forty names, from Beathag Bhàn to Catriona nic Mhuirich, and the king-list more than ninety, from Goraidh Mòr to Mòr nic Coinnich. The Small-Burning Law is unchanged in any word since the stone cup of Fionnlagh Dall, and the cup stands yet on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach<sup>95</sup> at Dùn ìseal.

93. the house of Raghnaill

94. the house of Raghnaill

**I AN CÈITEAN, FE 2,949** — *The last age of even population.* So ends the Holy Age. The long years had gone out of the king's kin many generations before its end, and the chroniclers of after days look back on its later centuries with some unease: they are the last time in the history of Dia-thìr that no family's lives ran longer than any other's.

## AGE IV · AN AOIS SCARAI DH

*The Age of Sundering · the Landfall Era, LE 1 – 1,819*

- 6 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1** — *Land is found.* Word comes of a land across the open water, where no people like the Dia-thìrich dwell. Who first found it is not told.
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1** — *The tidings at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). Three crews from the western harbours bring word of the far land to the hall of Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill, daughter of Mòr nic Coinnich, at Cathair dhearg. None claims to have been first. The queen's scribe takes down all three tellings; they agree on the coast and on nothing else.
- 8 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1** — *The Choosing.* A vote, or what the later chroniclers call a vote, settles who will go. Only the willing go; no lots are drawn and none are pressed.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 2** — *The roll of the willing* (Seann Skell). The harbour scribes of Seann Skell open a roll of those who mean to go, written by household and not by name, on boards in the harbour-house. A later hand notes that names were struck out as often as they were added.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 2** — *The queen neither commands nor forbids* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag declares that the crown will send no one across the water and keep no one back. Within the season her younger sister, Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, enters her own household on the roll at Seann Skell.
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 3** — *The custodians count the cost* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house above Muileann dhearg, keeper of Crom's stone and heir to the Keepers' Hall at Dùn iséal where Bride's flame was first bound, counts the households of the coal-right that have entered the roll. The custody-book makes it nearly one in five, and says the count was made twice, for the first figure was not believed.
- 16 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 5** — *The ships are built.* The shipwrights of the island, used to small coasting craft, build ships to keep the open sea, the first in the memory of Dia-thìr.
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 5** — *Alasdair Saor lays the first keel* (Seann Skell). On the river strand below Seann Skell the shipwright Alasdair mac Iain, called Alasdair Saor, lays down the first deep-keeled hull built on Dia-thìr. Until then the island's boats were sewn-plank coasters that never lay a night out of sight of land.
- 26 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 5** — *The oaks of Doire fhionn* (Doire fhionn). The oak grove that named Doire fhionn is felled for the keels of the fleet and drawn to the coast on ox-sleds. It never grew again, and the village kept a name it had no more cause for.
- 24 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 5** — *The shipwrights' fellowship* (Seann Skell). Alasdair Saor gathers the wrights of the Seann Skell strand into one fellowship, and binds each apprentice for seven years after the manner of the vein custodians. The custody-book names it Comann nan Saor-luinge<sup>1</sup>, the fellowship of the ship-wrights.

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1. the shipwrights' fellowship

- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 6** — *The trial bull lost off Ros àrsaidh* (Inis àrsaidh). The first finished hull is taken down the Abhainn naomh and out past Ros àrsaidh, where the ships of Inis àrsaidh put to sea, for trial in open water. It founders in a following sea and eleven are drowned. Alasdair Saor alters the setting of the keel, and every later hull of the fleet is built to the new pattern.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 8** — *The rope-walks of Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). Cuan shean lays out long rope-walks along its harbour front and gives all its hemp fields to cordage for the fleet. Its rope trade lasts some centuries beyond the Sundering.
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 9** — *The sail-cloth levy* (Baile àrsaidh). Every weaving household in Si-orrachd Baile àrsaidh owes a set length of close-woven sail-cloth, scored on tally-sticks at the shire seat. The tallies survive; how many paid is not known.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, LE 13** — *The star-lore of Cuan ruadh* (Cuan ruadh). The old steersmen of Cuan ruadh on the eastern coast, the only sailors of the island who had ever held a course by night, teach the pilots of the fleet to steer by the stars. Their lore was written down only in part, and that part is lost.
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, LE 18** — *The willing choose their leaders* (Seann Skell). The households of the roll meet at Seann Skell and choose Mòrag nic Dhòmhnaill, the queen's sister, and Fearchar mac Ruairidh, a custodian of the vein, to lead them. The custody-book records the choice; how it was made is not told.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 25** — *The handful for the new hearth* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house rules that each departing ship may carry one sealed measure of the coal, no more than a single household may burn in a season under the Small-Burning Law. It is the only writing in the custody-book addressed to those who were leaving.
- 16 AN T-IÚCHAR, LE 30** — *The west quay lengthened* (Seann Skell). Masons from the capital lengthen the west quay at Seann Skell with dressed stone, so that the deep hulls may lie alongside at low water. On these stones the later rite was held.
- 20 AN GEARRAN, LE 38** — *The strife over the grain*. Strife over how much of the island's stored grain the ships may take all but ends the venture. Within a season it is settled; how is not recorded.
- 21 AM MÀRT, LE 38** — *Àth shean shuts its granaries* (Àth shean). In the strife over the fleet's grain Tormod mac Coinnich, reeve of the granaries at Àth shean, bars the store-houses and sets a watch on them until the matter is settled. He holds no office afterward.
- 3 AN GIBLEAN, LE 38** — *Grain down Abhainn dhombhain* (Abhainn dhomhain). The strife settled, grain barges go down Abhainn dhomhain to the capital, on by the coast to Ros àrsaidh, and up the Abhainn naomh to Seann Skell. A tally-keeper at Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>2</sup> counts forty-one barges passing.

2. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

- 2 AN CÈITEAN, LE 38** — *The fleet assembled* (Seann Skell). The fleet lies complete at Seann Skell. The custody-book gives nineteen hulls; a later hand in the margin makes it twenty-one. Which is right has never been settled.
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *The night of lamps* (Seann Skell). On the last night before the sailing every house on the Seann Skell waterfront sets a lamp on its sill and keeps it burning till morning. It is the first custom of the Sundering written down as a custom, and the town kept it long after its cause had become a tale.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *The Setting-Out*. The willing sail out past the north cape. The chronicles of the island fall silent on them as the ships clear the harbour; the Dia-thìrich tell that the fleet sailed into Manannan's mist, toward the Otherworld.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 40** — *The sunwise turn* (Seann Skell). Before going down the Abhainn naomh to the open sea the fleet goes once round the river pool of Seann Skell sunwise, diosal, for luck, and the watchers on the quay count the hulls as they pass. The harbour scribe's account ends at the foot of the pool.
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 44** — *The years counted from the turn* (Muileann dhearg). Donnchadh mac Thormoid, scribe of the vein-house, begins to number the years from the sunwise turn at Seann Skell, and calls them the years of the Diosal. The count is his; the crown's scribes take it up a generation later.
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 44** — *Tidings reach Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Tidings of the fleet reach Seann Skell, by what road or whose mouth is not told. The harbour scribe copies them in a shaking hand; the copy came down to later keepers water-stained and lacking its end.
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 44** — *Two landfalls*. Such broken tidings as come back tell of two coasts reached, not one. In this telling lies the seed of the two peoples that came after.
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 46** — *Mòrag's line struck* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag strikes her sister Mòrag and Mòrag's children from the succession, as no longer on Dia-thìr. The act stands without comment between a grain ruling and the mending of a bridge.
- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 53** — *The thinning*. Cut off from the vein, the strength the crossing asked of them fades in the children of those who went. By the third generation over the water nothing is left that Dia-thìr would know.
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 53** — *The custodians' second count* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house counts again the households of the coal-right and sets the loss at one hand in five. Beside it Donnchadh mac Thormoid writes that the vein answers no differently for those who stayed.
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 54** — *The Mourning Custom*. Dia-thìr sets in order a rite of mourning for the departed, neither wholly grief nor wholly feast. In a far later age it was used again, uneasily, for a very different leaving.

- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 54** — *The white sorrow first kept at court* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag mourns her sister in undyed wool, with one place left empty at a meal that is neither feast nor fast. The court calls it an Tùrsa Geal<sup>3</sup>, the white sorrow, and within a generation it is kept in every harbour town of the island.
- 7 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 55** — *The custodians fewer*. With part of the coal-bound folk gone, the Dia-thìrich order themselves anew about a smaller and closer class of custodians. From this shape every later nobility descends.
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 55** — *The seven houses of custody* (Muileann dhearg). The custodian households that remain are gathered into seven houses, each answerable to the vein-house for its share of the coal and of the measured burning: Clann Mhuirich, Clann Fhearchair, Clann Ìomhair, Clann Raghnaill, Clann Thormoid, Clann Choinnich and Clann Lachlainn. Here for the first time the right to the coal passes by house and not by apprenticeship.
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 55** — *Death of Queen Beathag* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill dies at Cathair dhearg, the last ruler of Dia-thìr who saw the fleet. Her son Raghnaill mac Uilleim is crowned in the same hall.
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 61** — *The rite of the empty harbour*. A rite grows up about the quay the ships sailed from. It is still kept, lessened, on a day that none can now date truly.
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 64** — *The harbour at half trade* (Seann Skell). The harbour-master of Seann Skell finds his berths at half their old use, for the fishing households that crewed the fleet are gone. The rope-walks of Cuan shean turn off hands for the first time.
- 8 AN GEARRAN, LE 65** — *The second silence*. There is a rumour of a second, smaller crossing, with fewer ships and no word of where they went. Nothing that survives confirms or denies it.
- 5 AM MÀRT, LE 67** — *The watch at Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). The fishing families of Ceann mhòr on the north-west coast keep a watch from the headland for returning sails, household by household in turn. The watch lapses within a generation. No sail is seen.
- 13 AM MÀRT, LE 67** — *The west quay renamed*. The quay the ships sailed from is given a new name, so that common trade might go on under the old one without the memory. It is an early and quiet forgetting, made on purpose.
- 15 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 67** — *Cidhe an Diosail*<sup>4</sup> (Seann Skell). The departure berth is entered in the harbour rolls of Seann Skell as Cidhe an Diosail, the quay of the sunwise turn. The name Cidhe an Iar passes to the new fish-wharf at the north end of the strand, and within a few years the fishers use it without a thought.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 67** — *Roghnaich takes its narrow sense*. In the custody-book the verb roghnaich, to choose, begins to stand with no object, meaning to have chosen the crossing. The scribes of the next century use it so without explaining it, the surest sign that it had passed into common speech.

3. the Mourning Custom; lit. 'the white sorrow'

4. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 67** — *The first generation that never saw the fleet.* Children born soon after the Setting-Out grow up never having seen the harbour with those ships in it. To them the leaving is already history.
- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 67** — *Death of Alasdair Saor* (Seann Skell). Alasdair Saor, who laid the first deep keel, dies at Seann Skell. His last work was a coasting trader of the old sewn-plank kind, built for a fish merchant of Inis àrsaidh.
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 84** — *The shipwrights' fellowship ends.* No more sea-going ships being wanted, the fellowship that built the fleet of the Sundering quietly breaks up. Its craft is half forgotten by the time anyone needs it again.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, LE 85** — *The keel-moulds burned* (Seann Skell). In a hard season the patterns and moulds of the broken fellowship, kept in a shed on the strand at Seann Skell, are burned for firewood. The harbour-master notes the loss of the shed and not of what was in it.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, LE 109** — *The mountain divided among the houses* (Muileann dhearg). The seven houses draw lots at the vein-house for the galleries each will keep, and the vein-house confirms each its Small-Burning measure. The lot-stones were kept in a bag at Muileann dhearg and shown to visitors for centuries after.
- 14 AN T-IÚCHAR, LE 109** — *The coppice law of Doire fhionn* (Doire fhionn). The great oaks gone to the fleet, the shire of Doire fhionn forbids the felling of any living oak without the reeve's mark and begins to cut its woods by coppice. The law spreads to every shire with a Doire in its name.
- 12 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 109** — *The lamps kept at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The waterfront of Seann Skell keeps the night of lamps each year on the eve of the rite of the empty harbour. The children are told the lamps are for ships coming home, and the priests do not gainsay it.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 109** — *Death of Donnchadh mac Thormoid* (Muileann dhearg). Donnchadh mac Thormoid, the vein-house scribe who began the count of years, dies at Muileann dhearg. His last entry is the season's burning of coal, household by household, in the same hand as his first.
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 125** — *Raghnall dies; Ìomhar crowned* (Cathair dhearg). King Raghnall mac Uilleim dies at Cathair dhearg after a long and quiet reign, and his son Ìomhar mac Raghnall is crowned. The custody-book gives Raghnall's reign a single line.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 149** — *The silversmiths of Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Silver of the seam at Muileann chiar, mined since the Holy Age, is wrought into neck-rings for the heads of the seven houses. The smiths' fellowship of the seam, heirs of Sliochd Fhearchair, keeps its craft within four families.
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 154** — *Inis mhòr's grain fleet* (Inis mhòr). Inis mhòr in the north builds barges to carry grain down the Abhainn ghorm to Caol bheag, and from Ros chiar at the river mouth west along the coast to Cnoc bheag. They are sewn-plank boats of the old kind, and none lies a night out of sight of land.



- 2 AN GEARRAN, LE 156** — *The coughing sickness at Caol fhiadhaich* (Caol fhiadhaich). A coughing sickness runs through Caol fhiadhaich on the south-west coast and kills some two hundred before it burns out. The shared meal is kept throughout, and the reeve holds that it saved the rest.
- 3 AM MÀRT, LE 164** — *Am Buabhall Fortanach rebuilt in stone* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). The old road-house of Am Buabhall Fortanach burns to its footings, and its keeper, Eilidh nic Chaluim, rebuilds it in stone. It is already known for its jugged buffalo.
- 7 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 179** — *The spirit-house at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). The keepers of the Old Spirits, the faith of the hearths, raise a house for the ancestors at Dùn ìseal, and cut the names of the dead of the eastern shires on wooden posts. The posts are cut anew each generation as the old ones rot.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, LE 180** — *Ìomhar dies without an heir* (Cathair dhearg). King Ìomhar mac Raghnaill dies at Cathair dhearg with no living child, and with him ends the line of Beathag. The heads of the seven houses are summoned to the capital to name a king.
- 19 AN GEARRAN, LE 182** — *Fearchar mac Lachlainn chosen* (Cathair dhearg). The heads of the houses choose Fearchar mac Lachlainn of Baile Mòr dhomhain, of Clann Fhearchair, and he is crowned at Cathair dhearg. He is the first king made by the seven houses and not by descent.
- 20 AM MÀRT, LE 194** — *A court at Baile Mòr dhombhain* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). King Fearchar keeps his court part of each year at Baile Mòr dhomhain, near the mountain, that he may take counsel of the vein-house without a journey. The double court lasts as long as his house.
- 21 AN GEARRAN, LE 209** — *The fishers of Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). After a season of losses the fishing families of Àth fhiadhaich join in one fellowship to share boats and nets. It is the first fishers' fellowship on the east coast.
- 21 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 211** — *Fearchar Donn crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Fearchar mac Lachlainn dies, and his son, called Fearchar Donn, is crowned at Cathair dhearg without dispute.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, LE 229** — *Gormshuil of the Hawk* (Cnoc bheag). At Cnoc bheag, where the dawn-hawk rite of the Holy Age is still kept, the priestess Gormshuil nic Artair teaches that the hawk of the rite is Mòd, the Hawk of Acaill, as old as Fionntan mac Bòchra, eldest of men, and remembering all things with him. The vein, she teaches, is the Hungry Hawk, to be fed the measured handful and no more, for a hawk overfed will not hunt and a hawk starved will turn on the hand. Her followers gather the old rite into the first house of Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>5</sup>, the order of the Hawk of Acaill.
- 22 AM MÀRT, LE 239** — *The hawk-house at Ros gheal* (Ros gheal). Gormshuil's pupils found a second house of the Hawk at Ros gheal. Its priests take charge of the measured burning for all the country between Ros gheal on the coast and Cnoc bheag up the river.

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5. the Hawk order

- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 244** — *Flood at Seann Vell* (Seann Vell). In a wet spring the river at Seann Vell on the south-east coast breaks its banks and carries away the lower mills. The mill-wrights build them again on the higher bank.
- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 251** — *The sayings of Gormshuil written* (Cnoc bheag). After Gormshuil's death her sayings are written at Cnoc bheag as Leabhar an t-Seabhaig<sup>6</sup>, the Book of the Hawk. The copyist, Ùisdean mac Pàdraig, marks every saying he did not hear from her own mouth, and these are the greater part.
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 259** — *The storm that took Seann Toll's boats* (Seann Toll). A northern storm, named Am Fuath Mòr<sup>7</sup> in the harbour rolls, breaks the harbour wall of Seann Toll and sinks forty boats at their moorings. Eighteen fishers drown.
- 16 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 261** — *Seann Toll walls its harbour again* (Seann Toll). Seann Toll builds its harbour wall again, higher and with a hooked end, to a plan the reeve had from the masons of the capital. The wall stands through every storm of this age.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 261** — *The walls of Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Clann Ìomhair, who hold the land about Dùn dhearg in the eastern hills, wall it in stone. These are the first walls on the island raised by a custodian house and not by the crown.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 261** — *Queen Sileas's measures* (Cathair dhearg). Sileas nic Fhearchair, crowned after her father Fearchar Donn, fixes one measure for grain across the island, the firiot of Cathair dhearg, so that barter between shires need not begin with a quarrel over the size of a basket. Firlots of oak bound with iron are sent to every shire seat.
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 284** — *Tally-houses in the royal granaries* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Sileas sets a tally-house in each royal granary, where every exchange of grain for cloth, salt or labour is cut on paired sticks, one for each party. It is the first reckoning of trade across the whole island, and it runs without coin.
- 17 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 287** — *The market charter of Cathair fhada* (Cathair fhada). Queen Sileas grants Cathair fhada a market on its ridge at every full moon, with a tally-house for the south; it is the first market right cut on paired sticks. The merchants of the long city carry the honey, hemp, wax and pots of the south to the capital, and begin to go as one company to the harvest fair at Muileann òg.
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 289** — *Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>8</sup> widened* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg). The old stone bridge over Abhainn dhomhain at Cathair dhearg is widened for two carts to pass. Queen Sileas's name is cut on the downstream parapet, and may still be read there.
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 304** — *The crossing days of the panthers* (Imrich nam Pantar<sup>9</sup>). In the southern hills near Imrich nam Pantar the herders keep the panther roads clear on the days the great cats cross, and drive their flocks off the paths beforehand. The crossing days are the first thing the southern shires agree on in writing.

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6. the Book of the Hawk

7. the great hate, the storm that drowned Seann Toll's boats

8. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

9. the panthers' crossing

- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 304** — *An Leòmhann Buidhe*<sup>10</sup> on the north road (An Leòmhann Buidhe). An Leòmhann Buidhe, a road-house on the northern mining road, serves the coal-carters oatcakes fried in linseed oil, and fire water. Its keeper is fined for watering the fire water.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, LE 314** — *The house of disputation at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn, a druid of the schools of Flidais, lady of the deer, founds a house of disputation at Dùn thais, where the old question of the schools, Carson an làmh seo?, why the vein answers some hands and not others, is argued by rule. Pupils come from as far as Caol bheag.
- 1 AN GIBLEAN, LE 324** — *Coinneach's question* (Dùn thais). In open disputation Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn asks whether the hands that went with the fleet were those the vein answered best, and whether it now answers fewer. The seven houses forbid the question at their own tables; it is the first time they forbid a question and not a deed.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, LE 324** — *Baile Mòr mhòr grows* (Baile Mòr mhòr). After a run of poor seasons Baile Mòr mhòr on the northern plain takes in families from the upland farms and doubles within a generation. Its reeve divides the common grazing anew.
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 324** — *Death of Queen Sileas* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Sileas nic Fhearchair dies at Cathair dhearg after a reign of more than fifty years. Her son Uisdean mac Dhùghaill is crowned.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, LE 344** — *The deep hull that would not float true* (Inis àrsaidh). A merchant of Inis àrsaidh has a deep-keeled hull built for the long coast run eastward. The wrights no longer remember how Alasdair Saor scarfed his keels; the hull lists so badly at launch that it is broken up for timber.
- 3 AM MÀRT, LE 354** — *Salt pans at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). The river town of Ros fhionn in the north-east lays out salt pans at the brine springs on its river flats and sends salt inland over Drochaid Ros fhionn. Within a generation Ros fhionn salt is the common measure of worth in the north-eastern shires.
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 361** — *The wool of Baile gharbh* (Baile gharbh). The weavers of Baile gharbh make a heavy undyed cloth that sheds rain, and it becomes the common cloak of the north-east. In this cloth the white sorrow is kept.
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 369** — *Salt over Drochaid Ros fhionn* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). So many salt carts cross Drochaid Ros fhionn that the bridge-keeper is granted a handful from each load. His salt-box is said to hold more than some villages' granaries.
- 27 AN CÈITEAN, LE 379** — *The wells crack at Cill ghlas* (Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>11</sup>). An earth tremor in the hills about Cill ghlas cracks three wells and brings down a byre. The custodians of the vein-house note it, and note that the galleries were untouched.

10. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

- 26 AN GIBLEAN, LE 394** — *The Hollow Man spoken of again* (Marbh-bheò<sup>12</sup> Doire uaine). The shepherds of the Doire uaine hills will light no fires on the high pastures, for the old inscriptions of Marbh-bheò Doire uaine. A reeve sent from Muileann chiar to make them see sense does not stay the night.
- 25 AN CÈITEAN, LE 394** — *Aonghas mac Uisdein crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Uisdean mac Dhùghaill dies, and his son Aonghas mac Uisdein is crowned at Cathair dhearg. Aonghas is the first king to learn his letters as a child.
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 394** — *Àth fhiadhaich salt fish* (Àth fhiadhaich). Àth fhiadhaich begins to salt its catch with Ros fhionn salt and send it inland to the mining towns. From this time the mining shires eat salt fish in the lean season.
- 28 AM MÀRT, LE 409** — *Clach first preached at Inis thais* (Inis thais). Dòmhnall mac Ailein, a net-maker of Inis thais, where the wolf-sworn's stone Clach stands, preaches that the stone is Lia Fàil<sup>13</sup>, which cries out under the rightful king, and that its sworn guards are the Fianna, who keep the island as a wolf keeps its range. His hearers are the first congregation of Òrd na Cloiche<sup>14</sup>, the order of the Stone.
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 419** — *The wolf-house at Inis thais* (Inis thais). The followers of Dòmhnall mac Ailein raise at Inis thais the first temple on the island to Lia Fàil<sup>15</sup> by name. It is roofed with slate brought by sea from the north.
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 429** — *Hawk and wolf at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). The priests of the Hawk and the Fianna of the Stone both claim the harbour shrine at Caol leathan. The king's reeve divides its days between them, as the sacred woods were divided in the Holy Age, and the division holds.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 435** — *The market inside the new gate* (Seann Skell). Seann Skell on the Hawk bay is walled, and a market is granted inside the new landward gate, where amber, whale-oil, honey and the sheep of the northern moors are sold. The amber-workers of the bay swear to sell no rough amber outside the walls.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 441** — *Macha at court* (Cathair dhearg). King Aonghas takes up the wood-watchers' rite of Macha, which keeps the two horses of one chariot, foaled on one night, Liath Macha the grey and Dubh Sainglenn the black: two horses, one yoke, light and dark two powers in balance, and the vein belonging to both. The court follows him, and Òrd Mhacha<sup>16</sup>, the order of Macha, becomes the order of Cathair dhearg and the crown.
- 28 AM MÀRT, LE 446** — *Fire at Tobar dhearg* (Tobar dhearg). Fire runs through the thatch of Tobar dhearg and burns most of the village. It is rebuilt with slate from the quarries nearby, and is known thereafter for its slate roofs.

11. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

12. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

13. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

14. the order of the Stone

15. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

16. the order of Macha

- 14 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 471** — *Macha's priests in Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag*<sup>17</sup> (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag). The custody of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag, shared since the Holy Age, passes by royal grant to the priests of Macha. The other claimants leave the wood without contest. Why is not told.
- 11 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 479** — *The druid schools keep Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*<sup>18</sup> (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar). The druids of the schools take the keeping of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar, the wood of Flidais's white stag, and walk its bounds each year. The walk becomes the one open rite of the schools.
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 484** — *The drovers of Àth chiar* (Àth chiar). Drovers of Àth chiar begin to drive cattle each year over the eastern hills to the mining towns. Theirs are the first roads on the island marked with cairns.
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 484** — *Eilidh Dhubh's tracts* (Doire chiar). At Doire chiar Eilidh nic Iain, called Eilidh Dhubh, wakes again the teaching of the rival school of the Holy Age, that the vein answers labour and not birth, and sets it out in tracts that her pupils copy. The tracts are read aloud at harvest gatherings across the north-east.
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 484** — *The tracts burned at Muileann dhearg* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house commands every copy of Eilidh Dhubh's tracts brought to Muileann dhearg and burned, and some hundred are given up. Eilidh is not punished. She dies at Doire chiar, still teaching.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 484** — *Death of King Aonghas* (Cathair dhearg). King Aonghas mac Uisdein dies at Cathair dhearg and is buried by the rite of Macha, the first king so buried. His son Iain mac Aonghais is crowned.
- 27 AN GEARRAN, LE 496** — *Tormod Bàn crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Iain mac Aonghais dies after a short reign, and his son Tormod mac Iain, called Tormod Bàn for his white hair, is crowned at Cathair dhearg. The houses swear to him without dispute.
- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 509** — *Winter at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). An Taigh-seinnse Mòr on the central mining road becomes the house where the ox-teams of the mountain wait out the worst of the snow. Its keeper, Iain mac Mhurchaidh, builds them a second byre and keeps a book of the teams that lodged.
- 6 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 514** — *The bell-founders of Muileann naomh* (Muileann naomh). A family of Muileann naomh casts the first bronze bell on Dia-thìr to hang in a hawk-house. It cracks in its first frost; the second holds.
- 5 AM MÀRT, LE 519** — *An Gàire Dubh*<sup>19</sup> (Cuan dhearg). A storm named in the south-coast rolls An Gàire Dubh, the Black Laugh, drives the sea over the waterfront of Cuan dhearg and spoils the season's salt fish. The town is built again a street further from the shore.

17. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

18. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 526** — *The hawk-house at Muileann naomh* (Muileann naomh). Muileann naomh in the south becomes the southernmost house of the Hawk, and rings its bell at each measured burning. There the Hawk's teaching holds when it fades elsewhere in the south.
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 534** — *The king's sons drowned in Abhainn fhionn* (Abhainn fhionn). Both sons of King Tormod Bàn drown when a ferry overturns on Abhainn fhionn in spate. The king has no other child.
- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 547** — *Death of Tormod Bàn* (Cathair dhearg). King Tormod Bàn dies at Cathair dhearg without naming an heir, and three claims are laid before the houses at once.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, LE 552** — *The three claimants* (Cathair dhearg). The crown is claimed by Catriona nic Aonghais of Inis thais, niece of the late king; by Dùghall Garbh of Baile Mòr dhomhain, his half-brother; and by Ragnall Ruadh, head of Clann Raghnaill and master of the vein-house. The seven houses divide among them, and the War of the Three Claimants begins.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, LE 553** — *Seann Warr shuts its gates* (Seann Warr). Seann Warr, the port nearest the capital on the west, shuts its gates to all three claimants and declares for none. Twice besieged in the war, it is taken by neither.
- 22 AN GEARRAN, LE 554** — *The ford at Àth shean* (Àth shean). The host of Dùghall Garbh meets that of Ragnall Ruadh at the ford of Àth shean and breaks it. The custody-book counts some three hundred dead, most of them drowned in the ford.
- 24 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 555** — *The burning of Doire mhin* (Doire mhin). Ragnall Ruadh's men in retreat burn the village of Doire mhin and its granary, to deny them to Dùghall. The villagers winter at Cathair mhòr on the charity of Macha's priests.
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 557** — *The siege of Cathair dhombain* (Cathair dhomhain). Catriona nic Aonghais besieges Cathair dhomhain, which had declared for Dùghall, and takes it after forty days, when its wells are fouled by the dead of the siege lines. She lets the garrison go free on their oath.
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 558** — *The hearths refused* (Muileann dhearg). Ragnall Ruadh, holding the vein-house, denies the measured handful of coal to every hearth and temple in the shires that stand against him. Hearths lit with the coal for generations go cold, and this deed turns more against him than any battle.
- 14 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 560** — *The battle of Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The hosts of Catriona and Dùghall, joined for the purpose, meet Ragnall Ruadh below Muileann chrom. Ragnall falls on the field, and the next day his own custodians open the vein-house.

- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 561** — *Death of Dùghall Garbh* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Dùghall Garbh dies at Baile Mòr dhomhain of the wounds he took at Muileann chrom. His followers go over to Catriona without further fighting.
- 13 AM MÀRT, LE 562** — *Catriona Bhuadbach crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Catriona nic Aonghais is crowned at Cathair dhearg, and is known thereafter as Catriona Bhuadhach. So ends the War of the Three Claimants, after some ten years.
- 12 AN GEARRAN, LE 565** — *The ruling of the hearth* (Muileann dhearg). Catriona Bhuadhach and the vein-house set down in law that no claimant, house or king may withhold the measured handful from any lawful hearth. It is the first law written to bind the custodians themselves.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, LE 584** — *Catriona's road south* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Queen Catriona has the road south from the capital by Baile shean and Am Buabhall Fortanach at Doire shean laid with stone, that her own town of Inis thais may be reached in any weather. It is called Rathad na Banrighinn.
- 11 AN GIBLEAN, LE 594** — *Seann Warr's gates honoured* (Seann Warr). In memory of its standing aside in the war, Queen Catriona grants Seann Warr the right to keep its own gates and take its own tolls. The grant is cut over the landward gate.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 604** — *Death of Catriona Bhuadbach* (Cathair dhearg). Catriona Bhuadhach dies at Cathair dhearg. Her son Lachlann mac Iain is crowned, and the houses swear to him in a single day, a thing the chroniclers remark on.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 624** — *The Book of the Three Claimants* (Cathair dhearg). Seònaid nic Coinnich, once a clerk of Queen Catriona's household, writes the story of the war from the custody-book and from the witness of those who fought. It is the oldest history of Diathìr that survives written as one tale and not as entries.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 624** — *The sickness at Inis chrom* (Inis chrom). A spotted fever kills some three hundred at Inis chrom on the south-west coast. The Fianna of the Stone nurse the sick, and many of them die of it; thereafter the town is the Stone's.
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 634** — *The oyster beds of Doire shean* (Doire shean). Doire shean, a village on the southern shore, lays out oyster beds in its shallow bay and sends oysters by cart to the capital. The trade makes it rich enough to be a shire seat.
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 644** — *The feast-market at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). The crowds that come to the ancestor shrine at Seann Tarr for the great feasts begin to hold a market on the three feast days, chiefly of honey, beeswax for the shrine lights, and the dyes of Baile fhiadhaich. The wax lights of Seann Tarr are soon burned at ancestor shrines all along the north-eastern coast.

- I AN T-SULTAIN, LE 654** — *Manannan preached at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell, where the sting-creed of the Holy Age first called itself the only true one, the preacher Mānas mac Ruairidh proclaims its one power to be Manannan mac Lir, lord of the sea, whose Cup of Truth bears the yellow scorpion. He teaches that Manannan shut the eastern sea behind the fleet with his mist, which hides Dia-thìr from every ship beyond it, and that the crossing must not be tried again. His hearers are the first congregation of Òrd Mhanannain<sup>20</sup>, the order of Manannan.
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 654** — *Death of Lachlann mac Iain* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann mac Iain, son of Catrìona Bhuadhach, dies at Cathair dhearg, and his daughter Anna is crowned. The chroniclers call his reign quiet, and mean it as praise.
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 674** — *Manannan's order at Ros bheag and Cuan shean* (Ros bheag). Fishing families carry the teaching of Manannan's order down the west coast to Ros bheag and Cuan shean. At Cuan shean the rope-makers are among the first to turn to it.
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 694** — *Within sight of land* (Ros bheag). The priests of Manannan at Ros bheag lay down that no boat of the faithful may go out of sight of the headlands. The rule is kept on the west coast for centuries, and steering by the stars, already half lost, is lost there wholly.
- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 699** — *The granaries of Àth shean rebuilt* (Àth shean). The royal granaries at Àth shean, standing since before the Sundering, are pulled down and built again in stone on raised floors against the rats. The tally-house is rebuilt with them.
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 714** — *The rope-walks shortened* (Cuan shean). Cuan shean takes up half its rope-walks and sows the ground with barley. The rope trade had lived on the fleet and then on the fishing, and the fishing no longer needs rope of such length.
- 22 AN GEARRAN, LE 724** — *Wave at Cnoc chaol* (Cnoc chaol). A great swell with no storm behind it runs up the beach at Cnoc chaol on the south coast and carries off the drying racks and two children. The village sets its racks higher up the shore.
- II AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 731** — *The market of the eastern road* (Baile Mòr dhìreach). Baile Mòr dhìreach, the citadel on the straight eastern road, is granted a market for the east coast. There the fish and sail-cloth of the coast towns meet the furs, hides and dyes of the hills, and the dyers of Baile Mòr ruadh sell their colours nowhere else.
- 23 AM MÀRT, LE 739** — *The two counts reconciled* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house and the crown's scribes find that their counts of years since the Setting-Out differ, and settle the difference by agreement. The same agreement fixes the day of the rite of the empty harbour, which each count had placed otherwise; later scribes cease to pretend it was fixed by proof.
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 769** — *The druid school at Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). Pupils of Dùn thais found a house of disputation at Inis mhòr, and the question of the vein is argued in the north for the first time. Its first master, Fionnlagh mac Aonghais, is remembered for refusing every answer offered him.

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20. the order of Manannan



- 10 AN GEARRAN, LE 769** — *Queen Eilidh Bhàn crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Eilidh Bhàn, fifth ruler of the house of Catriona, is crowned at Cathair dhearg. The annals of her long reign are almost wholly of harvests.
- 22 AN GEARRAN, LE 769** — *The bath-house at the hot springs* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>21</sup>). Clann Choinnich rebuilds in dressed stone the old bath-house over the hot springs of Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh, and admits the sick of any house one day in seven. Its physicians keep a book of cures, afterwards lost.
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 784** — *The sea-thieves of the north-west* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Boats out of the small islands off the north-west coast begin to rob the coasting traders of fish and grain. The sea-thieves are Dia-thìrich, men of the north-west shore, and the harbour rolls name some of them.
- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 789** — *Baile chrom half empty* (Baile chrom). The reeve of Baile chrom on the north-west coast reports half the houses of the town empty, their families gone east before the sea-thieves and the poor harvests. The crown remits the town's grain dues.
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 801** — *The raid on Eilean dhubh* (Eilean dhubh). A force sent by Queen Eilidh Bhàn lands on Eilean dhubh and burns the sea-thieves' boats on the strand. Their leader, Uilleam Ruadh, is taken to Cathair dhearg and hanged.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, LE 819** — *The dearth on the north-west shore* (Gorta Baile chrom<sup>22</sup>). Harvest after harvest fails along the north-west shore, and the dearth is more than the shared meal can bear. Families leave the coast for the inland shires and the east, and the north-west is thinly held from this time to the end of the age.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, LE 829** — *The king-list recopied* (Cathair dhearg). The scribes of Queen Eilidh Bhàn copy the king-list of Dia-thìr afresh from its oldest surviving roll, adding the rulers since the Sundering. The new copy begins the present age with the Choosing and not with the fleet.
- 19 AN GEARRAN, LE 835** — *The strand-market at Àth fhionn* (Àth fhionn). Àth fhionn, the ford town where the coast road crosses the clear river, holds a market on the strand for the north coast, of fish, the flesh and oil of stranded whales, wool and barley. The fishers of the north coast no longer carry their catch to Inis mhòr.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, LE 841** — *Eilidh Bhàn dies without an heir* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Eilidh Bhàn dies at Cathair dhearg without a child, and the house of Catriona ends with her. The seven houses meet at the vein-house and not at the capital.
- 23 AM MÀRT, LE 846** — *Dòmhnall Ruadh crowned* (Cathair dhearg). The houses name Dòmhnall Ruadh of Clann Raghnaill, of the line of the claimant slain at Muileann chrom. He is crowned at Cathair dhearg and keeps the mastery of the vein-house with the crown.

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21. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 859** — *The crown and the custody joined* (Muileann dhearg). Dòmhnall Ruadh's reeves write into the custody-book that the ruler of Dia-thìr is also master of the vein-house. Thereafter the heads of the seven houses sit as the king's council, and the custodians and the court are one body.
- 1 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 865** — *The custody's seal on the king's letters* (Muileann dhearg). From the joining of the crown and the custody the king's letters bear the vein-house's own seal: a trellis of gold on blue, which the custodians read as the galleries of the mountain, and over it a hollow lozenge for Crom's slab, laid on the first break. The crown adds a white band across the field and nothing more. From this time the seal is the arms of the kingdom.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 871** — *Death of Dòmhnall Ruadh* (Cathair dhearg). Dòmhnall Ruadh, the first to hold both the crown and the vein-house, dies at Cathair dhearg and is buried at Muileann dhearg. His son Ragnall Òg is crowned.
- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 889** — *The schism of the Hawk* (Cnoc bheag). A council of the Hawk at Cnoc bheag divides over whether Mòd's measure may ever be raised. Those who hold it fixed for ever keep the name of the Hungry Hawk and the house at Cnoc bheag; those who hold that a greater flock may be fed a greater handful are called the Fed Hawk.
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 899** — *The harbour of Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). Seann Chwen builds its harbour mole and becomes the port of the coal-carts coming down from the mountain to the coast towns of the south.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, LE 909** — *The Fed Hawk at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The priests of the Fed Hawk, driven from Cnoc bheag, settle at Seann Skell on the north coast, not the western river port of that name. The custody-book writes their teaching down as an error, and at length.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 919** — *The Fed Hawk's petition* (Seann Skell). From Seann Skell the Fed Hawk asks the king's council to raise the measured handful by a quarter for the hearths of the north coast. The council refuses. It is the first plea on record to alter the Small-Burning Law.
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 929** — *The gallery at Cill ghlas* (Cill ghlas). A second tremor in the hills of Cill ghlas brings down a gallery of the vein and kills fourteen labourers of the custodians. The vein-house closes the gallery and sets at its mouth a stone with the fourteen names.
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 939** — *The coal-roads kept by the crown* (Cathair dhearg). The king's council takes the roads from the mountain to the coast into the crown's keeping, that no house may stop the carts bearing the measured coal to the temples. The roads are marked with posts bearing the crown's sign: the carriers' road down to Cathair dhearg, An Rathad Tuath over the pass by Muileann fhada, Slighe Muileann dhearg south from the hills by Muileann chrom, and Slighe Baile òg down to the southern Seann Skell.

- 17 AN GEARRAN, LE 944** — *The crown's riders* (Cathair dhearg). Fresh horses are kept for the crown's riders at the waypoint houses on the coal-roads, and a rider changing at every house carries the council's word from Cathair dhearg to the mountain between dawn and dark. The stabling is paid out of the coal-road tolls.
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 949** — *The high pastures of Doire uaine forsaken* (Marbh-bheò<sup>23</sup> Doire uaine). The last shepherd families leave the high pastures of the Doire uaine hills for the valley villages. They give the grazing as the reason; every one of them speaks also of the Marbh-bheò.
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 959** — *The salt fair at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). Ros fhionn holds its great salt fair, and the reeve counts some four thousand people on the flats in a single day. It is the height of the town, and the chronicle calls it the richest place in the north-east.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 969** — *Cathair mhòr the largest town* (Cathair mhòr). Cathair mhòr, its market drawing the trade of all the south, grows greater than the capital. The capital remains the seat of the crown, and the lesser town.
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 979** — *The stair at Toll-dubh* (Toll-dubh). Quarrymen north of the capital break into Toll-dubh, the shaft of the old tales, long lost, and find a stair cut in the rock going down beyond their lamps. The custodians of the vein-house wall up the entrance. The one quarryman who went down never tells what he saw.
- 11 AN GEARRAN, LE 994** — *The copper-workers of Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). The copper-workers of Cathair mhòr begin to make cooking pots, which are sold on every road of the island. Each bears its maker's sign, and some are still found in the ground.
- 31 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 999** — *Ailean measures Làrach an Teampaill*<sup>24</sup> (Làrach an Teampaill). Ailean mac Dhùghaill, a scholar of the druid school at Dùn thais, measures the ruin of Làrach an Teampaill and writes that its altar faces the central mountains and not the sea. Who set it so he will not guess.
- 20 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,011** — *Ailean's tables of the old ruins* (Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>25</sup>). Ailean mac Dhùghaill finishes his tables of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire, Làrach an Dùin<sup>26</sup> and Làrach an Teampaill<sup>27</sup>, with the measure, stone and lie of each. He cannot say whether one people built all three, and because of his tables no scholar after him could say either.
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,019** — *Queen Mòrag Ruadh crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Mòrag Ruadh of Clann Raghnaill is crowned at Cathair dhearg. Hers are the first household accounts of a ruler that survive whole.

22. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

23. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

24. the temple ruin

25. the watch-fort ruin

26. the fortress ruin

27. the temple ruin

- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,034** — *The obelisk at Carragh Cnoc bheag*<sup>28</sup> *cleaned* (Carragh Cnoc bheag). The priests of the Hawk at Cnoc bheag clear the moss from the obelisk of Carragh Cnoc bheag and try to read the old letters on it. They cannot, and they write down that they tried.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,039** — *Caol shean's fishing year* (Caol shean). Caol shean, whose boats fish the east coast from the mouth of the Abhainn chaol, lands the greatest catch in its rolls, so great that the salt runs short and half is dried in the wind. The dried fish sells poorly, and the town goes back to salting.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,039** — *The thousandth year* (Seann Skell). The vein-house marks the thousandth year of its count with a single measured burning of the coal on Cidhe an Di-osail<sup>29</sup> at Seann Skell, and Queen Mòrag Ruadh is there. It is told that the flame burned the colour of the vein, and that the crowd went home without a word.
- 28 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,051** — *The market above the mill-race* (Cnoc bhàn). The hill-lords of Baile ghorm hold a market for the farms of the south-east at Cnoc bhàn, above the long mill-race of Muileann fhada. Its common goods are grain, clay and honey. Its rare good is pearls, which the women of the shore take from the mussel beds in the shallows, and which no other market sells.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,064** — *The blue dyers of Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). The dyers of Baile ghorm in the south-east make a fast blue from a marsh plant and a mordant of their own. Cloth of Baile ghorm blue becomes the feast-day dress of the seven houses.
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,079** — *The swallowing cough at Muileann dhombhain* (Muileann dhomhain). A sickness that closes the throat breaks out at Muileann dhomhain and moves along the coast road. The town loses near a third of its people.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,081** — *The cough at Seann Bhral* (Seann Bhral). The swallowing cough comes to the port of Seann Bhral. The townsfolk themselves close the harbour, and keep the shared meal by leaving food at the town gate.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,082** — *Queen Beathag Fhionn closes the roads* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Fhionn, crowned after her mother Mòrag, closes the coast road between Seann Bhral and Muileann dhomhain and sets reeves at the fords to turn travellers back. The cough goes no further west.
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,104** — *Muileann dhombhain resettled* (Muileann dhomhain). Families from the hills about Muileann dhomhain settle the town that the swallowing cough emptied, and take the empty houses by lot. The older families of the town say they never again knew half their neighbours.
- 13 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,119** — *Drochaid Ros fhionn repaired* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). The arches of Drochaid Ros fhionn, worn by seven centuries of salt carts, are built anew at the cost of the salt-masters of Ros fhionn, whose names are cut on the keystones.

28. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

29. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,129** — *Death of Queen Beathag Fhionn* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Beathag Fhionn, who closed the coast road against the cough, dies at Cathair dhearg. Her son Ailean is crowned, first of four kings of that name in the house of Ragnhall.
- 13 AM MÀRT, LE 1,139** — *The Baile ghorm blue fades* (Baile ghorm). The last dyer who knew the Baile ghorm mordant dies without apprentices, having quarrelled with both of hers. The blue that follows is the common blue of the rest of the island.
- 11 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,149** — *The ancestor-posts of Dùn iséal burned* (Dùn iséal). Lightning fires the ancestor-posts at Dùn iséal. The keepers cut the names again from memory and from the custody-book, and own in their roll that some are guesses.
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,159** — *The silting of Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). A shifting bar below Ros fhionn silts up the Abhainn bheag, and the salt barges can no longer reach the quays. The salt-masters take their trade to Caol gharbh on the coast.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,169** — *Caol gharbh takes the salt* (Caol gharbh). Caol gharbh, a fishing village, becomes the salt port of the north-east, and its harbour is dug out and walled with the money of the Ros fhionn masters.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,169** — *The stone on the neck* (Coinneachadh na h-Amhaich<sup>30</sup>). Caol gharbh and Caol chrom, the two harbours of the strait, send their headmen to a stone on the neck of land between them, and there settle the dues the salt-boats pay to each. Thereafter they meet at that stone over every quarrel of the strait, and it is called Coinneachadh na h-Amhaich, the meeting of the neck.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,179** — *Drochaid Ros fhionn falls quiet* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). The salt going by sea from Caol gharbh, the carts no longer cross Drochaid Ros fhionn. The office of bridge-keeper is done away with, and from this time the bridge is little used.
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,184** — *The market-court stays at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). The salt-masters take their ships to Caol gharbh but leave their market-court on the headland at Ros fhionn, where the weights and tally-sticks are kept. The farms and forges of the north-eastern hills still bring their goods there, and the town keeps its market after it has lost its harbour.
- 25 AM MÀRT, LE 1,189** — *Seòlaid Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). The salt of Ros fhionn now goes by sea: its boats run down the river past Caol gharbh, round the north-east cape, south along the eastern shore past Seann Tarr and Àth bheag, and west again into the bay below Caol shean, where the salt goes inland. The lane is called Seòlaid Ros fhionn after the town whose salt made it, and the eastern boats keep it long after the salt-pans fail.
- 15 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,189** — *The millers of Muileann shean* (Muileann shean). The mills of Muileann shean are fitted with a new gearing, cut in oak, that turns two stones from one wheel. Within a lifetime it spreads to the mills of the north.

30. the meeting at the neck

- 21 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,199** — *The Sea-Watcher off the north-west* (Uilebheist na Mara<sup>31</sup>). Fishers of the thinned north-west coast see the Sea-Watcher, Uilebheist na Mara, near enough to foul their nets. The few boats still working those waters draw further in.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,209** — *The table of years at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). Ragnall mac Chaluim, a scholar of the druid school at Dùn thais, sets out a table showing that the heads of the custodian houses live some years longer, on the whole, than the tenants of their lands. He asks whether the vein answers the hand that holds it. The finding is set down with unease, and no answer.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,219** — *The table forbidden* (Muileann dhearg). The king's council forbids the copying of Ragnall mac Chaluim's table of years, and the house of disputation at Dùn thais is shut for a generation. Ragnall's own copy is kept in the vein-house and entered in its inventory.
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,229** — *The great gale at Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). Before the autumn grain fleet has sailed, a gale out of the north-east drives the sea up the river at Inis mhòr higher than any then living had seen. Boats are crushed at their moorings, and the grain fleet does not sail until spring.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,246** — *Baile ruadh's quarrel with Achadh naomh* (Baile ruadh). Baile ruadh and Achadh naomh in the far north-east go to law over the grazing on the hills between them. The case is heard three times at Cathair dhearg, and settled by dividing the hills along a stream.
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,259** — *Pilgrims at Allt an Àigh*<sup>32</sup> (Allt an Àigh). The keepers of the Old Spirits renew the pilgrimage to Allt an Àigh, and a guest-house is built beside the stream for those who come to drink at the right phase of the moon. Its book names pilgrims from every shire.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,266** — *Death of King Ailean mac Raghnaill* (Cathair dhearg). King Ailean mac Raghnaill dies at Cathair dhearg, leaving two sons by different mothers, Iain Ciar and Alasdair Bàn, and each has been told he is the heir.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,270** — *The battle of Cnoc naomh* (Cnoc naomh). Alasdair Bàn's men seize Cnoc naomh and Iain Ciar takes it back. The houses divide four to three, and from this battle Cogadh nam Bràithrean<sup>33</sup>, the Brothers' War, takes its name.
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,272** — *The fire at Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). Alasdair Bàn's ships burn the waterfront of Ceann mhin, which held for his brother. The fire takes the rope stores and the granary, and the town begs its bread of Cathair mhòr.
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,274** — *The battle of Muileann ghlas* (Muileann ghlas). Iain Ciar defeats Alasdair Bàn below Muileann ghlas. Alasdair is taken alive; his captains are let go home.

31. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

32. the stream of the healing water

33. the Brothers' War

- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,276** — *The brothers' peace at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). The brothers make peace at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, on neutral ground between their lands. Alasdair Bàn gives up his claim and has the lordship of Seann Chwen for life. Iain Ciar is crowned.
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,291** — *Death of Alasdair Bàn* (Seann Chwen). Alasdair Bàn dies at Seann Chwen, having kept the peace he made. His lordship returns to the crown.
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,295** — *White stone from Baile Mòr dhombhain* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Masons of Ceann leathan buy a veined white stone from the hills above Baile Mòr dhomhain for the new front of their temple. From this time the quarry is worked, and its marble goes south by the carriers' road to every town that can pay for it.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,299** — *Iain Ciar's grain law* (Cathair dhearg). Having seen Ceann mhin beg its bread, King Iain Ciar commands that every shire seat keep a year's grain in store against the next war. The law is kept as long as he lives.
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,304** — *The account of the Brothers' War* (Cathair dhearg). Pàdraig mac Ruairidh, a clerk of King Iain Ciar, writes the story of the Brothers' War. It praises the king at every turn, and it is the only account that survives, to the vexation of later readers.
- 28 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,319** — *The inns of the mining roads chartered* (An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>34</sup>). The crown grants a charter to the seven great road-houses of the mining circuit, An Sligeanach Fad' às among them, and makes their keepers answerable for the roads between them. The keepers meet once a year at An Sligeanach Fad' às to settle their accounts.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,326** — *Death of Iain Ciar* (Cathair dhearg). King Iain Ciar dies at Cathair dhearg. His grain law lapses within a few years, as he had foreseen in a note in his own hand.
- 22 AM MÀRT, LE 1,339** — *An Taigh-seinnse Òir<sup>35</sup>'s beef* (An Taigh-seinnse Òir). An Taigh-seinnse Òir, at the eastern end of the circuit, is written into the charter-roll as keeping syrupped beef for the custodians' reeves on their rounds. It is the first dish of that house on record; the rest of the entry is a complaint about the price.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,349** — *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). An Taigh-seinnse Reòta, the road-house on the bare northern road, is snowed in for a whole season with a party of custodians' reeves within. They live on its pickled spinach and fire milk, and their complaint stands in full in the charter-roll.
- 11 AM MÀRT, LE 1,359** — *The bull that sank at launch* (Seann Skell). Seumas mac Iain, a boat-builder of Seann Skell, tries to build a deep-keeled hull again from the scraps of the Sundering fellowship's lore still remembered on the strand. At its launch it fills and sinks, and Manannan's priests preach on it for a year.

34. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

35. the golden house, a waypoint inn

- 31 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,369** — *The Caol ìseal fishers go east* (Caol ìseal). Their own harbour silted, the fishing families of Caol ìseal on the north coast move east to Caol bheag. Caol ìseal becomes a farming town.
- 4 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,389** — *The southern lane* (Caol fhiadhaich). The fishers of Caol fhiadhaich, on the wild strait of the west coast, take their boats round into the southern sea, along the whole south coast to the mouth of the Abhainn uaine, and up it to the landing of Cidhe Beag below Baile thais, where they sell dried fish for grain. The older harbours of the south coast, which had never sailed beyond their own capes, begin to follow. The lane is named for its first sailors: Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich<sup>36</sup>.
- 5 AM MÀRT, LE 1,389** — *The keel-song of Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). Iseabail nic Lachlainn, a gatherer of songs for the royal household, takes down a work-song of the rope-makers of Cuan shean that names the parts of a deep keel. Half its words mean nothing to those who sing it. It is all that survives, in any form, of the craft of the Sundering fleet.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,389** — *The Stone's schism at Inis thais* (Inis thais). The Stone's congregation at Inis thais divides over whether the dead may be prayed for at Clach. Those who say no keep the temple; the others build a second house at Baile gheal.
- 3 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,399** — *The grey storm at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). A storm named Gaillean Ghlas comes out of the east and destroys the harbour of Seann Tarr. The village is rebuilt and the harbour is not; its boats go to Cuan ruadh.
- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,399** — *The second wolf-house at Baile gheal* (Baile gheal). The dissenters from Inis thais raise their house at Baile gheal and pray there for the dead by name. The two houses of the Stone are not reconciled in this age.
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,409** — *Cuan ruadh's new harbour* (Cuan ruadh). Cuan ruadh builds a second harbour arm for the boats from Seann Tarr, and thrives on the east-coast fishing for the rest of the age.
- 31 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,429** — *Queen Catriona Bheag crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Catriona Bheag of Clann Raghnaill is crowned at Cathair dhearg, the first queen in more than three centuries. It is written that she was small, and that no one said so twice.
- 26 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,439** — *The grey glaze of Muileann gheal* (Muileann gheal). The potters of Muileann gheal make a grey-green glaze that no other kiln on the island can match, and the custodian houses buy it for their tables. The secret is kept within one family, Clann Mhic Phàil.
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,449** — *The oath of the seven* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Catriona Bheag has the heads of the seven houses swear to the ruling of the hearth before her, the first renewal of the oath since Catriona Bhuadhach. Clann Choinnich swears last.
- 14 AM MÀRT, LE 1,459** — *Macha's great house at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). The priests of Macha raise their great house at Cathair mhòr, the largest roofed building on Dia-thìr in this age. Its floor of black and white was eleven years in the laying.

36. the southern sea-lane



- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,469** — *The eastern Toll-dubh* (Toll-dubh). Charcoal-burners in the east find again the eastern Toll-dubh of the old tales, with the same cut stair as the one walled up in the west. The custodians wall this one too, and the scribe binds the two entries of the custody-book each to the other.
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,479** — *The dry years at Achadh shean* (Tiormachd Achadh shean<sup>37</sup>). Three dry seasons one after another empty the wells of the eastern shires about Achadh shean. The shared meal holds, and the crown carts grain in from the south.
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,489** — *The water-rights of Achadh shean* (Achadh shean). The reeves of Achadh shean share the deep wells among the households by lot and by turn, and write the sharing on a board at the well-head. The board is renewed each generation; the lots are never drawn again.
- 24 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,499** — *The firloft of Àth shean* (Àth shean). The granary of Àth shean finds that its firloft has worn smaller than the standard of Cathair dhearg, and has been so for generations. The reeve's accounts are put right as far back as anyone can reckon.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,509** — *The grey glaze lost* (Muileann gheal). The last of Clann Mhic Phàil dies at Muileann gheal without passing on the glaze. For a generation the potters of the town try to match it, and fail.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,519** — *Baile Mòr ruadh's fair* (Baile Mòr ruadh). Baile Mòr ruadh in the east holds a cattle fair that draws drovers from Àth chiar and the eastern hills. It becomes yearly, and the greatest fair in the east.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,529** — *Queen Sileas Òg crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Sileas Òg of Clann Raghnaill, named for the queen of the firloft, is crowned at Cathair dhearg. She is the first ruler known to have visited every shire seat.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,539** — *Sileas Òg's count of hands* (Muileann dhearg). Queen Sileas Òg commands a new count of every household holding the right to the coal. It is smaller than any before, for the right has narrowed into fewer and larger households, and the queen has it entered without comment.
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, LE 1,549** — *The fire of Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). A second great fire burns Ceann mhin, and this time there is no war to blame. By order of its reeve the town is rebuilt with gable walls of stone between the houses.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,559** — *The silver smelt refused* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Clann Choinnich asks leave to burn the coal beyond the measured handful to smelt silver at Muileann chiar, since the coal burns hotter than charcoal. The council refuses. It is the first asking to burn the coal for work and not for worship.
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, LE 1,569** — *The lost smithing at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). The smiths of Dùn dhearg, makers of the ceremonial blades of the custodian houses since the walls were built, lose the last man who knew how their layered steel was folded. After him the blades of Dùn dhearg are ordinary.

37. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,579** — *The houses bury at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach*<sup>38</sup> (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach). The custodian houses begin to bury their heads at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach, among graves older than any name on them. The tenants of the land about call it unwise, and go on burying their own dead elsewhere.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, LE 1,589** — *King Ailean the Fourth crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Ailean mac Raghnaill, fourth king of that name, is crowned at Cathair dhearg. He is remembered only for the shortest reign in the king-list.
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,590** — *The synod of Manannan's order* (Seann Skell). The priests of Manannan meet at Seann Skell and lay down again the rule of sight-of-land. To it they add a prayer, said at the foot of the river pool, that Manannan keep the sea shut: A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte.
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,590** — *Queen Mòrag nic Raghnaill crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Ailean's sister Mòrag nic Raghnaill is crowned after him. She reigns forty years, and the king-list has for her its longest run of entries telling of nothing but good harvests and the rite.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,619** — *The ferry at Cidhe Beag* (Cidhe Beag). A ferry family settles at Cidhe Beag on Abhainn uaine and carries folk and goods down the river by canoe. They hold the landing for the rest of the age.
- 1 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,626** — *The dark wine of Àth shean* (Àth shean). The growers on the slopes above Àth shean press blaeberry and bramble into a dark wine that keeps a year in the cask. It is sold along the eastern road, and the road-houses serve it as black wine.
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,634** — *Inis mhòr's grain fleet laid up* (Inis mhòr). The coasting grain barges of Inis mhòr, which had sailed Slighe-uisce fhuar, the cold way along the north coast from Ros chiar to Caol mhin, since the early years of the Sundering, are laid up for good as the roads grow better. The last is kept on the strand as a wonder.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,649** — *Earthquake at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). An earthquake shakes Dùn ìseal and cracks the spirit-house. No one is killed. The keepers take it for a warning, but cannot agree of what.
- 21 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,659** — *Beathag nic Thòmais gathers the old copies* (Muileann chaol). Beathag nic Thòmais, widow of a mill-owner of Muileann chaol, begins to buy old copies of the custody-book and the harbour rolls from houses that no longer read them. She keeps them in a loft over her mill.
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, LE 1,674** — *The paper mill at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). A mill at Muileann chaol begins to make paper from rags, the first on Dia-thìr. In this generation the custody-book is first copied onto paper.

38. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

- 27 **AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,679** — *Three copies of the landfall tidings* (Muileann chaol). Among her papers Beathag nic Thòmais finds three copies of the tidings of the two landfalls. They differ in the order of the coasts and the number of hulls. She writes out all three side by side and does not choose between them.
- 3 **AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,694** — *The north-west coast counted* (Baile chrom). The crown sends a reeve to list the households of the thinned north-west coast between Baile chrom and Ceann mhòr. He counts fewer households than there are harbour berths.
- 24 **AN LÙNASTAL, LE 1,699** — *The loft at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). Beathag nic Thòmais dies, and leaves her loft of papers to the town of Muileann chaol on condition that nothing in it be burned. The town keeps that condition and very little else of her wishes.
- 6 **AM MÀRT, LE 1,709** — *King Tormod mac Ruairidh crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Tormod mac Ruairidh of Clann Raghnaill is crowned at Cathair dhearg. His reign is remembered for its roads and its length.
- 5 **AN GEARRAN, LE 1,714** — *Manannan's harbour prayer* (Seann Skell). The priests of Manannan at Seann Skell begin to say their prayer for the shut sea on the day of the rite of the empty harbour, so that both are kept together on Cidhe an Diosail<sup>39</sup>. Neither side is pleased.
- 6 **AM MÀRT, LE 1,719** — *Tormod's bridges* (Cnoc ìseal). King Tormod builds stone bridges over the fords of the south-central shires, one of them at Cnoc ìseal. Ferry-keepers who lose their living are given land in amends.
- 9 **AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,729** — *The panther year* (Imrich nam Pantar<sup>40</sup>). The panthers cross the southern roads in numbers beyond any herder's memory, and for a whole season the crossing days run into one another. Flocks are kept in folds from Cnoc àrsaidh to the coast.
- 10 **AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,734** — *Caol gharbh loses the salt* (Caol gharbh). The sea rises over the salt pans of Caol gharbh and they fail, and salt comes to the north-east from the south instead. The town that took the trade of Ros fhionn is poorer than Ros fhionn had been.
- 12 **AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,739** — *Storm at Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). A south-westerly storm floods the low town of Baile ghorm and drowns twenty-three. The town raises its sea-wall by the height of a man.
- 22 **AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,749** — *The rite kept by few* (Seann Skell). The rite of the empty harbour on Cidhe an Diosail<sup>41</sup> at Seann Skell is kept by the harbour priests and a few old families. A visiting scribe writes that none there could say on what day the fleet had in truth sailed.

39. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

40. the panthers' crossing

41. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

- 23 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,754** — *Cuan dhearg flooded again* (Cuan dhearg). The sea comes over the waterfront of Cuan dhearg a second time, and the street moved back after An Gàire Dubh<sup>42</sup> is flooded to the thresholds. The town builds a sea-wall and does not move again.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,759** — *The house at Dùn thais reopened* (Dùn thais). The house of disputation at Dùn thais, shut and opened more than once since the table of years, is opened again on condition that the question of longer lives is not raised. The druids of the schools accept it and argue about the vein instead.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,766** — *Death of King Tormod* (Cathair dhearg). King Tormod mac Ruairidh dies at Cathair dhearg after a reign of more than fifty years. His daughter Gormshuil nic Thormoid is crowned.
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, LE 1,771** — *Queen Gormshuil's progress* (Cathair dhearg). Queen Gormshuil nic Thormoid rides round every shire seat of the island, the first ruler to do so since Sileas Òg. Her clerks write down the grievances of each shire; the queen answers none of them in writing.
- 5 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,776** — *The second silver petition* (Muileann dhearg). Clann Choinnich asks again to burn the coal beyond the measure for the silver smelt at Muileann chiar, now with three of the seven houses behind it. Queen Gormshuil's council refuses by one voice. The name of the member who changed his vote is written down; his reason is not.
- 25 AM MÀRT, LE 1,786** — *An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>43</sup>'s spinach* (An Taigh-òsta Grianach). An Taigh-òsta Grianach on the eastern road feeds the queen's progress with pan-fried spinach and black wine, as the charter-roll records. Its keeper, Peigi nic Dhonnchaidh, is spared her road dues for a year.
- 27 AN GEARRAN, LE 1,791** — *The last count of hands* (Muileann dhearg). The vein-house counts for the last time in this age the households holding the right to the coal. They are fewer than at any count before, and greater; the custody-book notes that three of the seven houses now hold more than half the right between them.
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, LE 1,794** — *Timber out of the mist* (Ceann mhòr). A worked timber, longer than any tree on the island and fastened with nails of a make no smith of Dia-thìr knows, comes ashore at Ceann mhòr on the north-west coast, from beyond Manannan's mist, as the fishers say. It is carried to Seann Skell, shown to Manannan's priests, and burned.
- 24 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,799** — *The lamps at Seann Skell go out* (Seann Skell). Fewer houses at Seann Skell keep the night of lamps each year, and at last none on the waterfront. An old woman sets a lamp in a window of the harbour-house, and the scribe writes that it was she and not the town.

42. the Black Laugh

43. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, LE 1,803** — *The last rite of the empty harbour in this age* (Seann Skell). Eleven people keep the rite of the empty harbour at Seann Skell. The harbour scribe enters their number, the weather and the state of the tide, and nothing more.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, LE 1,806** — *The silver petition laid aside* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The member who had turned the vote being dead, Clann Choinnich does not bring its silver petition to the council again. It lies unanswered in the vein-house, and the age ends with the Small-Burning Law still kept.
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, LE 1,813** — *The mist thins* (Seann Skell). The priests of Manannan at Seann Skell write that the mist on the eastern sea, which has hidden Dia-thìr from every ship beyond it since the fleet of the Sundering sailed into it, lies thinner each winter. They say their prayer, A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte, at every tide, and on still mornings the fishers of the north-west coast begin to see the line of the open sea beyond the headlands.

## AGE V · AN AOIS CHOIGREACH

*The Age of Strangers · the Anchor Era, AE 1 – 151*

- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 1** — *The Crossing*. Humans come ashore on Dia-thìr, bringing their Church with them, and are given leave to stay. They are the first strangers met since the Sundering.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 1** — *The ships met off the north-west* (Coinneachadh nan Long<sup>1</sup>). That winter the mist that had lain on the eastern sea since the fleet of the Sundering sailed into it lifts from the northern water. Two fishing boats of Achadh àrsaidh, working the water off the north-west cape where the Sea-Watcher is seen, meet three ships coming down out of the thin grey from the north, and hail them; neither side understands the other. The fishers turn south and the ships follow them down the coast toward Cuan shean. The fishers call the place Coinneachadh nan Long, the meeting of the ships, and the boats of Achadh àrsaidh still slow there.
- 5 AN GEARRAN, AE 1** — *Three ships off Cuan shean* (Cuan shean). Three ships down from the north anchor off Cuan shean, the first hulls of their size seen from Dia-thìr since the fleet of the Sundering. Their master, a captain the rolls name Edmund Harrow, comes ashore unarmed with eleven men and asks by signs for water.
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 1** — *Forty days on the dunes* (Cuan shean). The custodians of Cuan shean will not decide alone, and send inland to the capital for counsel. For forty days the strangers are fed on the beach and kept below the dunes.
- 10 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 1** — *The custodian of Baile fhiadhaich rides south* (Baile fhiadhaich). Word of the ships reaches Baile fhiadhaich, up the western coast, in two days. Its custodian rides south to see them, and writes to the council that the strangers' ropes are better than ours and their manners worse.
- 11 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 2** — *The Council of Custodians grants leave* (Cathair dhearg). The Council of Custodians at Cathair dhearg, which has sat in the crown's place since the crown fell empty at the close of the Age of Sundering, confirms the strangers' leave to stay under the high custodian Tormod mac Ailein. The council roll gives the vote as with one voice; a later hand in the margin notes that three custodians were absent.
- 9 AN GEARRAN, AE 2** — *The quarter of sea they came from* (Cuan shean). Old sailors at Cuan shean say that the strangers came in from the same quarter of sea the fleet of the Sundering sailed into. The council forbids the saying in its hall. It is written down all the same, and never answered.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, AE 2** — *The land beyond*. The strangers name their homeland in their own tongue, but no scribe of the Dia-thìrich writes the word down. From the first season the scribes call it an Tìr Thall<sup>2</sup>, the land beyond, and its people simply the humans.

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1. the meeting of the ships

2. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 2** — *The first attempts at speech*. For a whole season clerics of the humans' Church and custodians of Dia-thìr labour to make a store of words in common. Neither side's account of what was agreed survives whole.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 2** — *Wren's word-lists* (Cathair dhearg). The human cleric Samuel Wren and the custodian Gormshuil nic Fhearchair keep word-lists side by side through the season of speech-making. Wren's list survives in the Administration's letter-books. Gormshuil's is lost; only its first leaf, with forty words for the colours of broken coal, is known from a copy.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, AE 3** — *One word for the coal* (Cathair dhearg). The humans have a single word for the coloured coal, and it is their word for the black fuel they burn at home. Gormshuil's copyist notes that no Dia-thìris word in either list answers to it, and that the humans did not ask for one.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 3** — *Trade begins*. At first the trade is fair on both sides: the goods of Dia-thìr for tools and knowledge the lonely island lacks. For a few years it seems it may last.
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 3** — *The trading post at Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). The humans set up a trading post at Ros dhomhain, the capital's harbour, and give iron tools, window glass, lamp-oil and paper for wool, salt fish, hides and dyed cloth. The first tally-book of the post, kept by the trader Thomas Pike, balances evenly through its first year.
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 3** — *The first bull on Loch chrom* (Abhainn gheal). Pilots of Caol leathan bring the first of the strangers' ships up the Abhainn gheal into Loch chrom, towing her with boats through the shallows below Baile ghlas, and she anchors off Ros dhomhain. Thereafter the humans' goods come to the capital shore by water, and the pilots charge a stranger's hull twice the toll of a Dia-thìreach boat.
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 3** — *Cathair naomh sends its wool* (Cathair naomh). Cathair naomh, the city above Seann Toll on the northern coast, sends its first wool south to the humans' post by coasting boat. Its custodians take their payment in paper and ink, and with them begin the town's roll afresh.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 3** — *Iron in the smithies* (Cathair dhearg). The smiths of Cathair dhearg take the humans' bar-iron gladly and learn to temper it in a winter. Within a few seasons the old bronze hoes are melted down for bells.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 4** — *Dyes for Baile Mòr mhòr* (Baile Mòr mhòr). The weavers of Baile Mòr mhòr on the northern coast trade their cloth for the humans' dyes, a red and a blue brighter than any the island could make. Within a few years the old madder fields about the town go back to grass.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 4** — *Harrow's second voyage* (Cuan shean). Harrow sails for home with hides and dyed cloth and comes back with four ships in place of three. He brings carpenters, a surgeon, and a letter from a trading house in an Tìr Thall<sup>3</sup> asking what else the island has.

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3. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 4** — *The shipwrights of Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). The shipwrights of Inis mhòr come to look at the humans' hulls and measure them with knotted cords. Their guild had built nothing greater than a coaster since the fleet of the Sundering, and the old craft of building for deep water was half forgotten.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 4** — *The surgeon Jonas Tull* (Cuan shean). The humans' surgeon, Jonas Tull, sets the broken leg of a fisherman of Cuan shean who had been given up as lame. The town's custodian enters it in the roll as the first debt owed to a stranger.
- 30 AM MÀRT, AE 5** — *Salt from Seann Warr* (Seann Warr). The salt-pans of Seann Warr begin to sell to Pike's post by the barrel. They are the first goods of Dia-thìr that the humans come back asking for twice.
- 14 AN GIBLEAN, AE 5** — *Wool at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). The walled harbour of Caol leathan sends its first wool-ship to the humans' post. Its merchants will be paid only in iron by weight, and the tally-book of the post names them the hardest bargainers on the island.
- 22 AN GIBLEAN, AE 5** — *The first mixed settlement*. A small coastal town takes in both Dia-thìrich and humans under one rule. It is not tried again.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 5** — *Baile dhìreach under one council* (Baile dhìreach). The small port of Baile dhìreach on the south-west coast takes Dia-thìrich and humans under one council of six, three of each. Its founding compact is written twice, once in each tongue, the only such compact of the age.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 5** — *The first council of Baile dhìreach* (Baile dhìreach). The council is chaired in alternate years by the fisherman Iain mac Chaluim and the human carpenter William Rook. The harbour dues go half to the custodians at Cathair dhearg and half to the humans' post.
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 6** — *Inis thais declines the compact* (Inis thais). The city of Inis thais, whose harbour lies a few miles from Baile dhìreach, is bidden to join the joint council and declines. Its custodian writes that one town may be a trial, but two would be a rule.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 6** — *A supply ship lost on the western reefs* (Muir Mhanannain<sup>4</sup>). A human supply ship strikes the reefs off the western coast in fog, and nine of her crew drown. Her master was sailing by a chart drawn from memory, the humans' letter-books complain, on a coast lit only by the old driftwood fires.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 6** — *The beacons asked for*. Human seamen, strange to the coasts of Dia-thìr, ask for standing beacons. The builders of the Dia-thìrich agree, not yet seeing what the beacons will bring.
- 29 AM MÀRT, AE 6** — *The beacon headlands walked* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>5</sup>). The human navigator James Fenn and the Dia-thìreach mason Torcall Clachair walk the coast together to choose the places of the new beacons, and mark the five headlands of the old fires. Fenn's chart survives; Torcall's cairns for the most part do not.

4. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

5. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg



- 26 AN GIBLEAN, AE 7** — *Fenn's line* (Dia-thìr). On the same survey James Fenn runs a line of sights across the whole island, from the open sea off the north-west, where ships coming down from the north first raise the land, to the water off the eastern cape. He makes it a hundred and fifty-five miles, some thirty of them sea at the western end. It is the first measure of Dia-thìr from side to side, and every chart the Company draws afterwards is scaled to it.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, AE 7** — *A marriage in two tongues* (Baile dhìreach). At Baile dhìreach the net-maker Eilidh nic Ruairidh weds the human cooper Samuel Hale. The council enters the marriage in both its books; the custodians at Cathair dhearg, asked for a ruling, send none.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, AE 8** — *The first written treaty*. The terms on which the humans stay are first set down in writing, in the humans' tongue only. No one among the Dia-thìrich speaks against it at the time.
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, AE 8** — *The treaty signed at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). The treaty is signed in the council hall at Cathair dhearg by Tormod mac Ailein for the custodians, and for the Administration by Josiah Pell, newly come as the humans' first Commissioner. Tormod could not read the tongue it was written in. Who read it to him is not told.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, AE 9** — *The Residency above Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). Josiah Pell builds a house of dressed stone on the rise above Ros dhomhain and calls it the Residency. Captain Harrow, needed ashore no longer, goes back to the sea trade.
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, AE 9** — *The Company chartered* (Ros dhomhain). Harrow and Pike found a trading house under licence of the Administration, known on Dia-thìr simply as the Company. Its charter gives it first refusal of "all fuels, ores and minerals the island may yield."
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 9** — *The warehouse at Cathair dhomhain* (Cathair dhomhain). The Company builds a stone warehouse at Cathair dhomhain, along the lake shore from the capital, to keep its tools from the harbour thieves of Ros dhomhain. It is the first building on Dia-thìr the Company owns outright.
- 5 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 9** — *The strangers' fever* (Cuan shean). A fever comes ashore at Cuan shean with a crowded ship and runs down the west coast. Ninety-one Dia-thìrich die, and eleven humans. The custodians shut the town to ships for a season, and Pell protests in writing.
- 9 AN GEARRAN, AE 10** — *The fever at Baile àrsaidh* (Baile àrsaidh). The strangers' fever comes to Baile àrsaidh, a day's walk up the coast, and kills its custodian and both her sons. No humans dwell in the town at all, and the custodians of the west take note of it.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 10** — *The fever turned back at Cnoc àrsaidh* (Cnoc àrsaidh). At Cnoc àrsaidh in the south-west the townsfolk block the road with carts and turn back every traveller for a season, and the fever does not reach them. The Administration fines the town for hindering trade.

- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 10** — *Prospectors in the central hills* (Muileann chrom). The Company sends two prospectors, Abel Stone and Hugh Mercer, into the hills east of the capital. They come back with sacks of broken coal, and word that the black seam runs "further than can be walked in a day."
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 11** — *The sacks returned to the rock* (Muileann chrom). The custodians of the vein demand the broken coal back, to lay it in the rock again with the proper words. The Company returns half. The custodians' roll enters the other half as "carried west."
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 11** — *The first mining contracts*. Trade sours into bargain. Dia-thìrich hands mine the vein on a scale that no reverent custom had ever used.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 11** — *The first pit at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). Under the first contract a Dia-thìreach crew of thirty opens a working at Muileann chrom, paid by the ton in iron tools and lamp-oil. The custodians' own cuttings had never been measured by weight at all.
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 12** — *A coal quay at Ceann fhada* (Ceann fhada). The Company builds a stone quay at Ceann fhada, a fishing hamlet below the hills, for loading coal into coasting barges. The fishermen are paid for their foreshore in iron nails, by weight.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 12** — *Wren's grammar* (Ros dhomhain). Samuel Wren finishes a grammar of Dia-thìris for the Mission, the house of the humans' Church on Dia-thìr. It is careful and true in most things, and it gives the word for the vein's custodians as "keepers of the coal."
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 13** — *The hawk-priests read Wren* (Cnoc bheag). The hawk-priests of Cnoc bheag ask the Mission for a copy of Wren's grammar, to read what the humans write of them. The Mission sends one. Of all the copies that survive it bears the most notes in the margins.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 13** — *The Mission chapel* (Ros dhomhain). The Mission raises a timber chapel on the quay at Ros dhomhain, the first church on the island. Its bell is the first iron bell on the island, and the custodians ask that it not be rung before the fishing fleet is out.
- 29 AM MÀRT, AE 14** — *The first refusal*. One mining settlement will not sign a contract. For the present it is passed by, not punished.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, AE 14** — *Beathag Dhubh of Doire mhòr* (Doire mhòr). The settlement that refused was Doire mhòr, in the hills above Muileann chrom, and its custodian was Beathag Dhubh. Her answer to the Company's agent is known only in his words: that the hill was not hers to sell nor his to buy.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 15** — *The road around Doire mhòr* (Cnoc fhiadhaich). The Company opens its next working at Cnoc fhiadhaich instead, and runs its cart-road round the fields of Doire mhòr and not through them.

- 9 **AN CÈITEAN, AE 15** — *Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>6</sup> lit* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg). The first of the new beacons is finished on the southern headland at Tobar dhearg: a round tower of grey stone raised over the old fire-tower, paid for by the Company, with a Dia-thìreach keeper. Torcall Clachair builds it; James Fenn sets its lens.
- 29 **AM MÀRT, AE 16** — *The first keeper of Tobar dhearg* (Tobar dhearg). The first keeper of the southern beacon is Anna nic Dhòmhnaill of Tobar dhearg village, a fisherman's widow, who climbs the tower twice a night for the rest of her life. The village holds the keepership as a trust and keeps it in its own families through the age.
- 10 **AN GIBLEAN, AE 16** — *Raiders in the north-western waters* (Spùinneadairean-mara). A Company brig is boarded off the north-west coast and stripped of her cargo of tools. The raiders are never known. The Administration blames the custodians of the coast, and the custodians answer that those waters have always kept their own law.
- 5 **AN GEARRAN, AE 17** — *The obelisk at Cnoc bheag copied* (Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>7</sup>). Samuel Wren copies the writing on the obelisk near Cnoc bheag and sends it over the sea to the scholars of an Tìr Thall<sup>8</sup>. No answer comes. The custodians tell him the stone is older than the Dia-thìrich and that none living can read it.
- 13 **AN GEARRAN, AE 17** — *The first coin*. The humans' coin is brought in beside the old barter, for ease, it is said. Within ten years nothing that needs a tool from over the sea can be had for anything else.
- 10 **AN LÙNASTAL, AE 17** — *The mark and its hundred pence* (Ros dhomhain). The coins are struck at Ros dhomhain from silver and copper shipped from an Tìr Thall<sup>9</sup>: the mark and its hundred pence. The first striking bears a ship on one face, and nothing of Dia-thìr on either.
- 1 **AM FAOILLEACH, AE 18** — *Cathair mhòr refuses the mark* (Cathair mhòr). The market of Cathair mhòr, greatest below the hills east of the capital, refuses the humans' coin for a whole year. The custodians of the town give way when the Company's tool-sellers will not cross their bridge.
- 30 **AM FAOILLEACH, AE 18** — *Two books at the capital market* (Cathair dhearg). At the market of Cathair dhearg the tool-sellers take only marks, while cloth and fish still go by barter. The custodians' clerks begin to keep two sets of books, and complain of it in both.
- 3 **AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 18** — *Wren's winter at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). The masters of the druid school at Dùn thais receive Samuel Wren for a winter of disputation. He asks them why the vein should be holy; they ask him why his fuel should be burned. Neither telling of that winter names a winner.

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6. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

7. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

8. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

9. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 19** — *Drochaid Cathair dhearg*<sup>10</sup> *rebuilt* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg). Company masons rebuild in dressed stone the old bridge over Abhainn dhomhain at Cathair dhearg, wide enough for coal-carts to pass two abreast.
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 19** — *The Commissioner's carriage* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>11</sup>). Company wheelwrights build a closed carriage for Josiah Pell, and he drives in it over the new bridge from the Residency to the council at Cathair dhearg. It is the first carriage on the island. The custodians still walk to the council, and say so.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 19** — *The Harbour Articles* (Ros dhomhain). A second compact, the Harbour Articles, fixes the dues and anchorages of Ros dhomhain in the Company's favour. Like the first treaty it is written in the humans' tongue only, and this time two custodians refuse to sign.
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 20** — *The fishermen of Baile ghlais* (Baile ghlais). The fishermen of Baile ghlais, whose boats had anchored free at Ros dhomhain time out of mind, are charged anchorage under the Harbour Articles. They take their catch to their own small harbour and sell it there to anyone but the Company.
- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 20** — *The northern concession* (Muileann àrsaidh). The council grants the Administration upland pasture in the north-west about Muileann àrsaidh, for human families who will not work in the pits. The grant is for grazing; the families build houses of stone.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 20** — *Death of Tormod mac Ailein* (Cathair dhearg). Tormod mac Ailein, the high custodian who signed the first treaty, dies at Cathair dhearg. The council chooses Coinneach Glas of Ceann àrsaidh after him, who had never met a human before the Crossing and has dealt with little else since.
- 10 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 21** — *Harrow lost at sea* (Muir Mhanannain<sup>12</sup>). Edmund Harrow's ship does not come back from the crossing. The Company passes wholly into Thomas Pike's hands, and the humans' letter-books mourn Harrow as the man who found Dia-thìr.
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 21** — *The Small-Burning Law lapses*. Centuries of measured burning end within one generation. The Law is never repealed; once its keeping no longer pays, it is no longer kept.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 21** — *The last count at Doire mhin* (Doire mhin). The custodians of Doire mhin keep the old count of the Small-Burning Law, the measure of coal that might be burned in a year, one season longer than any others. They enter it in their roll with the note that no one asked for it.

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10. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

11. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

12. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

- 11 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 22** — *A defence of the Law at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Fionnghal nic Artair, a custodian of Dùn dhearg, writes to the council in defence of the Small-Burning Law, the only such defence that survives. She holds that the Law was never for the coal's sake but for the people, who would become whatever the burning made them.
- 6 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 22** — *Murchadh Seabhag preaches at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell the hawk-priest Murchadh Seabhag preaches that Mòd, the Hungry Hawk of Acaill, starves those who eat faster than the land can feed them. The sermon is copied and carried to the camps, and it is the first writing of the Dia-thìrich that the Company's agents are told to seize.
- 16 AM MÀRT, AE 23** — *The hearths of Achadh naomh* (Achadh naomh). The households of Achadh naomh, in the hills north of the workings, who keep Na Seann Spioradan<sup>13</sup>, will not light their hearths with coal bought of the Company. They burn peat as their grandparents did, and their elders teach that coal burned for wages is burned without the ancestors' leave.
- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 23** — *Burning by the cartload* (Muileann chrom). The Company's furnaces at Muileann chrom burn coal by the cartload to drive the new pumps, and no heed is paid to the custodians' tally of what the hill may give in a year. Coinneach Glas's council asks that the tally be kept, and is sent a copy of the Company's accounts.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, AE 24** — *Henry Maddox Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Josiah Pell sails home to an Tìr Thall<sup>14</sup> and does not return. After him comes Henry Maddox, bidden to double the yield, with a letter from the Company promising him a share of it.
- 12 AM MÀRT, AE 24** — *The oaks of Cathair fhada* (Cathair fhada). Maddox buys the oak woods about Cathair fhada for pit-props. The town had cut them sparingly for generations; they are gone within the working lives of the men who fell them.
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, AE 25** — *The first deaths of haste*. A tunnel worked faster than any Dia-thìreach crew would have worked it falls in and kills eleven. It is entered as an accident.
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 25** — *The eleven of Cnoc fhiadhaich* (Cnoc fhiadhaich). The fall was at Cnoc fhiadhaich, in a gallery driven forward without the timbering the Dia-thìrich crews had asked for. The custodians' roll names all eleven dead. The Company's report names none, and calls the gallery "unsound ground."
- 11 AN GEARRAN, AE 26** — *The coughing sickness* (Muileann chrom). A dry cough runs through the camps at Muileann chrom and Cnoc fhiadhaich, worst among the boys who break coal at the pit-mouth, and thirty-eight die of it. The Mission's surgeon calls it a winter complaint. It lasts through the summer.

13. the Old Spirits

14. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 6 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 27** — *The orphans of Cill thais* (Cill thais). The village of Cill thais takes in the children orphaned by the coughing sickness and keeps a house for them at its own custodians' cost. The Company, asked to give toward it, sends a crate of Mission primers.
- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 27** — *Taigh-solais Baile ìseal*<sup>15</sup> *lit* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal). The second beacon is lit on the eastern shore at Baile ìseal. Torcall Clachair, now too old to climb, directs its building from a chair at the foot of the headland.
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, AE 28** — *The keepers of Baile ìseal* (Baile ìseal). The keepers of the eastern beacon are drawn from the fishing families of Baile ìseal. The town's custodians ask for a rule, and get it, that the lamp be lowered on the nights the boats go out to the deep grounds, lest the fish take fright. When the rule lapsed no one wrote down.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, AE 29** — *Seòlaid Ceann òg* (Ceann òg). The traders' boats from the new quay at Ceann òg go down the Abhainn ìseal past Cnoc bheag and Inis bhàn to the north coast, west along it, round the western capes, and south past Inis thais into the capital's water. Their lane is called Seòlaid Ceann òg after the quay. Off the north-west it swings far out into the open sea, and there the ships bound for an Tìr Thall<sup>16</sup> leave it for the passage north-about, and the ships coming down from the north come in.
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 29** — *The camp at Àth ìseal* (Àth ìseal). The Company builds a camp of timber huts at Àth ìseal, at the ford below the new workings, for crews brought in from the coast. It is the first settlement on Dia-thìr made for nothing but the pit.
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 30** — *Doire mhòr's water taken* (Doire mhòr). The Company turns the stream that watered Doire mhòr to wash coal at Cnoc fhiadhaich. No order is written; the stream is dammed one season and not let go. Beathag Dhuhb's people carry water by hand for two summers, and then begin to leave.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 30** — *The short hunger in the hills* (Muileann chrom). The men drawn from the farms into the pits, the hill villages of Muileann chrom lose their oats to rain, with none at home to cut ahead of it. The Company sells meal at the camp stores for marks, and the villages have few.
- 15 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 31** — *Meal-carts at Doire fhiadhaich* (Doire fhiadhaich). The villages of Doire fhiadhaich in the south send carts of meal north to the hill villages, as the old custom of the Holy Age bids in a hungry year. The Company's agents at Àth ìseal buy up two of the carts on the road.
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 31** — *The mountain dug by the ton*. For the first time in the history of Dia-thìr the mountain is worked by the ton, and for ends no custom of the Dia-thìrich would have chosen.

15. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

16. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 31** — *Rope for the winding-gear* (Dùn chrom). The rope-walks of Dùn chrom, which had made cable for the fishing boats, turn wholly to winding-rope for the pit-heads. The Company pays well, and the town grows by half.
- 7 AN GIBLEAN, AE 32** — *The Company's second charter* (Ros dhomhain). The Company is chartered again in an Tìr Thall<sup>17</sup>, with new money and a new name the Dia-thìrich never take up. Its agents at Ros dhomhain now outnumber the Administration's own clerks four to one.
- 16 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 32** — *Barges at Cidhe Beag* (Cidhe Beag). Coal barges begin to load at Cidhe Beag on Abhainn uaine and float the black coal down to the coast. The old canoe landing, used since before the Sundering, is widened with cut stone, and its shrine is moved uphill.
- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 33** — *Abhainn uaine silts black* (Abhainn uaine). The washing of coal upstream fills Abhainn uaine with black slurry, and within a few seasons the salmon runs at its mouth fail. The river keeps its name, the green river, and the fishermen speak it bitterly.
- I AN LÙNASTAL, AE 33** — *Baile Mòr dhomhain a barge town* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). As the coal comes down to it from Cidhe Beag, Baile Mòr dhomhain on the river road grows into the busiest barge town of the north. Its people double in number, most of the newcomers bargemen from the coast.
- 10 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 34** — *Baile dhomhain raised as a camp town* (Baile dhomhain). A Company surveyor lays out a second camp, Baile dhomhain, on a grid, the first town of the Dia-thìrich drawn on paper before it was built. Within two seasons it houses four hundred.
- I AN LÙNASTAL, AE 34** — *An Taigh-seinnse Mòr reopens* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). The old carters' house at the half-way stage of the coal road between the capital and the hills is built again, opens its doors at Lùnastal, and keeps the name An Taigh-seinnse Mòr. Its first keeper, Seònaid Bhàn, takes both marks and barter, the only innkeeper on the road who will.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 34** — *Rathad na Mèinne*<sup>18</sup> (Àth chiar). The Company's road-gangs finish metalling the carriers' road from Cathair dhearg by Doire chaol and the ford of Àth chiar to the workings at Achadh dhomhain, wide enough for coal-carts to pass both ways. The carters call it Rathad na Mèinne, the mine road. The posts with the crown's sign that had marked it since the Age of Sundering are left standing along it.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, AE 35** — *The carters of Doire chaol* (Doire chaol). The carters of Doire chaol, on the road just east of the capital, band together in a guild to bargain with the Company over the rates for hauling coal. It is the first Dia-thìreach guild of the age, and the Company owns it because that is cheaper than breaking it.

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17. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

18. the mine road

- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 35** — *Seann Toll made a coal landing* (Seann Toll). The Company takes the river landing at Seann Toll, below the workings, and builds a loading stage there for the barges that carry the coal down the Abhainn uaine to Ceann leathan. The town's fishing boats are moved to the next reach.
- 31 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 36** — *The coal ships' lane* (Ceann leathan). From the landing at Seann Toll the coal barges go down the Abhainn uaine to Ceann leathan, where the Company's ships load at the river mouth and go out by the southern lane, Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich<sup>19</sup>, west along the south coast to the wild strait and the open sea. The fishers of the south coast, who had used the lane for five hundred years, learn to keep out of the coal ships' way.
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, AE 36** — *The first Dia-thìreach overseer*. A Dia-thìreach is set over other Dia-thìrich miners, answerable to human masters. It is the first open crack within the Dia-thìrich themselves, and not only between them and the humans.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 36** — *Raghnall Maor* (Muileann chrom). The first overseer is Raghnall mac Dhòmhnaill of Muileann chrom, a crew-leader who had worked the pits since the first contract. He is given the Company's staff and a house with a slate roof, and from the office the Dia-thìrich give him his byname: Raghnall Maor, Raghnall the steward.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 37** — *The overseers multiply* (Muileann chrom). Within a few years there are overseers at every working in the district, all Dia-thìrich, all answerable to the Company's agents. The custodians' roll no longer names them, and gives only their number.
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 38** — *Seumas Dubh killed at Cnoc mhòr* (Cnoc mhòr). Seumas Dubh, overseer of the new pits at Cnoc mhòr, is killed by his own crew after a boy is crushed on a haulage he had ordered hurried. The Company hangs two men at Ros dhomhain, the first hanging done by the Administration on Dia-thìr.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 38** — *Hawk-priests barred from the camps* (Muileann chrom). Henry Maddox bars the priests of Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>20</sup> from the camps, for their preaching slows the work. The overseers enforce the order, though several of them are hawk-faithful, as the roll says. The Mission's chaplains, who keep a chapel in every camp, are not barred.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 39** — *The pox at Ros dhombain* (Ros dhomhain). A spotted pox comes ashore at Ros dhomhain on a Company ship and climbs the coal road into the camps. The Mission counts four hundred and six dead. The custodians count more, and write the difference in the margin of the Mission's list.
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 40** — *The pox in the south* (Baile chiar). The pox spreads south from the harbour to Baile chiar and the villages about it. The custodians there cut the names of the dead into the stone lintel of the council house, and they can still be read.

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19. the southern sea-lane



- 31 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 41** — *Baile dhìreach loses its harbour dues* (Baile dhìreach). The Administration moves its customs house from Baile dhìreach to Ros dhomhain and ends the sharing of the harbour dues. The mixed council, left with half an income, cuts its members from six to four.
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 41** — *Arthur Lisle Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Henry Maddox leaves Dia-thìr a rich man. Arthur Lisle, a lawyer, comes after him, and his first act is to have every compact since the first treaty copied into one bound book.
- 2 AM MÀRT, AE 42** — *A customs house at Ros gheal* (Ros gheal). Lisle opens a second customs house at Ros gheal on the northern coast, where hawk-faithful fishing towns had traded with Company ships without paying dues. The customs officer is twice chased out of the town in his first year.
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 43** — *The silver of Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The humans seek to claim the silver seam at Muileann chiar as well. It is one of the few things the Dia-thìrich keep wholly in their own hands through all this age.
- 31 AM MÀRT, AE 43** — *Ùna nic Choinnich and the silver guild* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The silver seam was held for the town by its guild of refiners, led by Ùna nic Choinnich. When the Company's surveyors came she met them at the adit with every member of the guild and all its ledgers, and bade them find the humans' name anywhere in either.
- 1 AN GEARRAN, AE 44** — *The Silver Compact* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Arthur Lisle, reading the treaties closely, finds nothing in them touching silver. On Là Fhèill Bhrìde he signs a compact with the silver guild leaving the seam to the town, the first writing of the age in which the Dia-thìrich keep the better terms.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHOS, AE 44** — *Seann Bhràl the silver port* (Seann Bhràl). The silver guild sends its bars to the sea by the old port of Seann Bhràl and not by the Company's quays, and pays the port's custodians in silver for the use of it. The Company finds no ground in the compact to object.
- 21 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 45** — *The carters of Baile gheal* (Baile gheal). The carters of Baile gheal in the south-west take up the carrying of Seann Warr brine-salt round the lake to the capital, a trade the Company does not trouble to claim. It keeps the town's folk out of the pits for the whole age.
- 10 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 45** — *Taigh-solais Àth dhearg<sup>21</sup> lit* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg). The third beacon is lit on the north-east coast at Àth dhearg. Its keeper, Tormod mac Pheadair, keeps a daybook of every ship he sees, and from his book the number of human sailings in these years is known.

20. the Hawk order

21. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

- 28 AN CÈITEAN, AE 46** — *Àth dhearg builds the tower* (Àth dhearg). The masons of the beacon at Àth dhearg are its own townsmen, paid half in marks and half in the promise that the tower will guide their own boats home. Tormod mac Pheadair, the keeper, is one of them.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 46** — *Pirates off the eastern coast* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Raiders in low black boats take a Company coal ship off the eastern coast and burn her to the water-line, cargo and all. The Company says the silver guild paid them. The silver guild says nothing.
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 47** — *A cove burned near Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). A Company gunboat hunts the raiders to a cove near Ceann leathan and burns every boat drawn up on the shingle, most of them belonging to the town's fishermen. The raiders are not found.
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 47** — *The end of the joint council* (Baile dhireach). The mixed council of Baile dhireach breaks up in a quarrel over a boundary wall and never meets again. The human families go to Ros bheag and Ros dhomhain; the Dia-thìrich families stay. Households that were both split or fell silent, and which did which is not told.
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 47** — *The boatyard moves to Inis chrom* (Inis chrom). The human boatbuilders of Baile dhireach move their yard to Inis chrom, a day's sail east, where the Company has promised them timber. The town takes them in without a joint council or any other compact, and within a generation they fade from its rolls.
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 48** — *The dry year in the east* (Achadh shean). For a single season the rain fails over the eastern farmlands about Achadh shean. It is a warning, and no one heeds it.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 48** — *Baile ruadh loses its seed* (Baile ruadh). At Baile ruadh in the east the drought kills the seed corn in the ground, and the town borrows seed from the Company's store at Seann Dunn, at a price paid back over five harvests. It is the first Dia-thìreach town to owe the Company a debt in grain.
- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 49** — *Aonghas mac Coinnich's question* (Dùn thais). At Dùn thais the druid master Aonghas mac Coinnich puts to his students a question the school's register calls new: why the humans cannot see the colour in broken coal that every Dia-thìreach child sees. He does not answer it, and the register notes that he called it the wrong question.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 49** — *The druid students of Baile Mòr uaine* (Baile Mòr uaine). Students of Aonghas mac Coinnich carry his question to Baile Mòr uaine and teach it in the town's hall of disputation. The hall's record of the argument runs to four hundred leaves, and ends, like his, without an answer.
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, AE 50** — *Cathair gheal in the northern concession* (Cathair gheal). The human families of the northern concession found a market town at Cathair gheal, with a stone hall for their magistrate and a chapel. The Administration issues its charter without asking the custodians.

- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 50** — *Human farms at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). Human farmers of the concession clear land beside the Dia-thìrich village of Cnoc ghorm in the upland north-west, and build a mill. The villagers sell them grain until the mill is working, and then stop.
- 14 AM MÀRT, AE 51** — *A fishing station at Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). A few human fishing families of the concession settle at Ceann mhòr, the harbour under the north-western headland. They are the first humans to fish the island's waters for a living and not for the Company's table.
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, AE 51** — *The first Dia-thìreach child sent over the sea*. One family, hoping for better treatment, sends a son to be schooled in the humans' homeland. He is never known to return.
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, AE 51** — *The family of Eachann Mòr* (Ceann àrsaidh). The family that sent its son away was that of Eachann Mòr, a custodian of Ceann àrsaidh who had lost his seat on the council. The boy, Calum, sailed over the sea on a Company ship with a letter from the Mission and a purse of marks.
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, AE 51** — *The Mission school* (Ros dhomhain). The Mission opens a school at Ros dhomhain for Dia-thìrich children, taught in the humans' tongue. It takes thirty pupils in its first year, most of them overseers' children, and among them the Mission counts its first Dia-thìrich converts.
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 52** — *Schooling at Inis bhàn* (Inis bhàn). The custodians of Inis bhàn in the north open a school of their own in answer to the Mission's, and teach the old reckoning, the rolls and the names of the hills. The Mission complains that the pupils come to its school the next year already knowing how to argue.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 52** — *Tobacco on the concession farms* (Ceann mhòr). Human farmers of the northern concession plant tobacco on the sheltered slopes behind Ceann mhòr and sell the dried leaf to the Company's ships. Of the crops the humans brought, it alone is still grown on Dia-thìr.
- 1 AN GIBLEAN, AE 53** — *Drochaid Ros fhionn* (Drochaid Ros fhionn). The Company rebuilds the old bridge over the river at Ros fhionn to carry the eastern coal road. While the carts run it is the busiest crossing on that side of the island.
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 53** — *Coal through Inis bheag* (Inis bheag). Coal from the eastern workings is carted over the new bridge and down to the river quays of Inis bheag, and goes by barge to Caol chrom at the river mouth for shipping. The Company deepens the river at the quays, and the town's old fish market is moved to make room for the coal stage.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 54** — *Baile mhin ships the eastern coal* (Baile mhin). The river quays of Baile mhin, below Inis bheag on the Abhainn bheag, take the eastern coal that Inis bheag cannot load. The townsfolk are paid by the barge, and with the gain the town builds its first stone houses.

- 11 AN GEARRAN, AE 54** — *Caol gharbh passed by* (Caol gharbh). The coal road to Inis bheag passes Caol gharbh by a mile, and the town, which had hoped for the traffic, gets only its dust. Its custodians write that they had not known a town could be harmed by a road it was not on.
- 12 AM MÀRT, AE 55** — *The thing in the north-western sea* (Uilebheist na Mara<sup>22</sup>). The crew of a Company brig see a beast greater than their ship off the north-western headlands. The Administration's clerk files their report with the complaints about pirates, and the Dia-thìrich sailors of the coast say they had wondered when the humans would see it.
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 55** — *A brig lost in the mist* (Caol bheag). A Company brig bound for the northern landing with tools is caught by a gale in sea mist off Eilean fhada and driven onto the skerries. Her crew wade ashore at low water and walk to the harbour at Caol bheag. Thereafter the Company's charts mark the northern passage closed to its ships from midwinter to the end of spring, the season of the gales.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 55** — *Whale-boats out of Àth fhionn* (Àth fhionn). Human fishermen of the concession teach the boats of Àth fhionn to hunt whales with the hand-lance, and not wait for them to strand. The oil is sold to the Company for its lamps, and from this time whale-boats go out from the north coast every summer.
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 56** — *Surveyors lost at Doire uaine* (Marbh-bheò<sup>23</sup> Doire uaine). Two Company surveyors go up into the hills at Doire uaine against the villagers' counsel and are not seen again. The Company sends a search party, which comes back after a day and will go no further.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 56** — *The offerings at Doire uaine* (Doire uaine). After the surveyors are lost the villagers of Doire uaine leave salt and coal for the sith at the foot of the hills, as their grandparents did after any death on the high ground. The Company forbids coal to be left lying and has the offerings gathered up, and the villagers leave salt alone.
- 16 AN GEARRAN, AE 57** — *The tithe raised*. The share of mined coal taken by the humans' Administration rises steeply. What the Dia-thìrich receive does not rise with it.
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 57** — *Lisle's tithe schedule* (Ros dhomhain). The new schedule goes out from the Residency under Arthur Lisle's hand and raises the Administration's share from one part in five to one part in three. The custodians receive a copy in the humans' tongue, with a rendering made by a Mission pupil.
- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 58** — *Weighing the grain at Dùn fhiadhaich* (Dùn fhiadhaich). At Dùn fhiadhaich the tithe-gatherers begin to weigh grain as well as coal, saying the town's farms feed the pits and share in their gain. The custodians' roll calls it the tithe on the tithe.
- 6 AN T-IÚCHAR, AE 59** — *The flux at Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). A bloody flux breaks out in the crowded quarters at the Ros dhomhain quays. The Mission's nurse, Anne Colby, makes a sick-house of the chapel, and it is said that she kept the dead below two hundred.

22. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

23. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

- 7 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 60** — *The flux reaches Seann Vell* (Seann Vell). The coal barges carry the flux to Seann Vell, the river port east of the capital on the Abhainn fhionn. The custodians of the town shut the barge landing for a season, and the Company fines them for it.
- 3 **AM MÀRT, AE 61** — *Walter Crane Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Arthur Lisle dies at the Residency of a fever of the heart. Walter Crane, who had been the Company's chief agent at the pits, is made Commissioner after him, the first to hold both offices one after the other.
- 6 **AN T-SULTAIN, AE 61** — *The pay office at Ceann mhin* (Ceann mhin). Crane moves the Company's pay office for the southern workings to Ceann mhin, and makes the crews walk there to be paid, a day each way, in place of sending the paymaster to them. The crews are not paid for the walk.
- 12 **AM MÀRT, AE 62** — *Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill Maor* (Muileann chrom). Raghnaill Maor dies, and the Company gives his staff to his son Dòmhnall. The overseer's office, which the custodians had hoped would die with the man, becomes a family's inheritance.
- 11 **AN GEARRAN, AE 63** — *Taigh-solais Muileann bheag<sup>24</sup> lit* (Taigh-solais Muileann bheag). The fourth beacon is lit on the northern shore at Muileann bheag, the first to burn coal and not oil. Its keepers say the flame throws a colour on the water that no oil lamp ever did.
- 13 **AM FAOILLEACH, AE 64** — *The fishermen of Muileann bheag* (Muileann bheag). The fishermen of Muileann bheag complain that the colour the coal flame casts on the water drives the herring off. The keepers do not change the lamp. Within a season the herring come back, and the complaint is withdrawn in a letter the Company keeps.
- 27 **AN GIBLEAN, AE 64** — *The dig at Làrach an Teampaill<sup>25</sup>* (Làrach an Teampaill). The Mission cleric Edwin Lowe digs for a season at Làrach an Teampaill with Company labourers, seeking proof of an older faith on the island. He finds cut stone, burnt bone and marks he cannot read, and writes that the ruin's builders "were not the present race." The custodians agree, and add nothing.
- 9 **AN LÙNASTAL, AE 65** — *The pillar at Cnoc chiar* (Colbh Cnoc chiar<sup>26</sup>). Edwin Lowe copies the writing on the pillar near Cnoc chiar and sets it beside Wren's copy of the obelisk at Cnoc bheag. He judges that the two scripts are not the same, and that neither is of the Dia-thìrich. His notes stop there.
- 28 **AN GEARRAN, AE 66** — *The column at Cnoc ghorm* (Calbh Cnoc ghorm<sup>27</sup>). Lowe's last copy is of the column near Cnoc ghorm, and beside it he writes that its marks are like the pillar's, but not near enough to help. He leaves Dia-thìr the next year and takes his notebooks with him.

24. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

25. the temple ruin

26. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

27. the column at Cnoc ghorm

- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 66** — *The glass-house at Baile Mòr dhìreach* (Baile Mòr dhìreach). Peter Voss, a glazier left behind when his Company contract ended, builds a glass-house at Baile Mòr dhìreach and melts the white sand of Cuan ruadh with charcoal from the hills. It is the first glass made on Dia-thìr. Within a generation his Dia-thìrich apprentices carry the craft to the towns of the capital shore.
- 29 AM MÀRT, AE 67** — *The silver guild refuses again* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Martha Gale, an agent of the Company, offers the silver guild of Muileann chiar a partnership, on terms the guild's ledger calls generous. Ùna nic Choinnich, now very old, has the offer read aloud twice in the guild hall, and it is refused by show of hands.
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 68** — *The camp at Achadh dhomhain* (Achadh dhomhain). A new camp is opened at Achadh dhomhain for the deep galleries under the hill, and within a few seasons it is the most crowded place in the district. Its houses are built of spoil.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 68** — *Cloth for the camps at Dùn chiar* (Dùn chiar). The weavers of Dùn chiar take a Company contract for canvas for the camp tents and sacks for the coal, and the town thrives on it. Its custodians note that never before had the town made anything for a use it did not approve.
- 7 AM MÀRT, AE 69** — *The first of the undying generation*. A girl is born in the mining camps who takes more raw coal into her body over her life than any Dia-thìreach in living memory, and she does not age as the folk about her age. Her name is Aisling.
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 69** — *The coach to the camps* (Muileann chrom). The Company puts a coach on the road between the quay at Ros dhomhain and the camps at Muileann chrom, twice a week each way, changing horses at the old waypoint houses. Clerks and overseers ride in it. The crews walk.
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 70** — *The coal weighed at the quay* (Ros dhomhain). The Company sets up a great steelyard at the Ros dhomhain quay, and thenceforth the island's yield is known by the ton and the hundredweight. The custodians' old count, kept in seasons of labour, is no longer entered in the roll.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 70** — *Ros dhìreach the second coal port* (Ros dhìreach). The Company opens a second coal stage at Ros dhìreach on the southern coast for the workings south of the hills. Its first cargo is lost in a squall off the harbour mouth, and the fishermen moved to make room for the stage will not go out after it.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 71** — *The nameless change*. What is befalling the child born two years before has as yet no name in any tongue spoken on the island. Decades pass before anyone tries to make one.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, AE 71** — *The first steamer* (Ros dhomhain). The first ship driven by an engine comes into Ros dhomhain, a Company paddle-steamer out of an Tìr Thall<sup>28</sup>. The fishermen row out to look at a ship going against the wind with no sail set. Within a generation the Company's coal goes out in nothing else.

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28. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 72** — *The shrine at Cill dhìreach* (Cill dhìreach). At Cill dhìreach, a village at the edge of the workings, the custodians keep a small shrine where the pit crews leave the first piece of coal from each new gallery. The Company suffers the custom, for it costs a stone a gallery.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 72** — *The keepers of Cill ghlas* (Cill ghlas). The custodians of the shrine at Cill ghlas, in the hills among the workings, keep the old rites at the mouth of the oldest cutting while the Company's pits deepen about them. It is the last shrine in the district that the pit crews still visit on the old feast days.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 73** — *A' Phlàigh Uaine*<sup>29</sup>. The Green Death goes through the mining camps. The coal dust is blamed, though no study of it is ever finished. Twenty-six settlements have cases.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 73** — *The first cases at Achadh dhomhain* (Achadh dhomhain). The Green Death is first marked at Achadh dhomhain: a greenish pallor, then a cough that brings up dark dust, then weakness. The camp buries forty in the first month, in a field beyond the spoil-heaps still called the green acre.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 74** — *Twenty-six settlements* (A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>30</sup>). The sickness spreads along the coal roads from the camps at Muileann chrom, Àth ìseal and Cnoc fhiadhaich, and falls hardest on Ros dhìreach, Ceann òg, Inis ìseal, Baile dhomhain, Achadh fhada, Cnoc bheag, Muileann uaine, Cuan àrsaidh and Inis bhàn. The custodians' roll lists the twenty-six settlements that had cases, and leaves a blank line after the last, as though waiting for another.
- 11 AN GEARRAN, AE 74** — *The Green Death at Baile chrom* (Baile chrom). The Green Death comes to Baile chrom in the hills, not the town of that name in the north-west. The scribes keep the two apart with care, for in later tellings of the island's hungers they are confused.
- 12 AM MÀRT, AE 74** — *Àth ghlas burns its buts* (Àth ghlas). At Àth ghlas the custodians order every hut where a death has been burned with its bedding. The Company protests the loss of its property. The custodians note that the sickness stops sooner at Àth ghlas than anywhere else.
- 10 AN GIBLEAN, AE 74** — *The dead of Cnoc naomh* (Cnoc naomh). At Cnoc naomh the dead of the Green Death are laid in the burial ground of the town's old shrine until it is full, and then in a field outside. The field is never ploughed again.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 75** — *Doctor Bright's study* (Muileann chrom). Nathaniel Bright, physician to the Administration, begins to study the sickness at Muileann chrom, weighing the dust in the lungs of the dead. In the second season of the work he falls ill, and his notebooks break off in the middle of a table.

29. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 75** — *Walter Crane dies of the Green Death* (Ros dhomhain). Commissioner Crane, who had walked the camps in the worst of the sickness, dies of it at the Residency. Martha Gale, the Company's agent at Ros dhomhain, holds his seal for the months until another comes.
- 13 AM MÀRT, AE 76** — *George Tolley Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). George Tolley comes from an Tìr Thall<sup>31</sup> with orders that the yield must not fall for the sickness. He does not visit the camps. His letter-book blames the dust, the Dia-thìrich custom of sleeping near the fire, and the custodians' shrines, in that order.
- 11 AN GIBLEAN, AE 76** — *Quarantine at Caol mhin* (Caol mhin). Tolley sets a quarantine station at Caol mhin on the northern coast for ships from an Tìr Thall<sup>32</sup>, and holds them offshore until their crews are looked over. It is the first order of his rule the Dia-thìrich approve, and they say so.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, AE 76** — *The camps turn to the hawk* (Muileann chrom). The hawk-priests still barred from the camps, the crews carry their sermons in themselves. The overseers' reports of these years list hawk-feathers nailed above hut doors as a matter for punishment.
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, AE 77** — *Anne Colby's sick-houses* (Ros dhomhain). Anne Colby opens sick-houses at Àth iséal and Achadh dhomhain and nurses there until the sickness ebbs. She is the only human the camp folk name in their own accounts of the plague, and they name her kindly.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 77** — *The huts of Cnoc gharbh* (Cnoc gharbh). After the sickness the people of Cnoc gharbh, who had worked the southern galleries, leave their camp huts and go back to the old village on the hill. The next year the Company builds the huts again and brings in crews from the west.
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 77** — *The first strike*. A whole mining settlement stops work for eleven days over conditions worsened by the plague two years before. The strike ends when the food, which the humans' Administration holds, runs out.
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 77** — *The strike at Baile thais* (Baile thais). The settlement was Baile thais, below Cill ghlas, and the crew-leader Catriona nic Eachainn called the halt after the Company would not close the galleries where the Green Death had been worst. For eleven days no coal left the town. On the twelfth the Company's store, the only store, was empty.
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 78** — *The Company's granary* (Baile thais). After the strike the Company builds a granary of its own at Muileann chrom and forbids the camps to keep grain beyond a week's ration. The overseers enforce the order, and Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill Maor signs it.

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30. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

31. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

32. the land beyond, the humans' homeland



- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 79** — *Fish smuggled from Ros gharbh* (Ros gharbh). The fishermen of Ros gharbh carry salt fish up to the camps by night, past the Company's granary rule. The custodians' roll calls it the only trade of that decade that ran the right way.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 79** — *Catriona goes to the silver town* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Turned out of Baile thais and refused work at every Company pit, Catriona nic Eachainn goes east to Muileann chiar, and the silver guild takes her on as a refiner. The Company asks that she be sent back. The guild's answer was filed and has not survived.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 80** — *The springs at Muileann ruadh* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>33</sup>). The Administration builds a new bath-house at the hot springs near Muileann ruadh for its officers mending from fevers. Dia-thìrich who had bathed there for centuries are let in on certain days, and charged a penny.
- II AM MÀRT, AE 81** — *Muileann chiar grows* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The silver town grows beside the coal workings, for the humans want both, and the digging goes faster than the old reverence would ever have allowed.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 82** — *A second Muileann chiar* (Muileann chiar). The silver trade crowds the old town, and the guild settles its refiners and carters in the coal-breakers' mill town to the west, which is called by the silver town's name from then on. The rolls call them the old town and the new, and do not always say which they mean.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 83** — *Silver for marks* (Muileann chiar). The silver guild begins to sell bar silver to the Company for marks, at a price the guild sets. It is the only ware on Dia-thìr in this age priced by Dia-thìrich hands, and the guild's hall fills with human coin.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 84** — *Silversmiths at Muileann bhàn* (Muileann bhàn). Silversmiths settle at Muileann bhàn on the road to the silver town and live by working the guild's bar into ornaments for the humans' market. Theirs is the one Dia-thìreach craft sold in an Tìr Thall<sup>34</sup> under a Dia-thìreach name.
- 24 AN GEARRAN, AE 85** — *Macha's priests bless the coin* (Cathair dhearg). At Tolley's asking the priests of Òrd Mhacha<sup>35</sup> at Cathair dhearg, the order of the capital and the crown, bless the Residency's new coin. The priesthood of Macha teaches that the two horses of her rite, Dubh Sainglenn the black and Liath Macha the grey, each have their due; the dissenting priests say the coin is only one of them.
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 86** — *The second change of coin*. The barter goods of the Dia-thìrich are marked down against the humans' coin a second time, on terms the humans' Administration alone sets.

33. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

34. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

35. the order of Macha

- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 86** — *Wool marked down at Baile Mòr fhionn* (Baile Mòr fhionn). At Baile Mòr fhionn, where wool had been the measure of every bargain, a fleece is now worth by the Residency's table what a half-fleece was worth before. The town's weavers stop bringing wool to market and send it over the sea on their own account, until the Company refuses them freight.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, AE 87** — *The boats of Caol fhiadhaich sold* (Caol fhiadhaich). The fishing fleet of Caol fhiadhaich, unable to pay the new harbour dues in marks, sells half its boats to the Company. The men who sailed them go into the pits under the next year's contracts.
- 25 AM MÀRT, AE 87** — *The dissenters go to Cnoc bheag* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>36</sup>). Priests of Macha who refused the blessing leave the capital's temple and settle in the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag. There they keep the older reading of Macha's two horses, and take in custodians who have lost their seats.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, AE 87** — *Iain Maor* (Muileann chrom). Dòmhnall mac Raghnaill Maor dies, and his son Iain takes the overseer's staff. Iain Maor is the first overseer schooled at the Mission; he keeps his reports in the humans' tongue and his household in Dia-thìris.
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 88** — *The Levy* (Ros dhomhain). Tolley issues an ordinance, the Levy, by which every farming village in the west and north must send one in five of its able grown folk to the pits for two years. The villages are paid in marks, at the new rate.
- 3 AM MÀRT, AE 88** — *Levy officers at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). The Levy's officers take their first tally at Caol mhòr in the north-west, reading the names of the chosen from a list in the humans' tongue. The custodians of the town write the names again in Dia-thìris, that they may know whom to look for.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 88** — *The Levy in the north-west* (Muileann àrsaidh). The Levy falls hardest on the villages about Baile chrom and the northern concession, which had never sent crews to the pits. The Dia-thìrich of the concession are taken; its human farmers are spared.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 89** — *Baile ìseal sends its people* (Baile ìseal). Baile ìseal sends forty-one of its people to the pits under the Levy, and nineteen come back when their term ends. The custodians' roll names the other twenty-two and the camps they were sent to.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 89** — *Muileann naomh buys its way out* (Muileann naomh). The custodians of Muileann naomh pay the Levy's officers in silver to halve the town's tally. The officers take the silver and the whole tally. The complaint is lodged at the Residency and filed.
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 89** — *The druid school's hall shut* (Dùn thais). George Tolley shuts the hall of the druid school at Dùn thais over a lecture on whether the humans' blindness to the coal's colour is a kind of sickness. The masters go on teaching in their own houses, to smaller rooms each year.

- 30 AN GIBLEAN, AE 90** — *The last disputation at Doire chiar* (Doire chiar). At Doire chiar, a village of the druid schools north of the eastern workings, the masters hold the last open disputation of the school on the eve of Bealltainn, in the open air on the village threshing-floor. Its matter is whether a question may be forbidden. The Administration's clerk who attends writes that it may.
- 15 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 90** — *Teaching in the sacred forest* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>37</sup>). Druid masters who may no longer teach in a hall begin to teach under the trees in the sacred forest of Flidais near Muileann chiar, where the Administration has no building to shut.
- 14 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 90** — *Building the last beacon at Baile chrom* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>38</sup>). Work begins on the fifth and last beacon, on the north-western headland at Baile chrom, with masons taken by the Levy from the very villages whose fields they leave untilled.
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 91** — *The masons of Cnoc thais* (Cnoc thais). The Levy takes the masons of Cnoc thais to build the beacon at Baile chrom. Their foreman, Dùghall Clachair, cuts the names of his crew into the lintel of the lamp-room, the only writing on any of the five towers.
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 91** — *The five beacons complete* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>39</sup>). The ring of coast beacons is finished: Taigh-solais Baile chrom, Baile iséal, Muileann bheag, Àth dhearg and Tobar dhearg. They serve a trade that is by now plunder in all but name.
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 91** — *Cuan ruadh loses its trade* (Cuan ruadh). The ring of beacons finished, the Company's steamers round the island without putting in, and within a few years the old coasting trade of Cuan ruadh up and down the eastern shore dies.
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 91** — *Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>40</sup> lit* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom). The beacon at Baile chrom is lit with a coal flame, and the ring is whole. The Company's ships can now round the island by night, and the keepers' daybooks show the sailings doubled within a few years.
- 3 AM MÀRT, AE 94** — *Gorta Baile chrom<sup>41</sup>*. The Great Hunger follows a failed harvest across thirty-four settlements, made worse because the Levy has taken so many to the pits that too few are left to till the land.
- I AN GIBLEAN, AE 94** — *Baile chrom goes hungry* (Baile chrom). The hunger is worst at Baile chrom itself, whose people could see the new beacon from their empty fields. The custodians write that more died there than anywhere else, and the Administration, which kept its own count, does not gainsay them.

36. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

37. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

38. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

39. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

40. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

41. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

- 22 AN CÈITEAN, AE 94** — *The famine country* (Gorta Baile chrom<sup>42</sup>). The custodians' roll draws the bounds of the famine country along the north-west shore and the hills behind it. Within them lie Baile chrom in its own shire; Ceann mhòr, Àth fhionn and Àth dhearg in the shire of Ceann mhòr; Muileann àrsaidh in the shire of Cnoc thais; and Achadh àrsaidh in the shire of Muileann àrsaidh. Thirty-four settlements are counted within the line, and the roll gives the dead of each.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, AE 95** — *The hunger at Doire ghlas* (Doire ghlas). At Doire ghlas in the north the hunger takes the old and the very young first. The village sends its young folk to the camps for the Company's rations, and by the year's end it is half empty.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, AE 95** — *Inis mhin eats its seed* (Inis mhin). In the second winter of the hunger the townsfolk of Inis mhin on the north coast eat their seed corn. The Mission kitchen at the harbour feeds three hundred a day for a season.
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 96** — *The hunger reaches Seann Bhrenn* (Seann Bhrenn). The hunger reaches as far east as Seann Bhrenn, where the custodians open the old grain-pits of the Holy Age, unfilled in living memory. They hold only dust.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 96** — *The relief ship* (Ros dhomhain). A relief ship with grain from an Tìr Thall<sup>43</sup> lies a month at Ros dhomhain while the Residency and the Company dispute who shall pay for its unloading. Meanwhile the Mission opens kitchens at Cathair gheal and Baile chrom, and Anne Colby, come back to the island, keeps the one at Baile chrom.
- 20 AN GEARRAN, AE 97** — *The Levy set aside* (Baile chrom). The Levy is set aside in the famine districts, too late for the harvest. It is not repealed. The custodians note that it was never used again, nor needed to be, for the villages had learned what it meant.
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 97** — *Cnoc mhòr walks south* (Cnoc mhòr). Rather than starve, the families of Cnoc mhòr in the north walk south to the camps and take work under the Company. Their village stands empty for a generation.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 98** — *Robert Haskins Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). George Tolley retires with honours. Robert Haskins, who follows him, orders that the custodians' council be consulted on the tithe, and then sets the tithe before the council has met.
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 98** — *Customs at Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). Haskins opens a customs house at Seann Dunn on the eastern coast, and a Company store with it. The store sells the east its seed and its tools, and within a few years its ledgers hold the debts of half the district.
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 99** — *The first petition*. For the first time the custodians of the Dia-thìrich act together, and not settlement by settlement, and lay a written grievance before the humans' Administration. It is not answered.

42. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

43. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 3 AM MÀRT, AE 99** — *The gathering at Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). The petition was drawn up at Ceann àrsaidh by custodians of nineteen settlements, meeting for the first time as one body. Peigi Ghlas, custodian of Cill ghlas, carried it to the Residency and handed it to a clerk.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 99** — *Àth fhionn signs* (Àth fhionn). Ruairidh mac Thormoid, custodian of Àth fhionn in the south-east, is the eldest of those who signed the petition. He was born before the humans' coin was struck, and says so beside his name.
- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 101** — *Grievance first written*. From these years come the oldest writings of grievance among the Dia-thìrich that survive. No hand is yet raised in them; yet in them it is first written that something has gone wrong.
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 101** — *Leabhar Baile thais*<sup>44</sup> (Baile thais). The oldest of them is a book of complaints kept at Baile thais, set down by many hands over some years: wages, deaths, the granary, the stream at Doire mhòr. The custodians' copyists call it Leabhar Baile thais.
- 17 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 102** — *The songs of Fearchar Bàrd* (Muileann dhearg). The poet Fearchar Bàrd, a breaker of coal at Muileann dhearg since boyhood, makes songs of the Levy and the famine, and they are sung in the camps. The overseers forbid them, and because they were forbidden several were written down.
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 102** — *Songs at An Taigh-òsta Grianach*<sup>45</sup> (An Taigh-òsta Grianach). The songs of Fearchar Bàrd are sung in the roadside houses of the east, and An Taigh-òsta Grianach becomes known for them. The Company's carters sing them too, the keeper writes, not always knowing what they sing.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, AE 103** — *The Company's deep-water quay* (Ros dhomhain). The Company builds at Ros dhomhain a deep-water quay for the new iron steamships, which burn the island's own coal to carry it away. Fearchar Bàrd makes a song of that, the most quoted of all his songs.
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 103** — *The deep quay at Ceann chaol* (Ceann chaol). A second deep-water quay is built at Ceann chaol in the south-east for the eastern coal. Its builders are brought from the coast, and the village of forty houses becomes a town of four hundred.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 104** — *Baile thais walls its pithead* (Baile thais). The Company rings the pithead at Baile thais with a stone wall and a gate, and pays a watchman to count who goes in. It is the first working on Dia-thìr walled against its own crews.
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 104** — *Catriona nic Eachainn dies at the silver town* (Baile thais). Catriona nic Eachainn dies at Muileann chiar, a refiner of the silver guild to the end. The camp folk of Baile thais send men to her burying, and the Company docks each of them a day's pay.

<sup>44</sup>. the book of Baile thais, the book of grievances

<sup>45</sup>. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

- 4 AN GIBLEAN, AE 105** — *The quay fire* (Ros dhomhain). A fire starts in the Company's coal sheds at Ros dhomhain and burns three days, taking two streets of the harbour quarter with it. The Company's inquiry finds no cause; the harbour quarter's own account has several.
- 22 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 105** — *The council without a high custodian* (Cathair dhearg). After the death of the last high custodian the Council of Custodians cannot agree on another, and sits for years with the seat empty. Robert Haskins writes to an Tìr Thall<sup>46</sup> that this makes the council easier to deal with.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 106** — *Tìormachd Achadh shean*<sup>47</sup>. The Long Drought lies on the island's dry season three years together, and bears hard on a people already worn thin by the tallies of the pits.
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 107** — *The wells of Achadh shean* (Achadh shean). At Achadh shean, whose name the drought bears, the wells fail in the second summer, and the cattle are driven west in a column the roll calls a day long. Fewer than half reach water.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 107** — *The dry country* (Tìormachd Achadh shean<sup>48</sup>). The custodians' roll counts ten districts of the east as drought country, worst at Achadh shean, Àth uaine, Achadh àrsaidh and Muileann chiar, and reaching down to Cuan ruadh and west toward Baile chaol. The Administration keeps no count of its own.
- 6 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 107** — *The cattle of Baile chaol* (Baile chaol). At Baile chaol the herds are slaughtered in the second summer of the drought, rather than watched as they die. The salt meat is sold to the Company for the camps, at a price the Company names.
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 107** — *Doire fhionn walks for water* (Doire fhionn). At Doire fhionn in the east the women walk each day to the spring at Àth ruadh and back for water, half a day's journey. The custodians record it for the three dry years, and then cease.
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, AE 108** — *Pilgrims at Allt an Àigh*<sup>49</sup> (Allt an Àigh). The spring of Allt an Àigh, said never to have failed, runs on through all three dry years. Pilgrims who keep Na Seann Spioradan<sup>50</sup> come to it from all the east, the first of them at Bealltainn, and the Administration sets a watchman to charge them for the water. He is called back after one season.
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, AE 108** — *The pilgrims' road at Inis uaine* (Inis uaine). Pilgrims bound for Allt an Àigh<sup>51</sup> gather at Inis uaine, and the townsfolk feed them freely, as the Old Spirits require. The town's own wells are low, and it gives away more water than it keeps.

46. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

47. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

48. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

49. the stream of the healing water

50. the Old Spirits

51. the stream of the healing water

- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 109** — *Drought-fever at Baile Mòr ruadh* (Baile Mòr ruadh). A fever of foul water follows the drought into the towns, worst at Baile Mòr ruadh, where the wells had been deepened into the old middens. Two hundred and sixty die. The Mission's report is the first to name the cause rightly.
- 3 AN CÈITEAN, AE 109** — *The fever at Cnoc shean* (Cnoc shean). The drought-fever spreads to Cnoc shean, whose one well is found tainted. The custodians close it, and for a year the town drinks from carts.
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 109** — *The Mission's wells* (Achadh shean). The Mission sinks deep wells at Achadh shean and Àth chrom with a boring-rig brought from an Tìr Thall<sup>52</sup>, and they hold. The custodians of the east set down the Mission's wells and the Company's tallies on facing pages, without comment.
- 16 AM MÀRT, AE 110** — *Achadh chaol goes to the pits* (Achadh chaol). Their fields burned out by the drought, the people of Achadh chaol in the north-east go to the pits for wages, the first villagers of the eastern farm country to do so. Their custodian writes it down as the end of the village, not a fitting.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 110** — *The tally not lowered* (Baile Mòr dhìreach). The coal tally is not lowered in the drought. The custodians of the east, their joint petition unanswered, each write to Haskins alone; to each he answers that the matter is under consideration.
- 3 AN GEARRAN, AE 111** — *The petition of Àth mhòr* (Àth mhòr). Iseabail nic Leòid, custodian of Àth mhòr, writes the longest of the single petitions, forty pages listing her town's dead beasts. Haskins answers in two lines. Both survive, bound together by a later clerk.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, AE 111** — *The first inheritance of mixed blood*. A suit over whether the grandchild of a marriage between a Dia-thìreach and a human may inherit the customary rights of mining is decided, and the Administration makes the ruling wholly to its own gain.
- 4 AM MÀRT, AE 111** — *The case of Thomas Hale* (Ros dhomhain). The child was Thomas Hale, grandson of the marriage at Baile dhìreach of Eilidh nic Ruairidh and Samuel Hale, who claimed a share in a customary cutting through his Dia-thìrich grandmother. Oliver Dunstan, magistrate at Ros dhomhain, ruled that customary rights descend only through the line the Administration owns, and that it owns only its own.
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, AE 112** — *Dunstan's rule applied* (Ros dhomhain). Within a few years Dunstan's ruling is used to pass eleven customary cuttings to the Company, each because some holder in the line had married a human or been born of one. The custodians stop entering such marriages in the roll.
- 25 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 113** — *A cutting at Cnoc dhubh taken* (Cnoc dhubh). Among the cuttings taken under Dunstan's rule is the old customary working at Cnoc dhubh, held by one family since the Holy Age. A great-grandmother of the line had married a human sailor; that is enough.

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52. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 113** — *The Lamp-Watch* (Baile thais). A fellowship of pit crews calling itself the Lamp-Watch begins to meet at Baile thais and Cnoc chaol under cover of a burial club. Its first known deed is to pay for the burying of an old breaker who had died in the Company's lock-up.
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 114** — *Edward Vane Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Robert Haskins is called home after a quarrel with the Company over the price of steamship berths, and Edward Vane follows him. Vane is the first Commissioner born on Dia-thìr, at the Residency, and he speaks Dia-thìris, badly, but he speaks it.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 115** — *The tram-road to Ros dhìreach* (Ros dhìreach). Vane lays an iron tram-road, drawn by mules, from the southern workings down to the coal port at Ros dhìreach. It halves the cost of shipping coal, and ends the carting trade of the villages on the old road.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 116** — *The night-shift order*. For the first time the digging is made to run without ceasing, day and night, and the mountain is given no season of rest at all.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 116** — *The night crews at Cnoc chaol* (Cnoc chaol). The order falls first on Cnoc chaol, where the Company's newest galleries are opened to crews working by coal-lamp in two shifts. The custodians' roll writes that the hill was given no silence at all, and leaves the rest of the page blank.
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 117** — *The night-shift strike* (Cnoc chaol). The crews at Cnoc chaol refuse the night shift, and within a week are replaced by crews brought from the coast under the Company's new contracts. The Lamp-Watch keeps the strikers' families for a season, and then its money is gone.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 117** — *The strikebreakers of Muileann dhombhain* (Muileann dhomhain). The crews that replace the strikers at Cnoc chaol are brought through Muileann dhomhain, where the townsfolk turn them from every door. They sleep in the Company's barns, and several go home the next season.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 118** — *Matthew Dunne's sermon* (Ros dhomhain). Matthew Dunne, the Mission's minister at Ros dhomhain, preaches against the night-shift order from the chapel pulpit, saying the Dia-thìrich are right that even the ground must rest. The Company complains to the Mission, and Dunne is called back to an Tìr Thall<sup>53</sup>. The Lamp-Watch copies the sermon and reads it in the camps.
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 119** — *The lung-rot at Cnoc chaol* (Cnoc chaol). A wasting sickness of the lungs spreads among the night crews at Cnoc chaol and Baile thais. Unlike the Green Death it kills slowly. The Company pays the widows a pension for a year, then stops.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 119** — *Iain Maor and the night shift* (Muileann chrom). Iain Maor, overseer at Muileann chrom, writes to the Company that the night shift is killing his crews faster than it is paying for them. The letter survives because the Company filed it with his dismissal, which was undone a month later for want of anyone else.

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53. the land beyond, the humans' homeland



- 22 AM MÀRT, AE 120** — *The coal line* (Muileann chrom). The Company opens its railway from the pits at Muileann chrom down by Cathair dhearg to the deep-water quay at Ros dhomhain. Its engines burn the island's own coal, as the steamships do, and the tram-road to Ros dhireach is left to the mules. Within a year the carters' guild of Doire chaol, which had hauled the coal on Rathad na Mèinne<sup>54</sup> for eighty years, loses the long haul. From the first day the Dia-thìrich call the engine carbad-iarainn, the iron chariot, and the railway the coal line.
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, AE 120** — *Coal-lamps from Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). The potteries of Baile ghorm take a contract for clay lamp-bodies for the night crews, thousands in a year. The potters' own book notes that they are the first lamps made on the island for work in the dark by command.
- 21 AN GEARRAN, AE 121** — *Fionnan born*. A second child is born bound to the coal as Aisling was, half a century after her. So it is known that the thing is no chance of one birth: it comes of the digging, and it will go on.
- 19 AN CÈITEAN, AE 122** — *The Administration's count of the people* (Ros dhomhain). The Administration counts the people of Dia-thìr by district for the first time. Its figures for the humans are true to the household; for the Dia-thìrich they are rounded to the hundred, and in the hill districts to the thousand.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, AE 123** — *The district of the outer coasts* (Seann Vell). The Administration makes the outer coasts one district and rules it from the harbour office at Seann Vell on Eilean ruadh, where its revenue cutters lie: the islands of the west and south, Eilean bhàn with Cuan dhearg and Cnoc chaol, and the southern edge of the windy coast in the far north-west. Its surveyors walk to the edge of the great moss there, which no chain can cross, and go no farther. Beyond it the district map is left blank.
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 123** — *Seònaid nic Dhùghaill, last of the druid masters* (Dùn thais). Seònaid nic Dhùghaill, the last master of Scoiltean nan Draoidhean<sup>55</sup> to teach openly in this age, dies at Dùn thais. No one is named after her, and the school's register ends with her death. It is taken up again only long after the humans are gone.
- 5 AM MÀRT, AE 124** — *The custodians' rolls at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). The custodians of the east begin to send copies of their rolls for safe keeping to the town of Muileann chaol, which still kept Beathag nic Thòmais's loft of papers, beyond the Residency's reach. The copying is done in the houses of three families, and the copies kept in a cellar.
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 125** — *The second Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). Some of the copies bound for Muileann chaol go by mistake to the smaller town of that name further north, and are kept there for years before the mistake is found. The custodians note that they were kept just as well.

- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 126** — *The word found at last.* With two children now known, the custodians agree on a word for what is befalling them: fuil-ghuail<sup>56</sup>, "coal-blood", rendered in the humans' tongue as coal-touched. It is meant as a physician's word. It outlives that meaning.
- 21 AN GEARRAN, AE 126** — *The custodians who named it* (Cill ghlas). The word was agreed at a meeting of custodians at the shrine of Cill ghlas, where the oldest cutting still stood open. They chose a plain word, fit for the physician's book. The roll gives the vote; who first put the word forward it does not say.
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 126** — *The Line of Aisling found* (Muileann chaol). Cailean mac Eachainn, a copyist in the cellar at Muileann chaol, finds in the roll of the camp at Àth iséal the marriage of Aisling's father, Donnchadh mac Thormoid, with his line written seven names back, as the custodians write a marriage. He carries the seven names up to Tobar dhìreach, to Ealasaid of Clann na Ceiste<sup>57</sup>, the last who says the lines, and she knows them for the line of Somhairle son of Ailean Mòr. She says Aisling's line to him backward, from her father to the mason who found the fire. So what the camps whispered at Aisling's birth is found to be true. Cailean writes the line in the margin beside her birth.
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 127** — *The Administration's register* (Ros dhomhain). The Residency, hearing of the word, orders that any Dia-thìreach child showing the change be reported to the Commissioner's office. The custodians obey by reporting none.
- 7 AN GIBLEAN, AE 129** — *The third change of coin.* The old barter of the Dia-thìrich is struck down as lawful payment altogether. Every bargain on the island now goes by the humans' coin.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 129** — *The barter houses closed* (Ros dhomhain). The barter houses at Ros dhomhain and Cathair dhearg, where cloth and fish had changed hands without coin since before the Crossing, are shut by order. A clerk of the Residency writes that the ledgers are now "complete for the first time."
- 22 AM MÀRT, AE 130** — *The fishwives of Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). The fishwives of Inis mhòr, who had sold by barter at the river steps since before the Crossing, will take no coin for a week, in protest at the shutting of the barter houses, and give their fish away. The Company's clerks record it as a glut.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 130** — *Marks borrowed at interest* (Cathair dhearg). Barter being struck down, the hill villages borrow marks at interest from the Company's stores to buy seed. Within a few years most of the villages of Muileann chrom owe the Company more than a year's crops.

54. the mine road

55. the druid schools

56. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

57. the Children of the Question

- 20 AN GIBLEAN, AE 131** — *The old market at Muileann òg* (Muileann òg). The old barter market at Muileann òg, where hill and coast had met to trade since the Holy Age, closes after its last season, and the ground stands empty.
- 12 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 131** — *Mòrag nic Iain Maor* (Muileann chrom). Iain Maor dies, and his daughter Mòrag takes the overseer's staff at Muileann chrom, the first woman to hold it. The Company approves her in a letter that calls her "a safe pair of hands."
- 24 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 132** — *Charles Merriman Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Edward Vane dies at the Residency. Charles Merriman comes after him with a small company of armed constables, the first standing force the Administration has kept on Dia-thìr.
- 11 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 132** — *The constable post at Muileann shean* (Muileann shean). Merri-man's first constable post is built at Muileann shean on the northern coal road, a stone house with a yard for horses. The townsfolk call it the humans' second Residency, and do not mean it kindly.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 133** — *A barracks at Tobar ghorm* (Tobar ghorm). A second post is raised at Tobar ghorm, near the northern workings. The village's custodian is paid rent for the ground, and with it buys the village out of its debts to the Company store.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 133** — *A grey-night vigil at Baile chrom* (Baile chrom). The Mission at Cathair gheal reports that human labourers near Baile chrom keep vigil by night in the fields, praying in silence under the sign of a grey goose, which they call the wild goose of the Spirit. The Mission cannot find whence the practice came, and calls it irregular, a superstition learned of the Dia-thìrich. The Dia-thìrich of Baile chrom disown it.
- 21 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 133** — *Manannan's priests on the grey night* (Ceann mhòr). The priests of Òrd Mhanannain<sup>58</sup> at Ceann mhòr answer the Mission's report of the grey-night vigils. The practice owes something to the Dia-thìrich, they say, but to their own harbours and not to Baile chrom: the human fishing families of Ceann mhòr learned from them the night prayer to keep the sea shut, and the labourers inland keep it as a vigil of their Church, a night of silence under the wild goose of the Spirit in place of a prayer to Manannan. The priests call it Manannan's prayer gone astray, and do not admit its keepers to their house.
- 1 AN GIBLEAN, AE 134** — *The dockers' strike at Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). The dockers of Ros dhomhain, Dia-thìrich and human alike, refuse to load coal for nine days over the new berth charges. It is the only strike of the age in which human workers stand with Dia-thìrich. Merriman's constables break it, and the human dockers are shipped over the sea.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, AE 134** — *Seann Vell's dockers stay out* (Seann Vell). The dockers of Seann Vell, the harbour next to Ros dhomhain, refuse to load the coal sent to them during the strike. When it ends they are not shipped over the sea, for there are no humans among them; but they are not hired again either.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, AE 134** — *Lorccan born*. A third such child is born, in a mining town and not a camp; the thing is no longer bound to any one place.

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58. the order of Manannan

- 3 AM MÀRT, AE 135** — *Cian born*. A fourth is born within a year of the third. Never again do the children of the undying generation come so close together.
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 136** — *Blasting-powder at Cill ghlàs* (Cill ghlàs). The Company begins to drive galleries under the hills about Cill ghlàs with blasting-powder shipped from an Tìr Thall<sup>59</sup>. The custodians of the shrine ask that no charge be set within sight of the old cutting. The Company's engineer marks their asking on his plan, and sets the charges below it.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, AE 136** — *Powder landed at Caol iséal* (Caol iséal). The blasting-powder for the new galleries is landed at Caol iséal on the northern coast, away from the crowded southern harbours, and carted inland under guard. The town's custodians ask what is in the barrels and are told it is lamp-oil.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 137** — *Scàineadh Cill ghlàs*<sup>60</sup>. The Rending: in the hills east of the capital, about Cill ghlàs, the earth tears open along a fault beneath a common working. Dozens are killed, and a whole mining district is shut for a generation.
- 17 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 137** — *The first open fight*. A mining death, which the Dia-thìrich workers lay at the door of the humans' carelessness, leads to the first bloodshed between the two peoples.
- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 137** — *The shrine at Cill ghlàs lost* (Cill ghlàs). The Rending swallows the old cutting at Cill ghlàs, where the custodians had kept the rites through all the age, and its shrine with it. The custodians' roll sets down the loss of the shrine before the loss of the dead; a later copyist has put them in the other order.
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 137** — *The district closed* (Scàineadh Cill ghlàs<sup>61</sup>). The Company shuts the whole district of the Rending and fences it, leaving Cill ghlàs, Àth chaol and their hamlets in the shires of Muileann dhearg and Muileann chiorach without work. The villages empty toward Baile thais and Muileann dhearg, and the closed district is left to the thorn.
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 137** — *The meeting on the moor road* (Coinneachadh an Fhearainn<sup>62</sup>). The folk turned out of the closed district send their eldest to the custodians of Muileann dhomhain, who meet them at a standing stone on the moor road below the town, lest the Company's clerks see them in the town hall. At the stone the custodians lend them the land at the edge of the fenced ground. The place is called Coinneachadh an Fhearainn, the meeting of the land.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 137** — *Achadh chaol raised by the dispossessed* (Achadh chaol). Folk of the closed district build a new village at Achadh chaol, at the edge of the fenced ground, on land lent by the custodians of Muileann dhomhain. It is the only settlement of the age founded by Dia-thìrich for Dia-thìrich with no Company surveyor's hand in it.

<sup>59</sup> the land beyond, the humans' homeland

<sup>60</sup> the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlàs'

- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 137** — *The fight at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The death that began it was a flooded gallery at Muileann chrom, where seven died after the pumps were stopped to save fuel. When the Company's agent came to the pithead the crews stoned him and his constables, and the constables fired. Four Dia-thìrich and one constable were killed.
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 138** — *Mòrag Maor at the inquiry* (Muileann chrom). At the Administration's inquiry into the fight the overseer Mòrag nic Iain Maor bears witness that the pumps were stopped on the agent's order. Her words are struck out. The Lamp-Watch gets a copy of them all the same.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, AE 138** — *The grey fever* (Baile thais). A fever of the chest comes in on the ships and runs over the whole island, from the capital to the eastern farms. It kills the young and strong more than the old, the Mission notes in alarm. The camps, already hungry, bury more than the towns.
- 14 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 138** — *The grey fever at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). At Cathair mhòr the grey fever shuts the market for the first time in the town's memory. The custodians' roll gives the dead by street, and the longest list is of the street where the carters lived.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 138** — *The grey fever at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). At Dùn thais the fever takes the physician the Administration sent to treat it, and two of the Mission's nurses. The old houses of the druid masters are opened as sick-rooms.
- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 139** — *The second petition*. This one carries a threat beneath its words, not a plea. It is the first writing of the Dia-thìrich the Administration troubles to answer, and it answers with more guards, not with concessions.
- 12 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 139** — *The signatories of Cnoc dhìreach* (Cnoc dhìreach). Coinneach Ruadh, custodian of Cnoc dhìreach, signs the second petition, and in the same week is turned out of his post as clerk to the Company store. He is one of eleven who sign and lose Company work for it.
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 139** — *Eilidh nic Raghnaill* (Baile thais). The second petition was drawn up by Eilidh nic Raghnaill, a crew-leader of Baile thais and one of the Lamp-Watch, and signed by custodians and crew-leaders of thirty-one settlements. It ends with a sentence the Residency underlined: that the hill would not be worked by people who were not asked.
- 25 AN GEARRAN, AE 140** — *The constables tripled* (Ros dhomhain). Merriman answers by tripling the constables and posting companies at Muileann chrom, Baile thais, Ceann fhada and Cnoc chaol, each with a walled store. The constables are paid from the tithe.
- 26 AM MÀRT, AE 140** — *Barracks at Dùn chrom* (Dùn chrom). A barracks for the constables is built at Dùn chrom, on the capital side of the hills, with room for two hundred men. For most of its first year it stands empty, for want of constables to fill it.

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61. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

- 24 AN GIBLEAN, AE 140** — *Iòmhbar Seabhag* (Seann Skell). At Seann Skell the hawk-priest Iòmhbar Seabhag preaches that Mòd's hunger has turned on those who have eaten the hill. The hawk-shrines of the west begin to serve as meeting-houses for the Lamp-Watch, and the constables do not yet know it.
- 23 AN CÈITEAN, AE 140** — *The hawk-faithful of Ros gheal* (Ros gheal). At Ros gheal the hawk-faithful fishing families, who had chased out the Company's customs officers a century before, raise a shrine to Mòd on the harbour wall. The constables order it down. It is built again three times in a single season.
- 21 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 140** — *The hawk and the druids at Inis bhàn* (Inis bhàn). At Inis bhàn the priests of the hawk and a few who still keep the questions of the druid school in private meet for a disputation, the first between them in living memory. It is written that it settled nothing, and that both sides afterwards signed the petition.
- 20 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 140** — *The grey fever in the north-west* (Baile chrom). The grey fever returns and settles in the north-west, about Baile chrom and the towns of the concession, where it kills humans as readily as Dia-thìrich. The Mission's hospital at Cathair gheal overflows, and for the first time Dia-thìrich and human sick lie in the same wards.
- 6 AM MÀRT, AE 141** — *Muileann fhionn shut in* (Muileann fhionn). Muileann fhionn, a Dia-thìreach mill town in the north-west, shuts its roads against the fever and keeps them shut for a season. Human carters of the concession are turned back with their loads at the town's edge.
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, AE 141** — *The fever at Tobar fhiadhaich* (Tobar fhiadhaich). At Tobar fhiadhaich in the north the fever takes one household in three. The custodians of the village burn no huts; they had heard of Àth ghlas in their grandparents' time, but judge it too late.
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 141** — *The road-houses make ready* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). The road-houses along the old mining roads begin to serve as waystations for bands of armed men. The roads make ready for a war not yet declared.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 141** — *An Taigh-seinnse Òir*<sup>62</sup> (An Taigh-seinnse Òir). An Taigh-seinnse Òir, the great house on the eastern road beyond Dùn dhearg, digs a well in its yard and builds a wall round the well. The keeper tells the Company's carters it is against thieves.
- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 141** — *An Leòmhann Buidhe*<sup>63</sup> (An Leòmhann Buidhe). An Leòmhann Buidhe, the road-house on the northern road through the druid country, takes on six new ostlers in a single season, none of whom know anything of horses.
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 142** — *An Taigh-òsta Grianach*<sup>64</sup> walled (An Taigh-òsta Grianach). An Taigh-òsta Grianach, called the singing house since the songs of Fearchar Bàrd, raises a wall round its yard and sets a watch on its gate.

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62. the meeting of the crews on the moor

63. the golden house, a waypoint inn

64. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

65. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 142** — *Am Buabhall Fortanach barred* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Am Buabhall Fortanach, the great road-house on the south-western road, bars its gates at dusk and keeps a watch on the roof. Its keeper, Tormod Buabhall, keeps a list of travellers and sends it up the road each week, to whom is not told.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 142** — *The harbour of Doire shean* (Doire shean). The little harbour of Doire shean, below Am Buabhall Fortanach, becomes the landing for the goods the house cannot take by road. The fishermen of Doire shean are paid in silver from the east.
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 142** — *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). At An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the northern road the stables are rebuilt with a loft for sleeping men. The Company's carters mark that the loft is never empty, and never holds the same men twice.
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 142** — *An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>66</sup>* (An Sligeanach Fad' às). An Sligeanach Fad' às, on the eastern road near the silver country, becomes the post-house through which the Lamp-Watch sends word from the camps to Muileann chiar. The silver guild pays its keeper's rent.
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 142** — *The runners of Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). Runners from Àth fhiadhaich carry the Lamp-Watch's letters from An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>67</sup> to the silver town. They are boys of twelve and thirteen, too young for the constables to stop.
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 143** — *Achadh mhòr keeps the ledgers* (Achadh mhòr). The Lamp-Watch's ledgers of the money it has from the silver guild are kept at Achadh mhòr, a village near the house on the eastern road, in the roof of the village shrine.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, AE 143** — *Seònaid's house* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, the carters' house on the coal road that Seònaid Bhàn opened again in the early years of the digging, is kept now by her great-grandson Aonghas. It is the busiest of the walled houses, the one the constables search most often and find least in.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *The first stoppage together*. For the first time the mining country stops work on one day in many places at once. Scattered as it is, the resistance of the Diathirich can act as one when it chooses.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *Muileann bheag in the north-east* (Muileann bheag). The workings at Muileann bheag in the north-east, among the druid villages, stop with the rest. The town's custodian writes that it is the first thing the town has done with the hills in a hundred years.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *The northern pits at Àth dhombhain* (Àth dhombhain). The pits north of the hills at Àth dhombhain stop with the rest on the day of the stoppage, the word brought by a runner and not by the beacon. Their crew-leaders are among those shipped over the sea.

66. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

67. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *Ceann bheag stops* (Ceann bheag). The coal stage at Ceann bheag on the northern coast stops loading the same day. Its dockers had not been told; they stop because the coal stops coming.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *The quarrymen of Cnoc gheal* (Cnoc gheal). The quarrymen of Cnoc gheal in the north-east, who cut stone for the Company's buildings, lay down their tools on the day of the stoppage unasked. Why, no one says.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *The day the pits stopped* (Muileann chrom). On the day of the stoppage every working in the Muileann chrom district halted at once, and with them Baile thais, Cnoc chaol, the silver town and the eastern pits at Ros fhionn. The sign was a beacon fire lit on the hills above Doire mhòr, which the Company took for a heath fire.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 143** — *The coal ships wait* (Ros dhomhain). The Company's steamships lie six days at Ros dhomhain with empty holds. The agents at the quay write that they have never seen the harbour so quiet, and that it frightened them more than the crowds.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 143** — *The stoppage broken* (Ros dhomhain). The stoppage ends when the constables shut the Company stores in every district at once. Forty crew-leaders are taken; thirty-two are let go without charge, and eight are shipped over the sea to an Tìr Thall<sup>68</sup> for trial and never heard of again.
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 144** — *Beacon hill at Doire mhòr* (Doire mhòr). Doire mhòr, which refused the first contract and then lost its water, has by now but a few households. The beacon of the stoppage was lit on its hill by the children's children of Beathag Dhubh's people, and the constables burn the heather of the hill to deny it to them.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 144** — *Fewer ships from over the sea* (Muir Mhanannain<sup>69</sup>). The keepers' daybooks at the five beacons show fewer ships from an Tìr Thall<sup>70</sup> each year, and the ships that come are older. The Company's letters speak of troubles at home and do not say what they are.
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, AE 145** — *Caol leathan's idle harbour* (Caol leathan). At Caol leathan the wool for the humans' market waits for room in ships that do not come. The merchants of the town begin to sell their wool inland again by barter, against the law.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 145** — *Caol bheag's empty quay* (Caol bheag). The Company's quay at Caol bheag on the northern coast, built for the eastern trade, sees one ship in a season. The Company's agent there writes that he has been forgotten.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 146** — *Leave no longer asked*. The humans' Administration begins to give commands without seeking the counsel of the Dia-thìrich at all. The pretence of leave asked and given is dropped.

68. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

69. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

70. the land beyond, the humans' homeland



- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 146** — *Lionel Strake Commissioner* (Ros dhomhain). Charles Merri-man leaves Dia-thìr in ill health, and Lionel Strake, a soldier, comes after him. His commis-sion, read aloud at the Residency, makes no mention of the Council of Custodians, and he does not call on it.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, AE 147** — *The council locked out* (Cathair dhearg). Strake has the council hall at Cathair dhearg locked and its keys lodged at the Residency. The custodians meet instead in Macha's temple, whose priests, who had blessed the humans' coin, now shelter those who petitioned against it.
- 27 AM MÀRT, AE 147** — *The iron bird* (Ros dhomhain). Strake brings a flying machine from an Tìr Thall<sup>71</sup> in the hold of a Company steamship and has it flown from a field above the Residency over the coal country, to count the workings from the air. The Dia-thìrich call it eun-iarainn, the iron bird. The custodians enter it in the roll as the first thing seen over Dia-thìr that flew and was not alive.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 147** — *The edict of seizure*. The humans' Administration claims the right to take any dwelling of the Dia-thìrich it deems needful for the widening of the work-ings. Of all the grievances it is the one most often named in every surviving account of what followed.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 147** — *The seizure of Doire mhòr* (Doire mhòr). The first dwellings taken under the edict are those of Doire mhòr, for a new shaft beneath the hill, and con-stables carry out the last households. The village that refused the first contract is the first emptied by the last.
- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, AE 147** — *Evictions at Baile dhombhain* (Baile dhomhain). At Baile dhom-hain, the first camp laid out on paper, two streets are pulled down for a spoil-tip. The famil-ies are offered huts at Àth ìseal and marks for their timber; most go to kin in the hill villages instead.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 148** — *Mòrag Maor lays down the staff* (Muileann chrom). Mòrag nic Iain Maor, fourth of her line to hold the overseer's staff at Muileann chrom, will not carry out evictions in her district, and breaks the staff at the Company's door. Three other over-seers give up their places in the same month, and the Company puts humans in them.
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 148** — *The silver guild arms* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The silver guild of Muileann chiar, still holding its seam under the compact of a century be-fore, begins to buy rifles through the eastern pirates. Its ledger enters them as refining tools.
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 148** — *Rifles by way of the pirates* (Spùinneadairean-mara). The silver guild's rifles come ashore from the raiders' boats in the eastern waters, where no Company gunboat has sailed for years. The raiders take their pay in bar silver, by weight.

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71. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 148** — *The council in the forest of Cnoc bheag* (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>72</sup>). Custodians, crew-leaders of the Lamp-Watch and the dissenting priests of Macha meet in the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag and make one council for the mining country, and choose Eilidh nic Raghnaill to speak for it. No human writing records the meeting.
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 149** — *The order to seize* (Ros dhomhain). Strake orders the taking of Eilidh nic Raghnaill and the members of the forest council. The constables go to Baile thais and find the house empty and the town silent.
- 20 AN GEARRAN, AE 149** — *War*. The Dia-thirich, acting together across the whole mining country for the first time, pass from grievance to open war.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, AE 149** — *The stores taken at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The war opens in the hills. At Muileann chrom crews under Mòrag nic Iain rush the walled store at first light, and its eleven constables yield without a shot. The rifles and the grain of the store are carried off before noon.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 149** — *The quay at Ceann fhada seized* (Ceann fhada). Crews from the camps take the Company's coal quay at Ceann fhada and sink two barges across its mouth. No coal leaves the hills by water again in this age.
- 1 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 149** — *The siege of the store at Baile thais* (Baile thais). At Baile thais the constables hold their walled pithead against the town for eleven days, as long as the first strike a lifetime before, and yield on the twelfth when their water fails. Eilidh nic Raghnaill sends them under guard to the coast unharmed. The Residency did not look for such mercy, and did not return it.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 149** — *The crews meet on the moor* (Coinneachadh a' Mhonaidh<sup>73</sup>). Crew-leaders of Baile gharbh and the other northern pits meet by night on the moor above Cnoc naomh and fix the week of their rising. Each brings a stone of spoil from his own pit, and the stones are left in a cairn. The place is called Coinneachadh a' Mhonaidh, the meeting of the moor.
- 30 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 149** — *The northern pits rise* (Baile gharbh). The crews at Baile gharbh and the northern pits rise in the same week, take the constable posts at Muileann shean and Tobar gorm, and send the constables south on foot.
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 149** — *The coal road cut* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). Aonghas, keeper of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, shuts the gates of the house across the coal road, and the men in its loft come down armed. The road between the capital and the hills is cut at its half-way stage, and stays cut.
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 149** — *Uilleam Gobha's forge* (Muileann dhearg). At Muileann dhearg the smith Uilleam Gobha makes the Company's own blasting-powder into grenades cased in tin from the coal sheds, and forges pike-heads from rails torn up in the galleries. The rebels' council writes that without him it could not have fought its first season.

72. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

73. the meeting on the moor road

- 18 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 149** — *The capital rises* (Cathair dhearg). At Cathair dhearg the custodians break the Residency's locks on their council hall and sit in it again. The townsfolk hold Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>74</sup> against the constables sent up from the harbour, and barricade the bridge built for the coal-carts with the carts themselves.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 149** — *Cathair dhomhain joins* (Cathair dhomhain). At Cathair dhomhain the townsfolk break open the Company's warehouse, the first building on Dia-thìr the Company ever owned, and carry off its tools for the council's companies.
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 149** — *Muileann mhin takes sides* (Muileann mhin). At Muileann mhin, a river port just east of the capital, the townsfolk argue for three days, and then send boats to the council. Through the winter the boats carry food down the Abhainn fhionn to the capital.
- 27 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 149** — *The Residency fortified* (Ros dhomhain). Lionel Strake draws the Administration back into the Residency above Ros dhomhain and fortifies the Company's quarter of the harbour. The city below, Dia-thìrich almost to a man, neither joins the rising nor withstands it, and the constables do not trust it enough to leave the walls.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 149** — *The fight at the ford of Àth chiar* (Àth chiar). A column of constables and Company guards under Major Peter Ashdown marches up the coal road to relieve the hills, and is met at the ford of Àth chiar, where the rebels hold the far bank. Ashdown loses forty men and his baggage and turns back. The rebels lose nineteen, and the council's roll names them all.
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 150** — *Ashdown's retreat through Dùn chrom* (Dùn chrom). Ashdown's column falls back through Dùn chrom and lies a night at the barracks there. In the morning the town has shut its gates behind them, and the column goes on to the coast without its wounded, whom the townsfolk keep and nurse.
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 150** — *The silver town rises* (Muileann chiar). The silver guild of Muileann chiar declares for the council and opens its armoury, and the Company's agents in the town are escorted to the coast with their papers. The guild's ledger notes that here alone the rising took nothing, for the humans had never held anything there to take.
- 17 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 150** — *The surrender at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). The small constable post at Dùn ìseal, cut off by the rising at the silver town, yields to the silver guild's riflemen after a single exchange of fire. The east of the island is clear of human arms.
- 27 AM FAOILLEACH, AE 150** — *Dùn dhearg declares* (Dùn dhearg). The custodians of Dùn dhearg declare for the council and send it grain. Theirs is the town whose custodian wrote the only surviving defence of the Small-Burning Law, and their declaration quotes it.
- 1 AN GEARRAN, AE 150** — *Cnoc leathan's riflemen* (Cnoc leathan). Riflemen raised at Cnoc leathan in the east join the silver guild's companies and hold the eastern road. The Company's carters on the road are let go home with their carts.

- 13 AN GEARRAN, AE 150** — *The eastern pits at Ros fhionn* (Ros fhionn). The crews of the eastern workings about Ros fhionn stop the pumps and walk out, and the lower galleries flood. The Company's engineers there go down the Abhainn chaol and take ship at Seann Mhòrn for Ros dhomhain. The bridge on the eastern coal road falls silent.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, AE 150** — *Seann Toll shelled* (Seann Toll). A Company steamship comes up the Abhainn uaine and shells the coal stage at Seann Toll to deny it to the rebels, and sets the fishing town behind it burning. Twenty-three townsfolk die. For the first time the humans turn the island's own coal, burning in their boilers, against a town of the Dia-thìrich.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *The Leaden Hawk company* (Cuan dhearg). At An Cupa Dàna, the inn at Cuan dhearg, seven hawk-faithful crewmen of the river towns wait nine hours for the council's letters to the Hawk coast, and leave with them at dark. Each wears a hawk cast in lead from the cartridges taken at the store at Muileann chrom, and they are called Buidheann an t-Seabhaig Luaidhe<sup>75</sup>, the Leaden Hawk company.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *The Leaden Hawk walks to the Hawk coast* (Cnoc bheag). The company goes on foot and lightly laden: past the burned stage at Seann Toll, through Baile thais, over the hills by Achadh dhomhain and Cuan bheag, down the Abhainn ìseal by Ceann òg and Inis ìseal to Cnoc bheag, and along the Hawk coast by Inis bhàn, Ros gheal and Seann Skell to Inis mhin, some fifty-five miles in a little over two days. At every hawk-house on the way they read the council's letter aloud, and at Seann Skell they leave it with Ìomhar Seabhag.
- 22 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *Rumours at Inis mhin* (Inis mhin). At Inis mhin, the northern landing the humans had walled, the company lies twelve hours in a boat-shed and hears that Strake's constables ride the western roads out of Ros bheag every day. They hire a carriage of a carter of the town and leave the roads altogether.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *The watch in the grasslands* (Tobar dhomhain). A day and a half by carriage across country, off every road, brings the company to the grasslands above Tobar dhomhain in the western hills. They lie eleven hours in the long grass above the road from Ros bheag to the northern concession and count the constables' riders who pass. Their own list gives forty-one riders, none of them going north.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *The Leaden Hawk at Inis thais* (Inis thais). A day and a half more by carriage, still off the roads, brings the company down to Inis thais, six days after it left Cuan dhearg. The priests of Òrd na Cloiche<sup>76</sup> hear the council's letter in the temple of the Stone. They will send no men, but they shut the harbour of Inis thais to the Company's ships and give the hawk-faithful the use of the Fianna's roads. There the Leaden Hawk's road ends, and its seven join the hawk company when it is mustered at the western Seann Skell.

<sup>74</sup>. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

<sup>75</sup>. the Leaden Hawk company; lit. 'the company of the leaden hawk'

- 29 AN GIBLEAN, AE 150** — *Coaling from Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). The Company's steamships take their fuel from the coal stacked on the quays of Inis mhòr, the river port just east of the capital, whose barges carry it down the Abhainn fhionn to the ships at Cathair dhomhain. The townsfolk set the stacks alight. The ships put in at Ros dhomhain instead, and burn their own stores.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, AE 150** — *The fishermen of Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). Fishing boats of Seann Chwen and Ros ruadh, sailing by night along the south coast, board a Company coaster at anchor and burn her. The Company draws its coastal shipping back to the harbours of Ros dhomhain and Ros bheag.
- 11 AN CÈITEAN, AE 150** — *The other Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). The fishermen of the other Seann Chwen, further west on the south coast, join the raids along the shore. The rolls tell the two towns apart by the names of their boats.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, AE 150** — *Cathair gheal behind its walls* (Cathair gheal). The human town of Cathair gheal in the northern concession shuts its gates and raises a militia, but sends none of it south to the Residency. Its magistrate writes to both sides asking to be left alone. The council grants it; Strake does not answer.
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, AE 150** — *Muileann àrsaidh closes its road* (Muileann àrsaidh). Muileann àrsaidh, a town of the concession, blocks its road with carts and keeps a watch on it against both sides. No one attacks it. The watch is kept to the end of the war.
- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 150** — *The hawk-shrines open* (Seann Skell). From the shrine at Seann Skell Ìomhar Seabhag declares that the war is Mòd's own hunger turned back on those who fed it. The hawk-shrines of the west become mustering houses, and a company of the hawk-faithful marches south to join the council.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 150** — *The hawk company at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). The company of the hawk-faithful is mustered at Seann Skell, the western city, a short march north-east of the human port of Ros bheag. It holds the road between Ros bheag and the north-west for the rest of the war.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 150** — *The southern beacon dark* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>76</sup>). The keepers at Tobar dhearg put out the beacon, and the keepers at Àth dhearg and Baile ìseal do the same. Company ships feeling their way along the coast by night run on the reefs the beacons were built to light, and two are lost.
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 150** — *No relief from over the sea* (Muir Mhanannain<sup>78</sup>). The Administration's letter-books ask again and again for troops and ships from an Tìr Thall<sup>79</sup>. In the whole first year of the war one ship comes, with dispatches and a few crates of cartridges, and sails again within the week.

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<sup>76</sup> the order of the Stone

<sup>77</sup> the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, AE 150** — *The lines at midsummer* (Ros dhomhain). The lines stand at midsummer where the first winter of the war left them: the council holds the hills, the east and the capital; Strake holds the Residency, the harbour quarter below it, and the western ports. Neither side has the strength to attack the other.
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 150** — *Grain from Seann Warr* (Seann Warr). Seann Warr, the farming town in the south-east and not the salt port of that name in the west, has sent grain to the hills by the eastern roads since the winter. The council's roll lists the carts.
- 8 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 150** — *Hunger in the capital* (Cathair dhearg). Its harbour held by the Residency, Cathair dhearg has gone short since the winter. The custodians share out the grain by household, and the roll records that they took the same share as everyone else.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, AE 150** — *The burning of the tithe-books*. In three raids the rebels destroy the tithe ledgers of the humans' Administration. Later chroniclers make much of it; it did little.
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 150** — *The counting-house at Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). The first raid was on the Company's counting-house at the Ros dhomhain quay, within the lines. Men of the harbour quarter under Dùghall Dubh came in over the roofs, carried the tithe books into the yard and burned them.
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 150** — *The tithe-house at Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). The second raid burned the Administration's tithe-house at Ceann àrsaidh, where the share owed by every settlement in the hills had been entered since the first schedule. The clerks were let go. The custodians of Ceann àrsaidh asked that one ledger be spared for the record, and their own people refused them.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 150** — *The weigh-house at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The third raid burned the Company's weigh-house at Muileann chrom with its steelyard ledgers, where the coal of the hills had been entered by the ton since the first contract. The rebels' own chronicler writes that the fire burned green.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, AE 150** — *The fight at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). Company guards and constables sallying from the capital's harbour to win back the eastern road are driven back at Cnoc ghorm, in the hills beyond the capital. It is the Administration's last attempt in the war to reach the mining district.
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, AE 150** — *The harbour quarter changes sides* (Ros dhomhain). After the raid on the counting-house the Dia-thìrich of the Ros dhomhain harbour quarter open the lower gates to the council's companies, and Strake is left holding only the Residency and the Company's quays. The same night men of the quarter burn the Company's flying machine in its shed above the town. It had not flown since the war began, for want of the spirit its engine burned, and nothing has flown over Dia-thìr since that was not a bird.

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78. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

- 5 **AN T-SULTAIN, AE 150** — *Cuan uaine opens its quays* (Cuan uaine). The river quays of Cuan uaine, east of the capital, open to the council's boats. With them and the harbour quarter of Ros dhomhain both lost, the Residency can be fed only by water, up the Abhainn gheal from the sea.
- 21 **AN T-SULTAIN, AE 150** — *Strake forsakes the Residency* (Ros dhomhain). Lionel Strake leaves the Residency by water, down the Abhainn gheal, with his officers, the Mission's clergy and the Company's agents, and takes the Administration to Ros bheag. The council's companies enter the Residency the next morning and find it stripped of all but its furniture.
- 23 **AN T-SULTAIN, AE 150** — *Ros bheag the last seat* (Ros bheag). At Ros bheag, the western port the humans had used since the early years, Strake sets up what is left of the Administration. The human families of the west and south, a few thousand in all, gather behind its walls.
- 3 **AN DÀMHAIR, AE 150** — *Outposts at Ros àrsaidh* (Ros àrsaidh). Strake posts constables at Ros àrsaidh, north of Ros bheag, to hold the coast road, Ceum Ros àrsaidh. The townsfolk bring them food and news, and the news is always a day old.
- 4 **AN DÀMHAIR, AE 150** — *Hunger in Ros bheag* (Ros bheag). The roads cut and no ships coming from over the sea, Ros bheag runs short of food within months. By Strake's order the Company's stores are opened to the human families and the Dia-thìrich townsfolk alike, the one deed of his the Dia-thìrich rolls give him credit for.
- 20 **AN DÀMHAIR, AE 150** — *Cuan shean refuses the humans* (Cuan shean). The custodians of Cuan shean, where the first humans came ashore, shut its harbour to Company ships. The council's roll sets it down and says no more.
- 31 **AN DÀMHAIR, AE 150** — *The families of Baile dhìreach* (Baile dhìreach). At Baile dhìreach each side asks the children of the old joint council, many of them of both peoples, which they are. Most of them, it is written, would not answer, and neither side made them.
- 1 **AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 150** — *The last ship from the east* (Muir Mhanannain<sup>80</sup>). The last ship known to come from an Tìr Thall<sup>81</sup> anchors at Ros bheag at Samhain. She brings no troops and no grain, only a sealed letter for the Commissioner, and sails again on the next tide with as many passengers as she can hold.
- 2 **AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 150** — *The truce of Àth àrsaidh* (Àth àrsaidh). Envoys of the council and of the Administration meet at Àth àrsaidh, on the edge of the northern concession, and agree a truce: the humans left on Dia-thìr shall withdraw into the north-west under the council's safe-conduct, and the council shall leave the towns of the concession standing.

79. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

80. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

81. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 150** — *Baile Mòr ruadh receives the columns* (Baile Mòr ruadh). The truce names Baile Mòr ruadh, the greatest town of the north-west, as the place where the columns will be received. Its Dia-thìrich folk are given the choice of staying or going south. The roll gives the numbers of each, and they are close.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 150** — *The columns go north* (Cuan shean). The human families of Ros bheag, Cuan shean, Baile dhìreach and the south-west march north along the western roads under guard of the council's companies. Few of them had ever lived in the north. The roll records that no column was attacked, and none was helped.
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, AE 150** — *The columns at Àth chrom* (Àth chrom). The columns cross the ford at Àth chrom on their way north. The custodians of the town stand at the ford and count them over, and it is the last count the Dia-thìrich make of the humans on Dia-thìr in this age.
- I AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). At Àth leathan, the last stage before the northern country, the columns camp for a night. The custodians of the town write that the humans asked the name of the place, and that several of them wrote it down.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *The ship that sailed east* (Cuan shean). Lionel Strake, the last Commissioner, sails from Cuan shean for an Tìr Thall<sup>82</sup> with his officers in the last ship on the island able to make the crossing. The keeper at Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>83</sup> sets down her passing in his daybook. Nothing on Dia-thìr tells of her coming anywhere.
- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *The beacons relit* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>84</sup>). The council orders the five beacons lit again, from Baile chrom round to Tobar dhearg. The keepers' daybooks, which had counted human ships since the ring was finished, are still kept, with nothing in them.
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, AE 150** — *The rolls sent to Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). The custodians send what survives of the rolls of the age, their copies of the petitions, the book of Baile thais and the letter-books left in the Residency, to the cellars at Muileann chaol. What the Administration's own clerks carried west with Strake is not known.
- I AM FAOILLEACH, AE 151** — *The Severance*. The war ends, and the crossing itself is shut: whatever way let the humans reach Dia-thìr closes. The humans still on the island are led into the northern country that their children's children hold to this day. Cian and Lorccan, not yet twenty, grow up in the wake of it.

82. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

83. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

84. the lighthouse at Baile chrom



## AGE VI · AN AOIS RÌOGHACHD

*The Age of the Kingdom · the Severance Era, SE 1 – 71*

- 22 AM MÀRT, SE 1** — *The Tuathaich homeland fixed.* The descendants of the humans stranded by the Severance are settled by law in the north of the island and held there. It is a confinement; yet their children's children call it home.
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 1** — *The Severance companies stood down* (Cathair dhearg). The war-companies of the last campaign against the human administration are disbanded at Cathair dhearg. Their rolls go to the council unburned, and the companies are never abolished; they live on as names on a list.
- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 1** — *The boundary stones set* (Caol mhòr). Stones are set on the north roads where the Tuathaich country begins. No wall follows them. Many stand by the roadside yet, and no one has been paid to move them.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 1** — *The hungry year at Doire ghlais* (Doire ghlais). The stores that came over the water from an Tìr Thall<sup>1</sup> come no more, and in their first year alone the northern settlements go short of grain. Tuathaich memory puts the dead at Doire ghlais above two hundred. The Dia-thìrich made no count.
- 11 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 2** — *The human counting-houses emptied* (Ros dhomhain). Clerks of the council enter the human administration's counting-houses at Cathair dhearg, Ros dhomhain and Seann Skell and carry off every written thing. What the raids of the war have left of the tithe ledgers is boxed with the rest, unread, for few of the clerks can read the humans' hand.
- 10 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 2** — *The north-west ports without a master* (Inis àrsaidh). At Ceann mhòr, Cathair gheal and Inis àrsaidh the humans' harbour officers had sailed with the last ships before the crossing closed, and taken their keys with them. The Tuathaich fishermen break the locks of the harbour stores and share out what they find, house by house.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 2** — *Rìoghachd Dia-thìr<sup>2</sup> declared* (Cathair dhearg). The state names itself a kingdom, though it is ruled as before. Its own records carry the same contradiction to this day.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 2** — *The Moot at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Tuathaich householders of the northern towns meet at Caol mhòr and choose for their speaker Walter Hale, once a harbour clerk. The Moot has no standing in Dia-thìrich law. It meets all the same and keeps its own minutes, which run unbroken from that day to this.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 2** — *The council of the kingdom seated* (Cathair dhearg). A royal council of twelve is seated at Cathair dhearg, drawn from the custodian families and the captains of the Severance war. Its minute-books are the oldest unbroken record of the state in this age.

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

2. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

**8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 3** — *The harbour-houses of Ros dhomhain taken over* (Ros dhomhain).

The customs sheds that the humans built at Ros dhomhain, the greatest port of the kingdom, pass to Dia-thìrich harbour-masters. The first of them, Dùghall mac Iain, keeps the humans' tariff for want of another, and in the years after puts it into Dia-thìris line by line.

**11 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 3** — *The ship sent north* (Muir Mhanannain<sup>3</sup>). The council sends a ship out past the north-western capes and north-about to seek the crossing the humans used. She returns after a month of grey water with nothing to tell: no land, no ship, no sign of the passage. No second ship is sent. The priests of Manannan at Seann Skell say that the lord of the sea has shut the eastern sea again, as they have prayed him to since the Crossing.**19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 3** — *Niall crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Niall, first ruler of the restored kingdom, takes the throne at Cathair dhearg by Macha's rite. His is the first name in the line that the state's chronicles keep unbroken from this year on.**7 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *A saying enters speech* (Cathair dhearg). The crowning passes with so little dispute that 'mar a thàinig Niall', the way Niall came, becomes a saying for any smooth handing-on of power. It is first found written in a tavern ledger at Cathair dhearg, against a debt settled without argument.**12 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The shires drawn* (Cathair dhearg). The council divides the kingdom into siorrachdan, each named for its seat, and keeps most of the human administration's district lines under the new names. The humans' surveys are the only whole ones on the island; the kingdom uses them and says nothing of it.**15 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The windy coast left out* (Seann Vell). The shire lines stop where the humans' survey stopped, at the edge of the great moss of the far north-west. The windy coast beyond, an Oirthir Ghaothach<sup>4</sup>, with its sealers and fowlers, is set in no shire and given no maor. The council's minute says only that it 'is not in the survey'.**20 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The island shires* (Eilean dhìreach). Two rocks that each kept a customs station of the Administration, Eilean dhìreach off the Tuathaich coast and Eilean ìseal off the east coast, are kept as shires of their own, for the council has no rule for folding one district into its neighbour. Neither has a town to name it, and each shire takes the name of its island.**23 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 3** — *The market of Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). At the drawing of the shires the Tuathaich of Ceann mhòr are granted a market right for the north-west coast. Its court sits in the harbour store whose locks the fishermen broke. Fish, whale-oil, seal-oil, amber, dyes and the tobacco of the concession farms are sold there.**4 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 4** — *The maor appointed* (Ceann mhòr). A maor is set over each shire to gather the Crown's dues and keep its peace. In the Tuathaich shires the maor is Dia-thìrich, lodged in the seat towns. At Ceann mhòr the maor lives in the old human magistrate's house, and the townsfolk call it by its old name.

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3. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

4. the windy coast

- 21 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 4** — *The Crown's dues set* (Cathair dhearg). The council sets the dues the maorir shall gather: a head-due, *cis-cinn*, on every household by the number of its heads, and a market-due, *cis-margaidh*, on every sale made by a seller of the kingdom. The humans' harbour tariff at Ros dhomhain stands until the kingdom has a coin of its own to take the market-due in.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, SE 4** — *The roll of arms* (Cathair dhearg). The council's clerks make Clàr nan Suaicheantas<sup>5</sup>, a roll of arms, so that each maor may seal the letters of his court. The kingdom's arms are cut anew from the old seal of the custody, and every shire is given arms of its own. Many charges are copied from a book of arms left at the Residency, and so lions, parrots and crocodiles stand on the seals of shires where none was ever seen. The Dia-thirich shires bear the pointed shield of the custody's seal; the Tuathaich shires keep the rounded shield of the humans' district seals. At Seann Skell in the west the house of Òrd Mhanannain<sup>6</sup> asks for its badge, the yellow scorpion of Manannan's cup, and that shire alone of all the roll bears a scorpion.
- 8 AM MÀRT, SE 4** — *The maor of Baile Mòr mhòr* (Baile Mòr mhòr). Coinneach mac Ailein, first maor of Siorrachd Baile Mòr mhòr, holds his court under the market roof of the town, for the humans' courthouse has burned. He keeps it there after the new courthouse is built, and so do those who follow him.
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 4** — *Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol*<sup>7</sup>. The Great Wave falls without warning on the southern coast and lays waste Cnoc chaol, Cuan dhearg and Achadh mhin in a single night. It is the first disaster the new state meets by its own means.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 4** — *The dead of the Great Wave counted* (Cuan dhearg). Relief parties from Cathair dhearg come to Cuan dhearg on the southern coast and count the dead of the three settlements at a little over nine hundred. The harbour of Cuan dhearg is gone, and its boats are found in the fields behind the town. The wave has run on up the gulf as far as Ros gharbh, the seat of its shire, broken its quays and cast the gulf's fishing fleet on the headland. The town stands high and loses few of its people, but nearly every boat.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *Achadh mhin under salt* (Achadh mhin). The fields of Achadh mhin lie under salt and will not bear. The council moves the survivors to higher ground and pays for their seed from the treasury. It is the first relief the restored kingdom grants.
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 4** — *Cnoc chaol rebuilt on the hill* (Cnoc chaol). Cnoc chaol is built again on the slope behind the old town, beyond the wave's reach. The old site is left as the water left it. The townsfolk call it an Tràigh Bhàthte<sup>8</sup>, the drowned strand, and do not build there.

5. the roll of arms; lit. 'the table of the badges'

6. the order of Manannan

7. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

8. the drowned strand at old Cnoc chaol

- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 5** — *Tonn* (Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol<sup>9</sup>). In the survivors' accounts gathered by the relief parties, 'tonn', wave, is used of anything sudden and overwhelming. Within a generation the sense is heard across the south: 'tha e san tonn', he is in the wave of it.
- 1 AN GIBLEAN, SE 5** — *The wave's reach on Eilean mhin* (Eilean mhin). The Great Wave passes also over the low island of Eilean mhin off the southern coast, where none then lived the year round. The shepherds who summered there do not go back.
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, SE 5** — *The old human coinage withdrawn*. All the humans' coin still in hand is cried down and ceases to be money. Within a year a new coinage of the Rìoghachd takes its place, minted with ink of coal dust in its seal.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 5** — *The mint at Cathair dhearg* (Cathair dhearg). A mint is set up in the old human counting-house at Cathair dhearg under Fearchar mac Dhòmhnail, called Fearchar Bonn. The seal of each coin is pressed with an ink ground from coal dust, so that a clipped coin shows the colour at its edge.
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 5** — *The northern savings voided* (Caol mhòr). The Tuathaich households kept what savings they had in the humans' coin. Now it is withdrawn, and their savings are worth their weight in metal and no more. The Moot at Caol mhòr petitions the council for an exchange. The petition is received and filed.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, SE 6** — *Joseph Marlow's ploughshares* (Doire mhin). At Doire mhin in the north the smith Joseph Marlow melts down his neighbours' withdrawn coin and casts it into ploughshares, and sells them back at the cost of the charcoal. The Tuathaich songs name him yet.
- 3 AM MÀRT, SE 6** — *The coin at Inis thais* (Inis thais). At Inis thais on the south-west coast the new coin is scarce for most of the year, and the merchants trade in chits written on the paper of the house of the Stone. When the coin comes the chits are redeemed at the house's door, and the house keeps a tenth.
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, SE 6** — *Òrd Bhrìde*<sup>10</sup> *given its doctrine*. The Coal Rite, Òrd Bhrìde, the order that keeps Bride's flame and Crom's stone, is given a settled doctrine within the Old Faith. Through the long ages it had kept its flame by custom and by no written creed; now its doctrine is built upon the leyline and the unbroken line of the coal-touched.
- 17 AN CÈITEAN, SE 6** — *The first high custodian of the Rite* (Seann Skell). Dòmhnall mac Thormoid is named Àrd-choimheadaiche<sup>11</sup> of Òrd Bhrìde<sup>12</sup> and seated at Seann Skell on the southern coast, where the order's greatest house stands. His first charge is to write an order of worship. There had never been one.

9. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

10. the order of Bride's flame

11. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

12. the order of Bride's flame

- 23 AN CÈITEAN, SE 6** — *The Hawk houses refuse* (Cnoc bheag). The houses of Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>13</sup> about Cnoc bheag refuse the new order of worship, holding that the older form of the Old Faith needs no custodian above the local altar. They are not compelled. Here begins the long quarrel of the Hawk and the Rite.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, SE 6** — *The hawk-house at Muileann naomh takes the order* (Muileann naomh). The hawk-house at Muileann naomh, southernmost of the Hawk's houses and farthest from Cnoc bheag, takes the Rite's written order of worship and becomes a house of Òrd Bhrìde<sup>14</sup>. Its bell, the first hung in any hawk-house, now rings at the Rite's measured burnings. No other house of the Hawk follows.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, SE 7** — *The houses of the Stone stand aside* (Baile Mòr fhionn). The houses of Òrd na Cloiche<sup>15</sup> in the south-west, whose Clach, the Lia Fàil<sup>16</sup>, is not Crom's stone, are bidden to send witnesses to the settling of the Rite at Seann Skell. They send none, and a letter wishing it well.
- 10 AN GEARRAN, SE 7** — *The Moot's schoolhouse petition* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale asks the council for leave to open schools in the north that teach in the humans' tongue. The council answers that the kingdom's schools teach in Dia-thìris and it has no others. The Moot's minute calls the answer 'clear, at least'.
- 26 AN GEARRAN, SE 7** — *The crown's order and the court* (Cathair dhearg). The house of Òrd Mhacha<sup>17</sup> at Cathair dhearg, the order of the capital and the crown, is given the keeping of the coronation regalia, which it had kept before the humans came. The Rite's high custodian asks a share in the keeping and is refused.
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 7** — *The first census after the Severance*. The state counts its own people for the first time since it took back the island. The roll notes, and says no more of it, how few the coal-touched are.
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 7** — *The census of the faiths* (Baile chrom). The first census of the restored kingdom enters every town under the faith its people keep, the Old Faith, the Old Spirits or the Church. It is the first such roll since Seumas Bàn's clerks counted the rites at Dùn ìseal. On the far north-western cape beyond Baile chrom, where there is no town, the clerks find scattered families with no house of any faith, and on Eilean ghorm and the smallest islets no one to ask. All these they enter as *gun chreideamh*<sup>18</sup>, without a faith.
- 15 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 7** — *The count taken from the road* (Doire ghlas). Dia-thìrich census clerks count the Tuathaich towns of Siorrachd Doire ghlas from the road and enter few of the houses. That same year the Moot keeps its own tally. The two totals differ by nearly a fifth, and each side holds to its own.

13. the Hawk order

14. the order of Bride's flame

15. the order of the Stone

16. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

17. the order of Macha

18. without a faith

- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 7** — *The circuit justices* (Cathair dhomhain). Justices are appointed to ride circuit among the shires, and the first of them is Eilidh nic Leòid of Cathair dhomhain. Her circuit takes in eleven shires of the south-west and is most of a year in the riding.
- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 7** — *The head-due first collected* (Cathair dhearg). The maoir gather the head-due for the first time, on the households the census counted, at eighteen purses on every hundred thousand heads, and take it with the harbour dues.
- 3 AM MÀRT, SE 8** — *Muileann bhàn's waterworks* (Muileann bhàn). Muileann bhàn on the southern plain builds the first public waterworks of the restored kingdom: a stone tank on the hill, fed by the mill-race, with lead pipes to four street wells. The Guild of Hewers sends its surveyors to learn the making of it.
- 10 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 8** — *The Leòid ruling* (Seann Bhral). Sitting at Seann Bhral, Eilidh nic Leòid rules that land held by Tuathaich under human title passes to the Crown, and that the right to work it stays with the holders and their heirs. The ruling is cited in nearly every land case of the age after.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 8** — *The coal line repaired* (Muileann chrom). The railway the humans built from the central mountains to the sea, broken in three places in the Severance war, is mended as far as Muileann chrom. A Rail Board is formed at Cathair dhearg to run it, with a clerk, two engineers and the humans' timetable.
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 8** — *The bridge at Cathair dhearg re-dedicated* (Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>19</sup>). The stone bridge over the Abhainn dhomhain below the capital, rebuilt in the humans' day, is hallowed anew with a name-stone in Dia-thìris. The humans' stone is left in its place and turned to face the river.
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 9** — *The necropolis at Cnoc dhìreach* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>20</sup>). The shire of Ceann mhin closes the old burial ground at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach to new graves, for the vines have broken so many stones that no room can be found. Families of the town still tend the old graves, and some say the place is not empty after dark.
- 13 AN GEARRAN, SE 9** — *Eaglais nan Tuathach*<sup>21</sup> *persists*. The Tuathaich communities keep their Church alive in the north. Quietly they keep also the telling of the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan to the Isle of the Blessed, which the Dia-thìrich priesthood calls superstition still.
- 14 AM MÀRT, SE 9** — *The Grey Night kept openly* (Baile chrom). At Baile chrom in the far north-west the vigil-keeper Hannah Crane holds the vigil of Rùn-dìomhair na h-Oidhche Glaise<sup>22</sup> in the open, for the first time since the Severance. The sect keeps one night of silence in the year under Sine, the Peaceful Goose, its name for the wild goose of the Holy Spirit. The bishops of the Church call the vigil irregular. Outsiders are not told which night it is.

19. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

20. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

21. the Tuathaich Church; the old congregations of the north coast

22. the Mystery of the Grey Night

- 30 AM MÀRT, SE 9** — *The churches of the north* (Cnoc ghorm). Most Tuathaich towns keep An Eaglais<sup>23</sup>, the Church their forebears brought at the Crossing; the Dia-thìrch of the west coast beside them keep Manannan's order. A church is built at Cnoc ghorm, the greatest in the north.
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, SE 9** — *The cattle-market at Muileann fhionn* (Muileann fhionn). Muileann fhionn, the mill-town the humans built to guard the northern landing, is granted a market right for the north-western inland country. The Tuathaich drovers bring their cattle and sheep to it, and from it the droves go south to Ceann leathan and the farms of the south-east. It grows to be the greatest cattle-market on the island.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, SE 10** — *The church school at Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). The church at Cnoc ghorm opens a school for its priests. It teaches in the humans' tongue and reads the Bible in the Dia-thìris text its preachers use on the west coast. In all the north, both are taught there only.
- 11 AN CÈITEAN, SE 10** — *The border wall proposed*. A fixed boundary between the Dia-thìrich and the Tuathaich country is proposed for the first time. It is refused as needless, for the two peoples already keep apart of their own will.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 10** — *The minute on the wall* (Cathair dhearg). The council minute that refuses the boundary wall runs to four lines. The fourth reads: 'They do not come south.' Five of the twelve councillors initial it; the other seven do not sign against it.
- 8 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 10** — *The Allt an Àigh<sup>24</sup> walk* (Allt an Àigh). The followers of Na Seann Spioradan<sup>25</sup> keep their yearly walk to the holy well called Allt an Àigh in the east, whose water, the old tales say, brings fortune. The custodians of the Rite speak against the walk and do not forbid it.
- 11 AN GEARRAN, SE 11** — *The walkers at Achadh gharbh* (Achadh gharbh). The walkers to Allt an Àigh<sup>26</sup> lodge at Achadh gharbh on the way, and the village builds a long hall for them. The hall's keeper writes each walker's shire in a book, and by the end of the decade it holds names from fifty shires.
- 15 AN CÈITEAN, SE 11** — *The mine worked to the full again*. The mine's yield after the Severance comes up to what it gave under the humans, and then passes it. The working is the same as before. Only the profit goes to other hands.
- 23 AN CÈITEAN, SE 11** — *The Sloc Mòr concession* (Achadh dhomhain). The Crown grants the working of the Sloc Mòr, the great shaft at Achadh dhomhain, to Uisdean mac Ùisdein of Cathair mhòr, whose house held an overseer's post under the humans. The Crown takes a fifth of the yield. The terms are the humans' terms with the names changed.

23. the Church

24. the stream of the healing water

25. the Old Spirits

26. the stream of the healing water

- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 11** — *The night-shift kept* (Cnoc fhiadhaich). The council will not end the working of the vein by day and night that the humans ordered two generations before. The mountain is still given no season of rest. The custodians of the Rite enter a protest, and then bless the shafts.
- 14 AM MÀRT, SE 12** — *The pit towns fill* (Muileann dhearg). Dia-thìrich families from the hungry east go to the vein-towns for wages. Muileann dhearg doubles in size within three years. Its hall of the druid school, shut since the humans' time, is taken for a hewers' lodging and twice enlarged in those same years.
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 12** — *Baile thais grows on the coal road* (Baile thais). At Baile thais the coal road from the central mountains comes down to the Abhainn uaine above the gulf, and the town takes in carters, inns and a ropewalk. Its people double in a decade, and it is given a shire court.
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 12** — *Raiders off Cathair gheal* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Ships that fly no flag, some manned by men who once served the human administration, begin to raid the coast off Cathair gheal in the north-west. The Tuathaich towns suffer first, and no one defends them.
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 12** — *The coal line reaches the Sloc Mòr* (Achadh dhomhain). The mended railway is carried up the valley to the pithead at Achadh dhomhain. The first coal train runs from the Sloc Mòr to Cathair dhearg in the kingdom's name, on the humans' rails.
- 25 AN CÈITEAN, SE 13** — *The quarry at Achadh dhombhain* (Achadh dhomhain). The spoil of the Sloc Mòr, a grey stone veined with black, is cut and sold for building under the quarry-mark of the house of Mac Ùisdein. For forty years after it is used in public buildings across the south.
- 8 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 13** — *The shunting yards at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The Rail Board lays new sidings at Muileann chrom, where the coal trains from the Sloc Mòr are broken up and made up again for the ports. The families of the yard, who work the small engines that move the wagons, are counted apart by the Board and live apart in rows beside the lines.
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 13** — *The western branch* (Seann Bhral). The Rail Board carries a branch of the coal line west from Cathair dhearg to the port of Seann Bhral, with a spur north to the pits at Àth leathan, so that the western workings may send their coal east by rail.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 13** — *The guilds restored*. The old custom of binding apprentices, from the Holy Age, is taken up again in a changed form. It is now kept for Dia-thìrich alone.
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 13** — *The Guild of Hewers chartered* (Achadh dhomhain). The first guild under the restored custom, the Guild of Hewers, is chartered at Achadh dhomhain. Its oath is sworn with a hand on a piece of coal. By the charter its rolls are open to Dia-thìrich only.



- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 14** — *The shipwrights of Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). The shipwrights of Ros dhomhain take a guild charter of their own and bind their first thirty apprentices in a single day on the slipway.
- 28 AM MÀRT, SE 14** — *The indentures broken* (Cuan shean). At Cuan shean and Seann Bhrál the Tuathaich boys already bound to Dia-thìrich masters are loosed from their indentures under the charter rule. Some go north. Most stay on as day-labourers, outside the guilds and their wages.
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, SE 14** — *The chandlers of Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). The ship-chandlers of Ceann àrsaidh, on the Abhainn fhionn east of the capital, take a guild charter and the sole right to supply the Crown's patrol boats. The right outlasts the boats.
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 14** — *The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin* (Muileann mhin). The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin, who make the coal lamps of every shaft on the island, are chartered as a guild. Their mark, a flame over a hammer, is stamped on every lamp. Of all the guild marks, the humans' traders copied this one only.
- 6 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 15** — *The weavers of Baile chiar* (Baile chiar). The weavers of Baile chiar are chartered as a guild. Their cloth of southern wool undersells the northern cloth at the fair, until the mills of Doire ghlas are built.
- 14 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 15** — *Agnes Pike's school* (Doire ghlas). Agnes Pike, a Tuathaich teacher, opens a school at Doire ghlas that teaches in the humans' tongue, with the Moot's money and without the council's leave. Within ten years there are nine such schools in the north. The council never licenses them and never shuts them.
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 15** — *The Cill ghlas district reopened* (Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>27</sup>). The mining district shut since the Rending is surveyed and declared safe to work. On the surveyors' word the first new shafts are cut well back from the old fault line.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 15** — *The Leòid circuit in the north* (Ceann mhòr). Eilidh nic Leòid rides the northern circuit for the first time and holds court at Ceann mhòr. Of the nineteen cases brought before her, seventeen are Tuathaich suits over land. In fifteen she finds for the Crown, citing her own ruling.
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, SE 16** — *Eilidh nic Leòid dies* (Cathair dhomhain). Eilidh nic Leòid dies at Cathair dhomhain. Her rulings are bound in one book, the first law-book of the restored kingdom, and every circuit justice after her carries a copy.
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, SE 16** — *Leabharlann Muileann chaol*<sup>28</sup> founded (Leabharlann Muileann chaol). A great library is founded at Muileann chaol. In time it holds the fullest record of the island's past that has come down.

27. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

28. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 16** — *Ailean Leabhar, first keeper* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>29</sup>). Ailean mac Iain, called Ailean Leabhar, is made the first keeper of Leabharlann Muileann chaol. He brings with him the council's minute-books and what is left of the humans' tithe ledgers, takes in the custodians' rolls kept in the town's cellars since the Severance war, and spends his first years having them read.
- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 16** — *A chur san Leabharlann* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>30</sup>). Within a few years 'a chur san Leabharlann', to put it in the Library, is said of anything settled beyond dispute. Ailean Leabhar is said to have disliked the phrase, for the Library settles nothing, he said, and only keeps.
- 30 AN CÈTEAN, SE 17** — *The first readers* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>31</sup>). The library's first reading room is opened to any who can show a letter from a shire maor. The first reader written in its book is a shipwright of Ros dhomhain, who asks for the humans' plans of their hulls.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 17** — *The bath-house at the hot springs* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>32</sup>). A new bath-house is built over the hot springs near Muileann ruadh, paid for by the Guild of Hewers for miners sick with the dust. The guild's sick-roll for its first year names four hundred men by name and shift.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 17** — *The keepers of the five lights* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>33</sup>). The five lighthouses built under the humans are given Dia-thìrich keepers by royal warrant. At Taigh-solais Baile chrom on the Tuathaich coast the keeper is a Dia-thìreach man lodged in a Tuathaich town, and his warrant bids him report what he sees on land as well as at sea.
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 17** — *The Muileann chaol town grows* (Muileann chaol). Copyists, binders and paper-makers settle at Muileann chaol about the library. The town is granted a market charter, and its first market day is held in the library's yard.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 18** — *The paper-mill at Tobar dhìreach* (Tobar dhìreach). A paper-mill is built at Tobar dhìreach, a few miles from the library, on the stream below the village. For half a century nearly every page of the royal chronicle is written on its paper.
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 18** — *The first royal chronicler appointed* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>34</sup>). An office is made to keep the records of the kingdom. From it comes the archive whence these annals are drawn.

29. the Library at Muileann chaol

30. the Library at Muileann chaol

31. the Library at Muileann chaol

32. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

33. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

34. the Library at Muileann chaol

**20 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 18** — *The years counted by the ages* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>35</sup>).

With the office of chronicler the council orders that the kingdom's records shall count their years no longer by the Diosal but by the ages of the library's table, each age from its own first event: six ages as the table then stands, and seven since the Dubhan Era. The chronicler's first year is entered as the eighteenth of the Severance Era. Thereafter the count of the Diosal is kept only in old books.

**19 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 18** — *Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>36</sup>).

The first royal chronicler is Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill, a clerk of the council. She keeps her record at Muileann chaol and not at the capital, and writes in her first entry that a record kept beside the throne is kept for the throne.

**25 AM MÀRT, SE 19** — *The first chronicle circuit* (Àth àrsaidh). Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill sends clerks to every shire to copy parish books, grave-lists and harbour rolls. The returns from the south fill forty chests. The returns from Siorrachd Àth àrsaidh and the other northern shires fill one, for few Tuathaich will speak to the clerks.

**2 AN GIBLEAN, SE 19** — *The town arms copied* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>37</sup>). The clerks of the first chronicle circuit copy the seal of every town they visit into the roll of arms, and the roll comes to hold the arms of five hundred and five places. In the north most are copied from the humans' old town seals, for few Tuathaich will show the clerks their own.

**11 AN CÈITEAN, SE 19** — *The chest from Inis bheag* (Inis bheag). At Inis bheag in the north-east the chronicle clerks are shown a parish book that goes back before the coming of the humans, kept in the Seann Spioradan house there. The keeper lets it be copied, and not taken.

**28 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 19** — *Boats lost off Cuan bheag* (Cuan bheag). A storm out of the west drowns eleven Tuathaich fishermen off Cuan bheag in the north. The village has no lifeboat. The Moot buys one by subscription and asks the council to pay half; the council pays a third.

**9 AN GEARRAN, SE 20** — *The thing off the north-west cape* (Uilebheist na Mara<sup>38</sup>). Fishermen out of Achadh àrsaidh tell of a creature longer than their boats in the waters off the north-west cape. Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill writes down the tale, and adds that the raiders shelter in those same waters.

**10 AM MÀRT, SE 20** — *The Eilean dhubh sheep-count* (Eilean dhubh). A royal clerk is sent to count the flocks of Eilean dhubh, greatest of the outer isles, to set the island's dues. The islanders count them for him, and the dues are set on their count.

35. the Library at Muileann chaol

36. the Library at Muileann chaol

37. the Library at Muileann chaol

38. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

- 8 AN GIBLEAN, SE 20** — *Cathair gheal arms its boats* (Cathair gheal). The Tuathaich fishermen of Cathair gheal arm their own boats and drive the raiders from the bay. Twice they had asked the council for help, and none was sent. Afterwards the council fines the town for bearing arms without licence, and the fine is paid.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 20** — *The market cross at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). A market cross is raised at Cathair mhòr at the cost of the house of Mac Ùisdein, with the house's name cut on all four faces. The town's wool and coal markets are moved to its foot.
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, SE 21** — *The house of the Stone at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). The house of Òrd na Cloiche<sup>39</sup> at Caol leathan, greatest of the order, is rebuilt with a tower, and a bell rings the hours from it. The town sets its market and its courts by the bell.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 21** — *Fèill Muileann òg*<sup>40</sup> *first held* (Fèill Muileann òg). A fair is held each year at Muileann òg, and it becomes the greatest gathering on the island. Trade comes to it from every province the state holds.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 21** — *Oighrig nic Mhathain's rules* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>41</sup>). Oighrig nic Mhathain, first toll-mistress of the fair at Muileann òg, sets its rules: a stall-fee in coin, a court of the fair for disputes, and Tuathaich goods to be sold only through Dia-thirich factors. The rules are read aloud at the opening of every fair to this day.
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 21** — *The fair's road* (Dùn chrom). The road from Cathair dhearg to Muileann òg is widened and metalled for the carts of the fair. It passes Dùn chrom, which takes a toll at its gate and grows on it. As far as Muileann ghlas it runs on the old coal road; the new stretches are called Rathad na Fèille.
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 22** — *Dùn chrom's gate-toll* (Dùn chrom). The toll taken at Dùn chrom's gate on the fair road pays for a new wall on the town's southern side. The townsfolk call it the fair's wall. The carters of the fair call it something else.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 22** — *Niall dies; Brìghde crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Niall dies, and his daughter Brìghde follows him without contest: a mortal heir passing to a mortal heir among a nobility some of whom never age. It was thought no wonder then. It was thought one later.
- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 22** — *The chronicler's use of the saying* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>42</sup>). Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill writes that the succession came 'mar a thàinig Niall'; it is the first time the saying is found in the royal record. In all her years as chronicler she lets no other idiom into the chronicle.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 22** — *The ancestors' hall at Seann Dunn* (Seann Dunn). The Seann Spioradan houses of the east coast build a common hall at Seann Dunn, where each year the living heads of forty families name their ancestors aloud. The next year the list is copied to the library, and it grows by a few names every year after.

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39. the order of the Stone

40. the fair at Muileann òg

41. the fair at Muileann òg

42. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 25 AN GEARRAN, SE 23** — *Cuan ruadh's harbour light* (Cuan ruadh). Cuan ruadh on the east coast, which has none of the five lighthouses, raises a harbour light of its own on the mole and burns in it coal bought by the town. The Lighthouse Board will not take it on.
- 4 AM MÀRT, SE 23** — *Còmhrag Ceann leathan*<sup>43</sup> *first fought* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan). A fierce melee is first fought at Ceann leathan, and is fought there every year after. It is held to be a martial custom. More and more it is where a people with few other outlets spend their anger.
- 22 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 23** — *Calum Ruadh* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>44</sup>). The first champion of the Còmhrag whose name is remembered is Calum mac Aonghais, called Calum Ruadh, a hewer of Muileann chrom. Two men die in the melee he wins. The prize is a year's wages and the right to bear arms in any shire.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 23** — *Ceann leathan's inns* (Ceann leathan). Ceann leathan builds four new inns for the crowds of the Còmhrag. The fair-wardens of the town, who take a share of every room, become the Còmhrag's keepers in all but name.
- 10 AM MÀRT, SE 24** — *The grain-ships of Ros gheal* (Ros gheal). Ros gheal on the north-central coast builds a dock for the grain-ships of the Hawk country. The Hawk houses bless the dock and ask a tithe of its dues. The shire gives them a twentieth.
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 24** — *Splatter and Dodge's generation born*. Many children are born in these years to the shunting families of the yard. From them come Seachran and Brean and others of that generation, who grow up to be Dubhan's closest allies.
- 6 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 24** — *Seann Bhral in the south* (Seann Bhral). Seann Bhral on the south coast, not the town of that name in the west, becomes the greatest fishing port of the kingdom and lands more fish than Ros dhomhain. Its curing-sheds run the length of the harbour.
- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 25** — *The circus at Seann Chwen* (An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn<sup>45</sup>). The travelling show that calls itself An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn is first recorded, pitched near Seann Chwen on the southern coast. The chronicler's clerk could not say what its acts were meant to show. Nor, he adds, could the crowd, and it came back the next night.
- 2 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 25** — *Manannan's feast at Seann Bhral* (Seann Bhral). The house of Òrd Mhanannain<sup>46</sup> at Seann Bhral, one of the oldest on the west coast, will not admit the Tuathaich from the north who come to its feast of the sea, as their forebears learned to do from the Dia-thìrich harbours. Its keeper says the sea is the same and the house is not.
- 11 AN GEARRAN, SE 26** — *The northern sea-feast* (Cnoc ghorm). Turned away at Seann Bhral, the Tuathaich keep the feast at the church at Cnoc ghorm instead, as a blessing of the boats. They keep it there every year after, and within a generation the northern feast is greater than the western.

43. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

44. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

45. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

46. the order of Manannan

- 12 AM MÀRT, SE 26** — *The Depletion first noted*. The survey reports begin to note, without remark, that the vein yields less. For years the state does nothing.
- 9 AN CÈITEAN, SE 26** — *Iain Mapa's survey* (Achadh dhomhain). The survey behind the report is the work of Iain mac Ruairidh, called Iain Mapa, of the Mine Board. His measures of the faces of the Sloc Mòr show the vein thinning to east and south. The Board files the survey and shows it to no one, and Iain Mapa is sent to the silver works at Muileann chiar.
- 4 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 27** — *The Mine Board at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). The Mine Board, which has sat at Cathair dhearg since the Sloc Mòr concession, moves its clerks to Cathair mhòr to be nearer the mountain. By the Board's own rule its surveys are kept there and not sent to the library.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, SE 27** — *The scent-makers of Seann Vell* (Seann Vell). The glass-houses of the capital shore begin to make small flasks, and in them the women of Seann Vell sell the waters they distil from bog-myrtle, meadowsweet and heather honey. Within a few years scent is sold in every market town, and the towns of the western plain take up the trade.
- 15 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 27** — *The Grey Night forbidden* (Baile chrom). A Dia-thìreach magistrate at Baile chrom forbids the gatherings of the Grey Night sect as disorderly. Hannah Crane is fined. The vigil goes indoors and goes on.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 27** — *The harbour at Cuan dhearg reopened* (Cuan dhearg). The harbour at Cuan dhearg, lost to the Great Wave, is opened again with a new mole of dressed stone. The first boat in is one of those found in the fields behind the old town, refloated, and kept by the harbour-master as a relic.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 28** — *Achadh mhin resettled* (Achadh mhin). The fields of Achadh mhin bear again, and a few of the families moved away after the Great Wave come back to them. The shire gives them their old bounds from the humans' survey.
- 11 AN GEARRAN, SE 28** — *Eòghan crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Brighde dies young, and no cause is made known. Her cousin Eòghan takes the throne, and for the first time the restored kingdom's succession is in dispute.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 28** — *The succession entry* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>47</sup>). The royal chronicler's entry for the succession gives the bare fact. The chroniclers after Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill have added nothing to it.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 28** — *Dissent recorded in council* (Cathair dhearg). For the first time the council's minutes record votes against a succession. They name the councillors who voted, and not their reasons. Two of them do not sit again.
- 12 AM MÀRT, SE 29** — *Inis bhàn's fire* (Inis bhàn). Fire takes the warehouse quarter of Inis bhàn on the Abhainn ìseal in the north-central country and burns for two days. The town's Hawk house takes in the homeless. The fire-bell the town buys afterwards is the loudest in the kingdom.

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47. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 9 **AN CÈITEAN, SE 29** — *Dubhan born*. Dubhan is born mortal, in the north where the Severance confined his people, decades after the war that shut the island against those from whom his line descends.
- 7 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 29** — *The Tuathaich schools counted* (Doire ghlas). The Moot counts eleven schools in the north that teach in the humans' tongue, and three that have begun to teach Dia-thìris as well, at the parents' asking. Agnes Pike's school at Doire ghlas is one of the three.
- 10 **AN GIBLEAN, SE 30** — *The stone house of Mac Ùisdein* (Cathair mhòr). Uisdean mac Ùisdein's house at Cathair mhòr is rebuilt in stone quarried from the spoil of the Sloc Mòr, the greatest private house in the kingdom. The Guild of Hewers holds its feast in the new hall.
- 26 **AN CÈITEAN, SE 30** — *The northern fishing grounds* (Caol mhòr). Licences to fish the waters south and east of Caol mhòr are kept for Dia-thìrich boats. The Tuathaich boats are left the northern grounds, where the raiders also fish.
- 24 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 30** — *Doire shean's harbour* (Doire shean). Doire shean in the south-west builds a stone harbour for the fishing boats of the Stone's country, the first new harbour since the Severance not paid for by the Crown. The house of the Stone lends the money and takes the harbour dues.
- 3 **AN GIBLEAN, SE 31** — *Trenches at Làrach an Dùin*<sup>48</sup> (Làrach an Dùin). Diggers sent by the library open trenches at Làrach an Dùin on the south-east coast. They find walls older than any Dia-thìreach building, and no writing at all. Ailean Leabhar has the finds entered as of the Old Ones, purpose unknown.
- 7 **AN DÀMHAIR, SE 31** — *Làrach an Teampaill*<sup>49</sup> *measured* (Làrach an Teampaill). The library's diggers measure the ruin called Làrach an Teampaill in the east and do not dig it, at the asking of the Seann Spioradan houses of the district. The keeper enters it as measured and let be.
- 29 **AM MÀRT, SE 32** — *The obelisk at Cnoc bheag copied* (Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>50</sup>). A scribe of the library copies the writing on the obelisk near Cnoc bheag, stroke by stroke. It is like no script known on the island. The copy is filed and the obelisk fenced.
- 27 **AN GIBLEAN, SE 32** — *A lighthouse on the Tuathaich coast* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>51</sup>). The Dia-thìreach keeper of Taigh-solais Baile chrom reports to the council that the Grey Night sect keeps its vigil in the dark of the lighthouse's own shadow. The council does nothing.
- 26 **AN CÈITEAN, SE 32** — *Salt-pans of Àth bheag* (Àth bheag). Salt-pans are dug on the flats below Àth bheag on the east coast, and within a few years the town supplies the whole eastern seaboard. The salt goes inland by the old drove road past Baile ìseal.

48. the fortress ruin

49. the temple ruin

50. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

51. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

- I AM FAOILLEACH, SE 33** — *Cathair fhada's grain-store* (Cathair fhada). Cathair fhada on the southern plain builds a Crown grain-store great enough to feed the south for a season. It is filled from the south's own harvests, and first opened in the dry years at Achadh shean.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 33** — *The second census after the Severance*. The second census measures for the first time how far the Tuathaich live below the Dia-thirich; until now it was only seen. The report is not made public.
- 28 AN GEARRAN, SE 33** — *Walter Hale dies* (Caol mhòr). Walter Hale, first speaker of the Moot, dies at Caol mhòr. The Moot chooses Mary Coyle, a fisherman's widow, to follow him, the first woman to hold the chair.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 34** — *The census clerks' private note* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>52</sup>). Seonag nic Ille-Mhoire, one of the census clerks, leaves among her papers a note that she asked to see the report on the gap and was refused. The note came to the library with her papers after her death. It is the only mention of the report outside the council.
- II AN GEARRAN, SE 34** — *The Tuathaich doctors* (Àth àrsaidh). The Moot pays for two Tuathaich women to be taught medicine by a Dia-thireach physician at Àth àrsaidh, who takes them against the will of his guild. He is struck from its rolls. They practise in the north for forty years.
- 12 AM MÀRT, SE 34** — *The Abhainn ìseal floods* (Abhainn ìseal). The Abhainn ìseal, longest river of the island, breaks its banks along its lower reach and carries away three bridges and a stretch of the coal line's embankment. The line is shut most of a year, and the ports live on stored coal.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, SE 35** — *The Hawk houses' own custodian* (Inis ìseal). The Hawk houses of Siorrachd Cnoc bheag name a custodian of their own, Raonaid nic Iain, and seat her at Inis ìseal. The high custodian at Seann Skell will not own her. The houses carry on as if he had.
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 35** — *Raonaid nic Iain at Inis ìseal* (Inis ìseal). Raonaid nic Iain, custodian of the Hawk houses, writes out the Hawk's order of worship, which until now was spoken and never written. The Hawk houses read it aloud once a year and keep the written copy locked away.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 35** — *A hawk for Siorrachd Cnoc bheag* (Cnoc bheag). The Hawk houses of Siorrachd Cnoc bheag ask the council to set a hawk on the shire's arms in place of the white billet the roll gave it. The council grants it, and the maor's seal is recut with a white hawk among its twelve crescents. It is the first change made to the roll at the asking of an order.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, SE 36** — *Six dead at the Còmhrag* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>53</sup>). Six fighters die at the Còmhrag, the most in any year yet. The custodians of the Rite petition for its ending. The fair-wardens of Ceann leathan, whose town lives off the crowds, refuse.

52. the Library at Muileann chaol

53. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'



- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 36** — *The circus at Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). In the year of the six dead An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn<sup>54</sup> pitches at Ceann leathan and plays to the crowds who stay on after the melee. It is said the fair-wardens paid it to come.
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 36** — *The coal line reaches Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). The railway is carried through to the port of Ceann leathan, so that coal may be shipped from a second harbour. The quays of Ceann leathan are rebuilt for coal-ships, and the town outgrows its walls.
- 3 AN DÙHLACHD, SE 36** — *Ros bheag's shipyard* (Ros bheag). Ros bheag on the west coast opens a yard for coal-ships, and the western ports need no longer send to Ros dhomhain for hulls. The shipwrights of Ros dhomhain protest to the guild court and lose.
- 1 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 37** — *The silver at depth* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). The silver seam at Muileann chiar, which the Dia-thìrich kept in their own hands through the humans' time, is found richer at depth than any had looked for. The town's old silver guild takes a charter under the restored custom. Iain Mapa, working there since the Board sent him, measures the new faces.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 37** — *The eastern blank-houses* (Baile dhìreach). More silver comes up from Muileann chiar than the mint at Cathair dhearg can refine. The Crown gives the villages of the eastern hills the refining of the guild's bar, with the gold washed from the stream below Baile dhìreach, into blanks for the realm-coin. The mint strikes them. The villages are paid by weight.
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 37** — *Dùn thais in the west* (Dùn thais). Dùn thais on the west coast is granted a court of the sea of its own, to judge salvage and wreck along its shore. At its first sitting it awards a raider's hulk to the fishermen who drove it aground.
- 2 AN GEARRAN, SE 38** — *Dùn thais in the east* (Dùn thais). The other Dùn thais, in the east, seat of its own shire, builds a covered market for the hill farms. For ten years the royal record confuses the courts of the two towns, until Tormod Pinn marks them west and east.
- 18 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 38** — *Siorrachd Doire chaol* (Doire chaol). Doire chaol, the village laid out south of the capital for the families of the royal household, has grown too great for the maor of Baile chiar to govern from his seat. The council cuts it out as a shire of its own, the only shire made since the drawing.
- 23 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 39** — *The dead and not dead of Doire uaine* (Marbh-bheò<sup>55</sup> Doire uaine). Herders near Doire uaine will not graze the hills above the town, where old writings tell of a thing that is dead and does not rest. A shepherd is lost there. The magistrate enters wolves.
- 1 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 39** — *The fall at Muileann dhearg* (Muileann dhearg). A gallery of the reopened Cill ghlas district gives way under Muileann dhearg, along a line the surveyors had marked as sound. Thirty-one hewers die. It is small beside the Rending. It is the same fault.

54. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

55. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

- 19 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 39** — *The rules of the shafts*. After this lesser echo of the old fall of Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>56</sup>, new rules for digging are made. They are for Dia-thìrich workers. In the workings where Tuathaich labour they are kept loosely, and by intent.
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 39** — *The timber at Àth leathan (Àth leathan)*. At the pits about Àth leathan, where Dia-thìrich overseers work Tuathaich hands, the new rules of timbering are posted and not paid for. The overseers' books, which came later to the library, show the timber ordered and never delivered.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 40** — *Mòrag nic Coinnich, keeper (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>57</sup>)*. Ailean Leabhar dies at Muileann chaol, and Mòrag nic Coinnich becomes keeper of the library. She begins the custom, kept ever since, of writing beside each item whence it came.
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 40** — *The pit families of Achadh dhombhain (Achadh dhomhain)*. After the fall at Muileann dhearg forty hewers' families leave Achadh dhomhain for the fishing ports of the south. The Guild of Hewers binds sixty apprentices to fill its rolls. None of them are Tuathaich.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 40** — *Fire at the fair (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>58</sup>)*. On the eve of Samhain fire runs through the stalls of the fair at Muileann òg. The next day the fair's court sits in a field, and the fair goes on. Oighrig nic Mhathain, toll-mistress since the first fair, dies of her burns.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 40** — *The Tuathaich wool carts (Muileann leathan)*. The Rail Board will not carry goods sent by the Moot, pleading the fair's rule on factors. The wool of the north goes south to Muileann òg by cart, five days on the road, and is sold by factors when it comes.
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 41** — *The Tuathaich carters' road (Àth fhada)*. The carters of the northern wool go to the fair by Cnoc ghorm, Àth fhada and the old road down to Inis àr-saidh, and the Tuathaich villages on the way open inns for them. In the north the road is called the Carters' Road. In the south it has no name.
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 41** — *Dubhan's childhood*. Dubhan grows up watching a caste that does not age hold every true advantage on an island where his own forebears were pushed to the edge. The coal was never his to inherit.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 41** — *The Moot's pit register (Caol mhòr)*. The Moot at Caol mhòr begins a register of Tuathaich hewers killed or maimed in the western pits, for no Dia-thìreach book counts them. Mary Coyle's clerks enter the first year's names on the families' own word. The register is kept to this day and has never been sent south.
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, SE 42** — *Ros mhòr's boatyard (Ros mhòr)*. Tuathaich boatbuilders turned out of the guild yards open a boatyard at Ros mhòr in the north. Its boats are built to the humans' old lines and are swifter than anything in the south.

56. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

57. the Library at Muileann chaol

58. the fair at Muileann òg

- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 42** — *Tormod Pinn* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>59</sup>). Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill lays down the office of royal chronicler. Tormod mac Sheumais follows her, called Tormod Pinn for the speed of his hand. He keeps the record for more than twenty years and writes more of it than any before or since.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, SE 43** — *Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill's last entry* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>60</sup>). Tormod Pinn copies into the front of his first book the last entry Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill made as chronicler, a list of what the record lacks: the northern towns' own accounts, the humans' treaties in their own tongue, and the Board's surveys. He adds nothing to it.
- 3 AN CÈITEAN, SE 43** — *Dry years at Achadh shean* (Tiormachd Achadh shean<sup>61</sup>). Dry years come again to the country about Achadh shean, where the Long Drought settled in the humans' time. This time the council sends grain up the coal line and pays for it out of the Sloc Mòr's share. No one in the shire dies of hunger, and the chronicler records it.
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 43** — *The wells of Siorrachd Achadh shean* (Achadh shean). The maor of Siorrachd Achadh shean has twelve wells dug to the rock along the drove road, each marked with the name of the shire and of the council. Water is drawn from four of them still.
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 44** — *Grain by the coal line* (Achadh shean). The grain for Achadh shean comes from the store at Cathair fhada, and for the first time it goes by the coal line. The Rail Board charges the council for the carriage.
- 7 AN GEARRAN, SE 44** — *Raiders at Baile ìseal* (Spùinneadairean-mara). Raiders land near Baile ìseal on the far east coast and burn the salt-sheds of Àth bheag. The kingdom's patrol boats come two days later and find the sheds cold.
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 44** — *Murchadh mac Coinnich's log* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal<sup>62</sup>). Murchadh mac Coinnich, keeper of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal, begins to enter in the lighthouse log every unlit ship he sees, with her heading and the hour. His logs, kept most of his life, are the fullest record of the eastern raiders in the library.
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 45** — *The pirates' names* (Àth bheag). The raiders fly no flag, and Murchadh mac Coinnich's log names their ships as the fishermen of Àth bheag name them. From his log the names pass into the royal record.
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 45** — *The Còmhrag at its height* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>63</sup>). The Còmhrag draws its greatest crowd yet to Ceann leathan, and the fair-wardens build timber stands along three sides of the field. The champion is Ealasaid nic Coinnich of Àth ghlas, the first woman to win it. She does not fight again.

59. the Library at Muileann chaol

60. the Library at Muileann chaol

61. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

62. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

- 14 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 46** — *The Hawk river port of Cnoc bheag* (Cnoc bheag). Cnoc bheag, greatest town of the Hawk country, passes Cathair mhòr in its numbers. Its river quays take the grain of the north-central country, and its Hawk house is the richest of any order outside the capital.
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 46** — *Scoiltean nan Draoidhean*<sup>64</sup> *revived*. The druid schools of Flidais, silent since the humans ruled, open again. Their first question, why the vein answers some and not others, presses hard once more, for the vein itself is failing.
- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 46** — *Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain's lectures* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>65</sup>). The first teacher of the revived school is Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain. She lectures in the sacred wood of Flidais near Muileann chiar in the east, where the druids last met under the humans, and opens with the school's oldest question, plainly put: why the vein answers some hands and not others.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 47** — *The druid schools in Siorrachd Baile gharbh* (Baile gharbh). The houses of the druid schools in Siorrachd Baile gharbh in the north-east, silent since the humans' time, open again at Baile gharbh and Àth fhada. Their teachers walk to the sacred wood to hear Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain, and walk back.
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 47** — *The school at Caol shean* (Caol shean). The druid school takes a house at Caol shean, one of the great druid towns of the east, and teaches there in the wet months, when the wood is too sodden for lectures. Its students copy the census note on the coal-touched and dispute it openly.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 47** — *The Hawk given a place* (Cnoc bheag). A council of the Rite at Seann Skell offers the Hawk houses of Cnoc bheag a place under the high custodian with their own order of worship. The Hawk houses take the place and keep their order. After this the quarrel is quieter. It does not end.
- 7 AN GEARRAN, SE 48** — *The north-eastern harbours* (Caol chrom). Caol chrom and Caol gharbh on the north-east coast join their harbour dues to pay for a breakwater across the strait between them. It is eight years in the building and is the longest on the island yet.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, SE 48** — *Daniel Frayne's copying school* (Muileann leathan). At Muileann leathan in the north Daniel Frayne, a clerk of the Moot, teaches young Tuathaich to copy and bind books, since the guilds of that craft in the south will not take them. The bindings of Muileann leathan are found afterwards in Dia-thìrich libraries without their makers' names.
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, SE 48** — *The Abhainn uaine ferries* (Cidhe Beag). The boat-landing at Cidhe Beag on the Abhainn uaine is licensed as a ferry, to carry passengers and small freight down the river toward the coast. The first to hold the licence is an old boatman who had worked the landing without one for forty years.

63. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

64. the druid schools

65. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 49** — *Loch chrom* (Loch chrom). The fishermen of Loch chrom, the only great lake of the island, are licensed to net its trout, which was kept for the Crown's table. Each year the Crown's table is served first.
- 22 AN GEARRAN, SE 49** — *The pillar at Cnoc chiar* (Colbh Cnoc chiar<sup>66</sup>). Students of the druid schools try to read the pillar near Cnoc chiar by setting it beside the obelisk at Cnoc bheag and the column at Cnoc ghorm. They find signs in common and no meaning. Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain writes that the Old Ones were here and said so, and that none living can hear it.
- 23 AM MÀRT, SE 50** — *Flood at Inis chrom* (Inis chrom). A storm tide floods the lower town of Inis chrom on the south-west coast and drowns the net-lofts and the rope-walk. The town builds both again on piles, and so they stand now.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, SE 50** — *Cnoc leathan's schools* (Cnoc leathan). Cnoc leathan in the east opens a school in every one of its six parishes, paid from the shire's dues, the first shire to do so. The council asks how it paid for them and is shown the accounts.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, SE 50** — *Alasdair mac Ùisdein's loan* (Cathair mhòr). Alasdair mac Ùisdein, grandson of the first holder of the Sloc Mòr concession, borrows against his house's share to pay for a search for a second vein. The Mine Board lends its surveyors. The Crown lends its name.
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, SE 51** — *The druid school on the search* (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>67</sup>). Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain writes to the Mine Board that the search asks the wrong question. The school has always asked why the vein answers some hands, she says, and no one has asked why there is one vein. The Board files the letter.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, SE 51** — *The search for a second vein*. The search for a second seam of the coloured coal elsewhere on the island is costly, and finds nothing. The same search had been made in the Age of Ailean, thousands of years before, and had failed in the same way; it had been forgotten.
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 51** — *Forty-one dry shafts* (Dùn dhearg). The borings of the search run from the hills above Dùn dhearg to the moors south of Baile ruadh. Forty-one shafts are sunk, and none strikes the vein. Afterwards Mòrag nic Coinnich finds in a list of the Holy Age at the library the same hills named as searched and barren.
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 52** — *Dùn dhearg's claim* (Dùn dhearg). The town of Dùn dhearg, whose hills held a dozen of the dry shafts, claims damages from the house of Mac Ùisdein for spoiled grazing. The circuit court awards them. The house pays a third before it sells.
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 52** — *The house of Mac Ùisdein sells half* (Cathair mhòr). To meet its debts the house of Mac Ùisdein sells half its share in the Sloc Mòr back to the Crown. Its stone house at Cathair mhòr is let to the Mine Board, which moves its offices there.

66. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 52** — *The shafts at Baile ruadh left open* (Baile ruadh). The dry shafts of the search are left open on the moors near Baile ruadh. Sheep fall into them, and one child, before the shire fences them at its own cost. The shire's claim on the house of Mac Ùisdein for the fencing is never paid.
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, SE 53** — *The Muileann dhombain mills* (Muileann dhomhain). The mills of Muileann dhomhain in the south-east ground grain for the vein-towns. When the vein-towns' orders fall they turn to grinding bark for the tanners. The miller-families of the town keep their mark and change their trade.
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 53** — *The rope-makers of Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). The rope-makers of Seann Tarr on the north-east coast are chartered as a guild, the last guild the restored custom makes for a trade the humans had not touched. Their hemp comes from the fields about Doire uaine and Achadh naomh.
- I AN T-SULTAIN, SE 53** — *Seann Tarr's chest remembered* (Seann Tarr). By the shire's own rule the rope-makers' charter at Seann Tarr is kept in the shire's chest and not sent to Cath-air dhearg. The shire keeper of Seann Tarr keeps a list of what the chest holds and sends the list alone.
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 53** — *The Circus at Inis àrsaidh* (An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn<sup>68</sup>). An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn is recorded again, pitched this time on the common near Inis àrsaidh in the west. The magistrate who licenses it enters the acts as 'various' and the fee as paid.
- II AM MÀRT, SE 54** — *Ceann mhin's fish-market* (Ceann mhin). Ceann mhin, the great port south-east of the capital, opens a covered fish-market over the old strand. Fish from Seann Bhral and the eastern grounds is sold there for the capital.
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, SE 54** — *Edged tools banned from the Còmhrag* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>69</sup>). A fighter is killed with a hewer's pick, and the fair-wardens of Ceann leathan ban edged tools from the Còmhrag. Staves and fists are still allowed, and so the deaths go on, fewer.
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 54** — *The drowned lighthouse keeper* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>70</sup>). The keeper of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg on the south coast drowns going out to a boat aground on the reef below the light. The boat's crew are saved by his daughter, Ciorstaidh nic Artair, and she is given the keeper's warrant in his place.
- II AM MÀRT, SE 55** — *Ciorstaidh nic Artair's reef mark* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>71</sup>). Ciorstaidh nic Artair has an iron post set on the reef below Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg, painted and hung with a bell. While she keeps the light no boat goes aground there.

67. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

68. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

69. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

70. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

71. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

- 13 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 55** — *Mary Coyle lays down the chair* (Caol mhòr). Mary Coyle lays down the chair of the Moot at Caol mhòr. Daniel Frayne of Muileann leathan follows her, the first speaker born after the Severance.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 55** — *The Fèill's northern day* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>72</sup>). The court of the fair at Muileann òg sets aside one day of the fair for goods from the northern shires. They are still sold through Dia-thìrich factors, but under the northern makers' own marks. It is the first time a Tuathaich name is written on anything sold there.
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 56** — *The Tuathaich marks at the fair* (Baile chiar). The first northern mark sold under its own name at the fair is the cloth of the weavers of Doire ghlas, a grey twill with a white thread at the selvedge. The southern weavers of Baile chiar begin to weave a white thread into their own.
- 11 AM MÀRT, SE 56** — *The Depletion laid bare*. The quiet note of the survey in SE 26 is now an open trouble. The last unworked stretches of the vein are found, and they are smaller than any wish to own.
- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, SE 56** — *Catrìona nic Neacail's map* (Achadh dhomhain). Catrìona nic Neacail, surveyor-general of the Mine Board, publishes the map of the vein's last unworked stretches. It fits on one sheet. Within the year she gives up her post and goes to teach at the druid school at Caol shean.
- 9 AN GIBLEAN, SE 57** — *Iain Mapa's survey found* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>73</sup>). Among the Board's files Catrìona nic Neacail finds Iain Mapa's survey of thirty years before, which shows the same thinning she has just measured. She sends a copy to the library, with a note of when the Board received it.
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, SE 57** — *Iain Mapa dies* (Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid). Iain mac Ruairidh, called Iain Mapa, dies at Muileann chiar, where the Board sent him. His own copy of his survey is found among his papers with the Board's receipt pinned to it.
- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 57** — *Muileann dhearg empties* (Muileann dhearg). In a few years Muileann dhearg loses a third of its households to the ports. Its druid hall is shut, and its bell sold to the school at Caol shean, where it rings for lectures still.
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 57** — *Ceann leathan's coal quays idle* (Ceann leathan). Coal-ships wait at Ceann leathan for cargoes that come in half-loads. The harbour dues fall by half, and the fair-wardens raise the gate-price of the Còmhrag to make it up.
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 58** — *Baile Mòr dhombhain's market* (Baile Mòr dhomhain). As the trade of the coal-towns falls away, Baile Mòr dhomhain in the northern hills becomes the market for the wool and hides of the hill country. For two years together its market day draws more carts than the fair at Muileann òg.

72. the fair at Muileann òg

73. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 58** — *Mairead crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Eòghan's reign ends in the decade that the Depletion becomes known to all. Mairead inherits a kingdom whose founding wealth is plainly failing, for the first time since the restoration.
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 58** — *The Hewers bind no apprentices* (Achadh dhomhain). For the first time since its charter the Guild of Hewers binds no new apprentices. Its masters vote to keep the rolls open to the sons and daughters of members only.
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, SE 59** — *Muileann shean's school of hewers* (Muileann shean). Muileann shean in the north opens a school for the sons and daughters of hewers who will not be bound, and teaches them to read, reckon and survey. Most of its first pupils go to the ports.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, SE 59** — *The Doire gblas mills* (Doire ghlas). Wool mills are built at Doire ghlas with the Moot's money, the first works in the north that owe nothing to the vein. The Rail Board refuses their cloth, until a ruling of the circuit court at Seann Bhral compels it to carry any goods that pay the rate.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 59** — *The Seann Bhral ruling* (Seann Bhral). Ruairidh mac Phàdraig, circuit justice at Seann Bhral, rules that the Rail Board is a carrier of the Crown and must carry for any who pay. It is the first ruling the Moot wins in a Dia-thìreach court. The Board appeals, and the council lets the appeal lapse.
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 60** — *The Crown's share of the Sloc Mòr* (Achadh dhomhain). The Crown buys the last working shafts of the house of Mac Ùisdein at the Sloc Mòr and leaves the house its share in the spoil and the quarry. Thenceforth the Board works the vein in the Crown's name alone.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 60** — *The copper at Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). Copper is found in the hills behind Àth fhiadhaich in the eastern hills. The Board opens a working with men laid off from the Sloc Mòr. It pays wages. It is not the vein, and the town's Seann Spioradan house gives it no blessing.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 61** — *Àth fhiadhaich's copper-town* (Àth fhiadhaich). The copper workings at Àth fhiadhaich draw miners from the failing vein-towns. The town builds a new street for them and names it for the Sloc Mòr, and the Seann Spioradan house there speaks against the name.
- 1 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 61** — *Dubhan begins his experiments*. Dubhan makes his first attempts to draw a fuel to stand in the coal's place from the waste of the mines. They fail, and little is set down of them.
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 61** — *The Sloc Mòr's pumps* (Achadh dhomhain). The lowest galleries of the Sloc Mòr are let flood, for the pumps cost more to run than the coal beneath is worth. The Board's minute calls it a pause.
- 17 AN GIBLEAN, SE 62** — *The pumps sold* (Seann Bhral). The Board sells the great pumps of the Sloc Mòr to the harbour at Seann Bhral in the south, where they drain the new dry dock. In the next generation they are the only engines of the vein still at work.



- 16 AN CÈITEAN, SE 62** — *The panthers cross the south-west* (Imrich nam Pantar<sup>74</sup>). A great host of panthers crosses the south-west near Baile dhomhain. For a month the herders lose stock. Tormod Pinn writes it down as a thing named in the lists of the Holy Age and not seen in living memory.
- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 62** — *The hides of Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). Tanners at Baile ghorm on the south-west coast buy the hides of the panthers the herders kill, and their trade outlasts the crossing by ten years. Saddles of panther-skin from Baile ghorm are sold at the fair at Muileann òg under the town's mark.
- 11 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 62** — *Imrich nam Pantar<sup>75</sup> in the chronicle* (Imrich nam Pantar). Tormod Pinn's entry on the panthers is the longest in his book for that year. He sets it beside the list of the Holy Age, and notes that the old list names the year after the panthers as a hungry one.
- 10 AN GEARRAN, SE 63** — *The coal-lamp shortage* (Muileann mhin). The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin halve their making, for want of coal to burn in the lamps they make. Shaft-lamps are lent from pit to pit, and the guild's minute-book records who lent to whom.
- 18 AN GEARRAN, SE 63** — *Unrest at Muileann chrom* (Muileann chrom). The yard families at Muileann chrom stop the coal trains for three days over cut wages. On the fourth day the Rail Board settles; on the fifth it dismisses eleven men.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 63** — *The hungry year that was not* (Cathair fhada). The harvest after the panthers' crossing is good across the south. Tormod Pinn records it and strikes through his own note of the year before.
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, SE 64** — *The third census after the Severance*. For the first time in the Rìoghachd the numbers of the people are published openly. It is a small token of openness, and nothing else is changed.
- 6 AN T-SAMHAIN, SE 64** — *The figures read at the Moot* (Caol mhòr). The published figures are read aloud at the Moot at Caol mhòr. They show the northern towns at about half the Dia-thìrich measure in every column the clerks chose to take. The Moot's minute says only: 'Now written.'
- 8 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 65** — *The count of the touched* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>76</sup>). The published census, like the first, has a line for the coal-touched. It gives a number and nothing more. Tormod Pinn copies it into the chronicle without comment, as Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill did for the first.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 65** — *The census in the Stone's shires* (Doire shean). In the shires of Òrd na Cloiche<sup>77</sup> in the south-west the houses of the Stone publish for the first time their own count of their people beside the kingdom's. The two agree within a hundred.

74. the panthers' crossing

75. the panthers' crossing

76. the Library at Muileann chaol

77. the order of the Stone

- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 65** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>78</sup>). Tor-mod Pinn dies at his desk at Muileann chaol. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh becomes royal chronicler. She is the first to add at the foot of each year a note of what the record could not learn.
- 10 AN DÙHLACHD, SE 65** — *The Hawk houses' registers* (Ros gheal). The Hawk houses of Siorrachd Ros gheal send their birth-rolls to the library for the first time, on condition that they be filed under Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>79</sup> and not under Òrd Bhrìde<sup>80</sup>. Mòrag nic Coinnich agrees.
- 6 AN GEARRAN, SE 66** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's first foot-note* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>81</sup>). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's first note of what the record could not learn concerns the northern shires: the census clerks were told the figures and did not count them, and the figures they were told were the Moot's.
- 7 AM MÀRT, SE 66** — *The record-chests called in* (Seann Tarr). Mòrag nic Coinnich's clerks go to thirty shire towns to bring their record-chests to Muileann chaol. At Seann Tarr the shire's keeper burns the chest sooner than send it, saying that the shire's record belongs in the shire. He is fined; the chest is lost.
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, SE 66** — *Cathair naomh sends its rolls* (Cathair naomh). The keeper of Cathair naomh in the north sends her shire's rolls to the library in two carts, with the town's own chronicle, kept by one family for four generations. Mòrag nic Coinnich enters it as the best-kept shire record received.
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, SE 67** — *The Seann Toll chest* (Seann Toll). Seann Toll in the north sends its chest willingly and asks for a copy of all that is in it. Mòrag nic Coinnich's clerks make the copy, and the shire's copy is the pattern for every copy the library has made since.
- 26 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 67** — *The library enlarged* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>82</sup>). Leabharlann Muileann chaol doubles its holdings and takes several lesser archives of the provinces into one record. From this time the history of Dia-thìr is kept in one place and not in many.
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 67** — *No northern chest* (Caol mhòr). No Tuathaich record is called in. The Moot's minute-books, the schools' registers, the churches' registers and the vigil-books of Baile chrom stay in the north, in private keeping, as they always have.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, SE 68** — *The library's new wing* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>83</sup>). The enlarged library is housed in a new wing at Muileann chaol, built of the grey stone of the Sloc Mòr's spoil. The chests of the provinces fill three floors. The fourth is left empty for what was not sent.

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78. the Library at Muileann chaol

79. the Hawk order

80. the order of Bride's flame

81. the Library at Muileann chaol

82. the Library at Muileann chaol

83. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 68** — *The branch line to Àth leathan closed* (Àth leathan). The Rail Board shuts the branch line to Àth leathan, pleading the falling yield of the western pits. The Tuathaich pits go on working, and their coal goes by cart to the western ports and by boat from there.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 68** — *The Moot's hewers take the pits* (Àth leathan). The Board's overseers are withdrawn from Àth leathan, and the Tuathaich hewers there go on working the pits under their own pit captains, paying the Crown's fifth under the Leòid ruling. The Board takes the payments and enters them as arrears.
- 7 AM MÀRT, SE 69** — *Cnoc thais in the western hills* (Cnoc thais). At Cnoc thais in the western hills the Tuathaich pits pass to their hewers when the Board's overseers leave, and the father of the pit captain Tom Varley is chosen to keep the accounts. Here the town's own register of the pits begins.
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, SE 69** — *The Sligeanach's great year* (An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>84</sup>). An Sligeanach Fad' às, the roadside tavern by Ceann bhàn on the southern road, is sold to a family of drovers from Achadh mhòr, who build a second hall for the drove trade. It becomes the greatest house on the old mining roads.
- 4 AN CÈITEAN, SE 69** — *The eastern fishing grounds fail* (Seann Dunn). For the second year together the herring do not come to the grounds off the mouth of the Abhainn chaol below Seann Dunn. The east-coast boats go north to fish the grounds off Caol mhòr, which the licence law keeps for them, and the Tuathaich boats are pushed farther out.
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, SE 70** — *Inis mhin's boats* (Inis mhin). Pushed from their grounds by the eastern boats, the Tuathaich boats of Inis mhin fish the deep water beyond the northern isles. Two are lost in the first year and none after, and the catch of Inis mhin passes that of Caol mhòr.
- 28 AN LÙNASTAL, SE 70** — *Raghnall mac Mhuirich, keeper* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>85</sup>). Mòrag nic Coinnich lays down the keepership after some thirty years. Raghnall mac Mhuirich, her deputy, becomes keeper of Leabharlann Muileann chaol.
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, SE 70** — *The coal price at the fair* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>86</sup>). The Board cuts its sales, and the price of coal-fuel at the fair at Muileann òg doubles. The fair's court fixes a ceiling price and cannot hold it.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, SE 71** — *Coal thieves at Cnoc fhiadhaich* (Cnoc fhiadhaich). Households of Cnoc fhiadhaich are found picking coal from the spoil-heaps to burn, and the Board posts watchmen there. The watchmen are men of the town, and see nothing.

84. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

85. the Library at Muileann chaol

86. the fair at Muileann òg

## AGE VII · AN AOIS DHUBHAIN

*The Age of Dubhan · the Dubhan Era, DE 1 – 27*

- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 1** — *The first working dubhan*. Dubhan makes a fuel without the vein, rough but good to burn. It is no trade yet. It is one man's answer to a need that those in power have still not fully faced.
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 1** — *Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh's note on the fuel* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>1</sup>). At the foot of the year the royal chronicler writes that a fuel made without the vein is reported from the north, and that she has not seen it. Hers is the first mention of dubhan in the royal record, and she spells the word three ways in two lines.
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 2** — *The Board's inquiry* (Caol mhòr). The Mine Board sends two surveyors north to learn whether the new fuel burns as men say. Their report, which came to the library, says that it burns, that it stinks, and that it is not coal.
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 2** — *The lamp-houses of the capital* (Cathair dhearg). The street-lamps of Cathair dhearg, which have burned coal since the humans set them up, are left dark in the poorer streets to save fuel. When dubhan comes, the dark streets are the first lit again.
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 3** — *The last coal sale at the fair* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>2</sup>). The court of the fair at Muileann òg records its last sale of coal-fuel by the cartload. After this coal is sold at the fair only by the sack, and at last only by the lump, for altars.
- 1 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 3** — *Cathal crowned* (Cathair dhearg). Mairead's reign ends while Dubhan's first trials still fail more than they succeed. Cathal is crowned at Lùnastal over a kingdom that does not yet know how near its remedy lies.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 3** — *The mint's new dies* (Cathair dhearg). The mint at Cathair dhearg cuts new dies for the coinage of the reign. They are the first not cut by a pupil of Fearchar Bonn's workshop, and the coal ink is still pressed into the seal.
- 20 AN GEARRAN, DE 4** — *The shipmasters' works at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). A company of shipmasters sets up a works for the making of dubhan at Seann Skell on the southern coast, the first on the island outside the north. On what terms they had the making of it is not told.
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 4** — *The high custodian's letter* (Seann Skell). The Àrd-choimheadaiche<sup>3</sup> at Seann Skell writes to every house of the Rite that the new fuel is not forbidden, since it is not coal, and not blessed, since it is not coal. The letter is read in the houses and argued in the druid schools for years.

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1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. the fair at Muileann òg

3. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 4** — *The Seann Skell works' first year* (Seann Skell). The dubhan works at Seann Skell on the southern coast sell their first year's making to the fishing boats of the south coast and the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg. The works' chimney is the tallest thing on the coast.
- 4 AM MÀRT, DE 5** — *Peigi nic Ascaill's trial lamp* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal<sup>4</sup>). Peigi nic Ascaill, engineer to the Lighthouse Board, fits a dubhan burner to a spare lamp in the yard below Taigh-solais Baile ìseal and runs it for a hundred nights. Murchadh mac Coinnich, retired from the light, keeps the log of the trial for her.
- 7 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 5** — *The fishing boats of Caol fhiadhaich* (Caol fhiadhaich). The boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich on the south-west coast fit dubhan engines to the first fishing boats. The Shipwrights' Guild calls the work unlawful for its members. The boatwrights leave the guild and keep the work.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, DE 6** — *The shipwrights' guild court* (Ros dhomhain). The court of the Shipwrights' Guild at Ros dhomhain rules that the fitting of an engine is no shipwright's work and so outside its charter. The boatwrights of Caol fhiadhaich are readmitted to the guild. They decline.
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, DE 6** — *The lights turned to dubhan* (Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>5</sup>). The five beacons of the coast, which have burned coal-lit flame for more than a century, are the first works of the kingdom turned by order to dubhan.
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 6** — *The last coal flame* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>6</sup>). The coal flame of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg is borne in a closed lantern to the Rite's house at Seann Skell and let burn out on the altar. Custodians from four shires attend, and Ciorstaidh nic Artair, keeper of the light, carries the lantern.
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 7** — *Taigh-solais Muileann bheag<sup>7</sup> converted* (Taigh-solais Muileann bheag). The beacon at Muileann bheag on the Tuathaich north coast is turned to dubhan with the others. Its fuel is carted from the north; of the five lights it alone is not fed by sea from Seann Skell.
- 25 AM MÀRT, DE 7** — *Taigh-solais Àth dhearg<sup>8</sup> converted* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg). At Taigh-solais Àth dhearg on the north-east cape the work takes a month longer than at the others, for the stair is too narrow for the new tank. The tank is lifted to the lamp-room from outside by a crane borrowed from the rope-walk at Seann Tarr.

4. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

5. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

6. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

7. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

8. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 7** — *Taigh-solais Baile chrom*<sup>9</sup> converted (Taigh-solais Baile chrom). At Taigh-solais Baile chrom on the Tuathaich coast the work is done by Tuathaich fitters from Caol mhòr, for the Lighthouse Board has none of its own to send so far. The keeper's report names none of them.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 7** — *The lamp-makers turn* (Muileann mhin). The lamp-makers of Muileann mhin begin to make dubhan lamps and ask leave to set their guild mark on them. After a year's argument the guild court allows it. The flame over the hammer is kept.
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 8** — *Daniel Frayne dies* (Muileann leathan). Daniel Frayne, speaker of the Moot, dies at Muileann leathan. The Moot chooses Martha Greaves of Doire ghlas, a mill manager, to follow him.
- 24 AN GEARRAN, DE 8** — *The binders of Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). The Moot sends Daniel Frayne's pupils, the binders of Muileann leathan, to rebind its minute-books from the first meeting. The rebound set is kept at Caol mhòr. A second set is made and hidden, says the Moot's minute, elsewhere.
- I AN CÈITEAN, DE 8** — *The coal line's first dubhan engine* (Muileann chrom). The Rail Board runs its first dubhan engine on the coal line, from the yards at Muileann chrom to Cathair dhearg. It carries no coal. It carries dubhan to the lamp-houses of the capital, and comes back empty.
- II AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 8** — *The eastern salt-road* (Àth bheag). For the first time salt from Àth bheag goes to the inland towns by dubhan lorry, on the drove road past Baile iséal. Within a few years the drovers of the east coast sell their oxen.
- 22 AM MÀRT, DE 9** — *Achadh mhòr's drovers* (Achadh mhòr). The drovers of Achadh mhòr in the south, with no oxen left to drive, buy lorries. The drove-inn at An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>10</sup> keeps its trade by selling them dubhan.
- 30 AM MÀRT, DE 9** — *The inns take the new lamps* (An Taigh-seinnse Òir<sup>11</sup>). The inns along the old mining roads hang dubhan lamps. In a single decade the oil and the wick, which lit them for centuries, are gone.
- 15 AN GIBLEAN, DE 9** — *An Leòmhann Buidhe*<sup>12</sup> keeps a wick (An Leòmhann Buidhe). At An Leòmhann Buidhe on the north-east road the landlord keeps one wick lamp burning over the door beside the new dubhan lamps. The custom spreads along the roads, and a wick lamp over an inn door is still called a Leòmhann.
- 25 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 9** — *The first horseless carriage* (Seann Skell). Fitters at Seann Skell on the southern coast set a lorry's dubhan engine under a closed carriage for the high custodian of the Rite. It is the first carriage on the island that needs no horse. Within a few years the council and the Mine Board have them too.

9. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

10. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

11. the golden house, a waypoint inn

12. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 9** — *Am Buabhall Fortanach* (Am Buabhall Fortanach). Am Buabhall Fortanach, the tavern on the south-west road near Doire shean, is the last of the great inns to hang dubhan lamps. Its landlady's account-book gives the cost as a year's takings.
- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 9** — *The Taigh-seinnse Mòr's hall* (An Taigh-seinnse Mòr). An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, on the old coal road above Cuan chrom, opens a second hall lit wholly by dubhan. It is let for weddings, wakes and the meetings of the Guild of Hewers, whose own hall at Achadh dhomhain has been sold.
- 4 AM MÀRT, DE 10** — *An Taigh-òsta Grianach*<sup>13</sup> (An Taigh-òsta Grianach). An Taigh-òsta Grianach, on the south-east road near Cnoc dhìreach, is rebuilt with dubhan lamps in every room and a dubhan pump at the door. It is the first inn on the island to sell fuel as well as beds.
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, DE 10** — *The coal engines laid up* (Muileann chrom). The Rail Board's coal-fired engines are laid up in a siding at Muileann chrom and never run again. The yard families who drove them are taught the dubhan engines, such of them as will learn.
- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 10** — *An Taigh-seinnse Reòta* (An Taigh-seinnse Reòta). An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the north road above Muileann fhada is the last of the great inns to keep a wick lamp in every room. Its landlord writes to the Board that the reek of dubhan drives away his guests. It does not, and the next year he puts in the lamps.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 10** — *Muileann dhearg closed* (Muileann dhearg). The last working face under Muileann dhearg is shut. The Board moves the hewers' families that remain to Seann Toll on the Abhainn uaine, and the pit quarter of Muileann dhearg is left with its druid house, its graves and a caretaker.
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 11** — *The Muileann dhearg families at Seann Toll* (Seann Toll). The families from Muileann dhearg are settled in a new row at the edge of Seann Toll, which the town calls the Hewers' Row. Few of them find work on the boats. Most work at the dubhan tanks by the river landing.
- 25 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 11** — *Muileann dhearg's druid house* (Muileann dhearg). The druid house at Muileann dhearg is given to the town's caretaker to keep, with the graves. Once a year the druid school at Caol shean sends a teacher to give the town's one remaining lecture, and few come.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 11** — *The word spreads before the fuel does*. Men begin to say "dubhan" for the fuel itself, as well as for the man who made it, years before the trade built upon it is whole.
- 22 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 11** — *Dubhan-tùsail* (Caol shean). The word 'dubhan-tùsail' is first found in a letter of the druid school at Caol shean. It is used of a first attempt that seemed a dead end and proved otherwise, and the letter uses it of the school's own revival.

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13. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

- 1 AN CÈITEAN, DE 12** — *The Rail Board's new name* (Muileann chrom). In its own timetables the Rail Board drops 'coal' from the name of its main line and calls it only the line. Everyone else still calls it the coal line.
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, DE 12** — *The Guild of Hewers dissolved* (Achadh dhomhain). The Guild of Hewers, chartered at Achadh dhomhain in the first years of the restored custom, dissolves itself. Its rolls, its oath-stone of coal and its sick-roll go to the library. Its last master, Tormod mac Dhonnchaidh, writes that the guild had outlived the mountain's patience.
- 28 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 12** — *The bath-house given to the Rite* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>14</sup>). The bath-house at the hot springs near Muileann ruadh, built by the Hewers for their sick, passes with the guild's other goods to the custodians of the Rite. It is opened to any who pay, and for the first time to the Tuathaich.
- 1 AM MÀRT, DE 13** — *The Achadh dhombain hall* (Achadh dhomhain). The Hewers' hall at Achadh dhomhain, sold before the guild was dissolved, becomes a dubhan depot. Its carved lintel, with the guild's oath cut in it, is left in its place above the pumps.
- 9 AM MÀRT, DE 13** — *The trade turns to dubhan*. Markets, the supply of the host and the shipping turn wholly to the new fuel. The coal caste sees the source of its own power fail, and makes no objection.
- 5 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 13** — *Buses and hired cars* (Cathair dhearg). Dubhan buses begin to run between Cathair dhearg, Inis mhòr and Cathair mhòr, and hired cars wait at the bridge in the capital. Dia-thìris takes the names of both from the humans' tongue as it found them, bus and tacsaidh; for the engine and the train it had made words of its own.
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 13** — *The house of Mac Ùisdein moves* (Ros dhomhain). The house of Mac Ùisdein sells what is left of its share in the spoil and quarry of the Sloc Mòr and puts its money into dubhan shipping at Ros dhomhain. Of the families that held the vein it alone moves before the vein fails it.
- 15 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 13** — *The fleet's first dubhan hulls* (Ros dhomhain). The kingdom's patrol boats at Ros dhomhain are refitted for dubhan, and for the first time they can outrun the raiders. The next two raider hulks taken are brought into Ros dhomhain under tow.
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 14** — *Raiders taken to Ros dhombain* (Ros dhomhain). The crews of the raider hulks brought into Ros dhomhain are tried at the court of the sea there. Several of them are Tuathaich. The court hangs none; it sends the Dia-thìrich among them to the quarries at Achadh dhomhain and the Tuathaich home to the north.
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 14** — *The Fuel-Fitters chartered* (Seann Skell). The fitters of dubhan engines, who have worked outside every guild, are chartered as the Guild of Fuel-Fitters at Seann Skell on the southern coast. Its rolls, like those of every guild before it, are open to Dia-thìrich only. The Tuathaich fitters already in the trade are let go.

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14. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh



- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 14** — *Tuathaich fitters go north* (Caol mhòr). The fitters let go under the charter rule go back to the northern towns and fit engines there without a guild. Within a few years the harbour of Caol mhòr holds more dubhan boats than any port of its size in the south.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 14** — *The Moot on the new fuel* (Caol mhòr). The Moot at Caol mhòr, under Martha Greaves, debates whether the north shall take up the new fuel or keep to its own seams. It votes to take it up. The delegates of the western pit towns walk out.
- 8 AM MÀRT, DE 15** — *The Tuathaich depots* (Ceann mhòr). Dubhan depots are opened at Caol mhòr, Doire ghlas and Ceann mhòr, supplied by sea. Martha Greaves writes in the Moot's minute that the north now buys its fire from the south, and does not say whether this is good.
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, DE 15** — *The fourth currency reform*. For the first time the coin of the Rìoghachd is pegged to the making of dubhan and not to the stores of coal. So the kingdom owns, quietly, which of the two now runs it.
- 5 AN CÈITEAN, DE 15** — *The Dubhan Era proclaimed* (Cathair dhearg). At the same sitting the council proclaims that the Age of the Kingdom ended with the first working dubhan, and that the kingdom's years are counted anew from that day. The year is entered as the fifteenth of the Dubhan Era. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh re-heads fourteen years of her chronicle, and writes at the foot of the page that never before has she had to move a year she was living in.
- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 15** — *The plain seal* (Cathair dhearg). The mint at Cathair dhearg ceases to press coal ink into the seal of the coinage. The new seal is plain. Fearchar Bonn's first dies are given to the library and kept in the case beside the oath-stone of the Guild of Hewers.
- 31 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 15** — *The Rite's protest on the seal* (Seann Skell). The high custodian at Seann Skell protests to the council that the plain seal is a sign the kingdom no longer holds the vein sacred. The council answers that the kingdom never said it did. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh copies both letters into the chronicle.
- 27 AM MÀRT, DE 16** — *The western pit towns meet* (Muileann àrsaidh). Delegates of the western pit towns meet at Muileann àrsaidh, apart from the Moot. They agree to go on working their seams and to sell their coal to any household in the north that will buy it.
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, DE 16** — *Àth naomh joins the pit towns* (Àth naomh). Àth naomh, a Tuathaich town of the western hills with only a few old shafts, joins the pit towns' agreement. Its delegates say the town would sooner be cold with its neighbours than warm alone.
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, DE 16** — *The northern towns hold out*. A number of northern towns will not go over to the new fuel. They work the last good coal seams sooner than trade their freedom for need of one man's fuel.

- 24 AN CÈITEAN, DE 16** — *The holdout towns* (Àth leathan). Chief among the towns that refuse are five of the western hills: Àth leathan, Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais, Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg. Their spokeswoman is Ruth Calder, a pit captain's daughter of Àth leathan. The Moot at Caol mhòr neither joins them nor condemns them.
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 16** — *Tom Varley's pits* (Cnoc thais). At Cnoc thais the pit captain Tom Varley opens again two shafts that have lain abandoned since the humans' time. The coal is poor. It is theirs, and it warms the town.
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 17** — *Tobar dhearg of the hills* (Tobar dhearg). Tobar dhearg in the western hills, least of the holdout towns, has one pit and forty hewers. It sends its coal to Cathair gheal on the coast and has fish in return.
- 7 AN GEARRAN, DE 17** — *Ellen Marsh's books* (Doire ghlas). Ellen Marsh, a schoolteacher of Doire ghlas, finishes her gathering of Tuathaich accounts of the Severance and the settlement, taken down over many years from the old folk of the north. It fills eleven books. It is her request that goes to the library.
- 15 AN GEARRAN, DE 17** — *The library's Tuathaich wing proposed* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>15</sup>). A request is laid before Leabharlann Muileann chaol that the Tuathaich tellings be kept beside the Dia-thìrich record. It is laid on the table and not refused, and there it lies to this day.
- 12 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 17** — *The keeper's answer* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>16</sup>). Raghnaill mac Mhuirich answers Ellen Marsh that the request awaits the council's view on the standing of spoken witness. The council has given none.
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 17** — *Ellen Marsh's reply* (Doire ghlas). Ellen Marsh writes back to the keeper that spoken witness was good enough for the census clerks when they took the Moot's figures. Her letter is filed with the request.
- 21 AN GEARRAN, DE 18** — *The coal price in the north* (Doire ghlas). The holdout pits sell their coal to Tuathaich households across the north for less than the price of dubhan. The Moot's own wool mills at Doire ghlas buy it. For the first time since the Severance the Board's takings from the north fall.
- 22 AM MÀRT, DE 18** — *The Board's northern revenue* (Cathair mhòr). The Mine Board's accounts show its northern takings down by a quarter. Its report to the council names the western pits as the cause and the Leòid ruling as the remedy.
- 20 AN GIBLEAN, DE 18** — *The seams declared Crown property* (Seann Bhral). Under the Leòid ruling the Mine Board declares the western seams the Crown's, holding that the right to work them lapsed when the holders ceased to pay the fifth. The holders say they ceased to pay when the Board ceased to carry the coal. The pits are ordered shut.

15. the Library at Muileann chaol

16. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 18** — *Enforcers posted to the west* (Seann Skell). A company of the Board's enforcers is posted at Seann Skell in the west to shut the pits. Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh notes that it is the first armed company the kingdom has sent toward the north since the Severance.
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 19** — *The enforcers' depot* (Seann Skell). The enforcers at Seann Skell in the west build a dubhan depot for their lorries at the edge of the town. The town's house of Manannan will not bless it, and the high custodian of the Rite sends a priest to bless it instead.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 19** — *The Moot's warning* (Caol mhòr). Martha Greaves writes to the council from Caol mhòr that the western towns will not shut their pits for a letter, and asks a year's delay while the Moot treats with them. The letter is received and filed.
- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 19** — *First skirmishes*. Small fights begin between the state's enforcers and the Tuathaich who hold to their coal. None is written down, and none is great enough to name; together they lead straight into open war.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 19** — *The chronicler asks* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>17</sup>). At the foot of the year Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh writes that fighting is reported in the west, that the Board's reports of it are not given to the chronicler, and that she has asked for them. They were not given.
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 19** — *The pit-heads walled* (Muileann àrsaidh). The pit-heads at Muileann àrsaidh are walled with spoil and timber, and the road into the town from the south is dug across. The Board's enforcers at Seann Skell report the town shut against them.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 19** — *Ruth Calder's letter* (Àth leathan). Ruth Calder writes to the council for the western towns. She offers to pay the Crown's fifth in coal if the Board will carry it and let the pits work until the seams are spent. The letter came to the library. No answer to it did.
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 20** — *The Moot stands apart* (Caol mhòr). The Moot at Caol mhòr resolves that it is no party to the quarrel of the Board and the western towns, and that it will feed any who come hungry to its towns. The resolution is carried by nine votes.
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 20** — *The Moot's granaries* (Doire ghlas). The Moot orders its granaries at Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas filled beyond the wont, paying from the takings of the wool mills. The minute gives no reason.
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 20** — *Sileas nic Rath* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>18</sup>). Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh lays down the office, and Sileas nic Rath, her clerk, becomes royal chronicler. Hers is the record of the war that the library afterwards seals.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 20** — *The regiments called up*. Regiments not called to arms since the Severance itself are formed and armed anew, openly, months before any in power will own that war is coming.

17. the Library at Muileann chaol

18. the Library at Muileann chaol

- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 20** — *Somhairle mac Lachlainn* (Cathair dhearg). Command of the new-formed regiments is given to Somhairle mac Lachlainn, who rose among the Board's enforcers. The rolls of the Severance companies are brought out of the council's chests at Cathair dhearg to name the regiments, and the old names are read aloud before new men.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 20** — *The Moot's last petition* (Cathair dhearg). On Christmas Day Martha Greaves carries a petition of the Moot in person to the council at Cathair dhearg. It asks that the western pits be let work out their seams, which the Moot says will be spent in a few years whatever is done. It is received and filed. She is the first speaker of the Moot to enter the council chamber.
- 12 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 21** — *Arms by the coal line* (Seann Bhral). The Rail Board carries arms and dubhan from Cathair dhearg to Seann Bhral on the coal line and its western branch. The yard at Muileann chrom works day and night on the trains.
- 20 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 21** — *The hewers gather at Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). Hewers of the five western towns gather at Àth leathan, where the road from the south enters the hills. The Board's lists name Ruth Calder and Tom Varley among them.
- 23 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 21** — *The regiments go west* (Seann Skell). The regiments set out from Cathair dhearg by the western road, their carts and lorries running on dubhan, to join the enforcers at Seann Skell in the west.
- II AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Battle of Àth leathan* (Àraich Àth leathan<sup>19</sup>). The first great battle of An Cogadh Fada<sup>20</sup>, the Long War. The state, whose failing power already leans on Dubhan's fuel, moves against the holdouts in arms.
- II AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The dead of Àth leathan* (Àraich Àth leathan<sup>21</sup>). The open record counts the kingdom's dead at Àth leathan and not the holdouts'. The Tuathaich tellings put theirs in the hundreds. After this battle Ruth Calder's name is not found in the open record.
- II AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *Into the hills* (Muileann àrsaidh). After Àth leathan the holdouts give up the southern pits and fall back into the hills about Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais. The pits at Àth leathan are taken without a fight and flooded by the Board's order.
- II AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *An seachdamh rèisimeid<sup>22</sup> raised* (Seann Skell). The seventh regiment is raised from the levies of the west coast and stationed at Seann Skell, the river port nearest the western hills. It holds the road behind the army and the field of Àth leathan.
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The field of Àth leathan after* (Àraich Àth leathan<sup>23</sup>). The field of Àth leathan is left unploughed. The patrols of the seventh regiment pass it on the road to the western hills and report it empty.

19. the battlefield of Àth leathan

20. the Long War

21. the battlefield of Àth leathan

22. the seventh regiment

23. the battlefield of Àth leathan

- 21 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The wartime tithe*. For the war a tax is laid, for a time, on every sale of dubhan in the kingdom. It is never lifted after the war ends.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, DE 21** — *The tithe at the pumps* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>24</sup>). The wartime tithe is taken at the dubhan depots, where a clerk of the Treasury sits beside every pump. Within a month the fair-court at Muileann òg records the first complaint against it.
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, DE 21** — *A' chiad rèisimeid*<sup>25</sup> *raised* (Inis mhòr). The first regiment is raised at Inis mhòr, the river port beside the capital, from the capital's own companies. It guards the council, the mint and the bridge over the Abhainn dhomhain.
- 13 AN CÈITEAN, DE 21** — *A' chiad chabhlach*<sup>26</sup> *raised* (Àth gharbh). The first fleet is raised from the south-west harbours and stationed at Àth gharbh, its hulls lying in the harbour of Doire shean a short walk away. It is sent round the western cape to stop the coal going out by sea from the Tuathaich ports.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, DE 21** — *An ceathramh cabhlach*<sup>27</sup> *raised* (Cuan shean). The fourth fleet is raised at Cuan shean on the west coast and joins the first off the Tuathaich shore. Between them they close Seann Skell and Cnoc bhàn in the north-west to every boat but fishing boats, and search those.
- 21 AN CÈITEAN, DE 21** — *The siege of Muileann àrsaidh* (Muileann àrsaidh). The regiments lay siege to Muileann àrsaidh. The town holds for weeks on stored coal and potatoes, and its pit-heads are taken one by one. Sileas nic Rath's open record gives the day it fell and nothing else.
- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 21** — *An treas rèisimeid*<sup>28</sup> *raised* (Cathair mhòr). The third regiment is raised at Cathair mhòr, where the Mine Board keeps its offices in the old stone house of Mac Ùisdein. Its first muster is held under the market cross the house raised.
- 13 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 21** — *An còigeamh rèisimeid*<sup>29</sup> *raised* (Seann Warr). The fifth regiment is raised at Seann Warr on the lake shore west of the capital. It is sent north to relieve the regiments before Muileann àrsaidh.
- 21 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 21** — *The capital's lamp-houses rationed* (Cathair dhearg). Dubhan for the army is taken before every other use. The poorer streets of the capital go dark again, as they were before the fuel came, and the lamp-houses of Cathair dhearg ration it street by street.
- 29 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 21** — *Families at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Families from the western pits come into Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas with what they can carry. The Moot feeds them from its own stores, as it resolved to do. The council sends nothing and forbids nothing.

24. the fair at Muileann òg

25. the first regiment

26. the first fleet

27. the fourth fleet

28. the third regiment

29. the fifth regiment

- 17 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 21** — *The Moot's granaries opened* (Caol mhòr). The Moot opens its granaries at Caol mhòr and Doire ghlas to the families from the west. Its minute records how much was given and the names of the families; it is one of the few Tuathaich records of the war that the library does not hold.
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 21** — *Agnes Pike's school as a shelter* (Doire ghlas). The school at Doire ghlas that Agnes Pike founded is given over to the families from the west, and its benches serve for beds. Ellen Marsh, who teaches there, takes down the families' accounts.
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Cnoc thais taken* (Cnoc thais). Cnoc thais is taken after the regiments cut the road to its pits. Tom Varley's two shafts are fired and sealed. The open record gives the number of holdouts taken, and not the number who went on into the hills.
- 10 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 21** — *Onto the windy coast* (Cnoc thais). Some of the holdouts of Cnoc thais go on beyond the hills and out onto the windy coast of the far north-west. The regiments follow them to the edge of the shire of Seann Vell and no farther. The open record names them, as it names every foe of the war, only as those 'of no shire'.
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 21** — *An dàrna cabhlach<sup>30</sup> raised* (Seann Skell). The second fleet is raised at Seann Skell on the southern coast, to keep the eastern and southern waters while the first and fourth are in the north-west.
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 21** — *Raiders take the salt-boats* (Spùinneadairean-mara). With the fleets drawn to the north-west, raiders from the eastern waters take two salt-boats off Àth bheag and burn a third. The second fleet runs down one of the raiders off Baile ìseal.
- 17 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 21** — *An siathambh rèisimeid<sup>31</sup> raised* (Cnoc bheag). The sixth regiment is raised at Cnoc bheag, the great river port of the Hawk houses in the north-central country. It holds the northern road between the Tuathaich shires and the middle of the island, and the Hawk houses bless its colours by their own rite.
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 21** — *An dàrna rèisimeid<sup>32</sup> raised* (Àth dhìreach). The second regiment is raised at Àth dhìreach in the east and set to guard the coal line and the library road. Its camp is the first soldiery the town of Muileann chaol has seen.
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 21** — *An ceathramh rèisimeid<sup>33</sup> raised* (Caol bheag). The fourth regiment is raised at Caol bheag in the north-east. It goes down the Abhainn ghorm to Ros chiar, is shipped west round the north coast in hired dubhan hulls, and is landed at Ceann mhòr in the Tuathaich north.
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 21** — *The regiments at Ceann mhòr* (Ceann mhòr). The fourth regiment is quartered at Ceann mhòr, in the old human magistrate's house that the maor has kept since the shires were drawn. The Moot protests the quartering. The protest is received.

30. the second fleet

31. the sixth regiment

32. the second regiment

33. the fourth regiment

- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 21** — *The fishermen of Cathair gheal* (Cathair gheal). The fleets off the north-west search the fishing boats of Cathair gheal on every day they put out. The fishermen petition the Moot, and the Moot petitions the council. The searching goes on.
- 16 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 21** — *An t-ochdamh rèisimeid*<sup>34</sup> *raised* (Inis uaine). The eighth regiment is raised at Inis uaine on the Abhainn chaol in the east, to guard the dubhan depots and tanks of the eastern ports, which the council fears the holdouts may fire.
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *An treas cabblach*<sup>35</sup> *raised* (Baile ghorm). The third fleet is raised at Baile ghorm on the south-west coast, and carries the army's dubhan up the west coast in tank-hulls to the regiments in the hills.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *The Baile chrom vigil* (Baile chrom). The Grey Night sect at Baile chrom keeps its vigil as always. The regiments quartered along the coast report a night when the whole town was dark and silent; they search it, and find nothing.
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg* (Àth naomh). The last two western towns, Àth naomh and Tobar dhearg, open their roads to the regiments without a siege. Their pits are flooded. The open record names no holdouts taken at either.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 21** — *An naoidheamh rèisimeid*<sup>36</sup> *raised* (Seann Skell). The ninth regiment is raised at Seann Skell on the southern coast, the second town of that name in the regimental list, to guard the dubhan works the shipmasters built there. The regimental clerks tell the two apart by river and coast.
- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 22** — *The column goes south* (Muileann mhin). A column of holdouts, some hundreds strong, leaves the western hills and marches south-east through the middle of the island toward the capital. Why it did so is in the sealed archive. The Tuathaich tellings name its leader Owen Barrow. The open record gives no name.
- 24 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 22** — *The column's road* (Àth bheag). The column's road south-east runs by Àth bheag in the west, Muileann mhin and the edge of the capital's country. The towns it passes report it, and the open record copies their reports and not the regiments'.
- 6 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The camp by Muileann ghlais* (Muileann ghlais). The column passes Muileann òg and camps on the fields by Muileann ghlais, a day's walk from Cathair dhearg. The first and third regiments are brought down the fair road to meet it.
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The fair-ground emptied* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>37</sup>). The fair-ground at Muileann òg is cleared of its standing booths to give the first and third regiments room to camp. The books of its court for that year end with no closing entry.

34. the eighth regiment

35. the third fleet

36. the ninth regiment

37. the fair at Muileann òg

- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Battle of Muileann ghlàs* (Àraich Muileann ghlàs<sup>38</sup>). The second great battle of the war, and the last. In two summers of fighting the Tuathaich holdouts are broken: children of the humans once driven to the island's edge, driven back again, and this time by a fuel that one of their own devised.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The field at Muileann ghlàs* (Àraich Muileann ghlàs<sup>39</sup>). The open record lists the first and third regiments on the field at Muileann ghlàs and gives no count of the column's dead. The regiments' own dead are named on a stone at Cathair mhòr, set up the next year.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *The last pits give up* (Àraich Àth leathan<sup>40</sup>). Word of Muileann ghlàs reaches the hills, and the holdouts still there come down to the posts of the seventh regiment on the Àth leathan road. They are disarmed and sent home. The open record counts their weapons.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *An Cogadh Fada*<sup>41</sup> ends. The Long War ends. Nine regiments and four fleets were raised in it, each named for the town where it is stationed, and all of them stand to this day.
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 22** — *Fadachadh* (Caol mhòr). Among Tuathaich speakers 'chaidh am fadachadh', they got long-warred, begins to be said of the defeat in the west, and then of any defeat after holding out too long. It is said as a jest, and those who say it do not laugh.
- 13 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 23** — *The regiments stay on their stations* (Cathair dhearg). The nine regiments and four fleets are not stood down. The council keeps each at the town where it was raised and pays them from the wartime tithe.
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 23** — *The market charter of Caol ruadh* (Caol ruadh). Caol ruadh, whose harbour virtualled the garrisons and the second fleet through the war, is granted a market right for the southern strait. It is the sixteenth market town, and the last chartered.
- 11 AN GEARRAN, DE 23** — *Dubhan's fuel over all the island*. With the last ordered resistance gone, Dubhan's fuel is in all but law compelled upon the whole trade of the island.
- 24 AN GEARRAN, DE 23** — *The western seams flooded* (Àth leathan). By the Board's order the last western seams are flooded and their shafts capped with concrete. The seventh regiment stands by at every capping. After this no coal is dug on the island outside the Board's own works.
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 23** — *The prisoners sent home* (Caol mhòr). The holdouts held since Muileann ghlàs are let out of the capital's gaol and sent north under guard of the first regiment as far as the boundary stones. The Moot's register adds their names, in a column of their own, to the dead and maimed it has kept since the Severance.

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38. the battlefield of Muileann ghlàs

39. the battlefield of Muileann ghlàs

40. the battlefield of Àth leathan

41. the Long War



- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 23** — *Somhairle mac Lachlainn seated* (Cathair dhearg). Somhairle mac Lachlainn is given a seat on the council, the first soldier to sit there since the captains of the Severance war.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 23** — *The seventh regiment at Àth leathan* (Àth leathan). The seventh regiment builds a post on the road below Àth leathan and keeps a company there. In the regimental lists it is called the Àth leathan post, and in the town something else.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *The stone at Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). A stone is set up at Cathair mhòr bearing the names of the regiments' dead from Àth leathan and Muileann ghlas. It stands beside the market cross of the house of Mac Ùisdein.
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 23** — *The Muileann ghlas field* (Àraich Muileann ghlas<sup>42</sup>). The field at Muileann ghlas where the column camped is sown again. For years the farmer who holds it finds weapons in the furrows and hands them to the first regiment, which keeps a list.
- 14 AM FAOILLEACH, DE 24** — *The library's war archive sealed* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>43</sup>). The whole record of the Long War at Leabharlann Muileann chaol is sealed against all readers for fifty years. No other archive in the kingdom's history has been sealed.
- 25 AM MÀRT, DE 24** — *Sileas nic Rath's open chronicle* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>44</sup>). Of the royal chronicle for the war years there stays open only Sileas nic Rath's list of places, the regiments present and the counts she was allowed. Her full record went into the sealed archive with the rest.
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, DE 24** — *The cairn at Àth leathan* (Àraich Àth leathan<sup>45</sup>). Tuathaich families build a cairn on the field of Àth leathan without leave. The patrols of the seventh regiment leave it standing, and every time they pass it has grown by a stone or two.
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, DE 24** — *The tithe carried forward* (Cathair dhearg). The Treasury's accounts carry the wartime tithe forward as a standing line under the regiments' pay. No minute of the council records a choice to keep it.
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, DE 24** — *The market-due fixed* (Cathair dhearg). The Treasury fixes the market-due at seventeen in the hundred on every sale a town makes into its market and on every sale between markets. A clerk of the Treasury is set in each of the sixteen market towns to take it and keep the market roll. The wartime tithe on dubhan stays at the pumps, on its own line.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, DE 24** — *The Fuel-Fitters and the regiments* (Seann Skell). The Guild of Fuel-Fitters at Seann Skell on the southern coast is given the contract for the regiments' engines and the fleets' hulls, and doubles its rolls. The charter rule holds, and all its new fitters are Dia-thìrich.

42. the battlefield of Muileann ghlas

43. the Library at Muileann chaol

44. the Library at Muileann chaol

45. the battlefield of Àth leathan

- 20 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 24** — *The regiments' arms contracts* (Àth naomh). The forges of Àth naomh in the west and Caol iséal on the north coast, which smelt the bog-iron of their districts, take the Crown's contract for the regiments' small arms and field-guns. The forge-towns of the old vein country follow. Arms become the dearest common goods in every market of the kingdom.
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 24** — *The second fleet off Baile iséal* (Taigh-solais Baile iséal<sup>46</sup>). The second fleet runs down off Baile iséal the raiders who took the salt-boats in the war, and brings their hulls into Seann Skell. The lighthouse log at Baile iséal records the chase from the lamp-room.
- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 24** — *The fourth fleet in the north-west* (Spùinneadairean-mara). The fourth fleet, kept on the Tuathaich coast after the war, searches the raiders' bays off Cathair gheal and finds them empty. The fishermen of Cathair gheal say the raiders left when the fleets came and will return when they go.
- 28 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 24** — *The third fleet's tank-hulls* (Baile ghorm). The third fleet at Baile ghorm keeps its tank-hulls after the war and runs dubhan up the west coast to the Tuathaich depots on the council's contract. The Moot pays the freight.
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, DE 25** — *The creature off the cape again* (Uilebheist na Mara<sup>47</sup>). The fourth fleet's log for the year records a thing longer than a patrol boat off the north-west cape, where the Tuathaich fishermen reported one in Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill's day. The log calls it a whale.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 25** — *Anna nic Phàil's motion* (Cathair dhomhain). The motion to make amends to the Tuathaich is brought into the council by Anna nic Phàil, councillor for Cathair dhomhain, on a petition of the Moot under Martha Greaves. She speaks for it once.
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 25** — *The motion for amends* (Cathair dhearg). In the capital it is proposed to pay the Tuathaich for their losses in the war. The motion is let die quietly, and no vote is taken.
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 25** — *The Moot's minute on the amends* (Caol mhòr). The Moot's minute on the motion for amends runs to one line: 'Allowed to die.' That same year Martha Greaves lays down the chair. The Moot chooses Peter Hale, a great-grandson of its first speaker, to follow her.
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 25** — *The fifth regiment's barracks* (Seann Warr). The fifth regiment builds stone barracks at Seann Warr, the first lasting quarters any of the nine regiments has had. The town gives the land and takes the regiment's custom.

<sup>46</sup>. the lighthouse at Baile iséal

<sup>47</sup>. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *The eighth regiment at Inis uaine* (Inis uaine). The eighth regiment's guard on the eastern dubhan tanks at Inis uaine is made lasting. Its officers take houses in the town, and the Seann Spioradan house of Inis uaine adds the regiment to its prayers.
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 25** — *The fourth regiment leaves Ceann mhòr* (Caol bheag). The fourth regiment leaves the old magistrate's house at Ceann mhòr and goes home to Caol bheag. The Moot asks that the house be given to the town. It is given to the maor.
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, DE 26** — *Seann-chunntas* (Caol mhòr). Tuathaich speakers begin to name the tabled request to the library and the dead motion for amends together as 'seann-chunntas', an old reckoning that none in power will settle and none has cancelled. The Dia-thìrich in office do not take up the word.
- 17 AN CÈITEAN, DE 26** — *The Sloc Mòr closed* (Achadh dhomhain). The Mine Board shuts the upper galleries of the Sloc Mòr at Achadh dhomhain. One face is kept open in the Rite's keeping, to cut coal for the altars, a few baskets a year.
- 15 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 26** — *The last hewers* (Achadh dhomhain). Twelve hewers are kept at the Sloc Mòr to cut the altar-coal in the Rite's keeping. They are the last of their trade to work the vein on the island, and the Rite gives them its own oath, not the dissolved guild's.
- 14 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 26** — *The regiments at the Còmhrag* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>48</sup>). Fighters of the regiments are entered in the Còmhrag at Ceann leathan for the first time. The ninth regiment's man wins it. The fair-wardens raise the gate-price again.
- 12 AN LÙNASTAL, DE 26** — *The second regiment's library guard* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>49</sup>). The second regiment at Àth dhìreach keeps a guard at Leabharlann Muileann chaol over the sealed war archive. The keeper, Ragnall mac Mhuirich, writes to the council that the library did not ask for one.
- 10 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 26** — *The coal line carries no coal* (Achadh dhomhain). The last coal train runs from Achadh dhomhain to Cathair dhearg. The coal line keeps its name and carries dubhan, wool and soldiers.
- 9 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 26** — *The sixth regiment on the northern road* (Caol mhòr). The sixth regiment at Cnoc bheag keeps posts on the northern road where the boundary stones stand. For the first time since the Severance the Tuathaich going south must show a pass. The council's minute calls the passes for a time only.
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 26** — *The fair of the present year* (Fèill Muileann òg<sup>50</sup>). The fair at Muileann òg draws traders from every shire the state holds. Tuathaich wool is sold there on its northern day, through Dia-thìrich factors, as it has been since the first fair.

48. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

49. the Library at Muileann chaol

50. the fair at Muileann òg

- 19 AN FAOILLEACH, DE 27** — *The Còmhrag of the present year* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>51</sup>). The Còmhrag at Ceann leathan is fought with staves and fists, as it has been since edged tools were banned. Two regiments and nine shires send fighters. One man dies.
- 17 AN GEARRAN, DE 27** — *The eleven books* (Doire ghlas). Ellen Marsh's eleven books are copied by hand in the Tuathaich schools and kept in the north. The library's catalogue lists the tabled request, and not the books.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, DE 27** — *The Moot of the present year* (Caol mhòr). The Moot at Caol mhòr meets under Peter Hale. Its minute-books run unbroken from Walter Hale's first meeting. It has no standing in Dia-thìrich law and has never asked for any.
- 27 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, DE 27** — *The dubhan works of the present* (Seann Skell). Dubhan is made at Seann Skell on the southern coast and at works in the east and north. Every lamp, engine, ship and lorry on the island runs on it. The coin is pegged to it, and the tithe is taken on every sale.
- 29 AN T-IUCHAR, DE 27** — *The Treasury's roll of the present year* (Cathair dhearg). The Treasury's roll for the year stands at 9,568 purses: 6,375 from the head-due, taken at eighteen purses on every hundred thousand heads, and 3,193 from the market-due, taken at seventeen in the hundred on every sale. The wartime tithe is carried on its own line under the regiments' pay. The windy coast pays neither due.
- 7 AN T-SULTAIN, DE 27** — *Dubhan's charter of export* (Ros dhomhain). Dubhan, who made the first working fuel and is now in his sixty-ninth year, wins from the council at Cathair dhearg, after a year of letters and three sittings, leave to sell dubhan beyond the island. It is the first leave the kingdom has given since the Severance for any good of Dia-thìr to pass beyond its waters. The charter is narrow. The Treasury sets each year's measure. The fuel is loaded only at Ros dhomhain, where a clerk of the Treasury takes the tithe on every barrel. The kingdom's depots and the Moot's are served first. Nothing of the vein goes with it: the vein's coal is not sold, and the custodians of Òrd Bhride<sup>52</sup> seal every hold. Dubhan has told neither the council nor the chronicler who buys from him. In the autumn the first tank-hull loaded under the charter goes out past the north-western capes, and on the day she sails the priests of Manannan at Seann Skell say their prayer to keep the sea shut.
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, DE 27** — *The altar-coal* (Seann Skell). The Rite's twelve hewers at the Sloc Mòr cut the year's altar-coal. It fills four baskets. The high custodian at Seann Skell shares it among the houses of the Rite by lot.
- 22 AN T-SAMHAIN, DE 27** — *The chronicler's note on the present* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>53</sup>). Sileas nic Rath writes at the foot of the year that the kingdom's record is whole in every part but two: the war, which is sealed, and the north, which was not asked.

51. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

52. the order of Brìde's flame

53. the Library at Muileann chaol

**21 AN DÙBHLACHD, DE 27** — *The present* (Cathair dhearg). The coal is all but gone. The trade of the island runs on a name that once belonged to one man. The Dia-thìrich hold the capital and the sea. The Tuathaich hold the north, a grievance five years old, their Church, and the memory of the First Canoe, Naomh Breandan's voyage to the Isle of the Blessed, which the people who have twice defeated them still call folklore.



PART THREE

# The Appendices





## APPENDIX A

# The Rulers and Houses of Dia-thìr

Here are set down the lines of those who ruled in Dia-thìr, age by age, so far as the lists that survive allow. For the Ancient Age there is the Line of the Mason; out of it runs the Line of Aisling, which comes down to the Age of Strangers. For the Age of Ailean there are the two oral lists; for the Holy Age, the Keepers' roll and the king-list; for the Age of Sundering, the crown as the custody-book and the king-list record it; for the Age of Strangers, the council, the Commissioners and the overseers; and after them the rulers of the restored kingdom. The tables come first. After them are told the lines one by one, then the seven houses of custody, and last how the keeping of the vein and the keeping of the realm were joined and parted again.

No ruler stands in the tables whom the lists and chronicles do not name. Where a list owns that names are missing, the table says so and supplies none. A reign is dated by the rolls that mark its beginning and its end; where no roll marks the one or the other, the table gives "—", and where the rolls fix it only roughly the year is marked *c.* Of many rulers there is but a single mention, somewhere in the middle of the reign, and for these the table gives "in office" and the year of that mention.

## I. The Tables

**The Line of the Mason (Clann a' Chlachair<sup>1</sup>, later Clann na Ceiste<sup>2</sup>), Age I.** The eldest genealogy on Dia-thìr, recited by the Mason's line from the mason who broke the vein to the first king, each son of each father. In the short form given to strangers only the fathers who did something are named, and the stretches between them are given as a count of generations; the reciters keep the rest. The year shown is that of the deed, as the Library reckons it.

---

1. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

2. the Children of the Question

| NO. | NAME                     | THE DEED                                                                                                                                 | TOLD OF IN | AGE AT DEATH | GENERATIONS AFTER HIM TO THE NEXT NAMED |
|-----|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|--------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 1   | Neachdan, the Mason      | Broke into the coloured vein; the lightning fired it, and he carried the first fire home                                                 | VE 1       |              | none: his son follows                   |
| 2   | Conall mac Neachdain     | Kept the vein while it burned; his people laid the slab over it when it went out                                                         | VE 151     |              | thirty-four                             |
| 3   | Diarmad                  | Asked the Keeper why the coal has colours, at Doire ghlas, and was given the riddle                                                      | VE 890     |              | eighteen                                |
| 4   | Aodh                     | Threw the seven into the sea; the gold coal took fire on the water                                                                       | VE 1,370   |              | thirty-one                              |
| 5   | Fearghas                 | Let the six fall from the highest ground; the snowflake coal took fire in the air, and the summit was named Binnean a' Chlachair         | VE 2,170   |              | twenty-eight                            |
| 6   | Brian                    | Buried the five; the black coal was warm on the next day                                                                                 | VE 2,885   |              | thirty                                  |
| 7   | Cormac, of the Misstrike | Bled on the four in the grove; the red-brown coal, the coal of life, took fire                                                           | VE 3,670   |              | twenty-one                              |
| 8   | Eòghann                  | Tasted the river; the silver coal took fire under the water                                                                              | VE 4,225   |              | fifteen                                 |
| 9   | Colla                    | In his days the line was named Luchd-ceasnachaidh a' Ghuail Dhiomhair, Clann na Ceiste                                                   | VE 4,625   |              | ten                                     |
| 10  | Seathan                  | Snapped his fingers, and the fire coal's dust took fire in his hand                                                                      | VE 4,905   |              | fifteen, the last of them Suibhne       |
| 11  | Suibhne                  | Father of Ailean                                                                                                                         | —          |              | none: his son follows                   |
| 12  | Ailean Mòr mac Shuibhne  | Brought the six lit coals to the grove; the Keeper lit the rainbow coal; after a vigil of seven nights he was crowned Rìgh Chlann nan Dè | GE 1       | 4,626 years  | first of the Stone Kings                |

**The Line of Aisling, Ages II to V.** The line of Ailean Mòr's son Somhairle, kept apart by the reciters of Clann na Ceiste and not said at the hearth. It was given whole, backward from the child to the fire as a line is given at a naming, by Ealasaid of Clann na Ceiste at Tobar dhìreach to the copyist Cailean mac Eachainn (21 an Dàmhair, AE 126), and it runs on from the Line of the Mason. The first ten after Ailean are those in whom the reciters say the long years showed, each shorter-lived than the one before; the Library enters the long years among the tellings (section II). The Mason's line keeps the years of its dead beside their names, as it has since the mason, but gives them

to no stranger save where they are strange; so the column of ages is filled only for the long lives, and left empty for the ordinary. The year shown under *Told of in* is that of the deed, or of the event in whose days it was done.

| NO. | NAME                       | THE DEED                                                                                                                                                                                             | TOLD OF IN | AGE AT DEATH | GENERATIONS AFTER HIM TO THE NEXT NAMED                                                |
|-----|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 12  | Ailean Mòr mac Shuibhne    | Crowned in the grove; king of the godkin from that night until he fell, telling no one what was in him; held the ford below Dùn dhearg alone three days against the host of the east, and fell there | FE 1       | 4,626 years  | none: his son follows                                                                  |
| 13  | Somhairle mac Ailein       | Born in his father's sixty-second year; took no share of the kingdom, and lived among Clann na Ceiste by the slab; died before his father                                                            | GE 3,025   | 2,987 years  | none: his son follows                                                                  |
| 14  | Beathan mac Shomhairle     | Sat by the slab through the dark half of the year, as the households near the crack did                                                                                                              | GE 1,120   | 2,213 years  | six, each shorter-lived than the one before: 1,594, 1,148, 826, 597, 431 and 308 years |
| 15  | Gille-Bride                | Carried a coal of the First Flame home to the hills                                                                                                                                                  | FE 1       | 224 years    | none: his son follows                                                                  |
| 16  | Ceallach mac Ghille-Bhrìde | The last of the line in whom the long years showed; his son lived as other men live                                                                                                                  | —          | 140 years    | a hundred and sixteen                                                                  |
| 17  | Fionnlagh                  | Stood on the quay at Seann Skell when the ships went out, and did not go                                                                                                                             | LE 40      |              | seventy, the last of them the father of Ruairidh                                       |
| 18  | Ruairidh of Doire mhòr     | Stood behind Beathag Dhubh when Doire mhòr refused the Company                                                                                                                                       | AE 14      |              | none: his son follows                                                                  |
| 19  | Tormod mac Ruairidh        | Carried water up to Doire mhòr two summers when the stream was taken, then went down to the camp at Àth ìseal                                                                                        | AE 30      |              | none: his son follows                                                                  |
| 20  | Donnchadh mac Thormoid     | Hewer of the deep galleries at Achadh dhomhain; coughed a year with what the physicians took for the lung-rot, and the cough left him the night his daughter was born                                | AE 68      |              | none: his daughter follows                                                             |
| 21  | Aisling nic Dhonnchaidh    | First of the <i>fuil-ghuail</i> ; called in the camps <i>nighean an rìgh</i> , the king's daughter                                                                                                   | AE 69      |              | —                                                                                      |

The years agree with the annals as the Library reckons them. Ailean was crowned a young man of four and twenty (28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1) and fell at four thousand six hundred and twenty-six (2 an t-Sultain, FE 1). Somhairle, born in Ailean's sixty-second year, died at two thousand nine hundred and eighty-seven (7 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,025), more than fifteen hundred years before his father. Beathan was born in Somhairle's five hundred and fifty-fourth year, and was past five hundred when he sat by the slab (8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120). Beathan's son was born when Beathan was near fourteen hundred years old, well past the middle of his life; the six after him were each born about the middle of the life of the one before, and the last of the six was Gille-Brìde, born in the Grove Era's four thousand four hundred and thirty-first year, who was a man of a hundred and seventy-two at the Binding and died in the Flame Era's fifty-third. His son Ceallach was born some sixty years before Ailean fell, and died in the seventy-ninth year of the Flame. From Ceallach's son on, the generations run at about five and twenty years, as they do in the Line of the Mason.

**The Stone Kings of Dùn ìseal (Rìghrean na Cloiche<sup>3</sup>), Age II.** The oldest oral list, held on the hill of Dùn ìseal. It "gives no lengths of reign" (9 an Lùnastal, GE 1). It names those who held the hill: Ailean Mòr first, who took it, and after him those of his blood whom he set to hold it under him while he was king over the whole kingdom. He never gave up the kingship, and after the last name in the list he held the hill in his own hand (12 am Màrt, GE 4,391). The year shown is that of the deed for which each holder is remembered, and not the year of the coming to the hill.

| NO. | NAME                 | BY-NAME       | CAME TO RULE                                           | TOLD OF IN | THE REIGN                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----|----------------------|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Ailean Mòr           | the great     | crowned Rìgh Chlann nan Dè in the grove at Doire ghlas | GE 1       | Took the hill where Dùn ìseal now stands and the valleys about it, the first kingdom, and threw up its first ring of bank; king over all the holders after him until he fell at Blàr Àth na Fala |
| 2   | Gormshuil nic Ailein | —             | his daughter, born before the grove                    | GE 27      | The first woman in any list; brought the herds to the warm springs in a hard winter and lost none                                                                                                |
| 3   | Dòmhnall Clachach    | of the stones | his son                                                | GE 107     | Set the boundary stones of the valley grazing, some still standing and still argued over                                                                                                         |
| 4   | Fearchar Bacach      | the lame      | his son, after the first named storm                   | GE 227     | Carried to the gatherings in a chair of woven birch; the first ruler remembered for a hurt                                                                                                       |

3. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

| NO. | NAME                | BY-NAME     | CAME TO RULE                           | TOLD OF IN          | THE REIGN                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----|---------------------|-------------|----------------------------------------|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5   | Mòrag Chruaidh      | the hard    | his granddaughter, Dòmhnall's daughter | GE 672              | Raided the salt-pans at Baile ghorh: the first war in either list, seven dead on the hill side                                                                |
| 6   | Iain Dubh           | the black   | his son                                | — to GE 727         | Went down to repeat the salt raid and was killed on the shingle at Baile ghorh; the king went down after him alone, and the salt shore bent the knee (GE 728) |
| 7   | Ragnall Ceannfhionn | fair-headed | his grandson                           | GE 1,175            | Made the peace of the ford with the Red Hill: salt for wool                                                                                                   |
| 8   | Sileas Bhàn         | the fair    | of his blood                           | GE 1,927            | Held through the hungry years; the telling gives her no deed but that she outlasted them                                                                      |
| 9   | Tormod Liath        | the grey    | his grandson                           | GE 2,163            | Outlived three heirs; Dùn ìseal given its second bank                                                                                                         |
| 10  | Eilidh Ghlas        | the grey    | of his blood                           | GE 2,400            | Sent her younger son to be fostered on the Red Hill, the first fosterage in either list                                                                       |
| 11  | Calum Ciar          | the dusky   | the elder son of Eilidh Ghlas          | GE 2,412            | Asked that the keeper's lot be drawn in his sight, and was refused                                                                                            |
| 12  | Catriona Mhòr       | the great   | of his blood; twelfth and last         | GE 4,321 – GE 4,391 | Knew every household of the hills back seven names; the last name the list gives                                                                              |

**The holders of the Red Hill, Age II.** The second oral list, kept in the west on the hill where Cathair dhearg now stands. It gives no more lengths of reign than the list of the Stone Kings. The Red Hill was an old line of the western lake shore, and none of its holders was of Ailean's blood; it bent the knee to the king in Uisdean Mòr's time, and swore to him and not to Dùn ìseal, and kept its own holders under him.

| NO. | NAME               | BYNAME    | CAME TO RULE       | TOLD OF IN | THE REIGN                                                                                                                             |
|-----|--------------------|-----------|--------------------|------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Beathag Ruadh      | the red   | first in the list  | GE 18      | Held the hill; nothing else is told                                                                                                   |
| 2   | Uisdean Mòr        | the great | second in the list | GE 267     | Ditched the neck of the hill and set a palisade on it, twice burned and twice rebuilt; knelt to Ailean Mòr on the lake shore (GE 290) |
| 3   | Seonag nic Uisdein | —         | after her father   | GE 694     | Counted her people by pebbles in a bag, one to a household                                                                            |
| 4   | Murchadh Gearr     | the short | after Seonag       | GE 1,247   | Kept the peace of the ford and walked the salt road every year to be seen on it                                                       |

| NO. | NAME                                        | BYNAME                       | CAME TO RULE     | TOLD OF IN | THE REIGN                                                                        |
|-----|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------|------------------|------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5   | Lachlann Ruadh, <i>Lachlann an Al-traim</i> | the red; "of the foster-ing" | —                | GE 2,401   | Took in the son of Eilidh Ghlas; the list uses his byname more than his name     |
| 6   | Peigi Dhubh                                 | the black                    | after Lachlann   | GE 2,426   | Sent the fosterling home grown, with salt; the ford peace held a generation more |
| 7   | Seumas Òg                                   | the young                    | last in the list | GE 4,347   | The list stops with him                                                          |

**The Keepers of the Flame, Age III.** The keepers of Bride's flame and of Crom's stone, from the recited roll of Talla na Lasrach<sup>4</sup> at Dùn ìseal, written down on 17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,320. The roll holds one hundred and forty names, from Beathag Bhàn to Catrìona nic Mhuirich (2 an Giblean, FE 2,939); fourteen of them are found in the annals.

| NAME                      | BY-NAME   | HOUSE               | CAME TO THE FLAME                                          | KEEPING                       | THE KEEPING                                                                                                   |
|---------------------------|-----------|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Beathag Bhàn              | the fair  | of the nine hearths | chosen by the keepers of the slab and the sworn households | FE 4 – FE 44                  | First on the roll; would not keep Làrach an Teampaill                                                         |
| Muireach Liath            | the grey  | her sister's son    | chosen by the nine hearths                                 | FE 44 – FE 89                 | Fixed the coal basket; ruled that Allt an Àigh and the silver are not the mountain's                          |
| Gormshuil nic Mhuirich    | —         | Sliochd Mhuirich    | chosen over three of other lines                           | FE 89 – —                     | Her kin the first house known by a name; shut the galleries to the stag's people                              |
| Fionnlagh Dall            | the blind | —                   | after Gormshuil                                            | — (in office FE 139) – FE 184 | Re-cut the stone cup; asked the council for a crossing the river could not take; buried at Tuam Cnoc dhireach |
| Eilidh nic Ìomhair        | —         | Sliochd Ìomhair     | the first chosen outside the house of Muireach             | FE 381 – —                    | The Four Houses sworn under her; let the panthers pass on the road                                            |
| Coinneach Mòr mac Tormoid | the great | Sliochd Thormoid    | the first Keeper of his house                              | FE 475 – —                    | Kept the flame longer than any before him, and changed nothing; had the old places listed                     |

4. the Hall of the Flame

| NAME                  | BY-NAME   | HOUSE                         | CAME TO THE FLAME  | KEEPING                    | THE KEEPING                                                                              |
|-----------------------|-----------|-------------------------------|--------------------|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Seonaid Chiar         | the dusky | Sliochd Mhuirich              | —                  | — (in office FE 574) – —   | Let the stag's cutters back into the galleries; propped the galleries with oak           |
| Uisdean mac Ruairidh  | —         | —                             | —                  | — (in office FE 1,000) – — | Refused the flame to Iain Garbh's warband                                                |
| Calum Liath           | the grey  | —                             | —                  | — (in office FE 1,595) – — | Divided the holy woods with Fearchar Òg; the reckoning of the cords                      |
| Oighrig Bhàn          | the fair  | —                             | after Calum Liath  | FE 1,634 – —               | Bound the first twelve apprentices, four of them later Keepers                           |
| Dùghall mac Raghnaill | —         | —                             | after Oighrig Bhàn | FE 1,699 – —               | The census of hands; judged the Silver Feud                                              |
| Raonaid Dhubh         | the black | —                             | —                  | — (in office FE 2,366) – — | Heard both schools of the stag and gave no ruling; the shared-meal law with Lachlann Bàn |
| Seumas Bàn            | the fair  | Sliochd Mhuirich              | chosen             | FE 2,835 – —               | Struck his own house's count from the roll's preface; had the rites listed               |
| Catriona nic Mhuirich | —         | Sliochd Mhuirich, by her name | —                  | — (in office FE 2,929) – — | Set the stone cup in the hands of Mòr nic Coinnich; last name on the roll                |

**The rìghrean and ban-rìghrean of the Holy Age.** From the king-list begun by Tormod Sgrìobhaiche (20 an Lùnastal, FE 1,299) and kept in the red hall. It holds more than ninety names, from Goraidh Mòr to Mòr nic Coinnich (2 an Giblean, FE 2,939). The seat was at Dùn dhearg until Beathag Mhòr and at Cathair dhearg after her.

| NAME                                        | BY-NAME      | HOUSE               | HOW THEY CAME TO RULE                                    | REIGN           | THE REIGN                                                                                             |
|---------------------------------------------|--------------|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Goraidh mac Ìomhair, <i>Goraidh Mòr</i>     | the great    | Sliochd Ìomhair     | called rìgh by the households who ate from his granaries | FE 674 – FE 754 | The first ruler of the lowlands so called; the division of keeping with the Hall; the first road-toll |
| Mòrag nic Ghoraidh, <i>Mòrag nan Rathad</i> | of the roads | line of Goraidh Mòr | his daughter                                             | FE 754 – FE 834 | Walked every carriers' road; the golden house; the bridge-foot rebuilt                                |
| Dòmhnall Crùbach                            | the lame     | line of Goraidh Mòr | her son                                                  | FE 834 – FE 914 | Governed through the waypoint-keepers, who grew powerful                                              |

| NAME                        | BY-NAME   | HOUSE                | HOW THEY CAME TO RULE                                      | REIGN                      | THE REIGN                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------|-----------|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sileas Dhonn                | the brown | line of Go-raidh Mòr | his niece                                                  | FE 914 – FE 994            | Made the waypoint-keepers render account once a year                                                                           |
| Iain Garbh                  | the rough | line of Go-raidh Mòr | her son                                                    | FE 994 – FE 1,044          | The War of the Roads, the first war since the Peace of the Threshold, and the first fought over a road; never entered the Hall |
| Catriona Gh-lic             | the wise  | line of Go-raidh Mòr | his daughter                                               | FE 1,044 – —               | Sent her son to sit with the flame; the Hall and the hall reconciled                                                           |
| <i>eleven rulers</i>        |           |                      |                                                            | (FE 1,211)                 | Their names and order; the list keeps nothing more                                                                             |
| Ealasaid Chiar              | the dusky | line of Go-raidh Mòr | —                                                          | FE 1,299 – —               | Had Tormod Scriobhaiche set down the first written king-list                                                                   |
| Fearchar Òg                 | the young | line of Go-raidh Mòr | acceded as a boy                                           | — (in office FE 1,595) – — | The division of the woods; paid the road-guards in silver; died old                                                            |
| Beathag Mhòr                | the great | line of Go-raidh Mòr | great-granddaughter of Fearchar Òg                         | FE 1,685 – FE 1,735        | The first called ban-rìgh; moved the seat to Cathair dhearg; the census of hands                                               |
| Ruairidh Liath              | the grey  | line of Go-raidh Mòr | her son                                                    | FE 1,736 – —               | Grey already when he came to rule, which is the list's one jest; the Silver Feud                                               |
| Seonag Chrom                | the bent  | line of Go-raidh Mòr | his granddaughter                                          | FE 1,781 – —               | Gave the clerks a room and a stipend; from her reign the list was kept year by year                                            |
| Lachlann Bàn                | the fair  | line of Go-raidh Mòr | —                                                          | FE 2,406 – —               | Granaries in every province seat; the shared-meal law written                                                                  |
| Oighrig nic Lachlainn       | —         | line of Go-raidh Mòr | his daughter                                               | FE 2,461 – FE 2,511        | Childless; the line of Go-raidh Mòr, as the list reckons it, ends with her                                                     |
| <i>the red ball shut</i>    |           |                      | the Four Houses meet at Dùn ìseal                          | FE 2,511 – FE 2,516        | No custom covered a hall without an heir                                                                                       |
| Gilleasbuig Mòr mac Tormoid | the great | Sliochd Thormoid     | elected by the Four Houses; the stone cup set in his hands | FE 2,516 – FE 2,541        | The first ruler made at Dùn ìseal; a line drawn under Oighrig in every copy                                                    |
| Tormod Òg                   | the young | house of Tormod      | his son, without a meeting of the houses                   | FE 2,541 – —               | —                                                                                                                              |



| NAME                                      | BY-NAME  | HOUSE           | HOW THEY CAME TO RULE                                          | REIGN                  | THE REIGN                                                                                 |
|-------------------------------------------|----------|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>nine rulers of the house of Tormod</i> |          |                 |                                                                | (FE 2,558)             | Their names and years; of their reigns the rolls tell only of harvests, tolls and bridges |
| Anna Ruadh                                | the red  | house of Tormod | —                                                              | FE 2,806 – FE 2,829    | Walked the road circuit twice; chartered the sunny house; kept a wood-watcher at court    |
| Coinneach Bàn                             | the fair | house of Tormod | her son                                                        | FE 2,829 – —           | Ruled long and quietly; the laws copied for every province                                |
| Mòr nic Coinnich                          | —        | house of Tormod | granddaughter of Coinneach Bàn; the stone cup set in her hands | FE 2,929 – c. FE 2,953 | The last name in the king-list of the Holy Age                                            |

**The crowned rulers of the Age of Sundering.** From the king-list as recopied under Eilidh Bhàn (20 an Cèitean, LE 829) and from the custody-book of the vein-house. Every crowning in this age was at Cathair dhearg.

| NAME                   | BY-NAME   | HOUSE                                                       | HOW THEY CAME TO RULE                   | REIGN                         | THE REIGN                                                                                                 |
|------------------------|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill | —         | line of Beathag (of the house of Tormod through her mother) | daughter of Mòr nic Coinnich            | c. FE 2,953 – LE 55           | Neither sent nor kept back the fleet; struck her sister's line from the succession; kept the white sorrow |
| Raghnall mac Uilleim   | —         | line of Beathag                                             | her son                                 | LE 55 – LE 125                | Long and without event; the custody-book gives it one line                                                |
| Ìomhar mac Raghnall    | —         | line of Beathag                                             | his son                                 | LE 125 – LE 180               | Died with no living child; the line of Beathag ends                                                       |
| Fearchar mac Lachlainn | —         | Clann Fhearchair, of Baile Mòr dhomhain                     | chosen by the heads of the seven houses | LE 182 – LE 211               | The first crowning decided by the houses; the double court at Baile Mòr dhomhain                          |
| Fearchar Donn          | the brown | Clann Fhearchair                                            | his son, without dispute                | LE 211 – —                    | —                                                                                                         |
| Sileas nic Fhearchair  | —         | Clann Fhearchair                                            | after her father                        | — (in office LE 261) – LE 324 | The first of Cathair dhearg; tally-houses in the royal granaries; reigned more than half a century        |
| Uisdean mac Dhùghaill  | —         | line of Sileas                                              | her son                                 | LE 324 – LE 394               | —                                                                                                         |

| NAME                                             | BY-NAME        | HOUSE                            | HOW THEY CAME TO RULE                         | REIGN                             | THE REIGN                                                                                             |
|--------------------------------------------------|----------------|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Aonghas mac Uisdein                              | —              | line of Sileas                   | his son                                       | LE 394 – LE 484                   | The first king taught letters as a child; took up the rite of Macha; the first king buried by it      |
| Iain mac Aonghais                                | —              | line of Sileas                   | his son                                       | LE 484 – LE 496                   | A short reign                                                                                         |
| Tormod mac Iain, <i>Tormod Bàn</i>               | white-haired   | line of Sileas                   | his son                                       | LE 496 – LE 547                   | His two sons drowned in the Abhainn fhionn; died without naming an heir                               |
| <i>the War of the Three Claimants</i>            |                |                                  |                                               | LE 552 – LE 562                   | Catriona nic Aonghais, Dùghall Garbh and Ragnall Ruadh; the seven houses split                        |
| Catriona nic Aonghais, <i>Catriona Bhoadbach</i> | the victorious | house of Catriona, of Inis thais | niece of Tormod Bàn; won the war              | LE 562 – LE 604                   | The ruling of the hearth; Rathad na Ban-righinn; Seann Warr's gates honoured                          |
| Lachlann mac Iain                                | —              | house of Catriona                | her son                                       | LE 604 – LE 654                   | "Quiet", says the list, and means it as praise                                                        |
| Anna                                             | —              | house of Catriona                | his daughter                                  | LE 654 – —                        | —                                                                                                     |
| Eilidh Bhàn                                      | the fair       | house of Catriona                | fifth ruler of the house                      | LE 769 – LE 841                   | Harvests; the sea-thieves' boats burned on Eilean dhubh; the king-list recopied; died without an heir |
| Dòmhnall Ruadh                                   | the red        | Clann Raghnaill                  | named by the houses meeting at the vein-house | LE 846 – LE 871                   | The first to hold both the crown and the vein-house; buried at Muileann dhearg                        |
| Ragnall Òg                                       | the young      | Clann Raghnaill                  | his son                                       | LE 871 – —                        | —                                                                                                     |
| Mòrag Ruadh                                      | the red        | Clann Raghnaill                  | —                                             | LE 1,019 – —                      | Her household accounts survive entire; attended the thousandth-year burning                           |
| Beathag Fhionn                                   | the fair       | Clann Raghnaill                  | after her mother Mòrag                        | — (in office LE 1,082) – LE 1,129 | Closed the coast road against the swallowing cough                                                    |
| Ailean                                           | —              | Clann Raghnaill                  | her son                                       | LE 1,129 – —                      | The first of four kings of the name in the house of Ragnall                                           |

| NAME                     | BY-NAME                | HOUSE           | HOW THEY CAME TO RULE                                     | REIGN                  | THE REIGN                                                                                           |
|--------------------------|------------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ailean mac Raghnaill     | —                      | Clann Raghnaill | —                                                         | — – LE 1,266           | Left two sons of different mothers, each told he was the heir                                       |
| <i>the Brothers' War</i> |                        |                 |                                                           | LE 1,270 – LE 1,276    | Iain Ciar against Alasdair Bàn; the houses divided four to three                                    |
| Iain Ciar                | the dusky              | Clann Raghnaill | won the war; crowned at the peace of An Taigh-seinnse Mòr | LE 1,276 – LE 1,326    | The grain law, which lapsed after him as he had foreseen                                            |
| Catriona Bheag           | the small              | Clann Raghnaill | —                                                         | LE 1,429 – —           | The first queen in some three centuries; renewed the oath of the seven                              |
| Sileas Òg                | the young              | Clann Raghnaill | —                                                         | LE 1,529 – —           | The first ruler to visit every shire seat; a new census of hands                                    |
| Ailean mac Raghnaill     | the fourth of the name | Clann Raghnaill | —                                                         | LE 1,589 – LE 1,590    | The shortest reign in the king-list                                                                 |
| Mòrag nic Raghnaill      | —                      | Clann Raghnaill | his sister                                                | LE 1,590 – c. LE 1,629 | Forty years of good harvests and the rite                                                           |
| Tormod mac Ruairidh      | —                      | Clann Raghnaill | —                                                         | LE 1,709 – LE 1,766    | Roads and bridges; a reign of more than fifty years                                                 |
| Gormshuil nic Thormoid   | —                      | Clann Raghnaill | his daughter                                              | LE 1,766 – —           | Went round every shire seat and answered no grievance in writing; the last crowned ruler of the age |

**The Council of Custodians and the council of the rising, Age V.** The council sat at Cathair dhearg "in the crown's place since the crown fell empty at the close of the Age of Sundering" (11 am Faoilleach, AE 2).

| NAME              | OFFICE         | HOW THEY CAME TO IT   | HELD                       | THE TENURE                                                                                    |
|-------------------|----------------|-----------------------|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tormod mac Ailein | high custodian | —                     | — (in office AE 2) – AE 20 | Confirmed the strangers' leave to stay; signed the first treaty in a tongue he could not read |
| Coinneach Glas    | high custodian | chosen by the council | AE 20 – —                  | Asked in vain that the custodians' tally be kept at the Company's furnaces                    |

| NAME                  | OFFICE                        | HOW THEY CAME TO IT               | HELD     | THE TENURE                                                                            |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>the seat empty</i> |                               | the council could not agree       | AE 105 – | The Commissioner found the council easier to deal with                                |
| Eilidh nic Raghnaill  | speaker of the forest council | chosen at Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag | AE 148 – | Drafted the second petition; sent the constables of Baile thais to the coast unharmed |

**The Commissioners of the Administration, Age V.** The humans' governors, seated at the Residency in Ros dhomhain.

| NAME             | HOW THEY CAME TO OFFICE                               | HELD            | THE TENURE                                                                                                  |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Josiah Pell      | the first Commissioner, newly come to sign the treaty | AE 8 – AE 24    | Sailed home to an Tìr Thall and did not return                                                              |
| Henry Maddox     | sent with orders to double the yield                  | AE 24 – AE 41   | Bought the oaks of Cathair fhada for pit-props; left a rich man                                             |
| Arthur Lisle     | a lawyer, sent to replace Maddox                      | AE 41 – AE 61   | Bound every agreement in one book; signed the Silver Compact; died at the Residency                         |
| Walter Crane     | the Company's chief agent, appointed in Lisle's place | AE 61 – AE 75   | The pay office at Ceann mhin; walked the camps in the Green Death and died of it                            |
| Martha Gale      | the Company's agent at Ros dhomhain; held the seal    | AE 75 – AE 76   | Held the seal a year and more, until one was sent to follow Crane                                           |
| George Tolley    | sent from an Tìr Thall                                | AE 76 – AE 98   | Never visited the camps; retired with honours                                                               |
| Robert Haskins   | successor to Tolley                                   | AE 98 – AE 114  | Set the tithe before the council met; recalled after a quarrel with the Company                             |
| Edward Vane      | the first Commissioner born on Dia-thìr               | AE 114 – AE 132 | The tram-road to Ros dhireach; spoke Dia-thìris, badly, but he spoke it; died at the Residency              |
| Charles Merriman | successor to Vane                                     | AE 132 – AE 146 | Brought the first armed constables; left in ill health                                                      |
| Lionel Strake    | a soldier                                             | AE 146 – AE 150 | Locked the council out; the last Commissioner; sailed for an Tìr Thall, and of his landing nothing is known |

**The Maoir of Muileann chrom, Age V.** The Company's overseers at Muileann chrom, holders of its staff. The Dia-thìrich called the first of them *maor*, steward, and the byname went down the line.

| NAME                                          | HOW THEY CAME TO THE STAFF                                             | HELD            | THE TENURE                                                                                                               |
|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Raghnall mac Dhòmhnaill, <i>Raghnall Maor</i> | a crew-leader since the first contract; given the staff by the Company | AE 36 – AE 62   | The first overseer; after him the custodians' roll counted the overseers and named them no more                          |
| Dòmhnall mac Raghnall Maor                    | his son; the Company gave him the staff                                | AE 62 – AE 87   | The office became an inheritance; signed the order that the camps keep no grain beyond a week's ration                   |
| Iain Maor                                     | his son                                                                | AE 87 – AE 131  | Schooled at the Mission; wrote that the night shift was killing his crews, was dismissed, and was restored               |
| Mòrag nic Iain Maor                           | his daughter; the first woman to hold the staff                        | AE 131 – AE 148 | Testified at the inquiry and was struck from the record; refused the evictions and broke the staff at the Company's door |

**The rulers of Rìoghachd Dia-thìr<sup>5</sup>, Ages VI and VII.** From the chronicle of the restored kingdom, which keeps this line "unbroken from this year on". Nothing is here added to what that chronicle says of them.

| NAME    | HOW THEY CAME TO RULE                                                              | REIGN         | THE REIGN                                                                                                                                               |
|---------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Niall   | the first ruler of the restored kingdom, crowned at Cathair dhearg by Macha's rite | SE 3 – SE 22  | First of the line                                                                                                                                       |
| Brìghde | his daughter; succeeded without contest                                            | SE 22 – SE 28 | Her reign ended while she was young; no cause was ever made known                                                                                       |
| Eòghan  | her cousin                                                                         | SE 28 – SE 58 | Came to the throne when the succession of the restored kingdom was first in doubt; his reign ended in the decade when the Depletion became known to all |
| Mairead | crowned after Eòghan                                                               | SE 58 – DE 3  | Came to a kingdom founded on the vein, when the vein could be seen to fail                                                                              |
| Cathal  | crowned after Mairead                                                              | DE 3 –        | Reigning in DE 27                                                                                                                                       |

## II. The Age of Ailean: the Two Lists

Before the Binding the rulers of Dia-thìr were kept only in recitation. The eldest recital is the Line of the Mason, which runs from Neachdan, who broke the vein (20 am Faoilleach, VE 1), through the long generations of the Seven Coals, to Ailean son of Suibhne. It ends in a crowning. Ailean carried the six coals his forefathers had learned to light, each lit again by its own way, to the oak grove at Doire ghlas, where the Keeper of the kin had first given the riddle; the Keeper lit the rainbow coal among them (21 an

5. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

t-Iuchar, VE 5,324); and he kept watch by the seven fires for seven nights, fasting, until they were cold. On the eighth night, the line says, Caoran came into the grove with the Tuath Dè and named him Rìgh Chlann nan Dè<sup>6</sup>, king of the godkin, and put into him the power that had been in the coals (28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1). Of that power Ailean told no one. With it, the line holds, he took the hill of Dùn ìseal and the valleys about it, which is the first kingdom (9 an Lùnastal, GE 1), and his is the first name in the list of the Stone Kings. No other king in either list is said to have been crowned by the gods, and no other list keeps the title; the Stone Kings' list itself calls him only Ailean Mòr.

The line says also that Ailean never gave up the kingship. He set others of his blood on the hill to hold it for him while he rode beyond it, first his daughter Gormshuil and after her the rest; and so the list of the Stone Kings, which is the hill's list, names after him those who held the hill under him, and names them kings. He himself was king over them all, and over the Red Hill, which knelt to him (7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 290), and the salt shore, which knelt to him (5 an Lùnastal, GE 728), and every coast that sent its holder to the great gathering at the ford (2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000); and he was king until he fell at the Ford of Blood below Dùn dhearg, holding it alone against the host of the east (2 an t-Sultain, FE 1). The line gives all his days as four thousand six hundred and twenty-six years. The power was his alone and went with him. Of it his children had only their long years, and only those born after the grove; Gormshuil, born before it, had none. His children lived two and three thousand years, and their children less, and so on down, generation by generation; in Somhairle's line the long years ran out in Ceallach, the tenth after Ailean, in the early Holy Age. The reciters of the hill say that the long years are why the list of the Stone Kings stands so far apart in its names; the Library holds, as it holds of the later lists, that names have been lost. It enters the Line of the Mason and the Line of Aisling in its book of lines, and the long years in its book of tellings, and has not moved them.

The Line of Aisling is the line that asked for nothing. Somhairle took no share of the kingdom and held no hill, and his children after him kept the slab and the lines in the high valleys, and so had no part in the parting of the kingdom when the king fell. Clann na Ceiste<sup>7</sup> kept the line apart from the Stone Kings and did not say it at the hearth, and in the Holy Age Somhairle's children went down into the valleys and forgot whose they were. Seven names of it came up again in the roll of the camp at Àth ìseal, in the marriage of Donnchadh mac Thormoid, and the copyist Cailean mac Eathainn carried them to Tobar dhìreach, where Ealasaid of Clann na Ceiste knew them and said the rest (21 an Dàmhair, AE 126). So what the camps had whispered at Aisling's birth, that she was of the old king's blood, was found to stand in the lines. As a

6. king of the godkin, the first king's style

7. the Children of the Question

line of names the Library holds it as good as any it keeps. Of the four thousand years it holds what it holds of all the tellings.

The Stone Kings' list belonged to the hill of Dùn ìseal and is older than the name Dia-thìrich (9 an Lùnastal, GE 1). The Red Hill list belonged to the hill where Cathair dhearg now stands. Each list remembers a holder for a single deed and gives no length of reign, and for a long while neither speaks of the other. They first meet at the ford where the fair of Muileann òg is now held, when Ragnall Ceannfhionn traded salt for wool with the Red Hill (10 an Cèitean, GE 1,175). The peace of the ford held through a fosterage: Eilidh Ghlas's son went west to Lachlann an Altraim and came home grown under Peigi Dhubh (31 am Màrt, GE 2,427). Neither list keeps the foster-son's name.

A third office ran beside the two lines and answered to neither. From 26 an t-Samhain, GE 2,403, the keeper of the slab over the crack was chosen by lot. When Calum Ciar asked for the lot to be drawn in his sight, the households refused him, and the king would not overrule the slab; from then on the Stone Kings ruled the grazing and not the vein (7 an Cèitean, GE 2,416).

Catriona Mhòr is the hardest name in either list. The tellings set three things "in her time": the first coming of Dùn dhearg to the ford, the first recital of both lists together, and the keepers' asking that their charge be declared (9 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,376). These lie more than half a century apart. That is a long holding, yet not longer than one life may hold, least of all a life of the king's blood, and the Library cannot tell whether one holder saw all three, or whether the tellings drew a neighbour's deeds to a famous name. Both lists end in her generation. After her the king took back the hill and named no holder, and the kin began to quarrel over the shares they looked to have when he was gone (12 am Màrt, GE 4,391). In the Holy Age it was said that the Binding's keepers were "older by centuries than any rìgh after Ailean" (23 an t-Sultain, FE 1); the Hall that kept that saying did not count the holders of the hill as kings, and by then it held the first king himself for a tale; the name *Rìghrean na Cloiche*<sup>8</sup> was given the holders by later scribes.

### III. The Holy Age: the Keepers and the Kings

The Keepers came first. Each was chosen by the nine hearths, and for many generations the choice fell within the house of Muireach. Under Eilidh nic Ìomhair, the first Keeper from outside that house, the office was bound to four houses of custody: Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>9</sup>, Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>10</sup>, Sliochd Thormoid<sup>11</sup> and Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>12</sup> (29

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8. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

an Giblean, FE 385). The Keeper held the flame, the galleries and the Small-Burning Law, and raised no spears. When Seumas Bàn found that more than half the Keepers on the roll were of his own house, he had the fact struck from its preface (16 an t-Samhain, FE 2,835). The unstruck copy survived him.

After the Roinn, kingship began again in the granaries of Dùn dhearg. The households who ate Sliochd Ìomhair's grain called Goraidh mac Ìomhair their *rìgh* (28 an Cèitean, FE 674), and he took care to claim nothing over the vein. By the division of keeping the *rìgh* held the roads, the granaries and the peace of the lowlands, and the Keeper held all else (9 an t-Sultain, FE 694). So the first kings of the lowlands were lords of roads, and the first war they fought, Iain Garbh's War of the Roads, was fought over tolls.

The king-list owns plainly where it fails. It gives eleven bare names after Catriona Ghlic (1 an t-Sultain, FE 1,211) and nine after Tormod Òg (29 am Màrt, FE 2,558), and Tormod Scriobhaiche marked which of his names came from reciters (18 an t-Sultain, FE 1,300). By the list's years Goraidh Mòr, his daughter, her son and his niece ruled some eighty years apiece before the niece's son, Iain Garbh, took the hall; and four lives of one line, one after another, cannot hold so many. Here, and wherever else the years of the list outrun the lives of those named in it, the Library holds that the reciters' names stand for more reigns than they tell of, and it lets the list stand uncorrected.

Beathag Mhòr, the first *ban-rìgh*, moved the seat to Cathair dhearg (10 an Gearran, FE 1,699). When Oighrig nic Lachlainn died without an heir, the Four Houses met at Dùn Ìseal, and the Keeper set the stone cup in the hands of Gilleasbuig Mòr of Sliochd Thormoid (12 am Màrt, FE 2,516). Thereafter the house of Tormod held the red hall to the end of the age. Mòr nic Coinnich took the cup from the Keeper in the same manner, and with her name the king-list closes.

## IV. The Age of Sundering: the Crown and the Houses

Queen Beathag nic Dhòmhnaill would neither send any across the water nor hold any back (11 an Dàmhair, LE 2). Her sister Mòrag went, as a leader of the departed, and six years after the Setting-Out the queen struck Mòrag's line from the succession "as no

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9. the house of Muireach

10. the house of Ìomhar

11. the house of Tormod

12. the house of Raghnaill



longer on Dia-thìr" (1 an Lùnastal, LE 46). Beathag's own line ended with her grandson Ìomhar.

Thereafter, whenever the blood failed, the seven houses made the king. They chose Fearchar mac Lachlainn of Clann Fhearchair (19 an Gearran, LE 182), and the crown passed through Sileas nic Fhearchair to her son's line. That line ended with Tormod Bàn, who died without naming an heir. In the War of the Three Claimants that followed, Ragnall Ruadh, master of the vein-house, used the coal itself as a weapon (24 am Faoilleach, LE 558). Catrìona Bhuadhach won the crown, and bound it, and the custodians with it, never to withhold the handful from a lawful hearth (12 an Gearran, LE 565).

The house of Catriona ended with Eilidh Bhàn. She is called its fifth ruler, though only four of the five are named in the annals. The houses, meeting at the vein-house, named Dòmhnall Ruadh of Clann Raghnaill (23 am Màrt, LE 846). His house held the crown and the vein-house together for the rest of the age, through a brothers' war and some of the longest reigns in the list. The last crowning in the annals is that of Gormshuil nic Thormoid (9 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,766). Of her death, of any heir, and of how the crown fell vacant, nothing is told; when the next age opens, the Council of Custodians is found sitting in its place (11 am Faoilleach, AE 2).

## **V. The Age of Strangers: the Council, the Commissioners and the Maoir**

The Council of Custodians gave the humans leave to stay, and its high custodian signed the first treaty in a tongue he could not read (7 an Cèitean, AE 8). Thereafter the council's power dwindled. It asked for its tally, and was sent the Company's accounts. From 22 an t-Sultain, AE 105, it could not agree on a high custodian. The last Commissioner locked it out of its hall (26 an Gearran, AE 147). Such authority as the custodians still had went with them into the forest council of the mining regions (20 an Lùnastal, AE 148). That council chose Eilidh nic Raghnaill to speak for it, and fought the war that ended the age.

The Commissioners governed from the Residency at Ros dhomhain. As the age went on the office and the Company grew together. Walter Crane rose from chief agent at the pits to Commissioner, and after his death an agent of the Company held the seal. The last Commissioner sailed for an Tìr Thall<sup>13</sup>, and where he came to land is not known on Dia-thìr (5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 150).

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13. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

The overseers were the Company's rulers at the pithead, all of them Dia-thìrich (21 an Lùnastal, AE 37). At Muileann chrom the staff went from father to son, against the custodians' hope, and the byname *Maor* went with it, until Mòrag nic Iain Maor broke the staff rather than carry out evictions (24 an Cèitean, AE 148).

## VI. The Age of the Kingdom and the Age of Dubhan: the Restored Kingdom

The kingdom was restored step by step. The war-companies were stood down (3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 1), the state was styled *Rìoghachd Dia-thìr*<sup>14</sup> (27 an t-Iuchar, SE 2), and a royal council of twelve, drawn from the custodian families and the captains of the war, took its seat (23 an t-Sultain, SE 2). Only then was a king crowned. The Crown's officer in each shire took the word *maor* (4 am Faoilleach, SE 4), and the house of Macha's order at Cathair dhearg was given back the keeping of the regalia (26 an Gearran, SE 7).

The chronicle of the restored kingdom names five rulers and tells of their successes, and of little else. All that it records of them stands in the table above.

## VII. Of the Seven Houses

The seven houses of custody were made out of what the Sundering left behind. With nearly one household in five gone onto the roll of the willing, the remaining custodian households were regrouped into seven houses. Each house answered to the vein-house for its share of the coal and of the measured burning (4 an t-Iuchar, LE 55). The houses were:

| HOUSE            | SEAT OR COUNTRY, WHERE ONE IS TOLD | HOLY AGE HOUSE OF THE SAME NAME                        | REMEMBERED FOR                                                                                                |
|------------------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Clann Mhuirich   | Dùn ìseal (as Sliochd Mhuirich)    | Sliochd Mhuirich, the Keepers' house                   | Gave most of the Keepers of the Holy Age; in this age it is seldom named                                      |
| Clann Fhearchair | Baile Mòr dhomhain                 | Sliochd Fhearchair, the silversmiths of Muileann chiar | The first king chosen by the houses; the double court                                                         |
| Clann Ìomhair    | Dùn dhearg                         | Sliochd Ìomhair, the first kings' house                | Walled Dùn dhearg in stone, the first walls raised by a house rather than the crown (12 an t-Sultain, LE 261) |

14. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

| HOUSE           | SEAT OR COUNTRY, WHERE ONE IS TOLD | HOLY AGE HOUSE OF THE SAME NAME | REMEMBERED FOR                                                                                             |
|-----------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Clann Raghnaill | —                                  | Sliochd Raghnaill of Seann Tarr | Raghnaill Ruadh the claimant; from Dòmhnall Ruadh, the crown and the vein-house together                   |
| Clann Thormoid  | —                                  | Sliochd Thormoid of Seann Dunn  | The last kings of the Holy Age were of the house of Tormod; in this age no deed is set down under its name |
| Clann Choinnich | —                                  | none                            | Rebuilt the bath-house at the hot springs; brought the silver petitions; swore last to Catriona Bheag      |
| Clann Lachlainn | —                                  | none                            | Named among the seven; no deed of its own is remembered                                                    |

The regrouping was the first act, so far as is known, that made the right to the coal an inheritance of the house, where before it had been earned by apprenticeship. All that followed grew from it. The houses drew lots at the vein-house for the galleries each would keep (30 an Giblean, LE 109). Their heads wore silver neck-rings from Muileann chiar, and on feast days they wore the blue of Baile ghorm until that blue was lost. When blood failed they made kings, once at the capital (19 an Gearran, LE 182) and once at the vein-house (21 an Giblean, LE 841). They split among the three claimants, and later divided four to three between the brothers (8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,270). From Dòmhnall Ruadh's reign the heads of the seven sat as the king's council (6 an t-Ògmhios, LE 859), and the custodian class and the court became one body.

The houses also forbade. At their own tables they forbade Coinneach mac Mhàrtainn's question (1 an Giblean, LE 324), and that is the first time a question, and not a deed, is known to have been forbidden. The king's council closed the house at Dùn thais for a generation after Raghnaill mac Chaluim tabled the lengths of lives (29 an Giblean, LE 1,219). His table found that the heads of the houses lived a few years longer than their tenants. Clann Choinnich twice asked leave to burn the coal beyond the measure for the silver smelt. The council refused the first petition (31 an Lùnastal, LE 1,559) and the second by one voice (5 an Gearran, LE 1,776). The house did not bring it again, and the petition lies in the vein-house unanswered (28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,806). The census of hands shows the houses narrowing: at the last count of the age three of the seven held more than half the right between them (27 an Gearran, LE 1,791).

Two of the seven names answer to no house of the Holy Age, and of the other five the name is known but not the descent. The Library observes that Clann Choinnich shares its name with Coinneach Bàn, grandfather of Mòr nic Coinnich, and Clann Lachlainn with Lachlann Bàn, father of the last queen of Goraith Mòr's line; but it is nowhere said that either house came of either man, and the Library does not say it.

After the Age of Sundering the seven are not named again together. The custodian families go on sitting in the Council of Custodians in the Age of Strangers, and the royal council of twelve of the Age of the Kingdom is drawn partly from them (23 an t-Sultain, SE 2).

## VIII. Of the Vein-House and the Crown

In every age the rulers of the island had one question to answer: who keeps the vein, and who keeps the people. Four times the answer changed.

In the Age of Ailean the two were kept apart. The keepers of the slab were chosen by lot, and the kings of the hills were refused a hand in the lot (4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,412). In the Holy Age that parting was made law. The Keeper at Dùn ìseal held the flame and the galleries, and the rìgh held the roads and the granaries. Neither might do the other's work (9 an t-Sultain, FE 694). Twice the Hall lent its authority to the crown: once when the line of kings failed and the stone cup was set in Gilleasbuig Mòr's hands (12 am Màrt, FE 2,516), and once when it was set in the hands of Mòr nic Coinnich.

In the Age of Sundering the heir of the Hall was the vein-house above Muileann dhearg (14 an Lùnastal, LE 3), and the parting did not hold. Raghnaill Ruadh first broke it: he was master of the vein-house and a claimant to the crown, and he made a weapon of the coal (24 am Faoilleach, LE 558). Catrìona Bhuaadhach's ruling of the hearth was written to bind the custodians themselves. The second break came when the houses crowned the next master of the vein-house, and his reeves wrote into the custody-book that the ruler of Dia-thìr is also master of the vein-house (6 an t-Ògmhios, LE 859). Dòmhnall Ruadh was buried at Muileann dhearg, by the vein-house. His successors took the coal-roads into the crown's keeping (12 an t-Samhain, LE 939). For nine centuries one ruler held both the vein and the realm of Dia-thìr, and in all that time the Small-Burning Law was not changed. Every petition to change it was refused or left unanswered.

In the Age of Strangers there was neither crown nor vein-house to hold the vein. The Council of Custodians sat in the crown's place and kept the vein in name only. The Law was never repealed; it lapsed when it no longer paid to enforce it (2 an Dùbhlachd, AE 21). At the pitheads the Company's overseers ruled, and the custodians did not.

The restored kingdom kept the form of the old parting and little more. The Crown granted the Sloc Mòr to a single house on the humans' terms with the names changed (23 an Cèitean, SE 11), and in time bought every shaft back and worked the vein

through its Board "in the Crown's name alone" (30 an t-Iuchar, SE 60). The keeping of the rite passed to the Àrd-choimheadaiche<sup>15</sup> of Òrd Bhrìde<sup>16</sup>, the order of Brìde's flame, at Seann Skell (17 an Cèitean, SE 6). When that high custodian protested that the plain coinage seal showed the kingdom no longer held the vein sacred, the council answered that the kingdom had never said it did (31 an t-Iuchar, DE 15). The last face of the Sloc Mòr is kept open under the custody of the Rite, to cut coal for the altars (17 an Cèitean, DE 26). In the present year it filled four baskets, and the high custodian shared them among the houses of the Rite by lot (6 an Dàmhair, DE 27), as the keeper of the slab was chosen by lot in the Age of Ailean.

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15. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'

16. the order of Brìde's flame



## APPENDIX B

# The Faiths of Dia-thìr

Here is set down what is known of the faiths of Dia-thìr: the three that the kingdom's map names; the older reverence out of which the first two grew; the gods and the orders of the Old Faith; the Church that the humans brought; and the two matters that every faith on the island has had to answer, the holiness of the vein and the riddle of why it answers some hands and not others. The account is drawn from the annals, the Keepers' roll of Dùn ìseal, the custody-book of the vein-house, the registers that the schools, orders and churches sent to Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>1</sup>, and the map. Several faiths and orders have kept their own counsel, and where they have, the gap is left open.

Each faith is entered under the Dia-thìris name the map gives it, with its god or powers as the map gives them, and each order of the Old Faith under its own name. Where it is known when a name first appears, that is noted; where it is not known, nothing is guessed.

## I. The Faiths in Brief

The kingdom's map counts 505 towns and sets each under one faith. The seat is the house held first among a faith's houses in the present age.

| FAITH              | IN THE COMMON TONGUE | KIND (AS THE MAP HAS IT) | GOD                                           | TOWNS | SEAT                                                                                            |
|--------------------|----------------------|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| An Creideamh Sean  | the Old Faith        | organised; polytheist    | an Dagda, the Good God, first of the Tuath Dè | 315   | Dùn ìseal, where Bride's flame was bound; each order has its own seat                           |
| Na Seann Spioradan | the Old Spirits      | folk; shamanic           | na Sithichean, the people of the mounds       | 126   | Seann Dunn of the east coast, where the houses name the ancestors of forty families in one hall |

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

| FAITH      | IN THE COMMON TONGUE | KIND (AS THE MAP HAS IT) | GOD            | TOWNS | SEAT                                                      |
|------------|----------------------|--------------------------|----------------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| An Eaglais | the Church           | organised; monotheist    | Crìosd, Christ | 64    | Doire ghlas (called its heart; no bishop's seat recorded) |

The Old Faith and the Old Spirits are Dia-thìrich faiths. The Church is the faith of the Tuathaich of the north, and it holds all 64 Tuathaich towns. The Old Faith is kept in six orders (*ùird*, singular *òrd*), each with its own houses, seat, sayings and history:

| ORDER                    | IN THE COMMON TONGUE                                                   | GODS                                                                                                                | BEAST                         | TOWNS | TEMPLES | SHIRES WHERE FIRST | SEAT                      |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------|---------|--------------------|---------------------------|
| Òrd Bhrìde               | the order of Bride's flame; the Coal Rite                              | Bride of the flame; Crom Cruaich of the stone, called Dòrsair, Uilebheist nan Geataichean, the Monster of the Gates | none                          | 9     | 5       | 4                  | Seann Skell (south coast) |
| Òrd an t-Seabhaig        | the Hawk order; the order of the Hawk of Acaill                        | the Hawk of Acaill, called Mòd, an Seabhag Acrach, the Hungry Hawk; and Fionntan mac Bòchra, as old as the hawk     | the hawk                      | 14    | 8       | 4                  | Cnoc bheag                |
| Scoiltean nan Draoidhean | the druid schools; Feall-sanachd an Fhèidh, the Philosophy of the Deer | Flidais, lady of the deer, whose white stag is Camaran, am Fiadh Rìoghail, the Royal Stag                           | the stag                      | 133   | 16      | 23                 | Dùn thais                 |
| Òrd Mhacha               | the order of Macha                                                     | Macha, with the two horses of one chariot, Liath Macha, the grey, and Dubh Sainglenn, the black                     | the black horse and the grey  | 103   | 17      | 29                 | Cathair dhearg            |
| Òrd na Cloiche           | the order of the Stone                                                 | Lia Fàil, called Clach, the stone that cries out under the rightful king                                            | the wolf, beast of its Fianna | 21    | 8       | 8                  | Inis thais                |



| ORDER                  | IN THE<br>COMMON<br>TONGUE | GODS                                 | BEAST                                                             | TOWNS | TEMPLES | SHIRES<br>WHERE<br>FIRST | SEAT                     |
|------------------------|----------------------------|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|---------|--------------------------|--------------------------|
| Òrd<br>Mhanan-<br>nain | the order of<br>Manannan   | Manannan mac<br>Lir, lord of the sea | the yel-<br>low scor-<br>pion,<br>badge of<br>his Cup<br>of Truth | 35    | 11      | 8                        | Seann<br>Skell<br>(west) |

The Church is kept in three bodies. The churches of the Mission's line hold 51 towns, with eight churches the map marks as temples; their largest house is at Cnoc ghorm. The old congregations of the north coast, Eaglais nan Tuathach<sup>2</sup>, hold twelve, with three. The vigil of the Grey Night, which the Church's bishops call irregular, holds one town and its one house.

Counted by towns, the Old Faith is the most widely held, and within it the druid schools are the most widely held order, with Macha's next. Counted by the people in their towns, the Old Faith comes first by far, at nearly three million two hundred thousand. The Old Spirits come next, at a little over one million two hundred thousand, and the Church holds some five hundred and forty thousand. Among the orders Macha's is the largest in people, at nearly one million two hundred thousand, close behind the Old Spirits, and the schools come next. Òrd Bhrìde<sup>3</sup>, which the kingdom holds to be the rightful keeper of the vein, has nine towns. This is no error in the count; the reason is told in section VIII.

**Shires and temples.** Counted by land rather than by towns, the faiths divide the island's 123 shires as follows. A faith *holds* a shire where it has more of the shire's land than any other faith, and *shares* one where it has a smaller part. The temples are the houses the map marks as temples.

| FAITH              | SHIRES HELD | SHIRES SHARED | TEMPLES |
|--------------------|-------------|---------------|---------|
| An Creideamh Sean  | 77          | 13            | 65      |
| Na Seann Spioradan | 34          | 11            | 24      |
| An Eaglais         | 11          | 5             | 12      |

That accounts for 122 shires. In Seann Vell, the shire whose lands take in the far north-western cape, most of the land keeps no faith at all. The orders between them stand first in seventy-six of the Old Faith's shires. In the seventy-seventh, Muileann dhomhain in the south-east, no order has the greater part: the Old Spirits, Òrd Bhrìde and

2. the Tuathaich Church; the old congregations of the north coast

3. the order of Bride's flame

Macha's order have almost equal shares and the schools a small one, so that the orders together hold two-thirds of the land.

**Descent.** The Old Spirits are the old reverence itself, kept at the hearths without a break, and nothing older is known from which they came. The Old Faith grew out of the same reverence: its six orders began as the companies of the Hall's council at the end of the Holy Age (section II), though the gods they serve are older than any company. The Church came over the sea with the humans (5 am Faoilleach, AE 1) and has no root on Dia-thìr older than the Crossing. The vigil of the Grey Night is the only rite on the island that grew out of two faiths at once: its prayer came from the harbours of Manannan's order, and its goose from the Church (section VII).

**How they spread.** The Old Spirits have never sought converts beyond their own people, and neither have Òrd Bhride, the Hawk order or the old congregations of the north coast. Each is held where its people live and nowhere else. The druid schools and Macha's order spread with the kingdom, the one through its schools and the other through the crown's favour, and neither has gone beyond the Dia-thìrich. Since King Aonghas took it up, Macha's order has spread faster than any other. The Church sought converts from the day the Mission landed, and counted its first Dia-thìrich converts among the children of its school at Ros dhomhain (9 an Cèitean, AE 51). It holds no Dia-thìrich town today. Manannan's order, the Stone and the Grey Night take in anyone of any people who comes to them. Only Manannan's has taught its prayers to a second people: the first human fishing families at Ceann mhòr learned its harbour prayers (14 am Màrt, AE 51). The Stone, for all its open doors, is still held only in Dia-thìrich towns of the south-west.

**Land without a faith.** No faith holds the far north-western cape beyond Baile chrom. It has no town, and most of it lies outside any shire. Its few families, herders and shore-folk, most of them Tuathaich, have no house of any faith, and the first census of the restored kingdom entered them as *gun chreideamh*<sup>4</sup>, without a faith (30 an t-Iuchar, SE 7). The same entry covers Eilean ghorm, where the grey geese winter and are never hunted (3 an Lùnastal, VE 3,821), Eilean dhubh, where the sea-thieves' boats were burned (27 an t-Samhain, LE 801), and the islet of Eilean gheal off the south-east coast. The cape has been thinly held since the dearth on the north-west shore (19 an Giblean, LE 819).

## II. The Old Reverence and Its Parting

The chronicle says plainly that the Dia-thìrich reverence was once one. On 11 an Gearran, FE 2,855, it says, that one reverence began to part into the several threads that

later ages named each for itself. What it had been while it was one may be gathered from the Ancient Age and the Age of Ailean, whose tellings name the slab, the cup and the handful, and set no god over them. The one telling of those ages that names the gods, the Telling of the Making, was kept within a single kindred (section III).

**The slab and the handful.** A mason broke into a vein of coal that showed every colour where it should have given dust (20 am Faoilleach, VE 1). That night lightning struck the broken vein and set it burning, and he carried the fire home, the first fire of the Dia-thìrich. His people dug no further. When the fire was out they laid a slab over the break and cut their well a stone's throw away (19 am Màrt, VE 151). Families took turns sitting by the slab (8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120) and later chose a keeper by lot (26 an t-Samhain, GE 2,403). The first was Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill, who had a cup ground out of grey stone to the size of her cupped hand (29 an t-Sultain, GE 2,405), because by then no fire took more coal than one hand could hold (5 an Lùnastal, GE 1,011). When a keeper was found with a basket of coal in his house, it was neither burned nor kept. It was laid back under the slab: *the coal went home* (4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,411). By the end of the age every household of the hills burned its handful on one night of the dark of the year, so that the low fires of the handful showed on every hillside at once (9 an Cèitean, GE 4,355).

**The doctrine.** The oldest saying on the island is cut on the column near Cnoc ghorm (6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851), and it was first spoken as a rule at the ford gathering (21 an t-Sultain, GE 2,423):

*Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann.* We did not come; we were here.

No order or house on Dia-thìr has disowned it since, though each reads it in its own way.

**What the Old Ones left.** Làrach an Teampaill<sup>5</sup> has its altar set square to the central mountains (14 an Lùnastal, VE 2,679), and every later temple on Dia-thìr faces some other way. Its top stone was prised off and never found (5 an Gearran, VE 4,175). The chronicle calls it older than any faith of which there is record, and says that it was turned toward the vein and not toward the sky's rim (7 am Faoilleach, VE 4,275). The Dia-thìrich walked round it and took no stone from it (13 an t-Sultain, GE 3,357). Whether its builders held the vein holy, or only knew where it lay, no one can now say.

**The Binding and the first parting.** The Holy Age opens with the fall of Ailean Mòr at the Ford of Blood (2 an t-Sultain, FE 1), and three weeks after it his heirs swore the Binding of the First Flame (23 an t-Sultain, FE 1), the flame the Old Faith calls

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4. without a faith

5. the temple ruin

Bride's. At Dùn ìseal Beathag Bhàn was chosen to hold the flame (28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 4), and Talla na Lasrach<sup>6</sup> was raised over it with one door facing the vein and none facing the sea (19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 15). The custom of the handful hardened into the Small-Burning Law (13 an Lùnastal, FE 142). The Keepers also judged what belonged to the vein, and each judgement drew a line. When Muireach Liath held that the fortune-stream Allt an Àigh<sup>7</sup> belonged "to the ancestors and the weather and not to the vein" (16 am Màrt, FE 59), the Hall's reverence and the older reverence of the hearths could be seen for the first time as two things. The first became the Old Faith, and the second the Old Spirits.

By the end of the Holy Age the Hall could no longer hold the island to one rite. Seumas Bàn's clerks listed every rite that burned the handful or claimed the vein (18 an Dàmhair, FE 2,838): the Hall's own, the ancestor-keeping of the old folk, the dawn-hawk of the north coast, the wood-watchers of the west, the wolf-sworn, the sting-oath, and both schools of the stag. The council then began to sit in companies by rite. Seumas Bàn complained that he kept the flame for eight peoples who each thought themselves its only keepers (16 an t-Samhain, FE 2,858). The ancestor-keepers are the Old Spirits of the map. The other companies are the roots of the six orders of the Old Faith. The Church grew from no root on Dia-thìr.

**What stayed common.** Pilgrims of every rite went on walking to Allt an Àigh (15 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,860), and the sick of every rite were bathed at the springs of Muileann ruadh (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>8</sup>) without being asked which rite they kept (19 an t-Sultain, FE 2,863). The Age of Sundering added two rites that belong to no single order. One is the Mourning Custom for the departed, which is neither wholly grief nor wholly rejoicing (1 an Lùnastal, LE 54). The other is the empty-harbour rite on Cidhe an Diosail<sup>9</sup> at Seann Skell (25 an t-Samhain, LE 61). The harbour saying spoken at that rite belongs to no order of worship:

*Dh'fhalbh iad, agus cha do dh'fhalbh iad.* They went, and they did not go.

### III. The Gods

The gods of the Old Faith are *na Dè*, and their people are the *Tuath Dè*, the people of the gods. The tellings of Dia-thìr are the oldest that hold them. The Dia-thìrich say the gods were on the island before the people were, for the Tuath Dè walked it with the

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6. the Hall of the Flame

7. the stream of the healing water

8. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

9. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

Young God in its first days, before the godfolk grew; and the people, in their turn, were on it before anyone else came: *bha sinn ann*. The priests of the Old Faith are the *draoidbean*, the druids; its poets are the *filidbean* and its judges the *britheamhan*. Most of the gods have no house of their own. The orders each serve one god or one pair above the rest, and honour the others at the feasts and in need.

**Caoran**, *an Dia Òg*<sup>10</sup>, the Young God, is the maker of this world and the god of the coal. His name is *ember*. He is the youngest son of an Dagda<sup>11</sup> and Danu, of a long line of gods and goddesses, each of whom on coming of age went out and made a world of their own out of some other thing: one of song, one of salt and bone, one of wind and horn. Caoran chose coal, and took his first coal from the ash under his father's cauldron. Of it he made all that is, then the earth. The island he did not make as he made the rest: it was born. He held the last coal of all over the empty sea and let drops of fire fall from it, and they hardened where they fell, one on another, until the island stood up out of the water; and that, the Telling says, is why its coal is not the coal of the wide earth. He gave a spirit to every spring and hill on it, to the old trees, the standing stones and the pools under the falls, and these are the old spirits of the land that the hearths honour, whom Na Seann Spioradan<sup>12</sup> keep (section VI). Then he laid his palms on the warm ground and called, and the first people grew up out of the island like grass after spring rain: *an Dia-sbluagh*<sup>13</sup>, the godfolk, whom the tellings call *feur uaine an eilein*, the green grass of the island, and from whom the Dia-thìrich, *Clann nan Dè*<sup>14</sup>, the godkin, are descended. The island is the elder of their line. He gave them the island to keep, and as a hidden gift he laid the elements in the coal under its mountains, each in its own colour. These are *na Seachd Guail*<sup>15</sup>, the Seven Coals; together they are *an gual dathach*<sup>16</sup>, the coloured coal:

| COAL         | DIA-THÌRIS             | HOLDS       |
|--------------|------------------------|-------------|
| black        | <i>gual dubh</i>       | earth       |
| fire         | <i>gual teine</i>      | fire        |
| snowflake    | <i>gual sneachda</i>   | air         |
| gold sheen   | <i>gual òir</i>        | the sea     |
| silver sheen | <i>gual airgid</i>     | river water |
| mahogany     | <i>gual donn-ruadh</i> | life        |

10. the Young God, Caoran

11. the Good God, father of the gods

12. the Old Spirits

13. the godfolk; lit. 'the god-host'

14. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

15. the Seven Coals

16. the coloured coal

| COAL    | DIA-THÌRIS               | HOLDS  |
|---------|--------------------------|--------|
| rainbow | <i>gual bogha-froise</i> | spirit |

There is coloured coal nowhere but on Dia-thìr, and only the eyes of the godkin see its colours; to all others it is black. The whole of this is the Telling of the Making, *Aithris a' Chruthachaidh*<sup>17</sup>, which stands before the Seven Books. It was told by Coimhdeach na Fine<sup>18</sup> to one of the mason's line, and the mason's kindred, *Clann a' Chlachair*<sup>19</sup>, afterward called *Clann na Ceiste*<sup>20</sup>, the Children of the Question, kept it among themselves; when it passed to the hearths at large is not known. The Telling and the Second Book say that Caoran came to the island once more, with the Tuath Dè about him, to make Ailean Mòr *Rìgh Chlann nan Dè*<sup>21</sup>, king of the godkin (28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1), who was king of the godkin from that night until he fell at the Ford of Blood four thousand six hundred years after (2 an t-Sultain, FE 1). Caoran has no order, no temple and no feast of his own. The Old Faith honours an Dagda first, as the father of the gods, and names Caoran after him as the maker of the world.

**An Dagda**, the Good God, is the father of the gods. His is the cauldron from which no company goes away hungry, the club that kills with one end and wakes the dead with the other, and the harp that calls the seasons in their order. He stands first among the gods on the map and in every order, yet he has no order and no temple of his own. Every house of the Old Faith fills a cauldron for him at the four feasts.

**Bride** is the goddess of the hearth-fire, of poetry, of healing and of smithcraft. The first flame bound at Dùn ìseal (23 an t-Sultain, FE 1), three weeks after the first king fell, is hers, and the Keepers from Beathag Bhàn on (28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 4) kept it in her name. Her order, Òrd Bhrìde<sup>22</sup>, keeps the flame still, and every hearth on the island is swept and relit on her feast.

**Crom Cruaich**, the bent one of the mound, is the god of the vein. The vein of coloured coal broken at the crack (20 am Faoilleach, VE 1) is his, for the Telling of the Making says that Caoran set him at its door, and so is the slab over it (19 am Màrt, VE 151). He gives, and his price is measured; the handful, the cup and the Small-Burning Law (13 an Lùnastal, FE 142) are that measure. The tellings of Magh Slèacht, where his stone stood covered in gold among twelve stones, say that his due there was the first-lings of every kind, paid at Samhain; the Law holds that due to a handful. His oldest byname is Dòrsair, Uilebheist nan Geataichean<sup>23</sup>, the Monster of the Gates, who

17. the Telling of the Making  
18. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'  
19. the Mason's children, the Mason's line  
20. the Children of the Question  
21. king of the godkin, the first king's style  
22. the order of Bride's flame

stands at the door between the mountain and those who take from it. He is honoured by Òrd Bhride at the southern Seann Skell and at the last open face of the Sloc Mòr.

**Fionntan mac Bòchra** is the oldest of men. He outlived the great flood of the old tellings, and passed the long ages as a salmon, an eagle and a hawk, and he forgets nothing. His fellow in memory is the Hawk of Acaill, the grey hawk of time, as old as he is, which took one of his eyes when he swam as a salmon; the two have told each other the ages. The Hawk order takes its name from that hawk and keeps them both, and on the north coast it calls the hawk Mòd. The oldest hawk on the island, over a door at Àth mhòr (13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 1,853), is read as the Hawk of Acaill.

**Flidais** is the lady of the deer and the wild. The white stag first told of at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>24</sup> (11 am Màrt, VE 3,513), the wood marked sacred before any order claimed it (21 an Giblean, VE 3,408), is hers in the tellings of the later ages, though the oldest tellings give it no god. The druid schools keep the wood in her name.

**Macha** is the goddess of sovereignty, of kingship and of horses. It is told that when she was great with child she was made to race against a king's horses. She won, and bore twins at the finish, and she laid on the men who made her run the pangs of a woman in labour, to fall on them in their hour of need. Eamhain Mhacha is named for her twins. The grey of the two horses that drew Cù Chulainn's chariot bears her name, Liath Macha, the Grey of Macha, and his yoke-fellow is Dubh Sainglenn, the black. The two were foaled on the night the hero was born; other tellings have them rise out of a grey lake in the mountains. Before his last battle the grey wept tears of blood, and when the hero fell the grey fought over him while the black ran on. Her order keeps the pair as its sign. Her wood is Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>25</sup>, and her order makes the kings of Dia-thìr: King Aonghas was the first king buried by her rite (31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 484), and Niall was crowned by it at Cathair dhearg (19 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3).

**Lia Fàil**<sup>26</sup>, the stone that cries out under the rightful king, which the Tuath Dè brought out of the north of the world and set up at Teamhair, is honoured as a power in its own right by the order of the Stone. The order holds that the Stone is one and its stones are many. Its first stone stood at the gate of Caol leathan (12 am Faoilleach, FE 1,009), and its second was dragged from the mountain to Inis thais (3 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,217). Some read the name of the oldest king-list, Rìghrean na Cloiche<sup>27</sup>, the kings of the stone (9 an Lùnastal, GE 1), as the kings of this stone. The list itself does not say.

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23. the Monster of the Gates, Crom Cruaich

24. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

25. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

26. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

27. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

**Manannan mac Lir** is the lord of the sea, and the sea round Dia-thìr is his, Muir Mhanannain<sup>28</sup>. His mist hides the Otherworld, and the Dia-thìrich tell that the fleet of the Sundering sailed into it (19 an Giblean, LE 40). Until the Crossing the same mist hid Dia-thìr from every ship beyond it. His Cup of Truth breaks in three when three lies are spoken over it, and three truths make it whole again. His order keeps the western coast, and its first seat is the western Seann Skell (1 an t-Sultain, LE 654).

**Lugh Làmhfhada**, Lugh of the long arm, is the master of every craft. Lùnastal is his feast, which he made in memory of his foster-mother Tàiltiu. On it markets open, games are held and oaths are sworn before witnesses, and on the feast itself Cathal was crowned (1 an Lùnastal, DE 3).

**Goibhniu** is the smith of the gods. The smiths of the old vein country, where the forges of Muileann chrom, Muileann dhearg and Muileann dhomhain now make arms, swear by him. No smith on Dia-thìr could place the nails of the timber that came ashore at Ceann mhòr from beyond Manannan's mist (22 an Cèitean, LE 1,794).

**Dian Cècht** is the healer of the gods, who made Nuadha's hand of silver. The springs of Muileann ruadh, where the sick of every rite are bathed (19 an t-Sultain, FE 2,863), are his.

**The Morrìgan** is the goddess of war and the crows. The battlefields are hers, among them the ford of Àth shean, where the custody-book counts three hundred dead (22 an Gearran, LE 554).

**Ogma** is the god of letters and of eloquence. The first Dia-thìrich letters, the stag-letters made from the cutters' tally-notches (15 am Màrt, FE 914), are the ogham, which the druids call his gift.

**Nuadha** is the first king of the gods, who lost his hand in battle and ruled again with the hand of silver that Dian Cècht made him. Dia-thìris still calls an artificial limb *ball-airgid*, silver-limb, after him.

**Danu** is the mother of the gods, and the Tuath Dè are named from her. She has no house; the tellings give her the rivers.

**Donn** is the lord of the dead. His house, *Taigh Dhuinn*<sup>29</sup>, is a rock in the sea to the south-west, and the dead go to it. The Old Faith names him at Samhain and at every burial.

**Coimhdeach na Fine**, the Keeper of the Kin, is neither god nor ghost. It is the spirit that watches over the island's people for Caoran, made, the Telling says, of the smoke of the first coal he woke. It shows itself seldom and generations apart, as a figure of grey smoke of a tall man's height that stands still in the wind. It has no order, no house and no feast, and it is not counted among the Tuath Dè. In the grove of Doire

28. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

29. the house of Donn, where the dead go



ghlas it told the Telling of the Making to one of the mason's line, and when he asked how the colours might be woken, it answered with a riddle, which the Children of the Question kept:

*Tha spiorad fa leth san speur, san talamh agus sa mhuir. Meascaich na spioradan agus bidh iad uile-chumbachdach.* The sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit. Merge the spirits, and they become almighty.

It came again to the grove to light the rainbow coal before Ailean Mòr (21 an t-Iuchar, VE 5,324), and at his vigil, the Children of the Question say, it told him that the power of the coals would be his alone, that his children would have a little of it and their children less, until it faded out of his line, and that when strangers held the island the fire would wake again in it. Once more, and in secret, it came in the Age of Strangers. The camps tell that it stood in the draught of a deep gallery at Achadh dhomhain before Donnchadh mac Thormoid, a hewer of Ailean's blood by the line of his son Somhairle, and bade him breathe; and what went into him with the dust the Mission's surgeon took for the lung-rot. It was a gift, *Tiodhlac a' Choimhdich*<sup>30</sup>, given in the dust of the deep places to the kin who went down, so that a people with its hill dug out from under it should have something of its own to stand against the strangers with; for the Keeper does not fight for the kin. It woke in Donnchadh's daughter Aisling (7 am Màrt, AE 69), the first of the *fuil-ghuail*<sup>31</sup>, and the camps hold that the coal-blood children after her came of it. No order keeps this as doctrine. The Rite, which holds the vein itself holy and no spirit in it, neither affirms the gift nor denies it (section VIII).

## IV. The Four Feasts and the Otherworld

**The feasts.** Four feasts divide the year into quarters (Appendix D). They are older than any order now on the island, and all three faiths keep them in some fashion, each for its own reasons. The Old Faith keeps them as the island kept them before the Crossing, by the moon, each on the first night of its moon; the kingdom and the Church keep them on the first day of the civil month, and the two may fall as much as a fortnight apart.

- **Samhain**, the first night of the moon Samhnas and 1 an t-Samhain in the civil calendar, is summer's end, and was the Dia-thìrich new year before the Crossing, when the Otherworld stands open and the dead are nearest. The Old Faith names

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30. the Keeper's gift

31. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

Donn and the dead of the year. In the Holy Age the Hall filled the baskets of the Small-Burning Law at Samhain and the galleries closed.

- **Là Fhèill Brìde**, or Imbolc, the first night of Gearras and 1 an Gearran, is Brìde's feast. Hearths are swept and relit, and Òrd Bhrìde<sup>32</sup> lights its first lamp of the year from the altar-flame.
- **Bealltainn**, the first night of Bealltach and 1 an Cèitean, is summer's beginning, the feast of the bright fire, when the cattle go up to the high pastures between two fires. The first sentence under the Small-Burning Law was given on Bealltainn itself (1 an Cèitean, FE 145).
- **Lùnastal**, the first night of Lùghnas and 1 an Lùnastal, is Lugh's feast of first-fruits and gathering.

The Old Spirits keep the same four nights at the hearth and at the mounds, counting to them by nights as the old reckoning did, and the Church keeps the civil days as saints' days and the feasts of the Church's year.

**The Otherworld.** The Old Faith holds that the Otherworld lies west over the open sea, past the sight of any headland. Its tellings give it two names: *Tìr nan Òg*<sup>33</sup>, the land of the young, where no one ages, and *Magh Meall*<sup>34</sup>, the plain of delight. On the way to it, on its rock in the south-western sea, stands *Taigh Dhuinn*<sup>35</sup>, the house of Donn, where the dead gather. The fleet of the Sundering went out north-about into Manannan's mist on the eastern sea (19 an Giblean, LE 40), not west, but the tellers say it went to find the Otherworld all the same, and the saying at the empty-harbour rite, *they went, and they did not go*, is read in the light of it. When the humans came in from the same quarter of sea, old sailors at Cuan shean said so aloud, and the council forbade the remark (9 an Gearran, AE 2).

**The sìth.** Nearer home the Otherworld opens in the hills. The *sìth*, the mounds, belong to the *sìthichean*, the people of the mounds, whom the Old Spirits honour at the hearth and the Old Faith leaves alone.

## V. An Creideamh Sean and Its Orders

The Old Faith is the faith of the gods, and it is kept in its orders. Each order has its houses, temples and custodians and its own history, and some have had schisms of

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32. the order of Brìde's flame

33. the land of the young

34. the plain of delight

35. the house of Donn, where the dead go

their own. All of them honour an Dagda<sup>36</sup> and keep the four feasts. They differ on the vein, on the measure and on which god stands nearest to it, and they have differed since the Holy Age. The druids of every order are trained in the schools or in the order's own houses. No single council speaks for the Old Faith as a whole.

## ÒRD BHRÌDE

Òrd Bhrìde<sup>37</sup>, the order of Brìde's flame, is the Hall of the Holy Age and the Coal Rite of the chronicle. It keeps Brìde's flame, bound at Dùn ìseal, and Crom's stone, the vein. In its settled form it is a teaching set in order within the Old Faith, where before there was only the scattered reverence of the hearths, and it is built about the leyline and the unbroken line of the coal-touched (18 an Giblean, SE 6). As an ordered body it is the youngest of the orders; as a rite it claims to be the oldest, and the claim is just. Its seat is at the southern Seann Skell, where its largest house stands (17 an Cèitean, SE 6). Its saying is the Law's own:

*Làn an dà bhois, agus gun tuilleadh.* The fill of the two palms, and no more.

It has nine towns, all in the south-east, and holds four shires: Seann Skell, Tobar dhearg, Muileann naomh and Àth fhionn. It has a third of Muileann dhomhain, and the Old Spirits hold the land on every side. The largest towns are Seann Skell, Tobar dhearg, Muileann naomh, Caol ruadh and Àth fhionn. The map marks five of its houses as temples: Seann Skell, Tobar dhearg, Muileann naomh, Baile gharbh on the coast road and Caol naomh, the pilgrims' landing. Muileann naomh was the southernmost house of the Hawk until it took the order of worship of Òrd Bhrìde (29 an Cèitean, SE 6). The order's history is given in section VIII.

## ÒRD AN T-SEABHAIG

**What it holds.** The Hawk order is the older form of Brìde's rite on the north coast. It teaches that the hawk of the vein is Mòd, the Hawk of Acaill, who is as old as Fionntan mac Bòchra and remembers the ages with him, and who must be fed the measured handful and no more, "for a hawk overfed will not hunt and a hawk starved will turn on the hand" (20 an Giblean, LE 229). Too much ruins the hawk, and so does too little; the measure lies between. The Hawk holds, moreover, that the measure is the hawk's to keep, and no custodian's.

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36. the Good God, father of the gods

37. the order of Brìde's flame

**Rites and sayings.** Each household feeds its hawk before it eats, and the handful is burned at dawn with the hawk on the wrist. The fowlers who began the rite gave its first saying (30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,999):

*Is acras an lasair.* The flame is a hunger.

The sayings of Gormshuil nic Artair, who gathered the rite into its first house, were written down after her death as *Leabhar an t-Seabhaig*<sup>38</sup>, the Book of the Hawk. The copyist marked every saying he had not heard from her own mouth, and the marked outnumbered the rest (5 an t-Ògmhios, LE 251). The saying most often cut over hawk-house doors is:

*Cha shealg seabhag sàthach.* A sated hawk will not hunt.

**Holy places.** The oldest hawk carved on the island is over a door at Àth mhòr (13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 1,853), and it is older than any rite. The rite itself began at the Seann Skell of the northern coast (Seann Skell). The first house of the order is at Cnoc bheag.

**History.** In the Holy Age the dawn-hawk spread along the north coast, and while it spread the Keeper wrote that it was no concern of the Hall's (28 am Faoilleach, FE 2,072). In time it was the first rite to refuse the Hall's measure-check outright (19 an t-Sultain, FE 2,840). The rite was old already when Gormshuil nic Artair gathered it at Cnoc bheag into its first house (20 an Giblean, LE 229), and from that day it was an order. A second house followed at Ros gheal (22 am Màrt, LE 239) and a southern one at Muileann naomh (13 an t-Sultain, LE 526), which is now a house of Òrd Bhrìde. The schism came when a council at Cnoc bheag split over whether Mòd's measure could ever be raised (20 an t-Ògmhios, LE 889). Those who called it fixed kept the name of the Hungry Hawk. The Fed Hawk were turned out to the northern Seann Skell (23 an Giblean, LE 909), and their petition to raise the handful by a quarter was the first recorded request to alter the Small-Burning Law (25 an Lùnastal, LE 919). It was refused, and after that the Fed Hawk are not heard of as a house of their own.

Under the humans the Hawk resisted before there was any ordered resistance for it to join. Murchadh Seabhag preached that Mòd starves those who eat faster than the land can feed them (6 an t-Sultain, AE 22), and his sermon was the first Dia-thìrich text the Company's agents were told to confiscate. When hawk-priests were barred from the camps (12 an t-Sultain, AE 38), the crews carried the sermons in themselves (10 an Cèitean, AE 76). Ìomhar Seabhag's shrines served as meeting houses for the Lamp-Watch (24 an Giblean, AE 140), and when the war came he called it Mòd's own hunger turned back on those who fed it (5 an t-Ògmhios, AE 150). In the Age of the

38. the Book of the Hawk

Kingdom the Hawk houses refused the written order of worship of Òrd Bhrìde (23 an Cèitean, SE 6); only the far southern house at Muileann naomh took it (29 an Cèitean, SE 6). The others named their own custodian at Inis ìseal (26 an Cèitean, SE 35). They then wrote down their order, which until that day had been spoken and never written, and they keep the book locked away (23 an t-Samhain, SE 35). They accepted a place under the high custodian only on condition that they kept that order (13 an Dùbhlachd, SE 47). The quarrel with Òrd Bhrìde has grown quiet, but it is not ended.

**Where it is held now.** Fourteen towns, all Dia-thìrich, along the north-central coast and up the Abhainn ìseal. It holds Inis bhàn and Ros gheal. It is the greatest order, though with less than half the land, in Cnoc bheag, where Manannan's order and Macha's hold the rest, and in the northern Seann Skell, which it shares with the Old Spirits and Manannan's order. It also has a quarter of the northern Doire fhionn. Cnoc bheag is the largest, and its Hawk house is the richest house of any order outside the capital (14 an Dàmhair, SE 46). After it come Inis bhàn, Ros gheal, the northern Seann Skell and Ros leathan. The map marks eight of its houses as temples: Cnoc bheag, Inis bhàn, Ros gheal and the northern Seann Skell; Àth shean on the northern march (Àth shean); the Hawk mill of Muileann uaine and its field village Achadh fhada; and Inis ìseal, where the Hawk's own custodian sits.

## SCOILTEAN NAN DRAOIDHEAN

**What it holds.** The druid schools are the reasoning order of the Old Faith, and they call themselves by their oldest name, Feallsanachd an Fhèidh<sup>39</sup>, the Philosophy of the Deer. They are schools more than a church. They gathered about one question, why the vein answers some hands and not others (10 an Dàmhair, FE 103), and they were the first within the Old Faith who reasoned about the coal as well as revering it. They do not deny that the vein is holy. They ask what its holiness does. Their patron is Flidais, lady of the deer and the wild, whose white stag walks in their sacred wood. In none of the schools' records kept in the Library is the stag, Camaran, worshipped, and his name is first found in writings much younger than the first schools (7 an Dùbhlachd, FE 118). The schools are counted among the orders of the Old Faith, and they have not objected.

**Rites and sayings.** Their one public observance is the yearly walking of the bounds of Flidais's wood (11 an t-Iuchar, LE 479). All else they do is argument. Their oldest question, as the masters put it to beginners, is:

*Carson an làmh seo?* Why this hand?

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39. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

A student who thinks he has solved it is given Aonghas mac Coinnich's answer (19 an t-Ògmhios, AE 49):

*Chan e sin a' cheist.* That is not the question.

**Holy places.** Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>40</sup>, which was held sacred long before any order of the Old Faith laid claim to it (21 an Giblean, VE 3,408), and where the white stag was first seen (11 am Màrt, VE 3,513). The wood lies outside the schools' own country, among Old Spirits towns in the shire of Baile chaol, and the people of Cnoc uaine and Àth dhearg on its edge, who keep the ancestors, share its keeping. Dùn thais has the first stone temple of the stag's people (21 am Màrt, FE 2,889). Caol shean is the schools' house in the Age of the Kingdom.

**Where it is held now.** 133 towns, all Dia-thìrich, in the north-east and the eastern hills; the east coast itself belongs to the Old Spirits. The schools stand first in twenty-three shires, a block running from Tobar ghorm and Àth mhòr in the north through Caol bheag, Baile gharbh and Dùn thais to Caol shean, Muileann chiar and Muileann dhearg in the hills, and west to Baile Mòr dhomhain in the middle of the island. They share ten more, most of them with the Old Spirits along the line where the two faiths meet, and they have nearly half of Cnoc dhubh, Dùn iséal and Cnoc gheal. The largest towns are Caol bheag, Baile gharbh, Dùn thais, Caol shean and Caol gharbh. The map marks sixteen of the schools' houses as temples, though the schools call them halls: among them Dùn thais, Caol shean, Caol bheag, Ros fhionn and the church villages whose chapels served the silver-miners and the old bridge. Muileann chaol, the Library town, is a school town. The schools' history is given in section IX.

## ÒRD MHACHA

**What it holds.** Macha's order keeps "two horses, one yoke, light and dark two powers in balance, and the vein belonging to both" (31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441). The wood-watchers held that their black beast has two natures, one that keeps and one that devours, and that the vein has the same two (13 am Faoilleach, FE 2,852); the order tells it of the two horses that drew one chariot, the black Dubh Sainglenn and the grey Liath Macha. It is the order of the capital and the court, and the kings of Dia-thìr are made by its rite. Its oldest saying is the wood-watchers':

*Tha dà nàdar aig a' bhèist, agus aig an fhèith.* The beast has two natures, and so has the vein.

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40. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

Its own saying is of the pair:

*Dà each, aon chuing.* Two horses, one yoke.

**Rites and holy places.** Its priests read omens for rulers and bury the dead by their own rite. King Aonghas mac Uisdein was the first king buried that way (31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 484). Its floors are laid in black and white, and the floor of its great house at Cathair mhòr took eleven years (14 am Màrt, LE 1,459). Its sacred wood is Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>41</sup>, near the lesser Cnoc bheag south of the capital (Cnoc bheag). That town is not the river port of the Hawk that bears the same name.

**History.** The order began as a watch. A small company settled at the edge of a wood no one had ever cleared and watched for a black horned beast that walked in it (15 an t-Samhain, FE 1,569), the beast the order takes for a sign of Dubh Sainglenn, the black horse. Its quarrel with the stag's people over both sacred woods became the holy-wood dispute, which was settled by dividing the keeping of the woods, and no side was named the winner (10 an Gearran, FE 1,589). Anna Ruadh took a wood-watcher into her household at Cathair dhearg to read the omens (23 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,822). Cathair dhomhain refused one, and from that day the rivalry of the two towns has been a matter of faith as well (24 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,826). Cathair dhomhain is a town of Macha's order now, with its own temple. The order took its settled form when King Aonghas took up the wood-watchers' rite of Macha (31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441). By royal grant its priests then had sole keeping of the western wood, and the other claimants withdrew, for reasons that are not told (14 am Faoilleach, LE 471).

Under the humans it split over the Residency's coin. The priests at Cathair dhearg blessed it (24 an Gearran, AE 85). Those who refused went to the sacred forest, where they received custodians who had lost their seats (25 am Màrt, AE 87). Sixty years later the capital's temple sheltered the council that Strake had locked out (26 an Gearran, AE 147). In the forest the dissenters sat with custodians and the Lamp-Watch when the council of the mining regions was formed (20 an Lùnastal, AE 148). In the restored kingdom the house at Cathair dhearg got back the keeping of the regalia and refused Òrd Bhride a share of it (26 an Gearran, SE 7).

**Where it is held now.** 103 towns, all Dia-thìrich, across the middle and south of the island. It stands first in twenty-nine shires in one block, from the capital's own shire (Cathair dhearg) and its neighbours in the middle of the island south to Ros dhomhain, Cathair fhada and Doire fhiadhaich, and east to Cathair mhòr and Seann Chwen. Manannan's order holds more than a third of Cathair dhomhain, the shire of the capital's old rival, and in Baile ghlas the Stone holds most of the land, though the

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41. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

harbour town is Macha's. The largest towns are Ros dhomhain, Cathair mhòr, Àth shean, Seann Chwen and Baile ghlas. The map marks seventeen of its temples. Five are the great houses of Cathair mhòr, Cathair dhomhain, Cathair dhearg, Ceann leathan and Cuan uaine; the others are the priests' towns, such as Cathair naomh and Cnoc bhàn, where acolytes are trained for the capital's temples, and the chapels along the roads to the capital. Cnoc naomh, whose people once kept the old reverence "with no hawk, wolf, sting or stag in it" (16 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,926), is a town of Macha's order on the map.

## ÒRD NA CLOICHE

**What it holds.** The order of the Stone holds that the Stone watches the whole island as a guard watches a road, and will cry out under the rightful king (21 an Lùnastal, FE 2,843). The Stone is Lia Fàil<sup>42</sup>, and its sworn guards are the Fianna, "who keep the island as a wolf keeps its range" (28 am Màrt, LE 409). The Stone's plain name is Clach, the common word for *stone*. The first stone was a white stone carved as a wolf at the gate of Caol leathan, on which the road-guards swore their watch, and later ages read more into it than the road-guards ever did (12 am Faoilleach, FE 1,009). The tales of Fionn and his Fianna are the order's own. The Stone is not known ever to have claimed the vein. When Òrd Bhride was set in order, the houses of the Stone sent no witnesses, only "a letter wishing it well" (2 an Gearran, SE 7).

**Rites and sayings.** Oaths are taken before the Stone. The houses of the Stone nurse the sick. When a spotted fever came to Inis chrom the Fianna nursed the sick and many of them died of it, and thereafter the town was the Stone's (3 an t-Sultain, LE 624). Its saying comes from the road-guards:

*Mar a gbleidbeas am freiceadan an rathad, gleidhidh Clach an t-eilean.* As the guard keeps the road, Clach keeps the island.

**Holy places.** Caol leathan, whose house of the Stone is the largest of the order and rings a bell for the hours (7 an Cèitean, SE 21); Inis thais, where a second stone of white quartz was dragged from the mountain (3 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,217) and the first temple to Lia Fàil by name was built (16 an Dùbhlachd, LE 419); and Baile gheal.

**History.** The wolf-sworn were soldiers before they were an order. The order took its form when Dòmhnall mac Ailein, a net-maker of Inis thais, preached that their stone was Lia Fàil and its guards the Fianna (28 am Màrt, LE 409). Its schism was over the dead. Those who would not pray to the Stone for the dead kept the temple at Inis

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42. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king



thais, and those who would build a house at Baile gheal (25 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,389, 8 an Lùnastal, LE 1,399). Of any reconciling of the two houses nothing is told. In the Age of the Kingdom the houses of the Stone have served as banks as well as churches. They issued chits on house paper when coin ran short (3 am Màrt, SE 6) and lent the money for Doire shean's harbour (24 an t-Ògmhios, SE 30). They also published a count of their own people that matched the kingdom's to within a hundred (28 an Lùnastal, SE 65).

**Where it is held now.** 21 towns, all Dia-thìrich, in the south-west. It holds six shires outright, Doire shean, Inis chrom, Baile ghorm, Caol fhiadhaich, Cnoc àrsaidh and Baile gheal, and most of Caol leathan and Baile ghlais. In Inis thais, the shire of its chief shrine, Manannan's order holds three-fifths of the land. The Stone also has a share of Seann Dunn, Baile chior and Seann Warr, where Seann Warr is a town of the Stone in Manannan's country. The largest are Doire shean, Inis thais, Inis chrom, Baile ghorm and Seann Warr. The map marks temples in eight of its towns: Inis thais, still the chief shrine of the order, Caol leathan, Baile gheal, Doire shean, Inis chrom, Caol fhiadhaich, Baile Mòr fhionn and Cnoc àrsaidh, which holds the oldest shrines of the Stone.

## ÒRD MHANANNAIN

**What it holds.** Manannan's order holds that the lord of the sea sees the liar wherever he is, and that his Cup of Truth breaks at the lies spoken over it and is whole again at the truth; the yellow scorpion is the old sign on the Cup, and the order's badge. It was the first teaching on the island that called itself the only true one (3 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,846). Its central teaching is about the sea: Manannan shut the eastern sea behind the fleet of the Sundering with his mist, which hid the island from every ship beyond it, and it must not be tried again (1 an t-Sultain, LE 654). The order keeps the sea shut by prayer. Its priests recorded the mist thinning in the last years of the Age of Sundering (27 an Dàmhair, LE 1,813), and it lifted in the winter the humans' ships came out of it (13 am Faoilleach, AE 1). They held the Crossing to be the price of a prayer grown slack. When no ship came from an Tìr Thall<sup>43</sup> after the Severance, and the council's ship found only open water, they said the lord of the sea had shut the sea again (11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3).

**Rites and sayings.** Oaths of trade were first sworn on a scorpion's sting kept in a box (19 an t-Samhain, FE 879). Since the sting-oath became a creed they have been sworn over a cup marked with the scorpion, Manannan's Cup of Truth. No boat of the faithful may go out of sight of the headlands, and on the west coast steering by the

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43. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

stars was lost entirely (27 an t-Samhain, LE 694). At the harbour mouth the priests pray (13 an Giblean, LE 1,590):

*A Mhanannain, cùm a' mhuir dùinte.* Manannan, keep the sea shut.

Since LE 1,714 that prayer has been said on the day of the empty-harbour rite. So on one quay, on one day, some mourn the departed and some pray that no one follows them. Neither side is pleased.

**Holy places.** Seann Skell in the west (Seann Skell), where the teaching was declared; Baile àrsaidh, where the sting-oath began; and Seann Vell, which has the first scorpion carved in yellow stone for worship (4 an t-Samhain, FE 2,849).

**History.** The sting-oath went from Baile àrsaidh up the coast to Ros bheag (1 am Faoilleach, FE 2,145) and became a creed at Seann Skell. The order took its form when Mànas mac Ruairidh named its power Manannan mac Lir (1 an t-Sultain, LE 654). A worked timber longer than any tree on the island, held with nails no smith on Dia-thìr could place, came ashore at Ceann mhòr. It was carried to Seann Skell, shown to Manannan's priests, and burned (22 an Cèitean, LE 1,794). This was twenty-five years before the humans came. The first human fishing families on the north-west coast learned the order's harbour prayers at Ceann mhòr (14 am Màrt, AE 51), and its priests there say the Grey Night grew from them (section VII). In the Age of the Kingdom the house at Seann Bhral turned away the Tuathaich of the north who came for its feast of the sea, and the northerners made a feast of their own at Cnoc ghorm (2 an t-Sultain, SE 25, 11 an Gearran, SE 26); that quarrel is told with the Church. On the eve of the Long War Manannan's house at Seann Skell refused to bless the enforcers' depot (23 am Faoilleach, DE 19). In the present year its priests said the prayer to keep the sea shut on the day the first dubhan was shipped off the island under Dubhan's charter (7 an t-Sultain, DE 27).

**Where it is held now.** 35 towns, all Dia-thìrich, on the west coast. Its seat, the western Seann Skell, is the largest town on Dia-thìr. It stands first in eight shires in the west, from Muileann naomh and Baile fhiadhaich south through Seann Skell, Ros bheag and Baile àrsaidh to Cuan shean and the Stone's holy shire of Inis thais, with Seann Warr inland. It also has more than a third of Cnoc bheag and Cathair dhomhain in the middle of the island and a quarter of Caol leathan. The map marks eleven of its houses as temples; besides the holy places above they include Ros bheag and the western Seann Bhral. After Seann Skell its largest towns are Cuan shean and Baile fhiadhaich.

## VI. Na Seann Spioradan

**What it holds.** The Old Spirits keep the reverence of the hearths as it was before the Hall: "reverence for the ancestors, for the vein, for the weather that rules the mining season" (17 an Faoilleach, FE 21). The chronicle calls it the oldest custom on the island that has never been broken. It has no priests, no order of worship and no council. Its powers, as the map gives them, are na Sithichean, the people of the mounds, and its tellings speak of the ancestors, the sith of the hills and mounds, and the spirits of weather, wells and streams, not of any one power over them. The Telling of the Making says that Caoran gave a spirit to every spring and hill when the island was born; the hearths of the Old Spirits do not deny it, and do not name him at their rites. The gods belong to the Old Faith. When the hearths first gave the powers of the mounds that name, or who first gave it, is not known.

**Rites and sayings.** The living heads of families name their ancestors aloud. The names of the dead are cut on wooden posts, which are recut each generation as the old ones rot (7 an Dàmhair, LE 179). The faith keeps the walk to Allt an Àigh<sup>44</sup> as its own, and after the Keepers declined the stream it took Muireach Liath's ruling for its saying:

*Buinidh an t-allt do na sinnsearan agus don t-side.* The stream belongs to the ancestors and to the weather.

The old night-count is kept at its hearths: a journey, a mourning or a guest's stay is reckoned in nights, and the dead are waked for three nights (Appendix D). It blesses what comes from the vein, and nothing else. When copper was found behind Àth fhiadhaich, the town's Seann Spioradan house held no blessing for it (28 an Lùnastal, SE 60).

**Holy places.** Dùn ìseal and its spirit-house; Seann Dunn, where the east-coast houses built a common hall for naming the ancestors of forty families (28 an Dàmhair, SE 22); Allt an Àigh, which lies in the schools' country behind Caol shean, with the walkers' hall at Achadh gharbh, a school village (11 an Gearran, SE 11); and Làrach an Teampaill<sup>45</sup>, which at the houses' request was entered by the Library as "measured and let be" (7 an Dàmhair, SE 31).

**History.** By the end of the Holy Age the Hall's list counted the old folk as "a company of its own" (16 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,926). In the Age of Sundering they built a guest-house at the stream, and its book records pilgrims from every shire (10 an t-Samhain, LE 1,259). Under the humans this was the first faith to refuse the Company's coal

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<sup>44</sup>. the stream of the healing water

<sup>45</sup>. the temple ruin

on grounds of belief. The households of Achadh naomh burned peat, and their elders taught "that coal burned for wages is burned without the ancestors' leave" (16 am Màrt, AE 23). In the Long Drought the Administration's watchman at Allt an Àigh, posted to charge pilgrims for the water, was recalled after one season (1 an Cèitean, AE 108). In the Age of the Kingdom the custodians of Òrd Bhrìde<sup>46</sup> discouraged the walk and did not forbid it (8 an t-Iuchar, SE 10).

**Where it is held now.** 126 towns, all Dia-thìrich, and more land than any single order of the Old Faith. It holds thirty-four shires: the whole south-east, from Seann Bhràl and Achadh mhòr to Baile ghorm and Ceann mhin; the east coast from Ceann leathan north through Seann Tarr and Achadh shean to Baile ruadh; the hills round Dùn ìseal, where the schools hold nearly as much (Dùn ìseal, Cnoc dhubh, Cnoc dhìreach); and a band of the north coast between the Hawk and the schools, from Baile Mòr mhòr and Seann Bhrenn to Seann Toll and Caol ìseal. It has a share of eleven more, among them Muileann bheag, which it divides almost evenly with the schools. The largest are Seann Bhràl, Achadh mhòr, Baile Mòr mhòr, Muileann bhàn, Achadh naomh and Dùn dhearg. The map marks temples in twenty-four of its towns, more than for any single order. The chief are Dùn ìseal, Seann Dunn, Seann Tarr, whose shrine draws the whole north-east at the great feasts, and Cathair naomh, whose elders the shrine-keepers of the north answer to. The rest are the shrines of wells, springs, fords and holy woods, and the houses of the largest towns.

## VII. An Eaglais

**What it holds.** The Church is the faith the humans brought over the sea at the Crossing (5 am Faoilleach, AE 1). It holds that there is one God, *Dia*, and that Crìosd<sup>47</sup>, Christ, is his son. Its book is *am Bioball*<sup>48</sup>, the Bible. Its clergy are *sagairt* and *ministearan*, priests and ministers, under *easbaigean*, bishops; it has had *manaich*, monks, and it keeps the days of its *naoimh*, its saints. On Dia-thìr it is the faith of the human labourers and the Residency in the Age of Strangers, and of the Tuathaich, their descendants, since. It brought the week with it, and keeps it: its day of rest is Didòmhnaich, the Lord's day, and its fasts from meat are on Diciadain and Dihaoine, which take their names from them. Its feasts fall on their days in the civil calendar, and it has never kept the moon (Appendix D).

**The Mission.** The Church came to the Dia-thìrich as the Mission. It raised a timber chapel on the quay at Ros dhomhain, the first church on the island (30 an Dùbhe-

<sup>46</sup>. the order of Brìde's flame

<sup>47</sup>. Christ

lachd, AE 13), and ran a school there that taught Dia-thìreach children in the humans' tongue (9 an Cèitean, AE 51). Samuel Wren made his grammar of Dia-thìris for its use (21 an Lùnastal, AE 12), and the hawk-priests of Cnoc bheag asked it for a copy (4 an t-Iuchar, AE 13). The Mission kept lists of the dead in the camps, and the custodians wrote their own count in its margins (11 an Dàmhair, AE 39). Samuel Wren asked the masters of the schools why the vein should be holy, and they asked him why his fuel should be burned (3 an Dùbhlachd, AE 18). The Mission's house in the north was at Cathair gheal.

**The churches of the north.** Most Tuathaich towns keep the Church their forebears brought at the Crossing, in the line the Mission left, while the Dia-thìrich of the west coast beside them keep Manannan's order (30 am Màrt, SE 9). How the churches of the Mission's line came to outnumber the older congregations of the north coast is not told. Their largest house is at Cnoc ghorm. It opened a school for its priests that taught in the humans' tongue and read the Bible in the Dia-thìris text its preachers use on the west coast; it is the only place in the north where both are taught (29 an Giblean, SE 10). In the early Age of the Kingdom the northerners came south to the feast of the sea at Seann Bhral, as their forebears had learned to from the Dia-thìrich harbours. The house of Manannan's order there turned them away, and its keeper said "the sea is the same and the house is not" (2 an t-Sultain, SE 25). They kept the feast at the church at Cnoc ghorm instead, as a blessing of the boats, and within a generation it was the larger of the two (11 an Gearran, SE 26).

These churches hold 51 towns. They hold seven shires: in the north-west Cnoc ghorm, Ceann mhòr, Cnoc thais, Muileann àrsaidh and Baile iséal, and on the north coast Caol mhòr and Àth àrsaidh. The map marks eight of their houses as temples, among them Cnoc ghorm and Cathair gheal. Their largest towns are Caol mhòr, the Moot's town, Ceann mhòr and Cnoc ghorm.

**Eaglais nan Tuathach<sup>48</sup> and the voyage of Naomh Breandan.** The old congregations of the north coast keep the Church in their own way (13 an Gearran, SE 9), and among their ways, quietly kept, is the telling of the First Canoe, the voyage of Naomh Breandan to the Isle of the Blessed, which the Dia-thìrich priests still call superstition. Beyond this almost nothing is known of them, and what is known comes from outside. Few Tuathaich would speak to the chronicle clerks (25 am Màrt, SE 19); the north's books stayed in private keeping (3 an Lùnastal, SE 67); and the request that Tuathaich memory be kept in the Library was laid on the table, neither granted nor refused, and it lies there still (15 an Gearran, DE 17). Their rites and their sayings are not known here, nor how far they differ from the churches of the Mission's line. Of their

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48. the Bible

49. the Tuathaich Church; the old congregations of the north coast

holy places three are known, the houses the map marks as temples: Doire ghlas, called the heart of the Church in the north, whose keepers are said to hold the First Canoe fragment and have not let the Library copy it; Muileann leathan; and Cill chaol, a Dia-thìrich chapel village whose chapel the Tuathaich made a church, leaving the old carvings on its doorposts beside their own.

The only one of their tellings known outside the north is the fragment its tellers set in the Ancient Age: "a steersman with a name, and a first crossing" (9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833). The steersman is Naomh Breandan, Saint Brendan the Navigator of the humans' Church, who sailed west from an Tìr Thall<sup>50</sup> in a boat of hides to the Isle of the Blessed, and the north's tellers say that isle was Dia-thìr. His name is in no Dia-thìrich record. In his voyage there is a mist on the sea and an island of the blessed in the west, as there is in the Dia-thìrich tellings of Manannan's sea; the Library notes the likeness and draws nothing from it. How families whose forebears came over the water in AE 1 came to keep the telling of a crossing set so long before the Sundering, no one has explained. It is left here where its tellers set it; the north keeps it still in the present day (21 an Dùbhlachd, DE 27).

The old congregations hold twelve towns, all Tuathaich, along the north. They hold three shires, Doire ghlas, Muileann leathan and the island shire of Eilean dhìreach off the coast to the west of them, and have a share of six more, among them the land west of Baile chrom on the north-western cape, a quarter of Àth àrsaidh and a sixth of Inis mhin and Caol mhòr. The largest are Doire ghlas, Muileann leathan, Inis mhin and Baile ghlas in Siorrachd Àth àrsaidh (Baile ghlas).

**Rùn-dìomhair na h-Oidhche Glaise**<sup>51</sup>. Of the Mystery of the Grey Night four things are known: its name, its goose, one custom and one town. The goose is Sìne, an Gèadh Sìtheil<sup>52</sup>, the Peaceful Goose, the keepers' name for an Gèadh Fiadhaich<sup>53</sup>, the wild goose of the Holy Spirit. The custom is "one night of silence in the year", a vigil, and outsiders are not told which night it is (14 am Màrt, SE 9). No saying is known.

The vigil first appears in a Mission report that human labourers near Baile chrom were keeping a vigil at night in the fields, praying in silence under the sign of a grey goose, which they called the wild goose of the Spirit (28 an Lùnastal, AE 133). The Mission called it irregular, a superstition learned from the Dia-thìrich, and the Dia-thìrich of Baile chrom disowned it. Manannan's priests at Ceann mhòr said the Mission was half right. The first human fishing families on that coast had settled at Ceann mhòr (14 am Màrt, AE 51) and learned Manannan's night prayer to keep the sea shut there, and

50. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

51. the Mystery of the Grey Night

52. the Peaceful Goose (Sìne)

53. the wild goose of the Holy Spirit

the labourers inland kept it as a Christian vigil, a night of silence under the wild goose of the Spirit instead of a prayer to Manannan. The priests called it Manannan's prayer gone astray and would not have its keepers in their house (21 an Dàmhair, AE 133). The Church's bishops call the vigil irregular and have not put it down. From the Ancient Age there is a telling of the grey geese that winter on Eilean ghorm and are never hunted there (3 an Lùnastal, VE 3,821); no one has shown that the two are joined, and it is not claimed here. After the Severance the vigil-keeper Hannah Crane held the vigil openly (14 an Màrt, SE 9). A magistrate fined her, and the vigil moved indoors (15 an t-Ògmhios, SE 27). The keeper of Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>54</sup> reported that the vigil was kept in the lighthouse's shadow (27 an Giblean, SE 32). In the Long War soldiers searched the town on a night when it lay wholly dark and silent, and found nothing (9 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21).

The vigil holds one town, Baile chrom in the far north-west (Baile chrom), and with it the whole of its shire (Baile chrom) and a tenth of Ceann mhòr next door. It is not the Baile chrom in the hills (Baile chrom), and the rolls take care to keep the two apart (11 an Gearran, AE 74).

**Where the Church is held now.** 64 towns, every Tuathaich town on the map, and eleven shires, all in the north and north-west. It has a share of five more: a quarter of Seann Skell and of Seann Vell, a sixth of Inis mhin, and smaller parts of Baile fhiadhaich and Muileann naomh. The map marks twelve of its churches as temples.

## VIII. Of the Coal Rite

The Rite is older than any name it has borne. Its root is the slab over the crack and the handful in the cup. What the chronicle calls the Coal Rite, and the Old Faith calls Òrd Bhride<sup>55</sup>, is the part of the old reverence that holds the vein itself to be sacred. The vein is Crom's, and Bride's flame is lit from what it gives; yet the Rite does not hold it to be the token of a god or the dwelling of a spirit. It is itself the holy thing.

**The vein as sacred.** The Rite holds that the vein bleeds because it is alive, in some fashion the Dia-thìrich are not asked to understand. What is broken from it must be burned in measure or returned. The vein answers a line of people, and that answering is itself holy. The doctrine of SE 6 is "built upon the leyline and the unbroken line of the coal-touched" (18 an Giblean, SE 6): the vein under the ground and the blood of those it has answered. Fionnghal nic Artair's defence of the Small-Burning Law, the only one that survives, argued that "the Law was never for the coal's sake but for the

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<sup>54</sup> the lighthouse at Baile chrom

<sup>55</sup> the order of Bride's flame

people, who would become whatever the burning made them" (11 an t-Ògmhios, AE 22). She wrote it two generations before Aisling was born, and it has been read as prophecy since; she made no such claim herself. Since the copyists found Aisling's line (21 an Dàmhair, AE 126), some of the Rite have read "the unbroken line" as the line that runs from the first king to her; the doctrine does not say which line it means.

**Under the Keepers.** In the Holy Age the Rite belonged to the Hall. The Keepers held the cup, took the census of hands (22 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,735) and sentenced households that burned beyond the measure (1 an Cèitean, FE 145). Their roll holds one hundred and forty names (2 an Giblean, FE 2,939).

**Under the vein-house.** Each ship of the Sundering carried one sealed measure of coal and no more (17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 25). The vein-house above Muileann dhearg kept the custody-book, and in LE 859 the crown and the custody were joined. The Rite's worst hour in that age came in war. Ragnall Ruadh, holding the vein-house, refused the handful to every hearth in the shires that stood against him, "and this deed turns more against him than any battle" (24 am Faoilleach, LE 558). The council refused the Fed Hawk's petition, and refused Clann Choinnich leave to smelt silver with the coal (31 an Lùnastal, LE 1,559), which was the first time any asked to burn the coal for work and not for worship.

**Under the humans.** The Small-Burning Law was never repealed; it lapsed when it no longer paid anyone to enforce it (2 an Dùbhlachd, AE 21). The Rite lived on in shrines at the pit mouths. At Cill dhìreach the crews left the first piece of coal from each new gallery, and the Company allowed it, "for it costs a stone a gallery" (19 an t-Sultain, AE 72). At Cill ghlas the custodians kept the rites at the mouth of the oldest cutting (18 an Dàmhair, AE 72). They agreed the word *fuil-ghuail*<sup>56</sup> there (21 an Gearran, AE 126), and the Rending swallowed that shrine (3 an t-Iuchar, AE 137).

**The Rite set in order.** The Rite was given its settled form on 18 an Giblean, SE 6. Dòmhnall mac Thormoid was seated at the southern Seann Skell as Àrd-choimheadaiche<sup>57</sup>, and his first charge was a written order of worship: "there had never been one" (17 an Cèitean, SE 6). The Hawk refused the order and the Stone stood aside. When the council kept the night shift, the custodians "enter a protest, and then bless the shafts" (18 an t-Samhain, SE 11). So the Rite has done ever since: it protests at the kingdom's use of the vein, and then it blesses it.

**The Depletion.** The high custodian ruled that dubhan was "not forbidden, since it is not coal, and not blessed, since it is not coal" (25 an t-Samhain, DE 4). When the beacons were converted (22 an Cèitean, DE 6), the coal flame of Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>58</sup> was carried to Seann Skell and left to burn out on the altar (19 an t-Iuchar, DE

56. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

57. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'



6). When the coinage seal lost its coal ink, the high custodian protested. The council replied that the kingdom had never said it held the vein sacred (31 an t-Iuchar, DE 15).

**The Rite now.** One face of the Sloc Mòr is kept open under the Rite's custody (17 an Cèitean, DE 26). Twelve hewers work it, the last of their trade (15 an t-Ògmhios, DE 26). On 6 an Dàmhair, DE 27, they cut the year's altar-coal. It filled four baskets, and the high custodian divided it among the houses by lot.

That is why Òrd Bhrìde holds only nine towns. Most Dia-thìrich who hold the vein sacred keep it at the hearth, as the Old Spirits do, or at the local altar, as the Hawk does. In name the Rite is the right faith of them all; in only nine towns is it the whole of their practice. It was set in order after the vein had begun to fail. In less than a century it went from an order of worship for the whole island to four baskets of coal.

## IX. Of the Schools' Question

*Carson an làmh seo?*

The druid schools began with one question, asked at Muileann chiar in the Holy Age: why does the vein answer some hands and not others (10 an Dàmhair, FE 103)? Some have made much of the nearness of *feidh*, deer, to *feith*, vein. The schools' own writings make nothing of it.

**Forbidden and allowed.** The Hall shut the galleries to the stag's people, "holding that a question asked of the vein is a demand made of it" (18 an Cèitean, FE 125). They were later let back in on an oath "to ask nothing of the vein aloud" (26 an Gearran, FE 574). The Hall called it a reconciliation, and the schools a truce. Long after, the stag's people made the first Dia-thìrich letters out of the cutters' tally-notches (15 am Màrt, FE 914), the letters the schools call ogham, and nearly every later hand on the island descends from them.

**Birth or effort.** Apprentices kept strike-books, written accounts of every blow (23 am Màrt, FE 1,641). Reading them, Donnchadh mac Iain found that the coal bled brighter for older cutters, whatever house they came from (28 an Gearran, FE 2,290). There followed a parting of the schools. A school broke away holding that the vein answers to effort and not to birth (7 an t-Sultain, FE 2,317); and over that same question, in another shape and many centuries later, the Long War was fought. The breakaway school at Muileann chaol did not write a cutter's parentage in the book at all (9 an Lùnastal, FE 2,330). The Keeper Raonaid Dhubh heard both schools and gave no ruling, "saying that the vein has not asked the Hall to decide" (4 an t-Samhain, FE 2,366).

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58. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

**The years of disputation.** At Dùn thais the question was argued by rule (29 an Cèitean, LE 314). Eilidh Dhubh's tracts for the effort-school were read aloud at harvest gatherings across the north-east (23 an t-Ògmhios, LE 484). Then Raghnaill mac Chaluim showed that the heads of the custodian houses lived a few years longer than their tenants, and asked whether the vein answers the hand that holds it (29 an t-Samhain, LE 1,209). For that the house was shut, and when it was opened again it was only on condition that the question of longer lives was not raised (20 an Giblean, LE 1,759). His table was made nearly seven hundred years before the first of the immortal generation was born.

**Under the humans.** Samuel Wren asked the masters why the vein should be holy, and they asked him why his fuel should be burned (3 an Dùbhlachd, AE 18). Aonghas mac Coinnich asked why the humans cannot see the colour in broken coal, and said it was the wrong question (19 an t-Ògmhios, AE 49). Tolley closed the hall at Dùn thais (14 an Dùbhlachd, AE 89). The last public disputation asked whether a question may be forbidden, and the Administration's clerk recorded that it may (30 an Giblean, AE 90). After that the masters taught under the trees (15 an t-Ògmhios, AE 90), until the last of them died in AE 123.

**The revival.** The schools reopened in SE 46, when the vein itself began to run short and their question was all at once pressing again. Seonaid nic Ghill-Eathain lectured in the sacred wood (11 an Dùbhlachd, SE 46), and the schools took a house at Caol shean, where students debated the census note on the coal-touched openly (5 an Dùbhlachd, SE 47). When the Mine Board searched for a second vein, she wrote that "no one has asked why there is one vein" (13 an Giblean, SE 51). The Board filed her letter, and the search found nothing (21 an Giblean, SE 51). The schools' own word for their revival is *dubhan-tùsail* (22 an Dàmhair, DE 11).

**What the question has come to.** In the Holy Age it asked whether the coal bled for birth or for practice. In the Age of Sundering it asked whether the vein lengthened lives. Under the humans it asked why the humans could not see the colour. Since AE 126, when the custodians agreed a plain word for what the vein had begun to do to a few children, the answer has had a name but no reason. The masters do not say that their question brought on the Long War, and no one has laid it to their charge. They say only that it was asked in the Holy Age, and has not been answered.

## APPENDIX C

# Hosts, Wars and Calamities

Here are gathered out of the annals every war and armed struggle of which they tell, the hosts that stand on the map today, and the calamities that have fallen on the island, whether they came from the sea, the ground, the weather or the vein. Nothing is added that the annals do not hold. Where the annals disagree, the entries are given as they stand; where the record is sealed, or was never made, that is said, and no more.

Much is missing, and the reader should know how much. The Age of Ailean cut its dead on tally stones and did not say what killed them. The Age of Sundering left two histories of its wars, and one was written to praise a king. For the Age of Strangers the custodians' rolls, the Mission's lists and the Residency's letter-books seldom agree in their numbers. The complete record of the Long War is sealed at Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>1</sup> until the fifty years run out (14 am Faoilleach, DE 24).

## Part I. The Wars

### Before the wars

The oldest deed of force that is remembered was no war, and who did it is not known. On 29 an Dàmhair, VE 3,973, the single gate of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>2</sup> was blocked with rubble from the inside, by people who left by another way or did not leave. More than a century later the cistern of Làrach an Dùin<sup>3</sup>, which had served four hundred people, was found choked with the bones of whole cattle (4 an Giblean, VE 4,074). Both were works of the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>4</sup>. What was fought over there, and by whom, no chronicler has ventured to guess.

The first war in either of the oral king-lists is **the salt-flats raid**. On 9 am Faoilleach, GE 672, Mòrag Chruaidh, fifth of the Stone Kings, led the hill-folk down

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1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. the watch-fort ruin

3. the fortress ruin

4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

to the salt-pans at Baile ghorm and carried the salt away. Seven of the hill side died, and the telling keeps the number. Her successor Iain Dubh went down to repeat the raid and was killed on the shingle (8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727). The list says only that he was brought home. Of the other wars the king rode to over the island, the lists keep no count, only that he came home from all of them but the last.

**Blàr Àth na Fala**<sup>5</sup>, the Battle of the Ford of Blood, closed the Age of Ailean and opened the Holy Age. The households of Dùn dhearg and the east, who had sworn to owe nothing to Dùn ìseal or its king, came against Ailean Mòr at the ford below Dùn dhearg, and he held it alone three days and three nights, until the dead of the host dammed the river. He fell on the third night, on 2 an t-Sultain, FE 1, worn down by the whole host; no one man overcame him. His kin, camped about Dùn ìseal and quarrelling over the shares they looked to have of him, did not come. One son, Ìomhar Dearg, came late, on the morning after, and fell on the spent host and took Dùn dhearg; and so the first share of the kingdom was won with a sword before any share was given.

## Aimhreit nan Oighrean, the strife of the heirs

*Cause.* At the king's death some seven hundred heirs of his blood stood up to claim at Dùn ìseal (13 an Dàmhair, FE 1). They bound the vein in common and gave it to no one of the blood (23 an t-Sultain, FE 1), and parted the rest of the kingdom by *Roinn na Rìoghachd*<sup>6</sup> (1 an t-Samhain, FE 2): nine great shares for the nine eldest lines, a portion of the dead out of all nine for the lines of the king's dead children, and the Red Share of Ìomhar Dearg at Dùn dhearg let stand as he had taken it. Every share was parted again into countries, provinces, counties and holdings, and many holdings owed oaths to two lords, some to three (25 am Màrt, FE 4). At every death of a holder the share was parted again. No part of the settlement was ever wholly agreed, and every part of it was a cause.

*Sides.* First the line of Murchadh Mòr, who held the great share of the north, against the line of Ìomhar Dearg; afterward nearly every line of the king's blood against some other, and the lines changed sides by marriage. The Hall at Dùn ìseal took no side in any of it, and its ground was the one place no feud could follow a man.

*Course.* The first blood was shed at Dùn thais, on the line between the north and the Red Share, when the men of two great-grandsons of the king met over a boundary stone and Aonghas Bàn mac Mhurchaidh was killed (17 an Giblean, FE 3). The strife ran after that for some five hundred and fifty years, in raids, burnings and killings

5. the Battle of the Ford of Blood

6. the Division; lit. 'the parting of the kingdom'

between kin, few of them large and none of them forgotten, for the men who began a feud might live a thousand years to remember it. Ìomhar Dearg himself was killed by a cousin at a ford in the Hall's second century. The waypoint houses made the road-peace against it (22 an Dàmhair, FE 175). The last and worst of it was **Cogadh an Dà Mhionn**<sup>7</sup>, the War of the Two Oaths, which began when a marriage between Eithne nic Ailein's line at Cathair mhòr and the line of Ìomhar failed, and each side called on every holding sworn to both to fight for it. It went on in fits for some forty years. It ended at Achadh mhòr, where Fearghas Dà-Mhionn, lord of the granary fields and sworn to both sides, burned his own harvest rather than feed either host, and died in his hall (24 an Lùnastal, FE 556). The middle of the island went hungry that winter.

*End.* The lords of the shares swore *Sìth an Stairsnich*<sup>8</sup>, the Peace of the Threshold, on the threshold of Talla na Lasrach<sup>9</sup> at Dùn ìseal, beside the stone cup, with the Keeper for witness (1 an t-Samhain, FE 556). No share was to be parted again at a death, no one was to swear to two lords, and the boundary stones were to stand where they stood. Eithne nic Ailein, last living of the nine who had taken the great shares, swore first. After the Peace the shares began to gather again, and the first to gather them was Goraidh mac Ìomhair (3 an Giblean, FE 674), who became the first rìgh after Ailean (28 an Cèitean, FE 674).

## The War of the Roads

*Cause.* In the Holy Age the carriers' road ran from the mountain to the sea, and its tolls went to the rìgh of Dùn dhearg. Lachlann Ciar, head of the leading family of the harbour town of Caol leathan, began to keep the southern tolls for himself and send none of them to Dùn dhearg (14 an Gearran, FE 991). Iain Garbh, son of Sìleas Dhonn, took the hall at Dùn dhearg and demanded the western tolls, and Lachlann Ciar sent him back a basket of fish-bones (12 an Cèitean, FE 994).

*Sides.* On the one side stood Iain Garbh of Dùn dhearg, with the road-guards and the lowland levies; on the other Lachlann Ciar and the men of Caol leathan. The Hall at Dùn ìseal refused to bless either side.

*Course.* On 13 an Giblean, FE 999, Iain Garbh marched west and burned the toll-house at Muileann òg, which Lachlann Ciar's people had taken. The annals call this the first war on the island since the Peace of the Threshold, and the first fought over a road; every war since the Roinn had been fought over a share. At the ford of Àth fhi-

7. the War of the Two Oaths

8. the Peace of the Threshold

9. the Hall of the Flame

adhaich the men of Caol leathan held Iain Garbh's levies for a day before they gave way (21 an Dàmhair, FE 1,001). Forty lay dead of the two sides together, and long afterward the carriers called it the ford of the forty. Falling back, Lachlann Ciar's men burned Baile ghlas so that the levies would find no grain there (16 am Faoilleach, FE 1,002). Its people walked to Cathair dhomhain, and many never came home. Baile chlar shut its gate against both armies and fed the burned-out people of Baile ghlas through the winter (18 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,003). Neither side forgave it, and neither attacked it. Iain Garbh then closed Caol leathan from the landward side for a season, but its boats brought in fish and he could not close the harbour. His levies drifted home for the harvest, and the siege ended without an assault (2 an t-Samhain, FE 1,005).

*End.* The two leaders met under the roof of the waypoint house that would later be called Am Buabhall Fortanach, where by the road-peace neither of them could draw (4 an Dàmhair, FE 1,006). Caol leathan kept half its tolls and sent the other half to Dùn dhearg, and Lachlann Ciar swore to the Law with the Keeper as witness. So the war ended in a house built to feed carriers. Muileann òg was rebuilt as a market town, and from its fair came Fèill Muileann òg<sup>10</sup> (5 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,665).

## Lesser strife of the Holy Age

The **Silver Feud** (17 an t-Sultain, FE 1,746) was a closing of the roads, and no war. For three seasons no silver left Muileann chlar. The road-guards went unpaid and the eastern tolls went uncollected. It has always been called a feud, though no one was killed in it. At sea, outlaw boats from the eastern islets began raiding the fishing strands. Sliochd Raghnaill<sup>11</sup> armed its boats at Seann Tarr and burned two of them (10 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,455), and the rest were never caught. Late in the age raiders from the north-western waters took a season's dried fish from the north-western strands. The sting-sworn merchants of Ros bheag paid for two armed boats to watch the shore, and the raiders moved north (28 an Gearran, FE 2,747).

## The War of the Three Claimants

*Cause.* King Tormod Bàn's two sons were drowned together when a ferry overturned on Abhainn fhionn (18 an t-Ògmhios, LE 534). The king died at Cathair dhearg without naming an heir (8 an t-Sultain, LE 547), and three claims were laid before the houses at once.

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10. the fair at Muileann òg

11. the house of Raghnaill

*Sides.* The claimants were Catriona nic Aonghais of Inis thais, the late king's niece; Dùghall Garbh of Baile Mòr dhomhain, his half-brother; and Ragnall Ruadh, head of Clann Raghnaill and master of the vein-house above Muileann dhearg (21 an Giblean, LE 552). The seven houses divided among the three. Seann Warr, the western port nearest the capital, shut its gates to all three and declared for none (20 an Cèitean, LE 553). It was twice besieged in the war, and taken by neither claimant.

*Course.* Dùghall's host broke Ragnall's at the ford of Àth shean on 22 an Gearran, LE 554. The custody-book counts some three hundred dead, the most of them drowned in the ford. Ragnall's men burned Doire mhin and its granary as they fell back (24 an t-Sultain, LE 555), and the villagers spent the winter at Cathair mhòr on the charity of Macha's priests. Catriona besieged Cathair dhomhain, which had declared for Dùghall, and took it after forty days, when the dead of the siege lines had poisoned its wells (26 an Dùbhlachd, LE 557). She let the garrison go free on their oath. Ragnall, who held the vein-house, then refused the measured handful of coal to every hearth and temple in the shires that stood against him (24 am Faoilleach, LE 558). Hearths that had burned coal for generations went cold. By the judgement of the annals this deed turned more against him than any battle did. Catriona and Dùghall joined their hosts against him and met Ragnall below Muileann chrom on 14 am Faoilleach, LE 560. Ragnall was killed on the field, and his own custodians opened the vein-house the next day.

*End.* Catriona was crowned at Cathair dhearg on 13 am Màrt, LE 562 and was known afterward as Catriona Bhuadhach. The war had lasted some ten years. Her first great law bound the custodians themselves: no claimant, house or king could withhold the handful from a lawful hearth (12 an Gearran, LE 565). Seann Warr's neutral gates were later honoured by the crown (11 an Giblean, LE 594). Seònaid nic Coinnich's *Book of the Three Claimants* (8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 624) is the oldest history on Dia-thìr told as a single tale, and not as a list of entries.

## The sea-thieves of the north-west

Boats working out of the small islands off the north-west coast began to take fish and grain from coasting traders (24 am Faoilleach, LE 784). The thieves were Dia-thìrich, men of the north-west shore, and the harbour rolls give some of their names. A force sent by Queen Eilidh Bhàn landed on Eilean dhubh and burned their boats on the strand (27 an t-Samhain, LE 801). Their leader, Uilleam Ruadh, was taken to Cathair dhearg and hanged.

## The Brothers' War, Cogadh nam Bràithrean

*Cause.* King Ailean mac Raghnaill died at Cathair dhearg leaving two sons by different mothers, Iain Ciar and Alasdair Bànn, and each of them had been told that he was the heir (7 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,266).

*Sides.* The seven houses divided four to three between the brothers.

*Course.* Alasdair Bànn's men seized Cnoc naomh, and Iain Ciar took it back on 8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,270. The war is named from that battle. Alasdair's ships burned the waterfront of Ceann mhin, which held for his brother; the fire took the rope stores and the granary, and the town had to beg its bread from Cathair mhòr (17 an Lùnastal, LE 1,272). Iain Ciar defeated Alasdair below Muileann ghlas on 19 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,274. Alasdair was taken alive, and his captains were allowed to go home.

*End.* The brothers made peace at An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, on neutral ground between their lands (12 an t-Sultain, LE 1,276). Alasdair gave up his claim and was given the lordship of Seann Chwen for life. Iain Ciar was crowned. Alasdair kept the peace until his death (8 an Dàmhair, LE 1,291), and his lordship went back to the crown. Iain Ciar, having seen Ceann mhin beg for bread, ordered every shire seat to keep a year's grain in store against the next war (20 an Giblean, LE 1,299). The only surviving account of the war was written by his clerk Pàdraig mac Ruairidh (14 an Lùnastal, LE 1,304). It praises the king at every turn, and later readers have found it a trial.

## The humans' campaigns and the forerunners of war

For the most part of the Age of Strangers the fighting was at sea. Raiders stripped a Company brig off the north-west coast (10 an Giblean, AE 16) and burned a coal ship off the east (20 an Dàmhair, AE 46). The Company's first armed reply was a gunboat that burned every boat on the shingle of a cove near Ceann leathan (25 an t-Iuchar, AE 47). Most of them belonged to the town's own fishermen, and the raiders were not found.

On land the Administration kept no standing force until Charles Merriman brought a company of armed constables (24 an Lùnastal, AE 132). They broke the dockers' strike at Ros dhomhain (1 an Giblean, AE 134). After the Rending the roll tells of the first bloodshed between the two peoples (17 an t-Ògmhios, AE 137), which its fuller entry sets at Muileann chrom (13 an Dùbhlachd, AE 137): a gallery drowned sev-



en when the pumps were stopped to save fuel, the crews stoned the Company's agent, and the constables fired. Four Dia-thìrich and one constable died. Merriman answered the second petition by tripling the constabulary and fortifying the stores of four mining towns (25 an Gearran, AE 140). The roadside houses became waypoints for a militia with no name (9 an t-Sultain, AE 141). The first stoppage held in concert across the pits was broken by the closing of the Company stores (30 an Dùbhlachd, AE 143). After the confiscation edict (25 an Giblean, AE 147) the silver guild began buying rifles from the eastern pirates (21 an t-Iuchar, AE 148), a council for the mining regions met in the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag (20 an Lùnastal, AE 148), and Strake ordered its arrest (3 am Faoilleach, AE 149).

## The War of the Hills

Here it is called the War of the Hills, after the country where it began. Later rolls call it the Severance war, after the manner of its ending.

*Cause.* On 20 an Gearran, AE 149, the Dia-thìrich of several mining regions rose together for the first time, and grievance became open war. The grievances are those told above, and the one most often named is the confiscation edict.

*Sides.* With the Dia-thìrich stood the council of custodians and crew-leaders under Eilidh nic Raghnaill, with the crews of the camps, the Lamp-Watch, the silver guild of Muileann chiar and its riflemen, the riflemen of Cnoc leathan (1 an Gearran, AE 150), the company of the Hawk order's faithful mustered at Seann Skell (8 an t-Ògmhios, AE 150), and the towns that declared for the council one after another. With the Administration stood Commissioner Strake, the constabulary, the Company's guards, and the Company's steamships and coasters. Some towns held aloof. The human town of Cathair gheal shut its gates and raised a militia that it sent to neither side (24 an Cèitean, AE 150). The concession town of Muileann àrsaidh closed its road against both sides for the rest of the war (28 an Cèitean, AE 150). Ros dhomhain, the Dia-thìrich city below the Residency, neither joined the rising nor stood against it until late in the war.

*Course.* The war opened in the hills. Crews under Mòrag nic Iain rushed the store at Muileann chrom at first light, and its eleven constables surrendered without a shot (28 an Gearran, AE 149). Crews sank two barges across the mouth of the coal quay at Ceann fhada (24 an Cèitean, AE 149). At Baile thais the constables held their walled pithead for eleven days and surrendered on the twelfth, when their water ran out, and Eilidh nic Raghnaill sent them to the coast unharmed (1 an t-Ògmhios, AE 149). The northern pits rose (30 an t-Ògmhios, AE 149), and An Taigh-seinnse Mòr shut its gates

across the coal road, which stayed cut (9 an Lùnastal, AE 149). The capital rose next and barricaded Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>12</sup> with coal-carts (18 an Lùnastal, AE 149), and Strake drew the Administration into the Residency above Ros dhomhain (27 an t-Samhain, AE 149).

The first relief column, under Major Peter Ashdown, was met at the ford of Àth chiar on 5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 149. Ashdown lost forty men and his baggage. The rebels lost nineteen, and the council's roll names every one. Dùn chrom shut its gates behind the retreating column and nursed the wounded it left (3 am Faoilleach, AE 150). In the east the silver town rose (15 am Faoilleach, AE 150), and the post at Dùn ìseal surrendered after one exchange of fire (17 am Faoilleach, AE 150).

The humans struck back from the sea. A Company steamship came up the Abhainn uaine and shelled the coal stage at Seann Toll and burned the town behind it, killing twenty-three (15 an Gearran, AE 150). On 10 an Cèitean, AE 150, fishing boats from Seann Chwen and Ros ruadh burned a Company coaster at anchor. The keepers of the southern beacons put out their fires, and two Company ships were lost on the reefs (9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 150).

Through the first winter neither side could come at the other (26 an t-Ògmhios, AE 150), and the capital went hungry (8 an t-Iuchar, AE 150). While the war stood still the rebels burned the tithe ledgers in three raids, at Ros dhomhain, Ceann àrsaidh and Muileann chrom (9 an t-Iuchar, AE 150). The Administration's last sally toward the mining country was driven back at Cnoc ghorm on 25 an Lùnastal, AE 150. The Ros dhomhain harbour quarter opened its gates to the council (4 an t-Sultain, AE 150), Strake left the Residency by water (21 an t-Sultain, AE 150), and Ros bheag became the last seat of the Administration (23 an t-Sultain, AE 150), where the human families went hungry within months (4 an Dàmhair, AE 150).

*End.* The last ship recorded from an Tìr Thall<sup>13</sup> came to Ros bheag with a sealed letter and left on the next tide (1 an t-Samhain, AE 150). Envoys met at Àth àrsaidh and agreed a truce (2 an t-Samhain, AE 150). The humans still on Dia-thìr would go into the north-west under the council's safe-conduct, and the council would leave the concession towns standing. The columns went north (29 an t-Samhain, AE 150) and camped a night at Àth leathan (1 an Dùbhlachd, AE 150), where several of the humans wrote down the name of the place. Strake sailed for an Tìr Thall in the last ship able to make the crossing (5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 150). On 1 am Faoilleach, AE 151, the war ended, and the crossing itself was closed. That is the Severance. The war-companies were stood down, but no act ever abolished them (3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 1).

12. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

13. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

## Raiders in the Age of the Kingdom

After the Severance, ships flying no flag, some crewed by men who had served the Administration, raided the coast off Cathair gheal (4 an t-Sultain, SE 12). The council sent no help. In the end the fishermen armed their own boats and drove the raiders off, and were fined for bearing arms without licence (8 an Giblean, SE 20). Not until the patrol boats were refitted for dubhan could they outrun the raiders (15 an t-Sultain, DE 13).

## An Cogadh Fada, the Long War

*Cause.* Some of the northern towns would not take the place made for them in the new trade (25 an Giblean, DE 16), and went on working the last coal seams sooner than hang on one man's fuel. When the Mine Board's northern revenue fell by a quarter (22 am Màrt, DE 18), it declared the western seams Crown property and ordered the pits closed. Enforcers were posted at Seann Skell (16 an Dàmhair, DE 18), the first armed company sent north since the Severance, and there followed skirmishes too small to name (29 an t-Sultain, DE 19). Ruth Calder's offer to pay the Crown's fifth in coal went unanswered (25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 19). The order to muster raised the regiments again (28 an Dàmhair, DE 20) under Somhairle mac Lachlainn (26 an t-Samhain, DE 20), and the Moot's last petition was filed (25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 20).

*Sides.* For the kingdom, in the reign of Cathal, were the Board's enforcers, the regiments raised again, and later the fleets, all running on dubhan. Against them were the holdouts of five western towns, Àth leathan, Muileann àrsaidh, Cnoc thais, Àth namh and Tobar dhearg, with Ruth Calder and Tom Varley named among them. The Moot stood apart and fed the hungry.

*Course.* Arms went west by the coal line (12 am Faoilleach, DE 21). The hewers gathered at Àth leathan (20 am Faoilleach, DE 21), and the regiments marched west (23 am Faoilleach, DE 21). The **Battle of Àth leathan**, fought on 11 an Giblean, DE 21, at Àraich Àth leathan<sup>14</sup>, was the first great battle of the war. The open record counts only the kingdom's dead. The Tuathaich tell of the holdouts' dead in the hundreds, and Ruth Calder's name is not found in the open record again (11 an Giblean, DE 21). The holdouts fell back into the hills (11 an Giblean, DE 21). The regiments besieged Muileann àrsaidh, which held for weeks on stored coal and potatoes (21 an Cèitean, DE 21). Cnoc thais was taken after its road was cut (2 an Lùnastal, DE 21), and Àth namh and Tobar dhearg opened their roads without a siege (17 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21).

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14. the battlefield of Àth leathan

In the autumn of the next year a column of several hundred holdouts came down out of the hills and went south-east toward the capital (29 an Dàmhair, DE 22). Why it went is written only in the sealed archive. The Tuathaich name its leader Owen Barrow; the open record names no one. It made camp by Muileann ghlas, a day's walk from the capital (6 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22), and the first and third regiments were brought down the fair road to meet it. The **Battle of Muileann ghlas**, fought on 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22, at Àraich Muileann ghlas<sup>15</sup>, was the second and last great battle of the war. The open record gives no count of the column's dead (10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22). It was the second battle fought below Muileann ghlas of which the annals tell; the first was fought there in the Brothers' War.

*End.* When word of the battle reached the hills, the last holdouts came down to the seventh regiment's posts and were disarmed and sent home (10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22). An Cogadh Fada<sup>16</sup> ended on 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22, and nine regiments and four fleets remained on their stations. By the Board's order the western seams were flooded and capped (24 an Gearran, DE 23). The wartime tithe (21 an Giblean, DE 21) was carried on in the Treasury's accounts, though no minute of the council shows that anyone decided to keep it (27 an Giblean, DE 24). Tuathaich families built a cairn on the field of Àth leathan (6 an Giblean, DE 24). The kingdom raised a stone with the regiments' dead at Cathair mhòr (15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23).

Table of battles

| BATTLE OR DEED OF ARMS   | DATE                          | PLACE       | WAR                   | OUTCOME, AND THE DEAD AS COUNTED                                                              |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Salt-flats raid          | 9 am<br>Faoilleach, GE<br>672 | Baile ghorm | Stone Kings           | Salt carried off; seven dead on the hill side                                                 |
| Death of Iain Dubh       | 8 an t-<br>Ògmhios, GE<br>727 | Baile ghorm | Stone Kings           | Iain Dubh, the king's son, killed on the shingle; the salt shore bends the knee the next year |
| Blàr Àth na Fala         | 2 an t-Sultain,<br>FE 1       | Dùn dhearg  | The king's last war   | Ailean Mòr holds the ford three days and falls; the dead of the host dam the river            |
| First blood at Dùn thais | 17 an Giblean,<br>FE 3        | Dùn thais   | Aimhreit nan Oighrean | Aonghas Bàn mac Mhurchaidh killed; the strife begins                                          |
| Burning of Achadh mhòr   | 24 an Lùnastal,<br>FE 556     | Achadh mhòr | War of the Two Oaths  | Fields fired by their lord; Fearghas Dà-Mhionn dead; the war ends                             |

15. the battlefield of Muileann ghlas

16. the Long War

| BATTLE OR DEED OF ARMS              | DATE                     | PLACE            | WAR                 | OUTCOME, AND THE DEAD AS COUNTED                |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------|------------------|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Fight at Àth fhiadhaich             | 21 an Dàmhair, FE 1,001  | Àth fhiadhaich   | War of the Roads    | Ford held a day, then lost; forty dead          |
| Siege of Caol leathan               | 2 an t-Samhain, FE 1,005 | Caol leathan     | War of the Roads    | Harbour not closed; ended without assault       |
| Ford at Àth shean                   | 22 an Gearran, LE 554    | Àth shean        | Three Claimants     | Raghnall's host broken; some three hundred dead |
| Siege of Cathair dhomhain           | 26 an Dùbhlachd, LE 557  | Cathair dhomhain | Three Claimants     | Taken after forty days; garrison freed on oath  |
| Battle of Muileann chrom            | 14 am Faoilleach, LE 560 | Muileann chrom   | Three Claimants     | Raghnall Ruadh killed; the war decided          |
| Raid on Eilean dhubh                | 27 an t-Samhain, LE 801  | Eilean dhubh     | Sea-thieves         | Boats burned; Uilleam Ruadh hanged              |
| Battle of Cnoc naomh                | 8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,270 | Cnoc naomh       | Brothers' War       | Iain Ciar retakes the town                      |
| Fire at Ceann mhin                  | 17 an Lùnastal, LE 1,272 | Ceann mhin       | Brothers' War       | Waterfront, rope stores and granary burned      |
| Battle of Muileann ghlas            | 19 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,274 | Muileann ghlas   | Brothers' War       | Alasdair Bàn taken alive                        |
| Cove burned                         | 25 an t-Iuchar, AE 47    | Ceann leathan    | Company and raiders | Fishermen's boats burned; raiders not found     |
| First bloodshed between the peoples | 17 an t-Ògmhios, AE 137  | Muileann chrom   | Forerunners         | Four Dia-thìrich and one constable killed       |
| Store at Muileann chrom             | 28 an Gearran, AE 149    | Muileann chrom   | War of the Hills    | Eleven constables surrender unharmed            |
| Siege of the store at Baile thais   | 1 an t-Ògmhios, AE 149   | Baile thais      | War of the Hills    | Surrender on the twelfth day                    |
| Ford of Àth chiar                   | 5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 149   | Àth chiar        | War of the Hills    | Ashdown turned back; forty and nineteen dead    |
| Surrender at Dùn ìseal              | 17 am Faoilleach, AE 150 | Dùn ìseal        | War of the Hills    | The east cleared of human arms                  |
| Shelling of Seann Toll              | 15 an Gearran, AE 150    | Seann Toll       | War of the Hills    | Twenty-three townsfolk dead                     |
| The fishermen of Seann Chwen        | 10 an Cèitean, AE 150    | Seann Chwen      | War of the Hills    | Company coaster burned                          |
| Fight at Cnoc ghorm                 | 25 an Lùnastal, AE 150   | Cnoc ghorm       | War of the Hills    | Last sally of the Administration repulsed       |

| BATTLE OR DEED OF ARMS    | DATE                   | PLACE                 | WAR            | OUTCOME, AND THE DEAD AS COUNTED                   |
|---------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------|----------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Battle of Àth leathan     | 11 an Giblean, DE 21   | Àraich Àth leathan    | An Cogadh Fada | Holdouts' dead in the hundreds (Tuathaich telling) |
| Siege of Muileann àrsaidh | 21 an Cèitean, DE 21   | Muileann àrsaidh      | An Cogadh Fada | Pit-heads taken one by one                         |
| Cnoc thais taken          | 2 an Lùnastal, DE 21   | Cnoc thais            | An Cogadh Fada | Shafts fired and sealed                            |
| Battle of Muileann ghlas  | 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22 | Àraich Muileann ghlas | An Cogadh Fada | Column broken; its dead not counted                |

## Part II. The Hosts

### The older hosts

Until the Long War the island kept no standing host. In the strife of the heirs the lords of the shares fought with their households and sworn men, seldom more than a few score to a side, and a holding sworn to two lords sent its spears to whichever called first. Later in the Holy Age the rìgh of Dùn dhearg fought with road-guards and with levies raised from the lowland farms, and those levies went home at harvest whether the war was done or not (2 an t-Samhain, FE 1,005). The claimants and the brothers of the Age of Sundering fought with the followings of the seven houses. The queen who burned the sea-thieves' boats sent a force raised for that errand alone (27 an t-Samhain, LE 801). In the Age of Strangers the only standing force on the island belonged to the humans: Merriman's constables and the Company's guards and gunboats. The Dia-thìrich fought the War of the Hills with companies raised by the council, the silver guild and the hawk-houses. Those companies were stood down in SE 1 and kept only as names on a roll. For ninety years the kingdom's regiments stood on paper alone, and its coast was guarded by patrol boats. The first armed company it sent north after the Severance was a company of Board enforcers (16 an Dàmhair, DE 18).

### The regiments and fleets

The thirteen hosts on the map were all raised in DE 21, the first year of An Cogadh Fada<sup>17</sup>, and none has been stood down (13 am Faoilleach, DE 23). Each takes its name

17. the Long War

from the town where it is stationed. The numbers do not follow the order of raising: the seventh regiment was raised first and the ninth last, and the fleets in the order first, fourth, second and third. Why they were so numbered is not told. The rolls of the Severance companies were read out when the regiments were raised again (26 an t-Samhain, DE 20), and the numbers may have come from those rolls; but the open record is silent. Two of the towns named Seann Skell have hosts. The seventh regiment stands at the western one. The ninth regiment and the second fleet stand at the one on the southern coast. The regimental clerks tell them apart by river and coast (25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21).

| HOST                                            | STATION      | RAISED                 | WHAT THE ANNALS RECORD OF IT                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------|--------------|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>An seachdamh rèisimeid</b> , the seventh     | Seann Skell  | 11 an Giblean, DE 21   | First raised, from the west-coast levies, on the day of Àth leathan. Held the road behind the army; the last holdouts came down to its posts (10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22); stood by at every capping of the western seams (24 an Gearran, DE 23). Keeps the Àth leathan post (28 an Dàmhair, DE 23) and leaves the Tuathaich cairn standing (6 an Giblean, DE 24). |
| <b>A' chiad rèisimeid</b> , the first           | Inis mhòr    | 7 an Cèitean, DE 21    | Raised from the capital's own companies to guard the council, the mint and the bridge over the Abhainn dhomhain. Fought at Muileann ghlas (10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22); escorted the prisoners north to the boundary stones (4 an t-Iuchar, DE 23); keeps the list of weapons turned up on the Muileann ghlas field (28 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23).                      |
| <b>A' chiad chabhlach</b> , the first fleet     | Àth gharbh   | 13 an Cèitean, DE 21   | Raised from the south-west harbours and sent round the western cape to stop coal leaving the Tuathaich ports by sea. Its hulls lie in the harbour of Doire shean, a short walk from the town.                                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>An ceathramh cabhlach</b> , the fourth fleet | Cuan shean   | 20 an Cèitean, DE 21   | With the first, closed Seann Skell and Cnoc bhàn to all but searched fishing boats. Still on the Tuathaich coast (29 an t-Sultain, DE 24); its log tells of a thing longer than a patrol boat off the north-west cape, and calls it a whale (23 an Giblean, DE 25).                                                                                            |
| <b>An treas rèisimeid</b> , the third           | Cathair mhòr | 5 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21  | First mustered under the Mac Ùisdein market cross, by the Mine Board's offices. Fought at Muileann ghlas. The stone of the regiments' dead stands in its town (15 an Dùbhlachd, DE 23).                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>An còigeamh rèisimeid</b> , the fifth        | Seann Warr   | 13 an t-Ògmhios, DE 21 | Sent north to relieve the regiments before Muileann àrsaidh. Built the first permanent barracks of any regiment (27 an Dàmhair, DE 25).                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>An dàrna cabhlach</b> , the second fleet     | Seann Skell  | 23 an t-Sultain, DE 21 | Kept the eastern and southern waters; ran a raider down off Baile ìseal in the war (2 an Dàmhair, DE 21) and the rest of them after it (2 an Lùnastal, DE 24).                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>An siathamh rèisimeid</b> , the sixth        | Cnoc bheag   | 17 an Dàmhair, DE 21   | Its colours blessed by the Hawk houses after their own order of worship. Holds the northern road; keeps the pass posts at the boundary stones (9 an Dàmhair, DE 26).                                                                                                                                                                                           |

| HOST                                        | STA-<br>TION | RAISED                 | WHAT THE ANNALS RECORD OF IT                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------|--------------|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>An dàrna rèisimeid</b> , the second      | Àth dhireach | 25 an Dàmhair, DE 21   | Guarded the coal line and the Library road, the first soldiery Muileann chaol had seen. Keeps a guard on the sealed archive, which the Library did not ask for (12 an Lùnastal, DE 26).                       |
| <b>An ceathramh rèisimeid</b> , the fourth  | Caol bheag   | 2 an t-Samhain, DE 21  | Shipped round the north coast in hired dubhan hulls and quartered in the magistrate's house at Ceann mhòr over the Moot's protest (10 an t-Samhain, DE 21). Went home to Caol bheag (22 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25). |
| <b>An t-ochdamh rèisimeid</b> , the eighth  | Inis uaine   | 16 an t-Samhain, DE 21 | Raised to guard the eastern dubhan depots against fire. The guard was made permanent, and the town's Seann Spioradan house prays for the regiment (14 an Dùbhlachd, DE 25).                                   |
| <b>An treas cabhlach</b> , the third fleet  | Baile ghorm  | 1 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21  | Carried the army's dubhan up the west coast in tank-hulls; still carries it to the Tuathaich depots, and the Moot pays the freight (28 an Dàmhair, DE 24).                                                    |
| <b>An naoid-heamh rèisimeid</b> , the ninth | Seann Skell  | 25 an Dùbhlachd, DE 21 | Last raised, to guard the dubhan works. Its fighter won the first Còmhrag the regiments entered (14 an t-Iuchar, DE 26).                                                                                      |

The regimental rolls of the present year count 5,577 foot, 3,022 riflemen and 2,322 horse in the nine regiments, with seventy-nine guns. The first regiment is the largest, at 1,818 men, and the eighth and ninth are the smallest, at about 850 each. The horse are kept for the hill roads of the west and the north, where lorries cannot go and the dubhan depots are far apart. The four fleets are small. The first and second have two hulls each and the third and fourth one each, with about a hundred men to a hull.

### Part III. The Calamities

#### The five stricken districts

The map shades five districts, each for the calamity that gave it a name. All five fell in the Age of Strangers or after, and in each of them the annals show that the same ground had been struck before.

**A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>18</sup>, the Green Death.** *Struck:* Ros dhìreach, Ceann òg, Inis ìseal, Baile dhomhain, Achadh fhada, Cnoc bheag, Muileann uaine, Cuan àrsaidh, Inis bhàn, all but the last two in the shire of Cnoc bheag. From 9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 73, the Green Death went through the mining camps. The coal dust was blamed, but no in-

18. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'



quiry into it was ever brought to an end. At Achadh dhomhain, where it was first noticed, forty were buried in the first month in a field still called the green acre (5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 73). It spread along the coal roads to these nine towns and to twenty-six settlements in all, and the custodians' roll leaves a blank line after the last (13 am Faoilleach, AE 74). Àth ghlas burned the huts of its dead and was free of it soonest (12 am Màrt, AE 74). No reckoning of all the dead survives. After it came the first strike, at Baile thais, over the galleries where the sickness had been worst (21 an Dàmhair, AE 77).

**Gorta Baile chrom<sup>19</sup>, the Great Hunger.** *Struck:* Baile chrom, Àth fhionn, Ceann mhòr, Àth dhearg, Muileann àrsaidh, Achadh àrsaidh, all Tuathaich towns today, in the shires of Ceann mhòr, Muileann àrsaidh, Baile chrom and Cnoc thais (22 an Cèitean, AE 94). The oldest hunger on Dia-thìr with a place to it was here, in pots of boiled bark and doubled grave-rows (7 an Cèitean, GE 1,966), and a dearth emptied the same shore in the Age of Sundering (19 an Giblean, LE 819). The Great Hunger began on 3 am Màrt, AE 94, when the harvest failed in thirty-four settlements; and it was the worse because the levy had taken so many that too few were left to work the land. It was worst at Baile chrom, whose people could see the new beacon from their empty fields (1 an Giblean, AE 94); the Administration did not dispute the count. At Seann Bhrenn the grain-pits of the Holy Age were opened and held only dust (7 an t-Samhain, AE 96). The Levy was suspended too late for the harvest and never repealed (20 an Gearran, AE 97).

**Tìormachd Achadh shean<sup>20</sup>, the Long Drought.** *Struck:* Achadh shean, Àth uaine, Achadh àrsaidh, Muileann chiar, in the shires of Achadh shean and Doire fhionn. The springs of Achadh shean failed in the Age of Ailean (8 an Giblean, GE 2,006), and dry years came again in the Holy Age (15 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,900) and in the Age of Sundering (2 an Dàmhair, LE 1,479); each time the shared grain brought the district through. The Long Drought began on 25 an Lùnastal, AE 106 and held three years. Fewer than half of Achadh shean's cattle reached water (28 an t-Ògmhios, AE 107), and the custodians counted ten districts as drought country while the Administration kept no count (27 an t-Iuchar, AE 107). The fever of bad water that followed killed two hundred and sixty at Baile Mòr ruadh (25 an Giblean, AE 109). When dry years returned in the Age of the Kingdom the council sent grain up the coal line, and none died of hunger (3 an Cèitean, SE 43).

**Scaineadh Cill ghlas<sup>21</sup>, the Rending.** *Struck:* Cill ghlas, Àth chaol, Achadh chaol, in the shires of Muileann dhearg, Muileann chiar and Muileann dhomhain. The

19. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

20. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

21. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

ground here has moved in every age: a crack across the valley (5 an Lùnastal, GE 827), cracked wells (27 an Cèitean, LE 379), a fallen gallery with fourteen names on a stone at its mouth (14 an Dàmhair, LE 929). The Rending came on 9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 137, while a common working was being driven with blasting-powder. It killed dozens, swallowed the old cutting and its shrine (3 an t-Iuchar, AE 137), and closed the district for a generation behind the Company's fence (13 an t-Samhain, AE 137). The displaced built Achadh chaol on the edge of the fenced ground (5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 137). The district was reopened (19 an t-Iuchar, SE 15), and on 1 an t-Iuchar, SE 39, a gallery under Muileann dhearg gave way along a line the surveyors had called sound, and thirty-one hewers died. It was, the annals note, the same fault.

**Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol<sup>22</sup>, the Great Wave.** *Struck:* Cnoc chaol, Cuan dhearg, Achadh mhin, Ros gharbh, on the coasts of the shires of Seann Vell, Cnoc naomh and Ros gharbh. Sea sand a hand thick lies over a village of the Age of Ailean at Cnoc chaol (7 an t-Iuchar, GE 777), a swell took two children there in the Age of Sundering (22 an Gearran, LE 724), and Cuan dhearg was twice flooded before it built its sea-wall (23 an Giblean, LE 1,754). The Great Wave struck without warning on 3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 4 and wrecked the three towns in one night. It was the first calamity the new kingdom met by its own means. The relief parties counted a little over nine hundred dead (24 an t-Samhain, SE 4). The wave ran on up the gulf to Ros gharbh and broke its quays, though the town on its headland lost few (24 an t-Samhain, SE 4). Cuan dhearg's harbour was gone and its boats lay in the fields. The shepherds of Eilean mhin did not go back (1 an Giblean, SE 5).

## Other calamities of the annals

**Plagues.** A coughing sickness killed some two hundred at Caol fhiadhaich (2 an Gearran, LE 156); a spotted fever some three hundred at Inis chrom, where the Fianna of the Stone nursed the sick and many of them died of it (3 an t-Sultain, LE 624); the swallowing cough near a third of Muileann dhomhain (29 an Lùnastal, LE 1,079). The strangers' fever came ashore with a crowded ship and killed ninety-one Dia-thìrich and eleven humans (5 an t-Samhain, AE 9). The spotted pox at Ros dhomhain killed four hundred and six by the Mission's count, and more by the custodians' (11 an Dàmhair, AE 39). The grey fever (2 an Gearran, AE 138) killed the young and strong more readily than the old, and in the north-west put Dia-thìrich and humans in the same wards for the first time (20 an t-Iuchar, AE 140).

**Famines.** The first hunger of the Holy Age with a place is the winter after the burning of Achadh mhòr (24 an Lùnastal, FE 556), whose dead the Hall counted with

the dead of the war. The first famine known to have been turned aside (4 an Dàmhair, FE 2,473) was the first trial of the shared-meal custom, and the custom held. Beyond the Great Hunger the annals record hunger in the capital and in Ros bheag during the War of the Hills (8 an t-Iuchar, AE 150, 4 an Dàmhair, AE 150), and the north's first year alone, when Tuathaich memory puts the dead at Doire ghlas above two hundred and no Dia-thìrich count was made (9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1).

**Storms, floods and fires.** The first storm given a name is remembered only for the naming (30 am Faoilleach, GE 147); the oldest whose name survives is A' Ghaoth Dhubh<sup>23</sup> (1 an Gearran, GE 2,417). Am Fuath Mòr<sup>24</sup> drowned eighteen at Seann Toll (23 an t-Samhain, LE 259), a storm drowned twenty-three at Baile ghorm (12 an Dàmhair, LE 1,739), and another eleven Tuathaich off Cuan bheag (28 an t-Sultain, SE 19). The Abhainn iséal cut the coal line for most of a year (12 am Màrt, SE 34). Fire burned Ceann mhin twice (5 an t-Sultain, LE 1,549) and the fair at Muileann òg once (31 an Dàmhair, SE 40).

**The vein's own dead.** The mountain has killed those who worked it in every age: from the basket burning at Achadh dhìreach (7 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,066) to the first deaths laid to the humans' pace of work, eleven of them, entered as an accident (26 an Giblean, AE 25).

## Table of calamities

| CALAMITY              | BEGAN                    | PLACE             | DEAD, AS COUN-<br>TED                      | WHAT FOLLOWED                         |
|-----------------------|--------------------------|-------------------|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| First named storm     | 30 am Faoilleach, GE 147 | unknown           | not recorded                               | Its name lost; the naming remembered  |
| Hunger at Baile chrom | 7 an Cèitean, GE 1,966   | Gorta Baile chrom | grave-rows doubled                         | Oldest hunger with a place            |
| Swallowing cough      | 29 an Lùnastal, LE 1,079 | Muileann dhomhain | near a third of the town                   | Seann Bhral closes itself             |
| Strangers' fever      | 5 an t-Samhain, AE 9     | Cuan shean        | 91 Dia-thìrich, 11 humans                  | Town closed to ships                  |
| Spotted pox           | 11 an Dàmhair, AE 39     | Ros dhomhain      | 406 by the Mission; more by the custodians | Dead cut on the lintel at Baile chiar |
| A' Phlàigh Uaine      | 9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 73    | A' Phlàigh Uaine  | not totalled; 26 settlements               | The first strike                      |

22. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

23. the Black Wind

24. the great hate, the storm that drowned Seann Toll's boats

| CALAMITY                 | BEGAN                  | PLACE                  | DEAD, AS COUN-<br>TED                   | WHAT FOLLOWED                  |
|--------------------------|------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Gorta Baile chrom        | 3 am Màrt, AE 94       | Gorta Baile chrom      | worst at Baile chrom; not totalled      | Levy suspended                 |
| Tiormachd Achadh shean   | 25 an Lùnastal, AE 106 | Tiormachd Achadh shean | 260 of drought-fever at Baile Mòr ruadh | Cause first named rightly      |
| Scàineadh Cill ghlas     | 9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 137 | Scàineadh Cill ghlas   | dozens                                  | District closed a generation   |
| Grey fever               | 2 an Gearran, AE 138   | island-wide            | not totalled                            | Shared wards at Cath-air gheal |
| Hungry year in the north | 9 an Dùbhlachd, SE 1   | Doire ghlas            | above 200 (Tuathaich memory)            | No Dia-thìrich count           |
| Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol     | 3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 4   | Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol   | a little over 900                       | Cuan dhearg's harbour lost     |
| Fall at Muileann dhearg  | 1 an t-Iuchar, SE 39   | Muileann dhearg        | 31                                      | The same fault                 |

The Library does not hold this list to be whole. It has only what the rolls kept, and the rolls counted some of the dead and left others uncounted.

APPENDIX D

The Reckoning of Years

Here it is told how the years of Dia-thìr are now counted, by the seven eras, and how that reckoning grew out of the older counts. After that comes the island's own reckoning of the moon, which the Dia-thìrich kept before the humans came and the Old Faith keeps yet; then the humans' calendar, and how it became the civil calendar of the island, and how its months and the days of its week got their Dia-thìris names; then the feasts. Last it is told how the Library at Muileann chaol turned every old date into the civil calendar, and that is why the annals give a civil day and month to every age alike.

I. The Seven Eras

The island counts its years by eras, *linntean*, one to each of the seven ages of *Clàr nan Aoisean*<sup>1</sup>, the table of the ages, as the Library received and extended it. Each era is counted from the first thing remembered in its age. That first year is year 1, and there is no year nought. A date is written with the day, the month and the year of its era, *19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1*, and a year alone as *DE 27*; in Dia-thìris it is read *air an naoidheamh latha deug den Ògmhios, sa chiad bhliadhna de Linn an Dubhain*<sup>2</sup>. In running prose the chroniclers are content to write "in the year 214 of the Flame".

| AGE | DIA-THÌRIS NAME  | IN THE COMMON TONGUE | ERA                               | SPAN         | FIRST EVENT                                      | LAST EVENT                                                   |
|-----|------------------|----------------------|-----------------------------------|--------------|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| I   | An Aois Àr-saidh | the Ancient Age      | Linn na Fèithe, the Vein Era (VE) | VE 1 – 5,324 | The mason's fire, 20 am Faoilleach, VE 1         | The rainbow coal lit by the Keeper, 21 an t-Iuchar, VE 5,324 |
| II  | An Aois Ailein   | the Age of Ailean    | Linn na Doire, the Grove Era (GE) | GE 1 – 4,603 | The vigil and the crowning, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1 | The eve of the Binding, 7 an Lùnastal, GE 4,550              |

1. the table of the ages  
2. the Dubhan Era (DE); lit. 'the era of Dubhan'

| AGE | DIA-<br>THÌRIS<br>NAME | IN THE<br>COMMON<br>TONGUE | ERA                                                  | SPAN            | FIRST EVENT                                                    | LAST EVENT                                                       |
|-----|------------------------|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| III | An Aois Na-<br>omh     | the Holy Age               | Linn an Teine,<br>the Flame Era<br>(FE)              | FE 1 –<br>2,960 | Ailean Mòr falls<br>at Àth na Fala, 2<br>an t-Sultain, FE<br>1 | The last age of<br>even population,<br>1 an Cèitean, FE<br>2,949 |
| IV  | An Aois<br>Scaraidh    | the Age of<br>Sundering    | Linn na Tìre, the<br>Landfall Era (LE)               | LE 1 –<br>1,819 | Land is found, 6<br>am Faoilleach,<br>LE 1                     | The mist thins, 27<br>an Dàmhair, LE<br>1,813                    |
| V   | An Aois<br>Choigreach  | the Age of<br>Strangers    | Linn an Acair,<br>the Anchor Era<br>(AE)             | AE 1 –<br>151   | The Crossing, 5<br>am Faoilleach,<br>AE 1                      | The Severance, 1<br>am Faoilleach, AE<br>151                     |
| VI  | An Aois<br>Rìoghachd   | the Age of the<br>Kingdom  | Linn an<br>Dealachaidh, the<br>Severance Era<br>(SE) | SE 1 –<br>71    | The Tuathaich<br>homeland fixed,<br>22 am Màrt, SE<br>1        | The watch on the<br>spoil-heaps, 26 an<br>Cèitean, SE 71         |
| VII | An Aois<br>Dhubhain    | the Age of<br>Dubhan       | Linn an<br>Dubhain, the<br>Dubhan Era (DE)           | DE 1 –<br>27    | The first work-<br>ing dubhan, 19<br>an t-Ògmhios,<br>DE 1     | The present, 21<br>an Dùbhlachd,<br>DE 27                        |

The names are plain. *Linn na Fèithe*<sup>3</sup> is the era of the vein, counted from the mason's fire. Its year 1 is the year in which a mason of the hills, splitting rock for a well, broke into the vein of coal, and the coal showed every colour at the break; and in the storm of that same night the lightning struck the broken vein and it caught fire, so that the mason carried home the first fire of the Dia-thìrich. That is the oldest thing the island dates. The making of the world by Caoran, the godfolk, and their first finding of the coloured coal, which they did not understand and let lie, are told in *Aithris a' Chruthachaidh*<sup>4</sup>, the Telling of the Making, and have no year. *Linn na Doire*<sup>5</sup> is the era of the grove, from the night in Doire ghlas when the gods came to the seven cold coals and named Ailean Mòr king of the godkin; it is counted from his crowning and not from his birth, as a reign is counted. *Linn an Teine*<sup>6</sup> is the era of the fire, from the year of the Binding of Bride's flame at Dùn ìseal, which opens with the fall of the first king at the Ford of Blood three weeks before it; the fire it names is the First Flame that was sworn to, and not the mason's fire, which is older by the whole of the Ancient Age and the Age of Ailean. *Linn na Tìre*<sup>7</sup> is the era of the land, from the word that came back of a land across open water. *Linn an Acair*<sup>8</sup> is the era of the anchor, from the day the

3. the Vein Era (VE); lit. 'the era of the vein'  
4. the Telling of the Making  
5. the Grove Era (GE); lit. 'the era of the grove'  
6. the Flame Era (FE); lit. 'the era of the fire'  
7. the Landfall Era (LE); lit. 'the era of the land'

humans' ships came to anchor at the Crossing. *Linn an Dealachaidh*<sup>8</sup> is the era of the parting, from the Severance and the settling of the north. *Linn an Dubhain* is the era of Dubhan, from the first fuel that burned without the vein. It is the only era of the seven named for a living man, and the north is apt to observe that he was one of theirs.

Five things in the table need a word.

An era's last year is also the first year of the next. The year in which an age opens is counted in the old era until the day of its first event, and in the new era from that day.

The Ancient Age closes with the lighting of the rainbow coal (21 an t-Iuchar, VE 5,324), and the Age of Ailean opens a week later with the vigil and the crowning in the same grove (28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1); so the Grove Era's first year is the last year of the Vein Era, and the week between them is the Vein Era's last.

The Holy Age is named for the flame and dated from it, but its first event is the fall of Ailean Mòr at Àth na Fala<sup>10</sup> (2 an t-Sultain, FE 1), three weeks before the Binding (23 an t-Sultain, FE 1). The copyists who first cut the past into ages began the Holy Age at the Binding; when the Library counted the Age of Ailean apart, its reckoners ended that age where the king ended, and gave the three weeks between to the Holy Age, so that no age should outlast the man it was named for.

The Age of Sundering is usually said to open with the Choosing, but the Choosing (8 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1) is not the first thing in it. The age opens with the finding of the land (6 am Faoilleach, LE 1), without which there would have been nothing to choose.

The Severance closes the Age of Strangers on the first day of AE 151, and the first events of the Age of the Kingdom follow it within that same year, which is therefore also SE 1. The copyists of the cellar entered the Severance as the last act of the age it ended, and the Library has left it there.

## II. How the Ages Counted Their Years

**The Ancient Age and the Age of Ailean.** Neither the Ancient Age nor the Age of Ailean kept a count of years that anyone has found. Their people counted other things. The Seann-Dhaoine<sup>11</sup> cut strokes on stones at the edges of their middens, one stone to a household, and the first strokes were cut on 31 an t-Iuchar, GE 308. The tally wall at Seann Warr grew to some three thousand strokes, and in one stretch the tallies

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8. the Anchor Era (AE); lit. 'the era of the anchor'

9. the Severance Era (SE); lit. 'the era of the parting'

10. the Ford of Blood, below Dùn dhearg

11. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

of three coasts thicken together (6 an Giblean, GE 470). These are counts of the dead. None of them has been read as a count of years.

The first tide-count (28 am Faoilleach, GE 1,671), a rock on which someone marked the high-water line, comes nearer. Its marks fall at intervals regular enough that later scholars have suspected a reckoning of the moon in them. The custom was carried to Ros dhomhain with the interval unchanged. What the interval was for no one knows, and the Library has declined to guess. The hill-folk also knew the crossing season of the great cats and kept off the passes while the panthers went over (20 am Faoilleach, VE 5,219). That season they kept year by year, but the years they did not number.

The oldest oral king-list, *Rìghrean na Cloiche*<sup>12</sup>, begins with Ailean Mòr (9 an Lùnastal, GE 1) and "gives no lengths of reign." The Red Hill list is the same. When both lists were recited together at the ford gathering (23 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,347), the recital lasted from dusk to dawn; yet it measured nothing but a line of names. Here and there the tellings of those ages bind a few deeds fast to one another, and where they do, those deeds are remembered as falling in one year or within a few. Between such points the tellings keep the order of things and little of the distance between them, and the years of those ages are known only so well as the tellings know them.

**The Holy Age.** The Holy Age counted in two ways, and neither of them ran from a fixed beginning.

The first was **by reigns**. From the Binding of the First Flame (23 an t-Sultain, FE 1) the Keepers of the flame were remembered in a recited roll that begins with Beathag Bhàn. After Goraìdh mac Ìomhair was first called *rìgh* at Dùn dhearg (28 an Cèitean, FE 674), the rulers of the lowlands had a list of their own. A year was named by whoever held it: "the ninth year of Iain Garbh," "the third winter of the Keeper Seumas Bàn." That served well enough for a debt within living memory; for the distance between two reigns it was of no use, since the recited lists gave no lengths. The first written king-list, Tormod Scriobhaiche's roll (20 an Lùnastal, FE 1,299), marks which names came from reciters and which from living memory. The Keepers had their own roll set down in answer (17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,320), and it proved several centuries longer than Tormod's. From the reign of Seonag Chrom the clerks of the red hall kept the king-list year by year. Between Tormod Òg and Anna Ruadh the list gives nine rulers of the house of Tormod, "their names and years and little else" (29 am Màrt, FE 2,558). Those years were counted within each reign and did not run on from one reign to the next.

The second was **by burnings**. From the Small-Burning Law (13 an Lùnastal, FE 142), a household might burn no more than its measured handful of coal in a season,

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12. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'



and the Hall at Dùn ìseal kept the record of those seasons. It counted them from the Law: the first burning, the second, and on through the centuries. A Small-Burning year ran from one filling of the baskets to the next, and the Hall filled them at Samhain, when the galleries closed and the hearths began to need the coal. The first sentence under the Law (1 an Cèitean, FE 145) took from a household its right "for the season after," and it was entered by the burning in which it fell. Of all the island's counts the count of burnings came nearest to an era, because it ran from a single act and was meant never to stop. It long outlived the age. The Law was never repealed; it lapsed (2 an Dùbhlachd, AE 21), and the custodians of Doire mhin kept the old count one season longer than anyone else (31 an Dùbhlachd, AE 21), with the note that nobody had asked for it.

By the close of the age the Keepers' roll held one hundred and forty names and the king-list more than ninety (2 an Giblean, FE 2,939). The two did not agree in every place, and the Hall's count of burnings did not always agree with either.

**The Age of Sundering.** In this age the island first numbered its years from a single day, and the count it made was the count of the Diosal.

### III. The Count of the Diosal, and How It Was Given Up

*Diosal* is the island's word for the sunwise turn: the way a hand moves, a boat rounds a point, or a procession goes about a cairn, with the right shoulder toward the centre and the course following the sun. Before going down the Abhainn naomh to open water the fleet of the Sundering went once round the river pool of Seann Skell sunwise, for luck, and the watchers on the quay counted the hulls as they passed. The harbour scribe's entry for the turn is the last thing any roll says of the departed.

The count was not made at the time. On 22 am Faoilleach, LE 44, Donnchadh mac Thormoid, scribe of the vein-house above Muileann dhearg, began to number the years from the sunwise turn and called them *bliadhnaichean an Diosail*, the years of the Diosal. By his own reckoning only a few of them had yet passed. There was no year nought, and the years before the turn were counted backwards, *ron Diosal*, "before the Diosal". The count was his alone at first. The crown's scribes at Cathair dhearg took it up about a generation later.

The harbour scribe sets the Setting-Out and the sunwise turn on one day, the sailing on 19 an Giblean, LE 40 and the turn on 19 an Giblean, LE 40, the same morning. The custody-book, however, enters the turn under a later day than the sailing, after the next Samhain. No one has accounted for that gap of half a year, and the keepers have

left both entries as they stand. Donnchadh counted from the turn as the custody-book entered it. The crown's scribes, taking up the count when the court remembered the departure as a single thing, counted from the year the ships sailed. Both began each year at Samhain, by the moon, as the Hall had done; so by the old year the sailing and the turn lay in different years, and the two counts stood a year apart. So, the Library believes, the counts came to differ. The rolls do not prove it, and it leaves unexplained why the turn is entered so long after the sailing.

The difference stood for more than six hundred years, until 23 am Màrt, LE 739, when the vein-house and the crown's scribes found that their counts disagreed and settled the matter by agreement. The same agreement fixed the day of the empty-harbour rite, which the two counts had placed differently. A later hand in the custody-book adds that the scribes afterwards "cease to pretend it was fixed by proof." From that day there was one Diosal count on Dia-thìr, and it followed the harbour scribe, setting the sailing and the turn both in its first year. The vein-house marked its thousandth year (15 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,039) with a single measured burning on Cidhe an Diosail<sup>13</sup>, the quay of the sunwise turn.

For the rest of the Age of Sundering, through the Age of Strangers and into the first years of the kingdom, the island dated its writings by the Diosal. The custodians set its year beneath the humans' year at the head of their pages (section VI). The keeper's proclamation at the founding of the Library (1 an Cèitean, SE 16) is dated "the year one thousand nine hundred and forty-five of the Diosal", and it is among the last public writings so dated.

The count had served the scribes of the rolls well enough. It served the Library ill. Everything older than the sunwise turn had to be counted backwards in years that ran into the thousands: the Binding fell nearly three thousand years before the Diosal, and the mason's fire nearly thirteen thousand, a number no keeper could write with a steady hand, since no roll and no telling measured it. The count ran, moreover, from an absence; and the Library's first keeper said that a people ought not to have to name every year of its life after the day its kin went away.

The copyists of the cellar had already cut the past into ages (section XII), and Ailean Leabhar, when he came to the Library (28 an t-Ògmhios, SE 16), took their table as the frame of his work. He counted each age from its own first event; and in doing so he and his reckoners parted the eldest age of the table in two, so that the Age of Ailean was counted apart from the Ancient Age, and he wrote the dates of the ledgers he was having read in the years of their age and not of the Diosal. The council followed him. With the creation of the office of royal chronicler (20 an t-Samhain, SE 18) it

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13. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

ordered that the kingdom's records should count their years by the ages of the Library's table (20 an t-Samhain, SE 18), six as the table then stood, and seven since. Gormshuil nic Dhùghaill entered her first year as the eighteenth of the Severance Era. The Diosal count was kept thereafter only in old books. Its name lives on in the day of the empty-harbour rite, *Là an Diosail*<sup>14</sup>, and in the quay at Seann Skell, and nobody has proposed to change either.

No one foresaw the seventh era. The first working dubhan was made on 19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1, and for years it was one man's fuel and no more; Beathag nic Fhionnlaigh, then chronicler, noted it at the foot of that year and spelled it three ways. When the council pegged the coinage to the making of dubhan in place of the coal reserves, it proclaimed at the same sitting that the Age of the Kingdom had ended with the first working dubhan, and that the kingdom's years were counted anew from that day (5 an Cèitean, DE 15). The Severance Era closed with its seventy-first year, and the year of the proclamation became the fifteenth of the Dubhan Era. Beathag re-headed fourteen years of her own chronicle, and wrote at the foot of the page that she had never before had to move a year she was living in.

The Tuathaich were not asked about either change. The northern parish books, so far as the Library has seen them, give the civil day and month and the kingdom's era in their dealings with the kingdom. What count they keep among themselves the Library cannot say, for few of those books come to it.

## IV. The Reckoning of the Moon

Before the humans came the Dia-thìrich had no calendar fixed to the sun. They reckoned by the moon, and they counted time by nights and not by days. The night went before its day, as the dark half of the year went before the bright: a feast began at dusk on its eve, *Oidhche Shambna* was the first night of Samhain and not the night before it, and a debt of "ten nights" fell due at the tenth dusk. The custody-book calls this reckoning *cunntas nan oidhcheannan*, the count of the nights, and the Library's word for it, *cunntas-oidhche*, the night-count, is shortened from the custody-book's.

The year began at Samhain, with the dark half of the year. It held twelve moon-months, *miosan-gealaich*, of thirty nights and twenty-nine nights in turn. Each moon-month was halved. It began on the night of the full moon and waned through its dark half, *an leth dubh*; at the dark of the moon it turned, and its bright half, *an leth geal*, waxed to the next full. Below the month the Dia-thìrich had the half-moon, *cola-deug*, "fourteen nights", though the halves were of fourteen or fifteen nights as the moon

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14. the day of the empty-harbour rite; lit. 'the day of the sunwise turn'

ran. They had no week. In the rolls of the Holy Age and of the Sundering a debt, a sentence or a turn in the galleries is set by the half-moon, and the markets met at the full; Queen Sileas's charter to Cathair fhada (17 an t-Samhain, LE 287) grants a market at every full moon. The night of the full and the night of the dark were rest-nights, *oid-bheannan-tàmh*, on which the Hall let no coal be cut and the fishing households set no nets.

Twelve moons make three hundred and fifty-four nights, some eleven fewer than the sun's year, so that without help the feasts would have walked backwards through the seasons. About every thirty moons, two and a half years, the keepers of the reckoning put in a thirteenth moon of thirty nights at the end of the year, after Damhrach and before Samhnas, so that Samhain should not come before the summer had ended. They called it *Eadrach*, the between-moon. In the Holy Age the Hall at Dùn iséal declared it; after the Hall's day the vein-house did, and since the vein-house's day the druid schools declare it, and the orders of the Old Faith follow them. The Hall's roll of the years in which Eadrach was put in is the thread on which every older date of the island hangs (section XII), and the thread is broken in places.

The four fire-feasts were fixed by the moon, each on the first night of its moon: Samhain at the opening of Samhnas, Là Fhèill Bhrìde of Gearras, Bealltainn of Bealltach, Lùnastal of Lùghnas. Against the sun they wander by as much as half a month from year to year, and the between-moon brings them back.

The names of the thirteen moons are old, and some of them were in dispute already when the Hall first wrote them down. The meanings given below are those the Library holds most likely.

| NO. | MOON      | NIGHTS | MEANING OF THE NAME                                                                                     | THE CIVIL MONTH NAMED FROM IT, OR NEAREST IT |
|-----|-----------|--------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Samhnas   | 30     | summer's end; Samhain on its first night                                                                | an t-Samhain                                 |
| 2   | Dubhlas   | 29     | the black moon, the dark of the year                                                                    | an Dùbhlachd                                 |
| 3   | Faolach   | 30     | the wolf-moon; the storm-time at the year's dead end                                                    | am Faoilleach                                |
| 4   | Gearras   | 29     | the short moon, or the gelding's moon; the Library does not choose. Là Fhèill Bhrìde on its first night | an Gearran                                   |
| 5   | Siolach   | 30     | the seed-time                                                                                           | am Màrt, whose name came from elsewhere      |
| 6   | Bearnach  | 29     | the gap: the moon between the last of the stores and the first of the green                             | an Giblean                                   |
| 7   | Bealltach | 30     | the moon of the bright fire, the first of summer; Bealltainn on its first night                         | an Cèitean                                   |

| NO. | MOON          | NIGHTS | MEANING OF THE NAME                                                      | THE CIVIL MONTH<br>NAMED FROM IT, OR<br>NEAREST IT |
|-----|---------------|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| 8   | Ògach         | 29     | the young moon                                                           | an t-Ògmhios                                       |
| 9   | Teasach       | 30     | the hot moon                                                             | an t-Iuchar                                        |
| 10  | Lùghnas       | 29     | Lugh's gathering; Lùnastal on its first night                            | an Lùnastal                                        |
| 11  | Pailteach     | 30     | the moon of plenty                                                       | an t-Sultain, whose name came<br>from elsewhere    |
| 12  | Dam-<br>hrach | 29     | the stags' moon, the rut of the deer                                     | an Dàmhair                                         |
| 13  | Eadrach       | 30     | the between-moon, put in at the year's end<br>about every thirtieth moon | none                                               |

## V. The Humans' Calendar

The humans who came at the Crossing (5 an Faoilleach, AE 1) brought a calendar of another kind. It was fixed to the sun and paid no heed to the moon. Its year began in the dead of winter and had twelve months of set lengths, thirty or thirty-one days and one of twenty-eight, with a twenty-ninth day put into that short month every fourth year. They counted by days from midnight, not by nights from dusk, and they divided the month into weeks of seven days, one of which was kept for rest and worship. Their years they numbered from an epoch in their own land, which they named and did not explain, and their numbers were far larger than the island's. No Dia-thìrich scribe set down the name of that land (26 an Gearran, AE 2), and the letter-books do not explain the epoch either.

In the season of translation Samuel Wren and the custodian Gormshuil nic Fhear-chair kept their word-lists side by side (13 an Dùbhlachd, AE 2). Wren's list, which survives in the Administration's letter-books, sets each of the humans' months against the moon it most nearly matched, and it is the first writing on Dia-thìr in which the two reckonings meet. From that pairing the Dia-thìrich named the humans' months (section VII).

## VI. How the Civil Calendar Came In

The humans' calendar was never proclaimed on Dia-thìr. It came in by paper. The first written treaty (27 an Giblean, AE 8) was drawn up in the humans' tongue only and dated by the humans' day, month and year. The custodians entered it in their roll under its Diosal year and the moon in which it was signed, and left the day to the Admin-

istration. The Harbour Articles (16 an t-Samhain, AE 19), the Company's charter and every contract for extraction (19 an t-Sultain, AE 11) were dated the same way, and the contracts paid their crews by the week and let them rest on the humans' day of rest. So the Dia-thìrich who worked for the Company learned the week before any of them was christened. The same clerks who kept two sets of books for coin and barter (30 am Faoilleach, AE 18) came to keep two dates at the head of every page, the humans' year and day above and the Diosal year and the night of the moon beneath, and they complained about both.

A contract that fell due on the humans' day could not be settled by the moon, and the clerks who had to settle it went over to the humans' months first and to the humans' new year after. By the third currency reform (7 an Giblean, AE 129) every contract on the island ran from am Faoilleach, and the Dia-thìrich civil year had moved to the humans' beginning without any decree. The moon-year survived in the shrines, in the Hall's count of burnings until it lapsed, and among the custodians of Inis bhàn, who taught "the old reckoning" in their school (7 an t-Ògmhios, AE 52). The Administration's census (19 an Cèitean, AE 122) and its register (26 an t-Samhain, AE 127) were dated by the humans' reckoning alone.

After the Severance the kingdom kept the civil calendar, since a century and a half of contracts, ledgers and letters already stood on it, and no one on the council wished to return the kingdom's debts to the moon. The kingdom has kept it since. Its months have the names the Dia-thìrich gave them, and its years are counted by the eras (section III).

## VII. The Civil Months

The civil months are the humans' months under Dia-thìris names. For ten of them the clerks took the name of the moon that Wren's list set beside the month, in the form it had in the speech of their day; two names they took from the humans themselves. Beside each month is set the island's work in it, as the rolls of every age describe that work, reckoned into the civil months.

| NO. | MONTH            | DAYS       | THE NAME                     | THE WORK OF THE MONTH<br>ON DIA-THÌR                                                    |
|-----|------------------|------------|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | am<br>Faoilleach | 31         | from Faolach, the wolf-moon  | Nets and boats mended ashore; the coal-hearths at their fullest; the high passes shut   |
| 2   | an Ge-<br>arran  | 28<br>(29) | from Gearras, the short moon | Là Fhèill Bride on the first; the first ploughing in the lowlands; lambing in the south |

| NO. | MONTH        | DAYS | THE NAME                                                                                                                                                 | THE WORK OF THE MONTH<br>ON DIA-THÌR                                                                                        |
|-----|--------------|------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 3   | am Màrt      | 31   | the humans' own name for the month, from their church-tongue, after a war-god of their forebears. The old folk still call it the seed-time, from Siolach | Sowing; the carters back on the roads; repairs to the bridges before the spring floods                                      |
| 4   | an Giblean   | 30   | obscure; the old folk say "the gap", which was the meaning of Bearnach, the moon it replaced                                                             | The hungry weeks of a poor year; granaries opened where the shared-meal law requires it                                     |
| 5   | an Cèitean   | 31   | the first of summer, as Bealltach was                                                                                                                    | Bealltainn on the first; cattle to the high pastures; in the Holy Age, the galleries opened when the cairn-watchers allowed |
| 6   | an t-Ògmhios | 30   | the young month, from Ògach                                                                                                                              | Peat cut and stacked; salt-pans worked on the south and west coasts                                                         |
| 7   | an t-Iuchar  | 31   | the hot month, as Teasach was                                                                                                                            | Hay; the herring off the north-west; the drovers of Àth Chiar on the eastern hills                                          |
| 8   | an Lùnastal  | 31   | from Lùghnas, the month of the Lùnastal gathering                                                                                                        | Lùnastal on the first; first-fruits; the harvest fair at Muileann òg in its season                                          |
| 9   | an t-Sultain | 30   | the humans' own name, from their church-tongue: "the seventh", though it is their ninth month. The old folk call it the month of plenty, from Pailteach  | The main harvest; the grain carried to the granaries; accounts rendered                                                     |
| 10  | an Dàmhair   | 31   | from Damhrach, the rut of the deer                                                                                                                       | The stags heard in the eastern forest; the druid schools walking the bounds of Flidais's wood; boats hauled up              |
| 11  | an t-Samhain | 30   | from Samhnas, summer's end                                                                                                                               | Samhain on the first; in the Holy Age the baskets filled and the galleries closed; the empty-harbour rite at Seann Skell    |
| 12  | an Dùbhlachd | 31   | from Dubhlas, the black month, the dark of the year                                                                                                      | Midwinter; the drowned remembered in the western harbours; the panther roads closed for the year                            |

An Gearran takes a twenty-ninth day in every fourth year, as the humans' calendar has it. The reckoning of the moon had no such day and needed none, for the between-moon did its work.

## VIII. The Week

The week, *seachdain*, came to Dia-thìr with the Mission. The humans' Church kept seven days, the first of them for rest and worship and two others for fasting, and when the Mission raised its chapel at Ros dhomhain (30 an Dùbhlachd, AE 13) and opened its school (9 an Cèitean, AE 51) it taught the week with its prayers. The Company's contracts had already taught it to the crews (section VI).

The names came with it. Each begins with *Di-*, the Mission's church-tongue word for a day, written solid with the rest of the name. Four are the church-tongue's own names put into Dia-thìris mouths. Three the first converts made for themselves, from the Mission's fasts. The names below are given in the forms the royal chronicler uses.

| DAY | DIA-<br>THIRIS | THE NAME                                                                                                                        |
|-----|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Didòmh-naich   | the Lord's day, from the church-tongue; the Mission's day of rest and worship. The Company's contracts let no coal be cut on it |
| 2   | Diluain        | the moon's day, from the church-tongue                                                                                          |
| 3   | Dimàirt        | the day of the war-god of the humans' forebears, from the church-tongue; the same name as the month am Màrt                     |
| 4   | Diciadain      | the day of the first fast                                                                                                       |
| 5   | Diardaoin      | the day between the fasts                                                                                                       |
| 6   | Dihaoine       | the day of the fast                                                                                                             |
| 7   | Disathairne    | the day of another old god of the humans' forebears, from the church-tongue. The Mission kept his name and not his story        |

The two fasts are the Mission's own: on the fourth day and the sixth the Church abstained from meat, and in the north it abstains still. Nobody else on Dia-thìr keeps them. An older opinion of the Library, that they were fasts from fire kept by Holy Age households under the Small-Burning Law, did not survive the reading of the Mission's letter-books; and the unlit hearth found under the peat (2 an Dàmhair, GE 902), which was once cited for it, proves nothing about weeks.

The Dia-thìrich had rested by the moon, on the nights of the full and the dark, and the Mission made a great deal of the difference. The custodians made little of it. It was the Mission's own minister Matthew Dunne who told the Company, against the night-shift order, that the Dia-thìrich were right that even the ground must rest (17 an t-Ògmhios, AE 118), and the Mission recalled him for it.



## IX. The Three Faiths and the Two Reckonings

The kingdom lives by the civil calendar; but the moon was never put away, and it runs on beside the civil months as the reckoning of the Old Faith.

*An Creideamh Sean*<sup>15</sup>, the Old Faith, keeps its feasts by the moon. Its four fire-feasts fall on the first nights of Samhnas, Gearras, Bealltach and Lùghnas, and its orders reckon on the moons as the druid schools declare them, between-moon and all. Òrd Bhride<sup>16</sup> lights its first lamp of the year on the first night of Gearras and not on the civil day, and in a year when the moon runs late its lamp is lit nearly a fortnight after the Church's candles.

*Na Seann Spioradan*<sup>17</sup>, the Old Spirits, keep the night-count at the hearth. They count a journey, a mourning or a guest's stay in nights, and their dead are waked for three nights and not three days. They keep the feasts with the Old Faith, by the moon, at the hearth and at the mounds.

*An Eaglais*<sup>18</sup>, the Church, keeps the civil calendar and the week it brought, with its day of rest, its two fasts and its own feasts on their civil days. The kingdom keeps the quarter-days on the first day of their civil months (section X), and the council, the courts and the markets follow the kingdom.

So a feast of the Old Faith and the same feast in the kingdom's calendar may fall a fortnight apart, and no one on Dia-thìr thinks it strange.

## X. The Quarter-Days

Four feasts divide the year into quarters. They are the great feasts of the Old Faith and older than any order now on the island, and all three faiths keep them in some fashion, though each for its own reasons (Appendix B). The kingdom keeps them on the first day of their civil months. The Old Faith keeps them on the first night of their moons (section IV).

**Là Fhèill Bhrìde**, 1 an Gearran, also called Imbolc, is the feast of Bhrìde, whose flame was bound at Dùn Ìseal. Every hearth is swept and relit and the year's first work in the fields begins. The followers of Na Seann Spioradan<sup>19</sup> set a sheaf by the door. Òrd Bhride<sup>20</sup> and the Hawk order, the two forms of her rite, light their first lamp of the year

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15. the Old Faith

16. the order of Bhrìde's flame

17. the Old Spirits

18. the Church

19. the Old Spirits

20. the order of Bhrìde's flame

from the altar-flame. The Church keeps the day as the feast of a saint of the same name.

**Bealltainn**, 1 an Cèitean, takes its name from a bright fire, and it is the feast of summer's beginning, when the Otherworld stands near. Cattle go up to the high pastures between two fires. In the Holy Age this was the day the Hall asked the cairn-watchers of Cnoc ghlais whether the galleries might open. The first sentence under the Small-Burning Law is dated 1 an Cèitean, FE 145, on Bealltainn itself. Whether the day was chosen for the sentence the roll does not say.

**Lùnastal**, 1 an Lùnastal, is Lugh's feast of first-fruits and gathering, which he made in memory of his foster-mother Taittiu, and the month is named for it. Markets open, contests are held, and oaths are taken before witnesses. Cathal was crowned on the feast itself, 1 an Lùnastal, DE 3.

**Samhain**, 1 an t-Samhain, marks summer's end, when the Otherworld stands open, the sith of the mounds are abroad, and the Old Faith names Donn and the dead of the year. Before the humans came it was also the beginning of the Dia-thìrich year. The Hall filled the baskets of the Small-Burning Law at Samhain, the galleries closed, and the dead were thought nearest. The Tuathaich, whose calendar came to them from an Tìr Thall<sup>21</sup>, keep the day with the rest of the island, in the Church's way, as the feast of all the saints and the day of the dead. They have never counted the year from it.

XI. Feasts and Days Particular to Dia-thìr

Beside the quarter-days Dia-thìr keeps days that spring from its own history. Those that the chronicles bear witness to are given below, on their civil days; under "since" stands the day on which the custom is first found.

| DAY                       | WHERE                         | WHAT IS KEPT                                                                                                   | SINCE                                                            |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 24 an t-Samhain, at night | Seann Skell water-front       | The night of lamps: a lamp on every sill until morning. Children are told the lamps are for ships coming home. | 18 an Giblean, LE 40; kept each year from 12 an Lùnastal, LE 109 |
| 25 an t-Samhain           | Cidhe an Diosail, Seann Skell | The empty-harbour rite, on the day the old counts agreed; in the harbour towns called Là an Diosail            | 25 an t-Samhain, LE 61; the day fixed 23 am Màrt, LE 739         |
| no fixed day              | the harbour towns, the court  | An Tùrsa Geal, the white sorrow: undyed wool and one place set empty at a meal that is neither feast nor fast  | 27 an Dàmhair, LE 54                                             |

21. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

| DAY                                | WHERE                                           | WHAT IS KEPT                                                                                                                 | SINCE                                                              |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| yearly, on the shore               | Inis chrom and the harbours north to Seann Warr | The drowned-feast, an empty place for each of the lost                                                                       | 10 an Dàmhair, FE 2,915                                            |
| yearly                             | Baile chrom                                     | The wake for the boat lost off the north-west                                                                                | 28 an Lùnastal, FE 405                                             |
| the crossing days                  | the southern hills, Imrich nam Pantar           | The panther roads kept clear, flocks driven off the paths                                                                    | 26 an t-Iuchar, LE 304                                             |
| yearly                             | Coille Naomh Muileann chiar                     | The druid schools walk the bounds of Flidais's wood                                                                          | 11 an t-Iuchar, LE 479                                             |
| harvest                            | Fèill Muileann òg                               | The great fair, with its northern day                                                                                        | 5 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,665; the fair established 16 an Dàmhair, SE 21 |
| yearly                             | Còmhrag Ceann leathan                           | The contest with staves, since edged tools were banned                                                                       | 9 an Giblean, FE 1,665; established 4 am Màrt, SE 23               |
| yearly, at its quarter of the moon | Allt an Àigh                                    | The walk of the Old Spirits to the healing water                                                                             | 8 an t-Iuchar, SE 10                                               |
| yearly                             | Seann Dunn                                      | The ancestors of forty families named aloud by their living heads                                                            | 28 an Dàmhair, SE 22                                               |
| yearly                             | Cnoc ghorm                                      | The northern feast of the sea, kept at the church as a blessing of the boats                                                 | 11 an Gearran, SE 26                                               |
| one night, undisclosed             | Baile chrom and the north                       | The vigil of the Grey Night under Sine, the Peaceful Goose, the wild goose of the Spirit; outsiders are not told which night | 14 am Màrt, SE 9                                                   |

The days of the older customs are given as the Library turned them (section XII). The night of lamps and the empty-harbour rite were fixed by the moon, and since the civil calendar came in the harbour towns have kept them on the civil days that the Library's tables give.

The day of the Setting-Out has never been kept as a feast. The chronicles say nothing more of the departed once the ships clear the harbour, and the island has kept its remembrance of them there, at the harbour where the rolls fall silent, on the day the custody-book gives for the turn and not on the day they sailed. Since 23 am Màrt, LE 739, the empty-harbour rite has fallen on that day, though the harbour scribe, whose count the island followed, sets the turn on the day of the sailing. The Library does not forget that the custody-book may have taken its day from the rite, and not the rite from the book. At the last rite of the empty harbour that the Age of Sundering records, it was kept by eleven people (25 an t-Samhain, LE 1,803). How many keep it now the chronicles of the later ages do not say.

**The Severance**, 1 am Faoilleach, AE 151, is kept at Cathair dhearg by the council as the day on which the latter history of the kingdom begins, and the era named for it bore its memory in every date for seventy-one years. The Mourning Custom of the Sundering, first made for a parting that was chosen, was used again, uneasily, for this parting that was not, and the council's keeping of this day is the use most often meant. In the north the day is not kept. It is worked through like any other, and the Tuathaich say that this is their way of keeping it.

**The Long War** left two days. The Battle of Àth leathan, 11 an Giblean, DE 21, opened *An Cogadh Fada*<sup>22</sup>. Tuathaich families have raised a cairn without leave on the field at Àraich Àth leathan<sup>23</sup>, and it grows by a stone or two whenever the patrols pass; whether they come on the day of the battle nobody has written down. The Battle of Muileann ghlas, 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22, ended the war, and the regiments raised in the campaign keep that day at their stations. So the two days are kept by two peoples; and the Library, whose record of the war is sealed (14 am Faoilleach, DE 24), holds what it can of both.

## XII. How the Library Turned the Old Dates

Every date in these annals is given in the civil calendar, with a day of the civil month and a year of the era, though for most of the island's history nobody who lived it counted so. The Library made it so, and the labour took three generations.

It began with Beathag nic Thòmais, the mill-owner's widow who bought up old copies of the custody-book and the harbour rolls and kept them in a loft over her mill at Muileann chaol (21 an Cèitean, LE 1,659). She did not reckon years. But she set copies that disagreed side by side and declined to choose between them (27 an Giblean, LE 1,679), and that became the way of all who worked in Muileann chaol after her. She left her loft to the town on condition that nothing in it be burned (24 an Lùnastal, LE 1,699).

The joining of the counts was done in the cellar. From 5 am Màrt, AE 124, the custodians of the east sent copies of their rolls to Muileann chaol for safekeeping, away from the Residency's reach, and three families did the copying. While they copied, they laid the counts against each other. Where the king-list gave a ruler's years and the Hall's roll gave the burnings of the same reign, the two could be made to meet, and each meeting fixed a stretch of the older count against the newer. The copyists called the result *Clàr nan Aoisean*<sup>24</sup>, the table of the ages. It is the first writing that runs one

22. the Long War

23. the battlefield of Àth leathan

numbered line of years from the Binding to the copyists' own day, in the years of the Diosal. It is also the first to divide the island's past into ages, and to set before the Holy Age an older age whose length, the table owns, it cannot measure. The copyists made that older age one, from the mason's fire to the Binding. When the custodians sent what survived of the Age of Strangers to the same cellars (29 an Dùbhlachd, AE 150), the table was carried through to the Severance, and in that form it gave the ages down to the Severance the bounds that historians of Dia-thìr still use.

Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>25</sup>, founded 1 an Cèitean, SE 16, took the table as one of its first possessions. The council's clerks had emptied the humans' counting-houses (11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 2) and boxed the ledgers unread, because few of them could read the humans' hand. Ailean Leabhar, the Library's first keeper, spent his first years having them read (28 an t-Ògmhios, SE 16), and he had every date in them, and in the custodians' rolls, turned into the civil calendar. For the Age of Strangers the double-dated pages of the custodians' clerks were his guide, since they set the humans' day above the night of the moon. For the ages before the Crossing he had only the moons, and he turned them by the Hall's roll of the between-moons, reckoning moon by moon back from the first double-dated page to the Binding. Each date so turned he set in the era of its age, as the council afterwards ordered for all the kingdom's records (section III).

It was in this work that the Library's reckoners counted the Age of Ailean apart from the Ancient Age. The copyists' eldest age ran from the mason's fire to the Binding, and Ailean Leabhar's reckoners, laying the tellings of Clann na Ceiste<sup>26</sup> against the king-lists, found that nearly half of it lay within the days of one man. Ailean Mòr was crowned in the grove at Doire ghlais and was king until he fell, and the Line of the Mason, which keeps the years of its dead beside their names, gives him more than four thousand six hundred of them. The reckoners held that a life so long was an age in itself, and that a count which ran over it in the same years as the mason's lightning and the Seven Coals would hide it. So they parted the eldest age at the crowning. What went before it, the mason and the Keeper and the lightings of the coals, they left as the Ancient Age, under the old name; what came after it they called *An Aois Ailein*<sup>27</sup>, the Age of Ailean, and its era *Linn na Doire*<sup>28</sup>, the Grove Era, from the grove where the king was made. Some of the Library's own scholars thought it a fancy to give one man an age, and said so in the margins; but the council took the table as the Library gave it, and the Age of Ailean has stood in it since. When the Library absorbed the provincial

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24. the table of the ages

25. the Library at Muileann chaol

26. the Children of the Question

27. the Age of Ailean

28. the Grove Era (GE); lit. 'the era of the grove'

archives (26 an t-Iuchar, SE 67), the table was checked against them and corrected where the archives knew better. When the seventh era was proclaimed, the Library re-headed the years since the first working dubhan as the chronicler had done.

So a reader of these annals who finds a Holy Age deed set on 3 an t-Samhain should remember that those who did it knew no such day. They knew a night of the moon Samhnas, and they began their year at Samhain and counted it by nights. The Library's day is the civil day on which that night would have fallen, as near as the roll of the between-moons allows. Where the roll has gaps, the day may be a half-moon out, and the Library says so. Ailean Leabhar disliked the saying *a chur san Leabharlann*, "to put it in the Library," on the ground that the Library settles nothing and only keeps it (3 an t-Samhain, SE 16). The turned dates should be read in the same spirit.

**Where the dates come from.** For the Age of Dubhan, the Age of the Kingdom and the Age of Strangers the days are remembered: they come from rolls, ledgers, letter-books and the chroniclers' own entries, and from the Crossing on they were written in the civil calendar or beside it. For the Age of Sundering they are remembered more thinly, from the custody-book, the harbour rolls and the crown's king-list, all dated by the moon, and a good many were settled by agreement, as the day of the empty-harbour rite was. For the Holy Age the years come from the Keepers' roll, the king-lists and the Hall's count of burnings, which do not always agree, and the days mostly from the feasts and moons the rolls name. For the Ancient Age and the Age of Ailean all rests on the tellings, the king-lists without lengths of reign, the tally walls and the tide-count. The tellings keep the order of things well and the distance between them poorly. Where they agree, the date is as sure as they are; where they disagree or fall silent it is not, and such a date should be trusted for the order it keeps rather than for its year.

## APPENDIX E

# Words BORN FROM History

Here are gathered the words, names and sayings of Dia-thìris that the island's history made, or bent to a new sense. They are set out in the manner of a historical dictionary. Each entry gives the headword and its part of speech, what it says word for word, what it has come to mean, the event that gave it that meaning, and a line from the annals or the seven books.

At the heart of it stands the chronicle's own list of *Words Born from History*, and every word on that list is entered here with the meaning the chronicle gives it. The rest are taken from the annals and the books: titles and offices, laws and customs, the names of storms, places and quarrels, and the sayings that the annals quote. A few are the words that Dia-thìris made for the strangers' things. Dia-thìris took few words from the humans, and most of those late (Appendix F). Where the humans said *train*, *engine* or *strike*, the island made a name out of old roots, and some of those names are entered here under the years in which the annals first had need of them.

## How to Read an Entry

The headword is given in full. An article (*an*, *am*, *a*') is written with it but not counted in the order, which is the island's order of eighteen letters, *a b c d e f g h i l m n o p r s t u*, the grave accent being ignored. Dates are given in the era of each age (Appendix D). Where no annal marks the first use of a word, the entry says so and gives only the event from which the word comes. Citations are given as the sources give them: the annals as this history renders their prose, the verses in Dia-thìris (Appendix F, *Of Translation*).

*n.* noun · *m.*, *f.* masculine, feminine · *pl.* plural · *v.* verb · *v.n.* verbal noun · *adj.* adjective · *phr.* phrase or saying · *lit.* literally

## The Glossary

### A

**a chur san Leabharlann** *phr.* · lit. "to put it in the Library" To make a thing official and past dispute. From the founding of Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>1</sup> (1 an Cèitean, SE 16); within a few years it was said of anything settled (3 an t-Samhain, SE 16).

"Ailean Leabhar is said to have disliked the phrase, for the Library settles nothing, he said, and only keeps." — annals, SE 16

**Aisling-aois** *n. f.* · lit. "Aisling-age" An unnaturally long youth in anyone; said half in jest of ordinary people who look young for their years. From the first of the immortal generation, born in the mining camps (7 am Màrt, AE 69). No annal marks its first use. Of all the words on the chronicle's list, in this one alone the jest and the legend are the same.

"...and she does not age as the folk about her age. Her name is Aisling." — annals, AE 69

**Aois Ailein, An** *n. f.* · lit. "the age of Ailean" The second of the seven ages, from the crowning in the grove to the fall of the first king at the Ford of Blood; its era is *Linn na Doire*<sup>2</sup>, the Grove Era. It is the only age given to one man. The reckoners of the Library parted it from the Ancient Age when they found, laying the tellings of Clann na Ceiste<sup>3</sup> against the king-lists, that nearly half the eldest age lay within the days of Ailean Mòr, who was crowned in Doire ghlas (28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1) and was king until he fell (2 an t-Sultain, FE 1). Some of the Library's own scholars thought it a fancy, and wrote so in the margins. Said of a thing that has lasted beyond reason, *bho Aois Ailein*, "from the Age of Ailean", means "since time out of mind".

"What came of that fire is the matter of the Second Book, and of an age that the reckoners of Muileann chaol would afterwards give to one man." — the First Book

**Àrd-choimheadaiche**<sup>4</sup> *n. m.* · lit. "high watcher" The high custodian of Òrd Bhride<sup>5</sup>, the order of Brìde's flame, seated at Seann Skell. The office came when the Rite was set

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. the Grove Era (GE); lit. 'the era of the grove'

3. the Children of the Question

4. the high custodian of the Rite; lit. 'high watcher'



in order (18 an Giblean, SE 6), and Dòmhnall mac Thormoid was the first to hold it (17 an Cèitean, SE 6). It is not the "high custodian" of the Age of Strangers, who headed the Council of Custodians; the two share a name in translation, and nothing more.

"The Àrd-choimheadaiche at Seann Skell writes to every house of the Rite that the new fuel is not forbidden, since it is not coal, and not blessed, since it is not coal." — annals, DE 4

## B

**Binnean a' Chlachair**<sup>6</sup> *n. m.* · lit. "the Mason's point" The highest summit of the island. When the gold coal had woken in the sea, the Mason's children carried the coals that were left to the highest point they knew and dropped them from it, and the snowflake coal took fire in the falling; from that day the height has borne their name. The tellers say that Lugh stood on it with Caoran on the first evening and named the winds. See *Seachd Guail, na*.

"It was Lugh who stood with Caoran on the highest summit of the island on the first evening and named the winds for him, and so the snowflake coal is his in honour." — the Telling of the Making

**Blàr Àth na Fala**<sup>7</sup> *n. m.* · lit. "the battle of the ford of the blood" The last battle of Ailean Mòr, fought at the ford below Dùn dhearg, east of the vein. The households of Dùn dhearg, who had never bowed, came against the king with every spear of the east, and he held the ford alone three days and three nights until the dead of the host dammed the river; on the third night he fell, worn down by the whole host, for his kin, quarrelling already over the shares of the kingdom, did not come (2 an t-Sultain, FE 1). The ford has been *Àth na Fala*<sup>8</sup>, the Ford of Blood, since. Three weeks after it the heirs swore the Binding (23 an t-Sultain, FE 1). In the east the battle's saying is still used of any great thing brought low by many small ones.

*Cha do leag aon duine e; leag an sluagh uile e.* "No one man brought him down; the whole host brought him down." — the Second Book

**Bliadhnachan Fada, na** *n. pl.* · lit. "the long years" The long lives of Ailean Mòr and his children, as the reciters of Clann na Ceiste tell them. The first king lived four thou-

5. the order of Bride's flame

6. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

7. the Battle of the Ford of Blood

8. the Ford of Blood, below Dùn dhearg

sand six hundred and twenty-six years, and did not die of them: he fell in war at the Ford of Blood (2 an t-Sultain, FE 1). The power of the coals was his alone, and the long years were his children's portion of it, those born after the grove; they lived two and three thousand years, and their children less, each generation shorter-lived than the one before. In the line of his son Somhairle, who lived two thousand nine hundred and eighty-seven years (7 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,025), the years ran two thousand two hundred and thirteen in Beathan, then one thousand five hundred and ninety-four, one thousand one hundred and forty-eight, eight hundred and twenty-six, five hundred and ninety-seven, four hundred and thirty-one, three hundred and eight, two hundred and twenty-four in Gille-Brìde, and a hundred and forty in Ceallach, early in the Holy Age, and then they were gone. The Mason's line keeps these years beside the names, as it keeps the years of all its dead. Since the Holy Age the long years have belonged to the tellings, and the Library keeps them in its book of tellings, apart from the lines. Said of a very old person the phrase is kindly; said of a claim, it means a tale.

"When there was no one left alive who had seen a man of three hundred, there was no one to swear to it, and a thing no one can swear to goes into the tellings." — the Second Book

**bonn-rioghachd** *n. m.* · lit. "realm-coin" Currency. Under the humans the coin was the mark, and barter was driven out in three reforms (13 an Gearran, AE 17, 2 an Dàmhair, AE 86, 7 an Giblean, AE 129). The Dia-thiris word belongs to the coinage struck when the humans' coin was withdrawn (30 an Giblean, SE 5). Its first mint-master was called Fearchar Bonn from his work (9 an Dàmhair, SE 5). After the re-pegging to dubhan (5 an Cèitean, DE 15) the realm-coin no longer rested on the vein.

"Within a year a new coinage of the Rìoghachd takes its place, minted with ink of coal dust in its seal." — annals, SE 5

## C

**Caoran** *n. m.* · lit. "ember" The Young God, *an Dia Òg*<sup>9</sup>, youngest son of an Dagda<sup>10</sup> and Danu. Each god of his line made a world of the thing dearest to him when he came of age; Caoran chose coal, and out of coal he made all that is, the earth last of all; the island was not made but born, of drops of fire from his last coal, and in the island's coal he hid the elements. He is the maker of this world and the god of the coal. The Old Faith still honours an Dagda first, as father of the gods (Appendix B). The name is

9. the Young God, Caoran

10. the Good God, father of the gods

the word for an ember such as lies in the ash of a spent fire, for it was from such an ember, under his father's cauldron, that he took the first coal.

"He looked at the coal in his son's hand for a long time, and then he said, 'It will do.' It is said that no word of his was ever dearer to Caoran." — the Telling of the Making

**carbad-iarainn** *n. m.* · lit. "iron-chariot" A train; the first of the *iarainn* words Diathiris made for machines. The kingdom mended the humans' coal line (9 an Dàmhair, SE 8) and ran its own first train on 3 an Dàmhair, SE 12.

"The first coal train runs from the Sloc Mòr to Cathair dhearg in the kingdom's name, on the humans' rails." — annals, SE 12

**Cha do chaill sinn blàr, ach chaill sinn an teine** *phr.* · lit. "we did not lose a battle, but we lost the fire" A defeat without fighting. An unsigned verse of the cold shires, from the day Ragnall Ruadh refused the measured handful to every hearth that stood against him (24 am Faoilleach, LE 558).

"...this deed turns more against him than any battle." — annals, LE 558

**Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann** *phr.* · lit. "we did not come; we were here" The doctrine of the Ancient Age, complete on Calbh Cnoc ghorm<sup>11</sup> (6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851). Who cut it is not known.

"Here, it may be, the belief was first spoken." — annals, VE 4,851

**Cha loisc clach na beinne do choigrich** *phr.* · lit. "the mountain's stone will not burn for strangers" The Keepers' ruling that no coal might feed a beacon (30 an Cèitean, FE 148). It held until the humans' towers were lit with a coal flame (22 an t-Sultain, AE 91).

"The Keepers rule that no coal may feed a beacon, since a beacon burns for strangers." — annals, FE 148

**Cha tàinig long** *phr.* · lit. "no ship came" The entry in the beacon-keepers' daybooks from the Severance on, after the council had the five beacons relit (19 an Dùbhlachd, AE 150).

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11. the column at Cnoc ghorm

"The keepers' daybooks, which had counted human ships since the ring was finished, are still kept, with nothing in them." — annals, AE 150

**Chaidh an gual dhachaigh** *phr.* · lit. "the coal went home" The tellings' words for the coal taken by Gilleasbuig Beag (2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,409), which was neither burned nor kept but laid back under the slab (4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,411).

"The tellings make much of it: the coal went home." — annals, GE 2,411

**Cidhe an Diosail**<sup>12</sup> *n. m.* · lit. "the quay of the sunwise turn" The berth at Seann Skell from which the fleet of the Sundering sailed. Its old name, Cidhe an Iar, passed to a new fish-wharf so that trade could go on without the memory (13 am Màrt, LE 67, 15 an Lùnastal, LE 67).

"The departure berth is entered in the harbour rolls of Seann Skell as Cidhe an Diosail, the quay of the sunwise turn." — annals, LE 67

**Clann a' Chlachair**<sup>13</sup> *n. pl.* · lit. "the Mason's children" The line of the mason who broke into the coal vein and carried home the first fire (20 am Faoilleach, VE 1). It is recited from the mason down, each son of each father (Appendix A, *The Line of the Mason*). To one of this line the Keeper of the Kin gave the Telling of the Making, and in this line the seven coals were woken, one by one, over many generations. By the waking of the fire coal its people were known as *Luchd-ceasnachaidh a' Ghuail Dhiombhair*<sup>14</sup>.

"The mason's children kept the telling after, father to son and mother to daughter, and said it over at the dark of the year word for word, and long afterward it was written down." — the Telling of the Making

**Clann na Ceiste** *n. pl.* · lit. "the children of the question" The short name of *Luchd-ceasnachaidh a' Ghuail Dhiombhair*, the name the recited lists use. The question is the one their forebear put to the Keeper in the grove of Doire ghlas: why the coal has colours in it. Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings, was of them (9 an Lùnastal, GE 1).

"...who had asked it why the coal of Dia-thìr has colours in it when the coal of the common earth has none." — the Telling of the Making

**Clann nan Dè**<sup>15</sup> *n. pl.* · lit. "the children of the gods" The godkin: the people of the island, descended from the godfolk, *an Dia-shluagh*<sup>16</sup>. The name is kept in the Old Faith

12. the quay of the sunwise turn at Seann Skell

13. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

14. the Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal

and in the style of the first king, *Rìgh Chlann nan Dè*<sup>17</sup>. Only the eyes of the godkin see the colours of the coal; the humans, when they came, saw black coal and nothing more (23 an Giblean, AE 3).

"And the Young God set the colours so that only the eyes of the godfolk and their children should see them." — the Telling of the Making

**Cogadh nam Bràithrean**<sup>18</sup> *n. m.* · lit. "the war of the brothers" The war between Iain Ciar and Alasdair Bàn, named from its first battle (8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,270).

"The houses divide four to three, and from this battle Cogadh nam Bràithrean, the Brothers' War, takes its name." — annals, LE 1,270

**Coimhdeach na Fine**<sup>19</sup> *n. m.* · lit. "the keeper of the kin" The spirit that watches over the island's people for Caoran. It is neither god nor ghost; it has no feast and no house, and when it shows itself it comes as a figure of smoke. It came to one of the Mason's line in the grove of Doire ghlas, told him the Telling of the Making and gave him the riddle (see *Luchd-ceasnachaidh a' Ghuail Dhiomhair*); generations later it came again to the grove, lit the rainbow coal, and bade Ailean Mòr keep watch over the coals until they were cold (21 an t-Iuchar, VE 5,324). In the Age of Strangers, the camps say, it stood in a deep gallery at Achadh dhomhain before Donnchadh mac Thormoid, a hewer of Ailean's line, and gave him the gift that woke in his daughter Aisling (see *Tiodhlac a' Choimhdich*<sup>20</sup>). The Keepers of Brìde's flame in the Holy Age share its name in the common tongue and nothing else.

"It is neither a god nor a ghost." — the Telling of the Making

**Comann nan Saor-luinge**<sup>21</sup> *n. m.* · lit. "the fellowship of the ship-wrights" The guild that built the fleet of the Sundering (24 an t-Sultain, LE 5). It melted away when no more ocean-going hulls were wanted (27 an t-Ògmhios, LE 84).

"The custody-book names it Comann nan Saor-luinge, the fellowship of the ship-wrights." — annals, LE 5

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15. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

17. king of the godkin, the first king's style

18. the Brothers' War

19. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

20. the Keeper's gift

21. the shipwrights' fellowship

**Còmhrag** *n. f.* · lit. "combat" With the article, the yearly melee at Ceann leathan (4 am Màrt, SE 23), fought on the field of the Holy Age road-guards' games (9 an Giblean, FE 1,665).

"Two men die in the melee he wins." — annals, of the first champion, SE 23

**crìdhe-iarainn** *n. m.* · lit. "iron-heart" An engine. The annals first have need of it for the shunting engines at Muileann chrom (8 an t-Iuchar, SE 13), and again when the Shipwrights' Guild court ruled that fitting one to a boat was not shipwrighting (23 an Giblean, DE 6).

"The families of the yard, who work the small engines that move the wagons, are counted apart by the Board and live apart in rows beside the lines." — annals, SE 13

**cuimhne-coinneimh** *n. f.* · lit. "meeting-memory" Minutes. Above all, those of the Moot at Caol mhòr, which has no standing in Dia-thìreach law and has kept its minutes since its first sitting (25 an Lùnastal, SE 2). See *Tha e scrìobhte a-nis*.

"It meets all the same and keeps its own minutes, which run unbroken from that day to this." — annals, SE 2

## D

**Dia Òg, an** *n. m.* · lit. "the young god" Caoran, youngest of the Tuath Dè. The making of the world was his coming of age, for in his line a god was a child until he had made a thing and kept it. See *Caoran*.

"He is called an Dia Òg, the Young God, and he is young still, as the gods reckon on it." — the Telling of the Making

**Dia-shluagh, an** *n. m.* · lit. "the god-host" The godfolk, the first people of the earth. Caoran did not shape them: he laid his palms on the warm ground in the middle of the island and called, and they grew out of it like grass after spring rain, and he gave them the island to keep (see *feur uaine an eilein*). Many lives after, when they had forgotten that the island was ever new, they found the coloured coal, did not understand it and let it lie. Their children are *Clann nan Dè*. The doctrine *Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann* is theirs in its oldest sense.

"'This is yours,' the Young God said to them. 'Keep it, and it will keep you.'" — the Telling of the Making

**diosal** *adv., n. m.* · lit. "sunwise" The sunwise turn. The fleet went once round the river pool of Seann Skell sunwise (19 an Giblean, LE 40), and the years were counted from that turn (22 an Faoilleach, LE 44).

"...they meant to go round the river pool, sunwise, *diosal*, as you walk round a well or a new-built house for luck." — the Fourth Book

**dòrlach** *n. m.* · lit. "a handful" The sealed measure of coal. The vein-house allowed one to each departing ship (17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 25). See *Làn na glaise*.

*Dòrlach airson an teallaich ùir, / is an seann teallach fhathast blàth.* "A handful for the new hearth, and the old hearth still warm." — the Fourth Book

**Dubh an gual, 's dubh an dubhan** *phr.* · lit. "black the coal, and black the dubhan" A rhyme of the north, heard in both tongues, from the years when the coinage was pegged to the new fuel (5 an Cèitean, DE 15).

*Dubh an gual, 's dubh an dubhan, / ach cò leis an teine?* "Black the coal, and black the dubhan; but whose is the fire?" — the Seventh Book

**dubhan** *n. m.* · lit. "the black one" (*dubh* + *-an*) The made fuel, written with a small letter. From the name of Dubhan, born SE 29, whose first working fuel came on 19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1. So a man's name wore down into a common noun.

"...for the fuel itself, as well as for the man who made it, years before the trade built upon it is whole." — annals, DE 11

**dubhan-tùsail** *n. m.* · lit. "dubhan of the beginning" A rough first attempt that looked like a dead end and later mattered; used in any field. From Dubhan's failed experiments (1 an t-Iuchar, SE 61). First recorded in a letter of the druid school at Caol shean, of the school's own revival (22 an Dàmhair, DE 11).

"It is used of a first attempt that seemed a dead end and proved otherwise..."  
— annals, DE 11

## F

**fadachadh** *v.n. m.* · lit. "lengthening", from *fadaich*, *fada* To be crushed after holding out too long; *am fadachadh*, a total and final defeat. Narrowed by An Cogadh Fada<sup>22</sup>, from Àth leathan (11 an Giblean, DE 21) to Muileann ghlas (10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22),

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22. the Long War

and first heard among Tuathaich speakers of their own defeat (10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22).

"... 'chaidh am fadachadh', they got long-warred... It is said as a jest, and those who say it do not laugh." — annals, DE 22

**faire-obrach** *n. f.* · lit. "work-watch" A shift. The annals first have need of it for the humans' night-shift order (25 an Lùnastal, AE 116), which the kingdom kept (18 an t-Samhain, SE 11).

*Cha d' fhuair a' bheinn fois a-riamb, / is cha d' fhuair sinne.* "The mountain never got its rest, and neither did we." — the hewers' saying, the Sixth Book

**Fèill** *n. f.* · lit. "feast-day, fair" With a town's name, a fair; above all Fèill Muileann òg<sup>23</sup> (16 an Dàmhair, SE 21), heir to the harvest fair held there after the War of the Roads (5 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,665).

"A fair is held each year at Muileann òg, and it becomes the greatest gathering on the island." — annals, SE 21

**feur uaine an eilein** *phr.* · lit. "the green grass of the island" The people of the island, in the oldest tellings. The godfolk grew up out of Dia-thìr on the first morning as the green grass comes up after the spring rain, and so the island is the elder of their line: they spring up and are cut down and spring up again, and the island is their root. A line said in full at a naming ends in it (see *sloinneadh*), as the Line of Aisling does (21 an Dàmhair, AE 126).

"So the tellings call the people of the island *feur uaine an eilein*, the green grass of the island." — the Telling of the Making

**Fo mhullach an taighe, chan eil nàmh ann** *phr.* · lit. "under the roof of the house there is no enemy" The road-peace, the oldest law on the island that neither Keeper nor lord made (22 an Dàmhair, FE 175). The War of the Roads ended under such a roof (4 an Dàmhair, FE 1,006).

"...no feud may be pursued under an inn roof or within a spear's throw of its door." — annals, FE 175

**fuil-ghuail**<sup>24</sup> *n. f.* · lit. "coal-blood" The condition of those who bond with the vein and do not age as others do, and the people who have it. For half a century it had no

23. the fair at Muileann òg



name (13 am Faoilleach, AE 71), until the custodians made this one (23 am Faoilleach, AE 126). The humans rendered it *coal-touched*. The custodians' word names only what the thing looked like to them. The camps hold that it is the Keeper's gift woken (see *Tiodhlac a' Choimbdich*), and that the first to have it, Aisling, was of the first king's line; and that much the copyists of Muileann chaol found to stand in the lines (21 an Dàmhair, AE 126).

"It is meant as a physician's word. It outlives that meaning." — annals, AE 126

## G

**Gaoth Dhubh, A' n. f.** · lit. "the black wind" The oldest storm whose name is kept (1 an Gearran, GE 2,417); the first named storm lost its name (30 am Faoilleach, GE 147). The harbour rolls went on naming storms: Am Fuath Mòr<sup>25</sup>, "the great hate" (23 an t-Samhain, LE 259), and An Gàire Dubh<sup>26</sup>, "the black laugh" (5 am Màrt, LE 519).

"Of all storms it is the eldest whose name is kept." — annals, GE 2,417

**gual dathach, an n. m.** · lit. "the coloured coal" The coal of Dia-thìr, in which Caoran hid the elements, each in its own colour; there is none anywhere else in the world. Its seven kinds are *na Seachd Guail*<sup>27</sup>. Only the godkin see its colours: to the humans it was black coal and no more (23 an Giblean, AE 3), where Gormshuil nic Fhearchair had forty words for the colours of it broken (13 an Dùbhlachd, AE 2). *Gual* alone is coal of any kind, and the Library writes *an gual dathach*<sup>28</sup> where it must be plain which is meant.

"Together they are called an gual dathach, the coloured coal. There is no coloured coal anywhere in the world but on Dia-thìr, for the gift was for Dia-thìr alone." — the Telling of the Making

**gun chreideamh**<sup>29</sup> *adj. phr.* · lit. "without a faith" Of land or people that keep none of the three faiths. The first census of the restored kingdom so entered the far north-western cape beyond Baile chrom, Eilean ghorm and the smallest islets (30 an t-Iuchar, SE 7); the phrase has stood on the map for that land since.

24. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

25. the great hate, the storm that drowned Seann Toll's boats

26. the Black Laugh

27. the Seven Coals

28. the coloured coal

29. without a faith

"All these they enter as *gun chreideamh*, without a faith." — annals, SE 7

## I

**Ithidh Mòd an neach a dh'itheas an cnoc** *phr.* · lit. "Mòd will eat whoever eats the hill" The saying of the feathered doors, from the years when the hawk-priests were barred and the crews carried the Hawk order's sermons themselves (10 an Cèitean, AE 76). Mòd is the Hawk of Acaill, as old as Fionntan mac Bòchra, and the hill is the vein.

"The overseers' reports of these years list hawk-feathers nailed above hut doors as a matter for punishment." — annals, AE 76

## L

**Lagh an Loscaidh Bhig**<sup>30</sup> *n. m.* · lit. "the law of the small burning" The Small-Burning Law: no household might burn more than a measured handful of coal in a season (13 an Lùnastal, FE 142). The ruling of the hearth bound the custodians never to withhold that handful (12 an Gearran, LE 565). The Law was never repealed; it lapsed (2 an Dùbhlachd, AE 21).

"The Law is never repealed; once its keeping no longer pays, it is no longer kept." — annals, AE 21

**Làn na glaise, 's gun tuilleadh** *phr.* · lit. "the fill of the hollow hand, and no more" The measure of the Age of Ailean (5 an Lùnastal, GE 1,011). When Fionnlagh Dall recut the stone cup to hold two palms (15 an t-Iuchar, FE 139), the saying became *Làn an dà bhois, agus gun tuilleadh*.

"It is nowhere written and everywhere kept." — annals, GE 1,011

**Loisc iad an leabhar, ach cha do loisc iad an cnoc** *phr.* · lit. "they burned the book, but they did not burn the hill" Said of the raids on the tithe ledgers (9 an t-Iuchar, AE 150).

"Later chroniclers make much of it; it did little." — annals, AE 150

**Luchd-ceasnachaidh a' Ghuail Dhìomhair** *n. pl.* · lit. "the questioners of the hidden coal" The Inquisitors of the Mystic Coal: the name that *Clann a' Chlachair* bore by the time the fire coal was woken, from the generations they had spent in asking what

30. the Small-Burning Law; lit. 'the law of the small burning'

the Keeper's riddle meant. *Diombhair* is hidden, secret, holy in the way of things not told. The recited lists shorten it to *Clann na Ceiste*.

*Tha spiorad fa leth san speur, san talamh agus sa mhuir. Meascaich na spioradan agus bidh iad uile-chumhachdach.* "The sky, the earth and the sea each carry their own spirit. Merge the spirits, and they become almighty." — the Keeper's riddle, the Telling of the Making

## M

**maor** *n. m., pl. maoir* · lit. "steward" Under the humans, an overseer: a Dia-thìreach set over Dia-thìrich for the Company. Ragnall mac Dhòmhnaill took his byname from the office (19 an Cèitean, AE 36, 17 an t-Ògmhios, AE 36). The kingdom gave the word to the Crown's officer in each shire (4 am Faoilleach, SE 4). The kenning *maor-obrach*, "work-steward", is a manager.

"...from the office the Dia-thìrich give him his byname: Ragnall Maor, Ragnall the steward." — annals, AE 36

**mar a thàinig Niall** *phr.* · lit. "the way Niall came" Any passing of power that goes uncommonly smoothly. From Niall's crowning (19 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3), which passed without dispute (7 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3).

"It is first found written in a tavern ledger at Cathair dhearg, against a debt settled without argument." — annals, SE 3

**Marbh-bheò**<sup>31</sup> *n. m.* · lit. "dead-alive" The Hollow Man of the Doire uaine hills, which attacked anyone who lit a fire in its sight (9 an Giblean, VE 3,251). The rule against open fires after dark came from it (26 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,460), and shepherds still named it when they left the high pastures (17 an Lùnastal, LE 949).

*Na las teine far am faic e thu.* "Light no fire where it can see you." — the First Book

## N

**nighean an rìgh** *phr.* · lit. "the king's daughter" What the camps called Aisling (7 am Màrt, AE 69), half in jest and half not, from the whisper that she was of the blood of Ailean Mòr, the first king: a hope drawn from an old tale, in a people whose hill was

31. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

going out in ships. The copyists of Muileann chaol later found it stand in the lines (21 an Dàmhair, AE 126). No annal marks its first use.

"In the camps they called her *nighean an rìgh*, the king's daughter, half in jest, as *Aisling-aois* is said now of anyone who keeps her youth; and half not." — the Fifth Book

## O

**ogham** *n. m.* · lit. "Ogma's letters" The letters of Dia-thìr. The teachers of the stag's people made them from the cutters' tally-notches (15 am Màrt, FE 914), and the druids name them for Ogma, god of letters. Nearly every later hand on the island descends from them (Appendix F).

"These are the first letters the Dia-thìrich use: the ogham, which the druids call the gift of Ogma." — annals, FE 914

## R

**rìgh** *n. m.* · lit. "king" A ruler of the lowlands, as against the Keeper of the flame. Go-raidh mac Ìomhair was the first of them so called (28 an Cèitean, FE 674). Before him only Ailean Mòr had borne the word, named *Rìgh Chlann nan Dè* by Caoran in the grove (28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1); at the Roinn his heirs swore that none of them would take it (1 an t-Samhain, FE 2). Under the division of keeping the rìgh had the roads and the granaries, the Keeper the flame (9 an t-Sultain, FE 694).

"No one had been so called since Ailean Mòr, for at the Roinn the heirs swore that none of them would take the word." — annals, FE 674

**Rìgh Chlann nan Dè** *n. m.* · lit. "king of the children of the gods" The style of the first king of the island's people. After the seven coals had burned together and the seven-night vigil was kept, Caoran came with the Tuath Dè, named Ailean Mòr so, and put into him the power that had been in the coals. Ailean told no one of it, all his life, and he was king from that night until he fell at the Ford of Blood (see *Blàr Àth na Fala*). It was his alone and went with him, and his children had of it only their long years (see *Bliadhnachan Fada, na*); with it he took the hill of Dùn ìseal and made the first kingdom (9 an Lùnastal, GE 1).

"When the godfolk had grown up out of the heather, Macha looked them over, one by one, and said that there was no king among them yet." — the Telling of the Making

**Rìghrean na Cloiche**<sup>32</sup> *n. pl.* · lit. "the kings of the stone" The oldest oral king-list, opening with Ailean Mòr (9 an Lùnastal, GE 1). It names those who held the hill of Dùn ìseal, the king first and after him those of his blood who held it under him, and it ends with Catrìona Mhòr, after whom the king held the hill himself (12 am Màrt, GE 4,391). The name was given to it later.

"...it gives no lengths of reign, and it is older than the name Dia-thirich." — annals, GE 1

**rogghnaich** *v.* · lit. "choose" With no object: to have chosen the crossing, to choose exile for good. From the Choosing (8 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1); the narrow sense is in the custody-book from 21 an Lùnastal, LE 67. The plain sense was never lost.

*Roghnaich iadsan, agus dh'fhuirich sinne.* "They chose, and we stayed." — the Fourth Book

## S

**scàinte** *adj.* · lit. "rent, split" Reeling, shaken, of a person as well as a building. From Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>33</sup>, the Rending (9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 137). No annal marks its first use.

"Dozens are killed, and a whole mining district is shut for a generation." — annals, AE 137

**Scaradh, a'** *n. m.* · lit. "the parting" The Sundering (19 an Giblean, LE 40); loosely, any lasting parting, chosen, between people who belonged together. Later it was used also of the Severance (1 am Faoilleach, AE 151), which was not chosen, and the one word now serves for both.

"The chronicles of the island fall silent on them as the ships clear the harbour..." — annals, LE 40

**Seachd Guail, na** *n. pl.* · lit. "the seven coals" The seven kinds of the coloured coal, each holding one element and each woken by its own element and by nothing else.

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32. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

33. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

The Mason's line learned to wake them over many generations, the gold coal first and the rainbow coal last; that is why the Ancient Age is so long.

| COAL                     | COLOUR             | HOLDS       | HOW IT WAS WOKEN                                     |
|--------------------------|--------------------|-------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>gual dubh</i>         | black              | the earth   | buried deep; warm on the next day                    |
| <i>gual teine</i>        | the colour of fire | fire        | dust on the hands, at the snap of the fingers        |
| <i>gual sneachda</i>     | snowflake          | the air     | dropped from Binnean a' Chlachair                    |
| <i>gual òir</i>          | gold sheen         | the sea     | thrown into the sea                                  |
| <i>gual airgid</i>       | silver sheen       | river water | thrown into a river                                  |
| <i>gual donn-ruadh</i>   | mahogany           | life        | the blood of a misstrike, in the grove               |
| <i>gual bogha-froise</i> | rainbow            | the spirit  | lit by the Keeper when the six were brought together |

The first king kept watch over them seven nights, one for each coal, and on the eighth they were cold (28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1).

"These are na Seachd Guail, the Seven Coals, and this is what each holds." — the Telling of the Making

**seann-chunntas** *n. m.* · lit. "old account" A grievance nobody in power acts on and nobody cancels. Tuathaich speakers coined it (18 an Giblean, DE 26) for the tabled archive request (15 an Gearran, DE 17) and the reparations motion left to die (10 an t-Ògmhios, DE 25).

"The Dia-thìrich in office do not take up the word." — annals, DE 26

**Seann-Dhaoine**<sup>34</sup> *n. pl.* · lit. "old people" The Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich. The name is a plain Dia-thìris description, and no annal dates it. Their first sure trace is the midden at Seann Dunn (28 an Lùnastal, VE 751).

"The Seann-Dhaoine, whoever they were, who built Làrach an Dùin-fhaire and Làrach an Dùin..." — annals, GE 348

**siorrachd** *n. f., pl. siorrachdan* · lit. "shire" Named in the annals from the Age of Sundering (9 an t-Samhain, LE 9). The kingdom redrew the shires on the humans' district lines (12 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3), and has had a hundred and twenty-three since SE 38 (Appendix H).

"...the kingdom uses them and says nothing of it." — annals, SE 3

34. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

**sliochd** *n. m.* · lit. "seed, offspring" A house of custody known by a founder's name, not a hearth. Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>35</sup> was the first (11 an t-Sultain, FE 96); four were bound to the Keepers' office (29 an Giblean, FE 385).

"...the first house of custody known by a name and not by a hearth." — annals, FE 96

**sloinneadh** *n. m.* · lit. "surname, pedigree" A line of descent said aloud, and above all the naming-line, which Clann na Ceiste give at a child's naming backward from the child to the fire, and on to the godfolk and the island. Of a stranger's child they give it in short form, the long stretches told as a count of generations. The Line of Aisling was given so, by Ealasaid of Clann na Ceiste to the copyist Cailean mac Eachainn (21 an Dàmhair, AE 126).

"...son of Neachdan, who found the fire; son of the godfolk, who grew out of the island like grass; and the island was born of Caoran's fire." — the Fifth Book

**stad-oibre** *n. m.* · lit. "work-halt" A strike. The first lasted eleven days (13 an Dàmhair, AE 77); the first held in several regions on one day came in AE 143.

"The strike ends when the food, which the humans' Administration holds, runs out." — annals, AE 77

T

**Tha an long ag ithe a' chnuic** *phr.* · lit. "the ship is eating the hill" Fearchar Bàrd's most quoted song, made when the Company's steamships began to burn the island's coal to carry it away (15 an Gearran, AE 103).

*Tha an long ag ithe a' chnuic / gus an cnoc a ghiùlan air falbh.* "The ship is eating the hill to carry the hill away." — the Fifth Book

**Tha e sgrìobhte a-nis** *phr.* · lit. "it is written now" The Moot's whole minute on the day the census figures were read at Caol mhòr (6 an t-Samhain, SE 64). The Sixth Book takes it for its epigraph.

"The Moot's minute says only: 'Now written.'" — annals, SE 64

**Tiodhlac a' Choimhdich** *n. m.* · lit. "the Keeper's gift" What the Keeper of the Kin gave the kin in the deep galleries in the Age of Strangers. The Keeper will not gift for

the kin; this it gave them so that a people with its hill dug out from under it should have something of its own to stand with against the strangers. It was breathed first by Donnchadh mac Thormoid at Achadh dhomhain, in the first winter of that camp (1 am Faoilleach, AE 68); the Mission's surgeon took it for the lung-rot; and it woke in his daughter Aisling (7 am Màrt, AE 69). The camps say it lies in the dust of the deep places for every one of the kin who goes down, and that the coal-blood children after her came of it. The name is the camps'. The rolls do not use it.

"A gift. It is not for you. You will carry it, and the carrying will not be easy. It will wake in your daughter." — the Fifth Book

**Tìr Thall, an** *n. f.* · lit. "the land beyond" The humans' homeland, whose own name no Dia-thìreach scribe set down (26 an Gearran, AE 2).

"From the first season the scribes call it an Tìr Thall, the land beyond, and its people simply the humans." — annals, AE 2

**tonn** *n. m.* · lit. "wave" A sudden, overwhelming change: *tha e san tonn*, "he is in the wave of it". From Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol<sup>36</sup> (3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 4), by way of the survivors' accounts (4 am Faoilleach, SE 5).

"Within a generation the sense is heard across the south." — annals, SE 5

**Tràigh Bhàthte, an** *n. f.* · lit. "the drowned strand" The old site of Cnoc chaol, left as the Great Wave left it (23 an Dùbhlachd, SE 4).

"The townsfolk call it an Tràigh Bhàthte, the drowned strand, and do not build there." — annals, SE 4

**Tùrsa Geal, an** *n. m.* · lit. "the white sorrow" The mourning for the departed, neither wholly grief nor wholly rejoicing (1 an Lùnastal, LE 54), first kept at court by Queen Beathag for her sister (27 an Dàmhair, LE 54). In a much later age it was used again, uneasily, for a departure of a very different kind.

"...with one place left empty at a meal that is neither feast nor fast." — annals, LE 54

35. the house of Muireach

36. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'



## U

**uaine** *adj.* · lit. "green" Beside its plain sense, sickly, plague-marked. From A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>37</sup> (9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 73), first seen as a greenish pallor at Achadh dhomhain (5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 73).

"...in a field beyond the spoil-heaps still called the green acre." — annals, AE 73

## Of What Is Not Known

Fewer first uses can be proved than a reader might wish. *Scàinte*, *Aisling-aois* and the loose sense of *a' Scaradh*<sup>38</sup> stand on the chronicle's list, but no annal marks the day any of them was first said. The rope-makers of Cuan shean sing a keel-song whose words have lost their sense (5 am Màrt, LE 1,389). The Tuathaich's own memory of the Long War is filed as folklore, and the northern towns' own accounts are among the things the royal record says it does not hold (25 an Giblean, SE 43). Where the history of a word is lost, the gap is left as it is.

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37. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

38. the Sundering; lit. 'the parting'



APPENDIX F

# The Tongues and Peoples of Dia-thìr

Here is gathered what the rolls and chronicles hold of the peoples who have lived on Dia-thìr and of the speech they used. It is drawn from the royal chronicles, from the rolls and custody-books copied into Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>1</sup>, from the map of the kingdom, and from the word-lists that survive from the Age of Strangers. Where the sources are silent, that is said, and the silence is left as it was found.

## I. The Peoples

Five peoples, or kinds of people, stand in the island's history. Two of them are gone. One, the *fuil-ghuail*<sup>2</sup>, is hardly a people in the common sense of the word; yet the chronicles have come to speak of it as one, and so it is set down here with the rest.

| PEOPLE                 | DIA-THÌRIS NAME                                                     | IN THE CHRONICLES                                  | ON THE MAP TODAY                                           |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Old Ones           | <i>na Scann-Dhaoine</i>                                             | Ages I and II; their works end before the Holy Age | no town; thirty towns and thirteen shires bear their names |
| The people of Dia-thìr | <i>na Dia-thìrich</i> (sg. <i>Dia-thìreach</i> )                    | every age                                          | 441 of 505 towns; the capital and the sea                  |
| The humans             | the chronicles' plain name for them                                 | Age V                                              | none by that name; their descendants are the Tuathaich     |
| The northern-ers       | <i>na Tuathaich</i> (sg. <i>Tuathach</i> )                          | Ages VI and VII                                    | 64 towns in the north and north-west                       |
| The coal-blooded       | <i>an fhuil-ghuail</i> ; in the humans' tongue, <i>coal-touched</i> | from Age V                                         | not counted on the map; counted, briefly, in the censuses  |

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

## THE SEANN-DHAOINE

The Dia-thìrich call the people before them *na Seann-Dhaoine*<sup>3</sup>, the Old Ones. The name is a Dia-thìris one, given from outside. What the Old Ones called themselves is not known, and cannot now be known.

**What survives of them** is stone, shell and names. The oldest sure trace is the midden at Seann Dunn (28 an Lùnastal, VE 751): limpet shell, seal bone and burnt weed, laid down over many lifetimes, with no tool in it shaped the way any later Dia-thìreach shaped tools. After it come the notched net-weights of Seann Chwen, every stone cut with the same three strokes (26 an t-Sultain, VE 820); the unmortared mole at Seann Skell on which every later quay wall there stands (1 an t-Iuchar, VE 951); the two hundred and twelve steps of Seann Bhral (30 an t-Iuchar, VE 1,027); the stone boxes on Eilean dhearg to which the dead of Seann Vell were rowed (4 an Cèitean, VE 1,096); the fish-channel of Seann Toll (2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 1,170); the shell causeway of Seann Warr, the first made road on the island that can still be walked (7 am Màrt, VE 1,233); the fish-kilns of Seann Mhorn (17 an Giblean, VE 1,443); and the slipways of Seann Bhrenn, wide enough for hulls bigger than any hide boat; the hulls are gone, and so is any telling of where they went (16 an Cèitean, VE 1,515).

At their widest reach (8 an Cèitean, VE 3,872) they held every coast of the island: the ten places whose names begin with *Seann*, and the islands off them. Their largest landing was at the place now called Seann Skell, on the Abhainn naomh.

**The ruins inland** are theirs by the oldest tellings. The telling of the counting of the dead (29 an Lùnastal, GE 348) names the Seann-Dhaoine as "the people who built Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>4</sup> and Làrach an Dùin". Làrach an Dùin-fhaire, the walled outpost on the spur above the ground where Cathair mhòr now stands, has a single gate, and it faces inland, away from the sea (19 an Cèitean, VE 2,524); Làrach an Dùin, near Ceann mhin, had three rings of wall and room inside for some four hundred people with their beasts (17 an t-Ògmhios, VE 2,576); and Làrach an Teampaill<sup>6</sup>, in the eastern hills, has its altar set square to the central mountains (14 an Lùnastal, VE 2,679), toward the vein and away from the sea. All three were already ruined when the first reliable chronicles begin (27 an t-Samhain, VE 4,023, 6 am Màrt, VE 4,124, 7 am Faoilleach, VE 4,275). Whether the builders of the outpost built the fortress too has never been settled. After the high places were left, every new work of the Seann-Dhaoine lies within sight of salt water (9 an Dùbhlachd, VE 4,325).

**The standing stones** are harder. Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>7</sup>, Colbh Cnoc chiar<sup>8</sup> and Calbh Cnoc ghorm<sup>9</sup> were raised in the Ancient Age (17 an t-Iuchar, VE 4,672, 9 an t-

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

4. the watch-fort ruin

Sultain, VE 4,770, 6 an t-Samhain, VE 4,851), and no telling says by whom. The upper face of Carragh Cnoc bheag bears a line of the unread script; the four Dia-thìris words, *Bha teine sa chloich*, "there was fire in the stone", lie lower down, cut with a narrower tool by another hand, and "when that second hand came is not known" (11 an Lùnastal, VE 4,718). So on Carragh Cnoc bheag the marks of two peoples lie on the same face. In few other places do they touch; one is the wind-stone at the central Seann Chwen, where a Dia-thìris wind-name is cut over an older mark of the Seann-Dhaoine (13 an Gearran, GE 2,447).

**Their counting.** Late in their time the Seann-Dhaoine began cutting single strokes on flat stones at the edges of their middens, one stone to a household (31 an t-Iuchar, GE 308). At the eastern Seann Warr the counting stones were built into a wall of some three thousand strokes (3 an t-Ògmhios, GE 389); at Seann Tarr in the north-east they were cut in fives and set in the floor of a house (2 an t-Iuchar, GE 428). At the Seann Chwen near Cuan dhearg the last tally stone was left half-cut: two strokes finished, a third begun and abandoned (5 an Cèitean, GE 510).

**Their end.** After the half-cut stone no new work of the Seann-Dhaoine can be dated. Their middens stop growing, their harbours silt, and their script is not cut again (7 an Gearran, GE 551). How they ended no telling knows, and no guess is offered here. The chronicles do not say that they were driven out, or that they died, or that their blood ran on in some later people; nor do they say otherwise.

**The hill-folk.** Alongside, or after, the Seann-Dhaoine the tellings set a second people: the hill-folk of the high valleys around the crack (10 an t-Samhain, VE 4,425), who buried their dead in the ground rather than on islands, and cut no script. They burned the coal, though sparingly: one sliver, one fire, at Àth gharbh (12 an Dàmhair, VE 4,475). Whether they shared the island with the Old Ones or came after them no telling knows. Their own answer, given later, is that they were always there, and it is the answer the Dia-thìrich give of themselves in the doctrine carried on Calbh Cnoc ghorm: *Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann*, "we did not come; we were here." When stag-scholars came to Calbh Cnoc ghorm in the Holy Age and could not read it, the people of Cnoc ghorm told them what it said, and "the scholars write that the people say so" (6 an Dàmhair, FE 2,376).

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7. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

8. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

5. the fortress ruin

6. the temple ruin

THE DIA-THÌRICH

The Dia-thìrich are the people of Dia-thìr: the majority in every age of the island's history, the holders of the capital, Cathair dhearg, and of the sea. Their name is the island's name with the people-ending, written *-ich* after the slender vowel of *thìr*; a single person is a *Dia-thìreach*. Writers of the humans' tongue called them *Dia-thìrian*, and that word is kept in this history for the adjective.

**Custodians.** The Dia-thìrich enter history as custodians. In the Age of Ailean a custom set in across the hill settlements that no fire should take more of the coal than one cupped hand could hold. The Binding of the First Flame (23 an t-Sultain, FE 1) made the custodianship of the vein a formal order, whose keepers were "older by centuries than any rìgh after Ailean", and the Small-Burning Law (13 an Lùnastal, FE 142) made the custom into rule. The Binding was sworn by the heirs of Ailean Mòr, gathered to part his kingdom, and the parting they swore after it, *Roinn na Rìoghachd*<sup>10</sup> (1 an t-Samhain, FE 2), cut the Dia-thìrich into great shares, provinces, counties and holdings under the king's kin, whose feuds, *Aimbreit nan Oighbrian*, ran until the Peace of the Threshold (1 an t-Samhain, FE 556). The first after Ailean to be called *rìgh* was Goraidh mac Ìomhair at Dùn dhearg (28 an Cèitean, FE 674), and he claimed nothing over the vein. For the whole of the Holy Age the kings ruled the roads and the granaries, and the Keepers at Dùn ìseal ruled the mountain. The Holy Age closes on the last age of even population (1 an Cèitean, FE 2,949). After it, the chroniclers note with some unease, there was never again a time on Dia-thìr when no family held more years of life than any other.

**The kingdom.** After the Severance the state restyled itself Rìoghachd Dia-thìr<sup>11</sup>, the Kingdom of Dia-thìr (27 an t-Iuchar, SE 2), and Niall was crowned at Cathair dhearg (19 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3). The rulers since are set down in Appendix A. Here it is enough to say that the kingdom is a Dia-thìreach kingdom: its schools teach in Dia-thìris "and it has no others" (10 an Gearran, SE 7), and the old apprentice-binding custom, when it was revived, was reserved for Dia-thìrich applicants only (20 an Dàmhair, SE 13).

**The sea.** The Dia-thìrich have always been a people of the coast as much as of the mountain. The largest towns on the map today stand on the sea or on the rivers that run down to it, and the two largest bear a name older than Dia-thìris:

| TOWN        | SHIRE       | FAITH (ORDER)                      | POPULATION |
|-------------|-------------|------------------------------------|------------|
| Seann Skell | Seann Skell | An Creideamh Sean (Òrd Mhanannain) | 74,120     |

10. the Division; lit. 'the parting of the kingdom'

11. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

| TOWN         | SHIRE        | FAITH (ORDER)                                | POPULATION |
|--------------|--------------|----------------------------------------------|------------|
| Seann Skell  | Seann Skell  | An Creideamh Sean (Òrd Bhrìde)               | 57,907     |
| Ros dhomhain | Ros dhomhain | An Creideamh Sean (Òrd Mhacha)               | 51,589     |
| Seann Bhral  | Seann Bhral  | Na Seann Spioradan                           | 49,681     |
| Cnoc bheag   | Cnoc bheag   | An Creideamh Sean (Òrd an t-Seabhaig)        | 49,661     |
| Cathair mhòr | Cathair mhòr | An Creideamh Sean (Òrd Mhacha)               | 49,298     |
| Caol bheag   | Caol bheag   | An Creideamh Sean (Scoiltean nan Draoidhean) | 42,649     |
| Achadh mhòr  | Achadh mhòr  | Na Seann Spioradan                           | 42,136     |

The capital itself is not among them. Cathair dhearg is counted at 10,274; its harbour, Ros dhomhain, is five times its size.

**The departed.** Part of the Dia-thìrich people is not on Dia-thìr. Land was found across the water (6 am Faoilleach, LE 1); volunteers chose to go, by "a vote, or what the later chroniclers call a vote" (8 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1); the fleet set out, turning sunwise round the river pool at Seann Skell, in the year from which the old count of the Diosal ran (19 an Giblean, LE 40). A broken report told of two landfalls (24 an Dùbhlachd, LE 44), and of the thinning: cut off from the vein, "by the third generation over the water nothing is left that Dia-thìr would know" (3 an t-Iuchar, LE 53). The departed stand in the chronicles only as a gap. The island kept them in rites (the empty-harbour rite, 25 an t-Samhain, LE 61; the white sorrow, *an Tùrsa Geal*<sup>12</sup>, 27 an Dàmhair, LE 54) and in words, of which more below. When the humans came, old sailors at Cuan shean remarked that the strangers had come in from the same quarter of sea the Sundering fleet once sailed into. The council forbade the remark in its hall; it was written down all the same, and never answered (9 an Gearran, AE 2). Whether the humans descend from the departed, no one on Dia-thìr knows.

## THE HUMANS OF AN TÌR THALL

**The Crossing.** Humans made landfall on Dia-thìr and were granted leave to stay (5 am Faoilleach, AE 1): the first contact since the Sundering. Three ships down from the north anchored off Cuan shean, and their master, whom the chronicles call Edmund Harrow, came ashore unarmed and asked by signs for water (5 an Gearran, AE 1). So the first dealing between the two peoples was made without words.

**Their homeland.** The strangers named their homeland in their own tongue, but no Dia-thìreach scribe set the word down. From the first season the chronicles call it *an Tìr Thall*<sup>13</sup>, the land beyond, and its people simply the humans (26 an Gearran, AE

12. the Mourning Custom; lit. 'the white sorrow'

2). Their own name for their country is written on Dia-thìr in no hand, and it cannot now be recovered.

**What they called things.** The humans' names for the island's things were few, plain and, to Dia-thìreach ears, careless. They had a single word for the coloured coal, and it was the word for the black fuel they burned at home; Gormshuil nic Fhearchair's copyist noted that no Dia-thìris word answered to it, and that the humans did not ask for one (23 an Giblean, AE 3). So *an gual dathach*<sup>14</sup>, the coloured coal of the vein, became in their tongue plain *coal*, and the custodians of the vein became, in Samuel Wren's otherwise careful grammar, "keepers of the coal" (21 an Lùnastal, AE 12). Their offices and bodies came with names in the humans' tongue and kept them (they are given here in English): the Company, the Administration, the Mission, the Residency above Ros dhomhain (10 an Cèitean, AE 9), the Commissioner, the Levy, the constable posts. Their faith was the Church, which the Dia-thìrich call *an Eaglais*, and the Mission was its house on Dia-thìr. Their coin was the *mark*. The townsfolk of Muileann shean called the constable post there "the humans' second Residency", and did not mean it kindly (11 an Dàmhair, AE 132).

**The camps.** What the humans built for themselves on Dia-thìr they built for the pit. The camp of timber huts at Àth ìseal was the first settlement on the island raised for the pit and for nothing else (6 an Dàmhair, AE 29); Baile dhomhain was laid out on a grid by a Company surveyor, the first Dia-thìreach town drawn on paper before it was built (10 am Faoilleach, AE 34); the camp at Achadh dhomhain was built of spoil (1 am Faoilleach, AE 68). Dia-thìreach hands worked the camps and human officers ruled them, and the record of them is kept in two tongues that seldom agree: the Mission counts four hundred and six dead of the spotted pox, and the custodians count more, and write the difference in the margin of the Mission's list (11 an Dàmhair, AE 39). Human families lived on Dia-thìr as well as human officers: upland pasture in the north-west, around Muileann àrsaidh, was granted for human families who would not work in the pits (3 an t-Samhain, AE 20). This was the first human settlement in the north; and to the north, in the end, their descendants were sent.

**Mixing.** The first mixed settlement (22 an Giblean, AE 5) was Baile dhìreach on the south-west coast, under a council of three Dia-thìrich and three humans, whose founding compact was written twice, once in each tongue, the only such compact on record in the age (10 an Dàmhair, AE 5). There the net-maker Eilidh nic Ruairidh married the human cooper Samuel Hale, and the council entered the marriage in both its books (26 an Cèitean, AE 7). It was not tried again, and the first inheritance case of

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13. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

14. the coloured coal



mixed blood (15 an Gearran, AE 111) the Administration decided wholly in its own favour.

**The going north.** War was declared in AE 149. Before the end, the human families of Ros bheag, Cuan shean, Baile dhìreach and the south-west marched north along the western roads under guard of the council's companies; few of them had ever lived in the north; no column was attacked, and none was helped (29 an t-Samhain, AE 150). The war ended with the crossing itself closed (1 am Faoilleach, AE 151). Whatever way had let the humans reach Dia-thìr was shut, and those still on the island were herded to the northern country their descendants hold today.

## THE TUATHAICH

From the Severance the chronicles stop calling them humans. The descendants of those left on Dia-thìr are *na Tuathaich*, the northerners, from *tuath*, north, with the same people-ending that makes *Dia-thìrich*; on the page the two names stand like brothers, though the two peoples' fortunes have been far apart. Their homeland in the north was fixed formally (22 am Màrt, SE 1): "It is a confinement; yet their children's children call it home." A formal wall between the two peoples was proposed and rejected as unnecessary, because the two were already keeping apart on their own (11 an Cèitean, SE 10).

What the Tuathaich call themselves in their own speech the chronicles do not say. The name used here is the kingdom's name for them.

**Their towns.** The kingdom's map counts sixty-four Tuathaich towns, all in the north and north-west, with some 543,000 people in them. The Dia-thìrich hold the other 441. The Tuathaich country is some fifteen parts in a hundred of the island's land, the windy coast of the far north-west among it, and the Dia-thìrich country the other eighty-five (Appendix H). The largest Tuathaich towns are these:

| TOWN        | SHIRE       | FAITH                                    | POPULATION |
|-------------|-------------|------------------------------------------|------------|
| Caol mhòr   | Caol mhòr   | An Eaglais                               | 42,002     |
| Doire ghlas | Doire ghlas | An Eaglais (Eaglais nan Tuathach)        | 40,740     |
| Ceann mhòr  | Ceann mhòr  | An Eaglais                               | 32,420     |
| Baile chrom | Baile chrom | An Eaglais (the vigil of the Grey Night) | 27,319     |
| Cnoc ghorm  | Cnoc ghorm  | An Eaglais                               | 25,112     |

Every Tuathaich town but one bears a Dia-thìris name, and most of them were Dia-thìreach towns before the Severance; the north-west had been thinly held since the dearth on that shore in the Age of Sundering (19 an Giblean, LE 819). One of them,

Seann Skell in the shire of Muileann àrsaidh, bears an Old One's name. The Tuathaich have added no names of their own to the map.

**Their assembly.** Tuathaich householders from the northern towns met at Caol mhòr and chose a speaker, Walter Hale, a former harbour clerk (25 an Lùnastal, SE 2). The Moot has no standing in Dia-thìreach law; it meets anyway, and its minutes run unbroken from that meeting to the present.

**Their faith.** All sixty-four Tuathaich towns keep An Eaglais<sup>15</sup>, the Church, which their forebears brought over the sea at the Crossing; no Dia-thìreach town keeps it. Fifty-one keep it in the line the Mission left, and their largest church is at Cnoc ghorm. Twelve are the old congregations of the north coast, Eaglais nan Tuathach<sup>16</sup>, whose towns lie together in the shires of Doire ghlais, Muileann leathan, Inis mhin and Àth àrsaidh. One, Baile chrom, keeps the vigil of the Grey Night, Rùn-dìomhair na h-Oidhche Glaise<sup>17</sup>, which the Church's bishops call irregular. The old congregations keep, quietly, the First Canoe fragment (13 an Gearran, SE 9): among coastal Tuathaich families, "a steersman with a name, and a first crossing", which their church tells as the voyage of Naomh Breandan to the Isle of the Blessed, and which the druids of the Old Faith dismiss as superstition (9 an t-Samhain, VE 2,833). The fragment is set in the Ancient Age, for there its tellers place it. The Library has neither upheld it nor struck it out. It is one of the two suppressed histories that stand at either end of the island's story, and it is left here as it was found.

## THE FUIL-GHUAIL

This section holds to what the rolls and chronicles say.

A child born into the mining camps was exposed to more raw coal across her lifetime than any Dia-thìreach in living memory, and did not age the way the people around her did. Her name is Aisling (7 am Màrt, AE 69). What was happening to her had no word, in any tongue spoken on the island (13 am Faoilleach, AE 71). A second, Fionnan, was born half a century later (21 an Gearran, AE 121), and it became plain that this was no single mischance: it came of the working of the pits, and would come again while they were worked. With two sure cases before them, the Dia-thìreach custodians settled on a word (23 am Faoilleach, AE 126): *fuil-ghuail*, "coal-blood", rendered in the humans' tongue as *coal-touched*. It was meant as a physician's word. It was agreed at a meeting of custodians at the shrine of Cill ghlais, and the roll records the vote but not who proposed it (21 an Gearran, AE 126). The Residency ordered

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15. the Church

16. the Tuathaich Church; the old congregations of the north coast

17. the Mystery of the Grey Night

every Dia-thìreach child showing the condition to be reported; the custodians complied by reporting none (26 an t-Samhain, AE 127). A third case, Lorccan, was born in a mining town (29 an Cèitean, AE 134), and a fourth, Cian, within a year of him (3 am Màrt, AE 135).

The camps say more than the rolls. They tell that Aisling's father, Donnchadh mac Thormoid, a hewer of the deep galleries at Achadh dhomhain, coughed a year with what the Mission's surgeon wrote down as the lung-rot, and that the cough left him on the night she was born; that what he carried was no rot but the Keeper's gift, *Tìodh-lac a' Choimhdich*<sup>18</sup> (Appendix B); and that she was of the first king's line. That last the copyists of Muileann chaol found to stand in the lines (21 an Dàmhair, AE 126; Appendix A, *The Line of Aisling*). The rest is the camps' own, and is set down here as theirs.

After the Severance the Coal Rite, Òrd Bhrìde<sup>19</sup>, was set in order within the Old Faith, built around the leyline and "the unbroken line of the coal-touched" (18 an Giblean, SE 6). The first census of the kingdom noted, without further comment, exactly how few such people exist (29 an t-Ògmhios, SE 7), and the published census of a later generation gave a number and nothing else (8 am Faoilleach, SE 65). The number is printed nowhere else, and it is not printed here.

Whether the *fuil-ghuail* are a people is a question of words. They are born to Dia-thìreach families; in Dia-thìreach speech the word names the gift that sets the Dia-thìrich apart from the Tuathaich; and the druid schools have asked since the Holy Age why the vein answers some hands and not others. The chronicles do not settle it.

## II. The Tongues

### DIA-THÌRIS

Dia-thìris is the tongue of Dia-thìr, spoken by the Dia-thìrich in every age. Three things mark it at once on the page:

| FEATURE          | DIA-THÌRIS                          | EXAMPLE                               |
|------------------|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Long vowels      | <b>grave accent only:</b> à è ì ò ù | <i>mòr, sìth, Dia-thìris</i>          |
| The cluster /sk/ | written <b>sc</b> , never <i>sg</i> | <i>uisce, scoil, sceul, Scàineadh</i> |
| "City"           | <i>cathair</i>                      | <i>Cathair dbearg</i>                 |

18. the Keeper's gift

19. the order of Bride's flame

Its greeting of thanks is *gu robh math agad*. Its verbs come first in the sentence (*Chunnaic Cian an long*, "Cian saw the ship"); it has no word for "a", no words for yes and no, and two initial mutations.

**Lenition.** After many words an initial consonant softens, and the change is written with *b*: *b > bh*, *c > ch*, *d > dh*, *f > fh*, *g > gh*, *m > mh*, *p > ph*, *s > sh*, *t > th*. The possessives, the past tense, a feminine noun after the article, an adjective after a feminine noun, most simple prepositions and the second element of a name all cause it. It does not touch vowels, nor *l*, *n*, *r* in writing, nor the clusters *sc*, *sp*, *st*, *sm*; and after a word ending in *n* it spares *d*, *t* and *s*, which is why the map has *Seann Dunn* and *Seann Toll* but *Seann Bhral*.

**Broad and slender.** Vowels are broad (*a o u à ò ù*) or slender (*e i è ì*), and within one word a consonant takes vowels of the same class on both sides: *caol le caol*, *leathan le leathan*, slender with slender, broad with broad. That is why so many endings come in pairs, and why the small rivers are *Ciaras* but *Àrsaidheas*.

**Sounds.** For the reader who would say these names aloud:

| WRITTEN | SAID                                                            | EXAMPLE               |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| bh, mh  | v                                                               | <i>Seann Bhral</i>    |
| ch      | as in <i>loch</i>                                               | <i>Seann Chwen</i>    |
| dh, gh  | a voiced <i>ch</i> before broad vowels; <i>y</i> before slender | <i>Cathair dhearg</i> |
| fh      | silent                                                          | <i>Àth fhada</i>      |
| sh, th  | h                                                               | <i>Dùn thais</i>      |
| sc      | sk                                                              | <i>Scàineadh</i>      |

The stress falls on the first syllable.

**How Dia-thìris names new things.** Dia-thìris was long spoken on an island that few new things reached, and it was slow to borrow. The humans brought many new things, and the kingdom after them more. In the first generations after the Crossing the Dia-thìrich named nearly all of them from old roots, calling the thing by what it does or what it is like: head first, the describer after, hyphenated, two elements and seldom three. Many of these kennings are still the common words. The loans Dia-thìris did take came mostly later: *bus*, the bus; *tacsaidh*, the taxi; *rèidio*, the radio; and many words of the sciences, such as *ogsaidean*, oxygen, and the names of the elements. Some of the kennings, with their literal sense:

| ENGLISH | DIA-THÌRIS            | LITERALLY    |
|---------|-----------------------|--------------|
| train   | <i>carbad-iarainn</i> | iron-chariot |
| engine  | <i>cridhe-iarainn</i> | iron-heart   |

| ENGLISH           | DIA-THÌRIS              | LITERALLY      |
|-------------------|-------------------------|----------------|
| computer          | <i>inntinn-iarainn</i>  | iron-mind      |
| aeroplane         | <i>eun-iarainn</i>      | iron-bird      |
| telephone         | <i>guth-sreinge</i>     | string-voice   |
| cable             | <i>sreang-theine</i>    | fire-string    |
| socket            | <i>tobar-dealanaich</i> | lightning-well |
| battery           | <i>ciste-spionnaidh</i> | strength-chest |
| heater            | <i>teine-gun-lasair</i> | flameless-fire |
| camera            | <i>ciste-scàile</i>     | shadow-chest   |
| film              | <i>sceul-scàile</i>     | shadow-tale    |
| novel             | <i>leabhar-sceòil</i>   | tale-book      |
| documentary       | <i>sceul-firinne</i>    | truth-tale     |
| plastic           | <i>cèir-cbruidh</i>     | hard-wax       |
| inflation         | <i>lobhadh-airgid</i>   | money-rot      |
| internet          | <i>lìon-fiosa</i>       | tidings-net    |
| crossing (street) | <i>àth-coise</i>        | foot-ford      |
| tyre              | <i>bròg-cuibhle</i>     | wheel-shoe     |

The kennings fall into families: machines are *iarainn*, of iron; screens and pictures are *scàil* and *scàthan*, shadow and mirror; electricity is *dealan*, spark, and *dealanach*, lightning. A crossing for feet is a ford, *àth*, the same word the map uses for a town at a river.

**Words born of the island's history.** Old words have also taken new senses from what the island lived through. The royal chroniclers keep a list of these, and the rolls date the first use of most.

| WORD                | PLAIN SENSE   | SENSE GIVEN BY HISTORY                                                   | FIRST RECORDED        |
|---------------------|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| <i>roghnaich</i>    | to choose     | to have chosen the crossing; to choose exile                             | 21 an Lùnastal, LE 67 |
| <i>a' Scaradh</i>   | the Sundering | any chosen, permanent parting; later used of the Severance               | Age of Sundering      |
| <i>uaine</i>        | green         | sickly, plague-marked, after A' Phlàigh Uaine (9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 73)    | Age of Strangers      |
| <i>scàinte</i>      | rent, cracked | shaken, of a person, after Scàineadh Cill ghlas (9 an t-Ògmhios, AE 137) | Age of Strangers      |
| <i>Aisling-aois</i> | Aisling's age | an unnaturally long youth in anyone, said half in jest                   | Age of Strangers      |

| WORD                           | PLAIN SENSE              | SENSE GIVEN BY HISTORY                                               | FIRST RECORDED         |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| <i>mar a thàinig Niall</i>     | the way Niall came       | any smooth handing-over of power                                     | 7 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3   |
| <i>tonn</i>                    | wave                     | a sudden, overwhelming change: <i>tha e san tonn</i>                 | 4 am Faoilleach, SE 5  |
| <i>a cbur san Le-abbarlann</i> | to put it in the Library | to make a thing settled and official                                 | 3 an t-Samhain, SE 16  |
| <i>dubhan</i>                  | a man's name             | the synthetic fuel                                                   | 23 an t-Sultain, DE 11 |
| <i>dubhan-tìsail</i>           | dubhan of the beginning  | a first attempt that seemed a dead end and proved otherwise          | 22 an Dàmhair, DE 11   |
| <i>fadachadh</i>               | lengthening              | to be crushed after holding out too long: <i>chaidh am fadachadh</i> | 10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22 |
| <i>seann-chunntas</i>          | old account              | a grievance nobody in power acts on and nobody cancels               | 18 an Giblean, DE 26   |

Of the Sundering the language also keeps one strange relic. A work-song of the rope-makers of Cuan shean names the parts of a deep keel, and half its words have no meaning to anyone who sings it (5 am Màrt, LE 1,389). Nothing else of the fleet's craft survives in any form. Whether the lost words are old Dia-thìris, or the cant of the wrights, or something else, no one has shown.

THE TONGUE OF THE SEANN-DHAOINE

Of the Old Ones' speech nothing survives but names. Ten roots are known, each standing after the Dia-thìris word *seann*, "old", which lenites it where Dia-thìris lenites:

| ROOT  | AS WRITTEN ON THE MAP | TOWNS BEARING IT | SHIRES NAMED FROM IT |
|-------|-----------------------|------------------|----------------------|
| Dunn  | Seann Dunn            | 3                | yes                  |
| Cwen  | Seann Chwen           | 3                | yes                  |
| Skell | Seann Skell           | 4                | yes (three)          |
| Bral  | Seann Bhral           | 3                | yes                  |
| Tarr  | Seann Tarr            | 3                | yes                  |
| Vell  | Seann Vell            | 5                | yes (three)          |
| Morn  | Seann Mhorn           | 2                | —                    |
| Brenn | Seann Bhrenn          | 2                | yes                  |
| Toll  | Seann Toll            | 3                | yes                  |
| Warr  | Seann Warr            | 2                | yes                  |

Thirty towns on the map bear these names, and thirteen shires are named from them.

The Dia-thìrich did not translate these names; they took them over. The fishers who resettled Seann Mhorn in the Holy Age kept "the name they find there, which is not of their own tongue", and said the old name came with the stones (23 an t-Sultain, FE 178). It is the first such taking-over on record. So the harbour-names of an older people outlived them inside a newer tongue, kept whole and hard like shells in a stone, and never put into Dia-thìris.

**What can be said.** The roots are single syllables. Seven of the ten end in a doubled consonant (-nn, -ll, -rr). Four of them hold letters that Dia-thìris writes nowhere else: *k* in *Skell*, *v* in *Vell*, *w* in *Cwen* and *Warr*. Everywhere else Dia-thìris writes the sound *sk* as *sc*, yet no scribe has ever written Seann Scell; they kept the foreign *k* as they found it, and the grammarians count *sk-* among the clusters that do not lenite.

**What cannot be known.** What any root meant. Whether *seann* was ever the Old Ones' own element, or only the Dia-thìrich's word for places they found already named (the second is the common reading, and the likelier; but it is no more than a reading). Whether the roots come from one tongue or several. Two of them look like Dia-thìris words, *toll*, a hole, and *dunn* beside *dùn*, a fort. The likeness has tempted scholars in every age and proves nothing, and the Library takes no side.

**The script.** The Seann-Dhaoine<sup>20</sup> also cut signs. Rows of them stand on the cliff above Seann Tarr (5 an Giblean, VE 1,301), in the script that is found again on the standing stones. It is not Dia-thìris. It has never been read, and not one sign of it has an agreed meaning. The stag-scholars of the Holy Age set their own new letters against the obelisk at Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>21</sup> and found that they matched nothing, and wrote down that the stone's writers were not their teachers (12 an Cèitean, FE 914). Samuel Wren copied the obelisk and sent it over the sea to the scholars of an Tìr Thall<sup>22</sup>; no reply is recorded (5 an Gearran, AE 17). Edwin Lowe copied the pillar near Cnoc chiar, compared it with Wren's copy, and decided that the two were not the same script and that neither was Dia-thìreach; his notes stop there (9 an Lùnastal, AE 65). The strokes on the midden stones are a count, and have nothing to do with this script. Whether the script records the Old Ones' tongue, or some other, or no tongue at all, is not known.

## THE HUMANS' TONGUE

The humans spoke a plain tongue, and this history renders it in English (see *Of Translation* below). The names they carried were names of that tongue: Edmund Harrow,

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20. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

21. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

Thomas Pike, Samuel Wren, Josiah Pell, Henry Maddox, Arthur Lisle, Samuel Hale, Edwin Lowe.

**The season of translation.** Human clerics and Dia-thìreach custodians spent a full season trying to build a shared vocabulary, and neither side's account of what was agreed survives intact (27 an Màrt, AE 2). Samuel Wren and the custodian Gormshuil nic Fhearchair kept parallel word-lists. Wren's survives in the Administration's letter-books; Gormshuil's was lost, and only its first leaf is known from a copy: forty words for the colours of broken coal (13 an Dùbhlachd, AE 2). Against those forty the humans had one word, and it was *coal*.

**The tongue of rule.** The humans wrote their agreements in their own tongue only. The first written treaty (27 an Giblean, AE 8) was signed at Cathair dhearg by Tormod mac Ailein, who could not read the tongue it was written in; who read it to him, no roll says (7 an Cèitean, AE 8). The Harbour Articles were written the same way, and that time two custodians refused to sign (16 an t-Samhain, AE 19). The Mission's school at Ros dhomhain taught Dia-thìreach children in the humans' tongue (9 an Cèitean, AE 51); a generation later Iain Maor, the first overseer schooled there, kept his reports in the humans' tongue and his household in Dia-thìris (23 an Giblean, AE 87). The Levy's officers read the names of the chosen at Caol mhòr from a list in the humans' tongue, and the custodians took the names down again in Dia-thìris, "that they may know whom to look for" (3 am Màrt, AE 88).

**Loanwords.** Few crossed, and most of those late. In the first generations Dia-thìris took the humans' goods and named them in its own way, as told above, and kept few of the humans' words for them. The humans for their part, so far as the rolls show, used the Dia-thìris names of places as they found them; *fuil-ghuail*<sup>23</sup> they did not borrow but turned into their own tongue, *coal-touched*, and that word, rather than the Dia-thìris, is the one the kingdom's own later entries use of the Rite's "unbroken line". What passed the other way, into the humans' speech, is best seen after the Severance, in the north.

The Dia-thìris word for the humans' country, *an Tìr Thall*, is the only name the island has for it.

## TUATHAICH SPEECH

The speech of the north is a mixed speech, and the chronicles speak of it only in passing. This much they say.

The Tuathaich kept the humans' tongue. Walter Hale asked the council for leave to open schools in the north teaching in it, and was refused (10 an Gearran, SE 7); Agnes

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22. the land beyond, the humans' homeland



Pike opened one at Doire ghlas anyway, with Moot money and without the council's leave, and within a decade there were nine (14 am Faoilleach, SE 15). The Moot later counted eleven such schools, and three that had begun to teach Dia-thìris as well, at the parents' asking (7 an t-Ògmhios, SE 29). The church at Cnoc ghorm taught its priests in the humans' tongue while reading the Bible in the Dia-thìris text its preachers use on the west coast: the only place in the north where both are taught (29 an Giblean, SE 10).

The Tuathaich live among Dia-thìris names and use Dia-thìris words. The words the north has added to the island's speech in the present age are Dia-thìris in form: *fa-dachadh*, from *fada*, long, the name of the war they lost (10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22), and *seann-chunntas*, an old reckoning, which official Dia-thìreach usage pointedly does not take up (18 an Giblean, DE 26). The word *dubhan* for the fuel came out of the north, from the name of Dubhan, a Tuathach, and it spread before the fuel did (23 an t-Sultain, DE 11); the royal chronicler who first set it down spelled it three ways in two lines (21 an t-Samhain, DE 1).

Beyond this the chronicles do not go. The northern towns' own accounts are among the things the royal chroniclers say they do not hold (25 an Giblean, SE 43). How far the humans' tongue has drifted in the north since the crossing closed, how much Dia-thìris is spoken at a Tuathach hearth, and in which tongue the First Canoe is told, the Library cannot say.

## NAMES AND NAMING

**Personal names.** Dia-thìreach names are the old given names of the island: Ailean, Beathag, Catriona, Dòmhnall, Eilidh, Fearchar, Gormshuil, Iain, Mòrag, Raghnaill, Sileas, Tormod. A person is further named from the father, with *mac*, son, or *nic*, daughter, and the father's name in the genitive, lenited where Dia-thìris lenites: Tormod mac Iain; Eilidh nic Iain; Gormshuil nic Fhearchair; Donnchadh mac Thormoid; Mòrag nic Dhòmhnail; Oighrig nic Lachlainn.

**Bynames** are as common as patronymics and often outlast them. They name a colour, a trade, a size or a deed. After a woman's name the byname is lenited, after a man's it is not: Seònaid Mhòr, Eilidh Dhubh, Beathag Bhàn, but Ailean Mòr, Calum Liath, Dùghall Garbh. Trade-names are nouns and stand as they are: Alasdair Saor, the wright; Iain Maor, the overseer. Some bynames are earned: Tormod mac Iain, the first of the royal kin to read, was called Tormod Scriobhaiche, Tormod the Writer, for the rest of his life (3 an Lùnastal, FE 1,255).

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23. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'

**Kindreds** take *Sliochd*, the seed or line, or *Clann*, the children, with a founder's name in the genitive: Sliochd Ìomhair<sup>24</sup>, Sliochd Mhuirich<sup>25</sup>, Clann Choinnich.

**Human and Tuathaich names** are of the humans' tongue and are kept in their own spelling: Walter Hale, Agnes Pike. The humans' names for the island's things were lost at the Severance; their names for themselves lived through it.

**Place names.** Dia-thireach places are named by a generic noun and a describing word after it. On the map the describer is always lenited, whatever the gender of the generic (*Baile ghorm*, *Cnoc bheag*, *Dùn thais*). In speech it would not be lenited after a masculine noun; the names keep an old fixed usage, as old compounds are kept. The generics are these:

| GENERIC          | SENSE             | USED FOR        |
|------------------|-------------------|-----------------|
| <i>Cathair</i>   | stone fort; city  | capital, city   |
| <i>Dùn</i>       | fortified hill    | capital, city   |
| <i>Baile Mòr</i> | great settlement  | city            |
| <i>Baile</i>     | settlement, town  | town            |
| <i>Àth</i>       | ford              | town            |
| <i>Cnoc</i>      | hill              | town            |
| <i>Muileann</i>  | mill              | town            |
| <i>Cill</i>      | holy cell, shrine | village, hamlet |
| <i>Tobar</i>     | well              | village, hamlet |
| <i>Achadh</i>    | field             | village         |
| <i>Doire</i>     | oak grove         | village         |
| <i>Carraig</i>   | rock              | hamlet          |
| <i>Ros</i>       | headland          | port            |
| <i>Ceann</i>     | head, point       | port            |
| <i>Cuan</i>      | harbour           | port            |
| <i>Caol</i>      | strait            | port            |
| <i>Inis</i>      | island            | port            |

The describers are colour, size and character words: *mòr*, *beag*, *dubh*, *geal*, *bàn*, *dearg*, *ruadh*, *uaine*, *glas*, *fada*, *dombain*, *ìseal*, *fiadhaich*, *naomb*, *fionn*, *ciar*, *gorm*, *sean*, *òg*, *garbh*, *min*, *caol*, *leathan*, *crom*, *dìreach*, *àrsaidh*. The great rivers are *Abhainn* with a describer; the small ones take a root and the ending *-as* or *-eas* by broad and slender. A

24. the house of Ìomhar

25. the house of Muireach

shire, *siorrachd*, takes the name of its seat, or, where it has no town, of its island (Appendix H). Names repeat freely: there are four Baile chrom and four Seann Skell, and the rolls tell them apart by where they lie.

Beside these stand the Old Ones' names, which follow none of the rules above except that the Dia-thìrich put *seann* before them.

## WRITING

**Before letters.** The first marks on Dia-thìr made on purpose are the Seann-Dhaoine's: the notched net-weights of Seann Chwen, their unread script, and their tally strokes. The Dia-thìrich's forebears kept counts too, but not in letters. Someone began marking the high-water line against a fixed rock in the Age of Ailean (28 am Faoilleach, GE 1,671), and at Ros dhomhain Seònaid Mhòr cut her marks in pairs, one for the high water and one for the low (25 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,424). The king-lists of that age were oral, and the Small-Burning custom was "nowhere written and everywhere kept".

**The Dia-thìris words on the stones.** *Bha teine sa chloich* on Carragh Cnoc bheag, *Cuimhnich an teine* on Colbh Cnoc chiar<sup>26</sup>, *Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann* on Calbh Cnoc ghorm<sup>27</sup>: these are the oldest Dia-thìris words in stone. When they were cut no roll tells. The stones were raised in the Ancient Age; the Dia-thìris on Carragh Cnoc bheag was cut later, by another hand. The words on Calbh Cnoc ghorm were recut along their old grooves by a hand from the Stone Kings' hill, and some later readers say the recutting changed a letter (2 an t-Samhain, GE 4,364). This does not prove that there were letters to change in that day; the Library keeps the claim and passes no judgement on it.

**The stag-letters.** The first letters in use by the Dia-thìrich were made at Muileann chiar in the far east, where the teachers of the stag's people, the first of the druid schools, later called Feallsanachd an Fhèidh<sup>28</sup>, turned the cutters' tally-notches into signs for sounds, "so that a teaching can be kept without a teacher" (15 am Màrt, FE 914). The druids call them the ogham, the gift of Ogma, god of letters. From them nearly every later hand on the island descends. From them too came the first written king-list (20 an Lùnastal, FE 1,299), kept by Tormod Scriobhaiche at Dùn dhearg; the Keepers' own roll, written down at Dùn ìseal in answer to it (17 an Dàmhair, FE 1,320); boundary stones cut with treaty terms (11 am Màrt, FE 1,595); and the first teaching of letters for their own sake, to fishers' children at Inis bheag, which the Hall recorded with the remark that fish do not need reading (22 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,854).

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26. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

27. the column at Cnoc ghorm

28. the Philosophy of the Deer, the druid schools' own name

**Books and paper.** The Age of Sundering is the age of the custody-book, kept by the vein-house, and of the first books: Leabhar an t-Seabhaig<sup>29</sup>, the sayings of Gormshuil (5 an t-Ògmhios, LE 251), and Seònaid nic Coinnich's Book of the Three Claimants, the oldest surviving history on Dia-thìr written as one narrative (8 an t-Ògmhios, LE 624). Aonghas mac Uisdein was the first king to learn his letters as a child (25 an Cèitean, LE 394). A mill at Muileann chaol began making paper from rags, the first on Dia-thìr, and the custody-book was copied onto paper in that generation (28 am Faoilleach, LE 1,674).

**Two tongues of record.** The humans brought paper in quantity, and the custodians of Cathair naomh asked for their first payment in paper and ink (19 an Lùnastal, AE 3). They brought, too, a written tongue the Dia-thìrich could not read, and for a century and a half the island kept its records in two. Whether the humans' letters and the stag-letters share any shapes, no roll says. The earliest Dia-thìreach grievance text to survive, Leabhar Baile thais<sup>30</sup>, was set down in Dia-thìris by many hands (18 an t-Sultain, AE 101).

**The kingdom's record.** After the Severance the kingdom founded Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>31</sup> (1 an Cèitean, SE 16) and the office of royal chronicler (20 an t-Samhain, SE 18), and in time drew the provincial archives into one place (26 an t-Iuchar, SE 67). This account is written in that Library.

## Of Translation

This history is written in English for readers who have no Dia-thìris, and some account is owed of what that has done to the tongues it tells of.

**The humans' speech is rendered in English.** The humans did not speak English. They spoke the tongue of an Tìr Thall<sup>32</sup>, whose name for itself, like the name of their country, is not recorded on Dia-thìr. It was a plain tongue, as English is plain beside Dia-thìris. Its speakers were strangers to the island and its things, and it has become, in the north, the everyday speech of the Tuathaich. For those reasons it is given here as English, and its names are given as English names, as the letter-books would have them. When this history says the humans called the coloured coal *coal*, it means that they used their ordinary word for their ordinary fuel, and saw in the vein nothing that their own hearths did not burn. When it gives a custodian's title as "keepers of the coal", it is rendering Wren's rendering. *Coal-touched* is likewise an English stand-in for

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29. the Book of the Hawk

30. the book of Baile thais, the book of grievances

31. the Library at Muileann chaol

32. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

the humans' word, chosen because it keeps the plainness of the original and the error in it. The coal of the vein is coal, *gual*, but it is not only black.

**Dia-thìris is kept as it is.** The Dia-thìrich are the people of this history and Dia-thìris is its first tongue, and it is not translated into something else here. Names of places, persons, faiths, laws and offices are left in Dia-thìris spelling, with the grave accent and the *sc*, and with their lenitions: *Cathair dbearg*, not "Red City"; *fuil-ghuail*<sup>33</sup>, not "coal-blood", except where a gloss is wanted. Where a Dia-thìris phrase is translated, the translation follows it in quotation marks, as a help to the reader; the Dia-thìris stands first. The seven ages have Dia-thìris names and are also given English ones for convenience; the English names are this archive's, not the chroniclers'. The adjective *Dia-thìrian* is English, and is used as such.

**The island's own name.** It is *Dia-thìr*, the god's land, of *dia*, god, and *tìr*, land, and it is written the same in the English text of this history as in Dia-thìris, accent, hyphen and all. The hyphen is the law of the spelling: the broad *a* of *dia* may not stand against the slender *ì* of *thìr* within one word, so the two are written apart and each keeps its own stress.

**The Seann tongue is left untranslated, for it cannot be translated.** Its ten roots are given as the Dia-thìrich wrote them, with the foreign letters the Dia-thìrich kept. No meaning is offered for any of them.

**What has been lost in the rendering.** Some things do not cross. The forty colour-words on Gormshuil's leaf are one; the Tuathaich jokes about being long-warred are another, since *fadachadh* is funny, and not funny, only in a tongue where *fada* is also the name of the war. Where there was a choice between a rendering that reads easily and one that keeps what the words did, the second has been taken.

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33. the coal-blooded; lit. 'coal-blood'



## APPENDIX G

# The Goods and Markets of Dia-thìr

Here is set down what the island grows, digs, catches and makes; the sixteen market towns through which nearly all of it is bought and sold; the chief roads of trade between them; and the dues the Treasury takes on that trade. The account of the present day is drawn from the Treasury's market roll for the last full year, which the clerks of the market-due keep in each of the sixteen market towns and send to Cathair dhearg, and from the books of the fair-court at Muileann òg. The older history comes from the annals, and where a trade has a first date in them the date is given.

The roll counts goods in the measures the markets use: grain, fish, clay and sand by the wain; timber by the pile; stone by the pallet; coal by the wagon; silver and gold by the bar; cattle, sheep, horses and oxen by the head; oil, dubhan, wine, honey and tar by the barrel; salt and dyes by the bag; cloth by the bolt; books by the volume. Prices are given in the realm-coin.

## I. The Countries of the Island and What They Grow

Dia-thìr is a wet and windy island, mild for so northerly a place, and most of it is forest and moor. Its husbandry follows the lie of five countries.

**The bare north.** Along the northern coast from Ceann mhòr to Seann Tarr, and inland over the moors behind the Hawk bay, the ground is low, bare and windswept, with snow on the higher ground in winter. Yet it grows more than its look promises. Barley and oats are sown in every sheltered hollow, hemp grows in the valley bottoms, and the heather feeds bees and sheep. The shore is the richer half. The northern and north-western waters hold the island's herring grounds and its whales, and amber is gathered from the wrack on the strands of the Hawk bay and the north-west. The market towns of this country are Ceann mhòr, Seann Skell, Àth fhionn, Muileann fhionn and Seann Tarr.

**The birch and pine hills.** The largest single country on the island is the belt of birch, pine and hill pasture that runs from the western plain across the middle of Dia-thìr into the eastern hills. It is cattle and sheep country before all else, and it gives besides timber, venison, honey and a dark wine pressed from blaeberry and bramble. Almost all of the island's mining ground lies in these hills: the silver of Muileann chiar — baile mèinne airgid and of the hills of Cuan ghlais, the copper and tin of Ceann àr-saidh, Cnoc bhàn and Doire fhionn, the gemstones of the Muileann dhearg hills, the marble of Baile Mòr dhomhain, the old spoil-heaps where dubhan is made for the forges, and the charcoal woods that fed the forges before it. Copper was little worked before the Age of the Kingdom. The humans shipped theirs in for the first coinage (10 an Lùnastal, AE 17), and the first great working is the copper-town of Àth fhiadhaich (2 an t-Ògmhios, SE 61). The market towns of the hills are Baile Mòr dhomhain, Ros fhionn, Dùn ìseal, Baile Mòr dhìreach and Ros bheag.

**The wet western and southern woods.** South and west of the capital the forest is oak, alder and hazel, dripping for half the year. Timber, game, clay, white sand, hemp and honey are its chief goods, with barley on the cleared ground. The potteries and glass-houses stand in this country because its clay and sand are the best on Dia-thìr, and the dyers of the south take their colours from its plants. Its market towns are Baile Mòr fhionn, Cathair fhada, Cnoc bhàn and Caol ruadh.

**The oak country of the capital and the east.** Around the capital and along the eastern road the woods are broad-leaved and the soil is deeper. This is the island's best mixed farming: cattle and sheep, grain, wine, hemp, and the horses of the Doire chaol country. Its farms sell through Cathair dhomhain, Ceann leathan and Dùn ìseal.

**The eastern plain and the mosses.** The open grassland east of Dùn ìseal, where the herders of the Age of Ailean drove their cattle to the warm springs (7 an Lùnastal, GE 3,771), is thin pasture and bees. The wet mosses of the west coast and the western plain give peat, reeds and wildfowl, and at Baile ghorm the salt-pans the Stone Kings fought over (12 an Gearran, GE 683).

Some goods grow in only one or two places. Flax grows only in the lake-shore fields of Seann Warr, and its seed is pressed there for linseed oil, in which the road-houses were frying their oatcakes as early as LE 304. Tobacco grows only on the old concession farms behind Ceann mhòr, where the humans first planted it (31 an Dàmhair, AE 52). Gold is washed only from the streams below Baile dhìreach and Cnoc dhìreach, and the pearl-mussels lie only in the shallows of the south-eastern coast off Cnoc bhàn and Caol ruadh.

Dia-thìr grows no spices, tea, sugar, silk or dates, and has no camels or elephants. Before the Severance the ships of an Tìr Thall<sup>1</sup> brought small amounts of spice, tea and



sugar to the Company's stores. No ship has come from an Tìr Thall since the last one sailed from Ros bheag (1 an t-Samhain, AE 150), and those goods are not sold on the island now.

THE RAW GOODS OF DIA-THÌR

| GOOD                 | WHERE IT COMES FROM                                                                               | MARKET MEASURE |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| Grain (barley, oats) | Everywhere below the high moors; most in the north coast and the western plain                    | wain           |
| Timber               | The birch and pine hills and the wet woods                                                        | pile           |
| Game and venison     | Every forest; most in the eastern hills                                                           | wain           |
| Hemp                 | Valley bottoms everywhere; cheapest of all goods in every market                                  | wain           |
| Honey and wax        | The heather of the north and the eastern plain; Seann Tarr, Cathair mhòr, Cathair fhada           | barrel         |
| Cattle               | The birch and pine hills, the north-west and the plain of Caol leathan                            | head           |
| Sheep and wool       | The hills, the northern moors and the outer isles                                                 | head           |
| Wine                 | The birch and pine hills and the oak country; Àth shean and Baile Mòr fhionn                      | barrel         |
| Fish                 | The northern and north-western grounds, the eastern narrows, the southern strait                  | wain           |
| Whale-oil            | Drift and hunted whales of the northern waters                                                    | barrel         |
| Seal-oil             | The skerries of the north-west, and a few places on the southern and eastern shores               | barrel         |
| Clay                 | River banks and shores of the south and west; Dùn fhiadhaich, Ros dhìreach, Àth bheag, Cuan shean | wain           |
| White sand           | Cuan ruadh, Ceann mhòr, Inis mhòr and the southern Seann Skell                                    | wain           |
| Dyes                 | The wet woods and the east; Baile Mòr ruadh, Baile fhiadhaich, Cnoc ghorm, Seann Vell             | bag            |
| Salt                 | The pans of Baile ghorm, Seann Warr, Caol ìseal and Àth bheag                                     | bag            |
| Stone and marble     | The hills; marble from Baile Mòr dhomhain                                                         | pallet         |
| Iron                 | Bog-iron of the west and north; Àth naomh and Caol ìseal                                          | wagon          |
| Copper and tin       | The eastern and central hills; Àth fhiadhaich                                                     | wagon          |
| Silver               | Muileann chiar, and small workings in the Cuan ghlas hills                                        | bar            |
| Gold                 | The streams below Baile dhìreach and Cnoc dhìreach                                                | bar            |

1. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

| GOOD                  | WHERE IT COMES FROM                                                                 | MARKET MEASURE              |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Gemstones             | The hills of Muileann dhearg and Seann Vell                                         | stone                       |
| Amber                 | The strands of the Hawk bay and the north-west; Cill àrsaidh, Muileann leathan      | stone                       |
| Pearls                | The mussel beds of the south-eastern shallows                                       | pearl                       |
| Furs and hides        | The eastern hills; Àth ruadh                                                        | pelt                        |
| Horses and oxen       | The plain of Caol leathan, Baile àrsaidh and the Doire chaol country                | head                        |
| Dubhan                | The works on the spoil-heaps of the hills, and at Seann Skell on the southern coast | barrel                      |
| Flax and lin-seed oil | Seann Warr only                                                                     | bale; the oil by the barrel |
| Tobacco               | The concession farms behind Ceann mhòr only                                         | bag                         |

The vein itself no longer appears in the roll. Coal-fuel from the Sloc Mòr was sold at the fair by the cartload until 22 am Faoilleach, DE 3, and the western coal seams sold their coal to the north until the Board closed them. The western seams were flooded and capped in DE 23, the upper galleries of the Sloc Mòr were closed in DE 26, and the few baskets of altar-coal cut each year under the Rite's custody are not sold in any market. Dubhan, the fuel that took the coal's place (19 an t-Ògmhios, DE 1), is a wrought good, and the only one the roll counts among the raw goods. It is made from the spoil of the old workings (1 an t-Iuchar, SE 61) at the works of Seann Skell on the southern coast and in the east and north (27 an t-Ògmhios, DE 27). The works sell it by the barrel into the markets for the forges, kilns and glass-houses, which burned charcoal from the hill woods before it, as the charcoal-burners of the eastern woods had burned it since the Age of Sundering (17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,469). Lamps, engines and lorries buy it at the works' own depots and pumps and at the inns that keep a pump (4 am Màrt, DE 10), and the wartime tithe on it is taken at the pump by a clerk of the Treasury (29 an Giblean, DE 21).

Dubhan is also the one good of Dia-thìr sold off the island. In the present year Dubhan, who made the first working fuel, won from the council the right to export it (7 an t-Sultain, DE 27), the first leave for any good to go beyond the kingdom's waters since the Severance. The export is held to a measure the Treasury sets each year and is loaded only at the quay of Ros dhomhain, where a clerk of the Treasury takes the tithe on every barrel and the custodians of Òrd Bhride<sup>2</sup> seal every hold, so that nothing of

2. the order of Bride's flame

the vein goes with it. The kingdom's own depots and the Moot's are served first. In this year dubhan goes abroad under that charter and under no other.

## II. The Wrought Goods

The greater part of the worth that passes through the markets lies in goods made in the towns. In the order of their worth in the last roll they are these.

**Salted and smoked food.** Salt fish, salt meat and smoked meat are made in almost every town and are the largest trade on the island by value. Salting is as old as the fish-kilns of Seann Mhorn (17 an Giblean, VE 1,443) and the salt road of the Age of Ailean (5 an Dàmhair, GE 2,468); the mining shires have eaten salt fish in the lean season since LE 394. The biggest salting towns are Cathair mhòr, Dùn ìseal, Seann Dunn and the harbours of the gulf.

**Arms and field-guns.** The forges of the old vein country, of Àth naomh in the west and of Caol ìseal on the north coast smelt bog-iron and bronze into arms, and a few of them cast field-guns. Every market in the kingdom sells arms back to its towns, where the regiments and fleets raised in An Cogadh Fada<sup>3</sup> are stationed. The trade is young. It grew from the Crown's contracts for the regiments (20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 24), and arms are now the dearest common goods in every market. The forge-town of Muileann dhearg, where Uilleam Gobha made the rebels' grenades (17 an Lùnastal, AE 149), stands in the same hills.

**Books, paper and ink.** Dia-thìr is a country of copyists. Paper has been made from rags and hemp at Muileann chaol since LE 1,674 and at Tobar dhìreach since SE 18, and books are bound and sold in more than eighty towns. The largest trade in books is at Dùn ìseal, Cathair dhomhain, Baile Mòr ruadh, Inis àrsaidh and Dùn chrom.

**Soap and candles.** Soap is boiled from tallow and seal-oil, and candles are dipped from beeswax and tallow, in most towns of the north and the gulf. The wax lights of the ancestor shrines were the first of this trade (26 an Dàmhair, LE 644).

**Ships, sails and rope.** Seagoing ships are built at nine yards: the two Seann Dunns on the east coast, Inis thais, Seann Skell of the Hawk bay, Ros fhionn, Inis ìseal, Ceann leathan, the royal quays of Cathair dhearg and Inis mhòr. Their sails are cut from hemp cloth in the same towns, and their rope comes from the rope-walks of Baile ghlas and Seann Tarr. The first deep keels since the Sundering were measured from the humans' hulls at Inis mhòr (14 an t-Samhain, AE 4).

**Glass and pottery.** Glass is blown from the white sand of Cuan ruadh, Ceann mhòr and the southern Seann Skell in some seventy towns, most of all at Cathair mhòr

on the north road, Baile Mòr dhìreach and Seann Vell. The first glass-house on Dia-thìr was built at Baile Mòr dhìreach in AE 66. Pottery is older. The red ware of the western road was fired at Baile ghorm and Cnoc àrsaidh in the Holy Age (8 an t-Samhain, FE 2,918, 19 an Giblean, FE 2,920). Today the largest potteries are at Dùn fhiadhaich, Ros dhìreach and Àth bheag, and Cathair fhada sells their ware to the north.

**Cloth, garments and leather.** Wool is spun and woven in every sheep country. The chartered weavers are those of Baile chiar (6 am Faoilleach, SE 15) and the mills of Doire ghlas (27 an Giblean, SE 59). Hides are tanned at Baile ghorm (13 an t-Iuchar, SE 62) and Muileann dhomhain (9 an Giblean, SE 53), and boots and harness are made in most of the market towns.

**Scent.** Scent waters are distilled from bog-myrtle, meadowsweet and heather honey and sold in small glass flasks. This trade belongs to the capital shore and the western plain: Seann Vell, Caol fhiadhaich, Cnoc àrsaidh, Baile ghlas and Doire shean. It began at Seann Vell in the first years of the restored kingdom (15 an Gearran, SE 27).

**Drink and cheese.** Barley spirit, the fire-water of the northern road (15 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,672), is distilled in some forty towns. Ale is brewed for sale only at Ceann chaol, Muileann fhada and Seann Bhral in the south-east. Cheese is made in the cattle towns, most of all at Ceann leathan and Cathair fhada.

**Coin.** The realm-coin is struck only at the mint at Cathair dhearg (9 an Dàmhair, SE 5). The blanks it is struck from are refined in the villages of the eastern hills from the silver of Muileann chiar and the gold of Baile dhìreach (19 an t-Sultain, SE 37), and the Treasury counts those blanks among the goods of the Dùn ìseal market.

### III. The Sixteen Market Towns

Every town on Dia-thìr belongs to one of sixteen markets. A town sells its surplus into its market and buys what it lacks there. The market town holds the market-court, weighs goods on the Crown's weights and keeps the clerk of the market-due. Each of the sixteen has a market square, and so do some hundred and seventy lesser towns that hold a weekly market of their own. Only the market towns keep a tithe-clerk.

| MARKET TOWN   | TOWNS IN ITS REACH | ITS COUNTRY                       | WHAT ITS TOWNS SELL INTO IT                                   | WHAT IT SENDS TO OTHER MARKETS | MARKET RIGHT |
|---------------|--------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------|
| Ceann leathan | 52                 | the gulf and the old vein country | salted food, arms and field-guns, soap, candles, books, glass | nothing                        | FE 584       |

| MARKET TOWN        | TOWNS IN ITS REACH | ITS COUNTRY                              | WHAT ITS TOWNS SELL INTO IT                              | WHAT IT SENDS TO OTHER MARKETS                  | MARKET RIGHT |
|--------------------|--------------------|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|--------------|
| Cathair dhomhain   | 31                 | the capital shore                        | salted food, scent, glass, books, ships                  | scent, cattle, horses                           | FE 1,699     |
| Ros fhionn         | 53                 | the north-eastern hills                  | arms, salted food, field-guns, tools, ships, coin-blanks | nothing                                         | LE 959       |
| Seann Skell        | 47                 | the Hawk bay and the north-central coast | salted food, soap, ships, candles, books                 | amber                                           | LE 435       |
| Ros bheag          | 25                 | the west coast                           | salted food, arms, scent, books, pottery                 | cattle, sheep                                   | FE 2,145     |
| Seann Tarr         | 27                 | the north-eastern coast                  | salted food, books, candles, boots                       | nothing                                         | LE 644       |
| Dùn iséal          | 47                 | the eastern hills and plain              | salted food, coin-blanks, arms, books                    | coin-blanks, copper                             | FE 556       |
| Baile Mòr dhomhain | 24                 | the northern hills                       | arms, salted food, glass, candles                        | cattle, sheep, venison, marble, horses, glass   | FE 1,122     |
| Baile Mòr dhìreach | 42                 | the east coast                           | salted food, arms, ships, tools, sails                   | pearls, clay                                    | LE 731       |
| Baile Mòr fhionn   | 27                 | the western plain                        | arms, scent, salted food, books, ships                   | scent, oxen, linseed oil                        | FE 1,699     |
| Cathair fhada      | 24                 | the south                                | salted food, books, candles, pottery, spirits            | pottery                                         | LE 287       |
| Ceann mhòr         | 28                 | the north-west coast                     | arms, salted food, books, tools                          | amber, arms, seal-oil, dyes, tobacco, whale-oil | SE 3         |
| Àth fhionn         | 28                 | the north coast                          | salted food, books, candles, garments                    | nothing                                         | LE 835       |
| Muileann fhionn    | 24                 | the north-western interior               | books, salted food, soap, candles                        | cattle, sheep, venison, soap, horses            | SE 9         |
| Cnoc bhàn          | 17                 | the south-eastern farms                  | arms, tools, field-guns, candles, ale                    | pearls, clay, amber                             | LE 1,051     |
| Caol ruadh         | 9                  | the southern strait                      | arms, glass, salted food, spirits                        | venison                                         | DE 23        |

**Ceann leathan** is the largest and dearest market on the island. Its reach runs from the gulf shore up into the old vein country of Muileann chrom, Muileann dhearg and Muileann dhomhain, whose forges now make arms where their pits once sent up coal. It became the market of the southern fishing in the Holy Age (16 am Faoilleach, FE

584), and its harbour-master's notched tallies are the oldest tallies kept in the Library. Today the crowds of the Còmhrag keep its prices the highest on Dia-thìr. Grain, timber, honey and wine all cost it nearly twice what they cost on the south coast. It sells nothing to other markets and buys from eight of them: scent from the capital, amber from the Hawk bay and the north-west, pearls from Cnoc bhàn, cattle, sheep and venison from the northern hills, coin-blanks from Dùn iséal, oxen and linseed oil from the western plain, and seal-oil, whale-oil and dyes from Ceann mhòr.

**Cathair dhomhain** is the market of the capital shore: the three harbour towns of Cathair dhomhain, Ros dhomhain and Baile ghlais, the royal precinct of Cathair dhearg, and the farms of Baile chiar and Àth shean behind them. Its right to its own tolls dates from the rivalry with the new royal seat (9 an Giblean, FE 1,699). Its scent-makers and glass-houses make it the chief seller of scent to the rest of the island, and the horses of Doire chaol go from it to three other markets.

**Ros fhionn** has the most towns of any market, fifty-three, from Muileann chaol and the Library in the south to Caol bheag on the north coast. The salt that made the town (3 am Màrt, LE 354, 9 an Lùnastal, LE 959) left it when the harbour silted (29 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,159), but the market-court the salt-masters had set up stayed on the headland (16 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,184), and the hill towns still bring their goods to it. The forge-towns of Baile Mòr uaine and Baile Mòr dhìreach make it the first market in arms. It has no goods of its own to spare for other markets and buys scent, pottery, pearls and amber from them.

**Seann Skell of the Hawk bay** gathers the north-central coast from Doire ghlais and Muileann leathan to Seann Toll. The amber of its strands has been prized since the Age of Ailean (8 an Gearran, GE 1,306), and it is the one good the market sends out, mostly to Ceann leathan. Whale-oil, honey and sheep are its other raw goods. The Tuathaich towns of the Doire ghlais country are in its reach and sell their cloth through it.

**Ros bheag** is the market of the west coast between Cuan shean and the western Seann Skell. Its harbour court was swearing trade oaths on the scorpion's sting by FE 2,145. Its clay, honey and the bog-iron of Àth naomh are worked into pottery and arms, and its surplus cattle and sheep go north to Seann Skell.

**Seann Tarr** is the smallest of the northern markets in people. It began as the feast-market of the ancestor shrine (26 an Dàmhair, LE 644) and is still busiest at the great feasts. Honey and wax, the dyes of Baile fhiadhaich and the hemp of Doire uaine and Achadh naomh are its goods. The hemp goes to the rope-makers chartered there in SE 53.

**Dùn iséal** holds the market of the eastern hills under the old Hall (10 an Dùbhlachd, FE 556). Its reach takes in the silver town, the gold stream of Baile dhìreach, the

copper-town of Àth fhiadhaich (2 an t-Ògmhios, SE 61) and the mills of Muileann bhàn and Muileann gheal. It sends coin-blanks and copper to Baile Mòr dhìreach, Ceann leathan and Seann Skell.

**Baile Mòr dhomhain** is the market of the northern hills (22 an t-Samhain, FE 1,122) and the island's second exporter of livestock. When the coal trade fell away its market day drew more carts than the fair at Muileann òg (30 an t-Sultain, SE 58). Cattle, sheep, venison, horses, the marble of its hills (29 an Dàmhair, LE 1,295) and glass go from it to five other markets.

**Baile Mòr dhìreach** gathers the east coast from Seann Tarr's southern country to Àth bheag. Its shipyards at the two Seann Dunns build more hulls than any other market's, its glass-houses are the oldest on Dia-thìr (8 an Lùnastal, AE 66), and the dyers of Baile Mòr ruadh and the furriers of Àth ruadh sell through it. It buys cattle, sheep, horses and coin-blanks from the hill markets.

**Baile Mòr fhionn** is the chief market of the western plain. Wool was the measure of every bargain there from the Holy Age (12 am Faoilleach, FE 1,699) until the second currency reform (31 an Dàmhair, AE 86). Its country grows grain, wine and cattle and breeds the island's horses and draught oxen. The old salt-pans of Baile ghorm and Seann Warr and the flax-fields of Seann Warr are in its reach, and its scent-makers send scent to Cathair fhada and Seann Skell.

**Cathair fhada** is the market of the south. Its charter dates from Queen Sileas's tally-houses (17 an t-Samhain, LE 287), and its merchants have run the fair at Muileann òg since the fair was first held in the restored kingdom (16 an Dàmhair, SE 21). It sends the pottery of Dùn fhiadhaich north to Ros fhionn and Seann Skell. The Crown grain-store built there in SE 33 is the reserve of the south.

**Ceann mhòr** is the market of the Tuathaich north-west. It was chartered when the humans' harbour officers had gone (23 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3), and it keeps its court in the old harbour store. It has the most varied goods of any market: grain, fish, whale-oil and seal-oil (4 an t-Samhain, FE 2,702), amber, dyes, the tobacco of the concession farms and the tools of Cathair gheal. It sends out more kinds of goods than any other market and buys none.

**Àth fhionn** is the market of the north coast from Inis mhòr's country to Caol mhin. The north coast's fish, whales and sheep come to it, and the whale-boats that go out from it learned their trade from the humans (9 an Dùbhlachd, AE 55). Its own market dates from the Age of Sundering (19 an Gearran, LE 835).

**Muileann fhionn** began as a fort and mill of the human administration and became a Tuathaich market town after the Severance (12 an Giblean, SE 9). It is the island's greatest cattle market. Its droves of cattle and sheep go south to Ceann leathan, Cnoc bhàn, Seann Tarr and Caol ruadh, and it buys arms from Ceann mhòr.

**Cnoc bhàn** is the market of the south-eastern farms above the long mill-race of Muileann fhada (28 an Giblean, LE 1,051). It sells pearls, clay and amber to the other markets. Its forge-towns make tools and field-guns, and its towns are the only ones on Dia-thìr that brew ale for sale.

**Caol ruadh** is the youngest and smallest market. It was chartered after An Cogadh Fada<sup>4</sup> to victual the garrisons and the second fleet at the southern Seann Skell (26 am Faoilleach, DE 23). The glass of Seann Skell and the venison of the strait's woods are its goods.

The **Fèill Muileann òg**<sup>5</sup> is not one of the sixteen. It is a yearly fair with a court of its own (14 an t-Samhain, SE 21), held on the old ford-ground where salt was first traded for wool (10 an Cèitean, GE 1,175). Traders from every shire come to it, and the northern day set aside in SE 55 is the only place where Tuathaich goods are sold under their makers' own marks.

## IV. The Roads of Trade

In the last roll the market-courts recorded 8,058 dealings. In 6,235 of them a market sold goods to one of its towns. In 1,759 a town sold its goods into its market. Only 64 were sales from one market to another. Nearly all the trade of Dia-thìr is near at hand. The dealings between markets are few, yet they carry the goods one country has and another lacks, and six roads of them stand out.

1. **Livestock south from the northern hills.** The largest trade between markets is in cattle, sheep, horses and venison. It runs from Muileann fhionn, Baile Mòr dhomhain and the capital shore south and east to Ceann leathan, Baile Mòr dhìreach, Seann Tarr, Cnoc bhàn and Cathair fhada. Its drove roads are the ones the drovers of Àth chiar first marked with cairns (29 am Faoilleach, LE 484). The dubhan lorries have now replaced the droves on most of them (22 am Màrt, DE 9).
2. **Scent from the capital shore and the western plain.** Scent is the costliest good that goes between markets. It goes from Cathair dhomhain and Baile Mòr fhionn to Ceann leathan, Ros fhionn, Seann Skell and Cathair fhada.
3. **Amber, pearls and whale-oil to the gulf.** The costly things of the coasts go to the dearest market. Amber goes from the Hawk bay and Ceann mhòr, pearls from Cnoc bhàn and Baile Mòr dhìreach, and seal-oil and whale-oil from the north-west, and Ceann leathan takes most of all of them.

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4. the Long War

5. the fair at Muileann òg



4. **Coin-blanks and copper from the eastern hills.** Dùn ìseal sends the blanks of the silver and gold refiners, and the copper of Àth fhiadhaich, to Baile Mòr dhìreach, Ceann leathan and Seann Skell.
5. **Pottery and clay.** Cathair fhada's pottery goes north to Ros fhionn and Seann Skell, and the clay of Cnoc bhàn and Baile Mòr dhìreach goes to the kilns of the north.
6. **Arms from the north-west to the north-western interior.** Ceann mhòr's smiths sell arms to Muileann fhionn, the only road of the arms trade that crosses between markets.

Two things are sold everywhere and seldom carried far: hemp, the cheapest good in every market, and grain. Grain is dearest at Ceann leathan and cheapest at Caol ruadh; hemp is cheapest at Cnoc bhàn.

## V. Taxes and the Treasury

The Crown takes two dues, both set by the council in the first weeks of the kingdom (21 an Faoilleach, SE 4) and collected by the maoir of the shires (Appendix H). The Treasury reckons them in purses of the realm-coin.

**The market-due.** Seventeen in every hundred of the price is taken on every sale a town makes into its market and on every sale between markets. Sales from a market back to its own towns are not charged. The Treasury fixed the due at that rate after An Cogadh Fada<sup>6</sup> and set a clerk in each of the sixteen market towns to take it and keep the market roll (22 an Cèitean, DE 24). It is kept apart from the wartime tithe on every sale of dubhan (21 an Giblean, DE 21), which is still taken at the pumps (29 an Giblean, DE 21) and which the Treasury carried forward after the war as a line of its own under the regiments' pay (27 an Giblean, DE 24). In the last roll the towns' sales into their markets were worth about 18,580 purses, the markets' sales back to their towns about 9,700 and the sales between markets about 200, and the market-due brought the Treasury 3,193 purses.

**The head-due.** Each household pays the head-due for every head in it. It was first collected on the count of SE 7 (27 an t-Sultain, SE 7) and stands at eighteen purses on every hundred thousand heads. It brought in 6,375 purses in the last roll, two parts in three of the Crown's money.

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6. the Long War

The Treasury's roll for the present year comes to 9,568 purses (29 an t-Iuchar, DE 27). The towns' own chests hold about 12,660 purses together, and the towns' yearly product is about 11,460.

**Earlier taxes and currencies.** Before any toll the lords of the shares of the Roinn took their dues from the holdings in kind, a sheaf, a fleece or a sack of meal, and from a holding sworn to two lords both took them (25 am Màrt, FE 4); the Peace of the Threshold ended the double dues with the double oaths (1 an t-Samhain, FE 556). The first toll on Dia-thìr was Goraidh Mòr's road-toll of one fish in twenty (22 an t-Sultain, FE 719). The silver weights of Muileann chiar gave the carriers' roads a common measure (30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 542), and the Hall's clerks first paid in stamped silver rings (20 an Cèitean, FE 1,654). In the Age of Sundering Queen Sileas fixed the firlot of Cathair dhearg as the measure of grain (11 an Dàmhair, LE 261) and set up the tally-houses, the first account of trade kept across the whole island (22 an t-Sultain, LE 284). Ros fhionn salt was the measure of value in the north-east (3 am Màrt, LE 354), and wool was the measure on the western plain. The humans' mark and its hundred pence were struck at Ros dhomhain (10 an Lùnastal, AE 17), and three currency reforms pushed barter out (13 an Gearran, AE 17, 2 an Dàmhair, AE 86, 7 an Giblean, AE 129). The Company's tithe on coal rose without any matching return (16 an Gearran, AE 57) and was extended to grain (4 an Lùnastal, AE 58). The rebels burned the tithe ledgers (9 an t-Iuchar, AE 150). The restored kingdom struck its own realm-coin (30 an Giblean, SE 5) and pegged it to dubhan in DE 15.

## VI. A Chronology of Trade

- 17 an Giblean, VE 1,443 — the fish-kilns of Seann Mhorn, the first buildings made for a trade.
- 12 an Gearran, GE 683 — the salt-pans of Baile ghorm.
- 29 an t-Samhain, GE 1,208 — the ford gathering at Muileann òg: salt, flint, wool, dried fish and pots.
- 8 an Gearran, GE 1,306 — amber from the Hawk bay.
- 5 an Dàmhair, GE 2,468 — the salt road to the north-west.
- 25 am Màrt, FE 4 — the shares of shares: dues in kind to the lords of the Roinn, from some holdings twice.
- 28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 84 — silver for salt at Ros fhionn, the first remembered price.
- 1 an t-Samhain, FE 556 — the Peace of the Threshold; no holding to pay dues to two lords.

- 10 an Dùbhlachd, FE 556 — the market under the Hall at Dùn ìseal.
- 16 am Faoilleach, FE 584 — Ceann leathan's fish-market.
- 22 an t-Sultain, FE 719 — the first road-toll.
- 22 an t-Samhain, FE 1,122 — the market at the fords of Baile Mòr dhomhain.
- 5 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,665 — the harvest fair at Muileann òg.
- 12 am Faoilleach, FE 1,699 — the fleece-measure of Baile Mòr fhionn.
- 9 an Giblean, FE 1,699 — Cathair dhomhain's charter of its own tolls.
- 1 am Faoilleach, FE 2,145 — the sting-oath of trade at Ros bheag.
- 4 an t-Samhain, FE 2,702 — seal-oil from Ceann mhòr.
- 11 an Dàmhair, LE 8 — the rope-walks of Cuan shean.
- 22 an t-Sultain, LE 284 — Queen Sileas's tally-houses; 17 an t-Samhain, LE 287, the market charter of Cathair fhada.
- 3 am Màrt, LE 354 — salt pans at Ros fhionn.
- 28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 435 — the market inside the new gate of Seann Skell.
- 5 an Lùnastal, LE 634 — the oyster beds of Doire shean; 26 an Dàmhair, LE 644, the feast-market at Seann Tarr.
- 11 an t-Samhain, LE 731 — the market of the eastern road at Baile Mòr dhìreach.
- 19 an Gearran, LE 835 — the strand-market at Àth fhionn.
- 9 an Lùnastal, LE 959 — the great salt fair at Ros fhionn.
- 28 an Giblean, LE 1,051 — the market above the mill-race at Cnoc bhàn.
- 16 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,184 — the market-court stays at Ros fhionn.
- 29 an Dàmhair, LE 1,295 — marble from Baile Mòr dhomhain.
- 18 an Dàmhair, LE 1,519 — the cattle fair of Baile Mòr ruadh.
- 1 an Dàmhair, LE 1,626 — the dark wine of Àth shean.
- 28 am Faoilleach, LE 1,674 — the paper mill at Muileann chaol.
- 22 an t-Ògmhios, AE 3 — the humans' trading post at Ros dhomhain.
- 18 an Cèitean, AE 9 — the Company chartered.
- 10 an Lùnastal, AE 17 — the mark and its hundred pence.
- 31 an Dàmhair, AE 52 — tobacco on the concession farms.
- 9 an Dùbhlachd, AE 55 — the first whale-boats of Àth fhionn.
- 8 an Lùnastal, AE 66 — the first glass-house, at Baile Mòr dhìreach.
- 7 an Giblean, AE 129 — barter abolished.

- 23 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3 — the market charter of Ceann mhòr.
- 21 am Faoilleach, SE 4 — the Crown's dues set: the head-due and the market-due.
- 9 an Dàmhair, SE 5 — the mint at Cathair dhearg.
- 27 an t-Sultain, SE 7 — the head-due first collected.
- 12 an Giblean, SE 9 — the cattle-market at Muileann fhionn.
- 16 an Dàmhair, SE 21 — Fèill Muileann òg<sup>7</sup>.
- 15 an Gearran, SE 27 — the scent-makers of Seann Vell.
- 26 an Cèitean, SE 32 — the salt-pans of Àth bheag.
- 19 an t-Sultain, SE 37 — the eastern blank-houses.
- 2 an t-Ògmhios, SE 61 — the copper-town of Àth fhiadhaich.
- 21 an Giblean, DE 21 — the wartime tithe.
- 26 am Faoilleach, DE 23 — the market charter of Caol ruadh.
- 22 an Cèitean, DE 24 — the market-due fixed at seventeen in the hundred.
- 20 an t-Ògmhios, DE 24 — the regiments' arms contracts.
- 7 an t-Sultain, DE 27 — Dubhan's charter: dubhan exported from Ros dhomhain.

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7. the fair at Muileann òg

APPENDIX H

# The Shires of Dia-thìr

Here is set out how Rìoghachd Dia-thìr<sup>1</sup> is divided and governed: the shires, their seats and how they came to be; the Crown's dues and the Treasury; the windy coast of the far north-west, which no shire holds; and the extent of the island's peoples in the present year. It is drawn from the council's minute-books, the Treasury's rolls, the shire record-chests called in to Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>2</sup> (7 am Màrt, SE 66), and the humans' district surveys the kingdom inherited.

## I. The Kingdom

The state styled itself Rìoghachd Dia-thìr<sup>3</sup>, the Kingdom of Dia-thìr, on 27 an t-Iuchar, SE 2, and Niall was crowned at Cathair dhearg on 19 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3. In form it is a monarchy. The crown, a royal council of twelve (23 an t-Sultain, SE 2) and the Treasury sit at Cathair dhearg, and Cathal reigns in the present year. The kingdom counts its years by the eras of the seven ages, and the present year is DE 27 (Appendix D).

The kingdom holds every coast of Dia-thìr and every island off it but one stretch of windswept shore in the far north-west (§ V). It has no neighbour but that shore and the sea. Since the crossing closed there has been no other state within reach of its ships (11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3), and it keeps no envoys and makes no treaties. Its one war has been fought on its own ground, against its own people: An Cogadh Fada<sup>4</sup>, the Long War of DE 21 and DE 22 (Appendix C). The regiments raised for it were not stood down (13 am Faoilleach, DE 23).

The kingdom grew along the island's waters, as the island's people had always done. Three shire seats in five stand on the sea or on a river, and so do nearly half of all the towns.

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1. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr  
2. the Library at Muileann chaol  
3. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr  
4. the Long War

## II. How the Shires Came to Be

**The shares of the Roinn.** The first divisions of the island were made by the heirs of Ailean Mòr, and they were made for the sake of fairness among kin, which is the hardest of all reasons to divide land by. At the parting of the kingdom, *Roinn na Rìoghachd*<sup>5</sup> (1 an t-Samhain, FE 2), the heirs cut the island below the mountain into nine great shares, *carrannan mòra*, with the Red Share of Dùn dhearg beside them and the ground of the Hall at Dùn Ìseal in none. Each great share was parted again into countries, provinces, counties and holdings (25 am Màrt, FE 4). The clerks of the Hall counted nine great shares, forty-four countries and a hundred and thirty-one provinces, and gave up at the counties. Every share was bounded with stones, *clachan-criche*, cut on each face with the sign of the share it looked into; and at every death of a holder the share was parted again, until the Peace of the Threshold (1 an t-Samhain, FE 556) forbade it and fixed the stones where they stood. From then on the holdings passed whole, and the shares gathered by marriage and by lords dying without heirs. Goraidh mac Ìomhair, the first rìgh after Ailean, began as a gatherer of three old counties of the east (3 an Giblean, FE 674).

Most of the shires whose seats were founded in the Age of Ailean and the Holy Age can be traced to a share of the Roinn. The provinces of the rìghrean were, most of them, the provinces of the Roinn under new masters, and the seats the rìghrean gave granaries to were seats the heirs had already quarrelled over. When the humans' surveyors ran their chains across the island they took the old boundary stones for marks without knowing what they were, and so a good many of the district lines the council kept at the drawing, and many shire bounds of the present day, run on the stones set at the Peace of the Threshold. A few of the stones still show a share's sign, worn shallow. The shire of Achadh mhòr keeps one in the wall of its maor's house, cut on its two faces with the signs of two shares, and says it is the stone Fearghas Dà-Mhionn was sworn by.

**The provinces of the Holy Age.** After the Peace the rìghrean made provinces of the gathered shares, for the sake of grain and roads. The census-takers of Beathag Mhòr worked from the waypoint houses, since every household on the island was within a day of one (9 an Gearran, FE 1,735). Lachlann Bàn built a granary in every province seat that would take one (16 am Faoilleach, FE 2,406), and under Coinneach Bàn the clerks of the red hall copied the rolls for the provinces, so that every seat had its own copy of the laws (27 an Giblean, FE 2,832). The Library holds several of those provincial rolls where the originals are lost (24 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,878). Most of the shire

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5. the Division; lit. 'the parting of the kingdom'

seats of the present day were already towns in the Holy Age, and many of them were seats then.

**The shires of the Sundering.** The word *siorrachd* first appears in the sail-cloth levy, when the weaving households of Siorrachd Baile àrsaidh were asked for cloth for the fleet, reckoned on tally-sticks at the shire seat (9 an t-Samhain, LE 9). Through that age the shire was the unit in which the crown's measures were kept. The coppice law of Doire fhionn spread shire by shire (14 an t-Iuchar, LE 109); Queen Sileas fixed the firlot of Cathair dhearg so that the shires need not quarrel over baskets (11 an Dàmhair, LE 261); Iain Ciar ordered a year's grain in store at every shire seat (20 an Giblean, LE 1,299). Two rulers, Sileas Òg and Gormshuil nic Thormoid, went round every shire seat in person (9 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,529, 12 an Giblean, LE 1,771). Doire shean became a shire seat on the wealth of its oyster beds (5 an Lùnastal, LE 634), the only raising of a seat in that age that the annals record.

**The districts of the humans.** The Administration did not use the shires. It governed by districts drawn for the pits, the customs and the Levy, counted the people by district for the first time (19 an Cèitean, AE 122), and set district seats where its clerks found it convenient: at Cnoc bhàn and at Baile Mòr ruadh on the eastern road, among others. One of its districts was hardly land at all. The outer coasts, the islands and the southern edge of the windy coast in the far north-west, where its revenue cutters chased the raiders, were governed from the harbour office at Seann Vell on Eilean ruadh (20 an Giblean, AE 123). Its surveyors went no farther north-west than the edge of the great moss. Beyond it the district map is empty.

**The drawing.** On 12 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3, the council divided the kingdom into shires, each named for its seat, and kept most of the human district lines under the new names. No other survey of the whole island had ever been made. Where the council did not keep a district seat it chose the old shire seat instead; so in the shire of Seann Tarr the seat went back from Baile Mòr ruadh, the humans' district town, to the old harbour. A *maor* was appointed to each shire to collect the Crown's dues and keep its peace (4 am Faoilleach, SE 4). In the Tuathaich shires the maor were Dia-thìrich, lodged in the seat towns. Circuit justices were set to ride among the shires a few years later (23 an Lùnastal, SE 7).

The drawing made one hundred and twenty-two shires. One more was cut later: Doire chaol, the village of the royal household south of the capital, was taken out of the shire of Baile chiar once it had grown large enough to need its own maor (18 an Dàmhair, SE 38). Since then Rìoghachd Dia-thìr<sup>6</sup> has had one hundred and twenty-three shires, and no more.

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6. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

### III. The Shape of the Shires

**Names.** A shire takes the name of its seat, and the island's names repeat, so the shires' names repeat too. Eleven names belong to more than one shire. There are three shires of Seann Skell, three of Seann Vell and three of Ceann mhin, and two each of Caol bheag, Àth shean, Baile ghorm, Achadh naomh, Muileann dhearg, Muileann dhomhain, Doire fhionn and Muileann naomh. The rolls tell them apart by where they lie, as the table in § VII does. Thirteen shires are named from the Old Ones' harbours (Appendix F).

**The island shires.** Two shires have no town at all. Eilean dhìreach, a rock off the Tuathaich coast, and Eilean ìseal, off the east coast, each kept a customs station of the Administration and was a district of its own. The council kept both as shires, for it had no rule by which a district might be folded into its neighbour, and since neither has a town to name it, each is named for its island (20 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3). They are the only shires on Dia-thìr not named for a seat.

**Scattered shires.** The shire of Seann Vell of the west is the Administration's district of the outer coasts, kept whole. Its seat is a small harbour on Eilean ruadh off the west coast. Its towns, Cuan dhearg and Cnoc chaol, stand on Eilean bhàn, hard by the southern coast, where the Great Wave struck (3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 4). Its largest land is the southern edge of the windy coast in the far north-west, where no town stands and the maor goes by boat. With it goes Eilean ghorm. The shire of Seann Vell of the south-east holds Eilean dhearg, the old island of the dead (Appendix F), with Eilean gheal and Eilean mhin, except for a corner of Eilean dhearg that belongs to Àth fhionn. The second Caol bheag, of the northern strait, lies on Eilean fhada with Eilean bheag, and Caol mhin on Eilean chrom with Eilean dhubh. On the main island, one town of the shire of Tobar ghorm, Baile gheal, lies apart from the rest.

**Seats that are not the largest town.** In five shires the seat is smaller than another town in the same shire. Caol leathan, the strait town, is the seat and not Baile Mòr fhionn, the lords' city of the western plain. Baile àrsaidh is the seat and not Seann Bhral of the west coast. Cnoc dhubh of the charcoal-burners is the seat and not Doire fhiadhaich, the citadel village of the same hills. Baile Mòr dhomhain is the seat and not Cuan bheag. Seann Vell of the west is the seat and not Cuan dhearg. In each case the council kept the seat the humans' district had, or the older shire had, and did not follow the growth of the towns.

**The Tuathaich shires.** Eleven shires lie wholly or mostly in the Tuathaich north and north-west: Caol mhòr, Ceann mhòr, Doire ghlas, Baile chrom, Cnoc ghorm, Cnoc thais, Àth àrsaidh, Muileann leathan, Muileann àrsaidh, Baile ìseal and the is-



land shire of Eilean dhìreach. Two of them keep one Dia-thìrich town each: Baile dhubh in Cnoc ghorm, and Achadh fhiadhaich in Muileann àrsaidh. Three Dia-thìrich shires have one Tuathaich town: Seann Skell of the west has Àth leathan, Muileann naomh of the west has Àth chrom, and Inis mhin on the northern shore has one town of each people. The windy coast in Seann Vell of the west is Tuathaich country too, though the shire's towns are Dia-thìrich. The boundary stones on the roads north (31 an t-Iuchar, SE 1) mark where the Tuathaich country begins; they are the bounds of no shire. The Moot at Caol mhòr has no standing in any shire court (25 an Lùnastal, SE 2).

**One kind of shire.** Every shire is a *siorrachd*, and the kingdom knows no other kind of division. The capital's shire, the Tuathaich shires, the island shires and the scattered shires have the same standing, the same officer and the same dues. The humans' distinctions of district, concession and Residency ground were dropped at the drawing.

## IV. The Crown's Dues and the Treasury

The maor of each shire collects two dues for the Crown, set by the council in the first weeks of the kingdom (21 an Faoilleach, SE 4). The head-due, *cis-cinn*, is laid on every household by the number of its heads, and so falls on the whole people of the kingdom, in town and country alike. The market-due, *cis-margaidh*, is taken on every sale made by a seller of the kingdom, in a market or out of one. The humans' tariff, which the harbour-masters of Ros dhomhain kept in force for want of another (8 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3), was folded into the market-due when the kingdom's own coin replaced the humans' mark (30 an Giblean, SE 5).

Beside the two dues the Treasury carries the wartime tithe on every sale of dubhan, laid "for the war" in DE 21 and never repealed (27 an Giblean, DE 24), which pays the regiments. The shires keep what the council allows them for their own works: Cnoc leathan paid for a school in every parish from the shire's dues (21 an Giblean, SE 50), and the shire of Baile ruadh fenced the open shafts at its own cost (3 an Lùnastal, SE 52). The first relief the kingdom ever granted came from the Treasury: seed for the survivors of Achadh mhin when their fields lay under salt (6 an Dùbhlachd, SE 4).

The Treasury reckons in purses, *sporain*, of the realm's coin. Its roll for the present year (29 an t-Iuchar, DE 27) stands as follows:

| DUE                                 | RATE                                            | YIELD IN THE PRESENT YEAR |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| Head-due ( <i>cis-cinn</i> )        | eighteen purses on every hundred thousand heads | 6,375 purses              |
| Market-due ( <i>cis-mar-gaidh</i> ) | seventeen in the hundred of the price           | 3,193 purses              |
| <b>The roll</b>                     |                                                 | <b>9,568 purses</b>       |

Two parts in three of the Crown’s money come from heads and one from trade. The kingdom counted 35,415,000 heads for the head-due in the present year. The head-due has stood at its rate since it was first collected (27 an t-Sultain, SE 7), and the market-due at seventeen in the hundred since the Treasury fixed it after the Long War (22 an Cèitean, DE 24). The windy coast pays neither due, and the roll carries no line for it.

## V. The Windy Coast

In the far north-west, beyond the Tuathaich shires and past the northern edge of Seann Vell’s lands, lies a low shore of heather moor, blanket bog and bare rock, open to the gales off the north-western sea, that no shire holds. The Dia-thìrich call it *an Oirthir Ghaothach*<sup>7</sup>, the windy coast. It is a little under two parts in a hundred of the island’s land, some 93 square miles, in two pieces: a long stretch of shore, and a small cape to the east of it. Its bays open on the waters where the raiders have sheltered since the Age of Strangers (10 an Giblean, AE 16, 4 an t-Sultain, SE 12), and the sea-beast of the north-west cape is reported off it (12 am Màrt, AE 55, 9 an Gearran, SE 20).

**Why no one holds it.** The humans’ surveyors stopped at the edge of the great moss, which no chain can cross (20 an Giblean, AE 123), and when the council drew the shires on the humans’ lines it drew nothing where there were no lines. Its minute says only that the windy coast “is not in the survey” (15 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3). No council since has taken it in. It has no coal, no field and no harbour the kingdom has any use for. A shire there would need a maor, and a maor there would need the fleet to keep the raiders’ bays, and when the raiders came to Cathair gheal the council, asked twice, sent no help (8 an Giblean, SE 20). The Moot claims no land of its own and has never asked for it.

**Who lives there.** Tuathaich families keep the windy coast: sealers, fowlers, and herders on the moor’s edge, in no town. The kingdom has never counted them. The Moot’s tallies put them near nine thousand, a figure the royal clerks do not accept. No maor, justice or census clerk has gone there, and they pay no due.

7. the windy coast

**In the Long War.** When Cnoc thais fell, some of its holdouts went on past the hills and out onto the windy coast, and the regiments did not follow them beyond the shire line (10 an Lùnastal, DE 21). The open record of the war names the kingdom's enemy only as those "of no shire". The holdouts who came down to the seventh regiment's posts after Muileann ghlas (10 an Dùbhlachd, DE 22) came from the hills; whether any came back from the coast, no roll says.

## VI. The Peoples on the Land

The land of Dia-thìr, with its islands, is some 5,340 square miles, of which the shires hold some 5,250. The two living peoples share it between them much as they share the towns. The Old Ones hold none of it. Their names remain on thirty towns and thirteen shires, and no household of theirs is counted anywhere (Appendix F).

| PEOPLE        | TOWNS | SHARE OF THE ISLAND'S LAND                                                                       | IN THE TOWNS | IN THE COUNTRY                                         |
|---------------|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Dia-thìrich   | 441   | some eighty-five parts in a hundred (about 4,520 square miles)                                   | 4,411,000    | 27,224,000                                             |
| Tuathaich     | 64    | some fifteen parts in a hundred (about 825 square miles), of which the windy coast is nearly two | 543,000      | 3,237,000 within the shires; the windy coast uncounted |
| Seann-Dhaoine | none  | none                                                                                             | —            | —                                                      |

The figures are the kingdom's count for the present year, on which the head-due is laid. The Dia-thìrich country is the capital's shire and every shire of the south, the east and the centre. The Tuathaich country is the north and north-west, and its middle lies in the shire of Cnoc ghorm. Together the two peoples number some 35,415,000 within the shires, one in seven of them in a town.

## VII. The Table of Shires

The shires are listed in the order of the council's roll, which begins with the capital. *Seat founded* gives the age in which the seat town was founded, from the gazetteer. *People of its towns* gives the people of the shire's towns; where a shire has towns of both, the number of each.

| NO. | SHIRE          | SEAT           | TOWNS | PEOPLE<br>OF ITS<br>TOWNS  | SEAT<br>FOUN-<br>DED     | NOTES                                                                                                                                       |
|-----|----------------|----------------|-------|----------------------------|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Cathair dhearg | Cathair dhearg | 1     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean            | The royal shire, the smallest of the great seats; the capital and nothing else                                                              |
| 2   | Caol leathan   | Caol leathan   | 2     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean            | Baile Mòr fhionn, the lords' city of the western plain, is larger than the seat; the shire kept the strait town, where the tolls were taken |
| 3   | Seann Skell    | Seann Skell    | 7     | Dia-thìrich 6, Tuathaich 1 | Ancient Age (Old Ones)   | The western Seann Skell, the great river port; its one Tuathaich town is Àth leathan, the pit town where the Long War began                 |
| 4   | Seann Skell    | Seann Skell    | 3     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean (Old Ones) | The southern Seann Skell, the fleet harbour and the Rite's house                                                                            |
| 5   | Ros dhomhain   | Ros dhomhain   | 3     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean            | The Residency stood above the seat in the Age of Strangers                                                                                  |
| 6   | Cnoc bheag     | Cnoc bheag     | 9     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean            | The carved stone and the sixth regiment                                                                                                     |
| 7   | Caol mhòr      | Caol mhòr      | 14    | Tuathaich                  | Age of Ailean            | Tuathaich; the Moot meets at the seat (25 an Lùnastal, SE 2); the boundary stones stand on its southern roads (31 an t-Iuchar, SE 1)        |
| 8   | Caol bheag     | Caol bheag     | 3     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean            | Caol bheag of the Abhainn ghorm                                                                                                             |
| 9   | Inis bhàn      | Inis bhàn      | 2     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean            | White-island river port and Hawk shrines                                                                                                    |
| 10  | Doire shean    | Doire shean    | 2     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean            | The oyster trade made the seat rich enough to be a shire seat in the Age of Sundering (5 an Lùnastal, LE 634)                               |
| 11  | Àth shean      | Àth shean      | 5     | Dia-thìrich                | Holy Age                 | Àth shean of the south                                                                                                                      |
| 12  | Achadh mhòr    | Achadh mhòr    | 2     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean            | The great granary fields                                                                                                                    |
| 13  | Seann Bhral    | Seann Bhral    | 2     | Dia-thìrich                | Ancient Age (Old Ones)   | The south-east's great walled harbour                                                                                                       |
| 14  | Ceann mhòr     | Ceann mhòr     | 6     | Tuathaich                  | Holy Age                 | Tuathaich; the maor keeps the old human magistrate's house (4 am Faoilleach, SE 4)                                                          |

| NO. | SHIRE             | SEAT              | TOWNS | PEOPLE<br>OF ITS<br>TOWNS | SEAT<br>FOUN-<br>DED   | NOTES                                                                                                                       |
|-----|-------------------|-------------------|-------|---------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 15  | Inis thais        | Inis thais        | 4     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | The shires of the Stone in the south-west count their own people (28 an Lùnastal, SE 65)                                    |
| 16  | Dùn thais         | Dùn thais         | 5     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Dùn thais of the east; the rolls mark it east against the western Dùn thais in the shire of Ros bheag (2 an Gearran, SE 38) |
| 17  | Inis chrom        | Inis chrom        | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Bent isle harbour and the Fianna's sailors                                                                                  |
| 18  | Doire mhin        | Doire mhin        | 6     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | The great grove-village of the north road                                                                                   |
| 19  | Doire fhi-adhaich | Doire fhi-adhaich | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Timber for Cathair fhada                                                                                                    |
| 20  | Baile ghar-bh     | Baile ghar-bh     | 5     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Rough-town wool market                                                                                                      |
| 21  | Ceann mhin        | Ceann mhin        | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Ceann mhin of the south                                                                                                     |
| 22  | Baile ghlas       | Baile ghlas       | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Rope-walks and sail-lofts                                                                                                   |
| 23  | Doire ghlas       | Doire ghlas       | 3     | Tuathaich                 | Age of Ailean          | Tuathaich; the heart of the Church in the north; counted from the road (15 an Lùnastal, SE 7)                               |
| 24  | Cathair mhòr      | Cathair mhòr      | 1     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | The great city beside the old outpost                                                                                       |
| 25  | Baile ghorm       | Baile ghorm       | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Baile ghorm of the south-west                                                                                               |
| 26  | Achadh naomh      | Achadh naomh      | 4     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Achadh naomh of the north-central country                                                                                   |
| 27  | Baile Mòr mhòr    | Baile Mòr mhòr    | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Its first maor held court under the market roof (8 am Màrt, SE 4)                                                           |
| 28  | Baile chrom       | Baile chrom       | 1     | Tuathaich                 | Age of Ailean          | Tuathaich; one town only, beside the north-western lighthouse                                                               |
| 29  | Muileann mhin     | Muileann mhin     | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | The capital's flour mills                                                                                                   |
| 30  | Caol ghar-bh      | Caol ghar-bh      | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Boatyards on the rough strait                                                                                               |
| 31  | Seann Chwen       | Seann Chwen       | 9     | Dia-thìrich               | Ancient Age (Old Ones) | The Còmhrag is fought at Ceann leathan in this shire                                                                        |

| NO. | SHIRE               | SEAT                | TOWNS | PEOPLE<br>OF ITS<br>TOWNS          | SEAT<br>FOUN-<br>DED | NOTES                                                                                                       |
|-----|---------------------|---------------------|-------|------------------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 32  | Cathair<br>dhomhain | Cathair<br>dhomhain | 3     | Dia-thìrich                        | Holy Age             | Deep-water harbour beside the capital                                                                       |
| 33  | Àth shean           | Àth shean           | 3     | Dia-thìrich                        | Age of Ailean        | Àth shean of the centre                                                                                     |
| 34  | Muileann<br>bhàn    | Muileann<br>bhàn    | 3     | Dia-thìrich                        | Age of Ailean        | White mills and citadel of the coal road                                                                    |
| 35  | Dùn iséal           | Dùn iséal           | 8     | Dia-thìrich                        | Age of Ailean        | The great temple of the Old Spirits, on the hill of Brìde's flame                                           |
| 36  | Cnoc<br>ghorm       | Cnoc<br>ghorm       | 6     | Dia-thìrich<br>1, Tuatha-<br>ich 5 | Age of Ailean        | Tuathaich but for one Dia-thìrich town, Baile dhubh; the middle of the Tuathaich country lies in this shire |
| 37  | Cnoc<br>leathan     | Cnoc leath-<br>an   | 5     | Dia-thìrich                        | Holy Age             | The first shire to open a school in every parish, from the shire's dues (21 an Giblean, SE 50)              |
| 38  | Cuan<br>shean       | Cuan shean          | 5     | Dia-thìrich                        | Age of Ailean        | The fourth fleet's harbour                                                                                  |
| 39  | Àth chìar           | Àth chìar           | 3     | Dia-thìrich                        | Holy Age             | The rebels' keep and southern cattle-market                                                                 |
| 40  | Doire<br>fhada      | Doire fhada         | 2     | Dia-thìrich                        | Holy Age             | Ship-timber and the fenced oak                                                                              |
| 41  | Achadh<br>naomh     | Achadh na-<br>omh   | 4     | Dia-thìrich                        | Holy Age             | Achadh naomh of the north-east                                                                              |
| 42  | Muileann<br>dhearg  | Muileann<br>dhearg  | 2     | Dia-thìrich                        | Holy Age             | Muileann dhearg by Cathair mhòr                                                                             |
| 43  | Baile<br>ghorm      | Baile ghorm         | 4     | Dia-thìrich                        | Holy Age             | Baile ghorm of the south-east, the market of its shire                                                      |
| 44  | Dùn<br>chrom        | Dùn chrom           | 7     | Dia-thìrich                        | Age of Ailean        | The citadel above Muileann ghlas                                                                            |
| 45  | Ros gheal           | Ros gheal           | 2     | Dia-thìrich                        | Holy Age             | The Hawk houses' birth-rolls (10 an Dùbhlachd, SE 65)                                                       |
| 46  | Cill<br>dhìreach    | Cill<br>dhìreach    | 2     | Dia-thìrich                        | Holy Age             | Chapel-town of the Ceann leath-an meile                                                                     |
| 47  | Doire<br>chìar      | Doire chìar         | 4     | Dia-thìrich                        | Age of Ailean        | Disputations under the oaks                                                                                 |
| 48  | Caol shean          | Caol shean          | 9     | Dia-thìrich                        | Age of Ailean        | The great eastern river port, pilgrims' landing                                                             |
| 49  | Cathair<br>fhada    | Cathair<br>fhada    | 2     | Dia-thìrich                        | Age of Ailean        | Merchants of the Fèill Muileann òg                                                                          |

| NO. | SHIRE             | SEAT              | TOWNS | PEOPLE<br>OF ITS<br>TOWNS | SEAT<br>FOUN-<br>DED   | NOTES                                                                                                                                                             |
|-----|-------------------|-------------------|-------|---------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 50  | Baile mhin        | Baile mhin        | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Sheltered river quays of the north-east                                                                                                                           |
| 51  | Seann Skell       | Seann Skell       | 4     | Dia-thìrich               | Ancient Age (Old Ones) | Seann Skell of the Hawk bay                                                                                                                                       |
| 52  | Baile chiar       | Baile chiar       | 5     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Market of the capital's southern country                                                                                                                          |
| 53  | Cnoc mhòr         | Cnoc mhòr         | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Cattle market below Cathair mhòr                                                                                                                                  |
| 54  | Tobar fhi-adhaich | Tobar fhi-adhaich | 7     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Wild spring and moorland grazing                                                                                                                                  |
| 55  | Ros gharbh        | Ros gharbh        | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Sundering       | The gulf's fishing fleet                                                                                                                                          |
| 56  | Tobar ghorm       | Tobar ghorm       | 5     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | One town, Baile gheal, lies apart from the rest of the shire, cut off by the shire of Muileann bheag                                                              |
| 57  | Àth fhi-adhaich   | Àth fhi-adhaich   | 1     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Wild ford of the eastern road, in the south-eastern hills                                                                                                         |
| 58  | Baile chaol       | Baile chaol       | 6     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Terraced houses and the valley toll                                                                                                                               |
| 59  | Muileann dhomhain | Muileann dhomhain | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Muileann dhomhain of the south-east                                                                                                                               |
| 60  | Seann Tarr        | Seann Tarr        | 7     | Dia-thìrich               | Ancient Age (Old Ones) | The humans' district seat was Baile Mòr ruadh; the kingdom set the seat back at the old harbour. The shire's chest was burned rather than sent (7 am Màrt, SE 66) |
| 61  | Achadh shean      | Achadh shean      | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | The twelve wells of the drove road (6 an t-Samhain, SE 43)                                                                                                        |
| 62  | Muileann shean    | Muileann shean    | 5     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | The oldest mill-wheel in the north                                                                                                                                |
| 63  | Tobar dhearg      | Tobar dhearg      | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | The southern lighthouse and red well                                                                                                                              |
| 64  | Baile àr-saidh    | Baile àr-saidh    | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | The sail-cloth levy was reckoned at the seat (9 an t-Samhain, LE 9); Seann Bhral of the west coast, in this shire, is a little larger than the seat               |
| 65  | Cuan ghlas        | Cuan ghlas        | 7     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | The grey river port and its citadel                                                                                                                               |

| NO. | SHIRE                 | SEAT                  | TOWNS | PEOPLE<br>OF ITS<br>TOWNS | SEAT<br>FOUN-<br>DED   | NOTES                                                                                         |
|-----|-----------------------|-----------------------|-------|---------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 66  | Doire fhionn          | Doire fhionn          | 7     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Doire fhionn of the east                                                                      |
| 67  | Doire chaol           | Doire chaol           | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Strangers       | Cut from the shire of Baile chiar in SE 38, the only shire made after the drawing             |
| 68  | Seann Toll            | Seann Toll            | 4     | Dia-thìrich               | Ancient Age (Old Ones) | Sea-caves and the north-coast her-<br>ring                                                    |
| 69  | Baile ru-<br>adh      | Baile ruadh           | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Red-earth fields of the east                                                                  |
| 70  | Àth bheag             | Àth bheag             | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | East-coast ford under pirate<br>watch                                                         |
| 71  | Ceann àr-<br>saidh    | Ceann àr-<br>saidh    | 6     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Ancient headland on the capital's<br>river road to the east                                   |
| 72  | Caol fhi-<br>adhaich  | Caol fhi-<br>adhaich  | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Strait-pilots and the harbour<br>wolf-stone                                                   |
| 73  | Baile fhi-<br>adhaich | Baile fhi-<br>adhaich | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | West-coast market harbour                                                                     |
| 74  | Seann Vell            | Seann Vell            | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Ancient Age (Old Ones) | Seann Vell of the capital's east                                                              |
| 75  | Cnoc thais            | Cnoc thais            | 4     | Tuathaich                 | Age of Ailean          | Tuathaich; taken in the Long<br>War (2 an Lùnastal, DE 21)                                    |
| 76  | Muileann<br>chrom     | Muileann<br>chrom     | 11    | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | The overseers' town; the stoppage<br>began here (27 am Màrt, AE 143)                          |
| 77  | Ros bheag             | Ros bheag             | 4     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Citadel harbour of the western<br>coast                                                       |
| 78  | Cnoc àr-<br>saidh     | Cnoc àr-<br>saidh     | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | Shrines of the Stone and the pan-<br>ther watch                                               |
| 79  | Inis bheag            | Inis bheag            | 6     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Boatyards of the small isle                                                                   |
| 80  | Àth<br>fhionn         | Àth fhionn            | 1     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | Holds a corner of Eilean dhearg,<br>whose larger part lies in the<br>south-eastern Seann Vell |
| 81  | Achadh àr-<br>saidh   | Achadh àr-<br>saidh   | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age               | The river quays that feed the cap-<br>ital                                                    |
| 82  | Cuan ru-<br>adh       | Cuan ruadh            | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Age of Ailean          | The island's easternmost harbour                                                              |
| 83  | Seann<br>Bhrenn       | Seann<br>Bhrenn       | 2     | Dia-thìrich               | Ancient Age (Old Ones) | The northern Seann-Dhaoine<br>harbour                                                         |



| NO. | SHIRE             | SEAT              | TOWNS | PEOPLE<br>OF ITS<br>TOWNS  | SEAT<br>FOUN-<br>DED   | NOTES                                                                               |
|-----|-------------------|-------------------|-------|----------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 84  | Cnoc shean        | Cnoc shean        | 4     | Dia-thìrich                | Holy Age               | Old hill market of the granary fields                                               |
| 85  | Dùn dhearg        | Dùn dhearg        | 6     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean          | The red fort city of the east                                                       |
| 86  | Àth àr-saidh      | Àth àrsaidh       | 8     | Tuathaich                  | Age of Ailean          | Tuathaich; the truce of the Severance was made at the seat (2 an t-Samhain, AE 150) |
| 87  | Cnoc dhìreach     | Cnoc dhìreach     | 2     | Dia-thìrich                | Holy Age               | Walled seat of the mining district                                                  |
| 88  | Muileann leathan  | Muileann leathan  | 6     | Tuathaich                  | Age of Ailean          | Tuathaich; the high pastures (3 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,717)                             |
| 89  | Achadh chaol      | Achadh chaol      | 6     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean          | Narrow barley fields                                                                |
| 90  | Muileann dhomhain | Muileann dhomhain | 4     | Dia-thìrich                | Holy Age               | Muileann dhomhain of the east                                                       |
| 91  | Inis mhin         | Inis mhin         | 2     | Dia-thìrich 1, Tuathaich 1 | Holy Age               | Dia-thìrich and Tuathaich, one town each                                            |
| 92  | Caol ìseal        | Caol ìseal        | 4     | Dia-thìrich                | Holy Age               | Salt pans of the low strait                                                         |
| 93  | Cnoc na-omh       | Cnoc na-omh       | 4     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean          | The priests who buried Muileann ghlas's dead                                        |
| 94  | Àth ghlas         | Àth ghlas         | 2     | Dia-thìrich                | Holy Age               | Grey ford below the ruined outpost                                                  |
| 95  | Seann Warr        | Seann Warr        | 1     | Dia-thìrich                | Ancient Age (Old Ones) | The fifth regiment's walled harbour                                                 |
| 96  | Muileann dhearg   | Muileann dhearg   | 4     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Sundering       | Baile thais, in this shire, holds a shire court of its own (6 an Lùnastal, SE 12)   |
| 97  | Àth dhomhain      | Àth dhomhain      | 3     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Sundering       | The citadel seat since the troubles before the Severance                            |
| 98  | Inis mhòr         | Inis mhòr         | 2     | Dia-thìrich                | Age of Ailean          | North-eastern river fleet and debating halls                                        |
| 99  | Ceann mhin        | Ceann mhin        | 5     | Dia-thìrich                | Holy Age               | Ceann mhin of the north-east                                                        |
| 100 | Seann Dunn        | Seann Dunn        | 4     | Dia-thìrich                | Ancient Age (Old Ones) | The Seann-Dhaoine harbour-mole                                                      |
| 101 | Ceann leathan     | Ceann leathan     | 2     | Dia-thìrich                | Holy Age               | Broad headland harbour of the east                                                  |

| NO. | SHIRE              | SEAT               | TOWNS | PEOPLE<br>OF ITS<br>TOWNS   | SEAT<br>FOUN-<br>DED | NOTES                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----|--------------------|--------------------|-------|-----------------------------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 102 | Cnoc gheal         | Cnoc gheal         | 6     | Dia-thìrich                 | Holy Age             | The white hill market of the north-east                                                                                                                   |
| 103 | Muileann bheag     | Muileann bheag     | 9     | Dia-thìrich                 | Holy Age             | Flour for the north-east harbours                                                                                                                         |
| 104 | Ceann bheag        | Ceann bheag        | 4     | Dia-thìrich                 | Holy Age             | Citadel harbour of the north-east                                                                                                                         |
| 105 | Muileann àrsaidh   | Muileann àrsaidh   | 11    | Dia-thìrich 1, Tuathaich 10 | Age of Ailean        | Tuathaich but for one Dia-thìrich town; the northern concession (3 an t-Samhain, AE 20); the seat is the elder of the two Muileann àrsaidh                |
| 106 | Cill thais         | Cill thais         | 3     | Dia-thìrich                 | Holy Age             | Wardens of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag                                                                                                                        |
| 107 | Baile ìseal        | Baile ìseal        | 4     | Tuathaich                   | Age of Sundering     | Tuathaich                                                                                                                                                 |
| 108 | Baile gheal        | Baile gheal        | 2     | Dia-thìrich                 | Age of Ailean        | White cloth of the western plain                                                                                                                          |
| 109 | Ceann mhin         | Ceann mhin         | 5     | Dia-thìrich                 | Age of Ailean        | Ceann mhin of the south-east, rival of Ceann chaol                                                                                                        |
| 110 | Cnoc dhubh         | Cnoc dhubh         | 17    | Dia-thìrich                 | Holy Age             | The seat is the charcoal-burners' Cnoc dhubh; Doire fhiadhaich, the citadel village, is larger; a second Cnoc dhubh, the walled market, lies in the shire |
| 111 | Baile Mòr dhomhain | Baile Mòr dhomhain | 13    | Dia-thìrich                 | Holy Age             | Cuan bheag, the river mooring, is a little larger than the seat                                                                                           |
| 112 | Muileann chiar     | Muileann chiar     | 5     | Dia-thìrich                 | Age of Sundering     | Coal mills of the eastern district                                                                                                                        |
| 113 | Doire fhionn       | Doire fhionn       | 5     | Dia-thìrich                 | Holy Age             | Doire fhionn of the north; the coppice law began here (14 an t-Iuchar, LE 109)                                                                            |
| 114 | Cnoc bhàn          | Cnoc bhàn          | 9     | Dia-thìrich                 | Holy Age             | The seat was a district seat of the Administration                                                                                                        |
| 115 | Àth mhòr           | Àth mhòr           | 2     | Dia-thìrich                 | Age of Ailean        | Walled great ford of the north                                                                                                                            |
| 116 | Muileann naomh     | Muileann naomh     | 2     | Dia-thìrich                 | Age of Ailean        | Muileann naomh of the south                                                                                                                               |
| 117 | Muileann naomh     | Muileann naomh     | 7     | Dia-thìrich 6, Tuathaich 1  | Holy Age             | Muileann naomh of the west; one Tuathaich town                                                                                                            |
| 118 | Caol bheag         | Caol bheag         | 1     | Dia-thìrich                 | Holy Age             | The second Caol bheag, on Eilean fhada, with Eilean bheag                                                                                                 |

| NO. | SHIRE           | SEAT                                   | TOWNS | PEOPLE<br>OF ITS<br>TOWNS | SEAT<br>FOUN-<br>DED         | NOTES                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|-----|-----------------|----------------------------------------|-------|---------------------------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 119 | Caol mhin       | Caol mhin                              | 1     | Dia-thìrich               | Holy Age                     | On Eilean chrom, with Eilean dhubh                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 120 | Seann Vell      | Seann Vell                             | 3     | Dia-thìrich               | Ancient<br>Age (Old<br>Ones) | The shire of the outer coasts: its seat on Eilean ruadh off the west coast, Eilean bhàn with Cuan dhearg and Cnoc chaol in the south, Eilean ghorm, and the southern edge of the windy coast in the far north-west |
| 121 | Seann Vell      | Seann Vell                             | 1     | Dia-thìrich               | Ancient<br>Age (Old<br>Ones) | Seann Vell of the south-east: Eilean dhearg, Eilean gheal and Eilean mhin                                                                                                                                          |
| 122 | Eilean dhìreach | — (the is-<br>land Eilean<br>dhìreach) | 0     | Tuathaich<br>(no town)    | —                            | An island shire with no town, named for its island                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 123 | Eilean ìseal    | — (the is-<br>land Eilean<br>ìseal)    | 0     | Dia-thìrich<br>(no town)  | —                            | An island shire with no town, named for its island                                                                                                                                                                 |



APPENDIX I

# The Land and Waters of Dia-thìr

Here is described the ground on which these things were done: the size and shape of the island, its countries and what covers them, the central mountains and the lesser hills, the rivers and their courses, Loch chrom, the offshore islands, the climate, and the sea and its mist. The measurements are those of the humans' surveys, which the council kept when it drew the shires, and the heights are the surveyors' heights above the sea. Where the annals record a change in the land, the date is given.

## The island

Dia-thìr is a little over a hundred and fifty miles from the capes of the far north-west to the eastern cape, and nowhere much more than seventy miles from the north coast to the south. The main island covers about five thousand three hundred square miles, near fourteen thousand of the square measure the humans call the kilometre. Twelve small islands lie off its coasts, and the largest of them is some eight square miles. One sea surrounds all of it, and the Dia-thìrich call it by one name on every coast, north and south: *Muir Mhanannain*<sup>1</sup>, Manannan's sea, for the lord of the sea whose mist lay on it and hid the island from every ship beyond until the humans came down out of it from the north (13 am Faoilleach, AE 1, 5 an Gearran, AE 1). Dia-thìr lies alone in it. The humans' charts put the nearest shore of their own land some sixty miles east of the eastern cape, among a chain of low islands, and a greater coast a hundred miles to the south-east; no one on the island has seen either, even from the summits on the clearest day, for the mist lies on that sea.

The coasts are unlike one another. The north coast is long and broken, cut by straits and sounds into headlands and near-islands, and most of the places named *Caol* (strait), *Ros* (headland) and *Ceann* (point) lie along it. Its one wide bay is the Hawk bay, shared by Ros gheal, Ros leathan and Seann Skell. The south coast is shorter and

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1. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

more sheltered. Its great inlet is the gulf, which the Abhainn uaine reaches at Cathair mhòr and whose mouth Ros bhàn guards from its white headland. On the west coast the Abhainn gheal comes down to the sea at Inis thais and Caol leathan, and every boat bound for the capital's waters passes between them. The east coast runs from the eastern narrows round the eastern cape, where the light of Baile ìseal stands (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal<sup>2</sup>).

The sea has taken land more than once. In the Ancient Age it rose over the low neck that joined Eilean dhubh to the main island (13 an t-Iuchar, VE 506). A storm drove it over the harbour of Seann Chwen (18 an Dùbhlachd, FE 879), and in the first years of the new kingdom the Great Wave came in over the southern coast in a single night (3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 4).

## The countries and what covers them

About two parts in five of Dia-thìr is open moor, heather, bog and short grass with no trees on it except in the valleys. Three parts in ten are birch and pine. A fifth is wet woodland of oak, alder and hazel. Something under a tenth is the drier oak woods of the east and the capital's country. The fens, the grass plateau of Dùn dhearg and the rough grazing at the north-western end of the shire of Seann Vell make up the rest.

**The northern moors.** The whole northern third of the island, from the Tuathach country in the north-west to the harbours of the north-east, is low moor, most of it under a hundred and fifty feet. The winters there are long, wet and windy, snow lies on the moor for days at a time and on the higher ground for weeks, and the summers are short and dry. Trees grow only in the sheltered valleys. The groves that give so many northern villages their *Doire* names are some of these: oak, birch and hazel in the hollows, with bog and heather between them. The pollen in the bog under Doire ghlas shows that the oak came to these lowlands after the cold years (11 an Lùnastal, VE 378), and that it fell back again when the winters lengthened (19 an t-Sultain, GE 3,588). The groves have stood in the valleys ever since. The moor is sheep country. It keeps the wool fairs of Tobar ghorm and Baile gharbh, the peat banks of Achadh gharbh and Cnoc dhubh, and barley and oats in every hollow that will take them. The north's largest towns are all on the coast or close to it: Caol mhòr, Doire ghlas, Baile Mòr mhòr on its northern plain (13 an t-Sultain, GE 2,616), and the harbours of the Hawk bay.

**The windy coast.** At the far north-western horn of the island the moor gives out onto an *Oirthir Ghaothach*<sup>3</sup>, the windy coast, about ninety-three square miles that no

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2. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

shire holds, and onto the rough grazing at the northern end of Seann Vell's shire beside it. It is the barest ground on Dia-thìr: low heather moor and blanket bog with no tree on it, open to the gales off the north-western sea, which have kept it bare since the oak came to the rest of the island (22 an Lùnastal, VE 451). Behind the shore lies the great moss, bog that no cart and no surveyor's chain can cross. The shore itself has seal-rocks, skerries and fowling cliffs, and sea mist lies on it for days together in summer. The windy coast keeps, by the Moot's tally, about nine thousand people, sealers, fowlers and herders, in no town, and the northern end of Seann Vell's shire about twice as many.

**The birch and pine country.** South of the moors a broad belt of birch and pine crosses the island from the western plain to the eastern hills, rising from under two hundred feet in the west to the skirts of the central mountains. It is the largest single stretch of woodland on Dia-thìr, with hill pasture in its clearings. The Abhainn ìseal runs through the middle of it, past Inis bhàn and Cnoc bheag, and the western hills rise at its south-western edge.

**The central mountains.** East of the middle of the island the ground rises into the central mountains, a single massif about fifty miles from west to east and twenty-five from north to south, from the hills behind the capital's country to the eastern foothills. The Doire uaine hills are its heart. The highest summit, Binnean a' Chlachair<sup>4</sup>, the Mason's Point, stands a little under three thousand six hundred feet, above Muileann gheal. Dùn ìseal, where the flame was kept, stands at about two thousand six hundred feet under the summit ridge (28 an t-Ògmhios, FE 4), and the silver town of Muileann chiar at nearly three thousand. The vein lies under this massif. The crack at Tobar dhìreach is at about two thousand six hundred feet, and the high valleys round it, where the first hearths lie under the turf at Achadh dhìreach, are the oldest ground on the island known to have been settled (16 an Cèitean, VE 303). The high ground is birch and pine below and bare moor above. Snowfields lay on the summits in the cold years (14 an t-Ògmhios, VE 227), and snow still lies late on the high passes in a hard spring (13 an Giblean, FE 2,472). The warm springs below Muileann ruadh (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>5</sup>) come up on the south-eastern side of the massif. On the eastern shoulder, round Dùn dhearg and Cnoc ghlas, is the only open grassland on the island, a dry plateau between fifteen hundred and two thousand feet in the lee of the mountains. It is the eastern plain of the annals (7 an Lùnastal, GE 3,771), and its granaries fed the mountain districts in hard years (19 am Màrt, FE 434, 15 an Dùbh-

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3. the windy coast

4. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

5. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

lachd, FE 2,473). The ground in the massif has moved in every age, most of all in the hills round Cill ghlas east of the capital.

**The lesser hills.** The hills east of the capital, the country of Muileann chrom and Cill ghlas, are the western foothills of the massif. The towns there stand between a thousand and thirteen hundred feet, with higher ground behind them. The western hills are low: round Àth leathan, where the road from the south enters them, and north to Muileann àrsaidh and Cnoc thais, they rarely rise above four hundred feet, but they are broken, wooded and easy to hide in, as the holdouts found (11 an Giblean, DE 21).

**The capital's country.** Around Cathair dhearg and Loch chrom the land is low and fertile, under wet oak woods to the west and south and drier oak woods to the east. The capital itself stands on a low rise above the water (23 am Màrt, FE 1,699).

**The wet west.** West of the lake and along the west coast the woods are wet oak, alder and hazel, and the island's largest fens lie behind the coast from Muileann naomh north to Baile fhiadhaich and Muileann àrsaidh. The heath of the west is wet heath on thin soil, good for goats and not worth ploughing (31 am Màrt, FE 599). With the south, this coast has the most rain on the island.

**The south.** The south coast from Inis chrom to Seann Bhral is the warmest and wettest part of Dia-thìr, almost all of it wet woodland. Behind Baile ghorm lie the fens of the south-west, whose marsh plants gave the dyers of Baile ghorm their blue, and whose salt-pans the Stone Kings fought over (9 am Faoilleach, GE 672).

**The eastern oak country.** From the eastern foothills of the massif to the east coast the woods are broad-leaved and the ground is drier: oak and hazel with pasture between, and the best cattle ground on the island. The Black Wind came in on this coast (1 an Gearran, GE 2,417).

## The rivers

A hundred and fifty-seven rivers and streams are named on Dia-thìr. A hundred and fifteen are rivers in their own right. The rest are forks and branches that join a larger river, and creeks, brooks and streams too short to carry a boat. The larger rivers are all called *Abhainn* with a describing word after it, and the small ones take the endings *-as* and *-eas*. The describing words are few, so the names repeat: there are three rivers called *Abhainn iséal* and three called *Abhainn naomh*, and the rolls name each by the towns on it. Most of the rivers are short. They rise in the central mountains or the moors and reach the sea within a day or two's walk.



**Abhainn ìseal**, the longest river on Dia-thìr, about thirty-seven miles. It rises in the northern foothills of the massif near Àth ghlas, at about seven hundred and forty feet, and runs north-west through the birch and pine country past Cuan bheag, Inis bhàn, the river-island of Inis ìseal, Cnoc bheag and Ceann òg, to the north coast below Ros gheal. It settled into its present wide bed in the Ancient Age (2 an t-Ògmhios, VE 681), the dawn-burning of the Hawk went up it from the coast (28 am Faoilleach, FE 2,072), and it last broke its banks along its lower reach in SE 34.

**Abhainn fhionn**, about thirty-two miles. It rises in the east near Baile chrom, at about nine hundred and fifty feet, and runs west past Ceann àrsaidh, Cuan chrom, Muileann mhin, Inis mhòr, Cuan uaine and Achadh àrsaidh into Loch chrom at Cathair dhomhain. It is the capital's river road to the east. Its shallows had the first made crossing of any river on the island (15 am Màrt, GE 3,628), and King Tormod Bàn's sons drowned in it in spate (18 an t-Ògmhios, LE 534).

**Abhainn uaine**, about twenty-eight miles. It rises in the central mountains near Doire mhòr and runs south past Ceann fhada, Baile thais, the landing of Cidhe Beag, Seann Toll, Cuan dhearg and Ros bhàn to the gulf at Cathair mhòr. Meltwater off the mountains cut its bed (14 an t-Ògmhios, VE 227), and the washing of the Company's coal upstream silted it black (27 am Faoilleach, AE 33).

**Abhainn chaol**, about twenty-four miles. It rises high in the massif near Baile dhìreach, at nearly three thousand feet, and runs east to the sea below Seann Dunn. Its fork, the eastern Abhainn ìseal, joins it below Caol shean. The river towns of Ros fhionn, Ceann ghorm and the river-island of Inis uaine stand on it. It is fast and dangerous in the wet season (10 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,680).

**Abhainn gheal**, the northern, about twenty-two miles. It rises in the massif near Àth gharbh and runs north to the north coast near Muileann fhada.

**Abhainn dhomhain**, the capital's river, about twenty-one miles. It rises in the low country south of the capital near Baile ìseal and runs north past Àth fhiadhaich and Doire chaol to Cathair dhearg, where Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>6</sup> crosses it. A little below the capital it joins the Abhainn gheal under Loch chrom. Its fords took the carriers in the Holy Age (3 an Gearran, FE 154), and the grain barges came down it to the capital (3 an Giblean, LE 38).

**Abhainn naomh**, the western, about twenty-one miles. It rises on the low ground of the west near Achadh gheal and runs past Inis àrsaidh, Seann Skell and Àth chrom to the sea at Ros àrsaidh. After the Abhainn gheal it carries more water than any river on the island, and its deep pool at Seann Skell made that town the great river port of the west (1 an t-Iuchar, VE 951).

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6. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

**Abhainn gheal**, the lake river, about seventeen miles. It is the outflow of Loch chrom. It leaves the lake by Seann Warr and runs short, deep and slow past Baile ghlas to the sea between Inis thais and Caol leathan. It carries more water than any other river on Dia-thìr, and sea-going hulls can come up it into the lake (21 an t-Iuchar, AE 3). The pilots of Caol leathan have taken a toll on it since the Holy Age.

**Abhainn ghorm**, the north-eastern, about nineteen miles. It rises in the northern massif and runs north past Inis mhòr and Caol bheag to the sea at Ros chiar, and the north-eastern grain went down it in barges (4 am Faoilleach, LE 154).

**The mountain rivers of the south.** The Abhainn mhòr, Abhainn dhubh, Abhainn bhàn and Abhainn chiar all rise high in the massif and fall south to the south coast in fourteen miles or less. The Abhainn gheal of the east joins the Abhainn bhàn at Ceann bhàn. They rise fast after rain on the eastern hills (26 an Cèitean, FE 2,875).

**The rivers of the north-east.** The Abhainn bheag rises below the Library at Muileann chaol and runs north-east past Ros fhionn of the old bridge and Inis bheag to the sea at Caol chrom. The north-eastern Abhainn naomh runs past Ceann dhomhain to the Library's landing at Ceann mhin.

## Loch chrom

Loch chrom is the island's only lake of any size (24 am Faoilleach, SE 49). It lies in the low country just north of the capital, about thirty-six square miles of fresh water. The Abhainn fhionn and the lesser Abhainn ìseal come into it from the east, the lesser Abhainn naomh from the north, and a dozen streams from the moors. Its one outflow is the Abhainn gheal.

The lake is the capital's harbour. The towns of the capital shore stand round its southern and western edge: Cathair dhomhain at the mouth of the Abhainn fhionn, Ros dhomhain, Seann Vell, Doire fhiadhaich, Doire fhada, Baile ghlas, and Seann Warr on the western shore, where brine springs rise in the reed marsh behind the town. Ceann gheal stands on the northern shore. Sea-going ships reach the lake from the west coast by the Abhainn gheal, and the lake towns have fitted, loaded and built ships for the capital since the Holy Age.

The lake rises and falls with the seasons. The keepers at Ros dhomhain began to cut its high-water line on a boulder in the harbour mouth in the Age of Ailean (26 an Gearran, GE 1,708), and the rock is still called the tide-rock, though Loch chrom has no tide. By the end of that age the lake stood a hand higher on the rock than at the first cut (10 am Màrt, GE 1,747). The oldest works on the lake are the platforms on oak

piles in its shallows (7 am Màrt, VE 1,588), which burned to the waterline (24 an Cèitean, GE 1,525). Its trout were kept for the Crown's table until SE 49.

## The islands

| ISLAND          | WHERE                    | SQUARE MILES | IN THE RECORD                                                                                                       |
|-----------------|--------------------------|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Eilean ghorm    | off the west coast       | 8            | Pine and fen; the grey geese winter there and are never hunted (3 an Lùnastal, VE 3,821)                            |
| Eilean bhàn     | off the south coast      | 8            | Wet woodland; the towns of Cuan dhearg and Cnoc chaol, struck by the Great Wave (3 an t-Ògmhios, SE 4)              |
| Eilean gheal    | off the south-east coast | 5            | Fen; no town                                                                                                        |
| Eilean fhada    | off the north coast      | 4            | The elder Caol bheag on the northern strait; the eight wind-names cut on its high point (24 an Cèitean, GE 2,124)   |
| Eilean dhearg   | off the south-east coast | 3            | The town of Seann Vell; the Seann-Dhaoine rowed their dead here (4 an Cèitean, VE 1,096)                            |
| Eilean mhin     | off the south coast      | 3            | Fen; the first seal-hunters' camps (1 an t-Iuchar, VE 551); crossed by the Great Wave (1 an Giblean, SE 5)          |
| Eilean chrom    | off the north coast      | 3            | Caol mhin, the harbour of Baile Mòr mhòr; Gilleasbuig Beag's exile (10 an t-Ògmhios, GE 4,373)                      |
| Eilean bheag    | off the north-east coast | 2            | Moor; no town                                                                                                       |
| Eilean dhubh    | off the north coast      | 1            | Cut off from the main island by the rising sea (13 an t-Iuchar, VE 506); first voyage round it (31 am Màrt, FE 397) |
| Eilean iséal    | off the east coast       | 1            | Given to the dead of the south-east coast (30 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,370)                                               |
| Eilean dhìreach | off the Tuathach coast   | 1            | Moor; no town                                                                                                       |
| Eilean ruadh    | off the west coast       | 1            | The town of Seann Vell; summer grazing (26 an Cèitean, FE 2,791)                                                    |

Sliochd Raghnaill's boats made the round of the offshore islands in a single season (27 an Giblean, FE 2,776). Besides these twelve there are skerries, tidal islets and river-islands too small for the surveyors' charts. Inis mhin, Inis naomh and Inis bheag of the north coast stand on tidal islets, and Inis mhòr, Inis iséal, Inis uaine, Inis chrom and Inis leathan on islands in their rivers.

## The climate

For so northerly a place Dia-thìr is a mild island, wet and windy, with cool summers and winters that are seldom hard. It stands alone in the open ocean, and no land breaks the gales before they reach it. At sea level the year averages about forty-eight degrees of the humans' scale on every coast, a little more on the south coast than on the north, and the harbours do not freeze. The cold is in the height. The towns of the hills east of the capital, at about a thousand feet, average near forty-four; Dùn ìseal, under the summit ridge, near thirty-nine; and the summits of the massif near thirty-six. Snow lies on the high tops and the high passes through the winter and on the northern moors for days at a time, and frost is common inland from the first of an t-Samhain to the end of the spring. Winter is the long season in the north, and it is a season of gales more than of frost: a gale that drove the sea up the river before the grain fleet had sailed was remembered at Inis mhòr for generations (2 an Dàmhair, LE 1,229).

The rain comes in off the western ocean. The west coast and the south get the most, and the fens lie there. The central mountains take much of what is left, so the eastern plateau and the northern moors lie in their lee and are dry. In the north a summer may pass without rain, and so the springs there that never fail are prized, and the towns built round them are remembered for them (13 an t-Sultain, GE 2,616). Droughts come to the east: the springs of Achadh shean failed in the Age of Ailean (8 an Giblean, GE 2,006), and the Long Drought lay over the island for three years in the Age of Strangers (25 an Lùnastal, AE 106). The storm season comes at the end of the year, and the oldest custom of sharing on Dia-thìr was made for it (7 an Cèitean, GE 2,328).

## The sea and the mist

Muir Mhanannain<sup>8</sup> is a grey, short-tempered sea. The gales come in off it from the west and north-west, most of all between Samhain and the spring, and sea mist lies on the coasts in still weather, thickest on the north and north-west in early summer. The hunters of the north shore took seals on the skerries off Eilean fhada in the autumn gales in the Ancient Age (30 an t-Sultain, VE 611), and the whale-boats of the north coast still go out in summer. The northern passage is dangerous in winter. After a Company brig was driven onto the skerries off Eilean fhada in mist and a gale (13 an t-Sultain, AE 55), it was held closed from midwinter to the end of spring.

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8. Manannan's sea, round Dia-thìr

Beyond the northern and eastern headlands lies Manannan's own mist. To the west the open ocean runs on past sight of land, and the tellings put the Otherworld there; the mist lies to the north and east, on the sea between the island and the humans' land, and the straight way east has never been found through it. The one passage the humans knew ran north-about, out past the north cape and down on the north-west, and that is why every harbour of the Crossing was on the west coast. The Dia-thìrich tell that the fleet of the Sundering sailed into the mist by the same road (19 an Giblean, LE 40), and the order of Manannan teaches that he shut the eastern sea behind the fleet with it and hid the island from every ship beyond (Appendix B; 1 an t-Sultain, LE 654). The priests of Manannan recorded it thinning in the last years of the Age of Sundering (27 an Dàmhair, LE 1,813), and it lifted in the winter of the Crossing, when the humans' ships came out of it (13 am Faoilleach, AE 1). Since the Severance no ship has come out of it, and the priests say the lord of the sea has shut it again (11 an t-Ògmhios, SE 3).

There is no lasting ice on Dia-thìr. The snowfields that lay on the central mountains in the cold years have been seasonal since the oak came (14 an t-Ògmhios, VE 227), and the snow of the high tops is gone by the summer.



## APPENDIX J

# The ARMS OF Dia-thìr

Here are set down the arms of the kingdom, of its hundred and twenty-three shires and of its towns, as they stand in Clàr nan Suaicheantas<sup>1</sup>, the roll of arms kept by the council and copied to Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>2</sup>. Each shire's arms are given in full, with the arms of the capital and of the great cities, and an account of the town arms by kind. Where the roll tells what a charge means, or when and why it was granted, that is told here; where it does not, the arms are given and no more is said.

## I. How Dia-thìr came by its arms

**Signs before arms.** Dia-thìr had carved signs long before it had arms. The oldest is the hawk over a door at Àth mhòr, older than any rite (13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 1,853). The road-guards of Caol leathan swore on a white stone carved as a wolf (12 am Faoilleach, FE 1,009). At Seann Vell a scorpion was cut in yellow stone for worship (4 an t-Samhain, FE 2,849), and the harbours of the order of the Stone still line their quays with wolf-head posts. These are the signs of the orders and of towns. None was ever borne on a shield, and none was ever granted.

**The custody's seal.** The first arms on the island were the seal of the vein-house above Muileann dhearg: a trellis of gold on blue with a hollow lozenge, the mascle, laid over it. The custodians read the trellis as the galleries of the mountain and the mascle as the slab laid over the first break (19 am Màrt, VE 151). No roll says when the seal was first cut. When the crown and the custody were joined, the king's letters were sealed with it, and the crown added only a white band across the field (1 an t-Ògmhios, LE 865). Those are the arms of the kingdom still. The seven houses of custody sealed with the custody's seal, and if they had badges of their own no roll remembers them.

**Under the humans.** The Residency and the Company sealed with their own devices, and the custody's seal went out of use. The Administration's district seals were cut in the humans' manner, on a shield with a rounded foot.

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1. the roll of arms; lit. 'the table of the badges'

2. the Library at Muileann chaol

**The roll of arms.** When the council drew the shires (12 an Dùbhlachd, SE 3) and set a maor over each (4 am Faoilleach, SE 4), every maor needed a seal for his court. The council's clerks made the roll of arms for them (2 an Gearran, SE 4). The kingdom's arms were cut again from the custody's seal, and each shire was given arms of its own. The Dia-thìrich shires took the pointed wedge of the custody's seal. The Tuathaich shires kept the heater of the district seals they had used before, and every Tuathaich town has kept it since. Many of the charges on the roll were drawn from a book of arms left at the Residency, as the shire lines were drawn from the humans' surveys. That is why lions, parrots, dragons and crocodiles stand on the seals of shires where no one has ever seen one.

**The town arms.** The clerks of the first chronicle circuit copied the seal of every town they visited into the roll (2 an Giblean, SE 19), and from then on the roll held the arms of all five hundred and five places. In the north most of the arms were copied from the humans' old town seals, because few Tuathaich would show the clerks their own.

**Changes since.** The roll has been changed once at an order's asking. The Hawk houses of Siorrachd Cnoc bheag, having seated their own custodian, asked for a hawk on the shire's arms, and the council granted it (29 an t-Samhain, SE 35). The coinage seal lost its coal ink (3 an t-Ògmhios, DE 15), but the arms on it were not changed, and the high custodian's protest was about the ink (31 an t-Iuchar, DE 15).

## II. How the arms are read

The arms are blazoned here in the plain terms of heraldry, rendered in English. The field is named first, then any partition, then the ordinaries (the broad bands and crosses), then the charges. The colours are:

| TINCTURE | COLOUR          |
|----------|-----------------|
| Or       | gold or yellow  |
| argent   | silver or white |
| gules    | red             |
| azure    | blue            |
| sable    | black           |
| vert     | green           |
| purpure  | purple          |
| sanguine | blood-red       |



*Trellised* is the custody's trellis. A *mascle* is a lozenge with its middle cut away, the hollow stone. A shield is a wedge unless the entry says otherwise. Where a shire's name is shared with another shire, the entry names the part of the island it lies in.

### III. The arms of the kingdom

**Rìoghachd Dia-thìr**<sup>3</sup>. *Azure trellised Or, a fess cotised argent, over all a mascle argent.*

The trellis and the mascle are the custody's. The fess, a white band between two thin ones, is the crown's addition at the joining (1 an t-Ògmhios, LE 865). Macha's order had been the court's order for four centuries before the joining (31 an Dùbhlachd, LE 441), and no king put her horses on the seal. The house of Òrd Mhacha<sup>4</sup> at Cathair dhearg keeps the regalia (26 an Gearran, SE 7), and the seal has never been in its keeping.

Nineteen shires and a hundred and five towns bear the crown's trellis in their own arms, and sixty-seven towns bear the mascle. The roll says only that the trellis was granted where a shire asked for the crown's colours; why these asked and others did not, it does not tell. No Tuathaich town bears the trellis. The mascle is on the arms of two Tuathaich shires, Siorrachd Caol mhòr and, in the crown's canton, the island shire of Eilean dhìreach, and of two Tuathaich towns, Caol mhòr and Cnoc uaine.

### IV. The arms of the shires

The shires are given in the order of the roll.

| NO. | SHIRE          | SEAT           | ARMS                                                                       | NOTES                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----|----------------|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Cathair dhearg | Cathair dhearg | Per fess gules and argent, in chief a horseman Or, in base a salmon sable. | The capital's shire.                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| 2   | Caol leathan   | Caol leathan   | Argent, on a fess cotised gules three lions passant argent.                | The roll calls the three beasts on the fess lions. In Caol leathan they are called the wolves of the gate, after the white stone on which the road-guards swore their watch (12 am Faoilleach, FE 1,009). |

3. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

4. the order of Macha

| NO. | SHIRE        | SEAT         | ARMS                                                                                                     | NOTES                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-----|--------------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 3   | Seann Skell  | Seann Skell  | Per bend sinister azure and argent, a point in base counter-changed, over all a scorpion Or.             | Seann Skell of the west. The shire of Manannan's order, whose teaching was declared at Seann Skell (1 an t-Sultain, LE 654). The scorpion, badge of Manannan's Cup of Truth, was set over the arms at the house's asking when the roll was made (2 an Gearran, SE 4). No other shire bears one. |
| 4   | Seann Skell  | Seann Skell  | Per fess barbed azure and argent, a pair of bones in saltire Or in chief, a compass rose gules in base.  | Seann Skell of the south. The seat of the high custodian of Òrd Bhrìde (17 an Cèitean, SE 6).                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| 5   | Ros dhomhain | Ros dhomhain | Gules, three crosses of eight points Or, two and one.                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 6   | Cnoc bheag   | Cnoc bheag   | Per fess gules and Or, within an orle of twelve crescent moons argent a falcon argent.                   | The shire of the Hawk order. The roll first gave it a white billet. The hawk replaced it at the Hawk houses' asking (29 an t-Samhain, SE 35).                                                                                                                                                   |
| 7   | Caol mhòr    | Caol mhòr    | Argent, three mascles purpure, two and one.                                                              | Heater shield.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 8   | Caol bheag   | Caol bheag   | Per pale azure and Or, on the dexter side an anchor argent, on the sinister side a feather vert.         | Caol bheag of the north-east.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| 9   | Inis bhàn    | Inis bhàn    | Argent, a pall sable, four billets argent, two in chief and two on the pall.                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 10  | Doire shean  | Doire shean  | Sanguine, three falcons argent in pale.                                                                  | The roll does not say why a shire of the Stone bears falcons, and the houses of the Stone have never asked for them to be changed. The town was made a shire seat on the wealth of its oyster beds (5 an Lùnastal, LE 634).                                                                     |
| 11  | Àth shean    | Àth shean    | Per fess invected Or and azure semy of hearts argent, an apple sable in chief, an anvil purpure in base. | Àth shean of the south.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 12  | Achadh mhòr  | Achadh mhòr  | Azure mailed argent, a dragon rampant argent.                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 13  | Seann Bhral  | Seann Bhral  | Quarterly engrailed purpure and argent masoned azure, two crosses formy Or in chief.                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

| NO. | SHIRE            | SEAT             | ARMS                                                                                                      | NOTES                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-----|------------------|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 14  | Ceann mhòr       | Ceann mhòr       | Azure, a wolf's head erased Or.                                                                           | Heater shield. The wolf's head was the device of the human magistrate at Ceann mhòr, whose house the maor took over (4 am Faoilleach, SE 4). It has nothing to do with the Stone or its Fianna.                                                                                  |
| 15  | Inis thais       | Inis thais       | Argent masoned sable, an anchor gules.                                                                    | The chief shrine of the Stone (16 an Dùbhlachd, LE 419). The shire reads its masoned field as Lia Fàil, since the Stone's plain name, Clach, is the common word for stone. The anchor is taken for the net-makers', among whom Lia Fàil was first preached (28 am Màrt, LE 409). |
| 16  | Dùn thais        | Dùn thais        | Per pile engrailed Or and vert, four fleurs-de-lis sable, two, one and one.                               | The seat of the druid schools. It bears no stag. The schools have never worshipped Flidais's stag and asked for none.                                                                                                                                                            |
| 17  | Inis chrom       | Inis chrom       | Argent chained purpure, a chevron purpure.                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 18  | Doire mhin       | Doire mhin       | Or, on a fess cotised indented purpure a sun in splendour Or.                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 19  | Doire fhiadhaich | Doire fhiadhaich | Gules, three ploughs contourny argent in chief.                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 20  | Baile gharbh     | Baile gharbh     | Gules honeycombed Or, on a chief Or three keys gules.                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 21  | Ceann mhin       | Ceann mhin       | Per pale azure trellised Or and Or, on the dexter side a mascle argent, on the sinister side a sun gules. | Ceann mhin of the south.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 22  | Baile ghlas      | Baile ghlas      | Sable, on a fess double cotised Or an anchor azure.                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 23  | Doire ghlas      | Doire ghlas      | Or, a cock vert.                                                                                          | Heater shield. The largest Tuathaich place and the heart of the Church in the north.                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 24  | Cathair mhòr     | Cathair mhòr     | Per fess barbed gules and Or, a cross paty argent in chief, a hand vert in base.                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 25  | Baile ghorm      | Baile ghorm      | Azure trellised Or, a cross humetty argent.                                                               | Baile ghorm of the south-west.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| 26  | Achadh naomh     | Achadh naomh     | Quarterly potenty azure and argent, a hatchet Or.                                                         | Achadh naomh of the north-central country.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| 27  | Baile Mòr mhòr   | Baile Mòr mhòr   | Azure trellised Or, a chevron reversed argent.                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

| NO. | SHIRE            | SEAT             | ARMS                                                                                    | NOTES                                                                                                                                      |
|-----|------------------|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 28  | Baile chrom      | Baile chrom      | Azure, two triangles Or in pale.                                                        | Heater shield. The one town of the Grey Night vigil. Its arms show nothing of the goose.                                                   |
| 29  | Muileann mhin    | Muileann mhin    | Vert, nine fleurs-de-lis argent, three, three and three.                                |                                                                                                                                            |
| 30  | Caol gharbh      | Caol gharbh      | Or, three ships' wheels sable, two and one.                                             |                                                                                                                                            |
| 31  | Seann Chwen      | Seann Chwen      | Per saltire, paly gules and Or, and argent, an orle Or.                                 |                                                                                                                                            |
| 32  | Cathair dhomhain | Cathair dhomhain | Argent, a bone sable.                                                                   |                                                                                                                                            |
| 33  | Àth shean        | Àth shean        | Or, a stag passant vert.                                                                | Àth shean of the centre.                                                                                                                   |
| 34  | Muileann bhàn    | Muileann bhàn    | Ermine, a plaice azure.                                                                 |                                                                                                                                            |
| 35  | Dùn iséal        | Dùn iséal        | Argent, three parrots azure in pale.                                                    | The hill of the Keepers' Hall (19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 15) and the seat of the Old Spirits. The parrots are birds no one on Dia-thìr has seen. |
| 36  | Cnoc ghorm       | Cnoc ghorm       | Per fess, chequy Or and gules, and sable, a chevron reversed vert.                      | Heater shield.                                                                                                                             |
| 37  | Cnoc leathan     | Cnoc leathan     | Azure, a pair of scales Or.                                                             |                                                                                                                                            |
| 38  | Cuan shean       | Cuan shean       | Per fess dancetty sable and argent, a fusil Or in chief, an inescutcheon gules in base. |                                                                                                                                            |
| 39  | Àth chiar        | Àth chiar        | Per fess azure trellised Or and Or, a pall argent.                                      |                                                                                                                                            |
| 40  | Doire fhada      | Doire fhada      | Azure, a cross argent between four caravels Or.                                         |                                                                                                                                            |
| 41  | Achadh naomh     | Achadh naomh     | Sable, on a pale wavy argent three parrots vert.                                        | Achadh naomh of the north-east.                                                                                                            |
| 42  | Muileann dhearg  | Muileann dhearg  | Gules, six mascles Or in orle.                                                          | Muileann dhearg of the centre. Six mascles, the hollow stone of the custody, in gold on red.                                               |
| 43  | Baile ghorm      | Baile ghorm      | Gules, a scythe argent.                                                                 | Baile ghorm of the south-east.                                                                                                             |
| 44  | Dùn chrom        | Dùn chrom        | Azure trellised Or, a cross humetty argent.                                             |                                                                                                                                            |
| 45  | Ros gheal        | Ros gheal        | Azure trellised Or, a terrace in base Or.                                               |                                                                                                                                            |

| NO. | SHIRE             | SEAT              | ARMS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | NOTES                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 46  | Cill dhìreach     | Cill dhìreach     | Or, a pile gules, a castle Or in chief.                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 47  | Doire chiar       | Doire chiar       | Argent, three maple leaves purple, two and one.                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 48  | Caol shean        | Caol shean        | Argent, a pile in bend azure, two billets gules in bend sinister.                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 49  | Cathair fhada     | Cathair fhada     | Per chevron azure trellised Or and argent, a mount in base Or.                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 50  | Baile mhin        | Baile mhin        | Quarterly argent and purpure, in the first quarter a griffin rampant azure; in the second quarter a sun Or; in the third quarter an arm embowed in armour argent; in the fourth quarter a wyvern vert.                              |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 51  | Seann Skell       | Seann Skell       | Azure trellised Or, an armillary sphere Or.                                                                                                                                                                                         | Seann Skell of the north. Where the dawn-hawk rite began (30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,999) and where the Fed Hawk were sent (23 an Giblean, LE 909). It bears the crown's field and no hawk. |
| 52  | Baile chiar       | Baile chiar       | Or, on a canton sable a mascle Or.                                                                                                                                                                                                  | The crown's mascle in a canton.                                                                                                                                                        |
| 53  | Cnoc mhòr         | Cnoc mhòr         | Sable, three bulls' heads caboshed Or, two and one.                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 54  | Tobar fhiadhaich  | Tobar fhiadhaich  | Quarterly dentilly purpure and argent, in the first quarter a cross clechy voided and pommetty Or; in the second quarter a rabbit sejant purpure; in the third quarter a dragon passant azure; in the fourth quarter an orb argent. |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 55  | Ros gharbh        | Ros gharbh        | Azure, a longship argent.                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 56  | Tobar ghorm       | Tobar ghorm       | Argent, a stirrup azure.                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 57  | Àth fhiadhaich    | Àth fhiadhaich    | Papelonny gules and argent, a pall argent.                                                                                                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 58  | Baile chaol       | Baile chaol       | Argent, a ram's head erased vert.                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 59  | Muileann dhomhain | Muileann dhomhain | Azure trellised Or, a carreau Or.                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Muileann dhomhain of the south-east.                                                                                                                                                   |
| 60  | Seann Tarr        | Seann Tarr        | Argent, a bendlet sinister engrailed purpure, a heart sable in dexter chief.                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                        |

| NO. | SHIRE             | SEAT              | ARMS                                                                                                        | NOTES                                                                                                          |
|-----|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 61  | Achadh shean      | Achadh shean      | Per pale dentilly argent and azure, a cannon sable on the dexter side, an escallop Or on the sinister side. |                                                                                                                |
| 62  | Muileann shean    | Muileann shean    | Sable, on a quarter Or an inescutcheon sable charged with a dove Or.                                        |                                                                                                                |
| 63  | Tobar dhearg      | Tobar dhearg      | Chevronny argent and purpure, a trefoil gules.                                                              |                                                                                                                |
| 64  | Baile àr-saidh    | Baile àr-saidh    | Argent, a goutte gules.                                                                                     | Where the sting-oath began (19 an t-Samhain, FE 879). The town reads the red drop as the drop the sting draws. |
| 65  | Cuan gh-las       | Cuan gh-las       | Purpure, a lymphad argent.                                                                                  |                                                                                                                |
| 66  | Doire fhionn      | Doire fhionn      | Or, a mullet azure.                                                                                         | Doire fhionn of the east.                                                                                      |
| 67  | Doire chaol       | Doire chaol       | Argent, a terrace in base rayonny gules, three crosses fleury gules in fess.                                |                                                                                                                |
| 68  | Seann Toll        | Seann Toll        | Azure, an escallop Or.                                                                                      |                                                                                                                |
| 69  | Baile ru-adh      | Baile ru-adh      | Per bend sable and argent, a crescent reversed counterchanged.                                              |                                                                                                                |
| 70  | Àth bheag         | Àth bheag         | Argent, three roses sable, two and one.                                                                     |                                                                                                                |
| 71  | Ceann àr-saidh    | Ceann àr-saidh    | Purpure, an armillary sphere argent.                                                                        |                                                                                                                |
| 72  | Caol fhi-adhaich  | Caol fhi-adhaich  | Vert, on a saltire undy Or five anchors gules.                                                              |                                                                                                                |
| 73  | Baile fhi-adhaich | Baile fhi-adhaich | Gules, a cross parted argent, over all a lance with a pennon gules.                                         |                                                                                                                |
| 74  | Seann Vell        | Seann Vell        | Per saltire argent and azure, four compass roses counterchanged in cross.                                   | Seann Vell of the capital's east.                                                                              |
| 75  | Cnoc thais        | Cnoc thais        | Sable, on a bendlet sinister embattled Or three skulls azure.                                               | Heater shield.                                                                                                 |
| 76  | Muileann chrom    | Muileann chrom    | Azure, on a pale argent a patriarchal cross azure.                                                          |                                                                                                                |
| 77  | Ros bheag         | Ros bheag         | Sable, a cross indented Or between four mascles argent.                                                     |                                                                                                                |
| 78  | Cnoc àr-saidh     | Cnoc àr-saidh     | Or, a mount in base gules, over all a cannon gules.                                                         |                                                                                                                |

| NO. | SHIRE             | SEAT              | ARMS                                                                                                 | NOTES                          |
|-----|-------------------|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 79  | Inis bheag        | Inis bheag        | Per fess potency purpure and Or, an anchor argent in chief, a fly azure in base.                     |                                |
| 80  | Àth fhionn        | Àth fhionn        | Azure trellised Or, a crescent Or.                                                                   |                                |
| 81  | Achadh àrsaidh    | Achadh àrsaidh    | Per fess nowy azure and argent, two anchors Or in pale.                                              |                                |
| 82  | Cuan ru-adh       | Cuan ru-adh       | Argent, on a chief embattled gules an angel Or.                                                      |                                |
| 83  | Seann Bhrenn      | Seann Bhrenn      | Argent, three bees vert, two and one.                                                                |                                |
| 84  | Cnoc shean        | Cnoc shean        | Azure, a thistle Or.                                                                                 |                                |
| 85  | Dùn dhearg        | Dùn dhearg        | Argent, a lion rampant azure.                                                                        |                                |
| 86  | Àth àr-saidh      | Àth àr-saidh      | Per pale Or and gules, a bow and arrow azure on the dexter side, a rake Or on the sinister side.     | Heater shield.                 |
| 87  | Cnoc dhìreach     | Cnoc dhìreach     | Vert, on a cross argent five apples gules.                                                           |                                |
| 88  | Muileann leathan  | Muileann leathan  | Azure, a horse passant argent.                                                                       | Heater shield.                 |
| 89  | Achadh chaol      | Achadh chaol      | Per bend fir-twigged gules and Or, an apple argent in sinister chief, a scythe sable in dexter base. |                                |
| 90  | Muileann dhomhain | Muileann dhomhain | Sable, a cross clechy Or.                                                                            | Muileann dhomhain of the east. |
| 91  | Inis mhin         | Inis mhin         | Sable, a fess argent, four lions' heads erased argent, three in chief and one in base.               | Heater shield.                 |
| 92  | Caol ìseal        | Caol ìseal        | Per fess argent and gules, a bend-let purpure.                                                       |                                |
| 93  | Cnoc na-omh       | Cnoc na-omh       | Or, a bordure gules.                                                                                 |                                |
| 94  | Àth ghlas         | Àth ghlas         | Per fess azure trellised Or and Or, an annulet argent in chief, a bee azure in base.                 |                                |
| 95  | Seann Warr        | Seann Warr        | Or, an anchor purpure.                                                                               |                                |

| NO. | SHIRE              | SEAT               | ARMS                                                                                                 | NOTES                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----|--------------------|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 96  | Muileann dhearg    | Muileann dhearg    | Azure trellised Or, a pale Or.                                                                       | The shire of the vein-house above Muileann dhearg (17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 25). It bears the custody's field with a pale of gold and nothing more.                           |
| 97  | Àth dhomhain       | Àth dhomhain       | Azure trellised Or, a bell argent.                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 98  | Inis mhòr          | Inis mhòr          | Azure, three escallops argent, two and one.                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 99  | Ceann mhin         | Ceann mhin         | Or, a saltire parted indented azure, over all on an inescutcheon Or a fleur-de-lis purpure.          | Ceann mhin of the north-east.                                                                                                                                            |
| 100 | Seann Dunn         | Seann Dunn         | Argent, two eagles vert in pale.                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 101 | Ceann leathan      | Ceann leathan      | Argent, a label purpure, two pairs of bones in saltire sable in pale.                                |                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 102 | Cnoc gheal         | Cnoc gheal         | Per pale wavy Or and sable.                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 103 | Muileann bheag     | Muileann bheag     | Per fess azure trellised Or and argent, a bear rampant Or in chief, a sheaf of arrows sable in base. |                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 104 | Ceann bheag        | Ceann bheag        | Gules, a comet Or.                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 105 | Muileann àrsaidh   | Muileann àrsaidh   | Azure, a saltire embattled Or, over all a serpent gules.                                             | Heater shield.                                                                                                                                                           |
| 106 | Cill thais         | Cill thais         | Vert, a salmon argent.                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 107 | Baile ìseal        | Baile ìseal        | Argent, three portcullises purpure, two and one.                                                     | Heater shield.                                                                                                                                                           |
| 108 | Baile gheal        | Baile gheal        | Purpure, five annulets argent in saltire.                                                            | The seat of the second house of the Stone (8 an Lùnastal, LE 1,399).                                                                                                     |
| 109 | Ceann mhin         | Ceann mhin         | Per bend sinister argent and gules, a lighthouse counter-changed.                                    | Ceann mhin of the south-east.                                                                                                                                            |
| 110 | Cnoc dhubh         | Cnoc dhubh         | Purpure, a lozenge ploye argent.                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 111 | Baile Mòr dhomhain | Baile Mòr dhomhain | Azure, a wing argent.                                                                                | The seat of Clann Fhearchair, the first house to give Dia-thìr a chosen king (19 an Gearran, LE 182). The house roll does not say whether the wing was ever the house's. |
| 112 | Muileann chiar     | Muileann chiar     | Vert, on a chief potency argent three inescutcheons purpure.                                         |                                                                                                                                                                          |



| NO. | SHIRE           | SEAT           | ARMS                                                                                                                                                                   | NOTES                                                                                                                                       |
|-----|-----------------|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 113 | Doire fhionn    | Doire fhionn   | Argent, three parrots gules, two and one.                                                                                                                              | Doire fhionn of the north.                                                                                                                  |
| 114 | Cnoc bhàn       | Cnoc bhàn      | Per fess argent and vert, in chief a palace azure, in base a paschal lamb Or.                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                             |
| 115 | Àth mhòr        | Àth mhòr       | Argent, three ploughshares purple in pale.                                                                                                                             | The oldest hawk carving on the island is over a door in this town (13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 1,853). Neither the shire nor the town bears a hawk. |
| 116 | Muileann naomh  | Muileann naomh | Chequy purpure and Or, a chevron argent.                                                                                                                               | Muileann naomh of the south.                                                                                                                |
| 117 | Muileann naomh  | Muileann naomh | Chevronny azure trellised Or and Or, a cross argent.                                                                                                                   | Muileann naomh of the west.                                                                                                                 |
| 118 | Caol bheag      | Caol bheag     | Per pale Or and azure, a bar gemel gules, two dolphins gules in chief, and a canton azure trellised Or charged with a mascle argent.                                   | Caol bheag of the northern strait. It bears the crown's arms in a canton.                                                                   |
| 119 | Caol mhin       | Caol mhin      | Sable, a centaur archer argent.                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                             |
| 120 | Seann Vell      | Seann Vell     | Azure trellised Or, a lymphad argent.                                                                                                                                  | Seann Vell of the west coast.                                                                                                               |
| 121 | Seann Vell      | Seann Vell     | Argent, three mascles purple in fess.                                                                                                                                  | Seann Vell of the south-east.                                                                                                               |
| 122 | Eilean dhìreach | —              | Gules, a ship's wheel argent, and a canton azure trellised Or charged with a mascle argent.                                                                            | An island shire with no town. It bears the crown's arms in a canton, on a heater shield.                                                    |
| 123 | Eilean ìseal    | —              | Per pale argent and purpure, on the dexter side a stirrup gules, on the sinister side a bear rampant Or, and a canton azure trellised Or charged with a mascle argent. | An island shire with no town. It bears the crown's arms in a canton.                                                                        |

Of the hundred and twenty-three shires, twelve bear the heater: the eleven Tuathaich shires, the island shire of Eilean dhìreach among them (Appendix H), and Inis mhin on the northern shore, which has one town of each people. Fifteen bear no charge at all, only their field, partitions and ordinaries.

## V. The arms of the towns

**By kind.** The roll holds the arms of five hundred and five towns. Four hundred and forty-one are on the wedge and sixty-four on the heater, one heater for every Tuathaich town. A hundred and five are on the crown's trellis, and seventeen of these carry

the mascle as well, so that their arms come close to the kingdom's own. Of the other fields, argent is the commonest, then azure, Or and gules, then sable, purple and vert. Ninety-five towns bear no charge, and eighteen of those bear nothing but their field and its partition. The commonest charge is the mascle. Crosses of one kind or another are on sixty-three town arms. A hundred and five towns bear a beast, and thirty-one of those are beasts no one on Dia-thìr has seen: lions, griffins, dragons, crocodiles, elephants, a rhinoceros. Twenty bear figures: horsemen, archers, monks, angels and two skeletons. Ships and anchors are on the harbours, and ploughs, scythes, saws and anvils on the farm and mill towns, but only twenty-eight of the hundred and thirty-three harbour towns carry anything from the sea.

**The capital and the great cities.** The capital and every city of more than twenty thousand people, largest first.

| TOWN             | SHIRE            | PEOPLE | ARMS                                                                                               | NOTES                                                                                                                           |
|------------------|------------------|--------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Cathair dhearg   | Cathair dhearg   | 10,300 | Ermine, flaunches gules.                                                                           | The capital reads its ermine as the black and white of Macha's floors, and the flaunches as the red of the red city.            |
| Seann Skell      | Seann Skell      | 74,100 | Or, a cross azure, three dolphins Or in pale.                                                      | The seat of Manannan's order and the largest town on Dia-thìr. Its own arms bear dolphins; the scorpion is on its shire's arms. |
| Ros dhomhain     | Ros dhomhain     | 51,600 | Argent, a cross of eight points purple.                                                            |                                                                                                                                 |
| Cathair mhòr     | Cathair mhòr     | 49,300 | Gules, a cross paty argent.                                                                        |                                                                                                                                 |
| Baile Mòr mhòr   | Baile Mòr mhòr   | 35,900 | Azure trellised Or, three mascles argent, two and one.                                             | The crown's field with the hollow stone three times over.                                                                       |
| Inis thais       | Inis thais       | 34,900 | Per chevron reversed argent masoned sable and gules, a pale azure.                                 | Masoned, like the arms of its shire.                                                                                            |
| Dùn thais        | Dùn thais        | 34,200 | Azure trellised Or, a saw argent.                                                                  |                                                                                                                                 |
| Ceann mhin       | Ceann mhin       | 32,300 | Azure trellised Or, six mascles argent in orle.                                                    |                                                                                                                                 |
| Cathair dhomhain | Cathair dhomhain | 29,400 | Per bend azure trellised Or and argent, a bone Or in sinister chief, a spear sable in dexter base. |                                                                                                                                 |
| Dùn dhearg       | Dùn dhearg       | 25,700 | Argent, three lions rampant gules in chief.                                                        |                                                                                                                                 |

| TOWN          | SHIRE         | PEOPLE | ARMS                                                               | NOTES                                                      |
|---------------|---------------|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Inis mhòr     | Inis mhòr     | 24,000 | Sable, a point in base argent, six plaice argent, three and three. |                                                            |
| Ros bheag     | Ros bheag     | 23,800 | Sable, a cross nowy argent between four mascles argent.            |                                                            |
| Dùn iseal     | Dùn iseal     | 22,600 | Argent, three mascles gules, two and one.                          | The hollow stone in red, on the hill of the Keepers' Hall. |
| Seann Skell   | Seann Skell   | 22,100 | Azure trellised Or, a cross Or, three columns gules in pale.       | The crown's field; see its shire.                          |
| Dùn chrom     | Dùn chrom     | 21,100 | Quarterly azure trellised Or and argent, an orle Or.               |                                                            |
| Cathair fhada | Cathair fhada | 20,900 | Azure trellised Or, four mascles argent, two, one and one.         |                                                            |

**The seats and holy towns.** Other towns whose arms have a part in the history.

| TOWN            | SHIRE           | PEOPLE | ARMS                                                                                                  | NOTES                                                                                                |
|-----------------|-----------------|--------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Cnoc bheag      | Cnoc bheag      | 49,700 | Gules, a plaice Or.                                                                                   | The first house of the Hawk. The town bears a plaice, a river fish. The hawk is on the shire's arms. |
| Seann Skell     | Seann Skell     | 57,900 | Or, an orle gules, three inescutcheons purpure in pale, each charged with a mullet of four points Or. | The seat of the high custodian.                                                                      |
| Caol leathan    | Caol leathan    | 8,600  | Argent, two mascles purpure in pale.                                                                  | The masle of the custody, in purple. The wolf-stone is not on the town's arms.                       |
| Muileann dhearg | Muileann dhearg | 14,100 | Azure trellised Or, three mascles argent in chief.                                                    | The vein-house town. It bears the custody's field and three mascles.                                 |
| Muileann chaol  | Cnoc bhàn       | 5,500  | Argent, a pale invected gules, a lion rampant azure in dexter chief.                                  | The Library town.                                                                                    |
| Baile chrom     | Baile chrom     | 27,300 | Argent, a chief gules, two lymphads azure.                                                            | The town of the Grey Night.                                                                          |

## VI. The beasts of the orders on the roll

Most of the orders of the Old Faith have a beast: the Hawk order its hawk, the druid schools Flidais's stag, Macha's order the black horse and the grey, the order of the

Stone the wolf of its Fianna, and Manannan's order the yellow scorpion of his Cup. The roll bears them seldom, and seldom where one who knows the orders would look for them; the orders have asked for them only twice.

**The Hawk.** Mòd, the Hawk of Acaill, is on one shield in the roll, the arms of Siorrachd Cnoc bheag, and only since the Hawk houses asked for him (29 an t-Samhain, SE 35). No town bears a hawk. The northern Seann Skell, where the rite began, bears the crown's field, and Àth mhòr, with the oldest hawk on the island over a door, bears ploughshares. The three falcons of Siorrachd Doire shean are in the country of the Stone, and no roll explains them.

**Macha's horses.** No arms on the roll bear Dubh Sainglenn as the wood-watchers told of him, the black horned beast of the wood. The order's houses show the black horse and the grey only in the black and white of their floors (14 am Màrt, LE 1,459), and the capital reads its own ermine, black on white, in that way. The capital's shire bears a horseman, and Cnoc dhubh, a town of Macha's order, a horse's head; the roll does not say that either is hers. The horses on the arms of Muileann leathan and its shire are in Tuathaich church country, and nobody reads them as Macha's.

**The Wolf of the Fianna.** No shire of the Stone bears a wolf. Inis thais bears masonry, which its people read as the Stone itself, since its plain name Clach is the common word for stone. Caol leathan's three beasts are lions in the roll and wolves in the town. Two towns bear a wolf's head: Achadh fhada, a town of the Stone, and Ceann mhòr in the north, where the head is the old magistrate's. Baile ghorm's wolf-head posts stand on its quays and are not on its arms.

**The Stag.** The druid schools have never worshipped Flidais's stag (7 an Dùbhlachd, FE 118), and none of their chief towns bears one. The stags on the roll are at Àth shean, in shire and town, and at Cnoc òg, both towns of Macha's order, and at Doire chaol, the hunters' village of the schools that sends its oak to Caol gharbh. Stags' antlers are on the arms of four more towns.

**The Scorpion.** The badge of Manannan's Cup is on the arms of the western Seann Skell, at the house's asking (2 an Gearran, SE 4). The three towns that bear a scorpion, Seann Chwen, Àth chrom and Achadh gharbh, are none of them towns of Manannan's order, and Seann Vell, which cut the first scorpion in yellow stone, bears a fleur-de-lis on the crown's field.

**The others.** Òrd Bhrìde<sup>5</sup> has no beast. It has the masclé, the hollow stone of Crom over the vein, on the kingdom's arms and on sixty-seven towns, and it has never asked for more. Bride's flame is on no arms. Of the other gods' signs the roll holds a harp, an Dagda's<sup>6</sup>, at Cnoc dhubh, a town of the schools, and three ravens, the birds of the

5. the order of Bride's flame

6. the Good God, father of the gods

Morrigan in the tellings, at Baile thais, Àth shean of the northern march and Achadh mhin; none of these towns claims the god. The Old Spirits keep no beast, and the people of the mounds are on no arms. The Church asked for no sign on the roll. The goose of the Grey Night is on no arms, and Baile chrom, the vigil's one town, bears ships.



PART FOUR

# A Gazetteer of Dia- thir

Every town of the island, by shire: when and by whom it was founded, its history, and what the annals record there. Dia-thìr is some hundred and fifty miles from the north-western capes to the eastern cape and some 5,340 square miles with its islands, alone in Manannan's sea. The humans' land lies east of it, behind the mist, and the one way through the mist ran north-about and came down on the north-west, so the harbours of the Crossing are all on the west coast.

## A

**Achadh àrsaidh** (Doire fhionn). Founded 12 an t-Ògmhios, FE 821 by Dia-thìrich herders on an older field. Achadh àrsaidh, the ancient field, was named by Dia-thìrich herders who found its field-walls already standing and old when they came. Who laid them is not known. Tìormachd Achadh shean<sup>1</sup>, the Long Drought, struck it in the Age of Strangers and parched its hay-meadows for three dry seasons running. It has stayed a small village of cattle and hay on the eastern uplands, keeping the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and its walls in repair. Known for its field-walls older than any memory.

**Achadh àrsaidh** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 14 am Màrt, FE 603 by Dia-thìrich fishers, resettled by the Tuathaich. An ancient field village on the far western coast, facing the waters of Uilebheist na Mara<sup>2</sup>, the Sea-Watcher. Gorta Baile chrom<sup>3</sup>, the Great Hunger, struck it in the Age of Strangers; it was resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance and keeps the faith of the Church. Pirates have been seen offshore and the villagers keep watch on the headland. Its boats first met the humans' ships at sea, off the north-west cape at the place they call Coinneachadh nan Long<sup>4</sup>. Known for the watch for the Sea-Watcher.

**Achadh àrsaidh** (Achadh àrsaidh). Founded 17 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,208 by the fishers of the capital's river. An ancient field village on the Abhainn fhionn east of the capital, grown into one of the largest settlements on the island while keeping its village name. It is the seat of Siorrachd Achadh àrsaidh, and its river quays land the fish and grain that feed Cathair dhearg. It follows the order of Macha. Known for the river quays that feed the capital.

**Achadh chaol** (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 5 an Dùbhlachd, AE 137 by the folk of the district closed after the Rending. Achadh chaol was built by the folk of the district the Company fenced and closed after Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>5</sup>, the Rending. It stands on the edge of the fenced ground, on land the custodians of Muileann dhomhain lent them at Coinneachadh an Fhearainn<sup>6</sup>, the standing stone on the moor road, and it is the only settlement of that age founded by Dia-thìrich for Dia-thìrich with no Company surveyor's hand in it. It is a village of narrow fields, and it sends its grain to the mills around it. Known for its narrow fields on the edge of the fenced ground.

1. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

2. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

3. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

4. the meeting of the ships

5. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

6. the meeting of the crews on the moor



**Achadh chaol** (Achadh chaol). Founded 27 an Gearran, GE 2,475 by field-clearing households of the east. Achadh chaol is a large village of narrow barley fields and the seat of its province. Its grain goes to the mills of Muileann dhìreach, and the two places have kept the same bargain since the Holy Age. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its narrow barley fields.

**Achadh dhìreach** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 16 an Cèitean, VE 303 by hill-folk of the high valleys. Achadh dhìreach holds the oldest hearths of the high valleys, and it was laid out anew in straight fields by the restored kingdom, when the diggings were worked to the full again and the towns of the plain needed feeding. It is small, fewer than eight hundred people. It feeds Baile Mòr àrsaidh. Known for its straight fields of the restored kingdom.

**Achadh dhomhain** (Muileann chrom). Founded 10 an t-Ògmhios, FE 272 by farmers of Muileann chrom. Achadh dhomhain of Muileann chrom is a large farming village in deep fields, founded in the Holy Age. Its granaries fed the mining camps in the Age of Strangers and were requisitioned in the war of the Severance. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its deep-field granaries of the camps.

**Achadh dhomhain** (Caol shean). Founded 27 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,871 by hosts of the Allt an Àigh<sup>7</sup> pilgrims. Achadh dhomhain of Caol shean is a large village beside Allt an Àigh, the stream of fortune. Pilgrims have come to drink from it since the Holy Age, and the village lives on them. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its lodging of the Allt an Àigh pilgrims.

**Achadh fhada** (Baile chiar). Founded 30 an Dùbhlachd, LE 916 by barley-farmers of the south-west. Achadh fhada, the long field, is a village of barley farms in the capital's southern country. It was founded in the long quiet centuries and has changed little since. It keeps the order of the Stone, unlike most of its neighbours. Known for its long field of barley.

**Achadh fhada** (Cnoc bheag). Founded 31 an Cèitean, LE 664 by druids of the Hungry Hawk. A long field village in the wooded middle west, one of the few settlements where Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>8</sup>, the Hawk order, which never took Òrd Bhrìde<sup>9</sup>'s written order of worship, still holds. A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>10</sup>, the Green Death, struck it in the Age of Strangers. Its fields feed the Hawk-order mill at Muileann uaine. Known for the Hawk-order fields.

**Achadh fhiadhaich** (Ceann bheag). Founded 10 an t-Ògmhios, LE 765 by horse-breeders of the north. Achadh fhiadhaich is a village of the north-east, founded in the long quiet centuries on wild pasture that no earlier people had fenced. It breeds horses and grows hay for the coast, and the carters of Ceann bheag have bought its horses for generations. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its wild-field hay and horses.

**Achadh fhiadhaich** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 19 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,512 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the west coast. A wild field village on the far western shore with a small harbour, kept in Dia-thìrich hands when the Tuathaich homeland was fixed to the north. It faces the waters where the Sea-Watcher is said to live, and pirates are still seen off the coast. Its people follow the order of Manannan. Known for its fishing within sight of the Sea-Watcher's waters.

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7. the stream of the healing water

8. the Hawk order

9. the order of Brìde's flame

10. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

**Achadh fhiadhaich** (Ceann àrsaidh). Founded 21 an t-Sultain, LE 1,813 by Dia-thìrich farmers who reclaimed the wild field. A village of fields reclaimed from wild ground in the Age of Sundering, when the island had fewer mouths and more hands to spare. It feeds the towns of Ceann àrsaidh and sends its surplus to Muileann chrom to be ground. It is a large village now, of nearly ten thousand. Known for its reclaimed wild fields.

**Achadh fhionn** (Baile ghorm). Founded 23 an Lùnastal, FE 1,069 by farmers of the south-east. Achadh fhionn is a village of the south-east, founded in the Holy Age in a fair field under Làrach an Dùin<sup>11</sup>. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and leaves the ruin alone. Its people say the ruin was old when the first Dia-thìrich came. Known for its fair field under Làrach an Dùin.

**Achadh fhionn** (Cnoc shean). Founded 9 an t-Samhain, LE 530 by farmers of Cnoc shean. A fair field village in the south-east, with meadows between the hill-towns of Cnoc shean and Cnoc fhada. It keeps the Old Spirits and is known for its hay. Known for its hay from the fair fields.

**Achadh fhionn** (Ceann mhin). Founded 15 an Dùbhlachd, LE 60 by Dia-thìrich barley farmers. A farming village of fair barley fields between Baile mhin and Àth ghlas. In the Age of Strangers its pastures were taken for the horses of the administration, and they have served as remount grounds for the soldiers of the district ever since. It is a quiet place, larger in fields than in people. Known for its barley fields and remount pastures.

**Achadh gharbh** (Inis bheag). Founded 7 an Dàmhair, LE 205 by farmers from Inis bheag. Rough ground behind the river port of Inis bheag, broken to the plough in the long centuries after the Sundering fleet had gone. It feeds the river port and its fishing boats, and it has grown larger than many towns while keeping the name and customs of a village. The druid schools have a strong following among its farmers, who are said to argue the schools' questions over the furrow. Known for its stony fields that feed Inis bheag.

**Achadh gharbh** (Inis bheag). Founded 3 am Faoilleach, LE 1,104 by farmers of Muileann chaol. A rough field village beside the older Muileann chaol, breaking stony ground for the mill. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and shares its name with two other Achadh gharbhs of the east, which the library's clerks tell apart only by their shires. Known for its stony fields for the old mill.

**Achadh gharbh** (Caol shean). Founded 13 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,597 by the keepers of Allt an Àigh<sup>12</sup>. A rough field village beside Allt an Àigh, the stream said to grant fortune to those who drink at the right phase of the moon. Pilgrims have come since the Holy Age, and the keepers' citadel was built to guard the stream from anyone who would bottle and sell it. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith, whose druids have never agreed whether the stream's luck is real. Known for Allt an Àigh, the stream of fortune.

**Achadh gharbh** (Tobar fhiadhaich). Founded 21 an Giblean, LE 565 by Dia-thìrich peat-cutters of the northern uplands. A village no bigger than a hamlet, of rough moor fields and peat banks above Tobar fhiadhaich. Its peat warmed the northern towns when the Small-Burning Law still held and the coloured coal was not burned freely. Fewer than a thousand people live there now. Known for its rough moor fields and peat.

11. the fortress ruin

12. the stream of the healing water

**Achadh gheal** (Seann Skell). Founded 23 an t-Samhain, FE 2,040 by Dia-thìrich flax-growers of Seann Skell. The white field is the flax country that feeds the linen-weavers of Seann Skell, and in the drying season the whole plain is laid with bleaching cloth. The village is large and prosperous for its kind, and it follows the order of Manannan as the river port does. Its growers' guild has sold to the same Seann Skell houses for longer than either side can prove. Known for its flax fields and bleached linen.

**Achadh ghlas** (Seann Skell). Founded 26 an Lùnastal, FE 1,341 by Dia-thìrich farmers of Seann Skell. A village of grey-green fields on the road north from Seann Skell, whose barley and oats feed the great river port. It lies just south of the Tuathaich line, and since the Severance its farmers have ploughed with one eye on the boundary. In the Long War its barns quartered soldiers of the seventh regiment on the way to Àth leathan. Known for its grey fields on the Seann Skell road.

**Achadh iseal** (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 27 an t-Sultain, LE 1,184 by farmers from Muileann dhomhain. A low field village in the south-east, farming for the mill town of Muileann dhomhain and the port of Ceann chaol. It keeps the Old Spirits. Of its history nothing is written but its harvests. Known for its harvests for the southern mills.

**Achadh mhin** (Cnoc naomh). Founded 1 an Lùnastal, FE 738 by farmers of the southern coast. Achadh mhin is a farming village of the south, founded in the Holy Age. Tonn Mhòr struck it in the first years of the restored kingdom and destroyed it in a single night. It was rebuilt and keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its rebuilding after the Great Wave.

**Achadh mhin** (Baile gharbh). Founded 19 an Lùnastal, LE 1,801 by Dia-thìrich farmers of Baile gharbh. A village of smooth, well-drained fields that feeds the harbour at Ceann dhubh. It is not the Achadh mhin of the southern coast that the Great Wave struck. It has had few recorded troubles and is mentioned in the older rolls chiefly for its tithe. Known for its smooth fields of Baile gharbh.

**Achadh mhòr** (Achadh mhòr). Founded 2 an t-Samhain, GE 4,000 by field-clearing households of the warm springs. Achadh mhòr is still called a field village, though it is one of the largest settlements on the island and the seat of its province. It is the granary of the east, and the shared-meal custom of the Holy Age is said to have been kept here most faithfully. Travellers on the road stop at An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>13</sup> nearby. In the Holy Age its lord Fearghas Dà-Mhionn, sworn both to Dùn dhearg and to Cathair mhòr, fired his own harvest sooner than feed either host, and so ended the War of the Two Oaths; a boundary stone cut with the signs of two shares is kept in the wall of the maor's house. Known for the great granary fields.

**Achadh mhòr** (Cnoc bheag). Founded 28 an Gearran, FE 2,856 by Dia-thìrich farmers of Cnoc bheag. A farming village of six thousand just south of the Tuathaich line. It follows the order of Manannan, like its neighbours across the line. It trades with both sides and has been watched by both. Known for its border fields south of the Tuathaich line.

**Achadh naomh** (Achadh naomh). Founded 5 an t-Ògmhios, GE 4,091 by settlers of the spring-fields. Achadh naomh is a large village and the seat of its province in the north-central country, settled in the Age of Ailean beside a spring held sacred. Colbh Cnoc chiar<sup>14</sup> stands to its east, carved 'remember the fire'. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for its holy field by Colbh Cnoc chiar.

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13. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

14. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

**Achadh naomh** (Achadh naomh). Founded 28 an t-Sultain, FE 2,324 by Dia-thirich households of the ancestor feasts. The holy field was a meeting ground for the ancestor feasts of the Old Spirits before any house stood on it, and the houses were built around its edge rather than upon it. It is now a village of twenty-five thousand and the seat of its province, yet the field at its heart is still left unploughed. The feasts are kept there as they were in the Holy Age. Known for the ancestor feasts on the unploughed field.

**Achadh shean** (Achadh shean). Founded 21 an Giblean, GE 3,125 by Dia-thirich farming households. Achadh shean, the old field, is a village of twenty-five thousand and the seat of its province. It gave its name to Tiormachd Achadh shean<sup>15</sup>, the Long Drought, which settled over the island's dry season for three years running in the Age of Strangers. Its granaries were emptied in those years and rebuilt larger afterward, and they are the largest on the eastern coast. Known for the old fields and the Long Drought.

**Àth àrsaidh** (Dùn dhearg). Founded 19 am Màrt, FE 1,894 by the ford-keepers of Dùn dhearg. An ancient ford in the east, between the mill town of Muileann leathan and Seann Mhorn on the coast. It keeps the Old Spirits and a ford-stone where travellers leave a pebble, and it has been a small crossing town since the Holy Age. Known for the pebble-cairn at the ford-stone.

**Àth àrsaidh** (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 12 an t-Samhain, GE 3,458 by quarrying households of the north-west; resettled by the Tuathaich. An ancient ford in the north-west, the seat of Siorrachd Àth àrsaidh, resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. It is a large town of the Church and the market of the Tuathaich southern country. Known for the ancient ford of the Tuathaich.

**Àth bheag** (Baile fhiadhaich). Founded 14 an t-Samhain, LE 224 by the ford-keepers of Baile fhiadhaich. A small ford in the west on the road between Baile fhiadhaich and Cnoc ìseal. It follows the order of Manannan and has never been much more than a crossing, though crown regiments marched through it to Àth leathan in the Long War. Known for a small western crossing.

**Àth bheag** (Baile ìseal). Founded 14 an Giblean, SE 9 by Tuathaich families sent north at the Severance. A small ford settlement founded by Tuathaich families who came north at the Severance. It has fewer than a thousand people. It trades with Baile ìseal and Baile òg, the other Tuathaich towns of its province. Known for a ford settled after the Severance.

**Àth bheag** (Àth bheag). Founded 26 an Cèitean, GE 4,347 by Dia-thirich ford-keepers of the east coast. Àth bheag is a town of twenty thousand at a ford of the Abhainn dhubh on the east coast, the seat of its province. Pirate ships have been seen offshore, and the town keeps watchers on the dunes. The lighthouse of Baile ìseal lies a short way south. Its salt-pans supply the whole eastern seaboard. Known for its east-coast ford under pirate watch.

**Àth chaol** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 5 an t-Sultain, LE 519 by the ford-wardens of Baile Mòr dhomhain. One of the island's many narrow fords, this one a walled post on the north road into Baile Mòr dhomhain. The city built its walls to hold the crossing in the troubles before the Severance, and it is still garrisoned in name. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its walled ford on the city's north road.

15. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

**Àth chaol** (Achadh naomh). Founded 20 an t-Sultain, FE 2,379 by the ford-keepers of Achadh naomh. A narrow ford in the east where the road to the harbour at Inis mhin crosses a stream. It keeps the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich, and its ford runs low in the dry months. It is a small market town for the holy field of Achadh naomh. Known for its narrow ford on the Inis mhin road.

**Àth chaol** (Seann Tàrr). Founded 6 an Gearran, LE 809 by harbour-folk of Seann Tàrr. A narrow harbour ford in the far east, close to the old Seann-Dhaoine<sup>16</sup> harbour of Seann Tàrr. It keeps the Old Spirits and sends its fishing to the market at Cnoc uaine. Known for its fishing in the eastern narrows.

**Àth chaol** (Muileann chiar). Founded 30 an Dùbhlachd, AE 66 by miners of the central diggings. A narrow ford-town in the central hills, grown in the Age of Strangers around the camp-roads to the diggings near Cill ghlas. The Rending, Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>17</sup>, killed miners of this town in the collapse, and the people here still use scàinte of a man who is shaken. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its miners, who died in the Rending.

**Àth chaol** (Dùn thais). Founded 12 an Lùnastal, LE 1,401 by carters of Dùn thais. A small town at a narrow ford on the Dùn thais road, living on the carts that pass through it. Since the library was founded at Muileann chaol many of its young people have gone to work there as porters and copyists. It has never been walled or fought over. Known for its narrow ford on the Dùn thais road.

**Àth chiar** (Àth shean). Founded 21 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,362 by ford-keepers of the east road. Àth chiar is a ford town east of the capital, founded in the long quiet centuries. The field of Muileann ghlas lies to its south-west, and the town was a supply post in the last battle of An Cogadh Fada<sup>18</sup>. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. The ford carries Rathad na Mèinne<sup>19</sup>, the mine road from the capital to the hills. Known for its dusky ford near Muileann ghlas field.

**Àth chiar** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 30 an Lùnastal, LE 1,347 by the ford-guards of Baile Mòr dhomhain. A dusky ford on the west road out of Baile Mòr dhomhain, walled against the roads' thieves in the Age of Strangers. It is a carriers' town, and the road-house An Taigh-seinnse Reòta at Muileann fhada lies a short way down the road. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its carriers of the west road.

**Àth chiar** (Àth chiar). Founded 18 an Giblean, FE 2,769 by the drovers of the south-east. A dusky ford in the south-east with a citadel, the seat of Siorrachd Àth chiar and a large market town. Its keep was held by Dia-thìrich rebels in the war before the Severance and is still garrisoned. It keeps the Old Spirits and trades with the coast at Seann Mhorn and Muileann chiar to the south. Known for the rebels' keep and southern cattle-market.

**Àth chrom** (Seann Skell). Founded 21 am Màrt, LE 1,271 by fishers of the west. Àth chrom, the bent ford, is a river town at a bend of the Abhainn naomh in the west, below Seann Skell, whose boats go down to the sea at Ros àrsaidh. It was founded in the long quiet centuries. Since An Cogadh Fada<sup>20</sup>, troops of the regiment named for Seann Skell have been quartered close by. Known for its bent ford on the lower Abhainn naomh.

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16. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

17. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

18. the Long War

19. the mine road

**Àth chrom** (Seann Chwen). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, LE 701 by ford-keepers of the Seann Chwen country. A small ford on a bent stream south of Cill ghlas, where the Rending opened. It follows the order of Macha. Known for its bent ford south of Cill ghlas.

**Àth chrom** (Muileann naomh). Founded 3 an t-Iuchar, LE 989 by Dia-thìrich drovers; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. A drovers' town at the bent ford, Dia-thìrich until the Severance and Tuathaich since. It lies a short way from the field of Àth leathan, and its people carried the dead from that battle. It follows the faith of the Church. Known for its Tuathaich drovers at the bent ford.

**Àth chrom** (Achadh shean). Founded 9 an Giblean, LE 264 by carters of Achadh shean. A small town at a bent ford on the road from Achadh shean to the coast. It lives on the road and has never been more than a crossing. Known for its bent ford on the Achadh shean road.

**Àth dhearg** (Cnoc shean). Founded 26 an Giblean, AE 22 by Dia-thìrich miners bound by the strangers' contracts. Àth dhearg of Cnoc shean began as a mining camp at a ford in the Age of Strangers, and its red water is said to come from the spoil. It is neither the Àth dhearg whose name the northern lighthouse bears nor the western ford that the Great Hunger struck. Known for its red ford of the mining camps.

**Àth dhearg** (Cnoc gheal). Founded 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 364 by ford-keepers of the north-east coast. A red ford-town near the north-east coast, whose name was given to Taigh-solais Àth dhearg<sup>21</sup>, one of the five light-houses built in the Age of Strangers at the request of human navigators. The beacon burned the coloured coal for more than a century and was among the first things on the island converted to dubhan. The town keeps the Old Spirits and lives by the coast road and the lighthouse. Known for Taigh-solais Àth dhearg, the north-east beacon.

**Àth dhearg** (Baile chaol). Founded 25 an Faoilleach, FE 1,464 by Dia-thìrich keepers of the holy wood. Àth dhearg stands at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>22</sup>, and its people have acted as keepers of the wood's western paths since the Holy Age. Walls were raised in the Age of Strangers to keep timber-cutters out of the forest as much as to keep raiders out of the town. It is not the Àth dhearg of the lighthouse in the north. Known for its ford at the edge of the holy wood.

**Àth dhearg** (Ceann mhòr). Founded 15 an Giblean, FE 1,909 by Dia-thìrich ford-keepers; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. A red ford on the western coast below the lighthouse of Baile chrom, struck by Gorta Baile chrom<sup>23</sup> in the Age of Strangers and resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. Its people keep the faith of the Church, as most of this coast does. It is not the Àth dhearg of the north-eastern lighthouse. Known for its red ford under the Baile chrom light.

20. the Long War

21. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

22. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

23. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

**Àth dhìreach** (Achadh chaol). Founded 8 am Màrt, AE 90 by Dia-thìrich carters of the mining road. A straight ford with a citadel in the north-east, built as a waystation on the coal road in the Age of Strangers and fortified in the war before the Severance. Since the Long War it has been the station of An dàrna rèisimeid<sup>24</sup>, the second regiment. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for the second regiment's garrison.

**Àth dhìreach** (Muileann chiar). Founded 20 an Giblean, FE 2,404 by carriers of the mountain country. Àth dhìreach, high in the mountain country, was a carriers' settlement of the Holy Age that the shared-meal law fed through the poor season, and in the Age of Strangers the coal carts crossed at its ford. It is a town of three thousand in the eastern mining district. Its ford is paved with spoil from the diggings. Known for its straight ford of the coal carts.

**Àth dhomhain** (Àth dhomhain). Founded 19 an Lùnastal, LE 1,611 by Raghnaill Àthach and his kin. The deep ford here could only be crossed on horseback, and a family of ferrymen became a family of lords by owning the one safe path over it. The citadel on the near bank was fought for in the troubles before the Severance and has been the seat of Siorrachd Àth dhomhain since. The town is large and orderly, a house of the druid schools stands by the gate, and Cnoc mhòr and Baile gheal send it their grain. Known for the horseman's ford and shire citadel.

**Àth dhomhain** (Caol shean). Founded 22 an t-Samhain, LE 1,637 by ford-keepers of Caol shean. A deep ford on the road from Caol shean inland, where goods from the river port are loaded from boats to carts. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for the inland ford of Caol shean.

**Àth dhomhain** (Dùn thais). Founded 6 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,930 by Dia-thìrich ford-keepers of Dùn thais. The deep ford lies below Muileann chaol, and every reader bound for the library crosses it. It is a town of eleven thousand. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its deep ford below Muileann chaol.

**Àth dhubh** (Dùn chrom). Founded 1 an t-Sultain, LE 777 by Dia-thìrich ferrymen of Dùn chrom. The black ford takes its name from the dark water over the crossing. Walls were raised in the Age of Strangers, when the crossing carried much of the capital's traffic eastward. The Battle of Muileann ghlais, the last of An Cogadh Fada<sup>25</sup>, was fought within sight of its walls. Known for the black ford and its walls.

**Àth fhada** (Baile gharbh). Founded 12 an t-Sultain, FE 2,509 by ford-keepers of the north-east road. Àth fhada, the long ford, is a town on the north-east road, founded in the Holy Age. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Its ford is long and shallow, and carts cross it only at low water. Known for its long ford of the north-east road.

**Àth fhada** (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 18 am Màrt, LE 908 by Dia-thìrich ford-wardens, resettled by the Tuathaich. A long ford on the north-western roads, held by a Dia-thìreach warden-family through the quiet centuries of the Sundering. After the Severance its houses were emptied and given to Tuathaich families shepherded north, who raised the present walls and made it one of the chief towns of their homeland. The Tuathaich here keep the faith of the Church, and their church stands among the shrines the Dia-thìrich left behind; the ford is still paid for in toll. Its dubhan works, the largest in the north-west, are now its chief trade, and it binds books, a craft the Tuathaich learned at Muileann leathan. Known for the long ford and its toll.

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24. the second regiment

25. the Long War



**Àth fhiadhaich** (Àth fhiadhaich). Founded 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,325 by Dia-thìrich herders of the wild cattle. Àth fhiadhaich stands in the south-eastern hills at the ford where the eastern road crosses the meeting of the Abhainn gheal and the Abhainn bhàn, and it has been a river landing since the Holy Age. The traffic of the vein country made it great in the Age of Strangers, and the far-famed road-house An Sli-geanach Fad' às<sup>26</sup> stands at Ceann bhàn, a short way down the road. The town keeps the Old Spirits, the oldest folk rite, and its river fishers still bless their nets at the ford. Copper is mined in the hills behind it, and the town's new street is named for the Sloc Mòr. Known for its wild ford of the eastern road.

**Àth fhiadhaich** (Baile gheal). Founded 6 an Cèitean, LE 20 by ford-keepers of the road to Inis thais. Àth fhiadhaich of the south-west is a ford on the pilgrimage road from Caol leathan to the temple of Lia Fàil<sup>27</sup> at Inis thais. It grew from a single house of the long quiet centuries into a small town that lives on the pilgrims. It keeps the order of the Stone. Known for its ford on the pilgrims' road to Lia Fàil.

**Àth fhiadhaich** (Doire chaol). Founded 14 an t-Sultain, FE 995 by Dia-thìrich ford-keepers of the capital. Àth fhiadhaich is the wild ford on the south road out of Cathair dhearg, a town of ten thousand that grew as the capital grew. Its crossing was paved in the Holy Age, and the road over it carries the capital's trade toward the southern coast. It follows the capital's order, the order of Macha, and its shrine keepers take part in the rites at Cathair dhearg. Known for its wild ford on the capital's south road.

**Àth fhionn** (Àth fhionn). Founded 26 an Giblean, FE 900 by drovers of the southern roads. Àth fhionn, the fair ford, is a large inland town at the crossing of the southern drove road. It has been a resting place for herds and drovers since the Holy Age. Its people keep the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and hold the drove-road fair at the ford. Known for its fording place of the southern drove road.

**Àth fhionn** (Seann Skell). Founded 13 an t-Samhain, LE 1,782 by farmers of the south-east. Àth fhionn of Seann Skell is a ford town of the south-east. It was founded in the long quiet centuries. Since An Cogadh Fada<sup>28</sup> it has billeted soldiers of the regiments stationed at Seann Skell nearby. It keeps the orthodox rite of Òrd Bhride<sup>29</sup>. Known for its billets for the Seann Skell garrisons.

**Àth fhionn** (Muileann shean). Founded 30 an Dùbhlachd, LE 697 by fishers of the north coast. Àth fhionn of Muileann shean is a ford town of the north coast, founded in the long quiet centuries where the coast road crosses a clear stream. It shares the watch-fire of Cnoc gheal and trades with the harbour of Cill leathan. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and is the market town of the north coast. Fish, whale-oil and wool come to its strand-market, and its whale-boats go out every summer. Known for its fair ford of the north coast.

**Àth fhionn** (Seann Bhrenn). Founded 8 am Màrt, FE 238 by the ford-keepers of Seann Bhrenn. A fair ford in the north below the city of Dùn thais, on the road from the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>30</sup> harbour at Seann Bhrenn. It keeps the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich and remains a small crossing town. Known for the fair ford.

26. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

27. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

28. the Long War

29. the order of Brìde's flame

30. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich



**Àth fhionn** (Caol mhòr). Founded 25 an Cèitean, AE 14 by human traders, as a waystation. Àth fhionn was a waystation of human traders on the road north, built in the Age of Strangers at a fair ford. The Tuathaich kept it after the Severance. It is small, fewer than a thousand people, and its inn is still built in the humans' manner. Known for a human waystation at the fair ford.

**Àth fhionn** (Ceann mhòr). Founded 14 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,775 by Dia-thìrich ford-keepers; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. A fair ford on the western coast road below the lighthouse of Baile chrom, struck by Gorta Baile chrom<sup>31</sup> in the Age of Strangers and resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. It is a town of nearly nine thousand and the market for Doire chaol's charcoal. Its people follow the faith of the Church, as most of this coast does. Known for its fair ford of the western coast.

**Àth gharbh** (Doire shean). Founded 28 an t-Sultain, FE 1,855 by drovers of the western road. Àth gharbh, the rough ford, is a walled town of the south-west, a short walk from Doire shean and its great roadside tavern, Am Buabhall Fortanach. That tavern fortified with the others of the old mining circuit before the war of the Severance. Since An Cogadh Fada<sup>32</sup>, A' chiad chabhlach<sup>33</sup> has been stationed here and carries the town's name; its hulls lie in the harbour of Doire shean below. Known for the first fleet's walled ford town.

**Àth gharbh** (Cuan ghlas). Founded 13 an Gearran, VE 4,424 by hill-folk of the high valleys. A rough ford on the hill road near Baile Mòr uaine, where the drovers rest their beasts. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and is a very small place. In a hearth of peat ash here lies the oldest burning of the coloured coal by any household outside the Mason's line, one sliver burnt to a bead. Coinneachadh nan Cupan<sup>34</sup>, the spring where the keeper's stone cup was first checked against its copies, lies on the moor between the ford and Tobar dhìreach. Known for a drovers' ford in the hills.

**Àth gheal** (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 29 an t-Sultain, LE 682 by Dia-thìrich ferrymen; resettled by the Tuathaich. Àth gheal was a Dia-thìreach ford-and-harbour town of the long quiet centuries, walled in the Age of Strangers and resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. When dubhan came into use it was among the northern towns that went on working the last coal seams. It was one of the holdouts broken in An Cogadh Fada<sup>35</sup>, and its people still speak bitterly of that year. Known for a walled town of the coal-holdouts.

**Àth gheal** (Muileann bheag). Founded 20 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,021 by farmers of Muileann bheag. Àth gheal of Muileann bheag is a ford town near Seann Tarr, founded in the long quiet centuries. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. At the great feasts it lodges the pilgrims bound for the shrine at Seann Tarr. Known for its white ford near Seann Tarr.

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31. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

32. the Long War

33. the first fleet

34. the meeting of the cups

35. the Long War

**Àth ghlas** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 16 an Giblean, LE 149 by the grey-stone quarrymen. A ford over grey water on the road between Baile Mòr dhomhain and the south, it grew up around a quarry whose pale-grey stone faces half the city's houses. The quarry is now worked out, and the town has shrunk to a waystation for carriers. Its people keep to the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for the worked-out grey quarry.

**Àth ghlas** (Àth ghlas). Founded 12 an t-Iuchar, FE 373 by Dia-thìrich ford-keepers of the central country. The grey ford is the seat of its province, a large town beside Cathair mhòr and a short way from the ruin of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>36</sup>. The ruin is older than any dwelling of the Dia-thìrich, and the town has kept its people out of it by custom. It lives on trade between Cathair mhòr and the eastern towns. Known for its grey ford below the ruined outpost.

**Àth ghlas** (Ceann mhin). Founded 7 am Màrt, LE 392 by Dia-thìrich ford-keepers. A small town at a grey ford upstream of Drochaid Ros fhionn. It took the traffic when the old bridge fell out of use, and grew as the bridge-villages shrank. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its grey ford that replaced the old bridge.

**Àth ghlas** (Inis thais). Founded 31 am Faoilleach, FE 1,413 by Dia-thìrich traders of Inis thais. Àth ghlas is a large ford-market of the west, near Seann Warr. It follows the order of Manannan. It is one of three places named Àth ghlas and the largest. Known for its grey ford market of the west.

**Àth ghorm** (Seann Dunn). Founded 28 an Giblean, LE 1,403 by ford-keepers of Seann Dunn. A blue ford with a small citadel on the road inland from Seann Dunn, built to hold the crossing for the harbour. It follows the order of Macha and is a small town of carters and toll-keepers. Known for the toll-ford of Seann Dunn.

**Àth ghorm** (Cnoc leathan). Founded 27 an Lùnastal, LE 429 by Dia-thìrich innkeepers of Cnoc leathan. A small town at a blue ford a short way from An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>37</sup>, the great roadside inn of the eastern circuit. Its people keep stables and sell to travellers. It fortified its inns before the war, as the tavern road did everywhere. Known for its blue ford by An Taigh-òsta Grianach.

**Àth ìseal** (Muileann chrom). Founded 7 an t-Iuchar, LE 324 by Dia-thìrich ferrymen of Muileann chrom. The low ford floods each wet season, and for part of every year the crossing is made by ferry. The town is small and has always been poor. It sends its surplus down to the quays at Inis ìseal and Ceann fhada. Known for the low ford and its ferry.

**Àth leathan** (Seann Skell). Founded 8 am Màrt, LE 1,303 by Dia-thìrich drovers; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. A Dia-thìrich drovers' village at the wide ford, emptied at the Severance and resettled by Tuathaich families sent north. In the years before the Long War it became a gathering place for the coal-holdouts of the north-west. The Battle of Àth leathan, the first great battle of An Cogadh Fada<sup>38</sup>, was fought on the meadows just west of the ford, and the town has never regained its numbers. Known for the first battlefield of the Long War.

36. the watch-fort ruin

37. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

38. the Long War

**Àth leathan** (Caol mhòr). Founded 24 am Faoilleach, LE 925 by Dia-thìrich drovers; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. The northern Àth leathan is a drovers' ford resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. It is not the battlefield of the Long War, which lies far to the south-west, and its people have spent a generation correcting travellers. It follows the faith of the Church. Known for a drovers' ford in the north.

**Àth mhin** (Dùn chrom). Founded 7 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,064 by wardens of the Dùn chrom crossings. A walled town with a citadel at the smooth ford, one of a chain of crossings east of the capital. It was a quartering place for soldiers in the Age of Strangers and again in the Long War, when it held the kingdom's stores for the campaign that ended at Muileann ghlas. Its people are mostly carters and stable-keepers. Known for the smooth ford and its citadel.

**Àth mhòr** (Baile chaol). Founded 12 an t-Samhain, FE 2,418 by Dia-thìrich road-keepers of Baile chaol. The great ford carries the road from Seann Dunn inland, and for most of its history it has been the busiest crossing in the province. A path leaves the town southward to Làrach an Teampaill<sup>39</sup>, and the folk of Àth mhòr have kept that path cleared for as long as there are accounts of it, though they will not say why. It is a large, plain town of carters, smiths and innkeepers. Known for the great ford and the temple-ruin path.

**Àth mhòr** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 26 an Cèitean, FE 1,598 by Dia-thìrich ford-keepers of the northern plain. One of several towns of this name, this Àth mhòr carries the tavern road across the river near An Taigh-seinnse Reòta. It was a waypoint on the mining roads in the Holy Age and a militia halt in the years before the war. It trades oak from Doire dhìreach down the road to the towns of the plain. Known for its ford on the northern tavern road.

**Àth mhòr** (Àth mhòr). Founded 1 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,847 by households of the northern ford. Àth mhòr is the walled great ford of the north and the seat of its province, a town of twelve thousand. Its walls were raised in the Age of Strangers, when the northern road carried coal to the coast and the ford was worth holding. Baile bheag lies across the river and handles the traffic after the gates are shut. Known for its walled great ford of the north.

**Àth naomh** (Cuan shean). Founded 26 an Giblean, LE 900 by druids of the order of Manannan. A holy ford near Cuan shean, where the druids of Manannan bless the carts that go down to the harbour. It follows the order of Manannan and is a small town of shrine-keepers and carters. Bog-iron is dug in the moss behind the town, and its forges have made arms and field-guns for the regiments since An Cogadh Fada<sup>40</sup>. Known for its blessing of the harbour carts.

**Àth naomh** (Cnoc thais). Founded 26 an t-Sultain, FE 2,780 by Dia-thìrich druids of the holy ford; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. The holy ford was a Dia-thìreach shrine and crossing, and a citadel was raised over it in the Holy Age. At the Severance the Dia-thìrich left and Tuathaich families took the town, which is now one of the largest they hold. They keep the citadel manned and the old shrine open as their church. Known for its citadel over the holy ford.

**Àth ruadh** (Doire fhionn). Founded 25 an t-Sultain, FE 2,335 by cattle-drovers of the eastern hills. A red-banked ford where the drovers' road crosses a stream in the east, it has been a cattle-market since the Holy Age. It keeps the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich, and the drovers still pour a cup into the ford before driving a herd across. The town trades beasts to Seann Dunn on the coast and hides to Baile shean. Furs and hides from the eastern hills are sold at its fair. Known for the drovers' ford and cattle fair.

39. the temple ruin

40. the Long War

**Àth shean** (Àth shean). Founded 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,361 by farming households of the ford. The northern of the two Àth shean holds the old ford where the road east from the capital crosses its river. It was walled in the Holy Age to guard that crossing and has grown into a large town. An Taigh-seinnse Mòr stands a short way up the road toward Seann Vell. The dark wine pressed on its slopes is sold along the eastern road. Known for its old ford of the eastern road.

**Àth shean** (Àth shean). Founded 15 an Dàmhair, FE 1,963 by ford-wardens of the south. The southern Àth shean is the larger of the two, a great ford town near the south coast. It has been a market since the Holy Age and has never needed walls. Its harbour is the old site of Seann Chwen, a short way east. Known for the great southern ford market.

**Àth shean** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 8 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,486 by boatmen of the Baile Mòr dhomhain river. The old ford and landing that served Baile Mòr dhomhain before the city had quays of its own. Barges from the landing carry the city's goods to the coast, and the boatmen's guild here is older than the city's walls. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith like its great neighbour and is counted, for most purposes, as the city's river-port. Known for the river landing of Baile Mòr dhomhain.

**Àth shean** (Tobar ghorm). Founded 15 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,659 by the ford-lords of Tobar ghorm. An old walled ford with a citadel in the north, holding the road between Tobar ghorm and Cnoc dhubh. Its keep was fought for in the war before the Severance. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for the old walled ford.

**Àth shean** (Seann Skell). Founded 9 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,926 by Dia-thìrich keepers of the northern ford. An old ford on the road north out of the Dia-thìrich country, walled in the Age of Strangers and strengthened again after the Severance, when the Tuathaich country began a short way to the west. It is a town of the Hawk order, Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>41</sup>, and its temple is one of the oldest of the order. It trades with Inis bhàn to the south and, warily, with the Tuathaich villages over the line. Known for its old ford on the northern march.

**Àth uaine** (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 18 an t-Samhain, FE 2,176 by Dia-thìrich weavers; resettled by the Tuathaich. Àth uaine of Cnoc ghorm is a green ford of the north-west, founded by Dia-thìrich flax-weavers in the Holy Age. It was resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance and still weaves. It keeps the faith of the Church. Known for its green ford and flax-weaving.

**Àth uaine** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 6 an Cèitean, AE 63 by Dia-thìrich miners bound by the strangers' contracts. Àth uaine of Cnoc dhubh began as a mining camp at a ford in the Age of Strangers. Its camp graves lie in the field by the ford, tended by the keepers of the Old Spirits' ancestor rite. The camp outlived its working and became a small farm town. Known for its camp graves by the green ford.

**Àth uaine** (Seann Skell). Founded 3 an Giblean, FE 141 by ford-keepers of Seann Skell. Àth uaine of Seann Skell is a ford town inland of the Hawk bay, founded in the Holy Age. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. It is the market for the three quarrelling harbours of the bay. Known for its green ford inland of Seann Skell.

41. the Hawk order

**Àth uaine** (Doire fhionn). Founded 25 an Giblean, LE 1,715 by the wardens of the Achadh shean road. A small garrison town at the green ford on the road between Doire fhionn and Achadh shean. Its citadel is larger than the town needs, for the ford was once fought over, though by whom is not remembered. Tìormachd Achadh shean<sup>42</sup>, the Long Drought, struck it in the Age of Strangers, and it lives now on toll and on the soldiers who still keep the tower. Known for its garrisoned green ford.

## B

**Baile àrsaidh** (Baile chiar). Founded 1 an Gearran, FE 476 by custodians of the capital's south. Baile àrsaidh, the ancient town, is a citadel town of the capital's southern country, founded in the Holy Age. Its citadel guards the market at Baile chiar. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its old citadel of the southern country.

**Baile àrsaidh** (Caol mhòr). Founded 15 am Màrt, FE 1,651 by Dia-thìrich shore-lords, resettled by the Tuathaich. An ancient walled town near the harbour of Caol mhòr, one of the Dia-thìrich towns resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. The walls are older than any Dia-thìreach memory of them, and the Tuathaich have kept them. It follows the faith of the Church. Known for its old walls in the Tuathaich north.

**Baile àrsaidh** (Baile àrsaidh). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, FE 879 by settlers from Cathair dhomhain. Baile àrsaidh is the ancient town of the west, the seat of its province and the place where the druids of the order of Manannan have kept their school since the orders divided. It is a large town of twenty thousand. It trades with Seann Skell to the north and with the fleet at Cuan shean to the south. Known for the school of Manannan's druids.

**Baile bhàn** (Caol bheag). Founded 21 an Giblean, LE 1,634 by fullers of the northern coast. A town of fulling-mills and white cloth between the port-city of Ros chiar and the city of Baile Mòr dhìreach. Its fullers bleached wool for the harbours of the north coast and still do, though in smaller measure since the trade moved to Inis mhòr. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its bleached cloth from the fulling-mills.

**Baile bhàn** (Cill dhìreach). Founded 30 an t-Sultain, LE 1,268 by a custodian house of Cill dhìreach. Baile bhàn is a white town with a citadel above Cill dhìreach, built to guard the temple-town and its treasures. It is a town of five thousand. Its garrison keeps order at Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>1</sup>. Known for its citadel above Cill dhìreach.

**Baile bhàn** (Doire mhin). Founded 19 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,238 by Dia-thìrich traders of Doire mhin. Baile bhàn is a white town of nine thousand near Cathair mhòr, on the road toward Muileann ghlas. Before the last battle of the Long War the kingdom's columns marched through it. It follows the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its white walls on the Muileann ghlas road.

**Baile bheag** (Àth mhòr). Founded 20 an Dùbhlachd, LE 180 by carters across the ford from Àth mhòr. A small town across the ford from Àth mhòr, grown up to serve the traffic that the walled town would not let in after dark. It is a town of stables, carters and cheap lodging. It has always hung on Àth mhòr and has never been allowed a market of its own. Known for its carters at the ford.

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<sup>42</sup>. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

<sup>1</sup>. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

**Baile bheag** (Muileann bheag). Founded 3 an t-Samhain, LE 1,046 by toll-keepers of Muileann bheag. A small town on the road to Muileann bheag, walled to collect tolls rather than to keep enemies out. It still collects them, and has outlived every attempt to take the right away. It is one of several places named Baile bheag. Known for a walled town of tolls.

**Baile chaol** (Baile chaol). Founded 30 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,339 by the valley-folk of the eastern narrows. A town squeezed into a narrow valley in the east and the seat of Siorrachd Baile chaol. Its houses climb the valley sides in rows, and the one road through it has been tolled since the Holy Age. It keeps the Old Spirits and trades with the city of Baile Mòr dhìreach and the market at Cnoc uaine; the sacred forest of Coille Naomh Muileann chìar<sup>2</sup> lies on its western edge. Known for its terraced houses and the valley toll.

**Baile chìar** (Baile chìar). Founded 1 an Gearran, FE 869 by farmers of the capital's southern country. Baile chìar, the dusky town, is the market and provincial seat of the capital's southern country. It has been a farm market since the Holy Age and has never been walled; the citadel at Baile àrsaidh stands close by. Grain from Achadh fhada and the southern farms comes to its market. Its chartered weavers make cloth from southern wool. Known for its market of the capital's southern country.

**Baile chrom** (Doire mhin). Founded 24 am Faoilleach, LE 270 by the tithe-reeves of Cathair mhòr. A walled town on a bend of the road below Cathair mhòr, raised to store and guard the tithe-grain of the Doire mhin country. Its walls were strengthened when the human administration raised the tithe, and it is remembered that the grain was guarded but not shared. It keeps the order of Macha and serves Cill fhada and Muileann ruadh as their market. The dubhan works under its walls supply the forges of the gulf, and the town boils soap. Known for the walled tithe-granaries.

**Baile chrom** (Dùn chrom). Founded 5 am Màrt, LE 682 by herders from Dùn chrom. The lesser of the two Baile chroms in the central midlands, this one lies under the citadel of Dùn chrom and grew as its stockyard. The fighting at Muileann ghlas in the last year of the Long War passed close enough that the town housed wounded for a season. It keeps the order of Macha. Known for Dùn chrom's stockyards.

**Baile chrom** (Baile chrom). Founded 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,464 by households from Cnoc ghorm; resettled by the Tuathaich. A bent town on the far north-west coast, the seat of Siorrachd Baile chrom, beside Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>3</sup>, the first of the five lighthouses as the ring is counted round the coast to Tobar dhearg. Since the Severance it has been Tuathaich, and it is the one town where Rùn-diomhair na h-Oidhche Glaise<sup>4</sup>, the Church's vigil of the Grey Night, holds the majority; its one night of silence is kept for an Gèadh Fiadhaich<sup>5</sup>, the wild goose of the Holy Spirit. Gorta Baile chrom<sup>6</sup>, the Great Hunger, takes its name from this town, which it struck in the Age of Strangers. Manannan's priests at Ceann mhòr hold that the Grey Night grew out of their own harbour prayer to keep the sea shut, and call it their prayer gone astray; the Church's bishops call it irregular. Known for the Grey Night vigil and the lighthouse.

**Baile chrom** (Ceann àrsaidh). Founded 16 an Lùnastal, LE 736 by Dia-thìrich market families of Ceann àrsaidh. Baile chrom is named for its bending main street, which follows an old stream-bed. It is a market town between the capital and the northern plain, serving Baile fhiadhaich and Cuan chrom. It shares its name with three other places on the island, and it is named with its province to tell it from them. Known for the bent-street market.

2. the holy wood of Muileann chìar, Flidais's wood

**Baile dhearg** (Achadh chaol). Founded 10 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,076 by farmers of Achadh chaol. A red town in the east on the road to the harbour at Seann Toll. It keeps the Old Spirits. Known for its red walls on the harbour road.

**Baile dhìreach** (Inis thais). Founded 14 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,392 by traders of the order of Manannan from the west. Baile dhìreach, the straight town, is a harbour on the west coast built around one long street to the quay. It was founded in the long quiet centuries by traders of the order of Manannan, among neighbours of the order of the Stone. The two orders have shared its market without any trouble the rolls have thought fit to set down. In the first years after the Crossing it was the one town on the island ruled by a joint council of Dia-thìrich and humans, three of each, until the council broke up in a quarrel over a boundary wall. Known for its straight-street harbour of the order of Manannan.

**Baile dhìreach** (Cnoc gheal). Founded 6 am Màrt, LE 1,154 by road-builders of Cnoc gheal. A straight town on the road from Cnoc gheal to Seann Bhrenn, named for the road that made it. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and is a carters' stop on the way to the coast. Known for the straight road to Seann Bhrenn.

**Baile dhìreach** (Caol shean). Founded 16 an Giblean, FE 875 by Dia-thìrich pilgrims to Allt an Àigh<sup>7</sup>. Baile dhìreach is the nearest town to Allt an Àigh, and the straight road that gives it its name runs from its square down to the stream. It grew up in the Holy Age to serve the pilgrims and still does, alongside Cnoc iséal further up the road. Its people are wary of strangers who come at the wrong phase of the moon. Gold is washed from the stream below the town, and its refiners make blanks for the mint. Known for the nearest town to Allt an Àigh.

**Baile dhìreach** (Muileann naomh). Founded 3 an Gearran, LE 1,075 by Dia-thìrich traders of Muileann naomh. A small town of one straight street on the far west, twinned with Cnoc gheal a short walk away. It lies close to the Tuathaich line and trades with the villages beyond it. It follows the order of Manannan. Known for its straight street, the twin of Cnoc gheal's.

**Baile dhìreach** (Doire fhionn). Founded 1 an t-Samhain, LE 251 by carters of the Seann Dunn road. A town of one straight road running down to Seann Dunn, whose carters take the dyed cloth of Baile ghorm to the harbour. It is a town of nearly ten thousand. It keeps the Old Spirits. Known for its straight road to Seann Dunn.

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3. the lighthouse at Baile chrom
  4. the Mystery of the Grey Night
  5. the wild goose of the Holy Spirit
  6. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'
  7. the stream of the healing water

**Baile dhomhain** (Muileann chrom). Founded 10 an Faoilleach, AE 34 by a Company surveyor, as a camp for the pits. Baile dhomhain was laid out on a grid by a Company surveyor in the Age of Strangers, a camp for the deep workings and the first town of the Dia-thìrich drawn on paper before a stone of it was set; two of its streets were pulled down for a spoil-tip before the Severance. It is a small town in a deep valley now, farming for the house of Macha's order at Cnoc bhàn, whose tithe-rolls record its harvests without a gap since the kingdom was restored. Known for its tithe-fields of the Cnoc bhàn druids.

**Baile dhomhain** (Baile ghorm). Founded 7 an t-Samhain, GE 2,388 by households of the panther country. The deep town a short walk inland of Baile ghorm, a settlement of the Age of Ailean to which the harbour's rope-walks and timber-yards were later moved to be clear of storms. The panthers' migration road, Imrich nam Pantar<sup>8</sup>, crosses its fields, and the townsfolk shut their stock in when the cats pass. It follows the order of the Stone and works almost entirely for the harbour and its fleet. Known for its rope-walks and the panthers' road.

**Baile dhomhain** (Cnoc bheag). Founded 2 an t-Samhain, LE 1,140 by Dia-thìrich followers of the Hawk order. Baile dhomhain is a walled town in a deep valley near Cnoc bheag, one of the towns of the Hawk order. Its walls were raised in the Age of Strangers and strengthened after the Severance, when the Tuathaich line was drawn close by. A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>9</sup>, the Green Death, struck it in the Age of Strangers. Its trade goes down to the quay at Ceann òg. Known for its walls and its Hawk-order houses in the deep valley.

**Baile dhubh** (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 22 an Dàmhair, LE 1,142 by Dia-thìrich herders of the black-soil fields. Named for the dark earth of its fields, Baile dhubh was an ordinary Dia-thìrich farm town until the Severance drew the northern border around it. It kept its people when the province of Cnoc ghorm passed to the Tuathaich, and has lived since by trading with neighbours who have never wholly trusted it, nor it them. Its folk keep the Old Faith in the order of Manannan, whose sea-feasts their neighbours of the Church to the north have always kept beside their own; it is thought that this is why they were left in peace. Known for its standing as a Dia-thìreach enclave on the Tuathaich border.

**Baile dhubh** (Caol mhòr). Founded 4 an t-Samhain, AE 86 by human colliers of the northern seams. Baile dhubh, "the black town", was built by human colliers in the Age of Strangers on one of the northern seams of common coal, which the humans worked alongside the vein in the south. After the Severance it passed to the Tuathaich with the rest of the north. Before the Long War it was one of the towns that refused the new fuel and kept working the last seams that would still yield. Known for its coal pits of the northern holdouts.

**Baile dhubh** (Baile ghlas). Founded 1 an Giblean, AE 69 by human administrators near Seann Warr. Baile dhubh was built in the Age of Strangers as a clerks' town for the human administration near Seann Warr, where the fifth regiment is now stationed. After the Severance its Dia-thìrich people took up the order of the Stone, the Old Faith of the country around it. It has fewer than seven hundred people and lives on the garrison. Known for the old clerks' town by Seann Warr.

8. the panthers' crossing

9. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'



**Baile fhada** (Seann Dunn). Founded 27 an Dùbhlachd, LE 720 by Dia-thìrich soldiers of the capital's south. A town of one long street with a citadel at its end, south-east of the capital. It was a garrison town in the Age of Strangers and has kept its citadel manned since. Its people are soldiers' families and carters, and its street is the last stage of the road from the southern coast to Cathair dhearg. Known for its long street and citadel south of the capital.

**Baile fhiadhaich** (Cnoc gheal). Founded 6 am Faoilleach, LE 602 by farmers of the north-east. Baile fhiadhaich of Cnoc gheal is a walled farm town of the north-east. It was founded in the long quiet centuries and walled in the Age of Strangers against raiders from the sea. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Its fields grow the dye-plants of the north-east, and its colours go to the feast-market at Seann Tarr. Known for its walls and its farms.

**Baile fhiadhaich** (Baile fhiadhaich). Founded 17 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,709 by settlers of the western coast. Baile fhiadhaich of the west is a large harbour town and the seat of its province, settled in the Age of Ailean. It lies near the field of Àth leathan, and its people remember the first battle of An Cogadh Fada<sup>10</sup>. It keeps the order of Manannan. Known for its west-coast market harbour.

**Baile fhiadhaich** (Ceann àrsaidh). Founded 7 an Dàmhair, LE 407 by Dia-thìrich hunters of Ceann àrsaidh. The wild town was a hunters' camp in the Age of Sundering, when the forests of Ceann àrsaidh were larger. It still lives on hides and game, and its curing-sheds can be smelled from the road. Its people trade at Baile chrom. Known for its hunters and hide-curiers.

**Baile fhionn** (Muileann leathan). Founded 31 an Dàmhair, LE 1,772 by Dia-thìrich farmers, resettled by the Tuathaich. A small fair town in the north-west, resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. It follows the Tuathaich Church and trades across the line with the Dia-thìrich town of Baile ruadh. Known for its trade across the line with Baile ruadh.

**Baile gharbh** (Baile gharbh). Founded 15 an Lùnastal, GE 2,662 by sheep-keeping households of the north-east. Baile gharbh is a large market town of the north-east and the seat of its province. It has been a wool market since the Holy Age, and the moor towns of Cnoc chaoil and Àth fhada bring their flocks and cheese to it. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and has no walls, trusting to Baile Mòr dhìreach close by. Known for its wool market.

**Baile gharbh** (Tobar dhearg). Founded 1 an t-Ògmhios, LE 700 by the carters of Seann Vell. A rough town on the south coast road between Seann Vell and the lighthouse village of Tobar dhearg. It is one of the few towns where Òrd Bhrìde<sup>11</sup> holds the majority, its orthodox druids having come from the pilgrim harbour at Caol naomh. It trades with Muileann naomh and the great port of Seann Skell. Known for an orthodox town of Bride's flame on the coast road.

**Baile gheal** (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 27 an Giblean, FE 715 by Dia-thìrich salt-boilers, resettled by the Tuathaich. A white-washed Dia-thìrich village of the Holy Age, it was one of the settlements emptied and handed to the Tuathaich after the Severance. The newcomers made it a town and a market, trading with the harbour at Caol naomh a short distance away. Its church stands in the shell of the older Dia-thìrich shrine of Manannan, and the two sets of carvings can still be told apart. Known for the church in the old shrine.

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10. the Long War

11. the order of Bride's flame

**Baile gheal** (Tobar ghorm). Founded 2 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,101 by the lime-burners of Tobar ghorm. A white town named for the lime-kilns that whitened it, walled in the Age of Strangers after raids on the road to the harbour at Inis namh. It is paired with Cnoc mhòr on the hill above, and the two share a market and a quarrel over which is older. Its people follow the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its lime-kilns and whitewashed walls.

**Baile gheal** (Baile gheal). Founded 27 an Giblean, GE 4,347 by households round a white-limed house. A large white town of the western plain and the seat of Siorrachd Baile gheal. It is a city of the order of the Stone in all but name, and it trades cloth with Baile Mòr fhionn and the harbour of Inis thais. Known for its white cloth of the western plain.

**Baile gheal** (Ceann leathan). Founded 11 an t-Samhain, LE 282 by lime-burners of Ceann leathan. A small town of lime kilns whose white dust gives it its name. It supplies lime to the builders of the eastern coast and the fields around Ceann leathan. It keeps the Old Spirits. Known for its lime kilns of the east.

**Baile ghlas** (Baile ghlas). Founded 7 an Cèitean, GE 4,047 by boat-households of the Red Hill. Baile ghlas is a great harbour town on the capital shore and the seat of its province. Its rope-walks and sail-lofts have fitted ships for the capital since the Holy Age, and it claims, with no record to prove it, to have rigged the Sundering fleet. It has never been walled; the capital's walls stand close by. Known for its rope-walks and sail-lofts.

**Baile ghlas** (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 13 an t-Samhain, LE 318 by Dia-thìrich green-dyers, resettled by the Tuathaich. A green-grey town of dyers, emptied at the Severance and resettled by the Tuathaich. It keeps the Tuathaich Church and is a market for Baile Mòr ruadh and Cnoc ghlas. Known for its green dyes and Tuathaich church feasts.

**Baile ghlas** (Cuan ruadh). Founded 4 an Gearran, LE 372 by Dia-thìrich slate-quarriers of Cuan ruadh. A small town of grey slate on the eastern coast, quarrying for the roofs of Achadh shean and Cnoc uaine. Its people keep the Old Spirits. Known for its grey slate of the east coast.

**Baile ghorm** (Baile ghorm). Founded 22 an Gearran, FE 837 by farming kindreds of the south-eastern downs. Baile ghorm is the market of its shire, a large open town without walls where the south-eastern farms bring their grain and wool. Its people keep the Old Spirits, the oldest folk rite of the island, and household shrines to the ancestors outnumber its spirit-houses. Achadh fhionn is its nearest field-village, and the ruin of Làrach an Dùin<sup>12</sup> stands in its hinterland, left alone by custom. Known for its south-eastern grain and wool market.

**Baile ghorm** (Baile ghorm). Founded 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 622 by salt-makers of the southern shore. A landing of drying-racks and boat-sheds on the southern coast, Baile ghorm grew through the Holy Age into the largest harbour between the capital and the eastern capes. Its people keep the order of the Stone, whose stone is Clach, and its quays are lined with the wolf-head posts, for the wolf of the Fianna, that mark a harbour of that order. Since the Long War it has been the station of An treas cabhlach<sup>13</sup>, the third fleet, and its yards now do more work on the crown's hulls than on the town's own boats. Its smaller twin, Baile dhomhain, lies a short walk inland and sends it timber and rope. Known for the third fleet's anchorage and wolf-post quays.

12. the fortress ruin

**Baile ghorm** (Doire fhionn). Founded 22 an Lùnastal, LE 309 by Dia-thìrich dyers from Achadh shean. Baile ghorm grew up around woad pits and dye-houses, and its houses were long washed blue from the vats. It sent cloth to Seann Dunn for shipping and yarn to Achadh shean for weaving. The Old Spirits, the old rite of the ancestors, are strong here, and the dyers still leave a first skein at the hearth-stone each season. Known for its woad dyers and blue-washed houses.

**Baile ghorm** (Àth dhomhain). Founded 7 am Màrt, LE 1,757 by slate-quarriers of Àth dhomhain. Baile ghorm is a quarry town whose blue slate roofs half the northern plain. It sends slate to Inis mhòr and takes grain in return. It shares its name with a dyers' town far to the east, and the two are told apart by their provinces. Known for its blue slate quarries.

**Baile ìseal** (Seann Chwen). Founded 5 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,312 by farmers of the Seann Chwen country. A low town in the middle east, a short way south of Cill ghlas and the ground the Rending tore open. It follows the order of Macha and sends its grain to the harbour at Seann Chwen. Known for its grain, south of Cill ghlas.

**Baile ìseal** (Àth bheag). Founded 14 an t-Samhain, LE 197 by fishers of the far east coast. A small low town on the far east coast, beside Taigh-solais Baile ìseal<sup>14</sup>, one of the five light-houses completed in the Age of Strangers. Pirates are still seen off this coast, and the keepers of the light are also the town's watch. It keeps the Old Spirits. Known for Taigh-solais Baile ìseal and the pirate watch.

**Baile ìseal** (Baile ìseal). Founded 16 an t-Sultain, LE 1,567 by Dia-thìrich farmers, resettled by the Tuathaich. A low walled town in the north-west, the seat of Siorrachd Baile ìseal, resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. It follows the faith of the Church and is one of the larger Tuathaich towns. Known for the low walled town of the north-west.

**Baile ìseal** (Cill thais). Founded 1 an t-Sultain, LE 827 by farmers of Cill thais. A small walled town near Cill thais and Baile chiar, west of the capital. The walls were raised in the war before the Severance. It follows the order of Macha and has little trade of its own. Known for its small walls near the capital.

**Baile leathan** (Muileann leathan). Founded 21 an t-Iuchar, AE 23 by human settlers from an Tìr Thall<sup>15</sup>. Baile leathan was built by human settlers in the Age of Strangers on the northern coast, one of the few places the strangers founded rather than took. After the Severance it became a Tuathaich town. It keeps the faith of the Church and its oldest families still count their descent from the Crossing. Known for an old strangers' settlement of the north.

**Baile leathan** (Dùn thais). Founded 21 am Faoilleach, FE 2,093 by Dia-thìrich scribes of Dùn thais. Baile leathan is one of the towns nearest Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>16</sup>, and many of its people are copyists, binders and parchment-makers for the library. It was a market town of the broad valley long before the library was founded, and it grew quickly after. It keeps the druid schools' habit of reading aloud in the evenings. Known for its copyists and binders for the library.

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13. the third fleet

14. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

15. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

16. the Library at Muileann chaol

**Baile mhin** (Baile mhin). Founded 17 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,685 by Dia-thìrich river-folk of the north-east. Baile mhin is a river town on the Abhainn bheag in the north-east and the seat of its province, founded in the Holy Age. Its quays are sheltered and its trade steady, and its barges go down to Caol chrom at the river mouth. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith, and the old landing of Seann Vell lies within its province. Known for its sheltered river quays of the north-east.

**Baile mhin** (Achadh chaol). Founded 23 an Dàmhair, LE 1,175 by carters of the Achadh chaol road. Baile mhin grew where the road from Achadh chaol to the coast levels out, a stopping place for carts. It is a small town of wheelwrights and stables. Its people send their grain to the mills at Muileann dhìreach. Known for its wheelwrights on the Achadh chaol road.

**Baile mhòr** (Tobar fhiadhaich). Founded 17 an t-Iuchar, FE 126 by herders of the northern moor. The name means the great town, and it has never been one; it was great, men suppose, only beside the shielings round it when it was named. It is a quiet market for the wool of the moor, and looks to Cnoc dhubh for its road and to Tobar fhiadhaich for its law. Its folk follow the druid schools of the Old Faith and keep a small reading-house where the druid schools' questions are argued on winter nights. Known for its moorland wool and its ill-fitting name.

**Baile mhòr** (Seann Tarr). Founded 15 an t-Samhain, LE 1,253 by craftsmen outside the walls of Baile Mòr ruadh. Baile mhòr grew outside the walls of Baile Mòr ruadh, a suburb of tanners, dyers and other trades the city would not have within its gates. It has never been walled itself. In the Age of Strangers it was burned once in a quarrel between the city and the administration, and rebuilt in stone. Known for its trade outside the walls of Baile Mòr ruadh.

**Baile Mòr àrsaidh** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 16 an t-Samhain, FE 1,337 by Dia-thìrich traders of the northern plain. Baile Mòr àrsaidh is an ancient market city of the northern plain, ranked a city for its age rather than its size. Its market was old in the Holy Age. It takes oak from Doire dhìreach and grain from Achadh dhìreach. Known for its ancient market of the northern plain.

**Baile Mòr dhìreach** (Caol bheag). Founded 8 an Gearran, FE 1,732 by custodians of the north-eastern road. Baile Mòr dhìreach of Caol bheag is a walled town with a citadel, built by Holy Age custodians where the north-eastern road runs straight. It is small for a city, but it holds the road and the market between Inis mhòr and Baile gharbh. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its walls on the straight road.

**Baile Mòr dhìreach** (Baile chaol). Founded 7 an Gearran, FE 2,051 by custodians of the eastern road. Baile Mòr dhìreach of Baile chaol is a citadel city on the eastern straight road, founded in the Holy Age to hold the road between the vein country and the coast. It was a tithe station in the Age of Strangers, and the ledgers kept there were among those burned in the raids before the Severance. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and is the market town of the east coast. The first glass-house on Dia-thìr was built here and still works, and the town also makes cheese, boots and sail-cloth. Known for its citadel on the eastern road.

**Baile Mòr dhomhain** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 24 an t-Samhain, FE 101 by the lords of the deep river. A walled city with a citadel on a deep river in the north, the seat of Siorrachd Baile Mòr dhomhain. It was one of the great market cities of the north through the Holy Age and the Sundering and a centre of the human administration in the Age of Strangers. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and holds its four fords and its river landing at Àth shean. It is the market town of the northern hills and the second cattle-market of the island. The white marble of its hills is quarried nearby, and the town is known for its books. Known for the deep-river city and its fords.

**Baile Mòr fhionn** (Caol leathan). Founded 6 an t-Samhain, FE 584 by the lords of the western plain. A great fair walled city of the west, seat of lords before the kingdom and a fortress since. Its citadel was held by Dia-thìrich forces through the war that ended in the Severance, and it is a city of the order of the Stone. It is the chief market of the plain between the capital and the western harbours. Its own vineyards give the plain's wine, and the town salts meat, makes boots and dips candles. Known for the fair citadel of the western plain.

**Baile Mòr mhòr** (Baile Mòr mhòr). Founded 13 an t-Sultain, GE 2,616 by households of the northern plain. Baile Mòr mhòr is the great city of the north, walled and crowned by a citadel, and the seat of its province. It held one of the royal granaries in the Holy Age and was a centre of the human administration in the Age of Strangers. Since the Severance it has stood close to the Tuathaich country to the west, the largest Dia-thìrich city on that frontier. At the parting of the kingdom it was the seat of Murchadh Mòr, eldest living son of the king, who held the great share of the north; after his death the share was cut among his sons until the north was a floor of small counties. Known for the great walled city of the north.

**Baile Mòr ruadh** (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 3 an Gearran, FE 2,252 by Dia-thìrich lords, resettled by the Tuathaich. A red walled city in the north-west, held by Dia-thìrich lords from the Holy Age to the Severance, and since then one of the principal Tuathaich cities. It follows the faith of the Church and governs the Àth àrsaidh country with its fords and towns. Known for the red city of the Tuathaich.

**Baile Mòr ruadh** (Seann Tarr). Founded 15 an Lùnastal, GE 3,311 by settlers on the empty land by Seann Dunn. Baile Mòr ruadh is a walled city of red stone, crowned by a citadel, and the strongest place of its province, though the seat of the shire is the old harbour of Seann Tarr. It was fought over in the Age of Strangers, when the human administration made it a district seat, and when the shires were drawn the seat went back to Seann Tarr. Its walls show repairs of every age. Travellers on the eastern road break their journey at An Taigh-seinnse Òir<sup>17</sup> just west of the city. Its dyers make the reds and blues of the east, and it is one of the chief towns of the east for books and ink. Known for its red-stone walls of the east.

**Baile Mòr uaine** (Cuan ghlas). Founded 22 am Màrt, FE 982 by custodians of Cuan ghlas. Baile Mòr uaine is a walled city with a citadel in the north-eastern hills, founded in the Holy Age. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and is among their strongholds. Its walls were repaired in the Age of Strangers. Its forges are the chief armoury of the north-eastern hills. Known for its walls and its houses of the druid schools.

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17. the golden house, a waypoint inn

**Baile naomh** (Dùn ìseal). Founded 1 an Gearran, FE 319 by custodians of the holy wells. Baile naomh, the holy town, grew around wells in the vein country that the Holy Age custodians held sacred. The hot springs of Muileann ruadh lie to the west and the silver workings of Muileann chiar to the north-west. It is a small town of shrines and lodging houses, keeping the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for its holy wells of the vein country.

**Baile òg** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 7 an Dàmhair, LE 518 by stone-gatherers of the temple hills. A young town in the eastern hills close by the ruins of Làrach an Teampaill<sup>18</sup>, whose altar faces the vein. Its early houses were built of stones carried off the ruins, a use the elders of the Old Spirits later forbade. It keeps the Old Spirits and serves travellers who come to look at the ruins. Known for its houses of stone from Làrach an Teampaill.

**Baile òg** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 25 am Màrt, LE 110 by carters of Baile Mòr dhomhain. A small young town on the road between Baile Mòr dhomhain and Baile Mòr àrsaidh, grown from a carters' stable. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and lives by changing horses. Known for a carters' stop between two cities.

**Baile òg** (Baile ìseal). Founded 5 an t-Samhain, SE 4 by Tuathaich families sent north at the Severance. Baile òg, "the young town", was built by Tuathaich families who arrived after the Severance and found no empty village to take. It stands a short way from the larger Tuathaich town of Baile ìseal and has always leaned on it. Its houses are the first the Tuathaich built for themselves on the island rather than inherited. Known for the first Tuathaich-built houses.

**Baile òg** (Seann Chwen). Founded 6 an Dàmhair, AE 40 by a mining crew under the human administration. Baile òg, "the young town", was a camp of the diggings east of the capital, raised in the Age of Strangers near Cill ghlas. It emptied when Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>19</sup> closed the district for a generation. It was reopened after the Severance, and its people now follow the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its camp houses of the Cill ghlas diggings.

**Baile ruadh** (Seann Tarr). Founded 25 an t-Samhain, LE 72 by herders of Seann Tarr. Baile ruadh is a farm town near the eastern coast, founded in the long quiet centuries. Since the lighthouses were built its people have supplied the keepers of Taigh-solais Baile ìseal<sup>20</sup> on the coast beyond. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for its supplies for Taigh-solais Baile ìseal.

**Baile ruadh** (Baile ruadh). Founded 3 an Dàmhair, FE 971 by red-earth farmers of the east. A red town of the east and the seat of Siorrachd Baile ruadh. It keeps the Old Spirits and trades grain with Achadh naomh. Known for its red-earth fields of the east.

**Baile ruadh** (Cuan shean). Founded 9 am Màrt, LE 1,793 by red-clay potters of the Cuan shean country. A red town of potters and brick-makers behind the harbour of Cuan shean, whose kilns have fired the roof-tiles of the western coast since the centuries after the Sundering. It follows the order of Manannan, and its potters mark each jar with a small scorpion, the order's badge, under the base. Most of what it makes goes out through Cuan shean. Known for its red roof-tiles and scorpion-marked jars.

18. the temple ruin

19. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

20. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

**Baile ruadh** (Inis mhin). Founded 9 an t-Iuchar, FE 957 by Dia-thìrich farmers of the red ground. A red town in the north-west that stayed Dia-thìrich when the Tuathaich homeland was fixed around it, and the line of the border wall that was proposed and never built would have run past its gate. It keeps the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich, and its market is used by Tuathaich from Baile fhionn and Dia-thìrich from Àth uaine alike. Known for a shared market on the border.

**Baile shean** (Doire fhionn). Founded 5 an Dàmhair, FE 1,655 by keepers of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>21</sup>. An old town beside Coille Naomh Muileann chiar, the forest marked sacred before any faith claimed it. Its people have kept the forest's edge since the Holy Age and keep the Old Spirits, though the forest is now held by the druid schools. Known for the keepers of the sacred forest's edge.

**Baile shean** (Cnoc thais). Founded 27 an Cèitean, FE 557 by Dia-thìrich founders; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. An old Dia-thìrich town with walls and a citadel, emptied at the Severance and taken over by Tuathaich families. In the years before An Cogadh Fada<sup>22</sup> it was counted among the northern towns that refused dubhan. Its walls still stand, and the Tuathaich guard them as the Dia-thìrich once did. Known for its old walls held by the Tuathaich.

**Baile shean** (Inis chrom). Founded 18 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,185 by road-guards of Caol leathan. An old walled town of Òrd na Cloiche<sup>23</sup>, the order of the Stone, beside the fort of Muileann bheag. Its walls are older than the fort, and for most of its history it was the stronger of the two. It is small now, and lives on the fort's custom. Known for its old walls and its house of the Stone.

**Baile shean** (Caol iséal). Founded 13 an Dùbhlachd, FE 727 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the northern shore. Baile shean is an old quay on the northern shore and the port of its province. The inn An Taigh-seinnse Reòta lies inland on the road south, and its pickled spinach goes out through the quay. It is one of several places named Baile shean. Known for its old quay of the northern shore.

**Baile thais** (Muileann dhearg). Founded 5 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,086 by river-boatmen of the Abhainn uaine. Baile thais stands on the Abhainn uaine where the river leaves the hills for its run down to the gulf, and the river landing of Cidhe Beag lies just downstream. Boats have been launched here since the Holy Age to carry goods inland and coal down. It is a busy, unwalled town of boatmen and warehouses. Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich<sup>24</sup>, the southern sea-lane, ends at the landing of Cidhe Beag below the town. Known for the Cidhe Beag landing on the Abhainn uaine.

**Baile thais** (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 28 an Cèitean, FE 2,183 by Dia-thìrich eel-fishers of the water-meadows. Baile thais stands on damp ground where the meadows flood each wet season, and its people have always fished the ditches for eels. It is a large town now, and it supplies Cnoc bhàn with hay and fish. The river works that keep the meadows are older than the town's charter. Known for its water-meadows and eel traps.

**Baile uaine** (Àth shean). Founded 5 an Gearran, LE 1,132 by market gardeners of Àth shean. Baile uaine is a small town of market gardens, sending green stuff to Dùn gheal and on to the capital each market day. It has never been walled or fought over. Its people follow the capital's order, the order of Macha, and pay their dues at Dùn gheal. Known for its market gardens for the capital.

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21. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

22. the Long War

23. the order of the Stone

24. the southern sea-lane

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**Caol bheag** (Caol bheag). Founded 15 an Màrt, FE 477 by fishers of the north coast. A small harbour on the northern strait, whose name, the small strait, fits it better than it fits its far larger namesake inland. It keeps the Old Spirits and is a quiet fishing town, though An ceathramh rèisimeid<sup>1</sup>, stationed at the larger Caol bheag, sends its patrols here. It stands on Eilean fhada, the long island off the north coast, and the strait it is named for is the sound between that island and Dia-thìr. Known for the Caol bheag of the strait.

**Caol bheag** (Caol bheag). Founded 14 an Lùnastal, GE 2,414 by fishing households of the north coast. Caol bheag is a river port of more than forty thousand on the narrows of the Abhainn ghorm, crowned by a citadel and the seat of its province; its barges run down to Ros chiar at the river mouth. The fourth regiment, raised in the Long War, is stationed here. The mills of Muileann bheag and the wool of Cnoc chiar pass through its quays. Known for its river port, where the fourth regiment lies.

**Caol chrom** (Caol gharbh). Founded 13 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,275 by the garrison of the bent strait. Caol chrom is a fortified harbour on a bent strait of the north-east, walled and given a citadel in the long quiet centuries. It is a city by rank but small in people, and its garrison has always outnumbered its fishermen. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Its few townsmen boil soap and blow glass for the hill towns. Its headmen and Caol gharbh's meet at Coinneachadh na h-Amhaich<sup>2</sup>, the stone on the neck of land between the two harbours, to settle the dues of the strait. Known for its fortified bent strait.

**Caol dhomhain** (Ceann mhin). Founded 8 an Gearran, LE 1,229 by the watch of the deep strait. Caol dhomhain is a harbour village on a deep strait of the south-east, with a citadel raised in the long quiet centuries to watch it. The village is small, and it lives by the citadel. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for the deep strait's watch-tower.

**Caol fhiadhaich** (Inis thais). Founded 13 an t-Iuchar, LE 739 by fishers of the wild strait. Caol fhiadhaich is a harbour on a rough strait of the west coast, within the province of Inis thais. It was founded in the long quiet centuries by fishers who braved waters the older harbours avoided. Its people keep the Old Faith in the order of the Stone. Its women distil scent-waters, the town's second trade after the fishing. The southern sea-lane, Slighe-mhara Caol fhiadhaich<sup>3</sup>, is named for its fishers, who first sailed it round the south coast in the long quiet centuries. Known for its fishing in the wild strait.

**Caol fhiadhaich** (Caol fhiadhaich). Founded 12 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,547 by salmon-trappers of the south-west. A harbour on a wild strait whose pilots earned their living guiding ships through the rocks. It is the seat of Siorrachd Caol fhiadhaich and a large town of the order of the Stone, trading with the great tavern-village of Doire shean on its road. The strait pilots still take no ship through without an offering to Clach, the Stone, at the harbour wolf-stone. Known for its strait-pilots and the harbour wolf-stone.

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1. the fourth regiment  
2. the meeting at the neck  
3. the southern sea-lane



**Caol gharbh** (Caol gharbh). Founded 10 am Màrt, GE 4,128 by Dia-thìrich seafarers of the rough strait. Caol gharbh is a walled harbour on the rough strait and the seat of its province, a village in name but a town of twenty-seven thousand in fact. Its boatyards take oak from Doire chaol and build the heavy boats the strait demands. Its quarrel with Seann Bhrenn next door is as old as the rolls. Its headmen and Caol chrom's meet at Coinneachadh na h-Amhaich<sup>4</sup>, the stone on the neck of land between the two harbours, to settle the dues of the strait. Known for its boatyards on the rough strait.

**Caol iséal** (Caol iséal). Founded 21 am Màrt, FE 1,450 by salt-makers of the northern coast. Caol iséal is a harbour town on a low strait of the north coast and the seat of its province. Its salt pans have supplied the northern fisheries since the Holy Age. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Bog-iron dug behind the pans feeds its forges, which cast field-guns for the regiments. Known for its salt pans of the low strait.

**Caol iséal** (Baile Mòr mhòr). Founded 25 am Faoilleach, FE 1,428 by the strait-watchers of the north coast. A small harbour-village on the northern strait, with a citadel built to watch the channel. It served Baile Mòr mhòr as a signal-station and watch-post, and it has never been more. It keeps the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich, and the watch-fire on its citadel is still lit on the old feast nights. Known for the strait watch-fire.

**Caol leathan** (Caol leathan). Founded 12 am Faoilleach, GE 1,560 by seal-hunting households of the western shore. Caol leathan grew on the wide strait that gives it its name, where the western pilots of the Holy Age took a toll from every boat bound for the capital's waters. Its walls and citadel were raised in the Age of Sundering to hold the strait, and were manned again when the strangers' ships began to use it after the Crossing. It is the northern anchor of the country of the Stone, and its druids look south to the temple of Lia Fàil<sup>5</sup> at Inis thais for their rite. Known for its strait tolls and the western pilots' guild.

**Caol mhin** (Caol mhin). Founded 17 am Màrt, FE 1,345 by Dia-thìrich seafarers of Baile Mòr mhòr. Caol mhin is the harbour of Baile Mòr mhòr on the calm strait, and its fortunes have always followed the city's. It is walled against raiders from the sea. Its quays, which stand on Eilean chrom across the calm strait from the city, load wool and hides from the northern uplands. Known for its calm-strait harbour of Baile Mòr mhòr.

**Caol mhòr** (Caol mhòr). Founded 31 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,462 by Dia-thìrich harbour-folk; resettled by the Tuathaich. Caol mhòr, the great strait, was a Dia-thìreach harbour from the Age of Ailean. After the Severance it became the chief port of the Tuathaich, and it is now their largest town. Its yards take timber from Doire mhin, and its people keep the faith of the Church. Known for its place as the chief harbour of the Tuathaich.

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4. the meeting at the neck

5. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

**Caol naomh** (Caol mhòr). Founded 9 an Dàmhair, FE 2,043 by Dia-thìrich ferrymen; resettled by the Tuathaich. Caol naomh, the holy strait, is a harbour of the north-west founded by Dia-thìrich ferrymen in the Holy Age, who held the crossing sacred and blessed each boat before it put out. It was resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance, and the new ferrymen kept the blessing without the old words. It keeps the faith of the Church. Known for the holy strait's ferry.

**Caol naomh** (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 17 an Giblean, LE 481 by druids of Òrd Bhrìde<sup>6</sup>. A holy strait-harbour near the ruins of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>7</sup>, where the orthodox order of Bride's flame built a landing for pilgrims coming to the mountain of Crom's stone. It is one of the few towns where Òrd Bhrìde holds the majority, and its druids were among those who set down the order's rite in the first years of the new kingdom. It is a small town and quiet outside the pilgrim season. Pilgrims' boats from the southern Seann Skell come round to its landing by Slighe-mhara chritheanach, the shaking seaway, named for the swell off the south cape. Known for its pilgrim landing of Òrd Bhrìde.

**Caol ruadh** (Muileann naomh). Founded 14 an Giblean, GE 2,570 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the red strait. Caol ruadh takes its name from the red rock of the strait it watches on the southern coast. It was a quiet fishing town for most of its history, and was among the first to take up the orthodox rite of Bride's flame and Crom's stone when Òrd Bhrìde<sup>8</sup> was first ordered. Through An Cogadh Fada<sup>9</sup> its harbour victualled the garrisons and the fleet at Seann Skell close by, and after that war it was chartered for the purpose as the sixteenth market town. Known for its red strait and the orthodox rite of Bride's flame.

**Caol shean** (Caol shean). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, GE 4,196 by river households of the east. An old river port on the narrows of the Abhainn ìseal, above its meeting with the Abhainn chaol, and one of the great river ports of the island, seat of Siorrachd Caol shean. It sent the coal of the central mountains down the river to Seann Mhorn when the mountain was worked hardest, and now sends dubhan and grain the same way. The spring of Allt an Àigh<sup>10</sup> lies in its hinterland, and pilgrims to it come up the river and land here; the town follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for the great eastern river port, pilgrims' landing.

**Cathair dhearg** (Cathair dhearg). Founded 6 an Dàmhair, GE 18 by the holders of the Red Hill. Cathair dhearg, the red city, stands on the Red Hill, whose holders are named in the oldest king-lists; the old settlement shrank to a fishing town and grew again in the Holy Age where the mining roads came down to the water on the Abhainn dhomhain, just above Loch chrom, and Beathag Mhòr made it the seat of rule; Drochaid Cathair dhearg<sup>11</sup>, heir of the first bridges, still carries the road across the river. It kept its walls, citadel and temple through the Sundering and the Age of Strangers, and after the Severance Rìoghachd Dia-thìr<sup>12</sup> was declared here and Niall was crowned in it, first of the restored line. The royal precinct is small for a capital, ringed by the great harbours of Ros dhomhain, Cathair dhomhain and Baile ghlais, and its temple is the first house of Macha, where kings are made by her rite and the two horses of her rite, Liath Macha the grey and Dubh Sainglenn the black, are honoured. The royal quays build seagoing hulls for the Crown. Known for its royal seat and temple of Macha.

6. the order of Bride's flame

7. the watch-fort ruin

8. the order of Bride's flame

9. the Long War

10. the stream of the healing water

**Cathair dhomhain** (Cathair dhomhain). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 634 by carriers settled at the mouth of the western road. Cathair dhomhain, the deep city, stands beside the capital on the deep-water side of the river mouth, and takes the ships whose draught the royal quays cannot. It was walled and given a citadel in the Holy Age, and its temple of Macha is second only to the capital's. Its harbour carried much of the coal trade in the Age of Strangers and most of the dubhan trade since. It is the market town of the capital shore, and its own workshops bind books and put up salted food for the ships. Its quays stand where the Abhainn fhionn runs into Loch chrom, and the sea-going ships that lie at them come up from the west coast by the Abhainn gheal. Known for its deep-water harbour beside the capital.

**Cathair fhada** (Cathair fhada). Founded 13 an Cèitean, GE 2,523 by households of the south coast. A long walled city in the south, strung along a ridge between the capital's country and the coast, and the seat of Siorrachd Cathair fhada. It follows the order of Macha and has always been one of the capital's chief supports. The Fèill Muileann òg<sup>13</sup> is held a short way north, and the city's merchants rule it. Its market right is among the oldest on the island, and its own trade is in cheese, honey and garments. Known for its merchants of the Fèill Muileann òg.

**Cathair gheal** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 5 am Màrt, GE 1,378 by builders of the western coast; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. Cathair gheal is a walled city of white stone on the far western coast. It was a Dia-thìreach settlement until the human families of the northern concession made it their market town in the Age of Strangers, and it passed to their Tuathaich children at the Severance. Its walls face the sea, where pirate ships have been seen offshore. It is the market for the Tuathaich villages of Muileann àrsaidh province. Its smiths make the tools of the north-west. Known for its white walls against the pirate coast.

**Cathair mhòr** (Cathair mhòr). Founded 9 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,847 by Dia-thìrich households of the hills. Cathair mhòr, the great city, grew from households of the Age of Ailean who settled below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>14</sup>, a Seann-Dhaoine<sup>15</sup> outpost already in ruins, and it was walled in the Holy Age, the first walled town on the island. After the parting of the kingdom it was the seat of Eithne nic Ailein, the king's daughter, who held the lowland plain as one of the nine great shares and lived to swear the Peace of the Threshold. It commands the roads between the gulf and the vein country, and it was a counting-house of the tithe in the Age of Strangers and a mustering place in the war that ended it. An treas rèisimeid<sup>16</sup>, raised in An Cogadh Fada<sup>17</sup>, is stationed here and bears its name. Its honey and its salted meat are sold in every market of the south, and its soap-boilers and weavers are the busiest in the gulf. Known for the great city beside the old outpost.

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11. the bridge at Cathair dhearg

12. the Kingdom of Dia-thìr

13. the fair at Muileann òg

14. the watch-fort ruin

15. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

16. the third regiment

17. the Long War

**Cathair mhòr** (Doire mhin). Founded 28 an Cèitean, FE 2,147 by the lords of Doire mhin. A hill-city with a citadel close to the capital, raised by lords of the Doire mhin country who held the roads north of Cathair dhearg. It has always been a garrison town and was one of the strongholds from which the war before the Severance was fought. It follows the order of Macha and draws on the tithe-granaries of Baile chrom and the great village of Doire mhin. It is not the Cathair mhòr of the third regiment, which lies further east. Its glass-house is the largest on the island. Known for the citadel on the capital's north road.

**Cathair naomh** (Seann Toll). Founded 22 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,162 by unknown builders, later the Dia-thìrich keepers of the Old Spirits. The holy city of the north grew around a ring of stones older than the Dia-thìrich, and who raised them is not known. The Dia-thìrich made it a place of the Old Spirits in the Holy Age and it has never had walls, since the ancestors' ground was held to need none. It is a city of pilgrims and hostels, and the spirit-house keepers of Cnoc chiar and Inis bheag answer to its elders. Dubhan from the works below the town and books copied in its hostels are its trades; the elders have never blessed the works, since dubhan is not of the vein. Known for the un-walled ring of the ancestors.

**Cathair naomh** (Seann Chwen). Founded 1 an Gearran, FE 2,841 by wood-watchers of the western wood. A holy city near the ruins of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>18</sup>, built in the last years of the Holy Age as a seat of learning by the wood-watchers, whose rite became the order of Macha. The ruins are said to have been older than any Dia-thìreach memory when the city was founded, and the druids left them as they were. It is un-walled and trades with the harbour of Seann Chwen and with Ceann leathan. Known for the druids' city by the old outpost.

**Ceann àrsaidh** (Ceann àrsaidh). Founded 17 an t-Sultain, GE 4,328 by households from the Red Hill. Ceann àrsaidh is a walled river city on an ancient headland over the Abhainn fhionn, east of the capital. It has been a river port since the Holy Age, and its barges run down to Cathair dhomhain where the river runs into Loch chrom and the barges meet the ships that come up from the sea. An Taigh-seinnse Mòr stands on the road to the west. Known for its ancient headland on the capital's river road to the east.

**Ceann bhàn** (Achadh mhòr). Founded 29 an t-Samhain, LE 1,063 by the tavern-keepers of the white headland. A walled river port on a pale headland where the Abhainn gheal meets the Abhainn bhàn, with the famous tavern An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>19</sup> at its gate, where travellers eat dried venison. It grew around the tavern road, and its walls went up in the troubles, when the roadside houses became militia posts. It keeps the Old Spirits, trades with the great village of Achadh mhòr close by, and sends its goods down the Abhainn bhàn to Seann Warr on the coast. Known for An Sligeanach Fad' às and dried venison.

**Ceann bheag** (Ceann bheag). Founded 15 an t-Iuchar, FE 311 by Dia-thìrich harbour-folk of the north-east. Ceann bheag is a citadel harbour of the north-east, a Holy Age landing that grew with the coastal trade. Its citadel was raised in the Age of Strangers to guard the anchorage the human ships used. The villages of Ceann thais and Achadh fhiadhaich lie within its province and send their goods through its quays. Known for its citadel harbour of the north-east.

18. the watch-fort ruin

19. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

**Ceann chaol** (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 23 an Giblean, FE 145 by Dia-thìrich seafarers of the narrow point. Ceann chaol is a port city on the narrow point, and the old rival of Ceann mhin along the same shore. Its ships carry the flour of Muileann dhomhain and the grain of the eastern plain. The two harbours have disputed fishing grounds in every age, and the rolls of their disputes are long. Known for its narrow-point harbour, rival of Ceann mhin.

**Ceann chiar** (Seann Tarr). Founded 10 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,404 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the eastern coast. Ceann chiar is a walled harbour on the eastern coast, walled against the pirate ships that have been seen in these waters in every age. It keeps a watch-fire on its headland. It is the port of Seann Tarr province. Known for its walled harbour against pirates.

**Ceann dhomhain** (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 7 am Màrt, FE 1,742 by custodians of the eastern headland. A small city on a headland over a deep reach of the Abhainn naomh, with a citadel that looks down the river toward the sea and back toward the mountain roads. River boats put in here with the cargoes landed at Ceann mhin, at the river mouth, for the library town of Muileann chaol, and the library's scholars and copyists pass through its gate. Its quay-masters have long kept a copy of every cargo-list for the Leabharlann. The druid schools hold the city, and its scholars are counted among the library's oldest correspondents. Known for the library's river landing and cargo registers.

**Ceann dhubh** (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 25 an Cèitean, FE 1,742 by Dia-thìrich headland-fishers, resettled by the Tuathaich. A black headland harbour on the north-west coast, all but joined to the city of Inis àrsaidh. It was a Dia-thìreach fishing town until the Severance and has been a Tuathaich harbour since. It follows the faith of the Church, and its boats sail with Inis àrsaidh's. Known for the black headland beside Inis àrsaidh.

**Ceann dhubh** (Baile gharbh). Founded 26 an Cèitean, LE 1,359 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the black headland. Ceann dhubh is a harbour under a dark headland, the port of Baile gharbh province, whose boats work the cold waters of the northern coast. Travellers on the coast road break their journey at An Leòmhann Buidhe<sup>20</sup> a short way west, and the inn buys most of the harbour's catch. The harbour was deepened in the Age of Strangers to take the humans' coal ships, and has been too large for its trade ever since. Known for its harbour under the black headland.

**Ceann fhada** (Muileann chrom). Founded 27 an Cèitean, LE 1,359 by Dia-thìrich river pilots. A long spit of land made Ceann fhada a landing for river craft, and its pilots have guided boats on the Abhainn uaine for centuries. It is the old rival of Inis ìseal, a short way downstream, and the two quays have quarrelled over tolls in every age the rolls cover. It prospered in the Age of Strangers carrying coal-cart loads by water and has held its trade since by carrying grain. Known for its long quay and river pilots.

**Ceann gheal** (Cathair dhomhain). Founded 8 an Gearran, LE 1,328 by fishers of the white headland. Ceann gheal is a harbour town north of the capital, founded in the long quiet centuries. The shaft called Toll-dubh lies in the hills behind it. Quarrymen broke into it in the Age of Sundering and found a stair cut in the rock going down beyond their lamps, and the custodians walled it up; the town's people do not go near it. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its white headland and the Toll-dubh hollow.

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20. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

**Ceann ghorm** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 29 an Giblean, LE 395 by river pilots of the east. Ceann ghorm, the blue headland, is a river town on the Abhainn chaol in the east whose pilots have long guided boats up from Seann Mhorn on the coast to the landings of Seann Dunn and Ros fhionn. It was founded in the long quiet centuries and grew in the Age of Strangers. Its people follow the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its river pilots of the Abhainn chaol.

**Ceann leathan** (Seann Chwen). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, GE 2,061 by sailing households of the gulf. Ceann leathan, the broad headland, is a walled temple city on the gulf, older than most of the harbours around it. Its temple of Macha is the chief house of her order in the gulf towns. Since the early years of the restored kingdom it has held Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>21</sup>, the brutal annual melee, which draws fighters and crowds from every province. It is the market town of the gulf and the old vein country, fifty-two towns in all, and the dearest market on Dia-thìr. Its own trade is in cheese and salted food, and its yards build seagoing hulls. Known for Còmhrag Ceann leathan, the annual melee.

**Ceann leathan** (Ceann leathan). Founded 27 am Màrt, FE 1,810 by Dia-thìrich harbour-folk of the east. Ceann leathan of the east is a harbour town and the seat of its province, founded in the Holy Age on a broad headland facing the open sea. It is not the gulf city of the melee, and its people resent the confusion. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and a fishing fleet that works as far south as the waters off Seann Bhràl. Known for its broad headland harbour of the east.

**Ceann mhin** (Ceann mhin). Founded 18 an Lùnastal, FE 745 by shipwrights of the smooth headland. Ceann mhin is a citadel harbour on the southern gulf shore, long the chief shipyard of the east. When Tonn Mhòr struck in the first years of the restored kingdom, its yards were spared and it took in the survivors of Achadh mhin. It has since grown into one of the great cities of the south. The hemp for its yards grows in its own fields, and its copyists bind books for the south. Known for its shipyards of the smooth headland.

**Ceann mhin** (Ceann mhin). Founded 12 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,663 by harbour-lords of the smooth headland. A smooth headland port, walled, and the seat of Siorrachd Ceann mhin. It was a trading harbour for the northern mines in the Age of Strangers and follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Slighe Ceann mhin, the long road down the east of the island to Seann Dunn, begins at its gate. Known for the northern coal harbour.

**Ceann mhin** (Ceann mhin). Founded 26 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,028 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the south-eastern shore. Ceann mhin stands below Làrach an Dùin<sup>22</sup>, the ruined fortress of the old builders, and its harbour lies under the fallen walls. The Dia-thìrich fishers who settled there in the Age of Ailean would not go up to the ruin, and took no stone from it; who built the fortress is not known. It is now a walled port town of nearly twenty thousand, the seat of its province, and the rival of Ceann chaol along the same coast. Known for its harbour beneath Làrach an Dùin.

21. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

22. the fortress ruin

**Ceann mhòr** (Ceann mhòr). Founded 6 an Cèitean, FE 163 by Dia-thìrich fishers; resettled by the Tuathaich. Ceann mhòr is a great harbour on a headland of the north-west, under the beacon of Taigh-solais Baile chrom<sup>23</sup>. It was a Dia-thìreach port of the Holy Age, struck by Gorta Baile chrom<sup>24</sup> in the Age of Strangers and resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. It keeps the faith of the Church. Its first human fishing families learned the harbour prayers of Manannan's priests here, and those priests say the Grey Night vigil of Baile chrom began from them. It has been the market town of the north-west coast since the shires were drawn, and it sends fish, whale-oil, seal-oil, amber, dyes and tobacco south. Glass is blown from the white sand of its beaches. Known for its great headland harbour under the Baile chrom light.

**Ceann òg** (Cnoc bheag). Founded 19 an t-Sultain, AE 8 by Dia-thìrich and human traders together. Ceann òg, "the young headland", was built as a river trading quay on the Abhainn ìseal in the first years after the Crossing, when trade with the humans still ran both ways. It stands near Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>25</sup>, the stone carved Bha teine sa chloich. The Green Death, A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>26</sup>, struck it in the Age of Strangers. It follows the Hawk order, and its quay was rebuilt after the Severance for Dia-thìrich boats alone. Seòlaid Ceann òg, the western lane round the capes to the capital's water, is named for its quay. Known for its young river quay near Carragh Cnoc bheag.

**Ceann thais** (Ceann bheag). Founded 30 an Giblean, LE 334 by fishers of the north-east. Ceann thais is a harbour village of the north-east, best known for An Leòmhann Buidhe<sup>27</sup>, one of the great taverns of the old mining circuit, which stands at its edge. It was founded in the long quiet centuries. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for An Leòmhann Buidhe, the Yellow Lion.

**Cill àrsaidh** (Doire fhionn). Founded 19 an Giblean, FE 2,448 by keepers of the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Cill àrsaidh of the north is an old cell of the ancestor rite, founded in the Holy Age and never much more than a village around its shrine. It lies inland of the Hawk bay and has kept to the Old Spirits while its neighbours took up the Hawk order and the rite of Mòd. The shrine keepers are hereditary. Its people gather amber on the strands of the Hawk bay. Known for its ancient cell of the ancestor rite.

**Cill àrsaidh** (Cuan ghlas). Founded 29 an Cèitean, FE 673 by teachers of the druid schools. Cill àrsaidh of Cuan ghlas is an old cell that the teachers of Scoiltean nan Draoidhean<sup>28</sup>, the druid schools, took as a retreat early in the schools' history. It became a large village of students and farmers. Through the Age of Strangers the teachers of the schools lay quiet here and kept it alive, and it filled again at the revival. Known for its retreat of the druid teachers.

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23. the lighthouse at Baile chrom

24. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

25. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

26. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

27. the Yellow Lion, a waypoint inn

28. the druid schools

**Cill àrsaidh** (Muileann bheag). Founded 25 an t-Sultain, FE 2,924 by keepers of the Old Spirits. An ancient cell-site village in the north-east, older than the druid schools that now hold it. The founding shrine is said to have been of the Old Spirits, and its foundations lie under the present meeting-house. It is a large village supplying Muileann bheag. Known for a druids' house on an old shrine.

**Cill bhàn** (Dùn dhearg). Founded 20 am Màrt, FE 276 by keepers of the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Cill bhàn, the white cell, is a village of the Old Spirits' ancestor rite in the east, founded in the Holy Age. It lies near the hot springs and the silver workings of the vein country. It has kept its spirit-house through every age and every change of master. Known for its white cell of the ancestor rite.

**Cill chaol** (Muileann leathan). Founded 10 am Màrt, FE 2,014 by Dia-thìrich druids; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. Cill chaol was a narrow Dia-thìrich chapel village near the northern coast, emptied at the Severance and taken by Tuathaich families. They made its chapel a church of the Tuathaich, and the Dia-thìrich carvings on its doorposts were left in place beside theirs. It is a small place near the lighthouse of Muileann bheag. Known for a Tuathaich church in a Dia-thìreach chapel.

**Cill chìar** (Baile chìar). Founded 16 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,283 by druids of Macha. A small temple-site village at the edge of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>29</sup>, the forest no one has settled or wholly charted. Its temple-house was built to watch the forest rather than enter it. It follows the order of Macha. Known for the temple-house watching the unclaimed forest.

**Cill dhearg** (Doire chìar). Founded 7 an t-Samhain, FE 549 by druids of the schools. A temple village of red stone near Drochaid Ros fhionn, whose house of the druid schools gave shelter to travellers crossing the old bridge when the river trade was busy. As the trade failed and the bridge fell out of use, the village shrank to its temple-house and a few farms. Its druids still keep a lamp at the bridge-end. Known for its red temple-house by the old bridge.

**Cill dhìreach** (Dùn ìseal). Founded 6 am Màrt, FE 2,650 by druids of the schools for the silver-miners. A temple village a short way from the silver seam at Muileann chìar, whose house of the druid schools has served the silver-miners since the seam was first worked. In the Age of Strangers its druids kept a record of the miners killed underground, one of the few such records to survive. It is not the Cill dhìreach of the central country. Known for its miners' temple by the silver seam.

**Cill dhìreach** (Cill dhìreach). Founded 12 am Màrt, FE 2,599 by wood-watchers of the western wood. Cill dhìreach is a temple village of Macha of twenty-four thousand and the seat of its province. It lies beside Ceann leathan, where Còmhrag Ceann leathan<sup>30</sup> is held each year. Its druids tend the wounded of the melee and bury its dead. Known for its temple-town of the Ceann leathan melee.

**Cill fhada** (Muileann dhearg). Founded 17 an Dùbhlachd, LE 96 by wood-watchers of the western wood. A temple-site village strung along a long ridge near Baile chrom, whose temple of Macha is the longest building in the district. It farms for the market at Baile chrom and sends its grain to the tithe-granaries there. Known for the long temple of Macha.

29. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

30. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'



**Cill gharbh** (Muileann naomh). Founded 27 an Lùnastal, FE 1,926 by Dia-thìrich druids of the western coast. A village around a rough stone shrine on the far western coast of the Dia-thìrich country. Its shrine is older than any of its houses, and Manannan was worshipped there before the orders divided. It is a small village of fewer than two thousand. Known for its rough stone shrine of the west.

**Cill ghlas** (Muileann dhearg). Founded 4 am Faoilleach, FE 1,814 by a house of the druid schools. Cill ghlas, the grey cell, was a quiet village of the druid schools in the hills east of the capital until in the Age of Strangers the workings were driven under it. Late in that age a common cutting tore open a fault around the village; dozens were killed and the working was closed. From the Rending the island has the word 'scàinte'. The village was rebuilt on the far side of the crack, and its people still mark the day of the dead. Known for Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>31</sup>, the Rending.

**Cill ghorm** (Cathair dhomhain). Founded 13 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,633 by wood-watchers of the western wood. A temple site on the ridge above the road north from Cathair dhearg, fortified in the Holy Age to guard the approach to the capital. The citadel dwarfs the village, which has never numbered more than a thousand or so, most of them in the service of the garrison and the shrine. Pilgrims of Òrd Mhacha<sup>32</sup>, the order of Macha, stop here before entering the capital. Known for its fortified temple above the capital road.

**Cill iséal** (Ceann mhòr). Founded 14 an t-Iuchar, LE 935 by Dia-thìrich shrine-keepers, resettled by the Tuathaich. A low church-site village of the Dia-thìrich, emptied at the Severance and resettled by Tuathaich families. It has grown larger than any village, with its church at its heart, and it farms for the harbour of Ros ruadh. The Tuathaich here call it by its Dia-thìrich name and no other. Known for the church of the north-west.

**Cill leathan** (Muileann shean). Founded 27 am Màrt, FE 1,689 by keepers of the north-coast cell. Cill leathan is a large harbour village of the north coast, founded as a cell in the Holy Age. A citadel was raised over its harbour in the Age of Strangers to guard the human ships that used it. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its broad cell and its sea citadel.

**Cill thais** (Cill thais). Founded 15 an t-Samhain, FE 1,933 by wardens of the sacred wood. Cill thais, the damp cell, is a large village and the seat of its province, founded in the Holy Age beside Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>33</sup>. The forest is sacred to Macha and her black horse and has never been settled or felled, nor ever wholly charted, and the village's wardens keep others out of it under the division of custody that settled the holy-wood dispute. In the Age of Strangers the wardens refused the timber contracts, and how they were let refuse is not told. Known for its wardens of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag.

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31. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

32. the order of Macha

33. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

**Cill thais** (Cuan shean). Founded 22 an Giblean, FE 2,877 by watch-keepers of the western coast. Cill thais is a shrine village on damp ground above the anchorage of Cuan shean, fortified with a citadel in the Holy Age to watch the western sea. The fourth fleet, raised in the Long War, is stationed at Cuan shean below, and the village's druids bless each ship in Manannan's name before it first puts out. It is a small place whose citadel is larger than its village. Known for its fortified shrine of Manannan over the fleet anchorage.

**Cnoc àrsaidh** (Caol mhòr). Founded 19 am Màrt, FE 420 by Dia-thìrich shepherds; resettled by the Tuathaich. Cnoc àrsaidh is a small hill town of the Holy Age on the Abhainn mhòr, crowned by a cairn older than its name. Its Dia-thìrich families went south at the Severance and Tuathaich households took their holdings. It is a small place of hill pasture, looking down on the harbour of Caol mhòr. Known for its hill pasture and the old cairn.

**Cnoc àrsaidh** (Dùn ìseal). Founded 5 an t-Sultain, FE 777 by shepherds of the eastern hills. Cnoc àrsaidh of Dùn ìseal is a hill town crowned by old cairns, above Baile naomh. It has been a shepherding place since the Holy Age. Its people keep the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and tend the cairns at the turning of the seasons. Known for its cairn hill and its shepherds.

**Cnoc àrsaidh** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 20 an t-Iuchar, LE 410 by hill-farmers from Cnoc dhubh. The 'ancient hill' of the eastern cluster of Cnocs is in fact among the younger of them; it is thought that the name was taken from the old cairn on its summit, and not from the town. It is a small farming town of the druid schools that sells its barley in Cnoc dhubh and Àth dhomhain. Known for the summit cairn and eastern barley.

**Cnoc àrsaidh** (Caol mhòr). Founded 9 an t-Samhain, FE 2,013 by Dia-thìrich hill-lords, resettled by the Tuathaich. A tiny ancient hill with a citadel, far larger than the handful of people who now live in it. It was a Dia-thìreach keep until the Severance and has been a Tuathaich watch-post since. It follows the faith of the Church. Known for an empty citadel on the southern march.

**Cnoc àrsaidh** (Cnoc àrsaidh). Founded 11 am Màrt, GE 2,405 by households of the panther road. Cnoc àrsaidh is a walled town of Òrd na Cloiche<sup>34</sup> and the seat of its province, holding the oldest shrines of the order of the Stone. The panther roads pass close by, and the town keeps a watch on them in the season of crossing. Its walls were raised in the Age of Strangers and have not been needed since. Known for its shrines of the Stone and the panther watch.

**Cnoc bhàn** (Caol ìseal). Founded 21 am Màrt, LE 35 by fishers of Caol ìseal. Cnoc bhàn grew as an overflow of the harbour at Caol ìseal, a white hill with a landing at its foot. Its boats work the kelp beds and the herring of the northern shore. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and has never needed walls. Known for its white-hill kelp and herring.

**Cnoc bhàn** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 30 an Dùbhlachd, LE 62 by Dia-thìrich fishers; resettled by the Tuathaich. Cnoc bhàn of the north-west is a harbour facing the pirate waters. It was founded by Dia-thìrich fishers in the long quiet centuries and resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. Its boats avoid the waters where old sailors place the Sea-Watcher. Known for its harbour facing the pirate waters.

34. the order of the Stone

**Cnoc bhàn** (Ceann àrsaidh). Founded 5 an t-Samhain, LE 1,264 by druids of Macha. A pale hill in the midlands, crowned by a house of Òrd Mhacha<sup>35</sup>, the order of the capital. The town grew around the druids' farms and remains a quiet place of tithe-barns and schools that train acolytes for the capital's temples of Macha. Baile dhomhain and Àth ghlas send it their tithes and their sons. Known for its training of Macha's acolytes.

**Cnoc bhàn** (Caol mhòr). Founded 11 an Lùnastal, FE 1,193 by Dia-thìrich hill-lords, resettled by the Tuathaich. A pale hill with a citadel built by a Dia-thìreach family in the Holy Age, taken over by the Tuathaich when their homeland was fixed. The Tuathaich garrison it as a guard-post on their southern marches, and it follows the faith of the Church. The town sells cattle and hides to Cnoc àrsaidh. Known for the Tuathaich southern guard-post.

**Cnoc bhàn** (Baile ghorm). Founded 23 an Dùbhlachd, LE 250 by the hill-lords of Baile ghorm. A walled pale hill in the south-east above the long mill-race of Muileann fhada, which grinds its grain. The walls were raised when the road from Làrach an Dùin<sup>36</sup> became unsafe. It keeps the Old Spirits and is the market of the south-eastern farms. It sends the pearls of the south-eastern shallows and the clay of its fields to other markets. Known for the market above the mill-race.

**Cnoc bhàn** (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 12 am Màrt, FE 282 by a custodian house of the Binding. The white hill was fortified early by a custodian house, and its citadel of pale stone is the oldest standing work in the province that bears its name. In the Age of Strangers it served as a district seat of the human administration, and the ledgers kept in its strong-room were among those later lost in the war. It is now a large town of scholars and advocates: the disputations of the druid schools are held in its hall, and its readers walk daily to the library at Muileann chaol. Known for its white citadel and the druid schools' disputations.

**Cnoc bheag** (Cnoc bheag). Founded 5 an t-Sultain, GE 3,908 by hill kindreds of the north-central country. Cnoc bheag is the small hill only in name: it is the largest town of the north-central country, a river port on the Abhainn ìseal whose barges run down to Ros gheal on the coast, and the heart of the Hawk order of the Old Faith, whose temple here is the chief house of the Hawk of Acaill. The standing stone Carragh Cnoc bheag<sup>37</sup>, carved 'there was fire in the stone', stands a short walk to the south, and the town's older families say their fathers' fathers found it there. A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>38</sup>, the Green Death, struck the town in the Age of Strangers. Since the Severance it has faced the Tuathaich border, and An siathamh rèisimeid<sup>39</sup>, raised in An Cogadh Fada<sup>40</sup>, is stationed here under the town's name. Known for the carved stone and the sixth regiment.

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35. the order of Macha

36. the fortress ruin

37. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

38. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

39. the sixth regiment

40. the Long War

**Cnoc bheag** (Muileann shean). Founded 8 an Lùnastal, LE 779 by farmers of the north coast. Cnoc bheag of Muileann shean is a small town of hill farms on the north coast, founded in the long quiet centuries. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Its people send their sons to the druid teachers at Cill àrsaidh. Known for its north-coast hill farms.

**Cnoc bheag** (Achadh naomh). Founded 9 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,100 by the herders of Achadh naomh. A small walled hill in the east, raised as a refuge for the herds of Achadh naomh in the troubled years. Its pastures are thin, and the town has always kept fewer herds than its walls could shelter. It keeps the Old Spirits. Known for its hilltop refuge for eastern herds.

**Cnoc bheag** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 5 an Dàmhair, LE 1,027 by shepherds of Cnoc dhubh. A small hill town below Cnoc dhubh, holding the shepherds' market for the province. It has always lived in the shadow of the larger town. It is one of several places named Cnoc bheag and is not the fort of the holy wood near the capital. Known for its shepherds' market below Cnoc dhubh.

**Cnoc bheag** (Cill thais). Founded 8 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,453 by settlers from the Red Hill. Cnoc bheag is a fort with a citadel at the edge of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>41</sup>, the forest that has never been settled or felled. Settlers from the Red Hill first built here in the Age of Ailean, and the fort was raised after the holy-wood dispute of the Holy Age, when the keeping of the wood was divided and given whole to none, to house the custodians of the share that went to the order now called Òrd Mhacha<sup>42</sup>, the order of Macha. It stands outside the trees, never within them, and its twelve thousand people guard the capital's south as well as the wood. Known for its fort at the edge of the holy wood.

**Cnoc chaol** (Baile gharbh). Founded 16 an t-Ògmhios, LE 807 by goatherds of the northern hills. Cnoc chaol, the narrow hill, is a small herding town of the north. It is not the southern Cnoc chaol that gave Tonn Mhòr its name. Its people keep the druid schools of the Old Faith and send their cheese and kids to the market at Baile gharbh. Known for its goat cheese for Baile gharbh.

**Cnoc chaol** (Seann Vell). Founded 23 am Faoilleach, LE 167 by Dia-thìrich shore farmers of Seann Vell. Cnoc chaol is the town the Great Wave is named after. Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol<sup>43</sup> came on the southern coast without warning in a single night and laid it waste, with Cuan dhearg and Achadh mhin. The town was rebuilt higher up the narrow hill, and its people still leave the lowest street empty. Cnoc chaol and Cuan dhearg share Eilean bhàn, off the south coast. Known for the town the Great Wave named.

**Cnoc chaol** (Muileann dhearg). Founded 22 an Cèitean, GE 2,404 by hill-folk of the vein country. Cnoc chaol, on the narrow hill, was a hill settlement of the Age of Ailean, where one of the first copies of the keeper's stone cup was ground, and in the Age of Strangers it was a mining camp worked by the ton. It emptied after Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>44</sup> closed the district and never recovered. Fewer than seven hundred people live there now, among the spoil heaps. Known for a spent camp on the narrow hill.

**Cnoc chiar** (Seann Toll). Founded 12 an Giblean, FE 596 by spirit-house keepers of Cathair naomh. A dusky hill beside the harbour of Seann Toll, settled by keepers of the Old Spirits who tended waymarks on the pilgrim road to Cathair naomh. It remains a small town of hostels and way-shrines, busy in the feast seasons and empty between them. Known for its way-shrines on the pilgrim road.

41. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

42. the order of Macha

43. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

44. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

**Cnoc chiar** (Achadh naomh). Founded 24 an Lùnastal, FE 10 by keepers of the Colbh. A dusky hill near the standing stone Colbh Cnoc chiar<sup>45</sup>, which carries only the words Cuimh-nich an teine, 'remember the fire'. The stone was old when the town was founded, and the town grew around the families who tended it. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith, whose druids still come to argue over a bidding that no one has explained. Known for the stone of 'remember the fire'.

**Cnoc chiar** (Doire mhin). Founded 10 an t-Samhain, LE 1,603 by herders of Doire mhin. A small dusky hill between Doire mhin and Muileann ruadh, pastured by herders of the great village. It follows the order of Macha. Known for its hill pastures of Doire mhin.

**Cnoc chiar** (Cuan ghlas). Founded 24 am Faoilleach, FE 416 by Dia-thìrich shepherds of Cuan ghlas. A large town on the dusky hill, living on the sheep walks above it and on the wool trade with Caol bheag. It was a mustering place for fleeces in the Age of Strangers, when the humans bought wool as eagerly as coal. Its market is the busiest in the province. Known for its sheep walks and wool market.

**Cnoc chrom** (Cnoc mhòr). Founded 23 an Lùnastal, AE 144 by the coal-carriers of the interior. Cnoc chrom was built in the Age of Strangers as a depot on the coal road from the interior to the gulf. It was walled in the years before the war of the Severance, when the mining roads began to arm themselves. It is a small town now and keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its walled depot of the coal road.

**Cnoc chrom** (Caol shean). Founded 26 an Cèitean, AE 35 by Dia-thìrich miners under contract. A crooked hill-town raised when the diggings of the strangers' contracts spread out from the central mountains toward the coast. Its walls were thrown up against the raids of the troubles before the war, and the shafts beneath it gave out before the Severance. It is now a small town of the druid schools that sends its young to the river port at Ros fhionn. Known for the abandoned shafts beneath its walled hill.

**Cnoc dhearg** (Muileann naomh). Founded 31 an Lùnastal, LE 644 by potters of the west. Cnoc dhearg of Muileann naomh is a small town of the west, founded in the long quiet centuries on a hill of red clay. Its potteries supply jars and tiles to the western harbours, and the Age of Strangers brought it a brief trade in crucibles for the assayers. It keeps the order of Manannan. Known for its red-clay potteries of the west.

**Cnoc dhireach** (Cnoc leathan). Founded 18 an Dàmhair, LE 1,239 by tavern-keepers of the eastern road. A straight hill on the mining road in the south-east, home of An Taigh-òsta Gri-anach<sup>46</sup>, a famous roadside inn that serves pan-fried spinach with black wine. The inn was fortified as a militia post in the troubles before the Severance and took dubhan lamps with the rest of the tavern circuit. It keeps the Old Spirits and lies close by the ruins of Làrach an Dùin<sup>47</sup>. Known for An Taigh-òsta Grianach.

**Cnoc dhireach** (Caol fhiadhaich). Founded 4 am Màrt, LE 1,118 by carters of Caol fhiadhaich. A small town on a straight hill road between Caol fhiadhaich and the great mill-town of Muileann bheag. It follows the order of the Stone and is a stop for carters. Known for its carters' stop on the south-west road.

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45. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

46. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

47. the fortress ruin

**Cnoc dhìreach** (Ceann mhin). Founded 20 an Lùnastal, FE 22 by Dia-thìrich keepers of Tuam Cnoc dhìreach<sup>48</sup>. A small town on the Sìtheas beside Tuam Cnoc dhìreach, the necropolis whose oldest graves are older than its oldest legible names. Its families have kept the necropolis since the Holy Age, when the first burial there was written down. It lived on the burials of the eastern coast until the shire closed the old ground to new graves in the first years of the restored kingdom, and lives now on the masons who cut and mend the stones. Known for its keepers of Tuam Cnoc dhìreach.

**Cnoc dhìreach** (Cnoc dhìreach). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, FE 2,845 by weavers of the carriers' road. Cnoc dhìreach is the walled seat of the eastern mining district, a town of nearly nineteen thousand. It was walled in the Age of Strangers, when the strikes in the district made the administration uneasy. It is not the small town of the necropolis on the south-east coast. Known for its walled seat of the mining district.

**Cnoc dhubh** (Achadh àrsaidh). Founded 20 an Giblean, FE 2,263 by custodians of the capital's south. Cnoc dhubh of Achadh àrsaidh is a black hill with a citadel, south-east of the capital, founded in the Holy Age. Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag<sup>49</sup> lies to its west and the field of Muileann ghlas to its east. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its black-hill citadel south of the capital.

**Cnoc dhubh** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 10 an t-Iuchar, FE 93 by charcoal-burners of the black hill. A black hill where charcoal burners worked through the long centuries of the Sundering, the Small-Burning Law allowing them no more than a handful of the coloured coal. It is the largest of the cluster of Cnocs in the eastern hills and their common market. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith, and its charcoal is still sold to smiths who will not work with dubhan. Known for its charcoal for the smithies.

**Cnoc dhubh** (Tobar fhiadhaich). Founded 22 an t-Sultain, LE 1,517 by the peat-cutters of the northern moor. A black hill of peat in the north, cut for fuel since the Small-Burning Law held every hearth to its handful of the coloured coal and left the rest of its fire to turf. It is the road-town for Baile mhòr and Àth shean and follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. The peat-banks are now nearly as worked out as the vein. Known for its peat cut from the black hill.

**Cnoc dhubh** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 2 am Faoilleach, FE 265 by a custodian house that quarried the black hill. The black hill is an outcrop of dark stone that the early custodians hoped was the vein; it was not, and the quarry that tested it became a town. Cnoc dhubh is a walled market for the herders and quarrymen of the hills near Làrach an Teampail<sup>50</sup>; the seat of the shire is the other Cnoc dhubh, the charcoal-burners' town. Prospectors dug here again in the Age of Strangers and found only rock, which the town remembers with some satisfaction. Known for its black-stone quarries and walled market.

48. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

49. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

50. the temple ruin

**Cnoc dhubh** (Caol mhòr). Founded 5 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,722 by Dia-thìrich founders; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. Cnoc dhubh is a black hill with coal seams in its flank, first dug by the Dia-thìrich for building-stone and later by the humans for coal. The Tuathaich who resettled it kept the pits open. It was among the northern towns that refused dubhan, and its pits were the last in the north to close after the Long War. Known for the last coal pits of the north.

**Cnoc fhada** (Cnoc shean). Founded 18 am Màrt, LE 1,361 by hill-farmers of Cnoc shean. A long hill in the south-east farmed in terraces since the centuries after the Sundering. It keeps the Old Spirits and trades with Muileann dhomhain. Known for its terraced farms on the long hill.

**Cnoc fhiadhaich** (Ceann mhin). Founded 2 an t-Samhain, LE 1,808 by hunters of the north-east hills. A wild hill above Ceann mhin, settled by hunters and later by carters on the harbour road. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and sends game and hides down to the port. Known for its game and hides for Ceann mhin.

**Cnoc fhiadhaich** (Muileann chrom). Founded 17 am Màrt, LE 488 by hunters of the Muileann chrom country. A wild walled hill in the middle country, near the canoe-landing of Cidhe Beag on Abhainn uaine. Its walls were raised in the troubled years when the river road carried coal. It follows the order of Macha and trades with Muileann chrom and Inis iséal. Known for a walled hill by the river road.

**Cnoc fhionn** (Baile ruadh). Founded 25 an t-Samhain, VE 3,715 by hill households of the east. Cnoc fhionn, the fair hill, is a large town of sheltered farms in the north-east. It has been settled since the Ancient Age and keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Its barley and ale go down to the harbour at Seann Tarr. Known for its fair-hill barley and ale.

**Cnoc gharbh** (Ros gharbh). Founded 5 an Giblean, LE 1,014 by quarriers of Ros gharbh. Cnoc gharbh is a rough hill of quarries near Seann Bhral, whose walls were built of its stone. It is a town of nearly five thousand, of quarrymen and carters. The standing column at Cnoc ghorm is not of its stone, a fact its masons have checked more than once. Known for its quarries on the rough hill.

**Cnoc gheal** (Muileann shean). Founded 20 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,177 by watchmen of the north. Cnoc gheal is a white hill with a small citadel, raised as a watchtower in the long quiet centuries to give warning of ships on the northern coast. Its fire could be seen from Cill Ieathan and Àth fhionn, and the three kept a common watch. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith, and its garrison is now a handful of old soldiers and their families. Known for its white-hill watchtower of the north coast.

**Cnoc gheal** (Cnoc gheal). Founded 5 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,928 by hill-farmers of the north-east. A white hill in the north-east, seat of Siorrachd Cnoc gheal, looking down on the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>51</sup> harbour of Seann Bhrenn. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and is the market for Baile dhìreach and Àth dhearg. Known for the white hill market of the north-east.

**Cnoc gheal** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 16 an Cèitean, LE 555 by Dia-thìrich shepherds; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. A white hill of sheepfolds, Dia-thìrich until the Severance and Tuathaich since. The Dia-thìrich Cnoc gheal lies a short walk south-west, over the line. The two villages share a name and very little else: the one has its church, the other its shrine of Manannan. Known for its white hill sheepfolds on the line.

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51. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

**Cnoc gheal** (Muileann naomh). Founded 16 an Màrt, LE 784 by Dia-thìrich druids of the order of Manannan. The Dia-thìrich Cnoc gheal is a white hill with a shrine of Manannan mac Lir, twinned with Baile dhìreach. A second Cnoc gheal, held by the Tuathaich, lies a short walk north-east over the line. The two villages share a name and very little else, not even a faith. Known for its white hill shrine of Manannan.

**Cnoc ghlas** (Tobar fhiadhaich). Founded 3 an Cèitean, FE 2,596 by hill shepherds of the northern coast. Cnoc ghlas is a hill town of the northern coast, a sheepwalk settlement of the Holy Age that later opened quarries in the grey slate of its hill. Its slate roofs much of the province of Tobar fhiadhaich. Its people follow the druid schools of the Old Faith, and the town sent more than its share of students to the schools' revival. Known for its grey slate and northern sheepwalks.

**Cnoc ghlas** (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 13 an Cèitean, AE 22 by human settlers from an Tìr Thall<sup>52</sup>. Cnoc ghlas of Àth àrsaidh was settled by humans in the Age of Strangers and became a Tuathaich town after the Severance. It keeps the faith of the Church, and its singers are among the keepers of the voyage of Naomh Breandan. Known for its strangers' settlement on the grey hill.

**Cnoc ghlas** (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 12 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,275 by Dia-thìrich herders, resettled by the Tuathaich. A small green-grey hill town of the north-west, emptied and resettled at the Severance. It follows the faith of the Church and trades with the Dia-thìrich mill at Muileann chrom over the line. Known for its trade across the line at Muileann chrom.

**Cnoc ghlas** (Dùn dhearg). Founded 21 an Dùbhlachd, FE 8 by quarriers for Dùn dhearg. Cnoc ghlas is the grey hill whose stone built much of Dùn dhearg. It is a quarry town and lives by the city. Its quarrymen keep the Old Spirits' rites of the ancestors and will not open a new face without them. Known for its grey stone for Dùn dhearg.

**Cnoc ghorm** (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 15 an Dàmhair, GE 1,362 by farming households; resettled by the Tuathaich. Cnoc ghorm of the north-west is the inland seat of its province and one of the largest Tuathaich towns. It was a Dia-thìreach farm town from the Age of Ailean, resettled after the Severance. It is not the place of the stone Calbh Cnoc ghorm<sup>53</sup>, which lies far to the south-east. Its dye-fields and smithies are the busiest in the Tuathaich north. Known for its place as the inland seat of the Tuathaich.

**Cnoc ghorm** (Doire fhionn). Founded 22 an Dàmhair, FE 734 by bee-keepers of the north. Cnoc ghorm of Doire fhionn is a town of the north-central country, founded in the Holy Age. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and its bees, whose wax lit the shrines at Cill àrsaidh before dubhan lamps came. Known for its blue hill and bee-keeping.

**Cnoc ghorm** (Ceann àrsaidh). Founded 24 an t-Sultain, LE 1,191 by herders of Cathair mhòr. A blue-grey hill town just north of Cathair mhòr, pasturing the garrison's horses. It follows the order of Macha and has always been the city's stable. Known for its horse pastures of Cathair mhòr.

52. the land beyond, the humans' homeland

53. the column at Cnoc ghorm



**Cnoc ghorm** (Ceann mhin). Founded 30 am Faoilleach, FE 2,292 by Dia-thìrich keepers of Calbh Cnoc ghorm<sup>54</sup>. The blue hill grew up around Calbh Cnoc ghorm, the standing column carved with the doctrine itself: Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann. If the doctrine has a birthplace it may be here, and the town has never let the island forget it. It is a large town now, and pilgrims of all three faiths climb to the stone. Known for the doctrine stone.

**Cnoc ìseal** (Doire chiar). Founded 7 an t-Samhain, LE 1,261 by flax-growers of the north. Cnoc ìseal, the low hill, is a small town of the north-east given to flax and linen. It was founded in the long quiet centuries and has changed little since. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its flax fields and linen.

**Cnoc ìseal** (Doire mhin). Founded 31 an Cèitean, LE 43 by farmers of Doire mhin. Cnoc ìseal of Doire mhin is a small town of hill farms east of the capital, founded in the long quiet centuries. The field of Muileann ghlas, where An Cogadh Fada<sup>55</sup> ended, lies just to the west, and the town's barns sheltered the wounded after the battle. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its hill farms by Muileann ghlas field.

**Cnoc ìseal** (Baile chiar). Founded 4 an Dàmhair, LE 870 by the garrison of the capital's south road. Cnoc ìseal of Baile chiar is a walled hill on the capital's south road, founded in the long quiet centuries as a watch-post over the southern farms. Its walls were strengthened in the war of the Severance. It is a small town now. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha, and a toll it no longer collects. Known for its walled hill on the capital's south road.

**Cnoc ìseal** (Ros bheag). Founded 18 an Lùnastal, FE 2,606 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the west. A low harbour on the western coast, sheltered by Ros bheag, which it has always served as a lesser port. Its people follow the order of Manannan, the order that runs along the west. The fighting of the Long War at Àth leathan was near enough that the harbour carried supplies for the crown's regiments. Known for its western fishing and war-supply landing.

**Cnoc ìseal** (Caol shean). Founded 23 an Giblean, FE 1,825 by Dia-thìrich pilgrims to Allt an Àigh<sup>56</sup>. Cnoc ìseal began as a halt for pilgrims going down to Allt an Àigh, and its inns still fill at the phase of the moon when the stream is said to give fortune. Its nearness to Muileann chaol has drawn scholars as well, and many readers of the library lodge here. The town keeps the druid schools' habit of arguing a question before answering it. Known for its pilgrim lodgings on the Allt an Àigh road.

**Cnoc leathan** (Cnoc leathan). Founded 11 am Màrt, FE 172 by innkeepers of the south road. Cnoc leathan is a large town and the seat of its province, on the south road of the east. An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>57</sup>, one of the great inns of the old circuit, stands to its south. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Slighe Cnoc leathan, the road south past An Taigh-òsta Grianach, has been kept up by the inn's own toll since Anna Ruadh's charter. Known for An Taigh-òsta Grianach on the south road.

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54. the column at Cnoc ghorm

55. the Long War

56. the stream of the healing water

57. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

**Cnoc leathan** (Dùn chrom). Founded 12 an Dàmhair, LE 1,189 by Dia-thìrich herders of Dùn chrom. A modest town on the broad hill beside Muileann òg, whose people live for most of the year on herding and for one season on the fair. Since Fèill Muileann òg<sup>58</sup> became the island's greatest gathering, Cnoc leathan has lodged the traders the fair town cannot hold and stabled their animals. It stood near the lines at Muileann ghas and was emptied for the battle. Known for its lodgings and horse-lines for Fèill Muileann òg.

**Cnoc leathan** (Muileann leathan). Founded 9 an t-Samhain, AE 14 by the human administration, as a coast fort. Cnoc leathan was built by the human administration as a fort on the northern coast road, not far from the lighthouse at Muileann bheag. The Tuathaich have held it since the Severance and keep its citadel manned. Its small garrison follows the Tuathaich Church. Known for its Tuathaich-held fort on the north coast.

**Cnoc mhòr** (Cnoc mhòr). Founded 8 am Màrt, FE 1,210 by cattle-droves of the interior. Cnoc mhòr is the market hill on the Abhainn chiar below Cathair mhòr, where the interior drove roads meet. It was walled in the Age of Strangers, when the city's markets spilled out to it. It is a prosperous town. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha, and sells the gulf its beef. Known for its cattle market below Cathair mhòr.

**Cnoc mhòr** (Doire ghas). Founded 5 an t-Sultain, LE 1,233 by Dia-thìrich herders; resettled by the Tuathaich. Cnoc mhòr of Doire ghas is a Tuathaich town of the north coast, founded by Dia-thìrich herders in the long quiet centuries and resettled after the Severance. Its people supply the keepers of Taigh-solais Muileann bheag<sup>59</sup>. It keeps the faith of the Church. Known for its keepers of the Muileann bheag light.

**Cnoc mhòr** (Àth dhomhain). Founded 11 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,375 by hill-farmers of the Àth dhomhain country. The great hill above Baile gheal, farmed since the Holy Age and never walled, since Baile gheal's walls stand close below. The two towns share a market and a long quarrel over which is the elder. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its hill farms and its quarrel with Baile gheal.

**Cnoc mhòr** (Muileann bhàn). Founded 31 an Cèitean, LE 1,645 by hill-lords of Muileann bhàn. A great hill in the south, above the harbour of Seann Warr and the large mill town of Muileann bhàn. It keeps the Old Spirits, and its hill-farms supply both. Known for its hill-farms above Seann Warr.

**Cnoc naomh** (Cnoc naomh). Founded 10 an t-Samhain, GE 2,894 by households who came for the spring of the holy hill. A holy hill with a citadel south of the capital, the seat of Siorrachd Cnoc naomh and a house of the order of Macha since the Age of Sundering. It lies close by the battlefield of Muileann ghas, and its druids buried the dead of both sides after the Long War's last battle. It is a large town of druids, soldiers and pilgrims. Known for the druids who buried Muileann ghas's dead.

**Cnoc naomh** (Inis mhòr). Founded 29 an Cèitean, FE 1,142 by a custodian house of Inis mhòr. The holy hill carried a shrine before it carried a citadel; the citadel was added to guard Inis mhòr from the hills. The shrine still stands inside the walls. The fourth regiment from Caol bheag drills on the plain below it. On the moor above the town is Coinneachadh a' Mhonaidh<sup>60</sup>, the cairn where the crew-leaders of the northern pits fixed the week of their rising. Known for its citadel on the holy hill.

58. the fair at Muileann òg

59. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

60. the meeting on the moor road

**Cnoc òg** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 8 an Dùbhlachd, AE 81 by miners' families from Cnoc dhubh. The 'young hill' was settled by families spilling out of Cnoc dhubh when the great diggings drew workers to the eastern hills. It has little of its own beyond houses and a meeting-hall of the druid schools, and its people work in the fields and shops of its larger neighbour. Known for housing the overflow of Cnoc dhubh.

**Cnoc òg** (Dùn ìseal). Founded 7 an t-Iuchar, AE 80 by silver miners of Muileann chiar. A young hill-town with a citadel beside the silver mine of Muileann chiar, raised when the Dia-thìrich held the silver seam against the human claims. The citadel was built to guard the seam, and the town grew as the silver town grew. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for the citadel over the silver seam.

**Cnoc òg** (Àth shean). Founded 24 an Cèitean, LE 124 by farmers from Àth shean. A young hill town close to Muileann òg, whose fair is the largest gathering on the island. It lodges traders and their beasts during the fair and is quiet the rest of the year. It follows the order of Macha. Known for its lodgings for the Fèill Muileann òg<sup>61</sup>.

**Cnoc òg** (Muileann naomh). Founded 31 am Faoilleach, SE 2 by the restored kingdom, as a border post. Cnoc òg, "the young hill", was walled by the restored kingdom soon after the Severance, on the Dia-thìrich side of the line facing the Tuathaich towns to the north and west. It has never been more than a small town of soldiers' families and carters. In An Cogadh Fada<sup>62</sup> it lay a short march behind the field at Àth leathan, and its walls held the wounded after that first battle. Known for its border walls facing the Tuathaich.

**Cnoc òg** (Àth shean). Founded 17 an t-Sultain, AE 43 by suppliers to the garrison at Inis mhòr. Cnoc òg grew up in the Age of Strangers to supply the garrison at Inis mhòr, where the first regiment is now stationed. It is a town of bakers and harness-makers. It follows the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its supplies for the first regiment.

**Cnoc ruadh** (Cathair fhada). Founded 9 an Dàmhair, LE 1,619 by herders of the south road. Cnoc ruadh of Cathair fhada is a town on the south road, a hill only in name, founded in the long quiet centuries by herders who grazed the red ground there. It grew as a stopping place between the southern ford towns and the capital. Its people keep the capital's order, the order of Macha, and sell hides at the market of Àth shean. Known for its red pasture on the south road.

**Cnoc ruadh** (Achadh chaol). Founded 14 am Màrt, FE 37 by shepherds of the eastern uplands. Cnoc ruadh of Achadh chaol is a hill town of the eastern uplands, a sheep town since the Holy Age. Its wool goes down to Cuan ruadh for shipping. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for its red-hill sheepwalks and Cuan ruadh wool.

**Cnoc shean** (Doire fhiadhaich). Founded 6 an t-Sultain, FE 1,217 by Dia-thìrich herders of the south. Cnoc shean, the old hill, is a small town of the south, settled since the Holy Age. Its common holds the market of the farms around it. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its market common on the old hill.

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61. the fair at Muileann òg

62. the Long War

**Cnoc shean** (Inis chrom). Founded 19 an Dùbhlachd, FE 202 by the lords of the old hill. A small old hill-town with a citadel in the west, commanding the road between Baile Mòr fhionn and the harbours of the south-west. It follows the order of the Stone and has kept a garrison since the war before the Severance. Known for the old hill citadel.

**Cnoc shean** (Cnoc shean). Founded 18 am Màrt, FE 3 by Dia-thìrich traders of the eastern plain. Cnoc shean is the old hill market for the granary fields of Achadh mhòr, and the seat of its province. It is a town of more than twenty thousand, with grain-halls and a weighing-house older than any coinage on the island. The tavern An Sligeanach Fad' às<sup>63</sup> lies on the road to Achadh mhòr, and its dried deer is sold in Cnoc shean's market. Known for its old hill market of the granary fields.

**Cnoc thais** (Cuan ghlais). Founded 28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 84 by shepherds of the Cuan ghlais hills. A damp hill-town above the river port of Cuan ghlais, its name taken from the mists that sit on it most mornings. It was never walled and never fought over, and its people send wool and cheese down to the river quays and to Cnoc chiar. A small house of the druid schools keeps the only books in the place. Known for its mist, its wool and its hill cheese.

**Cnoc thais** (Cnoc thais). Founded 19 an t-Sultain, GE 4,328 by Dia-thìrich hill-farmers, resettled by the Tuathaich. A damp hill in the north-west, seat of Siorrachd Cnoc thais, and one of the larger Tuathaich towns since the Severance. It follows the faith of the Church and is the market of the two Muileann àrsaidhs. Known for the market of the two ancient mills.

**Cnoc thais** (Ceann mhin). Founded 3 an t-Iuchar, LE 536 by hill-farmers of the south-east. A damp hill above the small harbour of Caol dhomhain in the south-east. It keeps the Old Spirits and sends its cattle to Baile gheal. Known for its cattle on a misty hill.

**Cnoc thais** (Cnoc leathan). Founded 20 an Dùbhlachd, LE 274 by reed-cutters of Cnoc leathan. Cnoc thais is a damp hill whose reed-beds thatch the roofs of the eastern plain. It is a town of eleven thousand. Its cutters work the beds in the dry months and its thatchers travel in the wet. Known for its reed-cutters and thatch.

**Cnoc uaine** (Caol ìseal). Founded 17 an t-Ògmhios, LE 1,305 by the garrison of the north-coast road. Cnoc uaine of Caol ìseal is a hill fort over the north-coast road, raised in the long quiet centuries and walled since. Its garrison watched the road through the Age of Strangers. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for its hill fort over the north-coast road.

**Cnoc uaine** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 9 an Dàmhair, LE 938 by Dia-thìrich herders; resettled by the Tuathaich. Cnoc uaine of Muileann àrsaidh is a green hill of the north-west, founded by Dia-thìrich herders in the long quiet centuries. It was resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. It is a grazing town and keeps the faith of the Church. Known for its green hill grazing.

**Cnoc uaine** (Cnoc àrsaidh). Founded 31 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,155 by hill-lords of the south-west. A green walled hill in the south-west, fortified against pirates who raided the coast in the centuries after the Sundering. It follows the order of the Stone and sends its young to the first fleet at Àth gharbh. Known for the walled green hill.

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63. the far-off house, a waypoint inn

**Cnoc uaine** (Baile chaol). Founded 21 an Cèitean, FE 2,852 by Dia-thìrich keepers of the holy wood. Cnoc uaine is a green hill on the Abhainn mhin at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>64</sup>. It is a large town of nearly seventeen thousand, and its people share the keeping of the wood with Àth dhearg. It keeps the Old Spirits, though the wood itself is sacred to Flidais and held by the druid schools. Known for its green hill on the holy wood's edge.

**Cuan àrsaidh** (Achadh naomh). Founded 28 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,483 by the river-lords of the Abhainn iséal. An ancient river port a little below Cuan bheag on the Abhainn iséal, trading grain from the fields around Baile fhiadhaich since the Holy Age. The Green Death, A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>65</sup>, struck the town in the Age of Strangers. It follows the capital's order, the order of Macha. Its stone jetty is held to be the oldest on the island still in use, and it is patched each generation rather than rebuilt. Known for the island's oldest working jetty.

**Cuan bheag** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 1 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,554 by river traders of the northern country. Cuan bheag, the small harbour, is a river port on the upper Abhainn iséal. It was a fishing water until the Age of Strangers, when human traders wanted a sheltered mooring on this side of the island, with the river open to the sea at Ros gheal, and it grew busy. The restored kingdom built its citadel to watch the northern approaches, and the town has since become one of the larger river ports of the province. Its people keep the Old Faith in the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its sheltered river mooring and the northern watch.

**Cuan bheag** (Caol mhòr). Founded 10 am Màrt, SE 17 by Tuathaich fishing families. Cuan bheag of the north-west was built by Tuathaich fishing families in the first years after the Severance, on a shore the Dia-thìrich had never settled. It is a village of boats and drying racks. It sells its catch through Caol mhòr. Known for its Tuathaich fishing boats and drying racks.

**Cuan chrom** (Seann Vell). Founded 10 am Faoilleach, LE 1,231 by Dia-thìrich innkeepers of Seann Vell. Cuan chrom is a river town on a bend of the Abhainn fhionn, and An Taigh-seinnse Mòr, one of the great houses of the old tavern circuit, stands at its river quay. The tavern was a waypoint on the mining roads and doubled as a militia halt in the years before the war. It is known across the island for its steamed carp and green brandy. Known for An Taigh-seinnse Mòr and steamed carp.

**Cuan dhearg** (Muileann chrom). Founded 12 an Dàmhair, LE 1,789 by river fishers of the Abhainn uaine. Cuan dhearg is one of the ring of small river towns on the Abhainn uaine above Cathair mhòr, named for the red cliffs over its landing. It lives on the river fish and the short ferry runs between the river towns, and sends what it has for the sea down to Ceann leathan at the river mouth. It has never been walled. It is not the southern Cuan dhearg that Tonn Mhòr destroyed; the chroniclers have confused the two more than once. Its inn, An Cupa Dàna, is where Buidheann an t-Seabhaig Luaidhe<sup>66</sup>, the Leaden Hawk company, gathered in the second spring of the Severance war before walking to the Hawk coast. Known for its red-cliffed river landing and ferries.

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<sup>64</sup>. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

<sup>65</sup>. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

<sup>66</sup>. the Leaden Hawk company; lit. 'the company of the leaden hawk'

**Cuan dhearg** (Seann Vell). Founded 31 an t-Faoilleach, FE 1,384 by fishing clans of the southern shore. A red-cliffed harbour on the southern coast that was a fishing town for three ages. The Great Wave, Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol<sup>67</sup>, struck it in a single night in the first years of the new kingdom and destroyed the lower town with its fleet, and the harbour was rebuilt higher up the cliff. Its people keep the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich, and every house facing the sea keeps a lamp in the upper window. The harbour is on Eilean bhàn, the largest island off the south coast, which it shares with Cnoc chaol. Known for its rebuilding after the Great Wave.

**Cuan ghlas** (Cuan ghlas). Founded 15 an t-Ògmhios, FE 221 by grey-water fishers of the north-east. A grey river port on the Abhainn ghorm in the north-east with a citadel, the seat of Siorrachd Cuan ghlas, and a large village, whose barges go down to Ros chiar at the river mouth. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and is served by the hill town of Cnoc thais above it. Known for the grey river port and its citadel.

**Cuan ruadh** (Cuan ruadh). Founded 1 an t-Sultain, GE 2,387 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the east. Cuan ruadh is the easternmost harbour of the island and the seat of its province, a port since the Age of Ailean. Its boats go out further than any on the coast, and it has lost more to pirates than any other eastern town. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for the island's easternmost harbour.

**Cuan shean** (Cuan shean). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,755 by Dia-thìrich households who took up the old landing. The old harbour of the west, the seat of Siorrachd Cuan shean and one of the largest towns on the island. It shipped western grain and timber through the Holy Age and served the human traders after the Crossing. Since the Long War it has been home to An ceathramh cabhlach<sup>68</sup>, the fourth fleet. It follows the order of Manannan. Known for the fourth fleet's harbour.

**Cuan uaine** (Doire fhada). Founded 23 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,534 by Dia-thìrich custodians of the capital's east. Cuan uaine, whose name means the green harbour, is a walled temple city on the Abhainn fhionn east of the capital, fortified in the Holy Age to guard the river road to the eastern shore. Its temple of Macha is much visited by those who cannot reach the capital's. The barracks town of Inis mhòr lies just upriver to the north. Its copyists and tailors work for the capital. Known for the temple of Macha on the Abhainn fhionn.



**Doire bhàn** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 14 an t-Iuchar, LE 27 by the oak-cutters of Seann Dunn. A white oak grove between Seann Dunn and Seann Mhorn, cut for charcoal and ship-timber. It keeps the Old Spirits and is a large, quiet village with no walls. Known for its timber for the coast harbours.

**Doire bhàn** (Àth ghlas). Founded 7 an t-Sultain, LE 1,287 by Dia-thìrich woodwards of Àth ghlas. A small village in a copse of white-barked trees across the river from Àth ghlas, cutting firewood and poles for the town. It keeps clear of the ruin of Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>1</sup> to the east, as its elder neighbour does. It follows the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its white-barked copse by Àth ghlas.

67. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

68. the fourth fleet

1. the watch-fort ruin

**Doire bheag** (Muileann mhin). Founded 4 an t-Samhain, LE 1,560 by Dia-thìrich woodcutters of the capital. A small village in an oak copse north-east of Cathair dhearg, which has cut firewood and charcoal for the capital for as long as there are accounts. It has never grown past seven hundred people. Its people follow the capital's order, the order of Macha, and take their wood into the city on market days. Known for its firewood for the capital.

**Doire chaol** (Doire chaol). Founded 3 an Giblean, AE 17 by carters of the capital's road. Doire chaol was a carters' village outside the capital in the Age of Strangers, and after the Severance it was laid out anew on a narrow oak strip by the Abhainn dhomhain south of the capital, to house the families of the royal household. It grew into a large village, and in the kingdom's fourth decade it was cut out of the shire of Baile chiar as a shire of its own, the only shire made since the shires were first drawn. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for the capital's household village.

**Doire chaol** (Ceann mhòr). Founded 28 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,234 by Dia-thìrich charcoal-burners; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. A charcoal village in a narrow oakwood, resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. The newcomers made the Dia-thìrich shrine of Manannan they found there their church rather than raising their own, as several villages of this coast did. It still burns charcoal for the smiths of Àth fhionn and Àth dhearg. Known for its narrow oakwood and charcoal.

**Doire chaol** (Caol gharbh). Founded 22 an Lùnastal, LE 762 by woodwards for Caol gharbh's yards. A village in a narrow oakwood that has sent timber to the boatyards of Caol gharbh since the yards were opened. It has always been small and has always been owed money by the yards. Its families also hunt the oakwood, and their venison goes down to Caol gharbh with the timber. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its oak for Caol gharbh's boatyards.

**Doire chaol** (Baile àrsaidh). Founded 16 an t-Ògmhios, LE 123 by Dia-thìrich woodwards of Baile àrsaidh. A village in a narrow oakwood south of Baile àrsaidh, felling for the yards at Cuan shean as the larger Doire gharbh does. The two oakwood villages have argued over the same buyers in every age. It follows the order of Manannan. Known for its narrow oakwood of Baile àrsaidh.

**Doire chiar** (Doire chiar). Founded 8 an Giblean, GE 4,183 by oak-keepers of the north-east. A dusky oak grove grown into a large village, the seat of Siorrachd Doire chiar. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith, and its druids are said to hold their disputations under the oldest trees. Known for its disputations under the oaks.

**Doire dhearg** (Muileann bhàn). Founded 21 an t-Iuchar, AE 32 by Dia-thìrich miners bound by the strangers' contracts. Doire dhearg began as a mining camp in the Age of Strangers, when the interior was first worked by the ton. Its red spoil-heaps are still visible above the village. Many of its people left when the workings moved on, and the village that remains keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for its red spoil-heaps of the camp years.

**Doire dhìreach** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 1 an Dàmhair, FE 647 by Dia-thìrich woodwards of the Baile Mòr dhomhain plain. An oak grove kept by woodward families, whose trees grow tall and true beyond the common run. It is told of the Sundering that the shipwrights sent to Doire dhìreach for keels when the ocean ships were built, and the village has told that tale of itself ever since. It has grown into a large village of timber-yards and cooperages, serving Àth mhòr and Baile Mòr àrsaidh. Known for its straight-grown oak for keels.

**Doire dhubh** (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 26 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,523 by Dia-thìrich woodwards of Cnoc bhàn. A village in a dark oak grove a short way north of Muileann chaol. When the library was founded its oak was cut for the shelves and reading-tables, and the woodwards still claim a right to repair them. It sends its remaining timber to Cnoc bhàn and Baile thais. Known for its dark oak for the library's shelves.

**Doire fhada** (Baile ghlas). Founded 3 an t-Sultain, LE 360 by woodsmen of the capital shore. Doire fhada, the long grove, is a walled village on the shore of Loch chrom near the capital, founded in the long quiet centuries. It was walled in the Age of Strangers to protect its grain stores. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its walled long grove.

**Doire fhada** (Doire fhada). Founded 27 am Faoilleach, FE 2,013 by oak-cutters of the capital's forests. A long oak grove east of the capital cut for ship-timber since the Holy Age, and the shipwrights who built the Sundering fleet are said to have taken their keels here. The village grew enormous without changing its name, and it is now the seat of Siorrachd Doire fhada and a river port of the capital's order, Macha's, on the Abhainn fhionn. The grove itself is mostly gone, and the village keeps one old oak fenced by the river quay. Known for its ship-timber and the fenced oak.

**Doire fhiadhaich** (Ros dhomhain). Founded 18 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,506 by woodcutters of the wild oak wood. Doire fhiadhaich was a wild oak wood on the capital shore, and tradition holds that timber for the Sundering fleet was felled here. The wood is long gone and the village is now a fishing quarter between Ros dhomhain and the capital's harbours. It has kept its village rank and its own fishing rights. Known for its oaks said to have built the Sundering fleet.

**Doire fhiadhaich** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 13 an t-Samhain, FE 1,348 by custodians of Cnoc dhubh. Doire fhiadhaich of Cnoc dhubh is a village only by the old rank; it is large, and it has a citadel raised by the Holy Age custodians who held these hills. Làrach an Teampaill<sup>2</sup> lies in the hills to its east. Its people keep the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and will not cut the oaks nearest the ruin. Known for its citadel above Cnoc dhubh.

**Doire fhiadhaich** (Doire fhiadhaich). Founded 19 an Lùnastal, FE 1,981 by the oak-keepers of the south. A wild oak grove in the south, grown into a very large village and the seat of Siorrachd Doire fhiadhaich. It follows the order of Macha and supplies timber to the city of Cathair fhada close by. Known for its timber for Cathair fhada.

**Doire fhiadhaich** (Seann Tarr). Founded 11 am Màrt, LE 1,117 by Dia-thìrich woodwards of Seann Tarr. A village in a wild oakwood between Baile Mòr ruadh and the east coast. It lives on timber and on the boar hunts that the city's families come out for. It keeps the Old Spirits. Known for its wild oakwood and boar.

**Doire fhionn** (Caol shean). Founded 19 an Lùnastal, FE 669 by woodsmen of the eastern hills. Doire fhionn of Caol shean is an oak-grove village on the way to Allt an Àigh<sup>3</sup>. Pilgrims to the stream have lodged in its houses since the Holy Age, and the Library at Muileann chaol stands on the road to the north. Its people follow the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its oak grove on the pilgrims' way.

2. the temple ruin

3. the stream of the healing water



**Doire fhionn** (Doire fhionn). Founded 20 an Màrt, FE 397 by Dia-thìrich woodsmen of the east. Doire fhionn of the east is the seat of its province, a great village of the Holy Age in an oak grove; for all its size it has never been raised to the rank of a town. Its oaks are felled and planted under rules older than the kingdom. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits, and the old field-village of Achadh àrsaidh lies to its north. Known for its great oak grove of the east.

**Doire fhionn** (Doire fhionn). Founded 4 an t-Samhain, FE 1,149 by the oak-keepers of the Old Spirits. A fair oak grove in the north, the seat of Siorrachd Doire fhionn and a large village of the Old Spirits. The grove has never been cut for ship-timber, its keepers holding it for the ancestors, and it lies on the road between Cathair naomh and the Tuathaich line. Known for an uncut grove of the ancestors.

**Doire fhionn** (Doire ghlas). Founded 5 an Dàmhair, LE 482 by Dia-thìrich woodwards; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. A Dia-thìreach village in a grove of pale oaks, left empty at the Severance and resettled by Tuathaich families sent north. Its people keep the Tuathaich Church, and it is one of the northern households where the voyage of Naomh Breandan is still told at the hearth, a telling the Dia-thìrich druids call superstition. It lives on timber and on the fort at Cnoc leath-an nearby. Known for its pale oaks and Tuathaich hearth-tellings.

**Doire gharbh** (Cnoc dhìreach). Founded 5 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,269 by Dia-thìrich woodwards of Cnoc dhìreach. A large village in rough oak-wood below the Doire uaine hills, walled against the thing that the old inscriptions say walks in those hills. The rolls give a plainer reason: the walls went up in the Age of Strangers, when the strikes in the eastern district reached its gates. The warm springs of Muileann ruadh lie a short walk east. Known for its palisade under the Doire uaine hills.

**Doire gharbh** (Cuan shean). Founded 2 an Dàmhair, FE 1,695 by Dia-thìrich shipwrights' woodwards. A large walled village in rough oak-wood that has supplied timber to the yards at Cuan shean since the Holy Age. When the fleet of Cuan shean was raised in the Long War its hulls were cut here. It follows the order of Manannan, as does most of the west. Known for its rough oak for the western fleet.

**Doire gheal** (Baile ìseal). Founded 10 an Dàmhair, AE 65 by human settlers of the Age of Strangers. A small white oak grove settled by humans in the early years after the Crossing, one of the few human foundations of the north-west. Its people stayed through the Severance and are among the oldest human families on the island. It follows the faith of the Church. Known for its house of one of the oldest human families.

**Doire ghlas** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 14 an Gearran, FE 503 by woodsmen of Cnoc dhubh. Doire ghlas of Cnoc dhubh is a village of grey oaks near Làrach an Teampaill<sup>4</sup>. It was founded in the Holy Age, and its people have guided visitors to the ruin ever since. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for its grey oaks by Làrach an Teampaill.

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4. the temple ruin

**Doire ghlas** (Doire ghlas). Founded 26 an Giblean, GE 2,470 by Dia-thìrich oak-cutters, resettled by the Tuathaich. The grey oak grove of Doire ghlas is the grove of the Keeper. Here, the Line of the Mason tells, Coimhdeach na Fine<sup>5</sup>, the kin's keeper, came as a figure of grey smoke to Diarmad of that line and told him the making of the world and gave him the riddle of the coal; here Cormac of the Misstrike lit the coal of life with his own blood; and here Ailean son of Suibhne brought the six lit coals, saw the Keeper light the seventh, and after a vigil of seven nights was crowned by Caoran and the Tuath Dè. It was a small Dia-thìrich village in the grove until the Severance, when the families shepherded north were gathered here before being sent on, and so many stayed that it became the largest settlement in the Tuathaich homeland almost at once. It never took a town's name, and the Tuathaich keep it a village in speech on purpose. It is the seat of Siorrachd Doire ghlas and the heart of the Tuathaich Church, whose priests are said to hold the oldest copy of the voyage of Naomh Breandan here; the library has asked to copy it and been refused. The priests keep no telling of the Keeper, and the Old Faith's households that still come to walk under the oaks keep to the edge of the churchyard. Its wool mills, built with the Moot's money, make the grey twill of the north. Known for the great Tuathaich gathering-village.

**Doire ghorm** (Seann Skell). Founded 26 an t-Sultain, LE 1,794 by charcoal-burners of the south-east. Doire ghorm is a grove village of the south-east, founded by charcoal-burners in the long quiet centuries. Its charcoal once fed the smithies of the south coast. It keeps the orthodox rite of Bride's flame, like its neighbours. Known for its charcoal for the south-coast smithies.

**Doire mhin** (Caol mhòr). Founded 3 an Giblean, FE 2,743 by Dia-thìrich woodsmen of the Holy Age. An oak-grove village of the Holy Age, Doire mhin was emptied of its Dia-thìrich families in the years of the Severance and filled by Tuathaich households moved north. It is a large village for its kind, living on the smooth-barked oaks that name it. Its timber goes down to the yards of Caol mhòr, and its people keep the faith of the Church. Known for its oak timber for the Caol mhòr yards.

**Doire mhin** (Doire mhin). Founded 10 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,260 by the oak-keepers of the capital's north. A smooth-barked oak grove north of the capital, grown into one of the largest settlements on the island while keeping its village name and customs. It is the seat of Siorrachd Doire mhin and follows the order of Macha. Its people farm for Cathair mhòr and send much of their grain to the tithe-granaries at Baile chrom. Known for the great grove-village of the north road.

**Doire mhòr** (Muileann chrom). Founded 24 an Giblean, LE 568 by Dia-thìrich hill households above Muileann chrom. Doire mhòr, the great oak grove, was a hill village above Muileann chrom when the humans came, and the first settlement to refuse the Company's contract: its custodian Beathag Dhubh told the agent that the hill was not hers to sell. The Company turned its stream to wash coal, and at last took the village itself for a shaft beneath the hill, and its last households were carried out by constables. The beacon of the day the pits stopped was lit on its hill. The oak wood went long ago to pit-props, and a few families farm the clearing. Known for its refusal of the first contract.

5. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

**Doire mhòr** (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 24 an t-Sultain, FE 1,316 by Dia-thìrich woodwards; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. A great oakwood village, resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance and now one of the largest places they hold, with fourteen thousand people. It lives on timber and charcoal, and its charcoal fed the northern smithies when the coloured coal was no longer theirs to burn. It follows the faith of the Church. Known for its great oakwood and charcoal.

**Doire naomh** (Seann Skell). Founded 14 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,785 by Dia-thìrich druids of the west coast. A holy oak grove in the west near Àth leathan, where the Long War's first battle was fought. It stayed Dia-thìrich and kept the order of Manannan, and it buried many of the dead of that battle in its grove. The grove is closed to strangers. Known for its graves of the Àth leathan dead.

**Doire ruadh** (Inis bhàn). Founded 24 an Cèitean, LE 1,491 by hawk-keepers of the north. Doire ruadh is a village of red oaks inland of the Hawk bay, founded in the long quiet centuries by families who kept hawks for the rite of Mòd, the hungry hawk of Acaill. Its birds are still flown at the Hawk order's gatherings in Cnoc bheag. Since the Severance it has lain close to the Tuathaich border and has seen more soldiers than it wishes. Known for its red oak grove and hawk-keepers.

**Doire shean** (Doire shean). Founded 14 an Lùnastal, GE 695 by potters of the south-west coast. An old oak grove in the south-west, grown into one of the largest villages on the island and the seat of Siorrachd Doire shean. At its heart is Am Buabhall Fortanach, the most famous tavern on the old roads, which serves juggled buffalo and has stood since the Holy Age. It is a harbour as well, where the hulls of the first fleet of Àth gharbh lie, and follows the order of the Stone. Rathad na Banrighinn, Queen Catrìona's stone road from the capital to Inis thais, runs through the village past the tavern. Known for Am Buabhall Fortanach and juggled buffalo.

**Doire uaine** (Muileann chiar). Founded 13 an Gearran, FE 2,879 by herders of the Doire uaine hills. Doire uaine is a small village in the hills where inscriptions describe the Hollow Man, something that walked without breathing and attacked anyone who lit a fire in its sight. The village was founded in the Holy Age. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for the Hollow Man of the hills.

**Doire uaine** (Muileann bheag). Founded 16 an Lùnastal, FE 1,738 by the grove-keepers of the Old Spirits. A green oak grove in the north-east, not the Doire uaine of the Hollow Man's hills, a confusion the library records note with some weariness. It keeps the Old Spirits and cuts its oak for Muileann bheag. Known for its oak for Muileann bheag.

**Dùn chiar** (Achadh àrsaidh). Founded 2 an Cèitean, FE 862 by a custodian house guarding the capital's east. Dùn chiar is a hill fort of dusky stone east of Cathair dhearg, called a city for its rank rather than its people, who are few. Its citadel and walls were rebuilt in every age, and it has served as the eastern guard of the capital since the kings of the Holy Age. It follows the capital's order, the order of Macha, and its garrison takes part in the rites of Cathair dhearg. Known for its dusky hill fort east of the capital.

**Dùn chrom** (Dùn chrom). Founded 7 am Faoilleadh, GE 2,801 by the lords of the bent hill. A fortified city on a crooked hill in the midlands, seat of Siorrachd Dùn chrom, with a citadel that commands the roads south of the capital. The last battle of the Long War, at Muileann ghlas, was fought within sight of its citadel, and the crown's commanders used its citadel as their headquarters. It follows the order of Macha and is served by the stockyard town of Baile chrom and the ford at Àth mhin. Known for the citadel above Muileann ghlas.

**Dùn dhearg** (Dùn dhearg). Founded 9 an Gearran, GE 4,274 by households who owed nothing to Dùn ìseal. Dùn dhearg is the red hill-fort city of the east and the seat of its province, a city of more than twenty-five thousand. The mills of Muileann dhomhain grind its bread and the quarries of Cnoc ghlas built its houses. It keeps the Old Spirits, and its old fort is the site of the province's ancestor feasts. Ìomhar Dearth, son of Ailean Mòr, took it with the sword on the morning after the king fell at the ford below it, and held it as the Red Share, the one share of the kingdom never given at the parting. His line kept the share whole, and out of it came the first rìgh after Ailean. Known for its red hill-fort.

**Dùn dhubh** (Muileann bheag). Founded 26 an Cèitean, FE 1,182 by a custodian house of Muileann bheag. Dùn dhubh is a walled hill fort of dark stone, ranked a city though it holds under three thousand people. It commands the coast road above Muileann bheag and the harbour of Seann Toll. Its walls were raised in the Holy Age and repaired in every age after. A dubhan works stands under its walls, on the old charcoal-burners' ground. Known for its black fort over the coast road.

**Dùn fhiadhaich** (Cnoc naomh). Founded 20 an Giblean, FE 1,384 by the lords of the wild hill. A small wild city on a hill south of the capital, near Achadh mhin, which the Great Wave struck. Its hill kept it clear of the water, and it took in the survivors of the villages below. It follows the order of Macha. The clay of its hill makes it the largest pottery on Dia-thìr, and Cathair fhada sells its ware to the north. Known for its refuge from the Great Wave.

**Dùn gheal** (Àth shean). Founded 26 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,934 by a custodian house of the southern approach. The white fort is ranked a city though it holds only a few thousand people, a hill fort limed white so that it could be seen from the capital. It watched the southern road in the Holy Age and has done so since. It is now the market for Baile uaine and the farms of Àth shean. Known for its white-limed hill fort.

**Dùn ìseal** (Dùn ìseal). Founded 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1 by the hill-folk of the first Stone King. A low fort-city in the east with walls, a citadel and a temple, the seat of Siorrachd Dùn ìseal. It is the hill of the first kingdom: Ailean Mòr, crowned in the grove at Doire ghlas, came here and took the hill and the valleys about it, and threw up its first bank, and the Stone Kings held it under him. Its temple is the Hall where Bride's undying flame was first bound, kept by the Dia-thìrich custodians through every age; the townsfolk themselves keep the Old Spirits, and their ancestor hall beside it is the chief spirit-house of the eastern hills. It stands between the silver seam of Muileann chiar and the hot springs of Muileann ruadh, and it was held by the Dia-thìrich in the dispute over the silver. It is the market town of the eastern hills and plain, and the market under the Hall is older than the kingdom. The silver, gold and copper of its hills pass through it as blanks for the mint, and the town salts venison and binds books. After Ailean Mòr fell, his heirs gathered here to part his kingdom, and here they bound the vein to no one of the blood; the ground of the Hall was put in no share, and on the Hall's threshold the lords of the shares swore the Peace of the Threshold. Known for the Hall of Bride's flame.

**Dùn thais** (Ros bheag). Founded 23 an Gearran, FE 2,142 by custodians of the western hills. Dùn thais, the damp fort, is a hill stronghold above the western coast, held by custodians of the vein's western road since the Holy Age. Its walls were rebuilt in the Age of Strangers, when the western harbours began shipping coal, and its citadel has never stood empty since. In An Cogadh Fada<sup>6</sup> its garrison marched to the field of Àth leathan, a short road to the north-east. Known for its hill citadel of the western coast.

**Dùn thais** (Dùn thais). Founded 28 am Màrt, GE 2,473 by hill-folk pushing east. Dùn thais of the north-east is a great hill city with a citadel and a temple, the chief place of its province. It lies close to Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>7</sup>, and many of the Library's clerks and copyists live in it. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith, and its temple is sacred to Flidais, lady of the deer. Its tailors and smiths work for the library's clerks and the hill towns, and its own woods give timber. At the parting of the kingdom it fell on the line between the great share of the north and the Red Share of Dùn dhearg, and the first blood of the strife of the heirs was shed under its bank. Known for its place as the great hill city near the Library.

**Dùn thais** (Baile Mòr mhòr). Founded 10 an Dàmhair, FE 1,454 by custodians of the northern coast. Dùn thais of the north is the northernmost Dia-thìrich citadel, raised by the Holy Age custodians on the northern coast. Since the Severance it has watched the Tuathaich country. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for the northernmost Dia-thìrich citadel.

## I

**Inis àrsaidh** (Seann Skell). Founded 28 am Faoilleach, FE 76 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the west. Inis àrsaidh is an island town on the Abhainn naomh in the west, founded in the Holy Age; its ships put to sea from Ros àrsaidh at the river mouth. It was the nearest river port to the field of Àth leathan, and in An Cogadh Fada<sup>1</sup> it victualled the kingdom's host for the first battle. Its fairground is one of the two grounds where the travelling circus, An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn<sup>2</sup>, pitches. Known for its river port near the field of Àth leathan.

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6. the Long War

7. the Library at Muileann chaol

1. the Long War

2. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

**Inis àrsaidh** (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 28 an t-Sultain, FE 242 by Dia-thìrich island-lords, resettled by the Tuathaich. An ancient island city on the north-west coast, all but joined to Ceann dhubh. It was a Dia-thìreach harbour-city until the Severance and has been Tuathaich since. It follows the faith of the Church and is one of the few Tuathaich harbours with a fleet of its own. Known for the Tuathaich island harbour.

**Inis bhàn** (Inis bhàn). Founded 16 an Giblean, GE 3,916 by seal-taking households of the lower river. Inis bhàn is the great river port of the north-west Dia-thìrich country and the seat of its province, a town of nearly forty thousand on the Abhainn iséal whose barges run down to Ros gheal on the coast. It is a town of the Hawk order, and its shrines face down the river toward the sea. The Green Death, A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>3</sup>, struck it in the Age of Strangers. It is one of several towns that claim to have built ships for the fleet of the Sundering, which sailed from Seann Skell; no roll bears the claim out. Known for its white-island river port and Hawk-order shrines.

**Inis bheag** (Inis bheag). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,435 by boat-builders of the north-east. Inis bheag is an island town on the Abhainn bheag in the north-east and the seat of its province. Its boatyards have built fishing craft for the coast since the Holy Age and send them down the river to the sea at Caol chrom. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and shares its river with Ros fhionn of the old bridge. Known for its boatyards of the small isle.

**Inis bheag** (Seann Toll). Founded 4 an Dàmhair, FE 2,244 by the island-keepers of Seann Toll. A small walled harbour on a tidal islet of the north coast, near the holy city of Cathair naomh. It ferries pilgrims from the sea to the holy city and keeps the Old Spirits. Known for the pilgrims' ferry to Cathair naomh.

**Inis chrom** (Inis chrom). Founded 25 an Giblean, FE 1,601 by sailors of the south-west. Inis chrom is a large walled harbour on a bent island in the mouth of the Abhainn ghorm in the south-west. It has been a port since the Holy Age and its sailors keep the order of the Stone. It lies close to Am Buabhall Fortanach and Àth gharbh. Known for its bent isle harbour and its sailors of the Stone.

**Inis iséal** (Cnoc bheag). Founded 9 an t-Ògmhios, FE 2,060 by Dia-thìrich river-folk of the Abhainn iséal. Inis iséal is a low island in the Abhainn iséal above Cnoc bheag, fortified in the long quiet centuries to guard that town's river and walled again in the Age of Strangers. Since the Severance it has been a frontier fortress facing the Tuathaich border, supplied by boats that come up the river from Ros gheal. The Green Death, A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>4</sup>, struck its garrison in the Age of Strangers. It ranks as a city, but it is a barracks. The fortress keeps its own boatyard and weaving-sheds, and its cheese goes down the river to Ros gheal. Known for its island fortress guarding Cnoc bheag.

**Inis iséal** (Muileann chrom). Founded 12 an Giblean, LE 1,110 by Dia-thìrich river boatmen. Inis iséal is a river port on a low island in the Abhainn uaine, a short way from the landing at Cidhe Beag. It is the rival of Ceann fhada a short way upstream, and the two have disputed tolls in every age. It prospered in the Age of Strangers carrying coal and has kept its trade by carrying grain. Known for its river-island port on the Abhainn uaine.

3. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

4. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

**Inis leathan** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 29 an Giblean, LE 1,298 by ferrymen of the broad isle. Inis leathan is a village on a broad island in the lower Abhainn fhionn near the north coast, founded in the long quiet centuries by ferrymen who ran boats to either bank. In the Age of Strangers its ferry carried supplies to the tavern and mill at Muileann fhada. It still keeps the ferry, and little else. Known for its ferrymen of the broad isle.

**Inis mhin** (Inis mhin). Founded 5 an Lùnastal, FE 2,644 by Dia-thìrich harbour-folk; resettled by the Tuathaich. Inis mhin was a Dia-thìreach harbour of the Holy Age on a tidal islet of the north coast, and its citadel was raised in the Age of Strangers by human administrators guarding the northern landing. After the Severance it passed wholly to the Tuathaich, and it is now one of their chief ports. It is among the coastal towns where the voyage of Naomh Breandan is still told, and its church keeps the old Tuathaich telling more closely than the churches of its neighbours. In the second spring of the Severance war the Leaden Hawk company, Buidheann an t-Seabhaig Luaidhe<sup>5</sup>, lay twelve hours in the town and heard of the constables riding the western roads. Known for the telling of Naomh Breandan's voyage in its Tuathaich port.

**Inis mhin** (Achadh naomh). Founded 20 an Cèitean, GE 3,172 by fowlers of the eastern cliffs. A smooth low island joined to the shore by a causeway, walled, with a small harbour. The fowlers who settled it in the Age of Ailean became traders and then wall-builders, since the eastern waters were a haunt of pirates in the Age of Strangers. It keeps the Old Spirits and is the harbour for Àth chaol and Achadh naomh. Known for its causeway harbour and seal-oil.

**Inis mhòr** (Seann Vell). Founded 12 an t-Sultain, LE 730 by boatmen of Seann Vell. An island town on the Abhainn fhionn, settled in the long quiet centuries by boatmen from Seann Vell upriver, Inis mhòr was walled once the capital's eastern approaches became worth defending. A' chiad rèisimeid<sup>6</sup>, raised in the campaign of An Cogadh Fada<sup>7</sup>, is stationed here and bears the town's name. Its barracks are now larger than the old fishing quarter. The temple town of Cuan uaine can be seen a little way downriver, and what the town ships goes down the river to Cathair dhomhain. The white sand of its river banks goes to its glass-house. Known for its barracks of the first regiment.

**Inis mhòr** (Inis mhòr). Founded 16 an Dàmhair, GE 4,328 by net-fishers of the Abhainn ghorm. Inis mhòr of the north-east is the great river port of its province, on the Abhainn ghorm, a fishing town of the Age of Ailean that the trade of the Age of Strangers made a city; its barges run down the river to Ros chiar at the mouth. Its people follow the druid schools of the Old Faith, and the town's debating halls were among the first to reopen at the schools' revival. It shares the river and coastal trade with Ceann bheag and the walled town of Baile Mòr dhìreach inland. Known for its north-eastern river fleet and debating halls.

**Inis naomh** (Tobar ghorm). Founded 9 am Faoilleach, FE 2,521 by keepers of the holy isle. Inis naomh is a walled harbour on a holy tidal isle of the north coast, reached on foot at low water, founded in the Holy Age. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Its walls were built to keep the isle's shrine safe from raiders. Known for its holy isle and its walled landing.

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5. the Leaden Hawk company; lit. 'the company of the leaden hawk'

6. the first regiment

7. the Long War

**Inis thais** (Inis thais). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, GE 2,408 by Dia-thìrich fishing households of the western coast. Inis thais is a walled temple city of the south-west and the seat of its province. Its temple of Lia Fàil<sup>8</sup>, the stone called Clach that cries out under the rightful king, is the chief house of the order of the Stone, and pilgrims come to it from Caol leathan and the whole western coast. It has been a holy city since the Holy Age. Besides its pilgrims it lives on its shipyard, which builds seagoing hulls for the western coast, and on its cheese and books. Buidheann an t-Seabhaig Luaidhe<sup>9</sup>, the Leaden Hawk company sent by the council in the Severance war, ended its road at the temple here; the druids of Lia Fàil kept the city out of the war but shut its harbour to the Company's ships. Known for the temple of Lia Fàil and its pilgrims.

**Inis uaine** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 3 an t-Ògmhios, LE 980 by boatmen of the Abhainn chaol. Inis uaine is a river town on a green island in the Abhainn chaol in the east, founded in the long quiet centuries; its boats go down to the sea at Seann Mhorn. In An Cogadh Fada<sup>10</sup>, An t-ochdamh rèisimeid<sup>11</sup> was raised here to guard the eastern dubhan tanks and took the town's name, and the barracks have changed the town's trade from fish to soldiers' wants. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for its barracks of the eighth regiment.



**Muileann àrsaidh** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 10 an t-Iuchar, FE 2,444 by Dia-thìrich millers; resettled by the Tuathaich. Muileann àrsaidh, the ancient mill, is the younger of the two Muileann àrsaidh in the Tuathaich north-west, founded as a Dia-thìreach mill town in the Holy Age; the seat of the shire is the elder town close by. It was walled in the Age of Strangers and resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. The mill still grinds for the surrounding villages. Known for the old mill of the north-west.

**Muileann àrsaidh** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 3 an t-Samhain, GE 2,466 by Dia-thìrich millers, resettled by the Tuathaich. An ancient mill town of the north-west, and seat of Siorrachd Muileann àrsaidh, resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. A second Muileann àrsaidh lies close by, and the two are called the elder and the younger. It follows the faith of the Church. Known for the elder of the two ancient mills.

**Muileann àrsaidh** (Cnoc thais). Founded 20 an Giblean, LE 1,779 by Dia-thìrich millers, resettled by the Tuathaich. The younger of the two Muileann àrsaidhs, walled, a short distance from the elder. Gorta Baile chrom<sup>1</sup>, the Great Hunger, struck it in the Age of Strangers, and it was resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. It follows the faith of the Church. Known for the younger ancient mill.

8. the Stone that cries out under the rightful king

9. the Leaden Hawk company; lit. 'the company of the leaden hawk'

10. the Long War

11. the eighth regiment

1. the Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'



**Muileann àrsaidh** (Dùn thais). Founded 19 am Faoilleach, FE 1,670 by a custodian house of Dùn thais. Muileann àrsaidh is an ancient mill fortified with a citadel, a short way from Muileann chaol. The citadel guarded the road to the coal in the Holy Age and now guards the road to the library. It is a small place of fewer than two thousand. Known for its fortified ancient mill.

**Muileann bhàn** (Muileann bhàn). Founded 24 an Dàmhair, GE 2,378 by herders of the eastern plain. Muileann bhàn is a town of thirty-four thousand with a citadel, the seat of its province, standing where the coal road from the eastern diggings met the mills. In the Age of Strangers its citadel held the human administration's weighing-house and its guards. The mills have turned to grain since the Severance, and the Old Spirits, the old rite of the ancestors, which were never lost here, have come back to the square. Known for its white mills and citadel of the coal road.

**Muileann bheag** (Muileann bheag). Founded 23 an Giblean, FE 1,789 by grain-millers of the north-east. A small mill that grew into a sizable town and the seat of Siorrachd Muileann bheag. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and grinds for the harbour at Ros chiar. It shares its name with three others on the island, including the Tuathaich lighthouse town. Known for its flour for the north-east harbours.

**Muileann bheag** (Muileann leathan). Founded 14 an Giblean, LE 1,530 by Dia-thìrich millers, resettled by the Tuathaich. A small mill town on the north coast beside Taigh-solais Muileann bheag<sup>2</sup>, one of the five lighthouses built in the Age of Strangers. It became Tuathaich at the Severance, but the beacon was tended by the kingdom's Dia-thìrich keepers until it was converted to dubhan. It follows the Tuathaich Church. Known for Taigh-solais Muileann bheag.

**Muileann bheag** (Caol fhiadhaich). Founded 31 an Cèitean, LE 1,295 by wardens of the panther roads. Muileann bheag is a fort with a citadel north of Baile dhomhain, whose fields the panthers of Imrich nam Pantar<sup>3</sup> cross. It is not the Muileann bheag of the northern lighthouse. Travellers stop at Am Buabhall Fort-anach nearby, and the first fleet lies at Àth gharbh a short way west. Known for its citadel north of the panther roads.

**Muileann bheag** (Cuan ghlas). Founded 23 an t-Sultain, LE 728 by millers of Cuan ghlas. Muileann bheag is a mill town of fourteen thousand grinding for Inis mhòr and Caol bheag. Its mills are among the busiest in the north. It is one of several places named Muileann bheag, and not the fort above the panther roads nor the town of the northern lighthouse. Known for its mills for Inis mhòr and Caol bheag.

**Muileann chaol** (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 12 am Màrt, FE 2,570 by grain-millers of the Holy Age. The smaller of the two Muileann chaols, a narrow mill beside a small keep in the eastern hills. The great library stands in its namesake to the south-east, and the library's carriers are said still to bring misaddressed parcels here. It is a town of the druid schools, and its mill feeds the villages of Achadh gharbh and Tobar dhubh. Known for the library's misaddressed parcels.

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2. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

3. the panthers' crossing

**Muileann chaol** (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,218 by households of the hill. A narrow mill town in the eastern hills, and the home of Leabharlann Muileann chaol<sup>4</sup>, the library that keeps the fullest record of the island. The library was founded in the new kingdom and has since taken in the provincial archives, and its war archive is sealed. The town lives on the library and on the river landing at Ceann dhomhain, and to put a thing in the Library is to settle it. Paper has been made here since the Age of Sundering, and its copyists and binders work for the library. Known for Leabharlann Muileann chaol, the great library.

**Muileann chiar** (Achadh shean). Founded 10 an Gearran, FE 98 by keepers of the sacred forest. Muileann chiar of Achadh shean stands at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar<sup>5</sup>, the forest marked sacred before any faith claimed it. Its people were party to the holy-wood dispute of the Holy Age and have kept the forest's edge since. Tiormachd Achadh shean<sup>6</sup>, the Long Drought, struck it in the Age of Strangers. It is not the silver town of the same name. Its smiths make arms for the east coast. Known for its keepers of the sacred forest's edge.

**Muileann chiar** (Seann Bhral). Founded 10 an t-Iuchar, LE 239 by millers of the Seann Bhral country. A dusky mill town with a citadel in the south-east, not the silver town of the same name further north; the confusion of the two is an old grievance here. It grinds for Àth chiar and the harbour of Seann Bhral. It keeps the Old Spirits. Known for the other Muileann chiar.

**Muileann chiar** (Muileann chiar). Founded 23 an t-Iuchar, LE 365 by coal-breakers of the eastern diggings. Muileann chiar, seat of the province of the same name, began as a coal-breaking mill for the diggings in the hills east of the capital. It grew large in the Age of Strangers, when the district was worked by the ton, and lost its trade when Scàineadh Cill ghlais<sup>7</sup>, a short way west, closed the district for a generation. It is not the silver town of the same name further east, and the two are often confused in the older records. Known for its coal mills of the eastern district.

**Muileann chiar** (Dùn ìseal). Founded 10 an Lùnastal, FE 7 by Dia-thìrich custodians who found the silver seam. Muileann chiar was founded when a seam of silver was found near the great vein but not of it, the first wealth proved in the island's rock that was not the coloured coal. In the Age of Strangers the humans' concerns tried to claim the silver too, and the Dia-thìrich kept it; the town grew beside the coal workings as the call for both rose. It is smaller now than in its great years. Known for the island's silver seam.

**Muileann chrom** (Seann Skell). Founded 22 an Cèitean, LE 1,226 by Dia-thìrich millers of the Seann Skell country. A crooked mill on the edge of the north-west, left in Dia-thìrich hands when the Tuathaich homeland was fixed around it. It keeps the order of Manannan, whose sea-feasts its Tuathaich neighbours keep beside their church's, and its millers have ground for both peoples since the Severance. Cnoc ghlais and Àth àrsaidh over the line buy its flour. Known for a Dia-thìreach mill on the Tuathaich line.

4. the Library at Muileann chaol

5. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

6. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

7. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlais'

**Muileann chrom** (Muileann chrom). Founded 11 an Gearran, FE 1,556 by Dia-thìrich millers on the river bend. The mill on the bend of the river gave its name to the town and then to the province, of which it is the seat and the largest place. It ground grain for the whole central country and, in the Age of Strangers, for the camps east of it as well. It is a busy town and has never needed walls, standing between Cathair mhòr and Ceann leathan on the road that joins them. In the last years of the humans' rule the Company laid the coal line from its yards, and the railway ran from its pits by Cathair dhearg down to the quay at Ros dhomhain; the kingdom's Rail Board keeps its yards here still. Known for the great mill on the river bend.

**Muileann chrom** (Tobar fhiadhaich). Founded 27 an Gearran, LE 471 by millers of Tobar fhiadhaich. A mill town on the north coast, grinding for Tobar fhiadhaich and the upland farms behind it. It is one of several places named Muileann chrom and is not the great mill town of the central country. It is a quiet town of millers and inshore fishers. Known for its north-coast mill of Tobar fhiadhaich.

**Muileann dhearg** (Inis bheag). Founded 15 an Giblean, LE 1,566 by red-stone millers. A red mill town beside Muileann fhada in the north-east, the two together grinding for Doire chiar. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its red mill beside Muileann fhada.

**Muileann dhearg** (Muileann dhearg). Founded 2 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,179 by Dia-thìrich millers of the central country. The red mill is the seat of its province and one of the largest towns of the centre, standing between Seann Chwen and Cnoc ghorm. Its mills broke coal in the Age of Strangers and turned back to grain after the Severance. It is a town of the capital's order, the order of Macha, busy and unwallled. Known for its stamping mills turned to grain.

**Muileann dhearg** (Muileann chrom). Founded 26 an Gearran, LE 797 by millers of Muileann chrom. A walled mill town on the road north of Muileann chrom, one of three places named Muileann dhearg. It was walled in the Age of Strangers to protect its stores. It follows the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its walled red mill.

**Muileann dhearg** (Muileann dhearg). Founded 30 an t-Sultain, LE 2 by coal-breakers of the central diggings. Muileann dhearg, seat of its province, is a mill town a short way from Cill ghlas. Above it stood the vein-house, heir of the Keepers' Hall, where the custody-book was kept through the Age of Sundering. Scàineadh Cill ghlas<sup>8</sup> tore open the hills nearby and killed dozens, and the town's mills stood idle for a generation after. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its red mill beside Cill ghlas.

**Muileann dhìreach** (Achadh chaol). Founded 17 an Lùnastal, FE 1,432 by the custodian house of Achadh chaol. Muileann dhìreach was raised to grind the barley of Achadh chaol, and its mill-race still runs straight as a ruled line from the stream above the town. In the Age of Strangers it ground for the camps as well as for its own people, and the tithe clerks kept a counting-room beside the wheel. A reading-house of the druid schools stands on the square, and the miller's guild and the school have shared its bell time out of mind. Known for its grain mills on the straight race.

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8. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

**Muileann dhomhain** (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 8 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,747 by the millers of the deep race. A mill on a deep, fast race in the central country and the seat of Siorrachd Muileann dhomhain. It was a milling town for centuries and grew rich carrying grain to the mining settlements in the Age of Strangers, when the camps could no longer feed themselves. It keeps the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich, and its grain-exchange still sets the price of flour for the south-east. Known for the grain-exchange of the south-east.

**Muileann dhomhain** (Dùn ìseal). Founded 23 am Màrt, FE 2,637 by Dia-thìrich millers of Dùn ìseal. The deep mill takes its name from a mill-race cut far down into the rock to reach a steady flow. It grinds for Dùn dhearg and the villages around it and has done so since the Holy Age. The Old Spirits, the old rite of the ancestors, hold here, and each new millstone is blessed at the hearth before it is set. Known for its deep-cut mill-race.

**Muileann dhomhain** (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 9 an t-Samhain, FE 1,417 by Dia-thìrich millers of the south-east. Muileann dhomhain, seat of its province, is a town of twenty thousand built around deep mill-pools fed from the hills. Its flour goes down to the quays of Ceann chaol and out by sea, and the two towns have leaned on each other since the Holy Age. It is not the smaller Muileann dhomhain of Dùn ìseal to the north. Known for its deep mill-pools feeding Ceann chaol's ships.

**Muileann dhubh** (Achadh naomh). Founded 27 an Dùbhlachd, LE 1,019 by millers of Achadh naomh. The black mill stands on the northern road near Tobar ghorm, grinding for the villages of Achadh naomh province. Its wheel was darkened, the old telling says, by coal dust carried downstream from the mining roads. It is a small town and has always been one. Known for its black mill of the northern road.

**Muileann fhada** (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 8 an Dàmhair, FE 550 by millers of the northern mining road. Muileann fhada, the long mill, is a small walled town on the old mining road of the north. An Taigh-seinnse Reòta stands at its edge, one of the great taverns of the old circuit. Colbh Cnoc chiar<sup>9</sup> stands to the west, and the town's people say the stone's three words are older than any mill. Known for An Taigh-seinnse Reòta on the mining road.

**Muileann fhada** (Baile ghorm). Founded 16 an t-Samhain, LE 617 by millers of the house of Tormod mac Ruairidh. A long mill-race cut beside a south-eastern stream gave the town its name and its living, grinding the grain of the farms about the other Baile ghorm. Its walls were raised in the Age of Strangers, when the roads past Làrach an Dùin<sup>10</sup> carried coal-wagons and the thieves who followed them. It keeps the Old Spirits, and the millers still leave the first sack of each season at the race-head for the ancestors. Cnoc bhàn on the hill above buys most of its flour. Known for the long mill-race and first-sack offering.

**Muileann fhada** (Doire chiar). Founded 10 am Màrt, LE 785 by millers of Doire chiar. A long mill in the north-east beside Muileann dhearg, grinding for the large village of Doire chiar. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its flour for Doire chiar.

9. the pillar at Cnoc chiar

10. the fortress ruin

**Muileann fhada** (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 21 an Giblean, FE 1,240 by millers of the Ros fhionn river. A long mill-house on the Ros fhionn gave the place its name, and a river quay below it made it a port, sending flour downstream by barge. Its walls date from the Age of Strangers, when a tithe store was kept here and needed guarding. The river trade failed when the carts took the traffic, and the crossing of Drochaid Ros fhionn just upstream is now rarely used; the town has shrunk to its walls. Known for a river port gone quiet.

**Muileann fhionn** (Caol mhòr). Founded 12 an t-Iuchar, AE 23 by human administrators of the northern landing. Muileann fhionn was built as a fort and mill by human administrators in the Age of Strangers, to guard the northern landing. After the Severance it became a Tuathaich town. It keeps the faith of the Church, and it has since been the market town of the north-western interior and the greatest cattle-market on Dia-thìr. Its own trade is in paper and books. Known for its strangers' fort of the north.

**Muileann fhionn** (Seann Chwen). Founded 1 an Cèitean, LE 1,404 by millers of the Ceann leathan country. A fair-stoned walled mill town between Ceann leathan and Cuan dhearg, grinding grain landed at Ceann leathan's harbour and Cuan dhearg's river landing. Its walls went up in the Age of Strangers. It follows the order of Macha. Known for its grain milled for two landings.

**Muileann gharbh** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 12 am Màrt, AE 33 by a human coal concern. Muileann gharbh, the rough mill, was built in the Age of Strangers to break coal on the road down to the eastern harbours. When the mountain was worked day and night the mill never stopped, and the town grew no larger than the mill needed. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith, whose teachers found many hearers among the mill hands. Known for its rough mill of the coal road.

**Muileann gheal** (Dùn dhearg). Founded 7 an Dàmhair, LE 1,082 by white-stone millers. A white stone mill in the south-east that grinds for the city of Dùn dhearg. It keeps the Old Spirits and is a large mill-town with a guild of millers older than the city's walls. Known for its flour for Dùn dhearg.

**Muileann gheal** (Muileann chlar). Founded 20 an Lùnastal, FE 2,347 by mountain households of the carriers' country. Above Muileann gheal rises Binnean a' Chlachair<sup>11</sup>, the Mason's Point, the highest ground of Dia-thìr, from which Fearghas of the Mason's line let the six unlit coals fall and saw the snowflake coal take fire in the air; the herders of the town leave a stone on its top when they pass. Muileann gheal was a mountain settlement of the Holy Age whose common granary was opened in the poor season, and in the Age of Strangers it was walled as a mill-camp under the Doire uaine hills to break coal from the eastern diggings. It is small, fewer than seven hundred people. The warm springs of Muileann ruadh lie a short walk away, and the camp's miners bathed there. Known for its walled mill-camp under Doire uaine.

**Muileann ghlas** (Dùn chrom). Founded 16 an t-Samhain, FE 748 by Dia-thìrich millers of Dùn chrom. The grey mill is an old grain town near the fair at Muileann òg and within a day of the capital. It is remembered above all for the Battle of Muileann ghlas, the second and last great battle of An Cogadh Fada<sup>12</sup>, fought on its fields, in which the Tuathaich holdouts were broken. The battlefield, Àraich Muileann ghlas<sup>13</sup>, lies just north-west of the town. Known for the last battle of the Long War.

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11. the Mason's Point, the island's highest summit

**Muileann leathan** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 23 an Lùnastal, SE 13 by Tuathaich millers. Muileann leathan of the north-west was built by Tuathaich settlers soon after the Severance to grind grain for the northern villages, which had lost the Dia-thìrich mills to the south. It is a small town, and its mill-race was dug by hand by the first households. It keeps the faith of the Church. Amber washed up on the nearby shore is its other trade. Known for its Tuathaich grain mill.

**Muileann leathan** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 15 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,746 by the millers of the wide stream. A broad mill on a slow river, old enough that its founding is recorded only in the king-lists of the Holy Age. It grinds for the coast-town of Seann Mhorn and for the villages round Àth àrsaidh, and its people keep the Old Spirits. The temple ruins of Làrach an Team-paill<sup>14</sup> lie in the hills behind it, and the millers will not quarry them. Known for its wide mill-wheels and grain for Seann Mhorn.

**Muileann leathan** (Muileann leathan). Founded 24 an Giblean, GE 1,610 by weaving households of the north; resettled by the Tuathaich. A wide mill on a northern stream, walled with a citadel, and the seat of Siorrachd Muileann leathan. It was a Dia-thìreach town until the Severance, when the Tuathaich took it over as one of the principal towns of their homeland. It is a centre of the Tuathaich Church, and its keep is where the Tuathaich northern coast is governed. Known for the Tuathaich mill-citadel.

**Muileann leathan** (Ceann mhin). Founded 16 an Dàmhair, LE 1,423 by millers of Ceann mhin. A walled mill town a short way inland from Ceann mhin, whose broad mill-pool is the largest on that coast. It was walled when Ceann mhin was, in the Age of Strangers, to protect its stores. Its flour goes to the ships at Ceann mhin and never to the rival quays of Ceann chaol. Known for its broad mill serving Ceann mhin.

**Muileann mhin** (Baile fhiadhaich). Founded 18 an Gearran, LE 1,599 by millers of the west. Muileann mhin of Baile fhiadhaich is a mill town of the west, founded in the long quiet centuries on a stream that turns smooth stones. It grinds for the harbour at Baile fhiadhaich. It keeps the order of Manannan, and its millers are known for honest measures. Known for its smooth-stone mill of the west.

**Muileann mhin** (Muileann mhin). Founded 20 an t-Iuchar, FE 1,458 by millers of the capital country. Muileann mhin is a large river town on the Abhainn fhionn east of the capital and the seat of its province. Its flour mills have fed the capital since the Holy Age. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha, and ships its flour down the river to Cathair dhomhain and along the shore to Cathair dhearg and Ros dhomhain. Known for the capital's flour mills.

**Muileann mhin** (Tobar ghorm). Founded 8 an t-Iuchar, LE 656 by millers of Tobar ghorm. Muileann mhin grinds the fine flour of Tobar ghorm, a short way east, and has risen and fallen with the larger village's harvests in every age. Its wheels are the oldest still turning in the province, and the miller families keep a roll of their masters going back to the Age of Sundering. In fair season the carts from the wool fairs come back loaded with its flour. Known for its fine flour for Tobar ghorm.

12. the Long War

13. the battlefield of Muileann ghlas

14. the temple ruin

**Muileann naomh** (Muileann naomh). Founded 4 an t-Ògmhios, FE 599 by Dia-thìrich millers of the west coast. A holy mill in the west, the seat of Siorrachd Muileann naomh, whose wheel is said to have been consecrated to Manannan mac Lir. It lies near the Àth leathan battlefield and was taken over by crown regiments in the Long War. It follows the order of Manannan. Known for the consecrated mill-wheel.

**Muileann naomh** (Muileann naomh). Founded 24 am Faoilleach, GE 2,986 by Dia-thìrich households of the south coast. A holy mill in the south, the seat of Siorrachd Muileann naomh, whose druids of the orthodox order of Bride's flame bless the grain before it is ground. It is one of the few towns of Òrd Bhride<sup>15</sup> and trades with Caol ruadh and Seann Skell. Its hawk-house was the southernmost of Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>16</sup>, the first on Dia-thìr to hang a bronze bell, until it took Òrd Bhride's written order in the first years of the restored kingdom; the bell now rings for Brìde's flame. Known for its grain blessed by the druids of Bride's flame.

**Muileann òg** (Dùn chrom). Founded 10 am Faoilleach, FE 905 by carriers of the western road. Muileann òg, the young mill, stood beside the old ford-ground of the gathering in the Holy Age; it was burned in the War of the Roads and rebuilt as a market town. Its annual fair, Fèill Muileann òg<sup>17</sup>, became the island's largest gathering. The field of Muileann ghlas, where An Cogadh Fada<sup>18</sup> ended, lies close by. Rathad na Fèille, the fair road, was metalled from Cathair dhearg in the fair's first years. Known for Fèill Muileann òg, the great fair.

**Muileann ruadh** (Doire fhionn). Founded 29 an Giblean, FE 1,583 by Dia-thìrich millers of the north. Muileann ruadh of Doire fhionn is a mill town of the north-central country, founded in the Holy Age. Its citadel was raised after the Severance to watch the Tuathaich border. It keeps the Hawk order of the Old Faith. Known for its red mill and border citadel.

**Muileann ruadh** (Cnoc naomh). Founded 14 an Lùnastal, LE 1,385 by red-sandstone millers. A small mill-town built of red sandstone, grinding for Baile chrom and the village of Cill fhada. It was never walled, relying on Baile chrom's walls in hard times. Its people keep the order of Macha, and the mill-house has a small shrine to Macha's black horse above the wheel. Known for its red sandstone mill-house.

**Muileann ruadh** (Dùn ìseal). Founded 11 an t-Ògmhios, FE 405 by keepers of the hot springs. A red walled mill town beside Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh<sup>19</sup>, the hot springs whose warm water drives its wheel through winter. The keepers of the Old Spirits held the springs sacred, and the healers of the Old Faith call them Dian Cècht's. The town walled them against the claims of the human administration. It is a place for the sick and the old to bathe. Known for the hot springs of Muileann ruadh.

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15. the order of Bride's flame

16. the Hawk order

17. the fair at Muileann òg

18. the Long War

19. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

**Muileann ruadh** (Cnoc leathan). Founded 15 am Faoilleach, LE 190 by Dia-thìrich millers of Cnoc leathan. Muileann ruadh is a walled mill town near An Taigh-òsta Grianach<sup>20</sup>, the great inn of the eastern road. Its walls were raised when the inns fortified before the war, and the town and the inn have shared a watch ever since. The eastern Toll-dubh, the shaft of the Old Ones that charcoal-burners found again in the Age of Sundering and the custodians walled up, lies close by, and the townsfolk keep away from it. It is not the Muileann ruadh of the warm springs to the west. Known for its red mill on the inn road.

**Muileann shean** (Muileann shean). Founded 1 an t-Samhain, FE 1,093 by the first millers of the northern river. The old mill of the north, whose wheel the Holy Age king-lists already call ancient, and the seat of Siorrachd Muileann shean. Its walls went up in the Age of Strangers, when it ground grain for the mining camps on contract and was raided for it. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and owns the well-village of Tobar ìseal below it. Known for the oldest mill-wheel in the north.

**Muileann uaine** (Muileann dhomhain). Founded 8 am Màrt, AE 48 by a human milling concern with Dia-thìrich labour. Muileann uaine was built in the Age of Strangers as a breaking mill for coal from the interior workings. It is not the Muileann uaine of the Cnoc bheag country that the Green Death struck, though the two are often confused. It is a small town now and keeps the orthodox rite of Òrd Bhride<sup>21</sup>. Known for its coal-breaking mill of the interior workings.

**Muileann uaine** (Cnoc bheag). Founded 3 an t-Sultain, FE 2,593 by millers of the green wood. A green mill in the wooded middle west, one of the few towns where Òrd an t-Seabhaig<sup>22</sup>, the Hawk order, which never took Òrd Bhride<sup>23</sup>'s written order of worship, still holds. The carved hawk over the mill-door is said to be as old as the Binding of the First Flame. A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>24</sup>, the Green Death, struck it in the Age of Strangers, and since then the second sense of 'uaine' has clung to its name. Known for the Hawk-order mill.

## R

**Ros àrsaidh** (Ros bheag). Founded 16 an t-Ògmhios, FE 1,221 by custodians of the western headland. Ros àrsaidh is a small walled harbour on an ancient headland of the west, fortified by the Holy Age custodians. It lies within the province of Ros bheag and has always stood in the shadow of that citadel. It keeps the order of Manannan. The coast road north from Ros bheag, Ceum Ros àrsaidh, starts below its walls; Strake's constables held it in the last months of the Severance war. Known for its walled harbour on the ancient headland.

**Ros bhàn** (Seann Chwen). Founded 24 an Lùnastal, LE 104 by the garrison of the gulf mouth. Ros bhàn is a fortified headland at the mouth of the gulf, walled and given a citadel in the long quiet centuries to guard the harbours within. It is a city by rank, though most of its people are soldiers, customs clerks and their families. The white stone of its headland gives it its name. The customs town also boils soap and blows glass for the gulf. Known for its fortified headland at the gulf mouth.

20. the sunny house, a waypoint inn

21. the order of Brìde's flame

22. the Hawk order

23. the order of Brìde's flame

24. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'



**Ros bheag** (Ros bheag). Founded 2 an Dàmhair, GE 1,274 by hill-folk households come down to the western shore. Ros bheag is the citadel harbour and provincial seat of the western coast, holding Dùn thais and Ros àrsaidh within its province. It was fortified in the Holy Age and has been the western sea's naval station through every age since. Its people keep the order of Manannan. It is the market town of the west coast, and its own trade is in books, boots and salted food. Known for its citadel harbour of the western coast.

**Ros chiar** (Ceann bheag). Founded 1 an t-Iuchar, FE 7 by the headland-lords of Ceann bheag. A dusky headland city on the north coast, walled, with a citadel on the rock and a harbour below. It was one of the harbours the human traders first used after the Crossing, and its citadel was taken and retaken in the war before the Severance. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and competes with Caol bheag for the northern trade. Slighe-uisce fhuar, the cold way along the north coast to Caol mhin, begins at its harbour; the grain barges of Inis mhòr sailed it until the roads took their trade. Known for the fortified headland harbour.

**Ros chiar** (Muileann bheag). Founded 19 an Lùnastal, LE 1,488 by fishers of Muileann bheag. A dusky headland harbour village on the north-east coast that ships the flour of Muileann bheag. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and competes with Seann Toll for the coast trade. Known for the flour harbour of Muileann bheag.

**Ros dhìreach** (Cnoc bheag). Founded 30 an Lùnastal, LE 625 by fishers of the Hawk coast. Ros dhìreach of Cnoc bheag is a walled fishing village on the north-central coast, founded in the long quiet centuries. A' Phlàigh Uaine<sup>1</sup>, the Green Death, struck it in the Age of Strangers. It was walled after the Severance, when the Tuathaich coast became a frontier. It keeps the rite of the Hawk order. Known for its walls and its fishing boats on the Hawk coast.

**Ros dhìreach** (Cnoc mhòr). Founded 22 an t-Ògmhios, LE 76 by Dia-thìrich harbour-folk of the gulf. Ros dhìreach of Cnoc mhòr is a harbour on a straight headland of the gulf, founded in the long quiet centuries. It is a city by rank and the harbour of Cnoc mhòr's cattle trade. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Its clay-pits feed its potteries, and its soap-boilers serve the gulf. Known for its straight headland harbour.

**Ros dhomhain** (Ros dhomhain). Founded 19 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,694 by fishers of Loch chrom. Ros dhomhain is the most populous place of the capital country, a merchant port that outgrew every wall it was ever given until no one built another. The first human traders lodged here after the Crossing, and its counting-houses have served every master of the island's trade since. It sits between the capital and the old harbour of Seann Vell, and the three have run together into one shore. The Company's railway, the coal line, came down to its deep-water quay from the pits at Muileann chrom in the years of Edward Vane's commission, and the first steamer seen on Dia-thìr had come into its harbour half a century before. In the present year its quay became the one place on the island where dubhan may be loaded for beyond the island, under the charter Dubhan won from the council: a clerk of the Treasury takes the tithe on every barrel, and the custodians of Bride's order seal every hold. Known for the capital country's great merchant port.

**Ros fhionn** (Caol shean). Founded 10 am Màrt, FE 1,262 by Dia-thìrich river-folk of the east. Ros fhionn of Caol shean is a small citadel city on the Abhainn chaol in the east, near the stream of Allt an Àigh<sup>2</sup>. It is where most pilgrims to the stream come ashore from the river boats that bring them up from Seann Mhòr, and its citadel was raised in the Age of Sundering to guard them. It is not the Ros fhionn of the old bridge, which lies to the north. Known for its river landing of the Allt an Àigh pilgrims.

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1. the Green Death; lit. 'the green plague'

**Ros fhionn** (Inis bheag). Founded 29 an Lùnastal, FE 41 by custodians of the river crossing. Ros fhionn of Inis bheag is a walled city on a headland over the Abhainn bheag, founded in the Holy Age where the first bridges crossed the river. Drochaid Ros fhionn, the old crossing, is still standing. Little has crossed it since the salt went by sea, save in the century when the Company's coal carts used it on the eastern coal road; it fell silent again when the eastern pits flooded in the Severance war. The salt-boats' lane round the east cape, Seòlaid Ros fhionn, is named for the town. Its temple is a hall of the druid schools, sacred to Flidais. The salt trade that built the bridge is gone, but the market-court the salt-masters set up stayed on the headland. The town is still the market of fifty-three towns of the north-eastern hills, and no market on the island reaches further. Its yards on the river build barges and hulls, and it makes cheese for the hill towns. Known for Drochaid Ros fhionn, the old bridge.

**Ros gharbh** (Ros gharbh). Founded 3 am Faoilleach, LE 255 by fishers of the rough headland. Ros gharbh is a harbour town on a rough headland of the gulf and the seat of its province. It was founded in the long quiet centuries and grew with the gulf's fishing fleet. Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol<sup>3</sup>, the Great Wave, ran up the gulf in SE 4, broke its quays and threw the fleet onto the headland, though the town on its height lost few people. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for the gulf's fishing fleet.

**Ros gheal** (Ros gheal). Founded 29 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,009 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the white headland. Ros gheal, Ros leathan and Seann Skell share one bay on the north-central coast, and have quarrelled over its moorings for as long as the rolls run. Ros gheal is the largest of the three and the seat of its province. Its people keep the Hawk order's rite of Mòd, and its white headland is the first land the northern fishing boats see coming home. Known for its white headland and the disputed bay.

**Ros leathan** (Ros gheal). Founded 30 am Faoilleach, LE 1,774 by Dia-thìrich fishers of the Hawk bay. Ros leathan is a harbour town on the Hawk bay, sharing it with Ros gheal and Seann Skell. It was founded in the long quiet centuries by fishers who would not pay Ros gheal's mooring dues. It keeps the Hawk order of the Old Faith. Known for its rival wharves of the Hawk bay.

**Ros mhòr** (Caol mhòr). Founded 15 an t-Ògmhios, LE 432 by Dia-thìrich fishers; resettled by the Tuathaich. Ros mhòr of the north-west is a harbour on a great headland, founded by Dia-thìrich fishers in the long quiet centuries. After the Severance it was resettled by the Tuathaich and grew with the northern trade. It lies between the harbours of Caol mhòr and Caol naomh. Known for its great headland harbour.

**Ros ruadh** (Seann Chwen). Founded 27 am Faoilleach, LE 100 by quarrymen of the red headland. Ros ruadh is a small harbour on the gulf, founded by quarrymen who shipped its red stone to the gulf cities. Much of Ceann leathan and Ros bhàn is built of it. It keeps a ferry to the harbours across the water. Known for its red stone for the gulf cities.

2. the stream of the healing water

3. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

**Ros ruadh** (Ceann mhòr). Founded 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,075 by fishing households of the north-west coast; resettled by the Tuathaich. A red headland harbour on the north-west coast, one of the Dia-thìrich harbours given to the Tuathaich after the Severance. The fishing families of Ros ruadh are among those who keep the voyage of Naomh Breandan alive in speech, and some say the saint's boat put out from this headland. It follows the faith of the Church. Known for the Naomh Breandan telling of the north-west.

## S

**Seann Bhral** (Baile àrsaidh). Founded 5 an Dàmhair, VE 196 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>1</sup>. Seann Bhral of the west coast is a Seann-Dhaoine site the Dia-thìrich resettled in the Holy Age. It grew into a large port on the western sea roads and took up the order of Manannan, the Old Faith's order of the sea, which is strong along this coast. Its harbour is unwalled, trusting to the citadel at Ros bheag to the north. Known for its west-coast harbour of the order of Manannan.

**Seann Bhral** (Seann Bhral). Founded 30 an Lùnastal, VE 1,005 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>2</sup>. Seann Bhral of the south-east is a Seann-Dhaoine site that the Dia-thìrich resettled in the Holy Age, and it has grown into the greatest harbour of that coast and the seat of its province. It was walled in the Age of Strangers, when its quays shipped coal from the interior. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. Known for the south-east's great walled harbour.

**Seann Bhral** (Ros gharbh). Founded 9 an t-Samhain, GE 2,077 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>3</sup>. Seann Bhral is a walled harbour on a Seann-Dhaoine site, settled by the Dia-thìrich and named by them for the Old Ones. It lies near Làrach an Dùin-fhaire<sup>4</sup>, the ruined outpost no one can date. It is a port town of four thousand. Known for its walled old harbour of Ros gharbh.

**Seann Bhrenn** (Seann Bhrenn). Founded 12 an Giblean, VE 321 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>5</sup>. A Seann-Dhaoine harbour on the north coast, called Seann Bhrenn by the Dia-thìrich, and the seat of the shire of the same name. It is a large village of the Old Spirits, and its fishers tell that the harbour-stones were laid by people who had no need of the Dia-thìrich's tides. Known for the northern Seann-Dhaoine harbour.

**Seann Bhrenn** (Ceann mhin). Founded 15 an Lùnastal, VE 23 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>6</sup>. Seann Bhrenn is an old harbour of the Seann-Dhaoine, settled by the Dia-thìrich in the Holy Age. It lies hard beside Caol gharbh, and the two harbours have quarrelled over the same water for as long as there are records, each claiming the other was built on its fishing ground. It is a port town of nearly nine thousand and the older of the two by its name. Known for its old harbour quarrelling with Caol gharbh.

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1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

4. the watch-fort ruin

5. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

6. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

**Seann Chwen** (Seann Dunn). Founded 1 am Faoilleach, VE 1,236 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>7</sup>. The landing stones at Seann Chwen are of the Seann-Dhaoine, and the name was given by the Dia-thìrich who resettled the site in the Holy Age. It is a small harbour on the south shore, but its citadel guards the capital's southern sea road, and it has been garrisoned more often than its size would suggest. Its people keep the order of Macha, the capital's order of the Old Faith, and its green is one of the two grounds where the travelling circus, An Siorcas Siubhail Do-thuigsinn<sup>8</sup>, pitches. Known for its citadel on the capital's southern sea road.

**Seann Chwen** (Seann Chwen). Founded 19 an Giblean, VE 32 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>9</sup>. The larger Seann Chwen is the chief harbour of the gulf and the seat of the province that bears its name, built on a Seann-Dhaoine site the Dia-thìrich resettled in the Holy Age. It takes the fish of the gulf and the goods of Cathair mhòr. It has no walls; the fortified headlands of Ros bhàn and Ceann leathan stand to either side of it. Known for the gulf's chief harbour and fish-market.

**Seann Chwen** (Àth shean). Founded 29 an Lùnastal, VE 3,488 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>10</sup>. Seann Chwen of Àth shean is a harbour on the south coast, on a Seann-Dhaoine site. It was resettled by the Dia-thìrich in the Holy Age and is the port for the southern Àth shean. It keeps the capital's order, the order of Macha. Known for its south-coast old harbour.

**Seann Dunn** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 5 an Cèitean, VE 642 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>11</sup>. Seann Dunn keeps a Seann-Dhaoine name, and its citadel stands on footings no Dia-thìreach mason laid. It stands on the Abhainn chaol a little above the river mouth, and is the river landing and lodging-place for those who visit Làrach an Teampaill<sup>12</sup> in the hills to the north, whose ships put in at Seann Mhorn down the coast; its own ancestor hall serves the Old Spirits. An Taigh-seinnse Òir<sup>13</sup>, one of the great taverns of the old mining circuit, stands in the town itself. Its yards are the largest shipyard on Dia-thìr, and the town cuts the sails and makes the cheese of the east coast. Slighe-mhara àr-saidh<sup>14</sup>, the ancient sea-way of the Old Ones, begins at the river mouth below the town and runs round the south-east cape to Ceann chaol. Known for An Taigh-seinnse Òir and the temple road.

**Seann Dunn** (Seann Dunn). Founded 28 am Faoilleach, VE 601 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>15</sup>. The Seann-Dhaoine left the harbour-mole and the name Dunn; the Dia-thìrich called it Seann Dunn and built a citadel over the mole. It is the seat of the shire of the same name and follows the order of Macha. It is a village in form but large in number, with the ford-town of Àth ghorm under its protection. Known for the Seann-Dhaoine harbour-mole.

7. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

8. the Incomprehensible Travelling Circus

9. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

10. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

11. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

12. the temple ruin

13. the golden house, a waypoint inn

14. the ancient sea-way

15. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

**Seann Dunn** (Baile chaol). Founded 22 an Dùbhlachd, VE 320 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>16</sup>. The harbour stones of Seann Dunn are older than any Dia-thìreach work, and the name the Dia-thìrich gave the place keeps a root that is not their own. It became a Dia-thìreach port in the Holy Age, and its citadel was raised above the harbour to guard the eastern approaches. It is now a city of shipping and salt-fish, and its oldest families still claim that the harbour wall was only repaired, never built, by their ancestors. Its yards build seagoing hulls and cut their sails. Known for its Seann-Dhaoine harbour stones and its citadel.

**Seann Mhorn** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 5 an t-Iuchar, VE 80 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>17</sup>. The Seann-Dhaoine left the harbour-stones and the name Morn; the Dia-thìrich, finding both, called the place Seann Mhorn and built on top. It is a walled port with a citadel over the harbour mouth, fought over more than once in the troubles before the Severance, and it keeps the Old Spirits of the Dia-thìrich. Stones of the older builders are set into the harbour wall, and the fishermen touch one before they sail. Known for the Seann-Dhaoine stones in its harbour wall.

**Seann Mhorn** (Àth chiar). Founded 31 an Cèitean, VE 784 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>18</sup>. Seann Mhorn is a small old harbour, one of several Seann names on this stretch of the southern coast, and was settled by the Dia-thìrich in the Holy Age. It lies between Seann Skell and Seann Vell. It is a fishing village of three thousand. Known for its small old harbour.

**Seann Skell** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 10 an Gearran, VE 1,404 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>19</sup>. Seann Skell is a Seann-Dhaoine harbour on the far north-west coast, named by the Dia-thìrich who resettled it; it passed to the Tuathaich after the Severance. Its citadel looks out over the waters where pirate ships are still reported and where old sailors place the Sea-Watcher. It is neither of the two Seann Skells whose names the seventh and ninth regiments carry, which lie far to the south-east. Known for its watch over the pirate waters.

**Seann Skell** (Seann Skell). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, VE 1,833 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>20</sup>. Seann Skell of the Hawk bay is a walled harbour city on a Seann-Dhaoine site, sharing its bay with Ros gheal and Ros leathan. It was resettled by the Dia-thìrich in the Holy Age and walled in the Age of Sundering. It keeps the Hawk order of the Old Faith. It is the market town of the Hawk bay and the north-central coast. Amber from the bay's strands is the one good it sells to other markets, and its yards build seagoing hulls. Known for its walled old harbour of the Hawk bay.

**Seann Skell** (Seann Skell). Founded 29 am Faoilleach, GE 2,664 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>21</sup>. Seann Skell is the great southern port, a town of nearly sixty thousand whose harbour lies on a site the Seann-Dhaoine used before the Dia-thìrich; the name keeps their root. It is the seat of its province and a centre of Òrd Bhrìde<sup>22</sup>, the order of Bride's flame. The ninth regiment and the second fleet, raised in the Long War, are stationed here. It shares its name with the great western river port. Glass is blown there from the white sand of its own shore. Known for the southern fleet harbour.

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16. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

17. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

18. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

19. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

20. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

21. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

22. the order of Bride's flame

**Seann Skell** (Seann Skell). Founded 6 an Gearran, VE 173 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>23</sup>. Seann Skell is the great river port of the west, a city of seventy-four thousand and the largest place on the island, whose barges run down the Abhainn naomh to Ros àrsaidh; its river harbour is a Seann-Dhaoine site and the name keeps their root. It is walled by its citadel rather than by curtain walls, and the seventh regiment, raised in the Long War, is stationed here. The first battle of that war was fought at Àth leathan, a short march north. Known for the great western river port.

**Seann Tarr** (Muileann bheag). Founded 30 an Cèitean, VE 884 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>24</sup>. Seann Tarr is a Seann-Dhaoine site on the north-eastern coast, resettled by the Dia-thìrich in the Holy Age, and its ancestor hall is one of the oldest spirit-houses of the Old Spirits still in use. A citadel was raised over the harbour in the Age of Sundering. It is small for a city, but the shrine draws the whole north-east at the great feasts. It is the market town of the north-eastern coast, whose market began at the shrine's feasts. Honey from its heather and wax for the shrine lights are its own goods, with cheese and books, and its rope-makers are a chartered guild. Known for its north-eastern ancestor shrine.

**Seann Tarr** (Seann Tarr). Founded 25 an Giblean, VE 1,212 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>25</sup>. A harbour of the Seann-Dhaoine on the eastern coast, named Seann Tarr by the Dia-thìrich, and the seat of the shire of the same name. It is a large village that follows the Old Spirits. Gaillean Ghlas, the grey storm, destroyed its harbour in the Age of Sundering, and for long its boats sailed from Cuan ruadh. The eastern pirates made it unsafe in the Age of Strangers, and it has a small fleet of its own again. Known for the old eastern harbour and fleet.

**Seann Tarr** (Cnoc gheal). Founded 17 an Lùnastal, VE 4,706 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>26</sup>. Seann Tarr is a small harbour whose landing stones are older than any Dia-thìreach work, and the root in its name is not of the Dia-thìrich tongue. Dia-thìrich fishers settled it in the Holy Age and gave it the name it bears, and the name marks it as a place of the Old Ones. On clear nights the lighthouse of Àth dhearg can be seen from its quay, and its boats steer by it. Known for the Old Ones' landing stones.

**Seann Toll** (Seann Toll). Founded 8 an t-Samhain, VE 1,033 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>27</sup>. Seann Toll, old hollow, is named for the sea-caves under its headland, where Seann-Dhaoine marks are said to be cut into the rock. The Dia-thìrich resettled it in the Holy Age and it has been a fishing port ever since. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and the northern herring fleet. Known for its sea-caves and the north-coast herring.

23. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

24. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

25. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

26. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

27. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

**Seann Toll** (Muileann chrom). Founded 8 an Gearran, VE 92 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>28</sup>. A Seann-Dhaoine river port on the Abhainn uaine in the midlands, called Seann Toll by the Dia-thìrich for the hollow in the rock where its boats lie. It is walled and follows the order of Macha, and it stands a short way west of Cill ghlas, where the Rending opened. It lies close to Ceann leathan at the river mouth, where the Còmhrag is fought each year, and fighters from the tournament fill its taverns. Known for the rock-hollow landing and Còmhrag crowds.

**Seann Toll** (Muileann bheag). Founded 19 an Giblean, VE 2,319 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>29</sup>. Seann Toll is a harbour in a cleft of the rock, and its lowest quay is cut in a manner the Dia-thìrich did not use; it is held to be the work of the Seann-Dhaoine, and nothing more is known of it. The Dia-thìrich settled it in the Holy Age as the nearest harbour for Dùn dhubh and Muileann bheag. It is a small port town of fishers and lightermen. Known for its cleft-rock harbour of the Old Ones.

**Seann Vell** (Ros dhomhain). Founded 29 an Lùnastal, GE 3,560 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>30</sup>. Seann Vell on the capital shore stands on Seann-Dhaoine quay stones, still visible at low water beneath the later harbour. The Dia-thìrich resettled it in the Holy Age and walled it in the long quiet centuries. It has since been drawn into the sprawl of Ros dhomhain, but keeps its own walls and its own harbour-master. Its scent-makers distil the best-known scent on the island. Known for its old quay stones of the capital shore.

**Seann Vell** (Seann Vell). Founded 4 an t-Ògmhios, VE 396 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>31</sup>. Seann Vell of the south-east is a citadel harbour on a Seann-Dhaoine site, resettled by the Dia-thìrich in the Holy Age. Its citadel guards the south-eastern coast and the approach to Seann Bhral, its larger neighbour and old rival. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits. The town stands on Eilean dhearg, the island where the Seann-Dhaoine of the older Seann Vell laid their dead. Known for its south-eastern citadel harbour.

**Seann Vell** (Baile mhin). Founded 1 an Gearran, VE 1,698 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>32</sup>. Seann Vell of Baile mhin is a small river landing on a Seann-Dhaoine site on the Abhainn bheag in the north-east, a short way above the river mouth at Caol chrom, resettled by the Dia-thìrich in the Holy Age. It lives on the seal-hunt at the river mouth and the fishing. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for its old landing stones and seal-hunters.

**Seann Vell** (Seann Vell). Founded 16 an Dàmhair, VE 1,197 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>33</sup>. Seann Vell of the west coast is a small harbour on a Seann-Dhaoine site, the seat of its province. It was resettled by the Dia-thìrich in the Holy Age and took up the order of Manannan with the rest of the coast. An ceathramh cabhlach<sup>34</sup> is stationed at Cuan shean, a short way up the coast. Its shire is the humans' old district of the outer coasts, kept whole: the islands of the west and south, Eilean bhàn with Cuan dhearg and Cnoc chaol, and the southern edge of the windy coast in the far north-west. Known for its old harbour of the west coast.

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28. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

29. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

30. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

31. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

32. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

33. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

34. the fourth fleet

**Seann Vell** (Seann Vell). Founded 1 an t-Ògmhios, VE 3,673 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>35</sup>. Seann Vell of the capital's east is a walled river town on a Seann-Dhaoine site on the Abhainn fhionn and the seat of its province. It was resettled by the Dia-thìrich in the Holy Age. An Taigh-seinnse Mòr stands just east of it, at the river quay of Cuan chrom. Known for its walls on the Cuan chrom road.

**Seann Warr** (Seann Warr). Founded 27 am Màrt, VE 725 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>36</sup>. Seann Warr is a Seann-Dhaoine harbour on the capital's western shore, resettled by the Dia-thìrich and walled in the Holy Age. Its citadel guards the western approaches to the capital. An còigeamh rèisimeid<sup>37</sup>, raised in An Cogadh Fada<sup>38</sup>, is stationed here and carries its name. Its salt-pans have sold salt since the first years of the humans' trade, and the flax of its lake-shore fields, pressed for linseed oil, is grown nowhere else on the island. Loch chrom is fresh, and the town's salt is boiled from brine springs that rise in the reed marsh behind it. Known for the fifth regiment's walled harbour.

**Seann Warr** (Àth chiar). Founded 15 an Gearran, VE 2,245 by the Seann-Dhaoine<sup>39</sup>. Seann Warr of Àth chiar is a small harbour on a Seann-Dhaoine landing on the south shore of the gulf. The Dia-thìrich resettled it in the Holy Age. It keeps the ancestor rite of the Old Spirits and a few boats, and pays its dues to the larger harbours across the water. Known for its old landing on the gulf's south shore.

## T

**Tobar bhàn** (Cnoc gheal). Founded 13 an Cèitean, FE 968 by well-keepers of the north-eastern shore road. Tobar bhàn is a well village on the north-eastern shore road, named for a spring whose water runs white with chalk. The beacon of Taigh-solais Àth dhearg<sup>1</sup> stands on the coast beyond it, and through the later Age of Strangers the village kept the lamp-keepers in bread and peat. Its people hold to the Old Spirits, the ancestors and the weather, and still leave a cup at the well before a sea-journey. Known for its white well and the lighthouse keepers.

**Tobar dhearg** (Tobar dhearg). Founded 12 an Dàmhair, GE 2,947 by the keepers of the southern beacon. Tobar dhearg is a large village around a well of red water, the seat of its province. Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg<sup>2</sup>, one of the five lighthouses of the Age of Strangers, stands on the shore below it; it burned a coal flame for over a century before it was converted to dubhan. The village holds to Òrd Bhride<sup>3</sup>, and its druids, keepers of Bride's flame, keep the light's log. Known for the southern lighthouse and red well.

35. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

36. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

37. the fifth regiment

38. the Long War

39. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

1. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

2. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

3. the order of Bride's flame



**Tobar dhearg** (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 16 an Dùbhlachd, FE 1,150 by Dia-thìrich well-keepers; resettled by the Tuathaich after the Severance. A Dia-thìreach village around a well of red water, resettled by Tuathaich families after the Severance. Like several villages of this coast it made the shrine of Manannan that it inherited its church rather than raising its own. It lives on sheep and on the market at Cathair gheal. Known for its red well of the western Tuathaich.

**Tobar dhìreach** (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, VE 42 by well-diggers of the high valleys. A large well village in the central-east, laid out along a straight channel that carries its water. It is the eldest of the three wells that claim the mason's crack, and the only one that can show a capped shaft, scorched at the lip, where it says the lightning fell into the vein and the first fire was taken. The slab laid over the burnt vein lies beside it, and the keepers' house faces the slab. The Mason's line lived here through the long generations of the Seven Coals: Brian buried the five coals beside the slab and found the black one warm on the next day, and Seath-an snapped the fire out of his own fingers in a doorway of the village. It follows the druid schools of the Old Faith and supplies water and vegetables to Baile Mòr uaine and Baile thais. Its paper-mill makes the paper of the royal chronicle. Known for the straight water-channel.

**Tobar dhomhain** (Cnoc bheag). Founded 17 am Màrt, AE 32 by miners of the western hills. A deep well-village in the western hills, dug to supply a mining camp that has since been abandoned. It is one of the smallest villages on the island and follows the order of Manannan. The grassland above the village is where the Leaden Hawk company kept its watch on the road from Ros bheag in the second spring of the Severance war. Known for the well of a lost camp.

**Tobar dhubh** (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 7 an t-Samhain, FE 1,590 by Dia-thìrich well-keepers of Cnoc bhàn. A village around a deep well whose water runs dark, said in the old telling to rise from near the vein. It has never been proved so, and the druid scholars of Cnoc bhàn have argued it both ways. The well still draws visitors who drink from it for luck. Known for the dark well of old telling.

**Tobar fhiadhaich** (Tobar fhiadhaich). Founded 10 an t-Samhain, GE 1,879 by herders of the northern moor. Tobar fhiadhaich is a large village around a wild spring on the moor, and the seat of its province. It lives on grazing and on the peat of Achadh gharbh. Its herders have walked the same moor paths since the Age of Ailean, and its spring is said never to have failed, even in the driest years. Known for its wild spring and moorland grazing.

**Tobar ghorm** (Doire fhionn). Founded 27 am Faoilleach, FE 2,921 by Dia-thìrich well-keepers of the northern road. A village around a blue spring on the road running north toward the Tuathaich country, and the last Dia-thìrich water on that road. Since the Severance it has traded with both sides of the line and has been trusted by neither. It is not the larger Tobar ghorm of the wool fairs, and it resents the confusion. Known for its blue spring on the northern road.

**Tobar ghorm** (Tobar ghorm). Founded 31 am Faoilleach, FE 950 by Dia-thìrich herders of the northern plain. Tobar ghorm is a large village around a blue spring, the seat of its province, and home to the greatest wool fairs of the north. The fairs were old before the humans came, and the humans' wool-buyers made them larger. The mills of Muileann mhin grind its grain. Known for its blue spring and wool fairs.

**Tobar ìseal** (Tobar fhiadhaich). Founded 26 an Dùbhlachd, FE 2,494 by the well-keepers of Muileann shean. A low well in a hollow below Muileann shean, ringed with stone in the Holy Age and watched ever since. The small keep that gives it a citadel was built to guard the water for the mill town in dry years, and the dry summers since have shown the builders wise. It is still a village, and the millers upstream own it in all but name. Known for the guarded low well.

**Tobar ìseal** (Dùn dhearg). Founded 26 am Faoilleach, LE 508 by well-keepers of Dùn dhearg. A low well-village in the east that waters the city of Dùn dhearg in dry seasons. It keeps the Old Spirits, and its well-keepers still bless the water before it is carted up the hill. Known for the well that waters Dùn dhearg.

**Tobar òg** (Inis bheag). Founded 21 an t-Iuchar, LE 1,395 by well-diggers of Inis bheag. A young well village in the north-east, dug to water the fields behind Inis bheag when those fields were first broken. It has grown into a sizeable village and follows the druid schools of the Old Faith. Known for the young well behind Inis bheag.

**Tobar shean** (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 29 an Lùnastal, LE 822 by well-keepers of Baile òg. An old well-village in the eastern hills, walled in the troubled years because its well was the only sure water on the road past Làrach an Team-paill<sup>4</sup>. It keeps the Old Spirits, and the well-keepers still close the gate in dry seasons and ration the water by the bucket. Known for the walled well on the temple road.

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4. the temple ruin